

Chaucer's Translation of
Boethius's "De Consolatione
Philosophiæ"

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Philosophiae"

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK CHAUCER'S
TRANSLATION OF BOETHIUS'S "DE CONSOLATIONE
PHILOSOPHIAE" ***

This text includes characters that require UTF-8 (Unicode) file encoding:

œ ("oe" ligature)

ȝ ȝ (yogh)

ħ ũ (h with bar, u with tilde: both rare)

The Sidenotes include a few Greek phrases:

ἔπου Θεῶ

If any of these characters do not display properly—in particular, if the diacritic does not appear directly above the letter—or if the apostrophes and quotation marks in this paragraph appear as garbage, you may have an incompatible browser or unavailable fonts. First, make sure that the browser's "character set" or "file encoding" is set to Unicode (UTF-8). You may also need to change your browser's default font.

Linenotes refer to the Cambridge MS.; see [end of Introduction](#). "H." in the Linenotes is not explained; Skeat's edition of Chaucer's *Complete Works* says that it refers to MS. Harley 2421.

In the printed book, line numbers were squeezed in wherever there was room. For the e-text, they have been regularized to the EETS-standard multiples of 4. Line divisions and page numbers were retained for use with the Index and linenotes, except that some very short words have been moved up or down to avoid awkward gaps. Headnotes have been moved to the nearest convenient line break.

Italic thorn (þ) and yogh (ȝ) seem to have been unavailable to the printer; both letters have been formatted to match the surrounding text. In the Appendix, decorative final letters are shown with) or + as sprong⁺, dar⁾ and similar to approximate the look of the original. The inverted semicolon (rare) is shown as ;̅.

In the primary text, anomalous spellings with initial "u" or non-initial "v" are not individually noted. Other errors, whether corrected or not, are shown in the text with mouse-hover popups.

For this e-text, Chaucer's translation of the *Consolatio* is given twice: first as printed, with all notes and apparatus, and then as text alone.

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Chaucer's Translation of
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Philosophiæ"

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INTRODUCTION.

WHEN master hands like those of Gibbon and Hallam have sketched the life of *Boethius*, it is well that no meaner man should attempt to mar their pictures. They drew, perhaps, the most touching scene in Middle-age literary history,—the just man in prison, awaiting death, consoled by the Philosophy that had been his light in life, and handing down to posterity for their comfort and strength the presence of her whose silver rays had been his guide as well under the stars of Fortune as the mirk of Fate. With Milton in his dark days, Boece in prison could say,—

‘I argue not
Against Heaven’s hand or will, nor bate a jot
Of heart or hope; but still bear up and steer
Right onward. What supports me, dost thou ask?
The conscience, friend, to have lost them overplied
In liberty’s defence, my noble task,
Of which all Europe rings from side to side.’

For, indeed, the echoes of Boethius, Boethius, rang out loud from every corner of European Literature. An Alfred awoke them in England, a Chaucer, a Caxton would not let them die; an Elizabeth revived them among the glorious music of her reign. ¹ To us, though far off, they come with a sweet sound. ‘The angelic’ Thomas Aquinas commented on him, and many others followed the saint’s steps. Dante read him, though, strange to say, he speaks of the Consolation as ‘a book not known by many.’ ² Belgium had her translations—both Flemish ³ and French ⁴; Germany hers, ⁵ France hers, ⁶ Italy hers. ⁷ The Latin editors are too numerous to be catalogued here, and manuscripts abound in all our great libraries.

No philosopher was so bone of the bone and flesh of the flesh of Middle-age writers as Boethius. Take up what writer you will, and you find not only

the sentiments, but the very words of the distinguished old Roman. And surely we who read him in Chaucer's tongue, will not refuse to say that his full-circling meed of glory was other than deserved. Nor can we marvel that at the end of our great poet's life, he was glad that he had swelled the chorus of Boethius' praise; and 'of the translacioun of Boece de Consolacioun,' thanked 'oure Lord Ihesu Crist and his moder, and alle the seintes in heuen.'

The impression made by Boethius on Chaucer was evidently very deep. Not only did he translate him directly, as in the present work, but he read his beloved original over and over again, as witness the following list, incomplete of course, of passages from Chaucer's poems translated more or less literally from the *De Consolatione*:

I. LOVE.

Wost thou nat wel the olde clerkes sawe,
That who schal yeve a lover eny lawe,
Love is a grettere lawe, by my pan,
Then may be yeve to (of) eny erthly man?

(*Knightes Tale*, *Aldine Series*, vol. ii. p. 36, 37.)

But what is he þat may ȝeue a lawe to loueres. loue is a gretter lawe and a strengere to hym self þan any lawe þat men may ȝeuen.

(*Chaucer's Prose Translation*, [p. 108](#).)

Quis legem det amantibus?
Major lex amor est sibi.

(Boeth., lib. iii. met. 12.)

II. A DRUNKEN MAN.

A dronke man wot wel he hath an hous,
But he not [8](#) which the righte wey is thider.

(*Knightes Tale*, vol. ii. p. 39.)

Ryȝt as a dronke man not nat [9](#) by whiche pape he may retourne home to hys house.

(*Chaucer's Trans.*, [p. 67](#).)

Sed velut ebrius, domum quo tramite revertatur, ignorat.

(Boeth., lib. iii. pr. 2.)

III. THE CHAIN OF LOVE.

The firste moevere of the cause above,
Whan he first made the fayre cheyne of love,
Gret was theeffect, and heigh was his entente;
Wel wist he why, and what therof he mente;
*For with that faire cheyne of love he bond
The fyr, the watir, the eyr, and eek the lond
In certeyn boundes, that they may not flee.*

(*Knights Tale*, p. 92.)

That þe world with stable feith / varieth acordable chaungynges // þat the contraryos qualite
of elementȝ holden amonge hem self aliaunce perdurable / þat phebus the sonne with his
goldene chariet / bryngeth forth the rosene day / þat the mone hath commaundement ouer
the nyhtes // whiche nyhtes hesperus the eue sterre hat[h] browt // þat þe se gredy to flowen
constreyneth with a certeyn ende hise floodes / so þat it is nat l[e]ueful to stretche hise
brode termes or bowndes vp-on the erthes // þat is to seyn to couere alle the erthe // Al this
a-cordaunce of thinges is bownden with looue / þat gouerneth erthe and see / and [he] hath
also commaundementȝ to the heuenes / and yif this looue slakede the brydelis / alle thinges
þat now louen hem to-gederes / wolden maken a batayle contynuely and stryuen to fordoon
the fasoun of this worlde / the which they now leden in acordable feith by fayre moeuynge
// this looue halt to-gideres poeples / ioyned with an hooly bond / and knytteth sacrament
of maryages of chaste looues // And loue enditeth lawes to trewe felawes // O weleful
weere mankynde / yif thilke loue þat gouerneth heuene gouerned yowre corages /.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, bk. ii. met. 8.)

Quod mundus stabili fide
Concordes variat vices,
Quod pugnantia semina
Fœdus perpetuum tenent,
Quod Phœbus roseum diem
Curru provehit aureo,
Ut quas duxerit Hesperus
Phœbe noctibus imperet,
Ut fluctus avidum mare
Certo fine coerceat,
Ne terris liceat vagis
Latos tundere terminos;
*Hanc rerum seriem ligat,
Terras ac pelagus regens,
Et cœlo imperitans amor.*
Hic si fræna remiserit,
Quicquid nunc amat invicem,
Bellum continuo geret:

Et quam nunc socia fide
Pulcris motibus incitant,
Certent solvere machinam.
Hic sancto populos quoque
Junctos fœdere continet,
Hic et conjugii sacrum
Castis nectit amoribus,
Hic fidis etiam sua
Dictat jura sodalibus.
O felix hominum genus,
Si vestros animos amor,
Quo cælum regitur, regat.

(*Boeth.*, lib. ii. met. 8.)

Love, that of erth and se hath governaunce!
Love, that his hestes hath in hevene hye!
Love, that with an holsom alliaunce
Halt peples joyned, as hym liste hem gye!
Love, that knetteth law and compaignye,
And couples doth in vertu for to dwelle!

(*Troylus & Cryseyde*, st. 243, vol. iv. p. 296.)

That, that the world with faith, which that is stable
Dyverseth so, his stoundes concordynge;—
That elementz, that ben so discordable,
Holden a bond, perpetually durynge;—
That Phebus mot his rosy carte forth brynge,
And that the mone hath lordschip overe the nyghte;—
Al this doth Love, ay heryed be his myght!

That, that the se, that gredy is to flowen,
Constreyneth to a certeyn ende so
Hise flodes, that so fiersly they ne growen
To drenchen erth and alle for everemo;
And if that Love aught lete his brydel go,
Al that now loveth asonder sholde lepe,
And lost were al that Love halt now to kepe.

(*Ibid.* st. 244, 245.)

IV. MUTABILITY DIRECTED AND LIMITED BY AN IMMUTABLE AND DIVINE INTELLIGENCE.

That same prynce and moevere eek, quod he,
Hath stabled, in this wrecched world adoun,
Certeyn dayes and duracioun
To alle that er engendrid in this place,

Over the whiche day they may nat pace,
Al mowe they yit wel here dayes abregge;

.
Than may men wel by this ordre discerne
That thilke moevere stabul is and eterne.

.
And therfore of his wyse purveaunce
He hath so wel biset his ordenaunce,
That spices of thinges and progressiouns
Schullen endure by successiouns
And nat eterne be, withoute any lye.

(*Knights Tale*, vol. ii. p. 92, 93.)

þe engendrynge of alle þinges quod she and alle þe progressiouns of muuable nature. and alle þat moeuþ in any manere takip hys causes. hys ordre. and hys formes. of þe stablenesse of þe deuyne þouȝt [and thilke deuyne thowht] þat is yset and put in þe toure. þat is to seyne in þe heyȝt of þe simplicité of god. stablisip many manere gyses to þinges þat ben to don.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, bk. iv. pr. 6, [p. 134](#).)

V. THE PART IS DERIVED FROM THE WHOLE, THE IMPERFECT FROM THE PERFECT.

Wel may men knowe, but it be a fool,
That every partye dyryveth from his hool.
For nature hath nat take his bygynnyng
Of no partye ne cantel of a thing,
But of a thing that parfyt is and stable,
Descendyng so, til it be corumpable.

(*Knights Tale*, vol. ii. p. 92.)

For al þing þat is cleped inperfit . is proued inperfit by þe amenusynge of perfeccioun . or of þing þat is perfit . and her-of comeþ it . þat in euery þing general . yif þat . þat men seen any þing þat is inperfit . certys in þilke general þer mot ben somme þing þat is perfit. For yif so be þat perfeccioun is don away . men may nat þinke nor seye fro whennes þilke þing is þat is cleped inperfit . For þe nature of þinges ne token nat her bygynnyng of þinges amenused and inperfit . but it procedip of þingus þat ben al hool . and absolut . and descendep so doune in-to outerest þinges and in-to þingus empty and wiþ-oute fruyt . but as I haue shewed a litel her byforne . þat yif þer be a blisfulnesse þat be frele and vein and inperfit . þer may no man doute . þat þer nys som blisfulnesse þat is sad stedfast and perfit.'

(bk. iii. pr. 10, [p. 89](#).)

Omne enim quod imperfectum esse dicitur, id deminutione perfecti imperfectum esse perhibetur. Quo fit ut si in quolibet genere imperfectum quid esse videatur, in eo perfectum quoque aliquod esse necesse sit. Etenim perfectione sublata, unde illud, quod imperfectum

perhibetur, extiterit, ne fingi quidem potest. *Neque enim ab diminutis inconsummatisque natura rerum cepit exordium, sed ab integris absolutisque procedens in hæc extrema atque effæta dilabitur.* Quod si, uti paulo ante monstravimus, est quædam boni fragilis imperfecta felicitas, esse aliquam solidam perfectamque non potest dubitari.

(*Boeth.*, lib. iii. pr. 10.)

VI. GENTILITY.

For gentilnesse nys but renomé
Of thin auncestres, for her heigh bounté
Which is a straunge thing to thy persone.

(*The Wyf of Bathes Tale*, vol. ii. p. 241.)

For if þe name of gentillesse be referred to renoun and clernesse of linage. þan is gentil name but a foreine þing.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, [p. 78.](#))

Quæ [nobilitas], *si ad claritudinem refertur, aliena est.*

(*Boethius*, lib. iii. pr. 6.)

VII. NERO'S CRUELTY.

No teer out of his eyen for that sighte
Ne cam; but sayde, a fair womman was sche.
Gret wonder is how that he couthe or mighte
Be domesman on hir dede beauté.

(*The Monkes Tale*, vol. iii. p. 217.)

Ne no tere ne wette his face, but he was so hard-herted þat he myzte ben domesman or iuge of hire dede beauté.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, [p. 55.](#))

Ora non tinxit lacrymis, sed esse
Censor extincti potuit decoris.

(*Boethius*, lib. ii. met. 6.)

VIII. PREDESTINATION AND FREE-WILL.

In 'Troilus and Cryseyde' we find the following long passage taken from Boethius, book v. prose 2, 3.

Book iv. st. 134, vol. iv. p. 339.

- (1) Syn God seth every thyng, out of doutaunce,
And hem disponeth, thorough his ordinaunce,
In hire merites sothely for to be,
As they shul comen by predesteyné

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- (2) For som men seyn if God seth al byforne,
Ne God may not deseyved ben pardé!
Than moot it fallen, theigh men hadde it sworne,
That purveyaunce hath seyn befor to be,
Wherfor I seye, that, from eterne, if he
Hathe wiste byforn our thought ek as oure dede,
We have no fre choys, as thise clerkes rede.

137

- (3) For other thoughte, nor other dede also,
Myghte nevere ben, but swich as purveyaunce,
Which may nat ben deceyved nevere moo,
Hath feled byforne, withouten ignoraunce;
For if ther myghte ben a variaunce,
To wrythen out fro Goddes purveyinge,
Ther nere no prescience of thyng comynge;

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- (4) But it were rather an opinyon
Uncertein, and no stedfast forseynge;
And certes that were an abusyon
That God shold han no parfit clere wetyng,
More than we men, that han douteous wenynge,
But swich an erroure upon God to gesse
Were fals, and foule, and wikked corsednesse.

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- (5) They seyn right thus, that thyng is nat to come,
For that the prescience hath seyne byfore
That it shal come; but they seyn that therfore
That it shal come, therfor the purveyaunce
Woot it bifore, withouten ignorance.

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- (6) And in this manere this necessité
Retourneth in his part contrarye agayn;
For nedfully byhoveth it not to be,
That thilke thynges fallen in certeyn
That ben purveyed; but nedly, as they seyne,
Bihoveth it that thynges, which that falle,
That thei in certein ben purveied alle.

- (7) I mene as though I labourede me in this,
To enqueren which thyng cause of whiche thyng be;
- (8) As, whether that the prescience of God is
The certein cause of the necessité
Of thynges that to comen ben, pardé!
Or, if necessité of thyng comynge
Be cause certein of the purveyinge.

- (9) But now nenforce I me nat in shewynge
How the ordre of causes stant; but wel woot I
That it bihoveth that the bifallynge
Of thynges, wiste bifer certeinly,
Be necessarie, al seme it nat therby
That prescience put fallynge necessaire
To thyng to come, al falle it foule or faire.

- (10) For, if ther sit a man yonde on a see, [seat]
Than by necessité bihoveth it,
That certes thyn opinioun soth be,
That wenest or coniectest that he sit;
And, further over, now ayeinwarde yit,
Lo right so is it on the part contrarie,
As thus,—nowe herkene, for I wol nat tarie:—

- (11) I sey, that if the opinion of the
Be soth for that he sit, than seye I this,
That he moot sitten by necessité;
And thus necessité in either is,
For in hym nede of sittynge is, ywis,
And in the, nede of soth; and thus forsoth
Ther mot necessité ben in yow bothe.

- (12) But thow maist seyne, the man sit nat therfore,
That thyn opinioun of his sittynge sothe is;
But rather, for the man sat there byfore,
Therfor is thyn opinioun soth, ywys;
And I seye, though the cause of soth of this
Cometh of his sittynge, yet necessité
Is interchaunged both in hym and the.

- (13) Thus in the same wyse, out of doutaunce,
I may wel maken, as it semeth me,
My resonyng of Goddes purveiaunce,
And of the thynges that to comen be; . . .

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- (14) For although that for thyng shal come, ywys,
Therfor it is purveyed certeynly,
Nat that it cometh for it purveied is;
Yet, natheles, bihoveth it nedfully,
That thyng to come be purveied trewly;
Or elles thynges that purveied be.
That they bitiden by necessité.

148

- (15) And this sufficeth right ynough, certeyn,
For to distruye oure fre choys everydele.

(1) Quæ tamen ille ab æterno cuncta prospiciens providentiæ cernit intuitus, et suis quæque meritis prædestinata disponit. . . . (*Boethius*, lib. v. pr. 2.)
.

(2) Nam si cuncta prospicit Deus neque falli ullo modo potest, evenire necesse est, quod providentia futurum esse præviderit. Quare si ab æterno non facta hominum modo, sed etiam consilia voluntatesque prænoscit, nulla erit arbitrii libertas;

(3) Neque enim vel factum aliud ullum vel quælibet existere poterit voluntas, nisi quam nescia falli providentia divina præsensierit. Nam si res aliorum, quam provisæ sunt detorqueri valent, non jam erit futuri firma præscientia;

(4) Sed opinio potius incerta; quod de Deo nefas credere iudico.

(5) Aiunt enim non ideo quid esse eventurum quoniam id providentia futurum esse prospexerit; sed e contrario potius, quoniam quid futurum est, id divinam providentiam latere non possit.

(6) Eoque modo necessarium est hoc in contrariam relabi partem; neque enim necesse est contingere quæ providentur, sed necesse est quæ futura sunt provideri.

(7) Quasi vero quæ cujusque rei causa sit,

(8) Præscientiane futurorum necessitatis an futurorum necessitas providentiæ, laboretur.

(9) At nos illud demonstrare nitamur, quoquo modo sese habeat ordo causarum, necessarium esse eventum præscitarum rerum, etiam si præscientia futuris rebus eveniendi necessitatem non videatur inferre.

(10) Etenim si quispiam sedeat, opinionem quæ eum sedere conjectat veram esse necesse est: at e converso rursus,

(11) Si de quopiam vera sit opinio quoniam sedet eum sedere necesse est. In utroque igitur necessitas inest: in hoc quidem sedendi, at vero in altero veritatis.

(12) Sed non idcirco quisque sedet, quoniam vera est opinio: sed hæc potius vera est, quoniam quempiam sedere præcessit. Ita cum causa veritatis ex altera parte procedat, inest tamen communis in utraque necessitas.

(13) Similia de providentia futurisque rebus ratiocinari patet.

(14) Nam etiam si idcirco, quoniam futura sunt, providentur: non vero ideo, quoniam providentur, eveniunt: nihilo minus tamen a Deo vel ventura provideri, vel provisa evenire necesse est:

(15) Quod ad perimendam arbitrii libertatem solum satis est.

(lib. v. pr. 3.)

See *Chaucer's Boethius*, [pp. 154-6](#).

IX. THE GRIEF OF REMEMBERING BYGONE HAPPINESS.

For, of fortunes scharp adversité,
The worste kynde of infortune is this,
A man to han ben in prosperité,
And it remembren, when it passed is.

(*Troilus and Cryseyde*, bk. iii. st. 226, vol. iv. p. 291.)

Sed hoc est, quod recolentem me vehementius coquit. Nam in omni adversitate fortunæ infelicissimum genus est infortunii, fuisse felicem. [10](#)

(*Boethius*, lib. ii. pr. 4.)

X. VULTURES TEAR THE STOMACH OF TITYUS IN HELL.

—————Syciphus in Helle,
Whos stomak fowles tyren everemo,
That hyghten volturis.

(*Troilus and Cryseyde*, book i. st. 113, p. 140.)

þe fowel þat hyȝt voltor þat etiþ þe stomak or þe giser of ticius.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, [p. 107](#).)

XI. THE MUTABILITY OF FORTUNE.

For if hire (Fortune's) whiel stynte any thinge to torne
Thanne cessed she Fortune anon to be.

(*Troilus and Cryseyde*, bk. i. st. 122, p. 142.)

If fortune bygan to dwelle stable. she cessed[e] þan to ben fortune.

(Chaucer's *Boethius*, [p. 32](#).)

(Compare stanzas 120, 121, p. 142, and stanza 136, p. 146, of 'Troilus and Cryseyde' with pp. 31, 33, 35, and p. 34 of Chaucer's *Boethius*.)

At omnium mortalium stolidissime, si manere incipit, fors esse desistit.

(*Boethius*, lib. ii. prose 1.)

XII. WORLDLY SELYNESSE

.

Imedled is with many a bitternesse.
Ful angwyschous than is, God woote, quod she,
Condicion of veyn prosperité!
For oyther joies comen nought yfeere,
Or elles no wight hath hem alwey here.

(*Troilus and Cryseyde*, bk. iii. st. 110, p. 258.)

þe swetnesse of mannes welefulnesse is yspranid wiþ many[e] bitterresses.

(Chaucer's *Boethius*, [p. 42](#).)

—ful anguissous þing is þe condicioun of mans goodes. For eyþer it comeþ al to-gidre to a wyzt. or ellys it lasteþ not perpetuely.

(*Ib.* [p. 41](#).)

Quam multis amaritudinibus humanæ felicitatis dulcedo respersa est!

(*Boethius*, lib. ii. prose 4.)

Anxia enim res est humanorum conditio bonorum, et quæ vel nunquam tota proveniat, vel nunquam perpetua subsistat.

(*Ib.*)

O, brotel wele of mannes joie unstable!
With what wight so thow be, or how thow pleye,
Oither he woot that thow joie art muable,
Or woot it nought, it mot ben on of tweyen:
Now if he woot it not, how may he seyen
That he hath veray joie and selynesse,
That is of ignoraunce ay in distresse?

Now if he woote that joie is transitorie,
As every joie of worldly thyng mot fle,
Thanne every tyme he that hath in memorie,
The drede of lesyng maketh hym that he
May in no parfyte selynesse be:

And if to lese his joie, he sette not a myte,
Than semeth it, that joie is worth ful lite.

(*Troilus and Cryseyde*, bk. iii. st. 111, 112, vol. iv. p. 258.)

(1) What man þat þis toumblyng welefulnesse leediþ, eiþer he woot þat [it] is chaungeable.
or ellis he woot it nat. And yif he woot it not. what blisful fortune may þer be in þe
blyndenesse of ignoraunce.

(2) And yif he woot þat it is chaungeable. he mot alwey ben adrad þat he ne lese þat þing.
þat he ne douteþ nat but þat he may leesen it. . . . For whiche þe continuel
drede þat he haþ ne suffriþ hym nat to ben weleful. Or ellys yif he leese it he wene[þ] to be
dispised and forleten hit. Certis eke þat is a ful lytel goode þat is born wiþ euene hert[e]
whan it is loost.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, [pp. 43, 44.](#))

(1) Quem caduca ista felicitas vehit, vel scit eam, vel nescit esse mutabilem. Si nescit,
quænam beata sors esse potest ignorantia in cæcitate?

(2) Si scit, metuat necesse est, ne amittat, quod amitti posse non dubitat; quare continuus
timor non sinit esse felicem. An vel si amisit, negligendum putat? Sic quoque perexile
bonum est, quod æquo animo feratur amissum.

(*Boethius*, lib. ii. prose 4.)

XIII. FORTUNE.

—————Fortune
That semeth trewest when she wol bigyle,
.
And, when a wight is from hire whiel ithrowe,
Than laugheth she, and maketh hym the mowe.

(*Troilus and Cryseyde*, bk. iii. st. 254, vol. iv. p. 299.)

She (Fortune) vseþ ful flatryng familiarité wiþ hem þat she enforceþ to bygyle.

(*Chaucer's Boethius*, [p. 30.](#))

. She lauþeþ and scorneþ þe wepyng of hem þe whiche she haþ
maked wepe wiþ hir free wille Yif þat a wyȝt is seyn weleful
and ouerþrowe in an houre.

(*Ib.* [p. 33.](#))

In book v., stanza 260, vol. v. p. 75, Chaucer describes how the soul of
Hector, after his death, ascended 'up to the holughnesse of the seventhe
spere.' In so doing he seems to have had before him met. 1, book 4, of
Boethius, where the 'soul' is described as passing into the heaven's utmost

sphere, and looking down on the world below. See *Chaucer's Boethius*, [p. 110](#), [111](#).

Ætas Prima is of course a metrical version of lib. ii. met. 5.

Hampole speaks of the wonderful sight of the Lynx; perhaps he was indebted to Boethius for the hint.—(See *Boethius*, book 3, pr. 8, [p. 81](#).)

I have seen the following elsewhere:

(1) Value not beauty, for it may be destroyed by a three days' fever.

(See *Chaucer's Boethius*, [p. 81](#).)

(2) There is no greater plague than the enmity of thy familiar friend.

(See *Chaucer's* translation, [p. 77](#).)

Chaucer did not English Boethius second-hand, through any early French version, as some have supposed, but made his translation with the Latin original before him.

Jean de Méung's version, the only early French translation, perhaps, accessible to Chaucer, is not always literal, while the present translation is seldom free or periphrastic, but conforms closely to the Latin, and is at times awkwardly literal. A few passages, taken haphazard, will make this sufficiently clear.

Et dolor ætatem jussit inesse suam. And sorow hap comaunded his age to be in me ([p. 4](#)).

Et ma douleur *commanda* a vieillesse
Entrer en moy / ains quen fust hors ieunesse.

*Mors hominum felix, quæ se nec dulcibus annis
Inserit, et mæstis sæpe vocata venit.*

Bilke deep of men is welful þat ne comeþ not in 3eres þat ben swete (i. *mirie*). but comeþ to wrecches often yclepid. ([p. 4](#))

On dit la mort des homes estre eueuse
Qui ne vient pas en saison plantureuse
Mais des tristes moult souuent appellee
Elle y affuit nue / seche et pelee.

Querimoniam lacrymabilem. Wepli compleynte ([p. 5](#)). Fr. ma complainte moy esmouuant a pleurs.

Styli officio. Wiþ office of poyntel ([p. 5](#)). Fr. (que ie reduisse) *par* escript.

Inexhaustus. Swiche . . . þat it ne my3t[e] not be emptid ([p. 5](#)). Fr. inconsumptible.

Scenicas meretriculas. Comune strumpetis of sicke a place þat men clepen þe theatre ([p. 6](#)). Fr. ces ribaudelles fardees.

Præcipiti profundo. In ouer-prowyng depnesse ([p. 7](#)).

[L]As que la pensee de lomme
Est troublee et plongie comme
En *abisme precipitee*
Sa propre lumiere gastee.

Nec peruetusta nec incelebris. Neyþer ouer-oolde ne vnsolempne ([p. 11](#)). Fr. desquelz la memoire nest pas trop ancienne ou *non* recitee.

Inter secreta otia. Among my secre restyng whiles ([p. 14](#)). Fr. entre mes secrettes *et* oyseuses estudes.

Palatini canes. Þe houndys of þe palays ([p. 15](#)). Fr. les chiens du palais.

Masculæ prolis. Of þi masculyn children ([p. 37](#)). Fr. de ta lignie masculine.

Ad singularem felicitatis tuæ cumulum venire delectat. It deliteþ me to comen now to þe singuler vphepyng of þi welefulnesse ([p. 37](#)). Fr. Il me plaist venir au singulier monceau de ta felicite.

Consulare imperium. Emperie of consulers ([p. 51](#)). Fr. lempire consulaire.

Hoc ipsum brevis habitaculi. Of þilke litel habitacle ([p. 57](#)). Fr. de cest trespetit habitacle.

Late patentēs plagas. Þe brode shewyng contreys ([p. 60](#)).

QViconques tend a gloire vaine
Et le croit estre souueraine
Voye *les regions patentēs*
Du ciel

Ludens hominum cura. Þe pleiyng besines of men ([p. 68](#)).

Si quil tollist par doulz estude
Des hommes la sollicitude . .

Hausi cælum. I took heuene ([p. 10](#)). Fr. ie . . . regarday le ciel.

Certamen adversum præfectum prætorii communis commodi ratione suscepi. I took strif azeins þe prouost of þe pretorie for comune profit ([p. 15](#)). Fr. ie entrepris lestrif a lencontre du prefect du parlement royal a cause de la commune vtilite.

At cuius criminis arguimur summam quæris? But axest þou in somme of what gilt I am accused? ([p. 17](#)). Fr. Mais demandes tu la somme du pechie duquel pechie nous sommes

arguez?

Fortuita temeritate. By fortunouse fortune ([p. 26](#)). Fr. par fortuite folie.

Quos premunt septem gelidi triones. Alle þe peoples þat ben vnder þe colde sterres þat hyȝten þe seuene triones ([p. 55](#)). Fr. ceulx de septentrion.

Ita ego quoque tibi veluti corollarium dabo. Ryȝt so wil I ȝeue þe here as a corolarie or a mede of coroune ([p. 91](#)). Fr. semblablement ie te donneray ainsi que vng correlative.

In stadio. In þe stadie or in þe forlonge ([p. 119](#)). Fr. ou (for au) champ.

Conjecto. I coniecte ([p. 154](#)). Fr. ie coniecture.

Nimum . . . adversari ac repugnare videtur. It semeþ . . . to repugnen and to contrarien gretly. Fr. Ce semble chose trop contraire et repugnante.

Universitatis ambitum. Envirounynge of þe vniuersite ([p. 165](#)). Fr. l'auironnement de l'universite.

Rationis universum. Vniuersite of resoun ([p. 165](#)). Fr. l'universite de Raison.

Scientiam nunquam deficientis instantiæ rectius æstimabis. Þou shalt demen [it] more ryȝtfully þat it is science of presence or of instaunce þat neuer ne fayleþ ([p. 174](#)). Fr. mais tu la diras plus droitement et mieulx science de instante presentiale non iamais defaillant mais eternelle.

Many of the above examples are very bald renderings of the original, and are only quoted here to show that Chaucer did not make his translation from the French.

Chaucer is not always felicitous in his translations:—thus he translates *clavus atque gubernaculum* by *keye and a stiere* ([p. 103](#)), and *compendium* (gain, acquisition) by *abreggyng* (abridging, curtailment), [p. 151](#). Many terms make their appearance in English for the first time,—and most of them have become naturalized, and are such as we could ill spare. Some few are rather uncommon, as *gouvernaile* (gubernaculum), [p. 27](#); *arbitre* (arbitrium), [p. 154](#). As Chaucer takes the trouble to explain *inestimable* (inæstimabilis), [p. 158](#), it could not have been a very familiar term.

Our translator evidently took note of various readings, for on [p. 31](#) he notes a variation of the original. On [p. 51](#) he uses *armurers* (= armures) to render *arma*, though most copies agree in reading *arva*.

There are numerous glosses and explanations of particular passages, which seem to be interpolated by Chaucer himself. Thus he explains what is meant by the *heritage of Socrates* (p. 10, 11); he gives the meaning of *coemption* (p. 15); of *Euripus* (p. 33); of the *porch* (p. 166).¹¹ Some of his definitions are very quaint; as, for instance, that of Tragedy—‘*a dité of a prosperité for a tyme þat endiþ in wrechednesse*’ (p. 35). One would think that the following definition of Tragedian would be rather superfluous after this, —‘*a maker of dites þat hyzten (are called) tregedies*’ (p. 77).

Melliflui . . . oris Homerus

is thus quaintly Englished: *Homer wiþ þe hony mouþe, þat is to seyn. homer wiþ þe swete dites* (p. 153).

The present translation of the *De Consolatione* is taken from Additional MS. 10,340, which is supposed to be the *oldest* manuscript that exists in our public libraries. After it was all copied out and ready for press, Mr Bradshaw was kind enough to procure me, for the purpose of collation, the loan of the Camb. University MS. li. 3. 21, from which the various readings at the foot of the pages are taken.

Had I had an opportunity of examining the Cambridge MS. carefully throughout before the work was so far advanced, I should certainly have selected it in preference to the text now given to the reader. Though not so ancient as the British Museum MS., it is far more correct in its grammatical inflexions, and is no doubt a copy of an older and very accurate text.

The Additional MS. is written by a scribe who was unacquainted with the force of the final *-e*. Thus he adds it to the preterites of strong verbs, which do not require it; he omits it in the preterites of weak verbs where it is wanted, and attaches it to passive participles (of weak verbs), where it is superfluous. The scribe of the Cambridge MS. is careful to preserve the final *-e* where it is a sign (1) of the definite declension of the adjective; (2) of the plural adjective; (3) of the infinitive mood; (4) of the preterite of weak verbs; (5) of present participles; ¹² (6) of the 2nd pers. pret. indic. of strong verbs; (7) of adverbs; (8) of an older vowel ending.

The Addit. MS. has frequently *thilk* (singular and plural), and *-nes* (in *wrechednes*, &c.), when the Camb. MS. has *thilke* ¹³ and *-nesse*.

For further differences the reader may consult the numerous collations at the foot of the page.

If the Chaucer Society obtains that amount of patronage from the literary public which it deserves, but unfortunately has yet not succeeded in getting, so that it may be enabled to go on with the great work which has been so successfully commenced, then the time may come when I shall have the opportunity of editing the Camb. MS. of Chaucer's Boethius for that Society, and lovers of Early English Literature will have two texts instead of one.

¹ Other translations are by John Walton of Osney, in verse, in 1410 (Reg. MS. 18, A 13), first printed at Tavistock in 1525, and to be edited some time or other for the E.E.T.S. An anonymous prose version in the Bodleian. George Coluile, alias Coldewel, 1556; J. T. 1609; H. Conningesbye, 1664; Lord Preston, 1695, 1712; W. Causton, 1730; Redpath, 1785; R. Duncan, 1789; anon. 1792 (Lowndes).

² Dante, in his *Convito*, says, "Misimi a legger quello *non conosciuto da molti* libro di Boezio, nel quale captivo e discacciato consolato s'avea."

³ Printed at Ghent, 1485.

⁴ By Reynier de Seinct Trudon, printed at Bruges, 1477.

⁵ An old version of the 11th cent., printed by Graff, and a modern one printed at Nuremberg, 1473.

⁶ By Jean de Méung, printed at Paris, 1494.

⁷ By Varchi, printed at Florence, 1551; Parma, 1798.

⁸ The Harl. MS. reads *not nat*, to the confusion of the metre.

⁹ = ne wot nat = knows not.

¹⁰ Cf. Dante, *Inferno*, V. 121.

Nessun maggior dolore
Che ricordarsi del tempo felice
Nella miseria; e ciò sa 'l tuo Dottore.

[11](#) See pages 39, 50, 61, 94, 111, 133, 149, 153, 159.

[12](#) In the *Canterbury Tales* we find participles in *-yngë*.

[13](#) It is nearly always *thilkë* in the *Canterbury Tales*.

APPENDIX TO INTRODUCTION.

THE last of the ancients, and one who forms a link between the classical period of literature and that of the middle ages, in which he was a favourite author, is Boethius, a man of fine genius, and interesting both from his character and his death. It is well known that after filling the dignities of Consul and Senator in the court of Theodoric, he fell a victim to the jealousy of a sovereign, from whose memory, in many respects glorious, the stain of that blood has never been effaced. The *Consolation of Philosophy*, the chief work of Boethius, was written in his prison. Few books are more striking from the circumstances of their production. Last of the classic writers, in style not impure, though displaying too lavishly that poetic exuberance which had distinguished the two or three preceding centuries, in elevation of sentiment equal to any of the philosophers, and mingling a Christian sanctity with their lessons, he speaks from his prison in the swan-like tones of dying eloquence. The philosophy that consoled him in bonds, was soon required in the sufferings of a cruel death. Quenched in his blood, the lamp he had trimmed with a skilful hand gave no more light; the language of Tully and Virgil soon ceased to be spoken; and many ages were to pass away, before learned diligence restored its purity, and the union of genius with imitation taught a few modern writers to surpass in eloquence the Latinity of Boethius.—(Hallam's *Literature of Europe*, i. 2, 4th ed. 1854.)

The Senator Boethius is the last of the Romans whom Cato or Tully could have acknowledged for their countryman. As a wealthy orphan, he inherited

the patrimony and honours of the Anician family, a name ambitiously assumed by the kings and emperors of the age; and the appellation of Manlius asserted his genuine or fabulous descent from a race of consuls and dictators, who had repulsed the Gauls from the Capitol, and sacrificed their sons to the discipline of the Republic. In the youth of Boethius the studies of Rome were not totally abandoned; a Virgil is now extant, corrected by the hand of a consul; and the professors of grammar, rhetoric, and jurisprudence, were maintained in their privileges and pensions by the liberality of the Goths. But the erudition of the Latin language was insufficient to satiate his ardent curiosity; and Boethius is said to have employed eighteen laborious years in the schools of Athens, which were supported by the zeal, the learning, and the diligence of Proclus and his disciples. The reason and piety of their Roman pupil were fortunately saved from the contagion of mystery and magic, which polluted the groves of the Academy, but he imbibed the spirit, and imitated the method, of his dead and living masters, who attempted to reconcile the strong and subtle sense of Aristotle with the devout contemplation and sublime fancy of Plato. After his return to Rome, and his marriage with the daughter of his friend, the patrician Symmachus, Boethius still continued, in a palace of ivory and [glass] to prosecute the same studies. The Church was edified by his profound defence of the orthodox creed against the Arian, the Eutychian, and the Nestorian heresies; and the Catholic unity was explained or exposed in a formal treatise by the *indifference* of three distinct though consubstantial persons. For the benefit of his Latin readers, his genius submitted to teach the first elements of the arts and sciences of Greece. The geometry of Euclid, the music of Pythagoras, the arithmetic of Nicomachus, the mechanics of Archimedes, the astronomy of Ptolemy, the theology of Plato, and the logic of Aristotle, with the commentary of Porphyry, were translated and illustrated by the indefatigable pen of the Roman senator. And he alone was esteemed capable of describing the wonders of art, a sundial, a water-clock, or a sphere which represented the motions of the planets. From these abstruse speculations, Boethius stooped, or, to speak more truly, he rose to the social duties of public and private life: the indigent were relieved by his liberality; and his eloquence, which flattery might compare to the voice of Demosthenes or Cicero, was uniformly exerted in the cause of innocence and humanity. Such conspicuous merit

was felt and rewarded by a discerning prince: the dignity of Boethius was adorned with the titles of consul and patrician, and his talents were usefully employed in the important station of master of the offices. Notwithstanding the equal claims of the East and West, his two sons were created, in their tender youth, the consuls of the same year. On the memorable day of their inauguration, they proceeded in solemn pomp from their palace to the forum amidst the applause of the senate and people; and their joyful father, the true Consul of Rome, after pronouncing an oration in the praise of his royal benefactor, distributed a triumphal largess in the games of the circus. Prosperous in his fame and fortunes, in his public honours and private alliances, in the cultivation of science and the consciousness of virtue, Boethius might have been styled happy, if that precarious epithet could be safely applied before the last term of the life of man.

A philosopher, liberal of his wealth and parsimonious of his time, might be insensible to the common allurements of ambition, the thirst of gold and employment. And some credit may be due to the asseveration of Boethius, that he had reluctantly obeyed the divine Plato, who enjoins every virtuous citizen to rescue the state from the usurpation of vice and ignorance. For the integrity of his public conduct he appeals to the memory of his country. His authority had restrained the pride and oppression of the royal officers, and his eloquence had delivered Paulianus from the dogs of the palace. He had always pitied, and often relieved, the distress of the provincials, whose fortunes were exhausted by public and private rapine; and Boethius alone had courage to oppose the tyranny of the Barbarians, elated by conquest, excited by avarice, and, as he complains, encouraged by impunity. In these honourable contests his spirit soared above the consideration of danger, and perhaps of prudence; and we may learn from the example of Cato, that a character of pure and inflexible virtue is the most apt to be misled by prejudice, to be heated by enthusiasm, and to confound private enmities with public justice. The disciple of Plato might exaggerate the infirmities of nature, and the imperfections of society; and the mildest form of a Gothic kingdom, even the weight of allegiance and gratitude, must be insupportable to the free spirit of a Roman patriot. But the favour and fidelity of Boethius declined in just proportion with the public happiness; and an unworthy colleague was imposed to divide and control the power of

the master of the offices. In the last gloomy season of Theodoric, he indignantly felt that he was a slave; but as his master had only power over his life, he stood without arms and without fear against the face of an angry Barbarian, who had been provoked to believe that the safety of the senate was incompatible with his own. The Senator Albinus was accused and already convicted on the presumption of *hoping*, as it was said, the liberty of Rome.

“If Albinus be criminal,” exclaimed the orator, “the senate and myself are all guilty of the same crime. If we are innocent, Albinus is equally entitled to the protection of the laws.” These laws might not have punished the simple and barren wish of an unattainable blessing; but they would have shown less indulgence to the rash confession of Boethius, that, had he known of a conspiracy, the tyrant never should. The advocate of Albinus was soon involved in the danger and perhaps the guilt of his client; their signature (which they denied as a forgery) was affixed to the original address, inviting the emperor to deliver Italy from the Goths; and three witnesses of honourable rank, perhaps of infamous reputation, attested the treasonable designs of the Roman patrician. Yet his innocence must be presumed, since he was deprived by Theodoric of the means of justification, and rigorously confined in the tower of Pavia, while the senate, at the distance of five hundred miles, pronounced a sentence of confiscation and death against the most illustrious of its members. At the command of the Barbarians, the occult science of a philosopher was stigmatized with the names of sacrilege and magic. A devout and dutiful attachment to the senate was condemned as criminal by the trembling voices of the senators themselves; and their ingratitude deserved the wish or prediction of Boethius, that, after him, none should be found guilty of the same offence.

While Boethius, oppressed with fetters, expected each moment the sentence or the stroke of death, he composed in the tower of Pavia the *Consolation of Philosophy*; a golden volume not unworthy of the leisure of Plato or Tully, but which claims incomparable merit from the barbarism of the times and the situation of the author. The celestial guide, whom he had so long invoked at Rome and Athens, now condescended to illumine his dungeon, to revive his courage, and to pour into his wounds her salutary balm. She taught him to compare his long prosperity and his recent distress, and to

conceive new hopes from the inconstancy of fortune. Reason had informed him of the precarious condition of her gifts; experience had satisfied him of their real value; he had enjoyed them without guilt; he might resign them without a sigh, and calmly disdain the impotent malice of his enemies, who had left him happiness, since they had left him virtue. From the earth, Boethius ascended to heaven in search of the SUPREME GOOD; explored the metaphysical labyrinth of chance and destiny, of prescience and free-will, of time and eternity; and generously attempted to reconcile the perfect attributes of the Deity with the apparent disorders of his moral and physical government. Such topics of consolation, so obvious, so vague, or so abstruse, are ineffectual to subdue the feelings of human nature. Yet the sense of misfortune may be diverted by the labour of thought; and the sage who could artfully combine in the same work the various riches of philosophy, poetry, and eloquence, must already have possessed the intrepid calmness which he affected to seek. Suspense, the worst of evils, was at length determined by the ministers of death, who executed, and perhaps exceeded, the inhuman mandate of Theodoric. A strong cord was fastened round the head of Boethius, and forcibly tightened till his eyes almost started from their sockets; and some mercy may be discovered in the milder torture of beating him with clubs till he expired. But his genius survived to diffuse a ray of knowledge over the darkest ages of the Latin world; the writings of the philosopher were translated by the most glorious of the English kings, and the third emperor of the name of Otho removed to a more honourable tomb the bones of a Catholic saint, who, from his Arian persecutors, had acquired the honours of martyrdom and the fame of miracles. In the last hours of Boethius, he derived some comfort from the safety of his two sons, of his wife, and of his father-in-law, the venerable Symmachus. But the grief of Symmachus was indiscreet, and perhaps disrespectful; he had presumed to lament, he might dare to revenge, the death of an injured friend. He was dragged in chains from Rome to the palace of Ravenna; and the suspicions of Theodoric could only be appeased by the blood of an innocent and aged senator.—Gibbon's *Decline and Fall*, 1838, vol. vii. p. 45-52 (without the notes).

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and the corresponding page of the translation).*

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[I] NCIPIT TABULA LIBRI BOICII DE CONSOLACIONE PHILOSOPHIE.

[Additional MS. 10,340, fol. 3.]

[LIBER PRIMUS.](#)

[fol. 3.]

1 Carmina qui quondam studio florente peregi.

- 2 Hic dum mecum tacitus.
3 Heu *quam* precipiti.
4 Set medicine inquit tempus.
5 Tunc me discussa.
6 Haut ¹ aliter tristicie.
7 Quisquis composito.
8 Sentis ne inquit.
9 O stelliferi conditor orbis.
10 Hic ubi continuato dolore.
11 Cum phebi radijs.
12 Primum igitur pateris rogacionibus.
13 Nubibus atris condita.

1 MS. hanc.

EXPLICIT LIBER PRIMUS.

LIBER SECUNDUS.

- 1 Postea paulisper ² conticuit.
2 Hec cum superba.
3 Uellem autem pauca.
4 Si quantas rapidis.
5 His igitur si *et* pro se.
6 Cum primo polo.
7 Tunc ego uera *inquam*.
8 Contraque.
9 Quisquis ualet *perhennem* cantus.
10 Set cum rationum iam in te.

2 MS. luper.

- 11 Felix *in* mirum iam prior etas.
- 12 Quid *autem* de dignitatibus.
- 13 Nouimus quantos dederat.
- 14 Tum ego scis *inquam*.
- 15 Quicumque solam mente.
- 16 Set ne me inexorabile.
- 17 Quod mundus stabile fide.

EXPLICIT LIBER SECUNDUS.

LIBER TERTIUS.

- 1 Iam tantum illa.
- 2 Qui serere ingenium.
- 3 Tunc defixo paululum.
- 4 Quantas rerum flectat.
- 5 Uos quoque terrena animalia.
- 6 Quamuis fluenter diues.
- 7 Set dignitatibus.
- 8 Quamuis se tirio.
- 9 An uero regna.
- 10 Qui se ualet esse potentem.
- 11 Gloria uero *quam* fallax.
- 12 Omne hominum genus in terris.
- 13 Quid *autem* de corporibus.
- 14 Habet hoc uoluptas.
- 15 Nichil igitur *dubium* est.

- 16 Heu *que* miseros tramite.
17 Hactenus mendacio formam.
18 O qui *perpetua*.
19 *Quoniam* igitur qui scit.
20 Nunc omnes pariter.
21 Assencior *inquam* cuncta.
22 Quis^{que} profunda.
23 Tunc ego platoni *inquam*.
24 Felix qui poterit.

EXPLICIT LIBER TERTIUS.

LIBER QUARTUS.

- 1 Hec cum philosophia.
2 Sunt etenim penne.
3 Tunc ego pape *inquam*.
4 Quos uides sedere celsos.
5 Uides ne igitur quanto.
6 U[e]lla naricij ducis.
7 Tunc ego fateor *inquam*.
8 Quid tantos iuuat.
9 Huic ego uideo *inquam*.
10 Si quis arcturi ³ sydera.
11 Ita est *inquam*.
12 Si uis celsi iura.
13 Iam ne igitur uides.

3 MS. arituri.

14 Bella bis quinis.

EXPLICIT LIBER QUARTUS.

INCIPIT LIBER QUINTUS.

1 Dixerat oracionis *que* cursum.

2 Rupis achemenie.

3 Animaduerto *inquam*.

4 Puro clarum lumine.

5 Tamen ego en *inquam*.

6 Que nam discors.

7 Tamen illa uetus.

8 Quondam porticus attulit.

9 Quod si *in* corporibus.

10 Quam uarijs figuris.

11 Quoniam igitur uti paulo ante.

EXPLICIT LIBER QUINTUS *ET* ULTIMUS.

ETHIUS DEPLORES HIS MISFORTUNES.

*LIBER PRIMUS.

[* fol. 3 b.]

INCIPIT LIBER BOICII DE CONSOLACIONE PHILOSOPHIE.

[The fyrste Metur.]

Carmina qui quondam studio florente peregi.

Allas I wepyng am constreined to bygynne vers of
sorouful matere. ¶ Þat whilom in florysching
studie made delitable ditees. For loo rendyng muses
of poetes enditen to me þinges to be writen. and drery 4
vers of wrecchednes weten my face wiþ verray teers.
¶ At þe leest no drede ne myzt[e] ouer-come þo muses.
þat þei ne weren felawes *and* folweden my wey. þat is
to seyne when I was exiled. þei þat weren glorie of 8
my you3th whilom weleful *and* grene conforten now þe
sorouful werdes of me olde man. for elde is comen
vnwarly
vpon me hasted by þe harmes þat I haue. *and*
sorou hap comaunded his age to be in me. ¶ Heeres 12
hore ben schad ouertymelyche vpon myne heued. and
þe slak[e] skyn trembleþ vpon myn emty body.
þilk[e] deep of men is welful þat ne comeþ not in 3eres
þat
ben swete (.i. mirie.) but comeþ to wrecches often 16
yclepid.

Boethius deplores his
misfortunes in the
following pathetic elegy.

ypalage antithesis

Laments his immature
old age.

Death turns a deaf ear to
the wretched.

- 1 *of*—MS. of of.
 2 *florysching*—floryssynge
 3 *rendyng*—rendynge
 4 *be*—ben
 5 *wrecchednes*—wrecchednesse
 teers—teeres
 6 *leest*—leeste
 myȝt[e] *ouer-come*—myhte ouercomen
 8 *seyne when*—seyn whan
 9 *youȝth*—MS. þoȝt, C. yowthe
 10 *sorouful werdes*—sorful wierdes [i. fata]
 12 *sorou*—sorwe
 hap—MS. haȝe
 be—ben
 13 *hore*—hoore
 ben—arn
 myne—myn
 14 *slak[e]*—slake
 vpon—of
 emty—emptyd
 þilk[e]—thilke
 15 *welful*—weleful
 comeþ not—comth nat
 16 .i. *mirie*—omitted

¶ Allas allas wiþ how deef an eere deep cruel
 tourneþ away fro wrecches *and* naieþ to closen wepyng
 eyen. ¶ While fortune vnfeipful fauored[e] me 20
 wiþ lyȝte goodes (.s. temporels.) þe sorouful houre þat
 is to seyne þe deep had[de] almost dreynt myne heued.
 ¶ But now for fortune cloudy hap chaunged hir
 disceyuable
 chere to me warde. myn vnpitouse lijf draweþ 24
 a long vnagreable dwellynges in me. ¶ O ȝe my
 frendes what or wherto auaunted[e] ȝe me to be

When Fortune was
 favourable Death came
 near Boethius,

but in his adversity life is
 unpleasantly protracted.

Why did his friends call
 him happy? He stood not
 firm that hath thus fallen.

weleful:

for he þat haþ fallen stood not *in* stedfast degree.

19 *tourneþ*—torneth

naieþ—nayteth

wepyng—wepyng

20 *While*—Whil

fauored[e]—fauorede

21 *lyzte*—lyhte

.s. temporels—omitted

sorouful houre—sorwful howre

22 *seyne*—seyn

had[de]—hadde

myne—myn

23 *haþ*—MS. haþe

chaunged hir disceyuable—chaungyd hyre deceyuable

24 *vnþitouse lijf*—vnþietous lyf

PHILOSOPHY APPEARS TO BOETHIUS.

[*HIC DUM MECUM TACITUS.*](#)

[The firste prose.]

IN þe mene while þat I stille recorded[e] þise þinges
28

Philosophy appears to Boethius, like a beautiful woman, and of great age.

wiþ my self. *and* markede my wepli compleynte wiþ
office of poyntel. I saw stondyng aboue þe heyzt of my
heued a woman of ful greet reuerence by semblaunt
hir eyen brennyng *and* clere seing ouer þe comune 32
myzt of men. wiþ a lijfly colour *and* wiþ swiche vigoure
and strenkeþ þat it ne myzt[e] not be emptid. ¶ Al
were it so þat sche was ful of so greet age. þat men ne
wolde not trowe *in* no manere þat sche were of oure 36
elde. þe stature of hir was of a doutous iugement. for
sumtyme sche constreyned[e] *and* schronk hir seluen
lyche to þe comune mesure of men. *and* sumtyme it
semed[e] þat sche touched[e] þe heuene wiþ þe heyzte 40

Her height could not be determined, for there were times when she raised her head higher than the heavens.

of hir heued. and when sche hef hir heued heyer sche
perced[e] þe selue heuene. so þat þe syzt of men lokyng
was in ydel. ¶ Hir cloþes weren maked of ryzt delye
þredes *and* subtil crafte of perdurable matere. þe
wyche 44

Her clothes were finely
wrought and
indissoluble, but dark
and dusky, like old
besmoked images.

cloþes sche hadde wouen wiþ hir owen hondes: as I
knew wel aftir by hir selfe. declaryng *and* schewyng
to me þe beaute. þe wiche cloþes a derkenes of a forleten
and dispised elde had[de] duskid *and* dirkid as 48
it is wont to dirken by-smoked ymages. ¶ In þe
neþerest[e]

On the lower hem of her
garment was the letter Π
and on the upper Θ.

hem or bordure of þese cloþes men redder
ywouen in swiche a gregkysche .P. þat signifiek þe lijf
actif. And abouen þat lettre in þe heyrest[e] bordure 52
a grekysche T. þat signifiek þe lijf contemplatif.

DESCRIPTION OF PHILOSOPHY.

¶ And by-twene þese two lettres þere weren seien
degrees
nobly wrouzt in manere of laddres. By wyche
degrees men myzt[en] clymbe fro þe neþemast[e] lettre 56
to þe ouermast[e]. ¶ Napeles hondes of sum men
hadde korue þat cloþe by vyolence *and* by strenkeþ.
¶ And eueryche man of hem hadde born away syche
peces as he myzte geet[e]. ¶ And forsoþe þis forsaide
60

Between the letters were
steps like a ladder.

Philosophy's garments
were tattered and torn,
and pieces had been
carried violently off.

In her right hand she
bore her books, and in
her left a sceptre.

woman ber bookes in hir ryzt honde. *and* in hir lefte
honde sche ber a ceptre. ¶ And when sche sauþ þese
poetical muses aprochen aboute my bedde. *and* endytyng
wordes to my wepynges. sche was a lytel ameued 64

and glowed[e] wiþ cruel eyen. ¶ Who *quod* sche haþ
suffred aprochen to þis seek[e] man þise comune
strumpetis

of siche a place þat *men clepen þe theatre.

¶ Þe wyche only ne asswagen not his sorowes. wiþ no 68
remedies. but þei wolde fede *and* norysche hem wiþ
swete venym. ¶ Forsope þise ben þo þat wiþ þornes
and prykynges of talent3 or affeccious wiche þat
ben no þing frutefyng nor profitable destroyen þe 72
cornes plenteuouse of frutes of reson. ¶ For þei
holden þe hertes of men *in* usage. but þei ne delyuere
not folk fro maladye. but if 3e muses hadde wiþdrawen
fro me wiþ 3oure flateries. any vnkonnyng *and* vnprofitable 76
man as men ben wont to fynde comunely amonges
þe peple. I wolde wene suffre þe lasse greuously.

Philosophy bids the
Muses leave Boethius, as
they only increase his
sorrow with their sweet
venom.

[* fol. 4.]

They may accustom the
mind to bear grief, but
cannot free it from its
malady.

PHILOSOPHY REBUKES THE MUSES.

¶ For-why in syche an vnprofitable man myne ententes
weren no þing endamaged. ¶ But 3e wiþdrawen me 80
þis man þat haþ ben norysched in studies or scoles of
Eleaticis *and* of achademicis in grece. ¶ But goþ now
raþer away 3e meremaydenes wyche ben swete til it
be at þe laste. *and* suffreþ þis man to be cured *and* 84
heled by myne muses. þat is to say by notful sciences.
¶ And þus þis compaygnie of muses I-blamed casten
wroþely þe chere adounward to þe erþe *and* schewyng
by redenesse hir schame þei passeden sorowfully þe 88
þreschefolde. ¶ And I of whom þe syzt plunged *in*
teres was derked so þat I ne myzt[e] not knowe what
þat woman was of so imperial auctorite. ¶ I wex al

Philosophy is deeply
grieved, because they
have not seduced one of
the profane, but one who
has been brought up in
Eleatic and Academic
studies.
She bids the syrens
begone.

Blushing for shame they
pass the threshold.

Boethius is astonished at
the presence of the
august dame.

a-besid *and* astoned. *and* caste my syȝt adoune in to þe 92
 erþe. *and* bygan stille forto abide what sche wolde don
 afterwarde. ¶ Þo come sche nere *and* sette hir down
 vpon þe vterrest[e] corner of my bedde. *and* sche
 byholdyng
 my chere þat was cast to þe erþe heuy *and* 96
 greuous of wepyng. compleinede wiþ þise wordes þat I
 schal sey þe perturbacioun of my þouȝt.

Philosophy expresses her
 concern for Boethius.

26 *auaunted[e]*—*auauntede*
be—ben

27 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
not—nat
stedfast—*stidefast*

28 *In þe mene*—omitted
recorded[e]—*recordede*

30 *saw*—MS. *sawe*, C. *sawh*
stondyng above—MS. *studying aboue*, C. *standinge abouen*
heyȝt—*heyhte*
my—*myn*

31 *greet*—*gret*

32 *brennyng*—*brennynge*
clere seing—*cleer seyng*

33 *swiche*—*swych*

34 *strenkeþ*—*strengthe*
it—*emptid*—*it myhte nat ben emted*
Al—*alle*

36 *wolde*—*trowe*—*wolden nat trowen*

37 *iugement*—*Iuggement*

38 *sumtyme*—*somtyme*
constreyned[e]—*constreynede*
schronk—MS. *schronke*, C. *shronk*

39 *lyche*—*lyk*

40 *semed[e]*—*semede*
touched[e]—*towchede*

41 *when*—*whan*
hef—MS. *heued*, C. *hef*
heyer—*hyere*

42 *perced[e]*—*percede*
syȝt—*syhte*

- lokyng*—lookynge
- 44 *crafte*—craft
- 45 *wouen*—MS. wonnen, C. wouen
owen hondes—owne handes
- 46 *knew*—MS. knewe, C. knewh
selfe declaryng—self declarynge
schewyng—shewynge
- 47 *derkenes*—dirknesse
forleten—forletyn
- 48 *dispised*—despised
had[de] duskid—hadde duskid
dirkid—derked
- 49 *by-smoked*—the smokede
neþerest[e]—nethereste
- 50 *þese*—thise
- 51 *swiche*—omitted
gregkysche—grekysshe
signifieþ—syngnifieth
- 52 *heyzest[e]*—heyeste
- 54 *by-twene þese*—bytwixen thise
þere—ther
seien—seyn
- 55 *nobly wrouȝt*—nobely ywroght
wyche—whiche
- 56 *myȝt[en] clymbe*—myhten clymbyn
neþemast[e]—nethereste
- 57 *ouermast[e]*—vppereste
sum—some
- 58 *hadde korue*—hadden koruen
cloþe—cloth
strenkeþ—strengthe
- 59 *born*—MS. borne, C. born
away syche—away swiche
- 60 *geet[e]*—geten
forsaide—forseide
- 61 *ber*—MS. bere, C. bar
bookes—smale bookes
honde—hand
lefte honde—left hand
- 62 *ber*—MS. bere, C. baar
sauȝ þese—say thise
- 63 *bedde*—bed
endytyng—enditynge

64 *ameued*—amoued
 65 *glowed[e]*—glowede
 hap—MS. haþe, C. hath
 66 *seek[e]*—sike
 þise—the
 strumpetis—strompetes
 67 *siche*—swich
 clepen—clepyn
 68 *only ne*—nat oonly ne
 not his—nat hise
 no—none
 69 *wolde fede*—wolden feeden
 norysche hem—noryssyn hym
 72 *ben*—ne ben
 frutefi yng—fructefi ynge
 73 *cornes plenteuouse*—corn plentyuos
 74 *þe* and *ne*—both omitted
 75 *not*—nat
 if 3e—MS. if þe, C. yif ye
 hadde—hadden
 76 *vnkonnyng*—vnkunnyng
 78 *peple*—poeple
 79 *sychē*—swhiche
 myne—myn
 80 *weren*—ne weeren
 3e—ye
 81 *hap*—MS. haþe, C. hath
 ben—be
 scoles—schooles
 82 *gop*—MS. goþe, C. goth
 83 *wyche*—whiche þat
 85 *say*—seyn
 notful—noteful
 86 *I-blamed*—Iblamyd
 87 *wroþely*—wrothly
 adounward—downward
 88 *redenesse*—rednesse
 sorowfully—sorwfully
 89 *þreschefolde*—thresshfold
 sy3t—syhte
 90 *derked*—dyrked
 my3t[e]—*knowe*—myhte nat knowen
 91 *wex*—wax

92 *a-besid*—abaysshed
caste—cast
adoune in to—down to
 93 *don*—MS. done
 95 *vtterrest[e] corner*—vttereste cornere
bedde—bed
 97 *compleinede*—compley[n]de
 98 *sey*—seyen

PHILOSOPHY ADDRESSES BOETHIUS.

[HEU QUAM PRECIPITI MERSA PROFUNDO.](#)

[The 2de Metur.]

Allas how þe þouzt of man dreint in ouer þrowyng
 depnesse dulleþ *and* forletip hys propre
 clerenesse. 100

Drowned in the depth of
 cares the mind loses its
 proper clearness.

myntyng to gone in to foreyne derknesses as
 ofte as hys anoious bisines wexip wiþ-uten mesure.
 þat is dryuen to *and* fro wiþ worldly wyndes. ¶ Þis
 man þat sumtyme was fre to whom þe heuene was
 open 104

Man in his freedom
 knew each region of the
 sky, the motions of the
 planets, and was wont to
 investigate the causes of
 storms, the nature and
 properties of the seasons,
 and the hidden causes of
 nature.

and knowen *and* was wont to gone in heuenelyche
 papes. *and* sauþ þe lyztnesse of þe rede sunne. *and* sauþ
 þe sterres of þe colde moone. *and* wyche sterre in
 heuene vseþ wandryng risorses yflit by dyuerse speres. 108

¶ Þis man ouer comere hadde *comprehendid* al þis by
 noumbre. of accountyng in astronomye. ¶ And ouer
 þis he was wont to seche þe causes whennes þe sounyng
 wyndes moeuen *and* bisien þe smoþe water of þe 112
 see. *and* what spirit turneþ þe stable heuene. *and*
 whi þe sterre ryseþ oute of þe reede eest. to falle
 in þe westren wawes. and what attempriþ þe lusty
 houres of þe fyrste somer sesoun þat hizteþ *and* apparaileþ 116
 þe erþe wiþ rosene floures. ¶ And who

makeþ þat plenteuouse autumpne in fulle 3eres fletip
 wiþ heuy grapes. ¶ And eke þis man was wont to
 telle þe dyuerses causes of nature þat weren yhid. 120
 ¶ Allas now lieþ he emptid of lyzt of hys þouzt. *and*
 hys nekke is pressid wiþ heuy cheynes *and* bereþ his
 chere enclined adoune for þe greet[e] weyzt. and is
 constreyned to loke on foule erþe. 124

But now, alas, he is
 constrained to keep his
 face to the ground.

- 101 *gone*—goon
 102 *bisines*—bysynesse
 outen—owte
 103 *worldly*—wordely
 104 *sumtyme*—whilom
 105 *gone*—goon
 106 *papes*—paathes
 sau3—sawh
 lyztnesse—lythnesse
 sunne—sonne
 sau3—MS. sue, C. sawgh
 107 *wyche*—which
 108 *risorses*—recourses
 111 *seche*—seken
 sounyng—sownynge
 114 *ryseþ oute*—aryseth owt
 falle—fallen
 115 *westren*—westrene
 116 *fyrste*—fyrst
 119 *eke*—ek
 120 *dyuerses*—diuerse
 yhid—MS. yhidde
 121 *lieþ*—lith
 emptid—emted
 123 *adoune*—adown
 greet[e] weyzt—grete weyhte
 124 *loke*—*foule*—looken on the fool

B vt tyme is now *quod* sche of medicine more þen
of

More need of medicine
than of complaint.

compleynte. ¶ Forsoþe þen sche entending to
me warde wiþ al þe lokyng of hir eyen saide. ¶ Art
not þou he *quod* sche þat sumtyme I-norschid wiþ my

Philosophy addresses
Boethius.

128

mylke *and* fostre[d] wiþ my meetes were ascaped *and*
comen to corage of a perfit man. ¶ Certys I 3af þe
syche armures þat 3if þou þi self ne haddest first caste
hem away. þei schulden haue defendid þe in sykernesse 132

þat may not be ouer-comen. ¶ Knowest þou me not.

*Why art þou stille. is it for schame or for astonyng.

[* fol. 4 b.]

It were me leuer þat it were for schame. but it semep
me þat astonyng haþ oppressed þe. ¶ And whan 136
sche say me not oonly stille. but wiþ-uten office of
tonge *and* al doumbe. sche leide hir honde softely
vpon

She fears his silence
proceeds from shame
rather than from
stupidity.
She finds him, however,
in a lethargy, the
distemper of a
disordered mind.

my brest *and* seide. ¶ Here nis no *peril quod* sche.

¶ He is fallen in to a litargie. whiche þat is a comune 140

sekenes to hertes þat ben desceiued. ¶ He haþ a litel
for3eten hym self. but certis he schal ly3tly remembren
hym self. ¶ 3if so be þat he haþ knowen me or now.

and þat he may so done I wil wipe a litel hys eyen. 144

þat ben derked by þe cloude of mortel þinges ¶ Þise
wordes seide sche. and wiþ þe lappe of hir garment
yplitid in a frounce sche dried[e] myn eyen þat were
ful of þe wawes of my wepynges. 148

To make his recovery an
easy matter, she wipes
his eyes, which were
darkened by the clouds
of mortal things, and
dries up his tears.

127 *al*—alle
 saide—seyde
 128 *sumtyme*—whilom
 I-norschid—MS. I-norschide, C. noryssed
 129 *fostre[d]*—fostered
 my—myne
 130 *Certys*—Certes
 ʒaf, *yaf*
 131 *syche*—swiche
 ʒif—yif
 caste—C. cast
 132 *away*—away
 schulden haue—sholden han
 133 *not be*—nat ben
 Knowest þou—knowestow
 134 *art þou*—artow
 136 *hap*—MS. haþe
 138 *tonge*—tunge
 doumbe—dowmb
 honde—hand
 139 *Here*—her
 140 *litargie whiche*—litarge which
 141 *sekenes*—sykenesse
 141, 143 *hap*—MS. haþe
 144 *done*—doon
 wil wipe—wol wyphen
 146 *garment*—garnement
 147 *dried[e]*—dryede
 were—weeren
 148 *ful*—fulle

ETHIUS RECOGNIZES HIS PHYSICIAN.

TUNC ME DISCUSSA.

Þus when þat nyȝt was discussed *and* chased away.
 derknesses forleften me. *and* to myn eyen repeyre
 aȝeyne her firste strenkeþ. and ryȝt by ensample as
 þe sonne is hid when þe sterres ben clustred. þat is to

152

[The 3^{de} Metur.]

Her touch dispels the
 darkness of his soul, just
 as the heavy vapours,
 that darken the skies and
 obscure the sunlight, are
 chased away by the north
 wind, causing the return
 of the hidden day, when

sey when sterres ben couered wiþ cloudes by a swifte
 wynde þat hyzt chorus. *and* þat þe firmament stont
 derked by wete ploungy cloudes. and þat þe sterres not
 apperen vpon heuene. ¶ So þat þe nyzt semeþ sprad 156
 vpon erþe. ¶ Yif þan þe wynde þat hyzt borias
 sent out of þe kaues of þe contre of Trace betiþ þis
 nyzt. þat is to seyn chasiþ it away *and* descouereþ þe
 closed day. ¶ Þan schineþ phebus yshaken wiþ 160
 sodeyne lyzt *and* smyteþ wiþ hys bemes in meruelyng
 eyen.

the sun smites our
 wondering sight with his
 sudden light.

149 *when*—whan

150 *myn*—myne
repeyre—repeyrede

151 *azeyne*—omitted
her firste—hir fyrst

152 *hid*—MS. hidde, C. hid
when—whan

153 *sey*—seyn
when—whan

154 *hyzt*—heyhte
chorus—MS. thorus
stont—MS. stonde, C. stant

157 *þan*—thanne
wynde—wynd
hyzt—hyhte

158 *sent*—isent

160 *þan*—thanne

161 *sodeyne*—sodeyn

E TRIALS OF PHILOSOPHY AND PHILOSOPHERS.

[HAUT](#) ¹ [ALITER TRISTICIE.](#)

[The 3^{de} prose.]

¹ MS. hanc.

R yzt so *and* none oþer wyse þe cloudes of sorowe
 dissolued *and* don away. ¶ I took heuene. *and* 164
 receyuede mynde to knowe þe face of my fyciscien.

The clouds of sorrow
 being dispelled, Boethius
 recollects the features of

¶ So þat I sette myne eyen on hir *and* festned[e] my
lokyng. I byholde my norice philosophie. in whos
houses I hadde conuersed *and* haunted fro my zouþe. 168

his Physician, whom he
discovers to be
Philosophy.

and I seide þus. ¶ O þou maistresse of alle uertues
descendid fro þe souereyne sete. Whi art þou comen
in to þis solitarie place of myn exil. ¶ Art þou comen
for þou art mad coupable wiþ me of fals[e] blames. 172

He addresses her.

¶ O *quod* sche my norry scholde I forsake þe now. and
scholde I not parte wiþ þe by comune trauaille þe
charge

She expresses her
concern for him, and
tells him that she is
willing to share his
misfortunes.

þat þou hast suffred for envie of my name. ¶ Certis
it nar[e] not leueful ne sitting to philosophie to leten 176
wiþ-uten compaignie þe wey of hym þat is innocent.

¶ Scholde I þan redoute my blame *and* agrisen as þou3
þer were byfallen a newe þing. q. d. non. ¶ For
trowest þou þat philosophi be now alþerfirst assailed 180

She fears not any
accusation, as if it were a
new thing.

in perils by folk of wicked[e] maneres. ¶ Haue I not
stryuen wiþ ful greet strife in olde tyme byfore þe
age of my plato azeins þe foolhardines of foly *and*
eke þe same plato lyuyng. hys maistre socrates 184
deserued[e] victorie of vnry3tful deef in my presence.

For before the age of
Plato she contended
against folly, and by her
help Socrates triumphed
over an unjust death.

¶ Þe heritage of wyche socrates. þe heritage is to seyne
þe doctrine of þe whiche socrates in hys oppinioun of
felicite þat I clepe welfulnesse ¶ Whan þat þe people
188

Of the inheritance of
Socrates the rout of
Epicureans and Stoics
wanted to get a part.

of epicuriens *and* stoyciens *and* many oper enforceden
hem to go rauische eueryche man for his part þat is
to seyne. þat to eueryche of hem wolde drawen to þe
defence of his oppinioun þe wordes of socrates. ¶ Þei
192

Philosophy withstood
them, whereupon they
tore her robe, and,
departing with the

as in *partie* of hir preye todrowen me criynge *and*
debatyng þer azeins. *and* tornen *and* torenten my
cloþes

shreds, imagined that
they had got possession
of her.

þat I hadde wouen wiþ myn handes. *and* wiþ þe
cloutes þat þei hadden arased oute of my cloþes. þei 196

wenten away wenyng þat I hadde gon wiþ hem euery
dele. In whiche epicuryens *and* stoyciens. for as

Thus, clothed with her
spoils, they deceived
many.

myche as þer semed[e] somme traces *and* steppes of
myne habit. þe folye of men wenyng þo epicuryens 200

and stoyciens my *familers peruertede (.s. *persequendo*) [* fol. 5.]

somme þoru3 þe errour of þe wikked[e] or vnkunnyng[e]

multitude of hem. ¶ Þis is to seyne for þei
semeden philosophres: þei weren pursued to þe deef

Philosophy adduces
examples of wise men,
who had laboured under
difficulties on account of
being her disciples.

204

and slayn. ¶ So yif þou hast not knowen þe exilynge
of anaxogore. ne þe empoysenyng of socrates. ne þe
tourment3 of 3eno for þei [weren] straungers.

¶ 3it my3test þou haue knowen þe senectiens *and* þe Canyos 208

and þe sorancis of wyche folk þe renoun is neyþer ouer

oolde ne vnsolempne. ¶ Þe whiche men no þing ellys

ne brou3t[e] hem to þe deef but oonly for þei weren

enfourmed of my maneres. *and* semeden moste vnlyke 212

to þe studies of wicked folk. ¶ And forþi þou au3test

not to wondre þou3 þat I in þe bitter see of þis lijf be

fordryuen wiþ tempestes blowyng aboute. in þe
whiche

It is the aim of
Philosophy to displease
the wicked, who are
more to be despised than
dreaded, for they have
no leader.

tempeste þis is my most purpos þat is to seyn to
displese 216

to wikked[e] men. ¶ Of whiche schrews al be

þe oost neuer so grete it is to dispyse. for it nis gouerned

wiþ no leder of resoune. but it is rauysched only by
flityng errour folylly *and* lyztly. ¶ And if þei somtyme
220

makyng an ost aʒeynest vs assaile vs as strengere. oure
leder draweþ to gedir hys rycchesse in to hys toure.
and þei ben ententif aboute sarpulers or sachels
vnprofitable

forto taken. but we þat ben hey3 abouen syker 224
fro al tumulte *and* wode noise. ben stored *and* enclosed
in syche a palays. whider as þat chaterying or anoying
folye ne may not attayne. ¶ We scorne swiche
rauiners *and* honters of foulest[e] þinges. 228

If Philosophy is attacked
by the wicked, she
retires within her
fortress, leaving the
enemy busy among the
useless baggage, and
laughing to scorn such
hunters of trifles.

163 *none oþer*—non oother
sorowe—sorwe

165 *knowe*—knownen

166 *myne*—myn
festned[e]—fastnede

170 *fro*—from

170, 171 *art þou*—artow

172 *mad*—MS. made, C. maked
fals[e]—false

174 *parte*—parten

176 *nar[e]*—nere
sittyng—sittinge

178 *þan*—thanne

179 *þing*—thing
q.d. non—omitted

180 *trowest þou*—trowestow
alþerfirst—alderfirst

181 *wicked[e]*—wikkede

182 *strife*—strif

183 *aʒeins*—ayenis
foolhardines—foolhardinesse
folly—folie

184 *eke*—ek

185 *deserued[e]*—desseruede

186 *wyche*—the which
 seyne—seyn
 188 *welfulnesse*—welefulnesse
 189 *oper*—oothre
 190 *go*—gon
 eueryche—euerich
 191 *seyne*—seyn
 to—omitted
 eueryche—euerich
 194 *tornen*—*read* coruen, C. koruen
 195 *wouen*—MS. wonnen, C. wouen
 196 *arased*—arraced
 197 *gon*—MS. gone, C. gon
 198 *dele*—del
 199 *myche*—moche
 semed[e]—semede
 and—or
 200 *myne*—myn
 wenyng—MS. wevyng, C. weninge
 202 *þoru3*—thorw
 wikked[e]—wikkede
 vnkunnyng[e]—vnkunnynge
 203 *seyne*—seyn þat
 204 *semeden*—semede
 pursued—MS. pursuede, C. pursued
 205 *slayn*—MS. slayne, C. slayn
 207 [*weren*]*—weeren*
 208 *my3test þou haue*—myhtestow han
 209 *sorancis*—sorans
 wyche—which
 is—nis
 210 *oolde*—MS. colde, C. old
 211 *brou3t[e]*—browhte
 212 *enfourmed*—MS. vnfourmed, C. enformyd
 my—myne
 vnlyke—vnlyk
 213 *wicked folk*—wikkede foolke
 au3test—owhtest
 214 *wondre*—wondren
 bitter—bittre
 216 *displese*—displesen

217 *wikked[e]*—*wikkede*
schrews—*shrewes*
 218 *oost*—*glossed acies* in C.
grete—*gret*
 219, 222 *leder*—*ledere*
 220 *flityng*—*fleetynge*
lyztly—*lythly*
if—*yif*
 221 *azeynest*—*ayenis*
 222 *to*—*rycchesse*, to gydere hise rychesses
toure—*towr*
 224 *hey3*—*heye*
 225 *al*—*alle*
ben—*omitted*
stored—*warnestored*
 226 *syche*—*swich*
pat—*omitted*
 227 *scorne*—*schorne*
 228 *rauiners*—*pinges*—*rauyneres* & *henteres* of *fowleste* thinges

E AIM OF PHILOSOPHY.

QUISQUIS COMPOSITO.

[The ferthe Metur.]

Who so it be þat is clere of vertue sad *and* wel
 ordinat
 of lyuyng. þat haþ put vnderfote þe prowed[e]
 wierdes *and* lokip vpryzt vpon eyþer fortune. he may
 holde hys chiere vndiscomfited. ¶ Þe rage ne þe
 manace 232
 of þe commoeuyng or chasyng vpwarde hete fro þe
 botme. ne schal not moeue þat man. ne þe vnstable
 mountaigne þat hyzt veseuus. þat wircheþ oute þoru3
 hys broken[e] chemineys smokyng fires. ¶ Ne þe wey 236
 of þonder lyzt þat is wont to smyte hey3e toures ne
 schal not mouene þat man. ¶ Wherto þen wrecches
 drede 3e tyrauntes þat ben wode *and* felownes wiþ-

He who hath triumphed
 over fate, and remained
 insensible to the changes
 of Fortune, shall not be
 moved by storms, nor by
 the fires of Vesuvius, nor
 by the fiercest
 thunderbolts.

Fear not the tyrant's
 rage.

outen

ony strenkeþ. ¶ Hope after no þing ne drede nat. *and*

240

so schalt þou desarmen þe ire of þilke vnmyȝty tyraunt.

¶ But who so þat quakyng dredeþ or desireþ þing þat
nis not stable of his ryȝt. þat man þat so doþ haþ cast
away hys schelde *and* is remoeued fro hys place. *and* 244
enlaceþ hym in þe cheyne wiþ whiche he may be
drawen.

He who neither fears nor
hopes for anything
disarms the tyrant.

He whose heart fails
him, yields his arms, and
forges his own fetters.

229 *clere*—cleer

230 *lyuyng*—leuyng

haþ—MS. haþe

vnderfote—vndir-foot

prowed[e]—prowde

231 *may*—*chiere*—may his cheere holde

232 *manace*—manesses

233 *þe*—þe see

235 *hyȝt*—hihte

veseuus—MS. vesenus

wircheþ—writith

236 *broken[e]*—brokene

smokyng—smokyng

237 *smyte*—smyten

238 *Wherto þen*—wharto thanne

239 *felownes*—*ony*—felonos withowte any

241 *schalt þou desarmen*—shaltow deseruien

243 *doþ*—MS. doþe, C. doth

haþ—MS. haþe, C. hath

cast—MS. caste, C. cast

244 *schelde*—sheld

remoeued fro—remwed from

245 *whiche*—the which

be—ben

ETHIUS SPEAKS OF HIS TROUBLES.

[SENTIS NE INQUIT.](#)

[The verthe prose.]

F Elest þou *quod* sche þise þinges *and* entren þei
ouȝt

Philosophy seeks to
know the malady of
Boethius.

in þi corage. ¶ Art þou like an asse to þe harpe. 248
Whi wepest þou whi spillest þou teres. ¶ Yif þou
abidest after helpe of þi leche. þe byhoueþ discouere þi
wounde. ¶ Ðo .I. þat hadde gadered strenkeþ in my
corage answered[e] *and* seide. *and* nedeþ it ȝitte *quod*

Boethius complains of
Fortune's unrelenting
rage.

252

.I. of rehersyng or of amonicioun. *and* scheweþ it not
ynouȝ by hym self þe scharpnes of fortune þat wexeþ
woode aȝeynes me. ¶ Ne moeueþ it nat þe to seen þe
face or þe manere of þis place (.i. prisoun.). ¶ Is þis 256
þe librarie wyche þat þou haddest chosen for a ryȝt
certeyne sege to þe in myne house. ¶ Þere as þou
desputest of[te] wiþ me of þe sciences of þinges touching
diuinitee *and* touchyng mankynde. ¶ Was þan 260
myn habit swiche as it is now. was þan my face or

Is not she moved, he
asks, with the aspect of
his prison?

His library, his habit, and
his countenance are all
changed.

quasi diceret non.

my chere swiche as now. ¶ Whan I souȝt[e] wiþ þe
secretys of nature. whan þou enfourmedest my maners
and þe resoun of al my lijf. to þe ensauple of þe ordre 264

ironice

Is this, he asks, the
reward of his fidelity?

of heuene. ¶ Is nat þis þe gerdoun þat I refere to þe
to whom I haue be obeisaunt. ¶ Certis þou enfourmedist
by þe mouþe of plato þis sentence. þat is to
seyne þat *commune* þinges or comunabletes weren 268
blysfyl yif þei þat haden studied al fully to wisdom
gouerneden þilke þinges. or ellys yif it so by-felle þat
þe gouernours *of *communalites* studieden in grete
wisdomes.

Plato (de Rep. v.) says
that those
Commonwealths are
most happy that are
governed by
philosophers, or by those
who study to be so.

[* fol. 5 b.]

PHILOSOPHERS TO BE POLITICIANS.

¶ Thou saidest eke by þe mouþe of þe same 272
plato þat it was a necessarie cause wyse men to taken
and desire þe gouernaunce of comune þinges. for þat
þe
gouernementes of comune citees y-left in þe hondes of
felonous *tourmentours* Citizenis ne scholde not brynge 276
inne pestilence *and* destruccioun to goode folk. ¶ And
þerfore I folowyng þilk auctoritee (.s. platonis).
desiryng
to put[te] furþe in execusioun *and* in acte of comune
administracioun þo þinges þat .I. hadde lerned of þe 280
among my secre restyng whiles. ¶ Thou *and* god þat
put[te] þee in þe þouȝtis of wise folk ben knowen wiþ
me þat no þing brouȝt[e] me to maistrie or dignite: but
þe comune studie of al goodenes. ¶ And þer-of comeþ
284
it þat by-twixen wikked folk *and* me han ben greuouse
discordes. þat ne myȝten not be relested by *prayeres*.
¶ For þis libertee haþ freedom of conscience þat þe
wrappe
of more myȝty folk haþ alwey ben despised of me for
288
saluacioun of ryȝt. ¶ How ofte haue .I. resisted *and*
wiþstonde þilk man þat hyȝt[e] conigaste þat made
alwey assautes aȝeins þe propre fortunes of poure feble
folke. ¶ How ofte haue .I. ȝitte put of. or cast out 292
hym trigwille prouost of þe kynges hous boþe of þe
wronges þat he hadde bygon[ne] to done *and* eke fully
performed. ¶ How ofte haue I couered *and* defended

The same Plato urged philosophers to take upon them the management of public affairs, lest it should fall into the hands of unprincipled citizens.

Boethius declares that he desired to put in practice (in the management of public affairs) what he had learnt in his retirement.

He sought to do good to all, but became involved in discord with the wicked.

Consciousness of integrity made him despise the anger of the most powerful.

He opposed Conigastus, and put a stop to the doings of Triguilla.

by þe auctorite of me put azeins perils. þat is to seine
put 296

He put his authority in
peril for the defence of
poor folk.

myne auctorite in peril for þe wreched pore folke. þat
þe couetise of straungeres vnpunysched *tourmentid* alwey
wiþ myseses *and* greuaunces oute of noumbre.

ETHIUS DEFENDS HIS OWN CONDUCT.

¶ Neuer man drow me 3itte fro ry3t to wrong. When I
say þe 300

I never deviated, he says,
from the path of justice.

fortunes *and* þe rychesse of þe people of þe prouinces
ben harmed eyþer by priue rauynes or by comune
tributis or cariages. as sory was I as þei þat suffred[e]
þe harme. *Glosa.* ¶ Whan þat theodoric þe kyng of 304
gothes in a dere 3ere hadde hys gerneris ful of corne
and comaundede þat no man ne schold[e] bie no corne
til his corne were solde *and* þat at a dere greuous pris.

I felt for those that were
wrongfully oppressed.

¶ But I *withstod* þat ordinaunce *and* ouer-com it 308
knowyng al þis þe kyng hym self. ¶ Coempcioun þat
is to seyn comune achat or bying to-gidere þat were
establisshed vpon poeple by swiche a manere imposicioun
as who so bou3t[e] a busshel corn he most[e] 3eue þe 312
kyng þe fifte part. *Textus.* ¶ Whan it was in þe
soure hungry tyme þere was establisshed or cried
greuous

I opposed successfully
Coemption in Campania.

and inplitable coempcioun þat men seyn wel it schulde
greetly *tourmentyn and* endamagen al þe prouince of 316
compaigne I took strif azeins þe prouost of þe pretorie
for comune profit. ¶ And þe kyng knowyng of it I
ouercom it so þat þe coempcioun ne was not axed ne
took effect. ¶ Paulyng a counseiller of Rome þe

I saved Paulinus out of
the hands of the hounds

rychesse 320

of the palace (*Palatini canes*).

of þe whyche paulyn þe houndys of þe palays. þat is to
seyn þe officeres wolde han deuoured by hope *and*
couetise ¶ 3it drow I hym out of þe Iowes .s. *faucibus*
of hem þat gapeden. ¶ And for as myche as þe peyne

I defended Albinus
against Cyprian.

324

of þe accusacioun aiuged byforn ne scholde not sodeynly
henten ne punischen wrongfully Albyn a counseiller of
Rome. I put[te] me azenis þe hates *and* indignaciouns
of þe accusour Ciprian. ¶ Is it not þan ynought yseyn 328
þat I haue purchased greet[e] discordes azeins my self.
but I aughte be more asseured azenis alle oper folk þat
for þe loue of ry3twisnesse .I. ne reserued[e] neuer no
þing to my self to hem ward of þe kynges halle .s. officers. 332
by þe whiche I were þe more syker. ¶ But þoru3 þe
same accusours accusyng I am condempned.

For the love of justice I
forfeited all favour at
Court.

E ACCUSERS OF BOETHIUS.

¶ Of þe noumbre of whiche accusours one basilius þat
somytyme
was chased out of þe kynges seruice. is now compelled
336

Boethius makes mention
of his accusers, Basilius,
Opilio, Gaudencius, men
who had been
commanded to leave the
city on account of their
many crimes.

in accusyng of my name for nede of foreine
moneye. ¶ Also opilion *and* Gaudencius han accused
me. al be it so þat þe Iustice regal hadde sumtyme demed
hem boþe to go in to exil. for her treccheries *and* fraudes 340
wiþ-outhe noumbre. ¶ To whiche iugement þei wolde
not obeye. but defended[e] hem by sykernesse of holy
houses. *þat is to seyne fledden in to seyntuaries. *and*
whan þis was aperceiued to þe kyng. he comaunded[e] 344

[* fol. 6.]

but þat þei voided[e] þe citee of Rauenne by certeyne
day assigned þat men scholde merken hem on þe forheued
wiþ an hoke of iren *and* chasen hem out of toune.

¶ Now what þing semeþ þe myȝt[e] be lykned to þis 348
cruelte. For certys þilk same day was receyued þe
accusyng

of my name by þilk[e] same accusours. ¶ What
may be seid herto. haþ my studie *and* my konnyng
deserued þus. or ellys þe forseide dampnacioun of me. 352
made þat hem ryȝtful accusours or no (q.d. non).

¶ Was not fortune asshamed of þis. [Certes alle hadde
nat fortune ben asshamyd] þat innocence was accused.
ȝit auȝt[e] sche haue had schame of þe filþe of myn
accusours. 356

But, on the day this
sentence was to be
executed, they accused
him, and their testimony
against him was
accepted.

Fortune, if not ashamed
at this, might at least
blush for the baseness of
the accusers.

E ACCUSATIONS AGAINST BOETHIUS.

¶ But axest þou in somme of what gilt .I.
am accused. men seyne þat I wolde sauen þe
compaignie
of þe senatours. ¶ And desirest þou to here
in what manere .I. am accused þat I scholde han distourbed 360
þe accusour to beren lettres. by whiche he
scholde han maked þe senatours guilty aȝeins þe kynges
Real maieste. ¶ O meistresse what demest þou of
þis. schal .I. forsake þis blame þat I ne be no schame to 364
þe (q. d. non). ¶ Certis .I. haue wold it. þat is to
seyne þe sauuacioun of þe senat. ne I schal neuer leten
to wilne it. *and* þat I confesse *and* am a-knowe. but
þe entent of þe accusour to be destourbed schal cese. 368
¶ For schal I clepe it a felonie þan or a synne þat I

Boethius says he is
accused of trying to save
the Senate, and of having
embarrassed an informer
against the Senate.

It is true that he tried to
save the Senate, for he
has and will have its best
interests always at heart.

haue desired þe sauuacioun of þe ordre of þe senat.
and certys 3it hadde þilk same senat don by me þoru3
her decret3 *and* hire iugementys as þou3 it were a synne 372
or a felonie þat is to seyne to wilne þe sauuacioun of
hem (.s. senatus). ¶ But folye þat lieth alwey to hym
self may not chaunge þe merit of þinges. ¶ Ne .I.
trowe not by þe iugement of socrates þat it were
leueful 376
to me to hide þe soþe. ne assent[e] to lesynges.

(Folly cannot change the merit of things.)

According to Socrates' judgment it is not lawful to hide the truth nor assent to a falsehood.)

¶ But certys how so euer it be of þis I put[te] it to gessen
or preisen to þe iugement of þe *and* of wise folk. ¶ Of
whiche þing al þe ordinaunce *and* þe soþe for as moche 380
as folk þat ben to comen aftir oure dayes schollen
knownen it. ¶ I haue put it in scripture *and*
remembraunce.
for touching þe lettres falsly maked. by
whiche lettres I am accused to han hooped þe fredom of 384
Rome. What apperteneþ me to speken þer-of.

Boethius determines to transmit an account of his prosecution to posterity.

Of whiche lettres þe fraude hadde ben schewed apertly
if

Boethius says that he could have defeated his accusers had he been allowed the use of their confessions.

I hadde had libertee forto han vsed *and* ben at þe
confessioun of myn accusours. ¶ Þe whiche þing in 388
alle nedys haþ grete strenkeþ. ¶ For what oþer fredom
may men hopen. Certys I wolde þat some oþer fredom
my3t[e] be hoped. ¶ I wolde þan haue answered by
þe wordes of a man þat hy3t[e] Canius. for whan he was 392
accused by Gayus Cesar Germeins son þat he (canius)
was knowyng *and* consentyng of a coniuracioun maked
a3eins hym (.s. Gaius). ¶ Þis Canius answered[e]
þus. ¶ Yif I had[de] wist it þou haddest not wist it. 396

But there is now no remains of liberty to be hoped for.

ETHIUS COMPLAINS TO PHILOSOPHY.

In whiche þing sorwe haþ not so dulled my witte
þat I pleyne oonly þat schrewed[e] folk apparailen
folies azeins vertues. ¶ But I wondre gretly how þat
þei may performe þinges þat þei had[de] hoped forto 400
done. For why. to wylne schrewednesse þat comeþ
paraenture of oure defaute. ¶ But it is lyke to a
monstre *and* a meruaille. ¶ How þat in þe present
syzt of god may ben acheued *and* performed swiche
404

þinges. as euery felonous man haþ conceyued in hys
þouzt azeins innocent. ¶ For whiche þing oon of þi
familers not vnskilfully axed þus. ¶ 3if god is.
whennes
comen wikked[e] þinges. *and* yif god ne is whennes
408

comen goode þinges. but al hadde it ben leueful þat
felonous folk þat now desiren þe bloode *and* þe deep of
alle goode men. *and* eke of al þe senat han wilned to
gone destroien me. whom þei han seyn alwey batailen 412
and defenden goode men *and* eke al þe senat. 3it
hadde I not desserued of þe fadres. þat is to seyne of
þe senatours þat þei scholde wilne my destruccioun.
¶ Þou remembrest wele as I gesse þat whan I wolde 416
don or *seyn any þing. þou þi self alwey present
reweledest me. ¶ At þe citee of verone whan þat þe
kyng gredy of comune slauzter. caste hym to
transporten
vpon al þe ordre of þe senat. þe gilt of his real 420
maieste of þe whiche gilt þat albyn was accused. wip

It is not strange that the
wicked should conspire
against virtue.

The will to do ill
proceeds from the
defects of human nature.

It is a marvel how such
evil acts can be done
under the eye of an
Omniscient God.

If there be a God,
whence proceeds evil? If
there is none, whence
arises good?

Boethius defends the
integrity of his life.

[* fol. 6 b.]

He defended the Senate
at Verona.

how grete sykernesse of peril to me defended[e] I al
 þe senat. ¶ Pou wost wel þat I seide soþe. ne I
 auaunted[e] me neuer in preysyng of my self. ¶ For 424
 alwey when any wyȝt resceiueþ *precious* renoun in
 auauntyng hym self of hys werkes: he amenusiþ þe
 secre of hys conscience. ¶ But now þou mayst wel
 seen to what ende I am comen for myne innocence. 428

He spake only the truth,
 and did not boast.

(Boasting lessens the
 pleasure of a self
 approving conscience.)

HIS FALSE ACCUSERS.

I receiue peyne of fals felonie in gerdoun of verray
 vertue. ¶ And what open *confessioun* of felonie
 had[de] euer iugis so accordaunt in cruelte. þat is to
 seyne as myne accusyng haþ. ¶ Þat oþer error of 432
 mans witte or ellys *condicioun* of fortune þat is vncerteyne
 to al mortal folk ne submytted[e] summe of hem. þat is
 to seyne þat it ne cheyned[e] summe iuge to han pitee
 or compassioun. ¶ For al þouȝ I had[de] ben accused
 436
 þat I wolde brenne holy houses. *and* strangle prestys
 wiþ wicked swerde. ¶ or þat .I. had[de] grayped deep
 to alle goode men algatis þe sentence scholde han
 punysched me present confessed or conuict. 440
 ¶ But now I am remewed fro þe Citee of rome almost
 fyue-hundreþ þousand pas. I am wiþ outen defence
 dampned
 to *proscripcioun* *and* to þe deep. for þe studie *and*
 bountees þat I haue done to þe senat. ¶ But o wel ben 444
 þei worþi of mercye (as who seiþ nay.) þer myȝt[e] neuer
 ȝit non of hem ben conuicte. Of swiche a blame as
 myn is of swiche trespas myn accusours seyen ful wel þe dignitee.

But as the reward of his
 innocence he is made to
 suffer the punishment
 due to the blackest
 crime.

Had he been accused of
 a design to burn temples,
 massacre priests, he
 would have been
 allowed to confront his
 accusers.

But now this is denied
 him, and he is proscribed
 and condemned to death.

ETHIUS ACCUSED OF SORCERY.

þe wiche dignite for þei wolde derken it 448
wiþ medelyng of some felonye. þei beren me on honde
and lieden. þat I hadde polute *and* defouled my conscience
wiþ sacrelege. for couetise of dignite. ¶ And
certys þou þi self þat art plaunted in me chacedest oute 452
þe sege of my corage al couetise of mortal þinges. ne
sacrilege ne had[de] no leue to han a place in me byforne
þine eyen. ¶ For þou drouppedest euery day in myn
eeres *and* in my þouȝt þilk comaundement of
pictogoras. 456
þat is to seyne men schal seruen to god. *and* not to
goddes. ¶ Ne it was no couenaunt ne no nede to
taken helpe of þe foulest spirites. ¶ I þat þou hast
ordeyned or set in syche excellence þat [þou] makedest 460
me lyke to god. and ouer þis þe ryȝt clene secre
chaumbre of myn house. þat is to seye my wijf *and* þe
compaignie of myn honeste frendis. *and* my wyues
fadir as wel holy as worþi to ben reuerenced þoruȝ 464
hys owen dedis. defenden me of al suspeccioun of syche
blame. ¶ But o malice. ¶ For þei þat accusen me
taken of þe philosophie feiþe of so grete blame. ¶ For
þei trowen þat .I. haue had affinite to malyfice or
enchauntementȝ 468
by cause þat I am replenissed *and* fulfilled
wiþ þi techynges. *and* enformed of þi maners.
¶ And þus it sufficeþ not only þat þi reuerence ne auayle
me not. but ȝif þat þou of þi fre wille raþer be blemished 472
wiþ myne offensioun. ¶ But certys to þe harmes þat I
haue þere bytydeþ ȝit þis encrece of harme.

Boethius says that his
enemies accused him of
sorcery.

He affirms that he has
always followed the
golden maxim of
Pythagoras,— ἔπου Θεῶ
[Greek: hepou Theō].

His family and friends
could clear him from all
suspicion of the crime of
sorcery.

Because he has given
himself up to
Philosophy, his enemies
accuse him of using
unlawful arts.

ETHIUS DEPLORES THE POPULAR CENSURE.

þat þe gessinge *and* þe iugement of myche folk ne loken no
þing to þe[de]sertys of þinges but only to þe auenture 476

of fortune. ¶ And iugen þat only swiche þinges ben
purueied of god. whiche þat temporel welefulnesse
commendip. *Glosa*. ¶ As þus þat yif a wyzt haue
prosperite. he is a good man *and* worþi to haue þat 480
prosperite. and who so haþ aduersite he is a wikked
man. *and* god haþ forsake hym. *and* he is worþi to
haue þat aduersite. ¶ Þis is þe opinioun of somme
folke. **and* þer of comeþ þat good gessyng. ¶ Fyrste of

484

al þing forsakeþ wrecches certys it greueþ me to þink[e]
ryzt now þe dyuerse sentences þat þe poeple seiþ of
me. ¶ And þus moche I seye þat þe laste charge of
contrarious fortune is þis. *þat whan þat ony blame is 488

laid vpon a caytif. men wenen þat he haþ deserued þat
he suffreþ. ¶ And I þat am put away from goode men
and despoiled from dignitees *and* defoulid of my name
by gessyng haue suffred torment for my goode dedis. 492

¶ Certys me semeþ þat I se þe felonus couines of
wikked men abounden in ioie *and* in gladnes. ¶ And
I se þat euery lorel shapiþ hym to fynde oute newe
fraudes forto accusen goode folke. and I se þat goode 496
men ben ouerþrowen for drede of my peril. ¶ and
euery luxurious *tourmentour* dar don alle felonie vnpunissed
and ben excited þerto by ziftes. and innocent3
ne ben not oonly despoiled of sykernesse but of defence 500
and þefore me list to crien to god in þis manere.

Most people imagine
that that only should be
judged to be undertaken
with prudent foresight
which is crowned with
success.

The unfortunate lose the
good opinion of the
world.

[* Text begins again.]

[* fol. 7.]

Boethius laments the
loss of his dignities and
reputation.

The wicked, he says, sin
with impunity, while the
innocent are deprived of
security, protection, and
defence.

247 *Felest þou*—Felistow
 ouȝt—awht
 248 *art þou*—artow
 249 *wepest þou*—wepistow
 spillest þou—spillestow
 252 *answered[e]*—answerede
 255 *woode*—wood
 257 *wyche*—which
 258 *myne house þere*—myn hows ther
 259 *desputest of[te]*—desputedest ofte
 260 *þan*—thanne
 261 *it* and *þan*—both omitted
 261, 262 *swiche*—swich
 262 *souȝt[e]*—sowhte
 263 *secretys*—secretȝ
 my—MS. me, C. my
 264 *al*—alle
 265 *gerdoun*—gerdouns
 266 *enfourmedist*—conformedest
 267 *mouþe*—mowht
 268 *comunabletes*—comunalitees
 270 *by-felle*—byfille
 271 *in grete wisdomes*—to geten wysdom
 272 *eke*—ek
 275 *comune*—omitted
 y-left—MS. ylefte, C. yleft
 276 *Citizenis*—citesenes
 brynge inne—bryngen in
 278 *þerfore*—therfor
 þilk—thilke
 desiryng—desired
 279 *put[te] furþe*—putten forth
 280 *þo*—thilke
 282 *put[te]*—putte
 283 *brouȝt[e]*—ne browhte
 284 *þe*—omitted
 al goodenes—alle goodnesse
 comeþ—comth
 287, 288 *hap*—MS. haþe
 289 *saluacioun*—sauacioun

290 *pilk*—thilke
 hy3t[e]—hyhte
 290 *conigaste*—MS. coniugaste
 292 *ofte*—ofte ek
 3itte—omitted
 294 *bygon[ne]*—bygunne
 done—don
 295 *couered*—MS. couerede, C. couered
 296 *put*—MS. putte, C. put
 seine—seyn
 297 *myne*—myn
 298 *vnpunysched*—vnpunyssed
 299 *myseses*—myseyses
 300 *drow*—MS. drowe, C. weth drowh
 3itte—yit
 wrong—wronge
 301 *rychesse*—richesses
 pe (2)—omitted
 302 *harmed eyper*—armyde or amened owther
 303 *tributis*—tribut3
 suffred[e]—suffreden
 304 *harme*—harm
 305 *3ere*—yer
 hys—hise
 305, 306, 307 *corne*—corn
 306 *schold[e] bie*—sholde byen
 308 *But I withstod*—Boece withstood (MS. withstode)
 com—MS. come, C. com
 311 *swiche*—swich
 312 *bou3t[e]*—bowhte
 busshel—bossel
 most[e] 3eue—moste yeue
 315 *inplitable*—vnplitable
 seyn—sayen
 319 *ouercom*—MS. ouercome, C. ouer com
 320 *counseiller*—consoler
 rychesse—richesses
 321 *whyche*—which
 322 *wolde*—wolden
 323 *drow*—MS. drowe, C. drowh
 324 *myche*—moche
 326 *punischen*—punisse

327 *putt[e]*—putte
 328 *yseyn*—MS. yseyne
 329 *greet[e]*—grete
 330 *aughte be*—owhte be the
 oper—oothre
 333 *by þe whiche*—by which
 þoruþ þe—thorw tho
 335 *whiche*—the whiche
 one—oon
 somtyme—whilom
 339 *sumtyme*—whilon
 340 *go*—gon
 her—hir
 341 *wip-uten*—withowte
 wolde not—nolden nat
 342 *defended[e]*—defendedyn
 by—by the
 343 *seyne*—seyn
 seyntuaries—sentuarye
 344 *was*—omitted
 comaunded[e]—comaundede
 345 *voided[e]*—voidede
 certeyne—certeyn
 346 *men*—me
 merken—marke
 347 *hoke of iren*—hoot yren
 348 *þe*—omitted
 myzt[e] be—myhte ben
 349 *pilk*—thilke
 350 *pilk[e]*—thilke
 351 *be*—ben
 seid—MS. seide, C. seyd
 hap—MS. haþe
 354, 355 [*Certes*—*asshamyd*]—from C.
 356 *auzt[e]*—owte
 haue had—han had, MS. hadde
 357 *axest þou*—axestow
 358 *seyne*—seyn
 sauen—saue
 359 *desirest þou*—desires thow
 here—hereen
 362 *maked*—MS. maken, C. makyd

363 *demest pou*—demestow
365 *wold*—MS. wolde, C. wold
366 *seyne*—seyn
367 *pat*—omitted
 am—I am
368 *be*—ben
369 *it*—it thanne
 pan—omitted
371 *pilk*—thilke
372 *her*—hir
 hire—hir
 pouȝ—thogh
373 *or*—and
 seyne—seyn
374 *lieth*—MS. liepe, C. lieth
377 *assent[e]*—assente
381 *schollen*—shellen
382 *and*—*and* in
385 *speken*—speke
 of—*lettres*—C. omits
386 *if*—yif
387 *had*—MS. hade, C. had
388 *myn*—myne
389 *hap*—MS. haȝe, C. hath
 grete—gret
 what—omitted
390 *some*—som
391 *myȝt[e]* *be*—myhte ben
 pan haue—thanne han
392 *hyȝt[e]*—hyhte
394 *maked*—ymaked
395 *answered[e]*—answerede
396 *had[de]*—hadde
397 *whiche*—which
 sorwe—sorw
 hap—MS. haȝe
 witte—wit
398 *schrewed[e]*—shrewede
399 *folies*—felonies
 vertues—vertu
400 *had[de]*—han

401 *done*—don
 comeþ—comth
402 *lyke to a*—lyk a
404 *syzt*—syhte
405 *hap*—MS. haþe
406 *innocent*—innocentȝ
 whiche—which
408 *wikked[e]*—wykkede
410 *bloode*—blod
411 *eke*—ek
412 *gone*—gon *and*
 seyn—seyn
413 *eke*—ek
414 *seyne*—seyn
415 *scholde*—sholden
416 *wele*—wel
417 *don*—MS. done, C. doon
 seyn—seyn
418 *þe* (1)—omitted
419 *slauȝter*—slawhtre
420 *transporten vpon*—transpor vp
422 *grete*—gret
 defended[e]—deffendede
423 *seide soþe*—seye soth
424 *auaunted[e]*—auauntede
425 *when*—whan
 precious—presious
429 *in*—for
430 *vertue*—vertu
431 *had[de]*—hadde
432 *seyne*—seyn
 myne—myn
 hap—MS. haþe
433 *witte*—wit
 vncerteyne—vncerteyn
434 *al*—alle
 submytted[e]—submittedde
435 *seyne*—seyn
 cheyned[e]—enclinede
436 *had[de]*—hadde

438 *wicked*—wykkede
 had[de]—hadde
 441 *almost*—almest
 442 *pousand*—MS. *pousas*
 wip ouden—withowte
 444 *done*—doon
 445 *myzt[e]*—myhte
 446 *ben*—be
 swiche—swich
 447 *myn (both)*—myne
 swiche—whiche
 seyen—sayen
 448 *wolde*—wolden
 449 *some*—som
 beren—baren
 on honde—an hand
 450 *polute*—polut
 451 *sacrelege*—C. *has sorcerie as a gloss to sacrilege*
 453 *al*—alle
 454 *had[de]*—hadde
 byforne—byforn
 455 *drouppedest*—droppedest
 myn—myne
 456 *pilk*—thilke
 457 *seyne*—seyn
 seruen—serue
 god—godde
 459 *helpe*—help
 spirites—spirite
 460 *set*—MS. *sette*, C. *set*
 syche—swiche
 [pou]—thow
 461 *lyke*—lyk
 462 *house*—hows
 seye—seyn
 463 *myn*—my
 465 *owen*—owne
 of al—from alle
 syche—swich
 467 *philosophie*—philosophre
 feipe—feyth
 grete—gret
 468 *had*—MS. *hadde*, C. *had*

473 *myne*—myn
 474 *pere*—ther
 harme—harm
 475 *myche*—moche
 476 *þe[de]sertys*—the desert
 479 *Glosa*—glose
 480 *good*—MS. goode, C. good
 haue—han
 481 *so*—omitted in C.
 481, 482 *hap*—MS. haþe
 483 *haue*—han
 484 *Fyrste*—fyrst
 485 *al*—alle
 þink[e]—thinke
 488 *ony*—any
 489 *laid*—MS. laide, C. leyd
 hap—MS. haþe
 490 *put*—MS. putte, C. put
 491 *from*—of
 494 *abownden*—habownden
 gladnes—gladnesse
 495 *oute*—owt
 496 *accusen*—accuse
 497 *ben*—beth
 501 *manere*—wise

E CRUEL CHANGES OF FORTUNE

O STELLIFERI CONDITOR ORBIS.

[The fifthe *metur.*]

O þou maker of þe whele þat bereþ þe sterres.
 whiche
 þat art fastned to þi *perdurable* chayere. *and*
 turnest þe heuene wiþ a rauyssyng sweighe *and constreine*st 504
 þe sterres to suffren þi lawe. ¶ So þat þe
 mone somtyme schynyng wiþ hir ful hornes metyng
 wiþ alle þe bemes of þe sonne. ¶ Hir broþer hideþ þe
 sterres þat ben lasse. *and* somtyme whan þe mone 508

Author of the starry sky,
 Thou, seated on high,
 turnest the spheres, and
 imposest laws upon the
 stars and planets.

The sun obscures the
 lesser lights, and

pale wiþ hir derke hornes approcheþ þe sonne. leesith
 hir lyztes. ¶ And þat þe euesterre esperus whiche
 þat in þe first[e] tyme of þe nyzt bryngeþ furþe hir
 colde arysynges comeþ eft azeynes hir vsed cours. *and*
 512

quenches even the
 moon's light.

Thou raisest Hesperus to
 usher in the shades of
 night, and again causest
 him to be the harbinger
 of day, whence his name
 Lucifer.

is pale by þe morwe at þe rysyng of þe sonne. and is
 þan cleped lucifer. ¶ Þou restreimest þe day by schorter
 dwellyng in þe tyme of colde wynter þat makeþ þe
 leues to falle. ¶ Þou diuidest þe swifte tides of þe 516
 nyzt when þe hote somer is comen. ¶ Þi myzt
 attempre[þ]

Thou controllst the
 changing seasons of the
 year.

þo variauntz sesons of þe zere. so þat
 zepherus þe deboneire wynde bringeþ azein in þe first[e]
 somer sesoun þe leues þat þe wynde þat hyzt[e] boreas 520
 haþ reft away in autumpne. þat is to seyne in þe laste
 eende of somer. and þe sedes þat þe sterre þat hyzt arcturus
 saw ben waxen hey[e] cornes whan þe sterre
 sirius eschaufep hym. ¶ Pere nis no þing vnbounde 524
 from hys olde lawe ne forleteþ hym of hys propre
 estat.

All nature is bound by
 thy eternal law.

INTRASTED WITH THE ORDER OF NATURE.

¶ O þou gouernour gouernyng alle þinges by certeyne
 ende. why refusest þou oonly to gouerne þe werkes of
 men by dewe manere. ¶ Whi suffrest þou þat slidyng
 528

Why, then, leavest thou
 man's actions
 uncontrolled?

Why should fickle
 fortune be allowed to
 work such mighty
 changes in the world?

fortune turneþ to grete vtter chaungynges of þinges.
 so þat anioius peyne þat scholde duelly punisshe felouns
 punissitz innocentz. ¶ And folk of wikked[e]
 maneres sitten in heize chaiers. *and* anoienge folk 532

The wicked are
 prosperous, while the
 righteous are in
 adversity.

treden *and* þat vnry3tfully in þe nekkes of holy men.
 ¶ And vertue clere *and* schynyng naturely is hid in
 dirke dirkenesses. *and* þe ry3tful man berip þe blame
and þe peyne of þe felowne. ¶ Ne þe forsweryng ne 536
 þe fraude couered *and* kembd wiþ a fals colour ne
 a-noyep not to schrewes. ¶ Þe whiche schrewes whan
 hem lyst to vsen her strengþe þei reioisen hem to
 putten vndir hem þe souerayne kynges. whiche þat 540
 poeple wiþ[outen] noumbre dreden. ¶ O þou what so
 euer þou be þat knyttes[t] alle bondes of þinges loke
 on þise wrecched[e] erþes. we men þat ben nat a
 foule party but a faire party of so grete a werke we 544
 ben turmentid in þe see of fortune. ¶ Þou gouernour
 wiþdraw *and* restreyne þe rauyssinge flodes *and* fastne
and forme þise erþes stable wiþ þilke [bonde] wiþ
 whiche þou gouernest þe heuene þat is so large. 548

O thou that bindest the
 disagreeing elements,
 look upon this wretched
 earth, and, as thou dost
 govern the spacious
 heavens, so let the earth
 be firmly bound.

- 502 *whele*—whel
 whiche—which
 503 *fastned*—yfastned
 chayere—chayer
 504 *sweighe*—sweyh
 constreinet, MS. contreuiest, C. constreynest
 506 *hir*—here
 508 *lasse*—lesse
 510 *esperus* *whiche*—hesperus which
 511 *first[e]*—fyrste
 furþe—forth
 512 *eft*—est
 514 *restreinet*—MS. restreniest
 516 *to*—omitted
 518 *attempre[þ]* *þo*—atempreth the
 sesons—sesoun
 gere—yer
 519 *wynde bringeþ*—wynd brengeth

520 *wynde*—wynd
 hyȝt[e]—hihte
 521 *reft*—MS. *refte*, C. *reft*
 seyne—seyn
 522 *hyȝt*—hihte
 arcturus—MS. *ariturus*
 523 *saw*—MS. *sawep*, C. *sawgh*
 hey[e]—hyye
 524 *hym*—hem
 þere—ther
 þing—thinge
 525 *from*—fram
 forleteþ hym of—forleetheth þe werke of
 527 *refusest þou*—refowsestow
 529 *to*—*þinges*—so grete entrechaunginges of thynges
 531 *punissitz*—punysshe
 wikked[e]—wykkede
 532 *heize*—heere
 533 *in*—oon
 534 *and*—omitted
 536 *Ne þe forsweryng*—Ne forswerynge
 537 *kembd*—MS. *kembde*, C. *kembd*
 541 *wiþ[outen]*—withhowtyn
 542 *knyttes[t]*—knytttest
 543 *wrecched[e]*—wrecchede
 544 *a* (2)—omitted
 545 *þe*—this
 546 *wiþdraw*—MS. *wiþdrawe*, C. *withdraw*
 þe—thei
 547 *forme*—ferme
 [bonde]—from C.
 wiþ—by

ILOSOPHY CONSOLES BOETHIUS,

[HIC UBI CONTINUATO DOLORE.](#)

[The fyfthe prose.]

Whan I hadde wiþ a continuel sorwe sobbed or
 broken out þise þinges sche wiþ hir chere
 peisible

Philosophy consoles
 Boethius.

and no þing amoeued. wiþ my compleyntes seide þus.
 whan I say þe *quod* sche sorweful and wepyng I wist[e] 552
 on-one þat þou were a wrecche and exiled. but I
 wist[e] neuer how fer þine exile was: 3if þi tale ne
 hadde schewed it to me. but certys al be þou fer fro þi
 contre. þou nart *nat put out of it. but þou hast 556
 fayled of þi weye and gon amys. ¶ and yif þou hast
 leuer forto wene þan þou be put out of þi contre. þan
 hast þou put oute þi self raþer þen ony oþer wyzt haþ.

[* fol. 7 b.]

She speaks to him of his country.

D PROPOSES TO ADMINISTER REMEDIES.

¶ For no wyzt but þi self ne myzt[e] neuer haue don 560
 þat to þe. ¶ For 3if þou remembre of what contre þou
 art born. it nis not gouerned by emperoures. ne by
 gouernement of multitude. as weren þe contres of hem
 of athenes. ¶ But o lorde and o kyng and þat is god 564
 þat is lorde of þi contree. whiche þat reioiseþ hym of
 þe dwellyng of hys Cite3enis. and not forto putte hem
 in exile. Of þe whiche lorde it is a souerayne fredom
 to be gouerned by þe bridel of hym and obeie to his 568
 iustice. ¶ Hast þou for3eten þilke ryzt olde lawe of þi
 Citee. in þe whiche Citee it is ordeyned and establised
 þat what wyzt þat haþ leuer founden þer inne hys sete
 or hys house. þen ellys where: he may not be exiled 572
 by no ryzt fro þat place. ¶ For who so þat is contened
 in-wiþ þe paleis [and the clos] of þilke Citee. þer nis
 no drede þat he may deserue to ben exiled. ¶ But
 who þat letteþ þe wille forto enhabit[e] þere. he forleteþ 576
 also to deserue to ben Cite3ein of þilke Citee.
 ¶ So þat I seye þat þe face of þis place ne amoeueþ me

She reminds him that he is a citizen of a country not governed by a giddy multitude, but εἰς κοίρανός ἐστιν, εἰς βασιλεύς.

The Commonwealth of Boethius.

Philosophy says she is moved more by the looks

nat so myche as þine owen face. Ne .I. ne axe not
 rap̃er þe walles of þi librarie apparailled *and* wrouzt 580
 wiþ yvory *and* wiþ glas þan after þe sete of þi þouzt.
 In whiche I putte nat somtyme bookes. but .I. putte
 þat þat makeþ bookes worþi of pris or precious þat is
 to sein þe sentence of my books. ¶ *And* certainly of 584
 þi decertes by-stowed in *commune* good. þou hast seid
 soþe but after þe multitude of þi goode dedys. þou hast
 seid fewe. *and* of þe vnhonestee or falsnesse of þinges
 þat ben opposed azeins þe. þou hast remembred þinges 588
 þat ben knowe to alle folk. and of þe felonies *and*
 fraudes of þine accusours. it semep þe haue I-touched
 it forsoþe ryztfully *and* schortly. ¶ Al myzten þo
 same þinges bettere *and* more plentiuously be couth 592
 in þe mouþe of þe poeple þat knowep al þis. ¶ Þou
 hast eke blamed gretly *and* compleyned of þe wrongful
 dede of þe senat. ¶ *And* þou hast sorwed for my
 blame. *and* þou hast wepen for þe damage of þi
 renoune 596
 þat is appaired. *and* þi laste sorwe eschaufed
 azeins fortune *and* compleinest þat gerdouns ne ben
 not
 euenliche zolde to þe desertes of folk. *and* in þe lattre
 ende of þi woode muse þou priedest þat þilke pees þat 600
 gouerneþ þe heuene scholde gouerne þe erþe ¶ But
 for þat many tribulaciouns of affecciouns han assailed
 þe. *and* sorwe *and* Ire *and* wepyng todrawen þee
 dyuersely ¶ As þou art now feble of þouzt. myztyer 604
 remedies ne schullen not zit touchen þe for whiche
 we wil[e] vsen somedel lyzter medicines. So þat

of Boethius than by his gloomy prison.

Books are to be valued on account of the *thoughts* they contain.

Boethius has rightfully and briefly recounted the frauds of his accusers.

Thou hast, said Philosophy, bewailed the loss of thy good name, thou hast complained against Fortune, and against the unequal distribution of rewards and punishments.

Strong medicines are not proper for thee now, distracted by grief, anger, and sadness.

þilk[e]

passiouns þat ben woxen harde in swellyng by

perturbacioun

folowyng in to þi þouȝt mowen woxe esy 608

and softe to receyuen þe strenkeþ of a more myȝty *and*
more egre medicine by an esier touchyng.

Light medicines must
prepare thee for sharper
remedies.

550 *broken*—borken

552 *wist[e]*—wyste

553 *on-one*—anon

554 *wist[e]*—wyste
fer—ferre

555 *ne hadde*—nadde

557 *gon*—MS. gone, C. gon

558 *leuer*—leuere

558, 559 *put*—MS. putte, C. put

559 *hap*—MS. haþe

560 *myȝt[e]*—myhte
haue—han

don—MS. done, C. don

562 *born*—MS. borne, C. born

566 *hys*—hise
putte—put

568 *be*—ben

571 *hap*—MS. haþe

572 *house*—hows

574 [*and*—*clos*—from C.

576 *wille*—wyl
enhabit[e]—enhabyte

578 *seye*—sey
amoeueþ—moueth

579 *myche*—mochel
owen—owne
ne (2)—omitted

582 *putte* (*both*)—put
somtyme—whilom

585 *decertes*—desertes
seid—MS. seide, C. seyde

586 *sope*—soth

587 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyd
 588 *opposed*—aposyd
 599 *knowe*—knowyn
 592 *be couth*—MS. be couthe, C. ben cowth
 596 *wepen*—wopen
 597 *laste*—last
 eschaufed—eschaufede
 598 *not*—omitted
 599 *zolde*—yolden
 602 *many*—manye
 604 *myȝtyer*—myhtyere
 605 *whiche*—which
 606 *wil[e]*—wol
 lyȝter—lyhtere
 þilk[e]—thilke
 607 *harde*—hard
 608 *folowyng*—Flowyng
 woxe—wexen
 610 *esier*—esyere

PHILOSOPHY QUESTIONS BOETHIUS.

CUM PHEBI RADIIS GRAUE CANCRI SIDUS ENESTUAT.

[The sixte metur.]

Whan þat þe heuy sterre of þe cancre eschaufþ by
 þe beme of phebus. þat is to seyne whan þat
 phebus 612

He who sows his seed
 when the sun is in the
 Sign of Cancer, must
 look for no produce.

þe sonne is in þe signe of þe Cancre. Who so ȝeueþ
 þan largely hys sedes to þe feldes þat refuse to receiuen
 hem. lete hym gon bygyled of trust þat he
 hadde to hys corn. to acorns or okes. yif þou wilt 616
 gadre violettȝ. ne go þou not to þe purper wode whan
 þe felde chirkyngre agriseþ of colde by þe felnesse of
 þe wynde þat hyȝt aquilon ¶ Yif þou desirest or
 wolt vsen grapes ne seke þou nat wiþ a glotonus hande
 620

Think not to ingather
 violets in the wintry and
 stormy season.

If you wish for wine in
 autumn let the tendrils of
 the vine be free in the
 spring.

to streine *and* presse þe stalkes of þe vine in þe first
somer sesoun. for bachus þe god of wyne haþ raþer
zeuen his ziftes to autumpne þe latter ende of somer.

¶ God tokeniþ *and* assigneþ *þe tymes. ablyng hem 624
to her propre offices. ¶ Ne he ne suffreþ not stoundes
whiche þat hym self haþ deuided *and* constreined to
be medeled to gidre ¶ And forþi he þat forleteþ
certeyne ordinaunce of doynge by ouerþrowyng wey.

628

he ne haþ no glade issue or ende of hys werkes.

612 *beme*—beemes

seyne—seyn

614 *hys*—hise

refuse—refusen

615 after *hem* C. adds [s. corn]

lete hym gon (MS. *gone*)—lat hym gon

616 *or*—of

wilt gadre—wolt gadery

618 *felde*—feeld

felnesse—felnesses

619 *hyzt*—hyhte

620 *hande*—hond

622 *haþ*—MS. haþe

625 *her propre*—heere propres

not—nat the

626 *haþ*—MS. haþe

627 *be medeled*—ben I-medled

628 *certeyne*—certeyn

629 *haþ*—MS. haþe

[* fol. 8.]

To every work God
assigns a proper time,
nor suffers anything to
pass its bounds.

Success does not await
him who departs from
the appointed order of
things.

COVERS THE CAUSE OF HIS DISTEMPER.

[PRIMUM IGITUR PATERIS ROGACIONIBUS.](#)

F Irst wolt þou suffre me to touche *and* assaie þe stat
of þi þouzt by a fewe demaundes. so þat I may

[The syxte prose.]

Philosophy proposes to
question Boethius.

vnderstonde what be þe manere of þi curacioun. ¶ Axe 632

me *quod* .I. atte þi wille what þou wilt. *and* I schal
answere. ¶ Þo saide sche þus. wheþer wenest þou *quod*
sche þat þis worlde be gouerned by foolisshe happes
and fortunes. or elles wenest þou þat þer be in it any 636
gouernement of resoun. Certes *quod* .I. ne trowe not
in no manere þat so certeyne þinges scholde be
moeued

by fortunouse fortune. but I wot wel þat god maker
and mayster is gouernour of þis werk. Ne neuer nas 640
3it day þat my3t[e] putte me oute of þe soþenesse of
þat sentence. ¶ So is it *quod* sche. for þe same þing
songe þou a lytel here byforne *and* byweyledest *and*
bywepetest. þat only men weren put oute of þe cure of
644

god. ¶ For of alle oþer þinges þou ne doutest nat
þat þei nere gouerned by reson. but how (.i. pape.).
I wondre gretly certes whi þat þou art seek. siþen þou
art put in to so holesom a sentence. but lat vs seken 648
depper. I coniecte þat þere lakkeþ I not what. but
sey me þis. siþen þat þou ne doutest nat þat þis worlde
be gouerned by god ¶ wiþ swycche gouernailes takest
þou hede þat it is gouerned. ¶ vnneþ *quod* .I. knowe 652
.I. þe sentence of þi questioun. so þat I ne may nat
3it answeren to þi demaundes. ¶ I nas nat deceiued
quod sche þat þere ne faileþ sumwhat. by whiche þe
maladie of perturbacioun is crept in to þi þou3t. so 656
as þe strengþe of þe paleys schynyng is open. ¶ But
seye me þis remembrest þou ou3t what is þe ende of
þi þinges. whider þat þe entencioun of al kynde tendep.

P. Is the world governed
by Chance?

B. By no means. The
Creator presides over his
own works.

I shall never swerve
from this opinion.

P. Yes! Thou didst say as
much when thou didst
declare man alone to be
destitute of divine care.

Still thou seemest to
labour under some defect
even in this conviction.

Tell me how the world is
governed.

B. I do not thoroughly
comprehend your
question.

P. I was not deceived,
then, when I said there
was some defect in thy
sentiment.

Tell me what is the chief
end of all things; and
whither all things tend.

¶ I haue herd told it somtyme *quod* .I. but drerynesse 660
 hap dilled my memorie. ¶ Certys *quod* sche
 pou wost wel whennes þat alle þinges ben comen *and*
proceded. I wot wel *quod* .I. *and* ansewered[e] þat
 god is þe bygynnyng of al. ¶ And how may þis be 664
quod sche þat siþen þou knowest þe bygynnyng of
 þinges. þat þou ne knowest not what is þe endyng of
 þinges. but swiche ben þe customes of *perturbaciouns*.
and þis power þei han. þat þei may moeue a man fro
 668

B. God is the beginning of all things.

P. How, then, art thou ignorant of their end?

But it is the nature of these perturbations (which thou endurest) to unsettle men's minds.

hys place. þat is to seyne from þe stablenes *and* *perfeccioun*
 of hys knowyng. but certys þei may not al
 arace hym ne alyene hym in al. ¶ But I wolde þat
 pou woldest answere to þis. ¶ Remembrest þou þat 672
 pou art a man ¶ *Boice*. ¶ Whi scholde I nat remembre
 þat *quod* .I. *Philosophie*. ¶ Maiste þou not telle
 me þan *quod* sche what þing is a man. ¶ Axest not
 me *quod* I. wheþir þat be a resonable best mortel. I 676
 wot wel *and* I confesse wel þat I am it. ¶ Wistest
 pou neuer 3it þat pou were any oþer þing *quod* she.

Dost thou remember that thou art a man?

B. Certainly I do.

P. What is man?

B. If you ask me whether I am a rational and mortal creature, I know and confess I am.

P. But dost thou not know that thou art more than this?

ETHIUS NEEDS LIGHT REMEDIES.

No *quod* .I. now wot I *quod* she oþer cause of þi
 maladie *and* þat ryzt grete ¶ Pou hast left forto 680
 knowe þi self what þou art. þoru3 whiche I haue
 pleynellyche
 knowen þe cause of þi maladie. or ellis þe
 entre of recoueryng of þin hele. ¶ Forwhy for þou
 art confounded wiþ for3etyng of þi self. forþi sorwest
 684

B. No.

P. Now I know the principal cause of thy distemper.

Thou hast lost the knowledge of thyself, thou knowest not the end of things, and hast

þou þat þou art exiled of þi propre goodes. ¶ And
for þou ne wost what is þe ende of þinges. for[þi]
demest

forgotten how the world
is governed.

[þou] þat felonous *and* wikked men ben myȝty *and* weleful
for þou hast forȝeten by whiche gouvernementȝ þe worlde 688

is gouerned. ¶ Forþi wenest þou þat þise mutaciouns
of fortune fleten wiþ outen gouernour. þise ben grete
causes not oonly to maladie. but certes grete causes to
deep ¶ But I þanke þe auctour *and* þe makere of 692
heeþe þat nature haþ not al forleten þe. *and* I haue
g[r]ete norissinges of þi heeþe. *and* þat is þe soþe
sentence

These are not only great
occasions of disease, but
also causes of death
itself.

I thank God that Reason
hath not wholly deserted
thee.

I have some hope of thy
recovery since thou
believest that the world
is under Divine
Providence, for this
small spark shall
produce vital heat.

[* fol. 8 b.]

of gouernaunce of þe worlde. þat þou byleuest
þat þe gouernynge of it nis nat subgit ne vnderput 696
to þe folie *of þise happes auenterouses. but to þe
resoun of god ¶ And þer fore doute þe noþing.
For of þis litel spark þine heet of lijf schal shine. ¶ But
for as muche as it is not tyme ȝitte of fastere remedies
700

But as this is not the time
for stronger remedies,
and because it is natural
to embrace false
opinions so soon as we
have laid aside the true,
from whence arises a
mist that darkens the
understanding, I shall
endeavour therefore to
dissipate these vapours
so that you may perceive
the true light.

¶ And þe nature of þouȝtes disseiued is þis þat as ofte
as þei casten awaye soþe opyniouns: þei clopen hem in
fals[e] opyniouns. [of whiche false opyniouns] þe
derknesse
of perturbacioun wexep vp. þat comfoundep þe verray
704

insyȝt. *and* þat derkenes schal .I. say somewhat to
maken þinne *and* wayk by lyȝt *and* meenelyche remedies.
so þat after þat þe derknes of desseyuynge
desyrynges is don away. þou mow[e] knowe þe schynnyng 708
of verray lyȝt.

630 *wolt pou*—woltow
 stat—estat
 633 *atte*—at
 wilt—wolt
 635 *worlde*—world
 foolisshe—foolyssh
 636 *fortunes*—fortunows
 638 *scholde*—sholden
 639 *wot*—MS. wote, C. woot
 641 *myȝt[e] putte*—myhte put
 644 *put*—MS. putte
 645 *doutest*—dowtedest
 646 *how*—owh
 647 *seek siȝen*—syke syn
 648 *put*—MS. putte, C. put
 649 *depper*—deppere
 not what—not nere what
 650 *siȝen*—syn
 worlde—world
 651 *takest pou*—takestow
 658 *seye*—sey
 remembrest pou—remenbres thow
 ouȝt—omitted
 659 *al*—alle
 660 *herd told*—MS. herde tolde
 herd told it—herd yt toold
 661 *hap*—MS. hape
 663 *proceded*—procedeth
 answered[e]—answerede
 664 *þe*—omitted
 al—alle
 665 *siȝen*—syn
 668 *fro*—owt of
 669 *seyne from*—seyn fro
 672 *Remembrest pou*—Remenbresthow
 674 *Maiste pou*—Maysthow
 675 *þan*—þanne
 þing—thinge
 Axest—Axestow
 677 *Wistest pou*—wystesthow

678 *þing*—thinge
 680 *hast left*—MS. haste lefte, C. hast left
 681 *knowe*—knownen
 pleynelyche knowen—pleynly fwonde [= founde]
 684 *sorwest þou*—sorwistow
 686 *for[þi] demest [þou]*—For thy demesthow
 687 *wikked*—MS. wilked, C. wykkyd
 688 *worlde*—world
 689 *wenest þou*—wenestow
 690 *outen*—owte
 693 *hap*—MS. hape
 al—alle
 694 *þi*—thin
 696 *vnderput*—vndyrputte
 697 *to (2)*—omitted
 698 *fore*—for
 noping—nothinge
 699 *spark þine heet*—sparke thin hete
 700 *muchē*—meche
 702 *aweye*—away
 703 [*of*—*opyniouns*]—from C.
 705 *insyzt*—insyhte
 say—assaye
 706 *lyzt*—lyhte
 708 *don*—MS. done
 mow[e]—mowe

IS NOT TO TAKE HIS LOSSES TO HEART.

[NUBIBUS ATRIS CONDITA.](#)

ÞE sterres couered wiþ blak[e] cloudes ne mowen
 geten a doun no lyzt. 3if þe trouble wynde þat
 hyzt auster stormynge *and* walwyng þe see medleþ þe
 712
 heete þat is to seyne þe boylyng vp from þe botme
 ¶ Þe wawes þat somtyme weren clere as glas *and*
 lyke to þe fair[e] bryzt[e] dayes wiþstant anon þe

[The seuende Metyr.]

Black clouds obscure the
light of the stars.

If the south wind renders
the sea tempestuous, the
waves, fouled with mud,
will lose their glassy
clearness.

syȝtes of men. by þe filþe *and* ordure þat is resolued. 716
and þe fletyng streme þat royleþ doun dyuersely fro
 heyȝe mountaignes is arestid *and* resisted ofte tyme
 by þe encountrynge of a stoon þat is departid *and*
 fallen from some roche. ¶ And forþi yif þou wilt 720
 loken *and* demen soþe wiþ clere lyȝt. *and* holde þe
 weye wiþ a ryȝt pape. ¶ Weyue þou ioie. drif fro þe
 drede. fleme þou hope. ne lat no sorwe aproche. þat is
 to sein lat noon of þise four passiouns ouer come þe.

724

or blynde þe. for cloudy *and* dirke is þilk þouȝt *and*
 bounde *with* bridles. where as þise þinges regnen.

If thou wouldst see truth
 by the clearest light,
 pursue the path of right.

Away with joy, fear,
 hope, and sorrow.

Let none of these
 passions cloud thy mind.

Where these things
 control, the soul is bound
 by strong fetters.

EXPLICIT LIBER PRIMUS.

710 *blak[e]*—blake

712 *stormyng*e—turnyng

713 *from*—fro

714 *somtyme*—whilom

715 *lyke*—lyk

fair[e]—*wipstant* (MS. *wipstante*)—fayre cleere dayes *and* brihte withstand

716 *syȝtes*—syhtes

717 *streme*—strem

718 *heyȝe*—hy

720 *from some*—fram som

wilt—wolt

721 *soþe*—soth

clere—cleer

holde—holden

722 *weye*—wey

pape—paath

724 *come*—comen

725 *blynde*—blende

þilk—thilke

INCIPIT LIBER SECUNDUS.

POSTEA [PAU]LISPER CONTICUIT.

[The fyrst prose.]

After þis she stynte a litel. and after þat she hadde
gadred by atempre stillenesse myn attencioun she

Philosophy exhorts
Boethius not to torment
himself on account of his
losses.

728

seide þus. ¶ As who so myȝt[e] seye þus. After þise
þinges she stynt[e] a lytel. *and* whanne she
aperceiued[e]

Thou art, she says,
affected by the loss of
thy former fortune.

by atempre stillenesse þat I was ententif to
herkene hire. she bygan to speke in þis wyse. ¶ Yif 732
I *quod* she haue vnderstonden *and* knowe vtterly þe
causes *and* þe habit of þi maladie. þou languished *and*
art deffeted for talent *and* desijr of þi raper fortune.

¶ She þat ilke fortune only þat is chaunged as þou 736
feinest to þe ward. haþ peruerterd þe clerenesse *and* þe
astat of þi corage. ¶ I vnderstonde þe felefolde
colour *and* deceites of þilke merueillous monstre
fortune.

It hath perverted thy
faculties.

I am well acquainted
with all the wiles of that
Prodigy (*i. e.* Fortune).

and how she vseþ ful flatryng familiarite wiþ hem 740
þat she enforceþ to bygyle. so longe til þat she confounde
wiþ vnsuffreable sorwe hem þat she haþ left
in despeir vnpurueyed. ¶ and if þou remembrest wel
þe kynde þe maners *and* þe desert of þilke fortune.
þow 744

Though she has left thee,
thou hast not lost
anything of beauty or of
worth.

shalt wel knowe as in hir þou neuer ne haddest ne
hast ylost any fair þing. But as I trowe I shal not

gretly trauaile to don þe remembren of þise þinges.

¶ For þou were wont to hurtlen [*and* despysen] hir 748
wip manly wordes whan she was blaundissinge *and*
presente *and* pursewedest hir wip sentences þat were
drawen oute of myne entre. þat is to seyne out of
myn *informacioun* ¶ But no sudeyne mutacioun ne 752
bytideþ nat wip outhen a maner chaungyng of curages.
and so is it byfallen þat þou art departed a litel fro
þe pees of þi þou3t. but now is tyme þat þou drynke
and atast[e] some softe *and* delitable þinges. so þat
whan 756

þei ben entred wip inne þe. it mow make weye to
strenger drynkes of medycynes. ¶ Com nowe furþe
þerfore þe suasioun of swetnesse Rethoryen. whiche
þat gob oonly þe ry3t wey whil she forsakeþ not myne
760

estatut3. ¶ And wip Rethorice com forþe musice a
damoisel of oure house þat syngeþ now ly3ter moedes
or *prolaciouns* now heuyer. *what ayleþ þe man. what
is it þat haþ cast þe in to murnyng *and* in to wepyng. 764
I trow[e] þat þou hast sen some newe þing *and* uncouþe.

¶ Þou wenest þat fortune be chaunged azeins
þe ¶ But þou wenest wrong. yif þou [þat] wene.
Alwey þo ben hire maners. she haþ raper [kept] as to
768

þe ward hire *propre* stablenes in þe chaungyng of hyre
self. ¶ Ry3t swyche was she whan she flatered[e]
þe. *and* desseiued[e] þe wip vnleueful lykynges of
false welefulnesse. þou hast now knowen *and* ataynt
772

Thou wert once proof
against her allurements.

But sudden change
works a great alteration
in the minds of men,
hence it is that thou art
departed from thy usual
peace of mind.

But with some gentle
emollients I shall prepare
thee for stronger
medicines.

Approach then, Rhetoric,
with thy persuasive
charms, and therewith let
Music also draw near.

[* fol. 9.]

Thou thinkest that
Fortune is changed
towards thee.

But thou art deceived.
In this misadventure of
thine she hath preserved
her constancy in
changing.

You have seen the
double face of this blind
divinity.

þe doutous or double visage of þilke blynde goddesse
 fortune. ¶ She þat 3it couereþ hir *and* wympleþ hir
 to oþer folk. haþ shewed hir euerydel to þe. ¶ 3if
 þou approuest hir *and* þenkest þat she is good. vse 776
 hir maners *and* pleyne þe nat. ¶ And if þou agrisest
 hir fals[e] trecherie. dispise *and* cast awaye hir þat
 pleyeþ so harmefully. for she þat is now cause of so
 myche sorwe to þe. sholde be to þe cause of pees *and* 780
 [of] ioie. ¶ she haþ forsaken þe forsoþe. þe whiche
 þat neuer man may be syker þat she ne shal forsake
 hym. *Glose.* ¶ But napeles some bookes han þe text
 þus. For soþe she haþ forsaken þe ne þer nis no man 784
 syker þat she ne haþ not forsaken. ¶ Holdest þou
 þan þilke welefulnesse *precious* to þe þat shal passen.
and is present fortune derworþi to þe. whiche þat nis
 not feiþful forto dwelle. *and* whan she goþ awaye þat
 788
 she bryngeþ a wyzt in sorwe ¶ For syn she may nat
 be wiþholden at a mans wille. she makeþ hym a wrecche
 when she departeþ fro hym. ¶ What oþer þing is
 flitting fortune but a manere shewyng of
 wrycchednesse 792
 þat is to comen. ne it ne suffriþ nat oo[n]ly to loken
 of þing þat is present byforne þe eyen of man. but
 wisdom lokeþ *and* mesureþ þe ende of þinges. *and* þe
 same chaungyng from one to an oþer. þat is to seyne
 796
 fro aduersite to prosperite makeþ þat þe manaces of
 fortune ne ben not forto dreden. ne þe flatrynges of
 hir to ben desired. ¶ Þus atte þe last it byhoueþ þe

If thou dost abhor her
 perfidy cast her off, for
 her sports are dangerous.

Is that happiness which
 is so transient?

Is the attendance of
 Fortune so dear to thee,
 whose stay is so
 uncertain, and whose
 removal causes such
 grief?

What is she (Fortune)
 but the presage of future
 calamity?

Her mutability should
 make men neither fear
 her threats nor desire her
 favours.

to suffren wiþ euene wille in pacience al þat is don 800
inwiþ þe floor of fortune. þat is to seyne in þis worlde.

PHILOSOPHY EXPOSTULATES WITH BOETHIUS.

¶ Syþen þou hast oones put þi nekke vnder þe 3okke
of hir. for if þou wilt write a lawe of wendying *and* of
dwelliing to fortune whiche þat þou hast chosen frely 804
to be þi lady ¶ Art þou nat wrongful in þat *and*
makest fortune wroþe *and* aspere by þin inpacience.
and 3it þou mayst not chaungen hir. ¶ Yif þou
committest
[*and*] bitakest þi sayles to þe wynde. þou shalt 808
be shouen not þider þat þou woldest(:) but whider þat
þe wynde shoueþ þe ¶ Yif þou castest þi seedes in þe
feldes þou sholdest haue in mynde þat þe 3eres ben
oþer while plenteuous *and* oþer while bareyne. ¶ Þou
812
hast bytaken þiself to þe gouernaunce of fortune.
and forþi it byhoueþ þe to ben obeisaunt to þe manere
of þi lady. and enforcest þou þe to aresten or
wiþstonden
þe swyftnesse *and* þe sweyes of hir tournyng 816
whele. ¶ O þou fool of alle mortel fooles if fortune
bygan to dwelle stable. she cessed[e] þan to ben
fortune.

If you submit to her yoke
you must patiently
endure her inflictions.

Impatience will only
embitter your loss.

You cannot choose your
port if you leave your
vessel to the mercy of
the winds.

You have given yourself
up to Fortune; it
becomes you therefore to
obey her commands.

Would you stop the
rolling of her wheel?

Fool! if Fortune once
became stable she would
cease to exist.

727 *she* (2)—I

729 *my3t[e]* *seye*—myhte seyn

730 *stynt[e]*—stynte

732 *hire*—here

733 *knowe vtterly*—knownen owtrely

734 *languissed*—languyssest

737 *hap*—MS. haþe
 738 *astat*—estat
 felefolde—feeleafold
 739 *colour*—colours
 deceites (MS. decrites)—deceytes
 merueillous—meruayles
 742 *hap*—MS. haþe
 743 *if*—yif
 746 *any* (MS. my)—any
 þing—thinge
 747 *trauaile*—travaylen
 don—do
 remembren of—remenbre on
 748 [*and despysen*]*—*from C.
 749 *was*—omitted
 750 *were*—weren
 751 *myne*—myn
 seyne—sayn
 752 *sudeyne*—sodeyn
 753 *outen*—owte
 757 *inne*—in
 mow—weye—mowe maken way
 758 *strenger*—strengere
 Com nowe furþe—MS. Come; C. Com now forth
 760 *gop*—MS. goþe
 761 *com*—MS. come, C. com
 762 *house*—hows
 ly3ter—lyhtere
 763 *prolaciouns*—probasyons
 heuyer—heuyere
 ayleþ—eyleth
 765 *trow[e]*—trowe
 sen—MS. sene, C. seyn
 some—som
 þing—thinge
 uncouþe—vnkowth
 766 *a3eins*—ayein
 767 *wenest*—weenes
 [*þat*]*—*C. that
 768 *hap*—MS. haþe
 [*kept*]*—*from C.
 769 *stablenes in þe*—stabylnesse standeth in the
 770 *swyche*—swich

771 *vnleueful*—vnlefful
 775 *hap*—MS. had, C. hat
 776 *good*—MS. goode, C. god
 777 *agrisest*—MS. agrised, C. agrysyst
 778 *fals[e]*—false
 780 *myche*—mochel
 781 [*of*]—from C.
 hap—MS. haþe
 783 *text*—texte
 784 *hap*—MS. haþe
 785 *forsaken*—forsake
 Holdest þou—holdestow
 786 *þan*—thanne
 precious—presyes
 787 *derworþi*—dereworthe
 whiche—which
 788 *feipful*—feythfulle
 gop—MS. goþe
 aweye—away
 790 *mans*—mannys
 791 *when*—wan
 þing—thinge
 793 *suffriþ*—suffiseth
 794 *of þing*—on thyng
 byforne—MS. byforne byforne
 man—a man
 795 *mesureþ*—amesureth
 796 *from one*—fram oon
 seyne—seyn
 797 *fro*—from
 to—into
 799 *atte þe last*—at the laste
 801 *seyne*—seyn
 worlde—world
 802 *Syþen*—Syn
 þokke—yoke
 803 *if*—yif
 write—wryten
 804 *whiche*—which
 805 *lady*—ladye
 Art þou—Artow

806 *wrope*—wroth
 pin—thine
807 *chaungen*—chaunge
808 [*and*]*—*from C.
809 *pider*—thedyr
 whider—whedyr
811 *haue*—han
814 *manere*—maneres
815 *and*—omitted
 wipstonden—withholden
816 *sweyes*—swey3
818 *cesed[e]*—cesede

E INCONSTANCY OF FORTUNE.

HEC CUM SUPERBA.

[The fyrst metur.]

Whan fortune wiþ a proude ry3t hande haþ turnid
 hir chaungyng stoundes she fareþ lyke þe

Fortune is as inconstant
as the ebb and flow of
Euripus.

maners 820

of þe boillyng eurippe. *Glose.* Eurippe is an arme of
þe see þat ebbith *and* flowiþ. *and* somtyme þe streme
is on one syde *and* somtyme on þat oþer. *Texte ¶* She
cruel fortune kasteþ adoune kynges þat somtyme
weren 824

She hurls kings from
their thrones, and exalts
the captive.

ydred. *and* she deceiuable enhaunseth vp þe humble
chere of hym þat is discomfited. *and* she neyþer hereþ
ne reccheþ of wrecched[e] wepynges. *and* she is so
harde

She turns a deaf ear to
the tears and cries of the
wretched.

þat she lau3eþ *and* scorneþ þe wepyng of hem þe whiche 828
she haþ makid wepe wiþ hir free wille. ¶ Þus she
pleyeþ *and* þus she preueþ hir strengþe *and* sheweþ a
grete wondre to alle hir seruau3t3. ¶ Yif þat a wy3t
is seyn weleful *and* ouerþrowe in an houre. 832

Thus she sports and
boasts her power and
presents a marvel to her
servants if, in the space
of an hour, a man is
hurled from happiness
into adversity.

819 *proude*—prowd
hande—hand
hap—MS. haþe
820 *lyke*—lik
821 *arme*—arm
822 *streme*—strem
823 *one*—o
821 *adoun*—adown
somtyme—whilom
825 *ydred* (MS. *ydredde*)—ydrad
humble—vmble
827 *reccheþ*—rekkeþ
wrecched[e]—wrecchede
harde—hard
828 *lauþeþ*—lyssheth
wepyng—wepynge
830 *strengþe*—strengthes

PROSPERITY DOES NOT CONSTITUTE FELICITY.

VELLEM AUTEM PAUCA.

[The secunde prose.]

Certis I wolde plete wiþ þee a fewe þinges vsynge
þe wordes of fortune tak heede now þi self. yif þat
she axeþ ryȝt. *¶ O þou man wher fore makest þou
me gilty by þine euerydayes pleynynge. what
wronges 836

haue I don þe. what goodes haue I byreft þe þat weren
þine. stryf or plete wiþ me by fore what iuge þat þou
wilt of þe possessioun of rycchesse or of dignites ¶
And

yif þou maist shewe me þat euer any mortal man hap 840
receyued any of þese þinges to ben his in propre. þan
wol I graunt[e] frely þat [alle] þilke þinges weren þine
whiche þat þou axest. ¶ Whan þat nature brouȝt[e] þe

Philosophy expostulates
with Boethius in the
name of Fortune.

[* fol. 9 b.]

Why do you accuse me
(Fortune) as guilty?

What goods or
advantages have I
deprived you of?

Can you prove that ever
any man had a fixed
property in his riches?

You came naked into the
world, and I cherished

forþe out of þi moder wombe. I receyued[e] þe naked

you and encompassed
you with affluence.

844

and nedy of al þing. *and* I norysshed[e] þe wiþ my
rychesse. *and* was redy *and* ententif þoru3 my fauour to
sustene þe. ¶ And þat makeþ þe now inpatient azeins me.

and I envirounde þe wiþ al þe habundaunce *and* 848

shinyng of al goodes þat ben in my ry3t. ¶ Now it
lykeþ me to wiþ drawe myne hande. þou hast had
grace

Now that I have a mind
to withdraw my bounty,
be thankful and
complain not.

as he þat haþ vsed of foreyne goodes. þou hast no ry3t to
pleyne þe. as þou3 þou haddest vtterly lorn alle þi 852
þinges. whi pleyneþ þou þan. I haue don þe no wrong.

Ricches honoures *and* swyche oþer þinges ben of my
ry3t. ¶ My seruauntes knowen me for hir lady. þei
comen wiþ me *and* departen whan I wende. I dar wel

Riches and honours are
subject to me.

They are my servants,
and come and go with
me.

856

affermen hardyly. þat yif þo þinges of whiche þou
pleyneþ þat þou hast forlorn hadde ben þine. þou ne
haddest not lorn hem. ¶ shal I þan only be defended
to vse my ry3t. ¶ Certis it is leueful to þe heuene to 860
make clere dayes. *and* after þat to keuere þe same
dayes

Shall I alone be
forbidden to use my own
right?

Doth not heaven give us
sunny days and obscure
the same with dark
nights?

wiþ derke ny3tes. ¶ Þe erþe haþ eke leue to appaile
þe visage of þe erþe now *with* floures *and* now wiþ
fruyt. *and* to confounde hem somtyme wiþ raynes *and*

Is not the earth covered
with frost as well as with
flowers?

864

wiþ coldes. ¶ Þe see haþ eke hys ry3t to be somtyme
calme *and* blaundyshing wiþ smoþe water. *and*
somtyme to be horrible wiþ wawes *and* wiþ tempestes.

The sea sometimes
appears calm, and at
other times terrifies us
with its tempestuous
waves.

¶ But þe couetyse of men þat may not be staunched 868

Shall I be bound to
constancy by the
covetousness of men?

shal it bynde me to be stedfast. syn þat stedfastnesse
is vnkouþ to my maneres. ¶ Swyche is my strengþe.
and þis pley. I pley[e] continually. I tourne þe whirlyng
whele wiþ þe tournyng cercle ¶ I am glade to chaunge
872
þe lowest to þe heyeste. and þe heyest to þe loweste.

SUBJECT TO FORTUNE'S CHANGES.

worþe vp yif þou wilt. so it be by þis lawe. þat þou
ne holde not þat I do þe wronge þou3 þou descende
doun whanne resoun of my pleye axeþ it. Wost þou 876
not how Cresus kyng of lyndens of whiche kyng Cirus
was ful sore agast a litel byforne þat þis rewlyche
Cresus was cau3t of Cirus and lad to þe fijr to be
brent. but þat a reyne descended[e] doun from heuene 880
þat rescowed[e] hym ¶ And is it out of þi mynde how
þat Paulus consul of Rome whan he hadde take þe
kyng of perciens weep pitou[s]ly for þe captiuitee of þe
self[e] kyng. What oþer þinges bywaylen þe criinges
of 884
Tragedies. but only þe dedes of fortune. þat wiþ an
vnwar stroke ouerturneþ þe realmes of grete nobley
¶ *Glose.* Tragedie is to seyne a dite of a prosperite for
a tyme þat endiþ in wrechednesse. Leredest nat þou
888
in grek whan þou were 3onge þat in þe entre or in þe
seler of Iuppiter þer ben couched two tunnes. þat on
is ful of good þat oþer is ful of harme. ¶ What ry3t
hast þou to pleyne. yif þou hast taken more
plenteuously 892

I turn my rolling wheel
and amuse myself with
exalting what was low,
and bringing down what
was high.

Ascend if you will, but
come down when my
sport requires it.

Know you not the
history of Cræsus and of
Paulus Æmilius?

What else does the
weeping muse of
Tragedy deplore but the
overthrow of kingdoms
by the indiscriminate
strokes of Fortune?

Did you not learn whilst
a youth, that at the gates
of Jove's palace stand
two vessels, one full of
blessings, the other of
woes?

What if you have drunk
too deep of the first
vessel?

of þe goode syde þat is to seyne of my rycchesse *and*
prosperites. and what eke. yif I be nat departed fro þe.
 What eke. yif my mutabilitee ȝiueþ þe ryȝtful cause of
 hope to han ȝit better þinges. ¶ Napeles desmaie þe 896
 nat in þi þouȝt. and þou þat art put in comune realme
 of alle: ne desir[e] nat to lyue by þine oonly propre
 ryȝt.

My mutability gives thee
 hope of happier days.

Desire not to be
 exempted from the
 vicissitudes of humanity.

833 *plete*—pleten

834 *tak*—MS. take, C. tak

835 *makest þou*—makes thow

836 *wronges*—wonge

837 *don*—MS. done, C. don

byreft—MS. byrefte, C. byreft

838 *stryf*—MS. stryue, C. stryf

plete—pleten

by fore—by forn

839 *wilt*—wolt

rycchesse—rychesses

840 *shewe*—shewyn

euer—euere

hap—MS. haþe

841 *þese*—tho

his—hise

842 *graunt[e]*—graunte

[*alle*]*—from C.*

845 *al þing*—alle thinges

norysshed[e]—noryssede

846 *rychesse*—rychesses

848, 849 *al*—alle

848 *habundaunce*—aboundaunce

850 *wip*—*hande*—withdrawen myn hand

had—MS. hadde, C. had

851 *hap*—MS. haþe

852 *vtterly*—outrely

lorn—MS. lorne, C. for lorn.

853 *don*—MS. done, C. don

854 *Ricches*—Rychesses

858 *forlorn*—MS. forlorne, C. forlorn

859 *lorn*—MS. *lorne*, C. *lorn*
 860 *vse*—*vsen*
 861 *keuere þe*—*coeueryn tho*
 862 *derke*—*dirk*
 erþe—*yer*
 hap—MS. *haþe*
 864 *confounde*—*confownden*
 865 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 866 *calme*—*kalm*
 867 (2nd) *wip*—omitted
 869 *stedfast*—*stidefast*
 stedfastnesse—*stidefastnesse*
 870 *vnkouþ*—MS. *vnkouþe*, C. *vnkowth*
 Swyche—*Swych*
 871 *pley[e]*—*pleye*
 872 *whele*—*wheel*
 glade—*glad*
 chaunge—*chaungyn*
 874 *worþe*—*worth*
 wilt—*wolt*
 876 *doun*—*adoun*
 whanne—*wan*
 pleye—*pley*
 Wost þou—*wistesthow*
 877 *kyng* (1)—*the kyng*
 lyndens—*lydyens*
 878 *byforne*—*byforn*
 880 *reyne descended[e]*—*rayn dessendede*
 from—*fro*
 881 *rescowed[e]*—*rescowede*
 882 *take*—*takyn*
 885 *an*—*a*
 886 *þe*—omitted
 887 *seyne*—*seyn*
 890 *tunnes*—*tonnes*
 891 *harme*—*harm*
 892 *hast þou*—*hasthow*
 893 *seyne*—*seyn*
 rycchesse—*rychesses*
 894 *I be nat*—*I ne be nat al*
 896 *better*—*betere*

898 *lyue*—lyuen
pine—thin

E COVETOUS ARE EVER DISCONTENTED.

SI QUANTAS RAPIDIS.

[the secunde metur.]

POuz plentee þat is goddesse of rycches hielde
adoun

Though Plenty, from her
teeming horn, poured
down as many riches on
the world as there are
sands on the sea-shore,
or stars in heaven,
mankind would not
cease to complain.

wiþ ful horn. *and* wiþdraweþ nat hir hand. ¶ As 900
many recches as þe see turneþ vpwardes sandes whan
it

is moeued wiþ rauysshing blastes. or ellys as many
rycches as þer shynen bryzt[e] sterres on heuene on þe
sterry nyzt. 3it for al þat mankynde nolde not cesce to 904

[* fol. 10.]

wope wrecched[e] pleyntes. ¶ And al be it so *þat
god receyueþ gladly her *prayers and* 3eueþ hem as ful
large muche golde *and* apparaileþ coueytous folk wiþ
noble or clere honours. 3it semeþ hem haue I-gete noþing. 908

Though Heaven may
grant every desire, they
will still cry for more.

but alwey her cruel ravyne deuourynge al þat þei
han geten shewiþ oþer gapinges. þat is to seye gapen
and desiren 3it after moo rycchesse. ¶ What brideles
myzten wiþholde to any certeyne ende þe desordene
912

What rein can restrain
unbounded avarice?

coueitise of men ¶ Whan euere þe raper þat it fletip in
large 3iftis: þe more ay brenneþ in hem þe þrest of
hauyng. ¶ Certis he þat quakyng *and* dredeful wenep
hym seluen nedy. he ne lyueþ neuere mo ryche. 916

He who thinks himself
poor, though he be rich,
doth truly labour under
poverty.

899 *rycches*—rychesses

901 *recches*—rychesses
vpwardes—vpward

902 *rauysshing*—rauysynge

903 *rycches*—rychesses
bryȝt[e]—bryhte
on (1)—in
 904 *nyȝt*—nyhtes
 905 *wope wrecched[e]*—wepe wrecchede
 906 *her*—hir
ful—fool
 907 *muchē*—meche
folk—men
 908 *haue*—hauen
I-gete—I-getyn
 909 *her*—hir
 910 *seye*—seyn
 911 *rycchesse*—rychesses
 912 *wipholde*—wytholden
certeyne—certeyn
 914 *prest*—thurst
 915 *dredeful*—dredful
 916 *lyueþ*—leueth

ETHIUS IS NOT UNHAPPY.

[HIIS IGITUR SI PRO SE.](#)

Perfore yif þat fortune spake wiþ þe for hir self in
 þis manere. For soþe þou ne haddest [nat] what
 þou myȝtest answerē. and if þou hast any þing wherwiþ.
 þou mayist ryȝtfully tellen þi compleynt. ¶ It 920
 byhoueþ þe to shewen it. *and* .I. wol ȝeue þe space to
 tellen it. ¶ Certeynely *quod* I þan þise ben faire
 þinges *and* enoyntid wiþ hony swetnesse of rethorike
and musike. *and* only while þei ben herd þei ben 924
 deliciouse. ¶ But to wrecches is a deppere felyng of
 harme. þis is to seyn þat wrecches felen þe harmes þat
 þei suffren more greuously þan þe remedies or þe
 delites

[The thrydde prose.]

If Fortune spake thus to
 you, you could not
 defend your complaint.

B. What you have said is
 very specious, but such
 discourses are only
 sweet while they strike
 our ears.

They cannot efface the
 deep impressions that
 misery has made in the
 heart.

of þise wordes mowe gladen or comforten hem. so þat 928
 whan þise þinges stynten forto soun[e] in eres. þe sorwe
 þat is inset greueþ þe þouzt. Ryzt so is it *quod* she.
 ¶ For þise ne ben 3it none remedies of þi maladie. but
 þei ben a manere norissinges of þi sorwe 3it rebel 932
 a3eyne þi curacioun. ¶ For whan þat tyme is. I shal
 moue swiche þinges þat percen hem self depe. ¶ But
 napeles þat þou shalt not wilne to leten þi self a
 wrecche. ¶ Hast þou for3eten þe noumbre *and* þe 936
 manere of þi welefulnesse. I holde me stille how þat
 þe souerayn men of þe Citee token þe in cure *and*
 keypyng whan þou were orphelyn of fadir *and* modir.
and were chosen in affinite of princes of þe Citee. 940
 ¶ And þou bygunne rapen to ben leef *and* deere þan
 forto ben a ney3bour. þe whiche þing is þe most
 precieuse
 kynde of any propinquitee or aliaunce þat may
 ben. ¶ Who is it þat ne seide þou nere ryzt weleful 944
 wiþ so grete a nobley of þi fadres in lawe. ¶ *And* wiþ
 þe chastite of þi wijf. *and* wiþ þe oportunitie *and*
 noblesse of þi masculyn children. þat is to seyne þi
 sones *and* ouer al þis me lyst to passe of comune þinges. 948
 ¶ How þou haddest in þi þouzt dignitees þat weren
 warned to olde men. but it deliteþ me to comen now to
 þe singuler vphepyng of þi welefulnesse. ¶ Yif any
 fruyt of mortal þinges may han any wey3te or price of 952
 welefulnesse. ¶ My3test þou euere for3eten for any
 charge of harme þat myzt[e] byfallen. þe
 remembraunce
 of þilke day þat þou sey[e] þi two sones maked conseillers.

P. So it is indeed; for my
 arguments are not
 designed as remedies,
 but as lenitives only.

When time serves, I will
 administer those things
 that shall reach the seat
 of your disease.
 But you are not among
 the number of the
 wretched.

I shall not speak of your
 happiness in being
 provided for (in your
 orphanage) by the chief
 men of the city; nor of
 your noble alliance with
 Festus and Symmachus;

nor of your virtuous
 wife, and manly sons.

Can you ever forget the
 memorable day that saw
 your two sons invested
 with the dignity of
 Consuls?

and ylad to gidre from þin house vndir so gret 956
assemble of senatours. *and* vndir þe blypenesse of poeple.
and whan þou say[e] hem sette in þe court in her
chaieres of dignites. ¶ Þou rethorien or pronouncere
of kynges preysinges. deseruedest glorie of wit *and* of 960
eloquence. whan þou sitting bytwix þi two soness
conseillers

When in the circus you
satisfied the expectant
multitude with a
triumphal largess?

in þe place þat hyȝt Circo. *and* fulfildest þe
abydyng of multitude of poeple þat was sprad about þe
wiþ large praysynge *and* laude as men syngen in victories. 964

By your expressions you
flattered Fortune, and
obtained from her a gift
which never before fell
to any private person.

þo ȝaue þou wordes of fortune as I trowe. þat
is to seyne. þo feffedest þou fortune wiþ glosynge
wordes *and* desseiuedest hir. whan she accoied[e] þe
and norsshed[e] þe as hir owen delices. ¶ Þou hast 968
had of fortune a ȝifte þat is to seyn swiche gerdoun
þat she neu[er]e ȝaf to preue man ¶ Wilt þou þerfore
leye a rekenyng wiþ fortune. she haþ now twynkeled
first vpon þe wiþ a wykked eye. ¶ Yif þou considere
972

Will you therefore call
Fortune to account?

She now begins, I own,
to look unkindly on you;
but if you consider the
number of your
blessings, you must
confess that you are still
happy.

[* fol. 10 b.]

þe noumbre *and* þe manere of þi blysses. *and* of þi
sorwes. *þou maist nat forsake þat þou nart ȝit blysful.

VERSITY IS BUT TRANSIENT.

For if þou þerfore wenest þi self nat weleful for þinges
þat þo semeden ioyful ben passed. ¶ Þer nis nat whi 976
þou sholdest wene þi self a wrecche. for þinges þat now
semen soory passen also. ¶ Art þou now comen firste
a sodeyne gest in to þe shadowe or tabernacle of þis
lijf. or trowest þou þat any stedfastnesse be in manniss
980

These evils that you
suffer are but transitory.

Can there be any
stability in human
affairs, when the life of

þinges. ¶ Whan ofte a swifte houre dissolueþ þe same
man. þat is to seyne whan þe soule departiþ fro þe
body. For al þou3 þat yelde is þer any feiþ þat fortunous
þinges willen dwelle. 3it napeles þe last[e] day 984
of a mannis lijf is a manere deef to fortune. *and* also
to þilke þat hap dwelt. *and* þerfore what wenist þou
þar recche yif þou forlete hir *in* deyng or ellys þat she
fortune forlete þe *in* fleenge away. 988

man is exposed to
dissolution every hour?

The last day of life puts
an end to Prosperity.

What matters it then,
whether you by death
leave it, or it (Fortune)
by flight doth leave you?

918 [*nat*]*—*from C.
 919 *if**—*yif
 920 *mayist**—*mayst
 *tellen**—*defendyn
 921 *ȝeue**—*yeuyn
 922 *þan**—*thanne
 *ben**—*bet (= beth)
 923 *swetnesse**—*swetenesse
 924 *while**—*whil
 *herd**—*MS. herde
 926 *harme**—*harm
 928 *mowe**—*mowen
 929 *soun*[*e*]-sowne
 930 *inset**—*MS. insette, C. inset
 932 *sorwe**—*sorwes
 933 *aȝeyne**—*ayein
 934 *moue swiche**—*moeue swych
 938 *soueraȝn**—*souerane
 943 *neyȝbour**—*neysshebour
 944 *nere**—*were
 945 *nobley**—*nobleȝe
 *fadres**—*fadyr-is
 947 *seyne**—*seyn
 948 *lyst**—*lyste
 *passe of**—*passen the
 949 *þouȝt**—*yowthe
 950 *warned**—*werned
 952 *fruyt**—*frute
 *price**—*pris
 953 *Myȝtest þow**—*myhtes-thow
 954 *harme**—*harm
 myȝt[*e*] *byfallen**—*myhte befalle
 955 *sey*[*e*]*—*saye
 956 *from**—*fro
 *gret**—*MS. grete, C. gret

958 *say[e]*—saye
 sette—set
 her—heere
961 *bytwix*—bytwyen
962 *hyzt*—hihte
963 *of* (1)—of the
 about—abowten
964 *wip*—with so
965 *3aue*—MS. þan, C. yaue
 of—to
966 *seyne*—seyn
967 *accoied[e]*—acoyede
968 *norsshed[e]*—noryssede
 owen—owne
 pou—*of*—thow bar away of
969 *had*—MS. hadde
 swiche—swich
970 *preue*—pryue
971 *leye*—lye
 hap—MS. haþe
972 *wykked*—wyckede
973 *blysses*—blysse
974 *forsake*—forsakyn
 nart—art
 blysful—blysseful
978 *soory*—sorye
 firste—fyrst
979 *sodeyne*—sodeyn
 shadowe—shadwe
980 *stedfastnesse*—stedefastnesse
981 *swifte*—swyft
 dissolueþ—dyssoluede
983 *al þou3 þat*—al þat though
 fortunous—fortune
984 *willen dwelle*—wolen dwellyn
 last[e]—laste
986 *hap*—MS. haþe
 wenist þou—weenestow
987 *þar recche*—dar recke
988 *away*—away

NY BLESSINGS STILL REMAIN.

CUM PRIMO POLO.

[The .iiij. Metur.]

Whan phebus þe sonne bygynneþ to spreden his
clerenesse

The stars pale before the
light of the rising sun.

with rosene chariettes. þan þe sterre ydimmyd
paleþ hir white cheres. by þe flamus of þe sonne þat
ouer comeþ þe sterre lyzt. ¶ Þis is to seyn whan þe 992
sonne is risen þe day sterre wexiþ pale *and* lesiþ hir
lyzt for þe grete bryzt nesse of þe sonne. ¶ Whan þe
wode wexeþ redy of rosene floures in þe first somer
sesoun þoruþ þe breþe of þe wynde Zephirus þat
wexeþ 996

Westerly winds deck the
wood with roses, but
easterly winds cause
their beauty to fade.

warme. ¶ Yif þe cloudy wynde auster blowe felliche.
þan goþ away þe fayrnesse of þornes. Ofte þe see is
clere *and* calme wiþoute moeuyng floodes. And ofte
þe horrible wynde aquilon moeueþ boylyng tempestes 1000
and ouer whelweþ þe see. ¶ Yif þe forme of þis worlde
is so [zeelde] stable. *and* yif it tourniþ by so many
entrechaungynges. wilt þou þan trusten in þe trublynge
fortunes of men. wilt þou trowen in flittyng goodes. 1004
It is certeyne *and* establissed by lawe *perdurable* þat
no

Now the sea is calm, and
again it is tempestuous.

If all things thus vary,
will you trust in
transitory riches?

All here below is
unstedfast and unstable.

þing þat is engendred nys stedfast no stable.

989 *his*—hyr

990 *þan*—thanne

991 *flamus*—flambes

995 *redy*—rody

rosene—rosyn

997 *warme*—warm

998 *goþ*—MS. goþe, C. goth

fayrnesse—fayrenesse

999 *clere*—cleer
calme—kalm
 1000 *wynde*—wynd
 1001 *whelweþ*—welueeth
 1002 [*zeelde*]*—from C.*
 1003, 1004 *wilt þou*—wolthow
 1003 *þan*—thanne
trublynge—towmblynge
 1004 *in flittyng*—on flettynge
 1005 *It is*—is it
 1006 *no*—ne
stable—estable

ICH TO BE THANKFUL FOR.

TUNC EGO UERA INQUAM.

[The ferthe prose.]

Þ Anne seide I þus. O norice of alle uertues þou
 seist ful soþe. ¶ Ne I may nat forsake þe ryȝt[e]
 1008
 swifte cours of my prosperitee. þat is to seine. þat
 prosperitee ne be comen to me wondir swiftly *and*
 soone. but þis is a þing þat gretly smertip me whan it
 remembreþ me. ¶ For in alle aduersitees of fortune þe
 1012
 most vnsely kynde of contrariouse fortune is to han
 ben weleful. ¶ But þat þou quod she abaist þus þe
 tourment of þi fals[e] opinioun þat maist þou not
 ryȝtfully
 blamen ne aretten to þinges. as who seiþ for þou 1016
 hast ȝitte many habundaunces of þinges. ¶ *Textus.*
 For al be it so þat þe ydel name of auenterouse welefulnesse
 moeueþ þe now. it is leueful þat þou rekene
 with me of how many[e] þinges þou hast ȝit plentee. 1020

B. I cannot deny my
 sudden and early
 prosperity.

It is the remembrance of
 former happiness that
 adds most to man's
 infelicity.

P. Recollect that you
 have yet much affluence.

¶ And þerfore yif þat þilke þing þat þou haddest for most *precious* in alle þi rycchesse of fortune be kept to þe by þe grace of god vnwemmed *and* vndefouled.

What you esteemed most precious in your happy days, you still retain, and ought therefore not to complain.

Mayst þou þan pleyne ryztfully vpon þe myschief of fortune. 1024
syn þou hast 3it þi best[e] þinges. ¶ Certys 3it lyueþ in goode poynt þilke *precious* honour of mankynde.

¶ Symacus þi wyues fadir whiche þat is a man maked al of sapience *and* of vertue. þe whiche 1028

Symmachus, dear to you as life, is safe and in health.

man þou woldest b[i]en redely wiþ þe pris of þin owen lijf. he byweyleþ þe wronges þat men don to þee. *and* not for hym self. for he liueþ in sykernesse of any sentence put azeins him. ¶ And 3it lyueþ þi wif þat 1032 is attempre of witte *and* passyng oþer women in clennes

Your wife Rusticiana is also alive, and bewails her separation from you.

of chastitee. and for I wol closen shortly her bountes she is lyke to hir fadir. I telle þe welle þat she lyueþ loop of hir life. *and* kepiþ to þee oonly hir goost. *and* 1036 is al maat *and* ouer-comen by wepyng *and* sorwe for desire of þe ¶ In þe whiche þing only I mot graunten þat þi welefulnesse is amenused. ¶ What shal I seyn eke of þi two sones conseillours of whiche as of children 1040

Why need I mention your two sons, in whom so much of the wit and spirit of their sire and grandsire doth shine?

[* fol. 11.]

of hir age þer shineþ *þe lyknesse of þe witte of hir fadir *and* of hir eldefadir. and siþen þe souereyn cure of alle mortel folke is to sauen hir owen lyues.

And since it is the chief care of man to preserve life; you are still most happy in the possession of blessings which all men value more than life.

¶ O how weleful art þou þou3 þou knowe þi goodes. 1044

¶ But 3itte ben þer þinges dwellyng to þe wardes þat no
man douteþ þat þei ne ben more derworþe to þe þen
þine owen lijf. ¶ And forþi drie þi teres for 3itte nys
nat eueriche fortune al hateful to þe warde. ne ouer
1048

Dry up thy tears, thou
hast still present comfort
and hope of future
felicity.

greet tempest haþ nat 3it fallen vpon þe. whan þat þin
ancres cliue fast[e] þat neiþer wole suffre þe comfort of þis
tyme present. ne þe hope of tyme comynge to passen
ne to fallen. ¶ And I *preie quod* I þat fast[e] mot[en]
1052

B. I hope these will
never fail me.

þei holden. ¶ For whiles þat þei halden. how so euere
þat þinges ben. I shal wel fleten furþe and eschapen.
¶ But þou mayst wel seen how greet[e] apparailes *and*
aray þat me lakkeþ þat ben passed away fro me. ¶ I
1056

But do you not see how
low I am fallen?

haue sumwhat auaunced *and* forþered þe *quod* she. if
þat þou anoie nat or forþenke nat of al þi fortune. As
who seiþ. ¶ I haue somewhat comforted þe so þat þou
tempest nat þe þus wiþ al þi fortune. syn þou hast 1060
3it þi best[e] þinges. ¶ But I may nat suffre þin
delices. þat pleinst so wepyng. *and* anguissous for þat
oper lakkeþ somewhat to þi welefulnesse. ¶ For what
man is so sad or of so *perfit* welefulnesse. þat he ne
1064

P. I should think that I
had made progress if you
did not repine so at your
fate.

stryueþ or pleyneþ on some half azeine þe qualitee of
his estat. ¶ For whi ful anguissous þing is þe
condicioun
of mans goodes. ¶ For eyþer it comeþ al to
gidre to a wy3t. or ellys it lasteþ not perpetuely. 1068

It grieues me to hear you
complain while you
possess so many
comforts.

Every one, however
happy, has something to
complain of.

The condition of human
enjoyment is anxious;
for either it comes not all
at once, or makes no
long stay when it does
come.

PPINESS ARISES FROM CONTENTMENT.

¶ For som man haþ grete rycchesse. but he is asshamed
of hys vngentil lynage. *and* som man is renommed
of noblesse of kynrede. but he is enclosed in so
grete angre for nede of þinges. þat hym were leuer þat
1072

he were vnknowe. and som man habundeþ boþe in
rychesse *and* noblesse. but ȝit he bywaileþ hys chast[e]
lijf. for he haþ no wijf. ¶ and som man is wel *and*
selily married but he haþ no children. *and* norissheþ his
1076

ricchesse to þe heires of straunge folk. ¶ And som
man is gladded wiþ children. but he wepiþ ful sory for
þe trespas of his son or of his douȝtir. ¶ and for þis
þer accordeþ no wyȝt lyȝtly to þe condicioun of his
fortune. 1080

for alwey to euery man þere is in mest somewhat
þat vnassaieþ he ne wot not or ellys he dredip þat he
haþ assaied. ¶ *And* adde þis also þat euery weleful
man haþ a wel delicat felyng. ¶ So þat but yif alle 1084
þinges fallen at hys owen wille for he inpatient or is
nat vsed to han none aduersitee. an-oone he is þrowe
adoũne for euery lytel þing. ¶ And ful lytel þinges
ben þo þat wiþdrawen þe somme or þe perfeccioun of
1088

blisfulnesse fro hem þat ben most fortunat. ¶ How
many men trowest þou wolde demen hem self to ben
almost in heuene yif þei myȝten atteyne to þe leest[e]
partie of þe remenaunt of þi fortune. ¶ Þis same place 1092
þat þou clepist exil is contre to hem þat enhabiten

One man is very
wealthy, but his birth is
obscure.

Another is conspicuous
for nobility of descent,
but is surrounded by
indigence.

A third is blest with both
advantages, but is
unmarried.

This man is happy in a
wife, but is childless,
while that other man has
the joy of children, but is
mortified by their evil
ways.

Thus we see that no man
can agree easily with the
state of his fortune.

The senses of the happy
are refined and delicate,
and they are impatient if
anything is untoward.

The happiness of the
most fortunate depends
on trifles.

How many would think
themselves in heaven if
they had only a part of
the remnant of thy
fortune!

here. *and* forþi. Nopþing wrecched. but whan þou
wenest it ¶ As who seiþ. þou3 þi self ne no wy3t
ellys nys no wrecche but whan he wenep hym self a
1096
wrecche by reputacioun of his corage.

Thy miseries proceed
from the thought that
thou art miserable.

Every lot may be happy
to the man who bears his
condition with
equanimity and courage.

- 1008 *sope*—soth
 Ne I may—Ne I ne may
1009 *seine*—seyn
1011 *a*—omitted
 gretly—gretely
1012 *aduersitees*—aduersyte
1013 *most*—mooste
1014 *abaist*—abyest
1015 *tourment*—torment3
 fals[e]—false
1016 *seiþ*—MS. seiþe, C. seyh
1017 *3itte*—yit
1019 *leueful*—leefful
1020 *many[e] þinges*—manye grete thinges
1022 *alle*—al
1023 *þe by*—the yit by
1024 *myschief*—meschef
1025 *best[e]*—beste
1026 *lyueþ*—leueth
 goode—good
1027 *whiche*—which
1028 *al*—alle
 of (2)—omitted
1029 *b[i]en*—byen
 owen—owne
1030 *byweyleþ*—bewayleth
 don—MS. done, C. don
1031 *liueþ*—leueth
1033 *witte*—wyt
 women—wymmen
1034 *shortly*—shortely
1035 *lyke*—lik
 welle—wel

1036 *hir life*—this lyf
 1037 *maat*—maad
 1038 *whiche*—weche
 1039 *amenused*—amenysed
 seyn—(MS. *seyne*) seyn
 1041 *lyknesse*—lykenesse
 witte—wyt
 1042 *and* (1)—or
 eldefadir—eldyr fadyr
 sipen—syn
 1043 *folke*—folk
 1044 *art pou pouz*—arthow yif
 1045 *But zitte*—for yit
 dwellyng—dwellyd
 wardes—ward
 1046 *pat*—than
 derworpe—dereworthe
 ben pine—than thin
 1047 *zitte*—yit
 1049 *hap*—MS. *hape*
 pin—thyne
 1050 *cliue fast[e]*—cleuen faste
 wole suffre—wolen suffren
 1052 *fallen*—faylen
 fast[e] mot[en]—faste moten
 1053 *holden*—halden
 1054 *furpe*—forth
 1055 *mayst*—mayste
 greet[e]—grete
 1058 *forpenke*—forthinke
 1061 *best[e]*—beste
 suffre pin—suffren thi
 1063 *oper*—ther
 1064 *perfit*—parfyt
 1065 *or*—and
 some half azeine—som halue ayen
 1067 *mans*—mannes
 comep al—comth nat al
 1068 *lastep*—last
 perpetuely—perpetuel
 1069 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 1070 *renomed*—renowned

1072 *angre for*—Angwysshe of
leuer—leuere
 1074 *chast[e]*—caste
 1075, 1076 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1076 *maried*—ymaryed
his—hise
 1077 *ricchesse*—Rychesses
heires—eyres
folk—foolkys
 1080 *þer*—þer ne
 1081 *mest*—omitted
 1082 *vnassaieþ*—vnassaied
wot—MS. wote, C. wot
 1083, 1084 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1084 *wel*—ful
 1085 *fallen*—byfalle
wille—wyl
 1086 *none*—non
an-oone—Anon
þrowe—throwen
 1087 *adoũne*—adoun
 1090 *wolde*—wolden
 1095 *it*—hyt
who—ho
 1096 *no*—a

E SOURCE OF TRUE HAPPINESS.

CONTRAQUE.

And aȝeinewarde al fortune is blisful to a man by þe
 agreablete or by þe egalite of hym þat suffreþ it.

¶ What man is þat. þat is so weleful þat nolde
 chaungen 1100

When patience is lost
 then a change of state is
 desired.

his estat whan he hap lorn pacience. þe swetnesse of
 mannes welefulnesse is yspranid wiþ many[e] bitternesses.

þe whiche welefulnesse al þouȝ it seme swete *and*
 ioyeful to hym þat vseþ it. ȝit may it not be wiþ-holden 1104

þat it ne goþ away whan it wol. ¶ Þan is it wel sen
how wrecched is þe blisfulnesse of mortel þinges. þat
neiþer it dwelliþ perpetuel wiþ hem þat euery fortune
receyuen agreablely or egaly. ¶ Ne it ne deliteþ not in
1108

al. to hem þat ben anguissous. ¶ O ye mortel folkes
what seke *3e þan blisfulnesse oute of 3oure self.
whiche

þat is put in 3oure self. *Error and folie confoundeþ*
3ow ¶ I shal shewe þe shortly. þe poynt of souereyne 1112
blisfulnesse. Is þer any þing to þe more *precious* þan
þi self ¶ Þou wilt answeere nay. ¶ Þan if it so be þat
þou art myzty ouer þi self þat is to seyn by tranquillitee
of þi soule. þan hast þou þing in þi power þat þou 1116
noldest neuer lesen. ne fortune may nat by-nyme it þe.
and þat þou mayst knowe þat blisfulnesse [ne] may
nat standen in þinges þat ben fortunous *and* temperel.
¶ Now vndirstonde *and* gadir it to gidir þus 1120
yif blisfulnesse be þe souereyne goode of nature þat
liueþ by resoun ¶ Ne þilke þing nis nat souereyne
goode þat may be taken away in any wyse. for more
worþi þing *and* more digne is þilke þing þat may nat be 1124
taken away. ¶ Þan shewiþ it wele þat þe vnstabilnesse
of fortune may nat attayne to receyue verray
blisfulnes. ¶ And 3it more ouer. ¶ What man þat
þis toublyng welefulnesse leediþ. eiper he woot þat
1128

[it] is chaungeable. or ellis he woot it nat. ¶ And yif
he woot it not. what blisful fortune may þer be in þe
blyndenesse of ignoraunce. and yif he woot þat it is

How much is human
felicity embittered!

It will not stay with
those that endure their
lot with equanimity, nor
bring comfort to anxious
minds.

Why then, O mortals, do
ye seek abroad for that
felicity which is to be
found within yourselves?

[* fol. 11 b.]

Nothing is more precious
than thyself.

If thou hast command
over thyself, Fortune
cannot deprive thee of it.

Happiness does not
consist in things
transitory.

If happiness be the
supreme good of nature,
then that thing cannot be
it which can be
withdrawn from us.

Instability of fortune is
not susceptible of true
happiness.

He who is led by fading
felicity, either knows that
it is changeable or does
not know it.

If he knows it not, what
happiness has he in the
blindness of his
ignorance?

chaungeable. he mot alwey ben adrad þat he ne lese 1132
þat þing. þat he ne douteþ nat but þat he may leesen it.

THES DO NOT CONSTITUTE HAPPINESS.

¶ As whoo seiþ he mot ben alwey agast lest he
leese þat he wot wel he may leese. ¶ For whiche þe
continuel drede þat he haþ ne suffriþ hym nat to ben

1136

weleful. ¶ Or ellys yif he leese it he wene to be
dispised *and* forleten hit. ¶ Certis eke þat is a ful
lytel goode þat is born wiþ euene hert[e] whan it is
loost. ¶ Þat is to seyne þat men don no more force. 1140
of þe lost þan of þe hauynge. ¶ And for as myche as
þou þi self art he to whom it haþ ben shewid *and*
proued

by ful many[e] demonstraciouns. as I woot wel þat þe
soules of men ne mowen nat dien in no wise. and eke

1144

syn it is clere. *and* certeyne þat fortunous welefulnesse
endiþ by þe deef of þe body. ¶ It may nat ben douted
þat yif þat deef may take away blysfulnesse þat al þe
kynde of mortal þingus ne descendip in to wrecchednesse 1148

by þe ende of þe deef. ¶ And syn we knowen
wel þat many a man haþ souȝt þe fruit of blisfulnesse
nat only wiþ suffryng of deef. but eke wiþ suffryng of
peynes *and* tourmentes. how myȝt[e] þan þis present

1152

lijf make men blisful. syn þat whanne þilke self[e]
lijf is endid. it ne makeþ folk no wrecches.

If he knows it is fleeting
he must be afraid of
losing it, and this fear
will not suffer him to be
happy.

Since thou art convinced
of the soul's immortality,
thou canst not doubt that
if death puts an end to
human felicity, that all
men when they die, are
plunged into the depths
of misery.

But we know that many
have sought to obtain
felicity, by undergoing
not only death, but pains
and torments.

How then can this
present life make men
truly happy, since when
it is ended they do not
become miserable?

1099 *it*—hyt
 1101 *whan*—what
 hap—MS. haþe
 lorn—MS. lorne, C. lost
 1102 *yspranid*—spraynyd
 bitternesses—beternesses
 1104 *hym*—hem
 it—hyt
 be—ben
 1105 *gop*—MS. geþe
 wol—woole
 sen—MS. sene
 1107 *dwellip*—dureth
 1109 *folkes*—folke
 1110 *oute*—owt
 1112 *shortly*—shortely
 1114 *wilt*—MS. wilte, C. wolt
 if—yif
 1117 *by-nyme*—be-neme
 1118 *blisfulnesse* [*ne*]—blyssefulnesse ne
 1120 *to gidir*—to gidere
 1121, 1122 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
 1125 *wele*—wel
 1126 *receyue*—resseyuen
 1129 [*it*]—from C.
 it—hyt
 1130 *be*—ben
 1131 *blyndenesse*—blyndnesse
 1134 *it*—hyt
 seip—MS. seiþe, C. seyth
 1135 *wot*—MS. wote, C. wot
 leese (2)—leese it
 whiche—which
 1136 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1137 *ellys*—omitted
 wene—weneth
 1138 *hit*—omitted
 1139 *goode*—good
 born—MS. borne, C. born
 hert[*e*]—herte
 1140 *seyne*—seyn
 don—MS. done, C. do

force—fors
 1142 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 1143 *many[e]*—*manye*
 1144 *mowen*—*mowe*
 dien—*deyen*
 1145 *clere*—*cleer*
 certeyne—*certeyn*
 1147 *al*—*alle*
 1150 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 fruit—*frut*
 1152 *myzt[e]*—*myhte*
 1153 *make*—*maken*
 self[e]—*selue*

THESE HAVE NO INTRINSIC VALUE.

[QUISQUIS UOLET](#) ² [PERHENNEM CAUTUS.](#)

[The ferthe metur.]

² MS. *ualet*.

What maner man stable *and* war þat wil founden
 hym

He who would have a
 stable and lasting seat
 must not build upon lofty
 hills; nor upon the sands,
 if he would escape the
 violence of winds and
 waves.

a *perdurable* sete *and* ne wil not be cast doune 1156
 wiþ þe loude blastes of þe wynde Eurus. *and* wil
 dispise

þe see manassyng wiþ floodes ¶ Lat hym eschewe to
 bilde on þe cop of þe mountayngne. or in þe moyste
 sandes. ¶ For þe fel[le] wynde auster *tourmenteb* þe cop 1160

If thou wilt flee perilous
 fortune, lay thy
 foundation upon the
 firmer stone, so that thou
 mayst grow old in thy
 stronghold.

of þe mountayngne wiþ alle his strengþes. ¶ *and* þe
 lowe see sandes refuse to beren þe heuy wey3te. *and*
 forþi yif þou wolt flee þe *perilous* auenture þat is to
 seine of þe worlde ¶ Haue mynde certeynly to ficchyn
 1164

þi house of a myrie site in a lowe stoone. ¶ For al
 þou3 þe wynde troubling þe see þondre wiþ ouereþrowynges
 ¶ Þou þat art put *in* quiete *and* welful by

strengþe of þi palys shalt leden a cleer age. scornynge 1168
þe wodenesses and þe Ires of þe eir.

1155, 1156, 1157 *wil*—wole

1156 *be cast*—MS. be caste, C. ben cast

1157 *wynde*—wynd

1158 *eschewe*—eschewen

1160 *fel[le]*—felle

1161 *his*—hise

1162 *lowe*—lavse

see—omitted

refuse—refusen

wey3te—wyhte

1163 *flee*—fleen

1164 *seine*—seyn

1165 *þi*—thin

lowe stoone—lowh stoon

1167 *welful*—weleful

1169 *wodenesses*—woodnesses

ORY NOT IN RICHES; THEY ADD NOTHING TO VIRTUE.

SET CUM RACIONUM IAM IN TE.

[The fyfthe prose.]

But for as moche as þe norryssinges of my resouns
descenden now in to þe. I trowe it were tyme to
vsen a litel strenger medicynes. ¶ Now vndirstonde

1172

here al were it so þat þe 3iftis of fortune nar[e] nat
brutel ne transitorie. what is þer in hem þat may be
þine *in any tyme. or ellis þat it nys foule if þat it be
considered *and* lokid perfitely. ¶ Richesse ben þei 1176

precious by þe nature of hem self. or ellys by þe
nature of þe. What is most worþi of rycchesse. is it
nat golde or my3t of moneye assembled. ¶ Certis
þilke golde *and* þilke moneye shineþ *and* 3eueþ better 1180

It is now time to use
stronger medicines, since
lighter remedies have
taken effect.

What is there in the gifts
of Fortune that is not vile
and despicable?

[* fol. 12.]

Are riches precious in
themselves, or in men's
estimation?

What is most precious in
them, quantity or
quality?

renoun to hem þat dispenden it. þen to þilke folke þat
mokeren it. For auarice makeþ alwey mokeres to be
hated. *and* largesse makeþ folke clere of renoun

¶ For syn þat swiche þing as is transfered from o 1184
man to an oþer ne may nat dwellen wiþ no man.

Certis þan is þilke moneye precious. whan it is
translated

in to oþer folk. *and* stynted to ben had by

vsage of large ȝeuynge of hym þat haþ ȝeuen it. *and* 1188

also yif al þe moneye þat is ouer-al in þe world were
gadered towar[d] o man. it sholde maken al oþer men

to ben nedý as of þat. ¶ And certys a voys al hool

þat is to seyn wiþ-oute amenusynge fulfilled to gyder 1192

þe herynge of myche folke. but Certys ȝoure rycchesse
ne mowen nat passen vnto myche folk wiþ-oute

amenussynge

¶ And whan þei ben apassed. nedys þei maken

hem pore þat forgon þe rycchesses. ¶ O streite *and* 1196

nedý clepe I þise rycchesses. syn þat many folke [ne]

may nat han it al. ne al may it nat comen to on man

wiþ-oute pouerte of al oþer folke. ¶ And þe shynynge

of gemmes þat I clepe precious stones. draweþ it nat

1200

þe eyen of folk in to hem warde. þat is to seyne for þe

beaute. ¶ For certys yif þer were beaute or bounte

in shynynge of stones. þilke clerenesse is of þe stones

hem self. *and* nat of men. ¶ For whiche I wondre 1204

gretly þat men merueilen on swiche þinges. ¶ For

whi what þing is it þat yif it wanteþ moeuynge *and*

ioynture of soule *and* body þat by ryȝt myȝt[e] semen

Bounty is more glorious
than niggardliness.

Avarice is always
hateful, while liberality
is praise-worthy.

Money cannot be more
precious than when it is
dispensed liberally to
others.

If one man's coffers
contained all the money
in the world, every one
else would be in want of
it.

Riches cannot be
dispensed without
diminution.

O the poverty of riches,
that cannot be enjoyed
by many at the same
time, nor can be
possessed by one
without impoverishing
others!

The beauty of precious
stones consists only in
their brightness,
wherefore I marvel that
men admire that which is
motionless, lifeless, and
irrational.

a faire creature to hym þat haþ a soule of resoun. 1208

¶ For al be it so þat gemmes drawn to hem self a litel of þe laste beaute of þe worlde. þoruþ þe entent of hir creatour *and* þoruþ þe distinccioun of hem self. 3it for as myche as þei ben put vnder 3oure excellence.

1212

þei han not desserued by no weye þat 3e shullen merueylen on hem. ¶ And þe beaute of feeldes deliteþ it nat mychel vnto 3ow. *Boyce*. ¶ Whi sholde it nat deliten vs. syn þat it is a ryzt fayr porcioun of þe ryzt

1216

fair werk. þat is to seyn of þis worlde. ¶ And ryzt so ben we gladed somtyme of þe face of þe see whan it is clere. And also merueylen we on þe heuene *and* on þe sterres. *and* on þe sonne. *and* on þe mone. 1220 *Philosophie*. ¶ Apperteineþ quod she any of þilke þinges to þe. whi darst þou glorifie þe in þe shynyng of any swiche þinges. Art þou distingwed *and* embelised

by þe spryngyng floures of þe first somer 1224 sesoun. or swellip þi plente in fruytes of somer. whi art þou rauyshed wip ydel ioies. why embracest þou straunge goodes as þei weren þine. Fortune shal neuer maken þat swiche þinges ben þine þat nature of þinges

1228

maked foreyne fro þe. ¶ Syche is þat wip-uten doute þe fruytes of þe erþe owen to ben on þe norssinge of bestes. ¶ And if þou wilt fulfille þi nede after þat it suffiseþ to nature þan is it no nede 1232 þat þou seke after þe superfluite of fortune. ¶ For

Precious stones are indeed the workmanship of the Creator, but their beauty is infinitely below the excellency of man's nature.

Doth the beauty of the field delight thee?

B. Why should it not? for it is a beautiful part of a beautiful whole.

Hence, we admire the face of the sea, the heavens, as well as the sun, moon, and stars.

P. Do these things concern thee? darest thou glory in them? Do the flowers adorn you with their variety?

Why embracest thou things wherein thou hast no property?

Fortune can never make that thine which the nature of things forbids to be so.

The fruits of the earth are designed for the support of beasts.

If you seek only the necessities of nature, the affluence of Fortune will be useless.

wiþ ful fewe þinges *and with* ful lytel þing nature
halt hire appaied. *and* yif þou wilt achoken þe
fulfylling

of nature wiþ superfluites ¶ Certys þilke 1236
þinges þat þou wilt þresten or pouren in to nature
shullen ben vnioyeful to þe or ellis anoies. ¶ Wenest
þou eke þat it be a fair þinge to shine wiþ dyuerse
cloþing. of whiche cloþing yif þe Beaute be agreable
1240

to loken vpon. I wol merueylen on þe nature of þe
matere of þilke cloþes. or ellys on þe werkeman þat
wrouȝt[e] hem. but al so a longe route of meyne.
makip

þat a blisful *man. þe whiche seruauntes yif þei ben 1244
vicioũs of condiciouns it is a greet charge *and* a
destruccioun to þe house. *and* a greet enmye to þe
lorde

hym self ¶ *And* yif þei ben goode men how shal
straung[e] or foreyne goodenes ben put in þe noumbre
1248

of þi rycchesse. so þat by alle þise forseide þinges. it is
clerly shewed þat neuer none of þilke þinges þat þou
accoumptedest for þin goodes nas nat þi goode. ¶ In
þe whiche þinges yif þer be no Beaute to ben desired.
1252

THESE BRING ANXIETIES.

whi sholdest þou be sory yif þou leese hem. or whi
sholdest þou reioysen þe to holden hem. ¶ For if þei
ben fair of hire owen kynde. what apperteneþ þat to

Nature is content with a little, and superfluity will be both disagreeable and hurtful.

Does it add to a man's worth to shine in variety of costly clothing?

The things really to be admired are the beauty of the stuff or the workmanship of it.

Doth a great retinue make thee happy?

[* fol. 12 b.]

If thy servants be vicious, they are a great burden to the house, and pernicious enemies to the master of it.

If they be good, why should the probity of others be put to thy account?

Upon the whole, then, none of those enjoyments which thou didst consider as thy own did ever properly belong to thee.
If they be not desirable,

why shouldst thou grieve for the loss of them?

If they are fair by nature, what is that to thee?

þe.

for as wel sholde þei han ben faire by hem self. 1256

þouȝ þei weren departid from alle þin rycchesse. ¶

For-why

faire ne precioũs ne weren þei nat. for þat þei
comen amonges þi rycchesse. but for þei semeden fair
and precious. þerfore þou haddest leuer rekene hem

1260

amonges þi rycchesse. but what desirest þou of fortune
wiþ so greet a noyse *and* wiþ so greet a fare

¶ I trowe þou seke to dryue away nede wiþ
habundaunce

of þinges. ¶ But certys it turneþ to ȝow al in þe 1264
contrarie. for whi certys it nedip of ful many[e]
helpynges

to kepen þe dyuersite of preciouſe ostelmentȝ.

and soþe it is þat of many[e] þinges han þei nede þat
many[e] þinges han. *and* aȝeyneward of litel nedip 1268
hem þat mesuren hir fille after þe nede of kynde *and*
nat after þe outrage of couetyse ¶ Is it þan so þat ye
men ne han no propre goode. I-set in ȝow. For
whiche ȝe moten seken outwardes ȝoure goodes in 1272
foreine *and* subgit þinges. ¶ So is þan þe condicioun
of þinges turned vpso down. þat a man þat is a devyne
beest by merit of hys resoun. þinkeþ þat hym
self nys neyþer fair ne noble. but if it be þoruȝ 1276
possessioun of ostelmentes. þat ne han no soules.

They would be equally agreeable whether thine or not.

They are not to be reckoned precious because they are counted amongst thy goods, but because they seemed so before thou didst desire to possess them.

What, then, is it we so clamorously demand of Fortune?

Is it to drive away indigence by abundance?

But the very reverse of this happens, for there is need of many helps to keep a variety of valuable goods.

They want most things who have the most.

They want the fewest who measure their abundance by the necessities of nature, and not by the superfluity of their desires.

Is there no good planted within ourselves, that we are obliged to go abroad to seek it?

Are things so changed and inverted, that god-like man should think that he has no other worth but what he derives from the possession of inanimate objects?

IGNORANCE CRIMINAL IN MAN.

¶ And certys al oþer þinges ben appaied of hire owen
beautes. but 3e men þat ben semblable to god by 3oure
resonable þouzt desiren to apparaille 3oure excellent

1280

kynde of þe lowest[e] pinges. ne 3e ne vndirstonde nat
how gret a wrong 3e don to 3oure creatour. for he
wolde þat man kynde were moost worþi *and* noble of
any oþer erþely pinges. and 3e þresten adoun 3oure 1284
dignitees by-neþen þe lowest[e] pinges. ¶ For if þat al
þe good of euery þing be more *precious* þan is þilk
þing whos þat þe good is. syn 3e demen þat þe
foulest[e] pinges ben 3oure goodes. þanne summytten

1288

3e *and* putten 3oure self vndir þo foulest[e] pinges by
3oure estimacioun. ¶ And certis þis bitidiþ nat wiþ
out 3oure desert. For certys swiche is þe *condicioun*
of al man kynde þat oonly whan it haþ knowyng of it

1292

self. þan passeþ it in noblesse alle oþer pinges. and
whan it forletip þe knowyng of it self. þan it is
brouzt byneþen alle beestes. ¶ For-why alle oþer
[leuyng] beestes han of kynde to knowe not hem 1296
self. but whan þat men leten þe knowyng of hem self.
it comeþ hem of vice. but how brode sheweþ þe *errour*
and þe folie of 3ow men þat wenen þat ony þing may
ben apparailled wiþ straunge apparaillementz ¶ but 1300
for-soþe þat may nat be don. for yif a wyzt shyneþ wiþ
þinges þat ben put to hym. as þus. yif þilke pinges
shynen wiþ whiche a man is apparailled. ¶ Certis
þilke pinges ben commendid *and* preised wiþ whiche

Inferior things are
satisfied with their own
endowments, while man
(the image of God) seeks
to adorn his nature with
things infinitely below
him, not understanding
how much he dishonours
his Maker.

God intended man to
excel all earthly
creatures, yet you debase
your dignity and
prerogative below the
lowest beings.
In placing your
happiness in despicable
trifles, you acknowledge
yourselves of less value
than these trifles, and
well do you merit to be
so esteemed.

Man only excels other
creatures when he knows
himself.

When he ceases to do so,
he sinks below beasts.

Ignorance is natural to
beasts, but in men it is
unnatural and criminal.

How weak an error is it
to believe that anything
foreign to your nature
can be an ornament to it.

If a thing appear
beautiful on account of
its external
embellishments, we
admire and praise those
embellishments alone.

he is apparailled. ¶ But napeles þe þing þat is
couered *and* wrapped vndir þat dwelleþ in his filþe.

and I denye þat þilke þing be good þat anoyeþ hym
þat haþ it. ¶ Gabbe I of þis. þou wolt seye nay. 1308

¶ Certys rycchesse han anoyed ful ofte hem þat han þe
rycchesse. ¶ Syn þat euery wicked shrew *and* for
hys wickednesse þe more gredy aftir oþer folkes
rycchesse

wher so euer it be in any place. be it golde or 1312
precious stones. *and* wenip hym *only most worþi þat
haþ hem ¶ þou þan þat so besy dredest now þe swerde
and þe spere. yif þou haddest entred in þe pape of þis
lijf a voide wayfaryng man. þan woldest þou syng[e]

1316

by-fore þe þeef. ¶ As who seiþ a poure man þat bereþ
no rycchesse on hym by þe weye. may boldly syng[e]
byforne þeues. for he haþ nat wher-of to ben robbed.

¶ O precieuse *and* ryzt clere is þe blysfulnesse of 1320
mortal rycchesse. þat whan þou hast geten it. þan hast
þou lorn þi syke[r]nesse.

1172 *strenger*—strengere
vndirstonde—vndyrstond

1173 *nar[e]*—ne weere

1174 *be þine*—ben thyn

1175 *foule*—fowl

1176 *Richesse*—Rychessis

1178 *rycchesse*—rychesses

1179, 1180 *golde*—gold

1180 *better*—betere

1181 *þen*—thanne

1182 *mokeres*—mokereres

The thing covered still
continues in its natural
impurity.

I deny that to be a good
which is hurtful to its
owner.

Am I deceived in this?
You will say no; for
riches have often hurt
their possessors.
Every wicked man
desires another's wealth,
and esteems him alone
happy who is in
possession of riches.

[* fol. 13.]

You, therefore, who now
so much dread the
instruments of
assassination, if you had
been born a poor
wayfaring man, might,
with an empty purse,
have sung in the face of
robbers.

O the transcendant
felicity of riches! No
sooner have you
obtained them, than you
cease to be secure.

1183 *folke clere*—folk cler
 1184 *swiche*—swich
 from—fram
 1187 *styntep*—stenteth
 1188 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1189 *world*—worlde
 1190 *al*—alle
 1191 *al hool*—omitted
 1193 *myche folke*—moche folke
 rycchesse—rychesses
 1194 *myche*—moche
 1196 *forgon*—MS. forgone
 1197 *pise*—this
 rycchesses—rychesse
 [*ne*]—from C.
 1198 *on*—o
 1199 *wip-oute*—with-owten
 al—alle
 folke—folke
 1200 *precious*—presyous
 1201 *in*—omitted
 warde—ward
 seyne—seyn
 1202 *beaute* (1)—beautes
 For—but
 1203 *in*—in the
 1204 *whiche*—which
 1207 *ioynture*—Ioyngture
 1208 *faire*—fayr
 hap—MS. haþe
 1210 *laste*—last
 worlde—world
 1212 *myche*—mochel
 1213 *desserued*—MS. desseyued, C. desseruyd
 weye—wey
 shullen—sholden
 1215 *mychel*—mochel
 1217 *fair werk*—fayre werke
 worlde—world
 1219 *clere*—cler
 1222 *darst þou glorifie*—darsthow gloryfyen
 1225 *in*—in the

1229 *Syche*—Soth
 1230 *on*—to
 1231, 1235, 1237 *wilt*—wolt
 1238 *shullen*—shollen
 1239 *fair*—fayre
 1240 *whiche*—which
 1242 *werkeman*—werkman
 1246 *house*—hows
 lorde—lord
 1248 *goodenes*—goodnesse
 1250 *shewed*—I-shewyd
 none—oon
 1251 *pin*—thine
 goode—good
 1255 *fair*—fayre
 hire owen—hyr owne
 1256 *sholde*—sholden
 self—selue
 1257 *pin rycchesse*—thyne rychesses
 1259 *amonges*—amonge
 1259, 1261 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 1259 *fair*—fayre
 1260 *leuer rekene*—leuere rekne
 1262 *greet* (2)—grete
 1265, 1267 *many[e]*—manye
 1267 *sope*—soth
 1272 *outwardes*—owtward
 1276 *fair*—fayre
 if—yif
 1278 *hire owen*—hir owne
 1281 *ne* (2)—omitted
 vndirstonde—vndyrstondyn
 1282 *gret*—MS. grete, C. gret
 1284 *oper erpely*—oothre worldly
 presten—threste
 1285 *by-nepen*—by-nethe
 if—yif
 1286 *good*—MS. goode, C. good
 ping—thinge
 preciousse—presyos
 pilk ping—thilke thinge

1287 *þe* (2)—tho
 1288 *summytten*—submitten
 1289 *self*—seluen
 foulest[e]—fowleste
 1290 *bitidiþ*—tydeth
 1291 *out*—owte
 desert—desertes
 1292 *al*—alle
 1293 *self*—selue
 1294 *it is*—is it
 1296 [*leuyng*]*e*—from C.
 hem—hym
 1297 *þat*—omitted
 1298 *comeþ*—comth
 1299 *þing*—thinge
 1302 *put*—MS. putte, C. put
 1303 *whiche*—which
 1306 *filþe*—felthe
 1307 *þing*—thinge
 good—MS. goode, C. good
 1308 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1309 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 þe—tho
 1310 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 shrew—shrewe
 1311 *rycchesse*—rychesses
 1312 *golde*—gold
 1314 *hap*—MS. haþe, C. hat
 besy—bysy
 swerde—sward
 1315 *pape*—paath
 1316 *wayfaryng*—wayferynge
 syng[e]—synge
 1317 *by-fore*—by-forn
 seip—MS. seiþe, C. seyth
 poure—pore
 bereþ—berth
 1318 *boldly syng[e]*—boldely synge
 1319 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1320 *preciouse*—precyos
 clere—cler
 1321 *rycchesse*—rychesses

E GOLDEN AGE.

[FELIX IN MIRUM PRIOR ETAS.](#)

Blysful was þe first age of men. þei helden hem
apaied wiþ þe metes þat þe trewe erþes brouzten

1324

furþe. ¶ þei ne destroyed[e] ne desceyued[e] not hem
self wiþ outerage. ¶ þei weren wont lyztly to slaken
her hunger at euene wiþ acornes of okes ¶ þei ne
couþe nat medle þe ȝift of bacus to þe clere hony. 1328
þat is to seyn. þei couþe make no piment of clarre.
ne þei couþe nat medle þe briȝt[e] flies of þe contre
of siriens wiþ þe venym of tirie. þis is to seyne. þei
couþe nat dien white flies of sirien contre wiþ þe 1332
blode of a manar shelfyssh. þat men fynden in tyrie.
wiþ whiche blode men deien purper. ¶ þei slepen
holesom slepes vpon þe gras. and dronken of þe
rynnyng

watres. *and* laien vndir þe shadowe of þe heyȝe 1336
pyne trees. ¶ Ne no gest ne no straunger [ne] karf
ȝit þe heyȝe see wiþ oores or wiþ shippes. ne þei ne
hadden seyne ȝitte none newe strondes to leden
merchaundyse

in to dyuerse contres. ¶ þo weren þe cruel 1340
clariouns ful whist *and* ful stille. ne blode yshed by
egre hate ne hadde nat deied ȝit armurers. for wherto
or whiche woodenesse of enmys wolde first moeuen
armes. whan þei seien cruel woundes ne none medes

1344

[The fyfthe metur.]

Happy was the first age
of men. They were
contented with what the
faithful earth produced.

With acorns they
satisfied their hunger.

They knew not Hypocras
nor Hydromel.

They did not dye the
Serian fleece in Tyrian
purple.

They slept upon the
grass, and drank of the
running stream, and
reclined under the
shadow of the tall pine.

No man yet ploughed the
deep, nor did the
merchant traffick with
foreign shores.

The warlike trumpet was
hushed and still.

Bloodshed had not yet
arisen through hateful
quarrels.
Nothing could stimulate
their rage to engage in
war, when they saw that

ben of blood yshad ¶ I wolde þat oure tymes sholde
 turne azeine to þe oolde maneres. ¶ But þe anguissous
 loue of hauyng brenneþ in folke moore cruely þan þe
 fijr of þe Mountaigne of Ethna þat euer brenneþ. 1348
 ¶ Allas what was he þat first dalf vp þe gobets or
 þe wey3tys of gold couered vndir erpe. *and* þe precious
 stones þat wolden han ben hid. he dalf vp precious
 perils. þat is to seyne þat he þat hem first vp dalf. he 1352
 dalf vp a precious peril. for-ghi. for þe preciousnesse
 of swyche hap many man ben in peril.

wounds and scars were
 the only meeds.
 O that those days would
 come again!
 The thirst of wealth
 torments all; it rages
 more fiercely than
 Ætna's fires.
 Cursed be the wretch
 who first brought gold to
 light.

It has since proved
 perilous to many a man.

1324 *erþes*—feeldes

1325 *furþe*—forth

destroyed[e]—dystroyede

1327 *her*—hyr

at—MS. as, C. at

euene—euen

1328 *couþe*—cowde

medle—medly

3ift—yifte

clere—cleer

1329 *couþe*—cowde

of—nor

1330 *couþe*—cowde

brizt[e] *flies*—bryhte flee3es

1331 *siriens*—Seryens

seyne—seyn

1332 *couþe*—cowde

dien—deyen

flies—fle3es

1333 *blode*—blood

shelfyssh—shyllefyssh

1334 *blode*—blood

1335 *holesom*—holsom

rynnyng watres—rennynge wateres

shadowe—shadwes

hey3e—heye

1337 *pyne*—pyn

no (2)—omitted

[*ne*]*—*from C.
*karf**—*karue
 1339 *hadden seyne zitte**—*hadde seyn yit
 1341 *whist**—*hust
*blode yshed**—*blod I-shad
 1343 *whiche woodenesse**—*whych wodnesse
 1344 *seien**—*say
 1346 *turne azeyne**—*torne ayein
 1347 *folke**—*folk
 1348 *þe**—*omitted
*euer**—*ay
 1351 *hid**—*MS. hidde, C. hydd
 1352 *seyne**—*seyn
he (2)*—*omitted
 1354 *swyche**—*swych thinge
*hap**—*MS. haþe
*ben**—*be

DIGNITIES AND POWERS.

QUID AUTEM DE DIGNITATIBUS ET CETERA.

But what shal I seyne of dignitees *and* of powers.
 þe whiche [ye] men þat neiþer knowen verray
 dignitee 1356
 ne verray power areysen hem as heye as þe
 heuene. þe whiche dignitees *and* powers yif þei come
 to any wicked man þei don [as] greet[e] damages *and*
 destruccion as doþ þe flamme of þe Mountaigne 1360
 Ethna whan þe flamme wit walwiþ vp ne no deluge
 ne doþ so cruel harmes. ¶ Certys ye remembriþ wel
 as I trowe þat þilke dignitee þat men clepiþ þe emperie
 of consulers þe whiche þat somtyme was bygynnyng
 1364
 of freedom. ¶ 3oure eldres coueiteden to han
 don a-wey þat dignitee for þe pride of þe conseilors.

[The sixte prose.]

But why should I
 discourse of dignities
 and powers which
 (though you are ignorant
 of true honour and real
 power) you extol to the
 skies?

When they fall to the lot
 of a wicked man, they
 produce greater
 calamities than the
 flaming eruption of
 Ætna, or the most
 impetuous deluge.
 You remember that your
 ancestors desired to
 abolish the Consular
 government (the
 commencement of the
 Roman liberty), because
 of the pride of the
 Consuls; as their
 ancestors before for the

same consideration had suppressed the title of King.

NOURS NOT INTRINSICALLY GOOD,

¶ And ryzt for þe same pride 3oure eldres byforne þat tyme hadden don away out of þe Citee of rome þe 1368 kynges name. þat is to seien. þei nolden haue no lenger no kyng ¶ But now yif so be þat dignitees *and* powers ben 3euen to goode men. þe whiche þing is ful 3elde. what agreable þinges is þer in þo dignitees. 1372 or powers. but only þe goodenes of folk þat vsen hem.

R THEY FALL TO THE LOT OF THE WICKED.

¶ And þerfore it is þus þat honour ne comeþ nat to vertue for cause of dignite. but a3einward. honour comeþ to dignite by cause of vertue. but whiche is 1376 3oure derworþe power þat is so clere *and* so requerable ¶ O 3e erþelyche bestes considere 3e nat ouer whiche þing þat it semeþ þat 3e han power. ¶ Now yif þou say[e] a mouse amongus *oper myse þat chalenged[e] to 1380

hymself ward ryzt *and* power ouer alle oper myse. how gret scorne woldest þou han of hit. ¶ *Glosa.* ¶ So fareþ it by men. þe body haþ power ouer þe body. For yif þow loke wel vpon þe body of a wyzt what 1384 þing shalt þou fynde moore frele þan is mannes kynde. þe whiche ben ful ofte slayn wiþ bytyng of smale flies. or ellys wiþ þe entryng of crepyng wormes in to þe priuetees of mennes bodyes. ¶ But wher shal 1388 men fynden any man þat may exercen or haunten any ryzt vpon an oper man but oonly vpon hys body. or

Virtue is not embellished by dignities, but dignities derive honour from virtue.

But what is this power, so much celebrated and desired? What are they over whom you exercise authority? If thou sawest a mouse assuming command over other mice, wouldst thou not almost burst with laughter?

[* fol. 13 b.]

What is more feeble than man, to whom the bite of a fly may be the cause of death?

But how can any man obtain dominion over another, unless it be over his body, or, what is inferior to his body,—

ellys vpon þinges þat ben lower þen þe body. whiche
I clepe fortunous possessiouns ¶ Mayst þou euer haue

1392

any comaundement ouer a fre corage ¶ Mayst þou
remuen fro þe estat of hys propre reste. a þouzt þat is
cleuyng to gider in hym self by stedfast resoun. ¶ As
somtyme a tiraunt wende to confounde a freeman of

1396

corage ¶ *And* wende to constreyne hym by tourment
to maken hym dyscoueren *and* acusen folk þat wisten
of a coniuracioun. whiche I clepe a confederacie þat
was cast azeins þis tyraunt ¶ But þis free man boot 1400

of hys owen tunge. *and* cast it in þe visage of þilke
woode tyraunte. ¶ So þat þe tourmentz þat þis
tyraunt wende to han maked matere of cruelte. þis
wyse man maked[e it] matere of vertues. ¶ But what

1404

þing is it þat a man may don to an oper man. þat he
ne may receyue þe same þing of oper folke in hym
self. or þus. ¶ What may a man don to folk. þat folk
ne may don hym þe same. ¶ I haue herd told of 1408
busirides þat was wont to sleen hys gestes þat
herburghden

in hys hous. and he was slayn hym self of
ercules þat was hys gest ¶ Regulus had[de] taken in
bataile many men of affrike. and cast hem in to
fetteres. 1412

but sone after he most[e] 3iue hys handes to
ben bounden *with* þe cheynes of hem þat he had[de]
somtyme ouercomen. ¶ Wenest þou þan þat he be

over his possessions, the
gifts of Fortune?

Can you ever command
a freeborn soul?

Can you disturb a soul
consistent with itself,
and knit together by the
bond of reason?

Have you not read how
Anaxarchus bit off his
tongue and spat it in the
face of Nicocreon?

What is it that one man
can do to another that
does not admit of
retaliation?

Busiris used to kill his
guests, but at last himself
was killed by Hercules,
his guest.

Regulus put his
Carthaginian prisoners in
chains, but was
afterwards obliged to
submit to the fetters of
his enemies.

Is he mighty that dares
not inflict what he would

myȝty. þat may nat don a þing. þat oþer ne may don

1416

hym. þat he doþ to oþer. *and* ȝit more ouer yif it so
were þat þise dignites or poweres hadden any *propre*
or naturel goodnesse in hem self neuer nolden þei
comen to shrewes. ¶ For contrarious þinges ne ben 1420
not wont to ben yfelawshipped togidres. ¶ Nature
refuseþ

þat contra[r]ious þinges ben yioigned. ¶ And so
as I am in certeyne þat ryȝt wikked folk han dignitees
ofte tymes. þan sheweþ it wel þat dignitees *and* powers

1424

ne ben not goode of hir owen kynde. syn þat þei
suffren

hem self to cleuen or ioynen hem to shrewes.

¶ And certys þe same þing may most digneliche Iugen
and seyen of alle þe ȝiftis of fortune þat most
plenteuously 1428

comen to shrewes. ¶ Of þe whiche ȝiftys I
trowe þat it auȝt[e] ben considered þat no man doutiþ
þat he nis strong. in whom he seeþ strengþe. *and* in
whom þat swiftnesse is ¶ Soþe it is þat he is swyfte. 1432
Also musyk makeþ musiciens. *and* fysik makeþ
phisiciens.

and rethorik rethoriens. ¶ For whi þe nature
of euery þing makith his *propretee*. ne it is nat
entermedled wiþ þe effectis of contrarious þinges. 1436

upon another for fear of
a requital?

If powers and honours
were intrinsically good,
they would never be
attained by the wicked.

An union of things
opposite is repugnant to
nature.

But as wicked men do
obtain the highest
honours, it is clear that
honours are not in
themselves good,
otherwise they would not
fall to the share of the
unworthy.

The worst of men have
often the largest share of
Fortune's gifts.

We judge him to be
valiant who has given
evidence of his fortitude.

So music maketh a
musician, &c.

The nature of everything
consists in doing what is
peculiar to itself, and it
repels what is contrary to
it.

WER DOES NOT CONFER GOODNESS.

¶ And as of wil it chaseþ oute þinges þat to it ben
contrarie ¶ But certys rycchesse may nat restreyne
auarice vnstaunched ¶ Ne power [ne] makeþ nat a
man myȝty ouer hym self. whiche þat vicious lustis

1440

holden destreined wiþ cheins þat ne mowen nat ben
vnbounden. *and* dignitees þat ben ȝeuen to shrewed[e]
folk nat oonly ne makip hem nat digne. but it shewep
raþer al openly þat þei ben vnworþi *and* vndigne. 1444

¶ And whi is it þus. ¶ Certis for ȝe han ioie to
clepen þinges wiþ fals[e] names. þat beren hem al in
þe contrarie. þe whiche names ben ful ofte reproued
by þe effect of þe same þinges. so þat *þise ilke
rycchesse 1448

ne auȝten nat by ryȝt to ben cleped rycchesse.
ne whiche power ne auȝt[e] not ben cleped power. ne
whiche dignitee ne auȝt[e] nat ben cleped dignitee.

¶ And at þe laste I may conclude þe same þinge of 1452
al þe ȝiftes of fortune in whiche þer nis no þing to
ben desired. ne þat hap in hym self naturel bounte.

¶ as it is ful wel sene. for neyþer þei ne ioygne
hem nat alwey to goode men. ne maken hem alwey

1456

goode to whom þei ben y-ioigned.

1355 *seyne*—seye

1358 *come*—comen

1359 *don*—MS. done, C. don

[as] *greet[e]*—as grete

1360 *distruccioun*—destruccion

dop—MS. doþe, C. doth

flamme—flaumbe

Riches cannot restrain
avarice. Power cannot
make a man master of
himself if he is the slave
of his lusts.

Dignities conferred upon
base men do not make
them worthy, but rather
expose their want of
merit.

Why is it so? 'Tis
because you give false
names to things. You
dignify riches, power,
and honours, with names
they have no title to.

[* fol. 14.]

In fine, the same may be
said of all the gifts of
Fortune, in which
nothing is desirable,
nothing of natural good
in them, since they are
not always allotted to
good men, nor make
them good to whom they
are attached.

1361 *flamme*—flawmbe
 wit—omitted
 1362 *dop*—MS. doþe, C. doth
 1363 *clepip*—clepyn
 1364 *whiche*—whych
 somtye—whilom
 1366 *for*—MS. of, C. for
 1368 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 1369 *seien*—seyn
 1370 *lenger*—lengere
 kyng—kyng
 1371 *whiche*—which
 1373 *folk*—foolkys
 1374 *comeþ*—comth
 1375, 1376 *vertue*—vertu
 1376 *comeþ*—comth
 by—for
 whiche—which
 1377 *derworþe*—dereworthe
 clere—cleer
 1378 *whiche*—which
 1379 *han*—MS. hanne, C. han
 1380 *say[e]*—saye
 mouse amongus—mous amonges
 myse—mus3
 1382 *scorne*—scorn
 1383 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1385 *mannes*—man
 1386 *þe*—*slayn*—the *whiche* men wel ofte ben slayn
 1388 *mennes bodyes*—mannes body
 1391 *lower*—lowere
 whiche—the which
 1395 *stedfast*—stidefast
 1396 *somtye*—whylom
 1399 *whiche*—which
 1401 *owen*—owne
 1406 *receyue*—resseyuen
 oper—oothre
 1408 *herd told*—MS. herde tolde, C. herd told
 1409 *hys*—hise
 herburghden—herberweden

1410 *slayn*—sleyn
 1411 *had[de]*—hadde
 1413 *most[e]*—moste
 1414 *bounden*—bownde
 cheynes—MS. þeues, C. cheynes
 had[de]—hadde
 1415 *somtyme*—whylom
 1416 *þat*—*þing*—that hath no power to don a thinge
 oper—oothre
 1417 *hym*—in hym
 dop—MS. doþe, C. doth
 to oper—in oothre
 1421 *togidres*—to-gidere
 1423 *certeyne*—certain
 1424 *tymes*—tyme
 1425 *owen*—owne
 1429 *whiche*—which
 1430 *auzt[e]*—owhte
 1432 *Soþe*—soth
 swyfte—swyft
 1435 *is*—nis
 1436 *effectis*—effect
 1437 *oute*—owt
 1441 *ben*—be
 1442 *shrewed[e]*—shrewede
 1446 *fals[e]*—false
 al—alle
 1447 *whiche*—which
 1449 *auzten*—owhten
 rycchesse—rychesses
 1450 *whiche*—swich
 auzt[e]—owhte
 1451 *whiche*—swich
 auzt[e]—owht
 1453 *al*—alle
 1454 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1455 *sene*—I-seene

RO'S CRUELTY.

WE han wel knowen how many greet[e] harmes
and

We know what ruin Nero
did.

destruccionns weren doñ by þe Emperoure Nero.

¶ He letee brenne þe citee of Rome *and* made slen þe

He burnt Rome, he slew
the conscript fathers,
murdered his brother,
and spilt his mother's
blood.

1460

senatours. and he cruel somtyme slou3 hys broþer. *and*
he was maked moyst wiþ þe blood of hys modir. þat is
to seyn he let sleen *and* slitten þe body of his modir to
seen where he was conceiued. *and* he loked[e] on
euery 1464

He looked unmoved
upon his mother's
corpse, and passed
judgment upon her
beauty.

half vpon hir colde dede body. ne no tere ne wette
his face. but he was so hard herted þat he my3t[e] ben
domesman or Iuge of hire dede beaute. ¶ And 3itte
neuerþeles gouerned[e] þis Nero by Ceptre al þe
peoples 1468

Yet this parricide ruled
over all lands, illumined
by the sun in his diurnal
course, and controlled
the frozen regions of the
pole.

þat phebus þe sonne may seen comyng from his
outerest

arysyng til he hidde his bemes vndir þe wawes. ¶ þat
is to seyne. he gouerned[e] alle þe peoples by Ceptre imperial

þat þe sonne goþ aboute from est to west ¶ And 1472

eke þis Nero goueyrende by Ceptre. alle þe peoples þat
ben vndir þe colde sterres þat hy3ten þe seuene triones.

þis is to seyn he gouerned[e] alle þe poeples þat ben vndir
þe parties of þe norþe. ¶ And eke Nero gouerned[e]

He governed, too, the
people in the torrid zone.

1476

alle þe poeples þat þe violent wynde Nothus scorchiþ
and bakip þe brennyng sandes by his drie hete. þat
is to seyne. alle þe poeples in þe souþe. [but yit ne
myhte nat al his heye power torne the woodnesse of

But yet Nero's power
could not tame his
ferocious mind.

1480

this wykkyd nero / Allas it is greuous fortune it is]. as
ofte as wicked swerde is ioyned to cruel venym. þat is
to sein. venimous cruelte to lordshipe.

It is a grievous thing
when power strengthens
the arm of him whose
will prompts him to
deeds of cruelty.

1458 *greet*[e]—grete

1460 *letee*—let

1461 *somtyme slouȝ*—whilom slow

1463 *let*—lette

1464 *where*—wher

1465 *half*—halue

1466 *myȝt*[e]—myhte

1467 *hire*—hyr

1468 *neuerþeles*—natheles

gouerned[e]—gouernede

al—alle

1469 *from*—fram

outerest—owtereste

1470 *hidde*—hide

1471 *seyne*—seyn

1472 *goþ*—MS. goþe, C. goth

1473 *goueyrende*—gouernyd

1474 *triones*—tyryones

1475 *gouerned*[e]—gouernede

1476 *parties*—party

norþe—north

gouerned[e]—gouernede

1477 *wynde*—wynd

scorchip—scorklith

1479 *seyne*—seyn

souþe—sowth

1479-81 [*but*—*it is*]*—MS. has: but ne how greuous fortune is*

1482 *swerde*—swerd

E LOVE OF GLORY.

[TUM EGO SCIS INQUAM.](#)

[The seuende prose.]

P Anne seide I þus. þou wost wel þiself þat þe 1484
couetise of mortal þinges ne hadden neuer

lordshipe

of me. but I haue wel desired matere of þinges
to done. as who seiþ. I desired[e] to han matere of
gouernaunce ouer comunalites. ¶ For vertue stille ne
1488

sholde not elden. þat is to seyn. þat list þat or he wex
olde ¶ His uertue þat lay now ful stille. ne sholde
nat perisshe vnexcercised in gouernaunce of comune.

¶ For whiche men myȝten speke or writen of his 1492
goode gouernement. ¶ *Philosophie*. ¶ For soþe *quod*
she. *and* þat is a þing þat may drawen to gouernaunce
swiche hertes as ben worþi *and* noble of hir nature.
but napeles it may nat drawen or tollen swiche hertes

as 1496

ben y-brouȝt to þe ful[le] perfeccioun of vertue. þat is
to seyn couetyse of glorie *and* renoun to han wel
administred þe comune þinges. or doon goode decertes
to profit of þe comune. for se now *and* considere how
1500

litel *and* how voide of al prise is þilke glorie. ¶
Certeine

þing is as þou hast lerned by demonstracioun of
astronomye þat al þe envyrnyng of þe erþe aboute
ne halt but þe resoun of a prykke at regard of þe
gretnesse 1504

of heuene. þat is to seye. þat yif þat þer were
maked *comparisoun* of þe erþe to þe gretnesse of
heuene. men wolde Iugen in alle þat erþe [ne] helde

B. Thou knowest that I
did not covet mortal and
transitory things.

I only wished to exercise
my virtue in public
concerns, lest it should
grow feeble by
inactivity.

P. A love of glory is one
of those things that may
captivate minds naturally
great, but not yet arrived
at the perfection of
virtue.

But consider how small
and void of weight is
that glory.

Astronomy teaches us
that this globe of earth is
but a speck compared
with the extent of the
heavens, and is as
nothing if compared with
the magnitude of the
celestial sphere.

no space ¶ Of þe whiche litel regioun of þis worlde

1508

þe ferþe partie is enhabitid wiþ lyuyng beestes þat we knowen. as þou hast þi self lerned by tholome þat prouith it. ¶ yif þou haddest wiþ drawen *and* abated in þi þouȝte fro þilke ferþe partie as myche space as þe

1512

see *and* [the] mareys contenen *and* ouergon *and* as myche space as þe regioun of drouhte ouerstreccheþ.

Ptolemy shows that only one-fourth of this earth is inhabited by living creatures.

Deduct from this the space occupied by seas, marshes, lakes, and deserts, and there remains but a small proportion left for the abode of man.

ME IS CIRCUMSCRIBED.

þat is to seye sandes *and* desertes wel vnneþ sholde *þer dwellen a ryȝt streite place to þe habitacioun of 1516

[* fol. 14 b.]

men. *and* ȝe þan þat ben environed *and* closed wiþ inne þe leest[e] prikke of þilk prikke þenke ȝe to manifesten ȝoure renoun *and* don ȝoure name to ben born forþe. but ȝoure glorie þat is so narwe *and* so 1520 streyt yþrongen in to so litel boundes. how myche conteinþe it in largesse *and* in greet doynge. And also sette þis þer to þat many a nacioun dyuerse of tonge *and* of maneres. *and* eke of resoun of hir lyuyng ben

1524

enhabitid in þe cloos of þilke litel habitacle. ¶ To þe whiche naciouns what for difficulte of weyes. *and* what

And do you, who are confined to the least point of this point, think of nothing but of blazing far and wide your name and reputation?

What is there great in a glory so circumscribed?

Even in this contracted circle, there is a great variety of nations, to whom not only the fame of particular men, but even of great cities, cannot extend.

for diuersite of langages. *and* what for defaute of vnusage entercomunynge of marchaundise. nat only þe 1528 names of singler men ne may [nat] strecchen. but eke þe fame of Citees ne may nat strecchen. ¶ At þe last[e] Certis in þe tyme of Marcus tulyus as hym

In the time of Marcus Tullius the fame of Rome did not reach beyond Mount Caucasus.

self writeþ in his book þat þe renoun of þe comune of 1532

Rome ne hadde nat zitte passed ne cloumben ouer þe mountaigne þat hyzt Caucasus. *and* zitte was þilk tyme rome wel wexen *and* gretly redouted of þe parthes.

and eke of oþer folk enhabityng aboute. ¶ Sest þou 1536 nat þan how streit *and* how compressed is þilke glorie þat 3e trauailen aboute to shew *and* to multiplie. May þan þe glorie of a singlere Romeyne stretchen þider as þe fame of þe name of Rome may nat clymben ne

1540

passen. ¶ And eke sest þou nat þat þe maners of diuerse folk *and* eke hir lawes ben discordaunt amonge hem self. so þat þilke þing þat sommen iugen worþi of preysynge. oþer folk iugen þat it is worþi of torment.

1544

How narrow, then, is that glory which you labour to propagate.

Shall the glory of a Roman citizen reach those places where the name even of Rome was never heard?

Customs and institutions differ in different countries.

What is praise-worthy in one is blame-worthy in another.

It is not the interest of any man who desires renown to have his name spread through many countries.

ME IS NOT ETERNAL.

¶ and þer of comeþ þat þou3 a man delite hym in preysyng of his renoun. he ne may nat in no wise bryngen furþe ne spreden his name to many manere peoples. ¶ And þerfore euery maner man auzte to ben

1548

paied of hys glorie þat is puplissed among hys owen ney3bores. ¶ And þilke noble renoun shal be restreyned wiþ-inne þe boundes of o maner folk but how

many a man þat was ful noble in his tyme. haþ þe 1552 nedy *and* wrecched for3etyng of writers put oute of

He ought, therefore, to be satisfied with the glory he has acquired at home.

But of how many personages, illustrious in their times, have the memorials been lost through the carelessness and neglect of writers.

mynde *and* don away. ¶ Al be it so þat certys þilke writynges profiten litel. þe whiche writynges longe *and*

derke elde doþ awaye boþe hem *and* eke her autours.
but 1556

þe men semen to geten 3ow a *perdurablete* whan 3e þenke þat in tyme comyng 3oure fame shal lasten. ¶

But

napeles yif þou wilt maken *comparisoun* to þe endeles space of eternite what þing hast þou by whiche þou 1560

maist reioysen þe of long lastyng of þi name. ¶ For if þer were makid *comparysoun* of þe abidyng of a *moment* to ten þousand wynter. for as myche as boþe þo spaces ben endid. ¶ For 3it haþ þe *moment* some 1564

porcioun of hit al þou3 it a litel be. ¶ But napeles þilke self noumbre of 3eres. and eke as many 3eres as þer to may be multiplied. ne may nat certys be *comparisound*

to þe *perdurablete* þat is een[de]les. ¶ For of 1568 þinges þat han ende may be mad *comparisoun* [but of thinges that ben *with-owtyn* ende to thinges þat han ende

may be makid no *comparysoun*]. ¶ And for þi is it al þou3 renoun of as longe tyme as euer þe lyst to þinken
1572

were þou3t by þe regard of eternite. þat is vnstauncheable *and* infinit. it ne sholde nat oonly semen litel. but pleinliche ry3t nou3t. ¶ But 3e men certys ne konne don no þing ary3t. but 3if it be for þe audience of poeple. 1576

But writings do not preserve the names of men for ever.

But perhaps you suppose that you shall secure immortality if your names are transmitted to future ages.

If you consider the infinite space of eternity you will have no reason to rejoice in this supposition.

If a *moment* be compared with 10,000 years, there is a proportion between them, though a very small one.

But this number of years, multiplied by whatever sum you please, vanishes when compared with the infinite extent of eternity.

There may be comparison between finite things, but none between the infinite and finite.

Hence it is, that Fame (however lasting), compared with eternity, will seem absolutely nothing.

But yet you do good from no other view than to have the empty applause of the people, foregoing the pleasures of a good conscience in

and for ydel rumours. *and* 3e forsaken þe grete
worþinesse
of conscience *and* of vertue. *and* 3e seken 3oure
gerdouns of þe smale wordes of strange folke.

order to have the
insignificant praises of
other people.

NITY REPROVED.

¶ Haue now here *and* vndirstonde in þe lyztnesse of
whiche 1580

This silly vanity was
once thus ingeniously
and pleasantly rallied.

pride *and* veyne glorie. how a man scorned[e] festiualy
and myrily swiche vanite. somtyme þere was a man
þat

A certain man, who had
assumed the name of a
philosopher through a
love of vain-glory, was
told by a man of humour
that he could prove he
was a philosopher by
bearing patiently the
injuries offered him.

had[de] assaied wiþ striuyng wordes an oþer man. ¶ þe
whiche nat for vsage of verrey vertue. but for proude
1584

veyne glorie had[de] taken vpon hym falsly þe name
of a philosopher. ¶ þis raper man þat I speke of
þou3t[e] he wolde assay[e] where he þilke were a
philosopher or no. þat is to seyne yif he wolde han suffred 1588

[* fol. 15.]

lyztly in pacience þe wronges *þat weren don vnto
hym. ¶ þis feined[e] philosophre took pacience a
litel while. *and* whan he hadde receiued wordes of
outerage he as in stryuyng a3eine *and* reioysynge of
1592

After counterfeiting
patience for a while, the
sophist said to the other,
'You must surely confess
that I am a philosopher.'

hym self seide at þe last[e] ry3t þus. ¶ vndirstondest
þou nat þat I am a philosophere. þat oþer man
answered[e]

'I might have believed
it,' said the other, 'had
you held your tongue.'

a3ein ful bityngly *and* seide. ¶ I had[de]
wel vndirstonden [yt]. yif þou haddest holden þi tonge 1596
stille. ¶ But what is it to þise noble worþi men.
For certys of swyche folk speke .I. þat seken glorie

What advantage is it to
great and worthy men to
be extolled after death?

wiþ

vertue. what is it *quod* she. what atteiniþ fame to

swiche folk whan þe body is resolued by þe deep. atte 1600

þe last[e]. ¶ For yif so be þat men dien in al. þat is
to seyne body *and* soule. þe whiche þing oure resoun
defendiþ vs to byleuen þanne is þere no glorie in no
wyse. For what sholde þilke glorie ben. for he of 1604
whom þis glorie is seid to be nis ryzt nouzt in no wise.
and 3if þe soule whiche þat haþ in it self science of
goode werkes vnbounden fro þe prisoun of þe erþe
wendeþ frely to þe heuene. dispiseþ it nouzt þan alle

1608

erþely occupaciouns. *and* beyng in heuene reioiseþ þat
it is exempt from alle erþely þinges [as wo seith /
thanne rekketh the sowle of no glorye of renoun of this
world]. 1612

If body and soul die,
then there can be no
glory; nor can there be
when he (to whom it is
ascribed) does not exist.

But if the soul is
immortal when it leaves
the body, it takes no
thought of the joys of
this world.

1487 *desired*[e]—desyre

1489 *wex olde*—wax old

1492 *whiche*—which
speke—spekyn

1496 *tollen*—MS. tellen, C. tollen

1497 *ful*[le]—fulle

1501 *al prise*—alle prys

1505 *seye*—seyn

1507 *wolde*—woldyn
alle—al
[*ne*]—from C.

1510 *lerned*—ylerned

1512 *þouzte*—thowht
myche—moche

1513 [*the*]—from C.

1514 *myche space*—moche spaces

1515 *seye*—seyn

1516 *streite*—streyt

1517 *pan*—thanne
 1518 *inne*—in
 leest[e]—leste
 pilk—thilke
 penke 3e—thinken ye
 1520 *born forþe*—MS. borne, C. born, forth
 narwe—narwh
 1521 *streyt*—streyte
 myche—mochel
 1522 *conteinþe*—coueyteth
 1525 *habitable*—MS. habitache, C. habytacule
 1529 [*nat*]—from C.
 1531 *last[e]*—laste
 1532 *writen*—writ
 1533 *hadde*—hadden
 3itte—omitted
 1534 *hyzt*—hyhte
 pilk—thikke
 1535 *wexen*—waxen
 1536 *Sest þou*—sestow
 1538 *shew*—shewe
 1539 *singlere*—singer
 1545 *comeþ*—comth it
 1547 *furþe*—forth
 manere—maner
 1548 *þerfore*—ther-for
 auzte—owhte
 1549 *paied*—apayed
 hys owen—hise owne
 1550 *neyzbores*—nesshebours
 be—ben
 1552 *hap*—MS. haþe
 1553 *put* (MS. *putte*) *oute*—put owt
 1556 *derke*—derk
 dop aweye—MS. doþe, C. doth a-wey
 her autours—hir actorros
 1557 *3e*—yow
 semen—semeth
 1558 *comyng*—to comynge
 1559 *wilt*—wolt
 1560 *whiche*—which
 1563 *myche*—mochel

1564 *þo*—the
 hæp—MS. hæpe
 some—som
 1566 *self*—selue
 1567 *be* (2)—ben
 1568 *een[de]les*—endeles
 1569 *mad*—MS. made, C. maked
 [*but*—*comparysoun*]*—*from C.
 1573 *by*—to
 1580 *whiche*—swych
 1581 *scorned[e]*—scornede
 1582 *swiche*—swych
 somtyme—whilom
 1583 *had[de]*—hadde
 1584 *whiche*—which
 proude—prowd
 1586 *speke*—spak
 1587 *þouȝt[e]*—thowhte
 assay[e]—assaye
 1588 *seyne*—seyn
 1590 *feined[e]*—feynede
 1592 *aȝeine*—ayein
 1593 *last[e]*—laste
 vndirstondest þou—vndyrstondow
 1594 *answered[e]*—answerde
 1595 *had[de]*—hadde
 1596 [yt]*—*from C.
 1601 *last[e]*—laste
 1602 *seyne*—seyn
 1604 *for* (2)—whan
 1605 *þis*—thilke
 seid—MS. seide, C. seyd
 nouȝt—nawht
 1606 *hæp*—MS. hæpe
 1608 *nouȝt þan*—nat thanne
 1610 *from*—fro
 1610-1612 [*as*—*world*]*—*from C.

ATH PUTS AN END TO RENOWN.

QUICUMQUE SOLAM MENTE.

[The 7th Metre.]

Who so þat wiþ ouerþrowyng þou3t only sekep
glorie
of fame. *and* wenip þat it be souereyne good
¶ Lete hym loke vpon þe brode shewyng contreys of
þe heuen. *and* vpon þe streite sete of þis erþe. *and* 1616
he shal be ashamed of þe encres of his name. þat may
nat fulfille þe litel compas of þe erþe. ¶ O what
coueiten proude folke to liften vpon hire nekkes in
ydel *and* dedely 3ok of þis worlde. ¶ For al þou3 1620
[þat] renoune y-spradde passynge to ferne poeples goþ
by dyuerse tonges. *and* al þou3 grete houses *and* kynredes
shyne wiþ clere titles of honours. 3it napeles
deep dispiseþ al heye glorie of fame. *and* deep
wrappeþ 1624
to gidre þe heye heuedes *and* þe lowe *and* makeþ egal
and euene þe heyest[e] to þe lowest[e]. ¶ where
wonen now þe bones of trewe fabricius. what is
now brutus or stiern Caton þe þinne fame 3it lastynge
1628
of hir ydel names is markid wiþ a fewe lettres. but
al þou3 we han knowen þe faire wordes of þe fames of
hem. it is nat 3euen to knowe hem þat ben dede *and*
consumpt. Liggip þanne stille al vtterly vnknowable
1632
ne fame ne makeþ 3ow nat knowe. *and* yif 3e wene
to lyuen þe lenger for wynde of 3oure mortal name.
whan o cruel day shal rauyshe 3ow. þan is þe secunde
deep dwellyng in 3ow. *Glosa.* þe first deep he clepip
1636

Let him who seeks fame,
thinking it to be the
sovereign good, look
upon the broad universe
and this circumscribed
earth; and he will then
despise a glorious name
limited to such a
confined space.

Will splendid titles and
renown prolong a man's
life?

In the grave there is no
distinction between high
and low.

Where is the good
Fabricius now?

Where the noble Brutus,
or stern Cato?

Their empty names still
live, but of their persons
we know nothing.

Fame cannot make you
known.

It will be effaced by
conquering Time, so that
death will be doubly
victorious.

here þe departyng of þe body *and* þe soule. ¶ and
þe secunde deef he clepeþ as here. þe styntyng of
þe renoune of fame.³

³ The next three
chapters are from the
Camb. MS.

1615 *Lete*—Lat
 loke—looken
1616 *sete*—Cyte
1617 *be*—ben
1619 *vpon*—vp
1620 *and dedely*—in the dedly
1621 *y-spradde*—ysprad
 [*þat*]—from C.
 ferne—MS. serue, C. ferne
 gop—MS. goþe, C. goth
1622 *and* (2)—or
1623 *shyne*—shynen
 clere—cler
1624 *al*—alle
1626 *heyest*[*e*]—heyoste
 lowest[*e*]—loweste
1628 *stiern*—MS. sciern, C. stierne
1632 *consumpt*—*consumpte*
1634 *lenger*—longere
1637 *þe* (1)—omitted
1639 *renoune*—renoun

VERSE FORTUNE IS BENEFICIAL.

[\[SET NE ME INEXORABILE CONTRA.\]](#)

B Vt for-as-mochel as thow shalt nat wenen *quod*
 she 1640
þat I bere vntretable batayle ayenis fortune // yit
som-tyme it by-falleth þat she desseyuable desserueth
to han ryht good thank of men // *And* þat is whan she
hire self opneth / *and* whan she descouereth hir frownt

[The viij prose.]

‘But do not believe,’ said
Philosophy, ‘that I am an
implacable enemy to
Fortune.

This inconstant dame
sometimes deserves well
of men, when she
appears in her true
colours.

/ 1644

and sheweth hir maneres *par-aventure* yit vndirstondesthow

nat þat .I. shal seye // it is a wondyr þat .I.

desyre to telle / *and* forthi vnnethe may I. vnpleyten

my

sentense *with* wordes for I. deme þat contraryos

fortune 1648

profiteth more to men than fortune *debonayre* // For
al-wey whan fortune semeth *debonayre* than she lyeth
falsly in by-hetyng the hope of welefulnesse // but
forsothe

contraryos fortune is alwey sothfast / whan she 1652

sheweth hir self vnstable thorw hyr chaungynge // the
amyable fortune desseyueth folk / the contrarye
fortune

techeth // the amyable fortune byndeth *with* the beaute
of false goodys the hertes of folk þat vsen hem / the

1656

contrarye fortune vnbyndeth hem by þ^e knowynge of
freele welefulnesse // the amyable fortune maysthow
sen

alwey wyndynge *and* flowynge / *and* euere
mysknowynge

of hir self // the contrarye fortune is a-tempre *and* restreynynd 1660

and wys thorw excersyse of hir aduersyte // at
the laste amyable fortune *with* hir flaterynges draweth
mys wandrynge men fro the souereyne good // the
contraryos

fortune ledith ofte folk ayein to sothfast goodes / 1664

and haleth hem ayein as *with* an hooke / weenesthow

And what I say may
perhaps appear
paradoxical.

That is, that adverse
fortune is more
beneficial than
prosperous fortune.

The latter lies and
deceives us, the former
displays her natural
inconstancy.

That deceives us, this
instructs us; that, by a
fallacious show of good,
enslaves the mind; this,
by the knowledge of her
fickleness, frees and
absolves it.

The one is wavering and
incapable of reflection,
the other is staid and
wise through experience
of adversity.

Lastly, prosperous
fortune leads men astray.
Adversity teaches them
wherein real happiness
consists.

It renders us no
inconsiderable service in

thanne þat thou owhtest to leten this a lytel thing / þat
this aspre *and* horrible fortune hath discouryd to the /
the

enabling us to recognize
our true friends.

thowhtes of thy trewe frendes // For-why this ilke fortune 1668

hath departyd *and* vncoueryd to the bothe the
certeyn vysages *and* ek the downtos visages of thy
felawes // whan she departyd away fro the / she took
away hyr frendes *and* lafte the thyne frendes // now
1672

At what price would you
not have bought this
knowledge in your
prosperity?

whan thou were ryche *and* weleful as the semede /
with

how mochel woldesthow han bowht the fulle knowynge
of this // þat is to seyn the knowynge of thy
verray frendes // now pleyne the nat thanne of
Rychesse 1676

Complain not, then, of
loss of wealth, since thou
hast found infinitely
greater riches in your
true friends.

.I.-lorn syn thou hast fowndyn the moste presyos
kynde
of Rychesses þat is to seyn thy verray frendes.

L THINGS BOUND BY THE CHAIN OF LOVE.

QUOD MUNDUS STABILI FIDE.

[The viij Metur.]

T Hat þ^e world *with* stable feith / varieth acordable
chaungynges // þat the contraryos qualite of
elementz 1680

This world, by an
invariable order, suffers
change.

holden amonge hem self aliaunce *perdurable* / þat
phebus

Elements, that by nature
disagree, are restrained
by concord.

the sonne *with* his goldene chariet / bryngeth forth the
rosene day / þat the mone hath *commaundement* ouer the
nyhtes // whiche nyhtes hesperus the eue sterre hat browt // 1684

þat þ^e se gredy to flowen constreyneth *with* a certeyn

The sea is thus kept
within its proper bounds.

ende

hise floodes / so þat it is nat l[e]ueful to stretche hise
brode termes or bowndes vp-on the erthes // þat is to seyn
to couere alle the erthe // Al this a-cordaunce of
thinges 1688

This concord is produced
by love, which governeth
earth and sea, and
extends its influence to
the heavens.

is bownden *with* looue / þat gouerneth erthe *and* see /
and

If this chain of love were
broken all things would
be in perpetual strife,
and the world would go
to ruin.

hath also *commaundement* to the heuenes / *and* yif
this looue slakede the brydelis / alle thinges þat now
louen hem to gederes / wolden maken a batayle
continuely 1692

and stryuen to fordoon the fasoun of this worlde /
the which they now leden in acordable feith by fayre
moeuynges // this looue halt to gideres poeples
Ioygned

Love binds nations
together, it ties the
nuptial knot, and dictates
binding laws to
friendship.

with an hooly bond / *and* knytteth sacrement of
maryages 1696

of chaste looues // And loue enditeth lawes to
trewe felawes // O weleful weere mankynde / yif thilke
loue þat gouerneth heuene gouerned[e] yowre corages
/

Men were truly blest if
governed by this
celestial love!

EXPLICIT LIBER 2^{us}.

1690 *hath*—H. he hath

ETHIUS IS COMFORTED BY PHILOSOPHY'S SONG.

INCIPIT LIBER 3^{us}.

IAM CANTUM ILLA FINIERAT.

By this she hadde endid hire songe / whan the
swetnesse 1700

of hire ditee hadde thorw perced me þat was desirous
of herkninge / *and* .I. astoned hadde yit streyhte myn
Eres / þat is to seyn to herkne the bet / what she wolde
seye // so þat a litel here after .I. seyde thus // O thow
1704

þat art souereyn comfort of Angwissos corages // So
thow

hast remounted *and* norysshed me *with* the weyhte of
thy

sentenses *and with* delit of thy syngynge // so þat .I. trowe
nat now þat .I. be vnpanygal to the strokes of fortune / as 1708

who seyth. I. dar wel now suffren al the assautes of fortune

and wel deffende me fro hyr // *and* tho remedies
whyche þat thow seydest hire byforn weren ryht
sharpe

Nat oonly pat .I. am nat agrysen of hem now // but .I. desiros 1712

of herynge axe gretely to heeren tho remedyes //

than seyde she thus // þat feeledde .I. ful wel *quod* she //

whan þat thow ententyf *and* styлле rauysshedest my
wordes // *and* .I. abood til þat thow haddest swych
habyte 1716

of thy thowght as thow hast now // or elles tyl þat .I.
my self had[de] makid to the the same habyt / which
þat is a moore verray thinge // And certes the
remenaunt

[The fyrste prose.]

Philosophy now ended
her song.

I was so charmed that I
kept a listening as if she
were still speaking.

At last I said, O
sovereign comforter of
dejected minds, how
much hast thou refreshed
me with the energy of
thy discourse, so that I
now think myself almost
an equal match for
Fortune and able to resist
her blows.

I fear not, therefore, thy
remedies, but earnestly
desire to hear what they
are.

P. When I perceived that,
silent and attentive, you
received my words, I
expected to find such a
state of mind in you, or
rather, I created in you
such an one.

What remains to be said
is of such a nature that
when it is first tasted it is

of thinges þat ben yit to seye / ben swyche // þat fyrst

1720

whan men tasten hem they ben bytynge / but whan
they ben resseyuyd *with-inne* a whyht than ben they
swete // but for thow seyst þat thow art so desirous to
herkne hem // wit[h] how gret brennyng woldesthow

1724

glowen / yif thow wystem whyder .I. wol leden the //
whydyre is þat *quod* .I. // to thilke verray welefulnesse
quod she // of whyche thyng herte dremeth // but
for as moche as thy syhte is ocupied *and* distorbed / by

1728

Imagynasyon of herthely thynges / thow mayst nat yit
sen thilke selue welefulnesse // do *quod* .I. *and* shewe
me / what is thilke verray welefulnesse / .I. preye the
with-howte tarynge // þat wole .I. gladly don *quod* she
/ 1732

for the cause of the // but .I. wol fyrst marken the by
wordes / *and* I wol enforcen me to enformen the //
thilke false cause of blyfulnesse þat thow more
knowest /

so þat whan thow hast fully by-holden thilke false 1736
goodes *and* torned thyne eyen to þat oother syde / thow
mowe knowe the clernesse of verray blyfulnesse //]

1702 *streyhte*—H. strenghed

1712 *am nat*—H. nam nought

1718 *had[de]*—H. hade

1734 *wol*—H. shalle

1739 *wil*—wole

felde—feeld

pungent and unpleasant,
but when once
swallowed it turns sweet,
and is grateful to the
stomach.

But because you say you
would now gladly hear,
with what desire would
you burn if you could
imagine whither I am
going to lead you?

B. Whither is that, I
pray?

P. To that true felicity, of
which you seem to have
but a faint foretaste.

But your sight is clouded
with false forms, so that
it cannot yet behold this
same felicity.

B. Show me, I pray, that
true happiness without
delay.

P. I will gladly do so at
your desire, but I will
first describe that false
cause (of happiness), so
that you may be better
able to comprehend the
exact model.

AY WITH FALSE FELICITY!

*QUI SERERE INGENIUM.

¶ Who so wil sowe a felde plentiuos. lat hym first
delyuer it of þornes *and* kerue asondre wiþ his hooke

1740

þe bushes *and* þe ferne so þat þe corne may comen
heuy

of eres *and* of greins. hony is þe more swete yif
mouþes

han firste tastid sauoures þat ben wikke. ¶ þe sterres
shynen more agreably whan þe wynde Nothus letiþ his

1744

ploungy blastes. *and* aftir þat lucifer þe day sterre haþ
chased away þe derke nyzt. þe day þe feirer lediþ þe
rosene horse of þe sonne. ¶ Ryzt so þou byholdyng
first þe fals[e] goodes. bygynne to wiþdrawe þi
nek[ke] 1748

fro þe 3ok of erþely affecciouns. *and* afterwarde þe
verrey goodes shollen entre in to þi corage.

1740 *delyuer*—delyuere

of—fro

hooke—hook

1741 *bushes*—bosses

ferne—fern

corne—korn

1743 *firste*—fyrst

wikke—wyckyd

1744 *wynde*—wynd

his—hise

1745 *haþ*—MS. haþe

1746 *feirer*—fayrere

1747 *horse*—hors

Ryzt—And Ryht

Here the Add. MS.
begins again.

[The fyrst *metur.*]

He who would sow seed
must first clear the
ground of useless weeds,
so that he may reap an
abundant harvest.

Honey tastes all the
sweeter to a palate
disgusted by offensive
flavours.

The stars shine all the
clearer when the
southern showery blasts
cease to blow.

When Lucifer has chased
away the dark night, then
Phœbus mounts his gay
chariot.

So you, beholding the
false felicity, and
withdrawing your neck
from the yoke of earthly
affections, will soon see
the sovereign good.

1748 *fals[e]*—false
bygynne—bygyn
wiþdrawe—with drawen
nek[ke]—nekke
1749 *afterwarde*—affterward
1750 *entre*—entren

E DESIRE OF THE TRUE GOOD.

TUNC DEFIXO PAULULUM.

PO fastned[e] she a lytel þe syzt of hir eyen *and*
wiþdrow

hir ryzt as it were in to þe streite sete of hir 1752
þouzt. *and* bygan to speke ryzt þus. Alle þe cures
quod she of mortal folk whiche þat trauaylen hem in
many manere studies gon certys by diuerse weies.

¶ But napeles þei enforced hem *to comen oonly to on
1756

ende of blisfulnesse [And blysfulnesse] is swiche a
goode

þat who so haþ geten it he ne may ouer þat no þing
more

desiire. and þis þing for soþe is þe souereyne good þat
conteinþ

in hym self al manere goodes. to þe whiche goode 1760
yif þere failed[e] any þing. it myzt[e] nat ben souereyne

goode. ¶ For þan were þere som goode out of þis ilke souereyne
goode þat myzt[e] ben desired. Now is it clere *and*
certeyne þan þat blisfulnesse is a *perfit* estat by þe
congregacioun 1764

of alle goodes. ¶ þe whiche blisfulnesse as
I haue seid alle mortal folke enforcen hem to geten by

[The 2^{de} prose.]

Philosophy, with a
serious air, and
appearing to recollect
herself, and to rouse up
all her faculties, thus
began.

All the cares and desires
of men seek one end—
happiness.

[* fol. 15 b.]

True happiness is that
complete good which,
once obtained, leaves
nothing more to be
desired.

It is the sovereign good,
and comprehends all
others. It lacks nothing,
otherwise it could not be
the supreme good.

Happiness is, therefore,
that perfect state, in
which all other goods
meet and centre.

It is the object which all
men strive after.

dyuerse weyes. ¶ For-whi þe couetise of verray goode
is naturely y-plaunted in þe hertys of men. ¶ But þe

1768

myswandryng *errour* mysledip hem in to fals[e] goodes.

¶ of þe whiche men some of hem wenen þat
souereygne

goode is to lyue wiþ outen nede of any þing.

and traueilen hem to ben habundaunt of rycchesse.

1772

and some oþer men demen. þat souerein goode be
forto

be ryzt digne of reuerences. *and* enforcen hem to ben
reuerenced among hir neyȝbours. by þe honours þat þei

han ygeten ¶ *and* some folk þer ben þat halden þat 1776

ryzt heyȝe power to be souereyn goode. *and* enforcen

hem forto regnen or ellys to ioignen hem to hem þat

regnen. ¶ And it semep to some oþer folk þat noblesse

of renoun be þe souerein goode. *and* hasten hem to

1780

geten glorious name by þe artes of werre or of pees.

and many folke mesuren *and* gessen þat souerein

goode

be ioye *and* gladnesse *and* wenen þat it be ryzt blisful

[thyng] to ploungen hem in uoluptuous delit. ¶ And

1784

þer ben folk þat enterchaungen þe causes *and* þe endes

of þise forseide goodes as þei þat desiren rycchesse to

han power *and* delices. Or ellis þei desiren power forto

han moneye or for cause of renoun. ¶ In þise þinges

1788

A desire of the true good
is a natural instinct, but
error misleads them to
pursue false joys.

Some, imagining the
supreme good to consist
in lacking nothing,
labour for an abundance
of *riches*; others,
supposing that this good
lies in the *reverence* and
esteem of their fellow
men, strive to acquire
honourable positions.

There are some, again,
who place it in supreme
power, and seek to rule,
or to be favoured by the
ruling powers.
There are those who
fancy *fame* to be the
height of happiness, and
seek by the arts of war or
peace to get renown.

Many there are who
believe nothing to be
better than *joy* and
gladness, and think it
delightful to plunge into
luxury.

Some there are who use
these causes and ends
interchangeably, as those
who desire riches as a
means of getting power;
or who desire power in
order to get money or
renown.

In all they do they have a
particular end in view.

and in swyche oþer þinges is tourned al þe entencioun
of desirynges *and* [of] werkes of men. ¶ As þus.

ENDSHIP A SACRED THING.

¶ Noblesse *and* fauour of poeple whiche þat 3iueþ as it
semeþ a manere clernesse of renoun. ¶ and wijf *and*

1792

children þat men desiren for cause of delit *and*
mirinesse.

¶ But forsoþe frendes ne shollen nat ben rekkened
among þe goodes of fortune but of vertue. for it
is a ful holy manere þing. alle þise oþer þinges forsoþe

1796

ben taken for cause of power. or ellis for cause of
delit. ¶ Certis now am I redy to referen þe goodes of
þe body to þise forseide þinges abouen. ¶ For it semeþ
þat strengþe *and* gretnesse of body 3euen power *and*

1800

worþinesse. ¶ and þat beaute *and* swiftenesse 3euen
noblesse *and* glorie of renoun. *and* hele of body semeþ
3iuen delit. ¶ In alle þise þingus it semeþ oonly þat
blisfulnesse is desired. ¶ For-whi þilke þing þat euery

1804

man desireþ moost ouer alle þinges. he demip þat be
þe

souereyne goode. ¶ But I haue diffined þat blisfulnesse
is þe souereyne goode. for whiche euery wyȝt

demip þat þilke estat þat he desireþ ouer alle þinges þat 1808

it be þe blisfulnesse. ¶ Now hast þou þan byforne
[thy eyen] almost al þe purposed forme of þe

Nobility and popular
favour are sought after
by some in order to
become famous.
By others, wives and
children are only desired
as sources of pleasure.

Friendship must not be
reckoned among the
goods of fortune, but
among those of virtue,
for it is a very sacred
thing.
All else are desired
either for the power or
pleasure they afford.

The goods of the body
fall under the same
predicament.
Strength and a good
stature seem to give
power and worthiness.

Beauty and swiftness
give glory and fame; and
health gives delight.

In all these happiness
alone is sought.
What a man most wishes
for, that he esteems the
supreme good, which, as
we have defined, is
happiness.

Thou hast now before
thee a view of human
felicity (falsely so
called), that is, riches,

welfulnesse

of mankynde. þat is to seyne rycchesse. honours.
power. glorie. *and* delitȝ. þe whiche delit oonly
considered 1812

Epicurus Iuged *and* establissed. þat delit is þe
souereyne goode. for as myche as alle oper þinges as
hym pouȝt[e] by-refte away ioie *and* myrþe from þe
herte. ¶ But I retourne aȝeyne to þe studies of meen.
1816

of whiche men þe corage alwey rehersiþ *and* seekeþ þe
souereyne goode of alle be it so þat it be wiþ a derke
memorie [but he not by whiche paath]. ¶ Ryȝt as a
dronke man not nat by whiche pape he may retourne
1820

home to hys house. ¶ Semeþ it þanne þat folk folyen
and erren þat enforcen hem to haue nede of no þing

L SEEK THE CHIEF GOOD.

¶ Certys þer nys non oper þing þat may so weel
perfourny
blisfulnesse as an estat plenteuous *of alle 1824
goodes þat ne haþ nede of none oper þing. but þat it is
suffisant of hym self. vnto hym self. and foleyen
swyche folk þanne. þat wenen þat þilk þing þat is
ryȝt goode. þat it be eke ryȝt worpi of honour *and* of 1828
reuerence. ¶ Certis nay. for þat þing nys neyþer foule
ne worpi to ben dispised þat al þe entencioun of mortel
folke trauaille forto geten it. ¶ And power auȝt[e]
nat þat eke to be rekened amonges goodes what ellis.
1832

honours, power, glory,
and delight, which last
Epicurus considered as
the sovereign good.

I now return to the
inclinations and pursuits
of mankind.

Their minds are bent
upon the chief good, and
are ever seeking it with a
darkened understanding,
like a drunken man, who
cannot find his way
home.
Do they go astray who
strive to keep themselves
from want?

By no means. No state is
happier than that in
which a man is above
want, and independent of
others.

[* fol. 16.]

Are they guilty of folly
that seek esteem and
reverence?

No; for that is not
contemptible for which
all men strive.

Is not power to be
reckoned amongst
desirable goods?

Why not? For that is not
an insignificant good

for it nys nat to wene þat þilke þing þat is most
worþi of alle þinges be feble *and* wiþ out strengþe *and*
clernesse of renoun auzte þat to ben dispised. ¶ Certys
þer may no man forsake þat al þing þat is ryzt excellent
1836

and noble. þat it ne semeþ to be ryzt clere *and* renommed.
¶ For certis it nedip nat to seie. þat blisfulnesse
be anguissous ne dreri ne subgit to greuances ne
to sorwes. syn þat in ryzt litel þingus folk seken to 1840
haue *and* to vsen þat may deliten hem. ¶ Certys þise
ben þe þinges þat men wolen *and* desyren to geten.
and for þis cause desiren þei rycches. dignites. regnes.
glorie *and* delices ¶ For þerby wenen þei to han
suffisaunce 1844

honour power. renoun *and* gladnesse. ¶ þanne
is it goode. þat men seken þus by so many dyuerse
studies. In whiche desijr it may lyztly be shewed.
how grete is þe strengþe of nature. ¶ For how so þat
1848
men han dyuerse sentences *and* discordyng algates
men
accordyn alle in lyuyngþe þe ende of goode.

which invests a man with
authority and command.

Fame also is to be
regarded, for everything
excellent is also shining
and renowned.

We hardly need say that
happiness is not an
unjoyous and
melancholy state, for in
the pursuit of the
smallest matters men
seek only pleasure.
Hence it is that mankind
seek riches, &c., because
by them they hope to get
independence, honour,
&c.

However varied their
desires, *happiness* is
their sole pursuit.

However various men's
opinions are respecting
happiness, all agree in
pursuing it as the end of
their actions and desires.

1751 *fastned[e]*—fastnede
wiþdrow—MS. wiþdrowen, C. with drowh

1752 *sete*—Cyte

1756 *enforced*—enforsen

1757 [*And blysfulnesse*]—from C.
goode—good

1758 *so*—so þat
hap—MS. haþe

1759 *souereyne*—souereyn

1760 *al*—alle
goode—good

1761 *pere*—ther
failed[e]—faylyde
myzt[e]—myhte
souereyne goode—souereyn good
 1762 *pan*—thanne
pere—ther
goode—good
souereyne—souereyn
 1763 *goode*—good
myzt[e]—myhte
 1764 *certeyne*—certein
 1766 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyde
folke—foolk
 1767 *goode*—good
 1769 *fals*[e]—false
 1770 *souereygne goode is*—souereyn good be
 1771 *lyue wiþ outen*—lyuen with owte
 1772 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 1773 *some*—som
goode be—good ben
 1774 *be*—ben
 1775 *neyzbours*—nesshebors
 1776 *halden*—holden
 1777 *heyze*—heyh
to—omitted
goode—good
 1780 *goode*—good
 1781 *or*—*and*
 1782 *folke*—folk
goode—good
 1783 *be*—by
 1784 [*thyng*e]—from C.
 1786 *rycchesse*—rychesses
 1787 *delices*—delytes
 1789 *oper*—oothre
al—alle
 1790 [*of*]—from C.
 1794 *shollen*—sholden
 1795 *þe*—tho
 1796 *oper*—oothre
 1801 *swiftenesse*—sweftnesse
 1803 *ziuen*—MS. *ziueþ*, C. yeuen

1806, 1807 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
 1807 *whiche*—whych
 1809 *þe*—omitted
 þan byforne—thanne byforne
 1810 [*thy eyen*]*—from C.; MS. has 3euen a3eyne*
 almost—almest
 welfulnesse—welefulnesse
 1811 *seyne rycchesse*—seyn Rychesses
 1814 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
 myche—moche
 oper—oothre
 1815 *pou3t[e]*—thowhte
 from—fram
 1816 *a3eyne*—ayein
 1818 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
 of—omitted
 alle—al
 derke—dirkyd
 1819 [*but*—*paath*]*—from C.*
 1820 *dronke*—dronken
 pape—paath
 1821 *home*—hym
 1823 *perfourny*—performe
 1825 *hap*—MS. haþe
 none—non
 1827 *pilk*—thilke
 1828 *goode*—good
 1829 *foule*—fowl
 1830 *al*—welneyh alle
 1831 *trauaille*—trauaylen
 au3t[e]—owhte
 1832 *be*—ben
 1834 *out*—owte
 1835 *au3te*—owhte
 1836 *al*—alle
 1837 *be*—ben
 clere—cleer
 1843 *rycches*—Rychesses
 1846 *goode*—good
 1847 *be*—ben
 1848 *grete*—gret
 1849 *algates*—Allegates

NATURE'S LAWS.

QUANTAS RERUM FLECTAT.

[The 2^{de} Metur.]

I T likeþ me to shew[e] by subtil songe wiþ slakke
and

I will now sing of
Nature's laws, by which
the universe is governed.

delitable soun of strenges how þat nature myȝty enclineþ 1852

and flitteþ gouvernementȝ of þinges ¶ and by

whiche lawes she purueiable kepith þe grete worlde. and

how she bindynge restreineþ alle þingus by a bonde þat

may nat be vnbounden. ¶ Al be it so þat þe liouns of 1856 [j]

þe contree of pene beren þe fair[e] cheines. and taken

metes of þe handes of folk þat ȝeuen it hem. and

dreden her sturdy maystres of whiche þei ben wont to

suffren [betinges]. yif þat hir horrible mouþes ben bi-

bled. 1860

The Punic lion submits
to man, and dreads the
keeper's lash; yet, if he
once taste blood, his
savage instincts revive,
and his keeper falls a
victim to his fury.

þat is to sein of bestes devoured. ¶ Hir corage

of tyme passeþ þat haþ ben ydel and rested. repaireþ

aȝein þat þei roren greuously. and remembren on hir

nature. and slaken hir nekkes from hir cheins vnbounden. 1864

and hir maistre first to-teren wiþ bloody toþe

assaieþ þe woode wrappes of hem. ¶ þis is to sein þei

freten hir maister. ¶ And þe Iangland brid þat syngith

on þe heye braunches. þis is to sein in þe wode and

1868

[ij]

If the caged bird though
daintily fed, gets a sight
of the pleasant grove
where she was wont to
sing, she will spurn her
food, and pine for the
beloved woods.

after is inclosed in a streit cage. ¶ al þouȝ [þat] þe

pleiynge besines of men ȝeueþ hem honied[e] drinkes

and large metes. wiþ swete studie. ¶ ȝit nabeles yif

þilke brid skippynge oute of hir streite cage seeþ þe 1872

agreable shadewes of þe wodes. she defouleþ wiþ hir

fete hir metes yshad *and* sekeþ mournyng oonly þe
wode *and* twitriþ desiryng þe wode wiþ hir swete
voys. ¶ þe 3erde of a tree þat is haled adoun by myȝty

1876

strengþe bowiþ redely þe croppe adoun. but yif þat þe
hande of hym þat it bente lat it gon aȝein. ¶ An oon
þe crop lokeþ vp ryȝt to heuene. ¶ þe sonne phebus
þat failleþ at euene in þe westrene wawes retornip
aȝein 1880

eftsones his cart by a priue pape þere as it is wont
aryse. ¶ Alle þinges seken aȝein in to hir propre
cours. and alle þinges reioisen hem of hir retournyng
aȝein to hir nature ne noon ordinaunce nis bytaken to

1884

þinges but þat. þat haþ ioignyng þe endyng to þe
bygynnyng. *and* haþ makid þe cours of it self stable
þat it chaungeþ nat from hys propre kynde.

1851 *shew[e]*—shewe

1854 *whiche*—MS. swiche, C. whyche
worlde—world

1856 *be*—ben
vnbounden—vnbownde

1857 *fair[e]*—fayre

1860 [*betinges*]—from C.

1862 *passeþ*—passed

1864 *from*—fram
vnbounden—vnbownde

1865 *to-teren*—to-torn
toþe—toth

1867 *Iangland*—Iangelyng

1869 *streit*—streyht

1870 *pleiyng*—MS. pleinyng, C. pleyynge
besines—bysynesse
honied[e]—honyede

[iij]

The sapling, bent down
by a mighty hand, will
resume its natural
position as soon as the
restraining force is
removed.

[iiij]

Though the sun sets in
the western main at eve,
yet by a secret path he
takes his wonted journey
toward the east.

All things pursue their
proper course, obedient
to the source of order.

Hence, throughout the
world entire stability is
found, for all things,
having fulfilled their
appointed course, return
from whence they came.

1872 *oute*—owt
 1873 *agreable*—agreables
 1874 *fete*—feet
 1875 *twitriþ*—twiterith
 1877 *croppe*—crop
 1878 *hande*—hand
 bente—bent
 1880 *failleþ*—falleth
 1881 *cart*—carte
 a—omitted
 pape—paath
 1883 *of*—MS. of of
 1885 *hap*—MS. haþe
 *ioignyng*e—Ioyned
 1886 *hap*—MS. haþe

E SEARCH AFTER FELICITY.

VOSQUE TERRENA ANIMALIA.

[The 3^{de} prose.]

***C** Ertis also 3e men þat ben erþeliche bestes dremen

[* fol. 16 b.]

1888

alwey [yowre bygynnyng] al þou3 it be wiþ a
 þinne ymaginacioun. *and* by a maner þou3t al be it
 nat clerly ne perfitly 3e looken from a fer til þilk
 verray fyn of blisfulnesse. and þerfore þe naturel
 entencioun 1892

O earthly animals, you
 have an indistinct
 perception of your
 beginning, and you have
 ever the true end of
 felicity in view, but your
 natural instincts are
 perverted by many
 errors.

ledeþ 3ow to þilk verray good ¶ But

many manere errours mistourniþ 3ow þer fro. ¶

Considere

Can men obtain the end
 they have in view by the
 means they usually
 employ in the pursuit of
 happiness?

now yif þat be þilke þinges by whiche a man

weniþ to gete hym blysfulnesse. yif þat he may comen 1896

to þilke ende þat he weneþ to come by nature ¶ For
 yif þat moneye or honours or þise oþer forseide þinges
 bryngen to men swiche a þing þat no goode ne faille

If riches and honours and
 the like make men
 happy, so that they shall
 want for nothing, then
 happiness may be

hem. ne semep faille. ¶ Certys þan wil I graunt[e] 1900
 þat þei ben maked blisful. by þilke þinges þat þei han
 geten. ¶ but yif so be þat þilke þinges ne mowe nat
perfourmen þat þei by-heten *and* þat þer be defaute of
 many goodes. ¶ Shewep it nat þan clerely þat fals 1904
 beaute of blisfulnesse is knowe *and* a-teint in þilke
 þinges. ¶ First *and* forward þou þi self þat haddest
 haboundaunces of rycchesses nat long agon. ¶ I axe
 3if þat in þe haboundaunce of alle þilk[e] rycchesses
 1908
 þou were neuer anguissous or sory in þi corage of any
 wrong or greuaunce þat by-tidde þe on any syde.

NE ARE FREE FROM CARE.

¶ Certys *quod* I it remembreþ me nat þat euere I was
 so free of my þou3t. þat I ne was al-wey in anguyshe of
 1912
 somewhat. þat was þat þou lakkedest þat þou noldest
 han lakked. or ellys þou haddest þat þou noldest
 han had. ry3t so is it *quod* I þan. desiredest þou
 þe presence of þat oon *and* þe absence of þat oþer. 1916
 I graunt[e] wel *quod* .I. for soþe *quod* she þan nedip
 þer
 somewhat þat euery man desireþ. 3e þer nedip *quod* I.
 ¶ Certis *quod* she *and* he þat haþ lakke or nede of a
 wy3t nis nat in euery way suffisaunt to hym self. no
quod .I. 1920
and þou *quod* she in alle þe plente of þi
 rycchesse haddest þilke lak of suffisaunce. ¶ what
 ellis *quod* .I. ¶ þanne may nat rycchesse maken þat a

procured by these
 acquisitions.

But if these things
 cannot make good what
 they promise, if there
 still be something to be
 desired, then they are
 delusions, and the
 felicity after all is a
 counterfeit.

In your prosperity were
 you never annoyed by
 some wrong or
 grievance?

B. I must confess that I
 cannot remember ever
 being wholly free from
 some trouble or other.

P. That was because
 something was absent
 which you did desire, or
 something present which
 you would fain be quit
 of.

B. That's quite true.

P. Then you did desire
 the presence of the one
 and the absence of the
 other?

B. I confess I did.

P. Every man is in need
 of what he desires.

B. Certainly he is.

P. If a man lack anything
 can he be supremely
 happy?

B. No.

P. Did you not in your
 abundance want for
 somewhat?

man nis nedy. ne þat he be suffisaunt to hym self. *and*

1924

þat was it þat þei byhyȝten as it semeþ. ¶ and eke
certys I trowe þat þis be gretly to consydere þat
moneye

ne haþ nat in hys owen kynde þat it ne may ben by-
nomen

of hem þat han it maugre hem. ¶ I by-knowe 1928

it wel *quod* I ¶ whi sholdest þou nat by-knowen it

quod she. whan euery day þe strengre folke by-nymen
it fram þe febler maugre hem. ¶ Fro whennes comen

ellys alle þise foreine compleintes or quereles of 1932

pletyngus. ¶ But for þat men axen aȝeine her moneye

þat haþ be by-nomen hem by force or by gyle. *and*

alwey maugre hem. ¶ Ryȝt so it is *quod* I. þan *quod*

she haþ a man nede to seken hym foreyne helpe by 1936

whiche he may defende hys moneye. who may say nay
quod .I.

RICHES BRING ANXIETIES.

¶ Certis *quod* she *and* hym nedip no helpe

yif he ne hadde no moneye þat he myȝt[e] leese. ¶ þat

is doutles *quod* .I. þanne is þis þing turned in to þe
contrarie 1940

quod she ¶ For rycchesse þat men wenen sholde

make suffisaunce. þei maken a man raþer han nede of

foreine helpe. ¶ whiche is þe manere or þe gise *quod*

she þat rycches may dryuen away nede. ¶ Riche folk

1944

may þei neiþer han hungre ne þrest. þise ryche men

B. What then if I did?

P. It follows that riches cannot put a man beyond all want, although this was what they seemed to promise.

Money may part company with its owner, however unwilling he may be to lose it.

B. I confess that's true.

P. It ought to be confessed when every day we see *might* prevailing over *right*.

From whence springs so much litigation, but from this, that men seek to recover their own of which they have been unjustly deprived?

B. Nothing is more true.

P. Then a man needs the assistance of others in order to keep his riches.

If he had no money to lose he would not stand in need of this help?

B. That is beyond all doubt.

P. Then the very reverse of what was expected (from riches) takes place? For riches add to a man's necessities.

Tell me how do riches drive away necessity? Are not rich men liable to hunger, thirst, and cold?

may þei feele no colde on hir lymes in wynter. ¶ But
þou wilt answere þat ryche men han y-nouȝ wher wiþ
þei may staunchen her hunger. *and* slaken her þrest 1948
and don away colde. ¶ In þis wise may nede be
conforted

by rycchesses. but certys nede ne may nat al
outerly be don away. for þouȝ þis nede þat is alwey
gapyng *and* gredy be fulfilled wiþ rycchesses. *and* axe
1952

any þing ȝit dwelleþ þanne a nede þat myȝt[e] ben fulfilled.

¶ I holde me stille *and* telle nat how þat litel
þing suffiseþ to nature. but certys to auarice ynouȝ ne
suffiseþ no þinge. *¶ For syn þat rychesse ne may nat
1956

al don away nede. but rychesse maken nede. what may
it þanne be þat ȝe wenen þat rycchesses mowen ȝeuen
ȝow suffisaunce.

You will say that the rich
have wherewithal to
satisfy these wants.

By riches indigence may
be alleviated, but they
cannot satisfy every
want.

Even if gaping and
greedy necessity be
filled with riches, yet
some cravings will
remain.

A little suffices for
nature, but avarice never
has enough.

If riches, then, add to our
wants, why should you
think that they can
supply all your
necessities?

[* fol. 17.]

1889 [yowre bygynnyng]—from C.
al—MS. as, C. Al
 1891 *from*—fram
til pilk—to thylke
 1892 *þe*—omitted
 1893 *pilk*—thylke
 1895 *be*—by
 1896 *gete*—geten
 1899 *swiche*—swych
goode—good
 1900 *wil*—wole
graunt[e]—graunte
 1904 *many*—manye
clerely—clerly
fals—false
 1905 *knowe*—knownen
 1908 *pilk[e]*—thylke
 1913 *þat*—*lakkedest*—And was nat þat quod she for þat the lacked som-what
 1915 *had*—MS. hadde, C. had
 1917 *graunt[e]*—graunte
 1919 *hap*—MS. haþe
a wyȝt—awht
 1921 *alle*—al
 1922 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
lak—lakke
 1923 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 1927 *hap*—MS. haþe
owen—owne
 1930 *strenger folke by-nymen*—strengere folk by-nemyn
 1931 *fram*—fro
febler—febelere
Fro—for
 1933 *azeine*—ayeyn
 1934 *hap*—MS. haþe
be—ben
 1936 *hap*—MS. haþe
helpe—help

1937 *say*—sey
 1938 *nedip no helpe*—nedede non help
 1939 *myzt[e]*—myhte
 1940 *doutles*—dowteles
 1941 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 1943 *helpe*—help
 whiche—whyh
 1944 *rycches*—Rychesse
 dryuen—dryue
 1945 *hungre*—hungyr
 prest—thurst
 1946 *pei*—the
 colde—coold
 in—on
 1947 *wilt answere*—wolt Answeren
 y-nouȝ—y-now
 1948 *prest*—thurst
 1949 *colde*—coold
 1950 *nat*—omitted
 1951 *outerly*—vtrely
 1953 *myzt[e] ben*—myhte be
 1957 *rychesse*—Rychesses

QUAMUIS FLUENTER DIUES.

[The 3^{de} Metur.]

A l were it so þat a ryche couetous man hadde riuer
 1960

The rich man, had he a
 river of gold, would
 never rest content.

fletyng alle of golde ȝitte sholde it neuer staunche
 hys couetise. ¶ And þouȝ he hadde his nekke I-charged
 wiþ preciouſe ſtones of þe rede ſee. *and* þouȝ he do
 1964
 erylle his feldeſ plentiuouſ wiþ an hundreþ oxen neuere

Though his neck be
 loaded with precious
 pearls, and his fields be
 covered with
 innumerable herds, yet
 ſhall unquiet care neuer
 forſake him; and at his
 death his riches ſhall not
 bear him company.

ne ſhal hiſ bytyng byſyneſſe forleten hym while he
 lyueþ. ne þe lyȝt[e] rychesſes ne ſhal nat beren hym
 compaignie whanne he iſ dede.

1960 *riuer*—a Ryuer

1961 *alle*—al
golde—gold
zitte—yit
staunche—staunchyn
1962, 1963 *pouȝ*—thow
1964 *erye*—Ere
hundrep—hundred
1965 *while*—whyl
1966 *lyȝt[e]*—lyhte
shal—shol
1967 *dede*—ded

DIGNITIES.

[SET DIGNITATIBUS.](#) 4

[The 4th prose.]

4 Read *dignitates*.

B vt dignitees to whom þei ben comen make þei hym
1968

honorable *and* reuerent. han þei nat so grete strengþe
þat þei may putte vertues in þe hertis of folk. þat vsen
þe lordshipes of hem. or ellys may þei don away þe
vices. Certys þei [ne] ben nat wont to don away
wikkednesses. 1972

but þei ben wont rapen to shew[en] wikkednesses.
and þer of comeþ it þat I haue ryȝt grete desdeyne.
þat dignites ben ȝeuen ofte to wicked men.

¶ For whiche þing catullus clepid a consul of Rome þat
1976

hyȝt nonius postum. or boch. as who seiþ he clepiþ
hym a congregacioun of uices in his brest as a postum
is ful of corrupcioun. al were þis nonius set in a
chayere of dignitee. Sest þou nat þan how gret vylenye
1980

dignitees don to wikked men. ¶ Certys vnworþines of

It may be said that
dignities confer honour
on their possessors.

But have they power to
destroy vice or implant
virtue in the heart?

So far from expelling
vicious habits, they only
render them more
conspicuous.

Hence arises the
indignation when we see
dignities given to wicked
men.

Hence Catullus'
resentment against
Nonius, whom he calls
the botch, or impostume
of the State.

The deformities of
wicked men would be
less apparent if they
were in more obscure
situations.

wikked men sholde ben þe lasse ysen yif þei nere renommed
of none honours. ¶ Certys þou þi self ne

myȝtest nat ben brouȝt wiþ as many perils as þou 1984

myȝtest suffren þat þou woldest bere þi magistrat wiþ

decorat. þat is to seyn. þat for no peril þat myȝt[e] bifallen

þe by þe offence of þe kyng theodorik þou noldest

nat ben felawe in gouernaunce with decorat. whanne 1988

þou say[e] þat he had[de] wikkid corage of a likerous

shrewe and of an acusor. ¶ Ne I ne may nat for swiche

honours Iugen hem worþi of reuerence þat I deme and

holde vnworþi to han þilke same honours. ¶ Now yif

1992

þou saie a man þat were fulfilled of wisdom. certys

þou

ne myȝtest nat demen þat he were vnworþi to þe

honour. or ellys to þe wisdom of whiche he is fulfilled.

No quod .I. ¶ Certys dignitees quod she appertienen

1996

properly to vertue. and uertue transporteb dignite anon

to þilke man to whiche she hir self is conioigned.

Would you free yourself from peril by accepting a magistracy along with Decoratus a buffoon and informer?

Honours do not render undeserving persons worthy of esteem.

If you find a man endowed with wisdom you deem him worthy of respect and of the wisdom which he professes.

B. I could not do otherwise.

P. Virtue has her proper worth, which she ever transfers to her votaries.

DIGNITIES APPERTAIN TO VIRTUE.

¶ And for as moche as honours of poeple ne may nat maken folk digne of honour. it is wel seyn clerly þat

2000

þei ne han no propre beaute of dignite. ¶ And ȝit men

auȝten take more hede in þis. ¶ For if it so be þat he

is most out cast þat most folk dispisen. or as dignite ne

may nat maken shrewes worþi of no reuerences. þan

2004

Honours conferred by the populace do not make men worthy of them, for they have no intrinsic merit to bestow.

Dignities conferred upon shrews only make their vices the more conspicuous.

makeþ dignites shrewes more dispised þan preised. þe
whiche shrewes dignit[e] scheweþ to moche folk ¶ *and*
for soþe nat vnpunissed. þat is forto sein. þat shrewes
reuengen hem azeinward vpon dignites. for þei zelden
2008

azein to dignites as gret gerdoun whan þei byspotten
and defoulen dignites wiþ hire vylenie. ¶ And for as
moch as þou mow[e] knowe þat pilke verray
reuerence

ne may nat comen by þe shadewy transitorie dignitees.
2012

vndirstonde now þis. yif þat a man hadde vsed *and*
hadde many manere dignites of consules *and* were
comen perauenture amonges straunge naciouns. sholde
pilke honour maken hym worshipful *and* redouted of 2016
straunge folk ¶ Certys yif þat honour of poeple were
a naturel zifte to dignites. it ne myzte neuer cesen
nowher amonges no maner folke to done hys office.

DIGNITIES DO CONFER ESTEEM.

¶ Ryzt as fire in euery contre ne stinteþ nat to 2020
enchaufen *and* *to ben hote. but for as myche as forto
be holden honorable or reuerent ne comeþ nat to folk
of
hir propre strengþe of nature. but only of þe fals[e]
opinioun of folk. þat is to sein. þat wenen þat dignites
2024

maken folk digne of honour. An on þerfore whan þat
þei comen þer as folk ne knowen nat pilke dignites.
her honours vanissen away *and* þat on oon. but þat is

Nor do dignities
themselves escape
without injury; for
worthless men take their
revenge upon them, and
defile them by their
contagious villanies.

These shadowy honours
have nothing in their
nature to procure
respect; for if a man,
having borne the
honours of the consulate,
should go among
barbarians would this
honour gain him their
respect?

If respect were an
attribute of honour it
would infallibly bring
esteem everywhere, just
as heat is ever an
attribute of fire.

[* fol. 17 b.]

Honours arise from the
false opinions of men,
and vanish when they
come among those who
do not esteem them, that
is, among foreign
nations.

a-mong straung folk. maist þou sein. but amongus 2028
hem þat þei weren born duren þilk[e] dignites alwey.

¶ Certys þe dignite of þe prouostrie of Rome was
somtyme

a grete power. now is it no þing but an ydel

name. *and* þe rente of þe senatorie a gret charge. *and*

2032

yif a whiȝt somtyme hadde þe office to taken he[de] to
þe vitales of þe poeple as of corne *and* what oþer þinges

he was holden amonges grete. but what þing is more

nowe out cast þanne þilke prouostrie ¶ And as I haue

2036

seid a litel here byforne. þat þilke þing þat haþ no
propre beaute of hym self resceyueþ somtyme pris *and*

shynyng *and* somtyme lesiþ it by þe opinioun of

vsaunces. ¶ Now yif þat dignites þanne ne mowen 2040

nat maken folk digne of reuerence. *and* yif þat dignites

wexen foule of hir wille by þe filþe of shrewes. ¶ *and*

yif þat dignites lesen hir shynyng by chaungyng of

tymes. *and* yif þei wexen foule by estimacioun of 2044

poeple. what is it þat þei han in hem self of beaute

þat auȝte ben desired. as who seiþ none. þanne ne

mowen þei ȝiuen no beaute of dignite to none oþer.

Do they always endure
in those places that gave
birth to them?

The Prætorate was once
a great honour, but now
it is only an empty name
and a heavy expense.

What is more vile than
the office of the
superintendency of
provisions?

That which hath no
innate beauty must lose
its splendour or value
according as popular
opinion varies
concerning it.

If dignities cannot confer
esteem, if they become
vile through filthy
shrews, if they lose their
lustre by the change of
times, if they become
worthless by the change
of popular opinion, what
beauty do they possess
which should make them
desirable, or what
dignity can they confer
on others?

1969 *make*—maken

1969 *grete*—gret

1972 [*ne*]—from C.

ben—be

1972, 1973 *wikkednesses*—wykkydnesse

1973 *to*—omitted

shew[en]—shewen

1974 *comeþ*—comth

grete desdeyne—gret desdaign

1976 *whiche*—which
 1977 *hyzt*—hyhte
 nonius—MS. *vonnus*, C. *nomyus*
 boch—MS. *bope*, C. *boch*
 clepiþ—clepyd
 1979 *nonius*—MS. *uonnus*, C. *nomyus*
 set—MS. *sette*, C. *set*
 1980 *Sest þou*—Sesthow
 þan—thanne
 vylenye—fylonye
 1981 *vnworþines*—vnworthynesse
 1982 *ben*—be
 ysen—MS. *ysene*, C. *I-sene*
 1984 *many*—manye
 1985 *bere*—beren
 1986 *myzt[e]*—myhte
 1987 *þe* (2)—omitted
 1988 *whanne*—whan
 1989 *say[e]*—saye
 had[de]—hadde
 1994 *demen*—deme
 1995 *whiche*—which
 1996 *quod she*—omitted
 1997 *vertue*—vertu
 uertue—vertu
 1998 *whiche*—whyh
 2000 *clerly*—MS. *clerkly*, C. *clerly*
 2002 *auzten*—*hede*—owhten taken mor heed
 2002-3 *For*—*dignite*—For yif so be þat a wykkyd whyght be so mochel the fowlere *and* the moore
 owt cast þat he is despised of most folk so as dignete
 2004-2007 *maken*—*soþe*—maken shrewes digne of Reuerence the whych shrewes dignete sheweth
 to moche foolk thanne makith dignete shrewes rather so moche more despised than preysed *and*
 forsothe
 2008 *zelden*—yilden
 2009 *byspotten*—by-spetten
 2010 *hire*—hyr
 2011 *moche*—mochel
 mow[e]—mowe
 2012 *þe shadewy*—thyse shadwye
 2013 *vndirstonde*—vndyrstond
 þis—thus
 2014 *hadde*—had

2018 *zifte*—yift
 2019 *folke*—foolk
 done—don
 2020 *enchaußen*—eschaufen
 2021 *myche*—mochel
 2022 *be*—ben
 2023 *fals[e]*—false
 2024 *þat* (2)—omitted
 2027 *her*—hyr
 vanissen—vanesshen
 2028 *a-mong*—amonges
 straung—straunge
 but—ne
 2029 *þat*—ther
 duren þilk[e]—ne duren nat thylke
 2030 *somtyme*—whylom
 2031 *grete*—gret
 2032 *þe* (2)—omitted
 2033 *somtyme*—whylom
 þe—MS. *þe þe*
 2034 *corne*—corn
 what—omitted
 2035 *more nowe*—now more
 2036 *cast*—MS. caste, C. cast
 2037 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyd
 here byforne—her by-forn
 hap—MS. haþe
 2042 *filþe*—felthe
 2043 *þat*—omitted
 2046 *auzte*—owhte
 none—non
 2047 *þei*—MS. *þe*, C. they
 none—non

QUAMUIS SE TIRIO.

A l be it so þat þe proude nero wiþ al his woode
 luxurie 2048
 kembed hym *and* apparaild hym wiþ faire purpers
 of Tirie *and* wiþ white perles. Algates zitte throf he

[The 4th Metur.]

Nero, though invested
 with the purple and
 adorned with pearls, was
 hated by all men.

hateful to alle folk ¶ þis is to seyn þat al was he by-hated
of alle folk. ¶ 3itte þis wicked Nero hadde gret 2052
lordship *and* 3af somtyme to þe dredeful senatours þe
vnworshipful setes of dignites. ¶ vnworshipful setes
he clepiþ here fore þat Nero þat was so wikked 3af þo
dignites. who wolde þanne resonably wenen þat
blysfulnesse 2056
were in swiche honours as ben 3euen by vicious
shrewes.

Yet he had lordship, and
gave to the senators the
dishonoured seats of
dignity.

Who then can think that
felicity resides in
honours given by vicious
shrews?

2048 *al* (2)—alle

2049 *kembed*—kembde

apparailled—MS. *apparailen*, C. *a-paraylede*

2050 *3itte*—yit

2053 *lordship*—lorshippe

3af somtyme—yaf whylom

dredeful—reuerenc3

2055 *fore*—for

3af—yaf

¶GDOMS DO NOT MAKE A MAN MIGHTY.

AN UERO REGNA.

B vt regnes *and* familiarites of kynges may þei
maken a
man to ben my3ty. how ellys. ¶ whanne hir 2060
blysfulnesse dureþ perpetuely but certys þe olde age of
tyme passeþ. *and* eke of present tyme now is ful of
ensaumples how þat kynges þat han chaunged in to
wrechednesse out of hir welefulnesse. ¶ O a noble þing
2064
and a cler þing is power þat is nat founden my3ty to
kepe it self. ¶ And yif þat power of realmes be auctour

[The 5th prose.]

P. Do kingdoms and a
familiarity with princes
make a man mighty?

B. Why should they not
if they are durable?

P. Past ages, as well as
the present, furnish us
with many examples of
princes who have met
with dismal reverses of
fortune.

O then how noble and
glorious a thing is power
that is too weak to
preserve itself!

and maker of blisfulnesse. yif þilke power lakkeþ on
any side. amenusip it nat þilke blisfulnesse *and*

bryngeþ 2068

in wrechednesse. but yif al be it so þat realmes of
mankynde

stretchen broode. 3it mot þer nede ben myche
folk ouer whiche þat euery kyng ne haþ no lordshipe
no comaundement ¶ and certys vpon þilke syde þat 2072
power failleþ whiche þat makip folk blisful. ry3t on þat
same side nounpower entriþ vndirneþ þat makeþ hem
wreches. ¶ In þis manere þanne moten kynges han
more porcioun of wrechednesse þan of welefulnesse.

2076

WER DOES NOT DRIVE AWAY CARE.

¶ A tyraunt þat was kyng of sisile þat had[de] assaied
þe peril of his estat shewid[e] by similitude þe dredes
of realmes by gastnesse of a swerde þat heng ouer þe
heued of his familier. what þing is þan þis power þat

2080

may nat don away þe bytynges of besines ne eschewe
þe prikkes of drede. and certys 3it wolden þei lyuen
*in sykernesse. but þei may nat. and 3it þei glorifien
hem in her power ¶ Holdest þou þan þat þilk[e] man

2084

be my3ty þat þou seest þat he wolde don þat he may
nat don. ¶ And holdest þou þan hym a my3ty man
þat haþ environed hise sydes wip men of armes or
seruauntes *and* dredeþ more [hem] þat he makeþ agast.

2088

If dominion brings
felicity, then misery will
follow if it be defective.

But human rule has its
limits, therefore
wherever power ceases
there impotence enters,
bringing misery along
with it.

Kings, therefore, have a
larger portion of misery
than of felicity.

Dionysius of Sicily,
conscious of this
condition, exhibited the
fears and cares of royalty
by the terror of a naked
sword hanging over the
head of his friend and
flatterer Damocles.
What then is this thing
called Power, which
cannot do away with
care or fear?
Men would live in
security but cannot, and
yet they glory in their
power.

[* fol. 18.]

Is he powerful who
cannot do what he
wishes?

Is he a mighty man who
goes surrounded with an
armed guard, to terrify
those whom he himself
fears, and whose power

þen þei dreden hym. *and* þat is put in þe handes of hise
seruaunt3. for he sholde seme my3ty but of familiers
[or] seruaunt3 of kynges. ¶ what sholde I telle þe
any þing. syn þat I my self haue shewed þe þat realmes
2092

hem self ben ful of gret feblenesse. þe whiche
familiaris
certis þe real power of kynges in hool estat *and* in estat
abated ful [ofte] þroweþ adoun. ¶ Nero constreined[e]
his familier *and* his maistre seneca to chesen on what
2096

deep he wolde deien. ¶ Antonius comaundid[e] þat
kny3tis slown wiþ her swerdis Papinian his familier
whiche Papinian had[de] ben long tyme ful my3ty
a-monges hem of þe courte. and 3it certis þei wolde
boþe 2100

han renounced her power. of whiche [two] senek
enforced[e]
hym to 3iuen to Nero his rychesses. *and* also
to han gon in to solitarie exil. ¶ But whan þe grete
wey3t. þat is to sein of lordes power or of fortune 2104
draweþ hem þat sholden falle. neyþer of hem ne
my3t[e] do þat he wolde. what þing is þanne þilke
power þat þou3 men han it þat þei ben agast. ¶ *and*
whan þou woldest han it þou nart nat siker. ¶ And 2108
yif þou woldest forleten it þou mayst nat eschewen it.
¶ But wheþir swiche men ben frendes at nede as ben
conseiled by fortune *and* nat by vertue. Certys swiche
folk as weleful fortune makeþ frendes. contrarious
fortune 2112

depends solely upon his
numerous retinue?

Why need I enlarge upon
the favourites of princes
having thus displayed
the imbecility of kings!

Their prosperity is
affected by the caprice of
their fortunate masters as
well as by the adversity
to which they are
incident.

Nero only allowed his
master Seneca to choose
the manner of his death.

Antonius (Caracalla)
commanded Papinian to
be slain by the swords of
his soldiers.

Yet both would have
given up all they
possessed.

Seneca begged for
poverty and exile. But
relentless fortune
precipitated them to
destruction, and did not
permit them to choose
their fate.

What then is Power,
which terrifies its
possessors, and which
cannot be got rid of at
pleasure?

No advantage is to be
gained by friendship
based on prosperity
instead of virtue.
Adversity will turn this
sort of friendship into
enmity. And what greater
plague can there be than

makeþ hem enmyse. ¶ And what pestilence is
more myzty forto anoye a wízt þan a familier enemy.

the enmity of thy
familiar friend?

2060 *myzty*—MS. vnmyzty, C. myhty

2062 *passep*—passed

of (2)—omitted

2063 *kynges þat han*—kynges ben

2066 *kepe*—kepen

2067 *maker*—makere

2069 *yif*—yit

realmes—the Reaumes

2070 *stretchen*—strechchen

myche—moche

2071 *hap*—MS. haþe

2073 *whiche*—whych

2074 *vndirneþ*—vndyr-nethe

2077 *had[de]*—hadde

2078 *shewid[e]*—shewede

2079 *realmes*—Reaumes

swerde—sward

heng—MS. henge, C. heng

2081 *besines*—bysynesse

2083 *zit*—yif

glorifien—gloryfye

2084 *pilk[e]*—thylke

2087 *hap*—MS. haþe

environed—enuyrownede

2088 [*hem*]*—from C.*

2089 *þen*—than

2091 [*or*]*—from C.*

2092 *realmes*—Reames

2093 *febleness*—feblesse

2094 *real*—Ryal

2095 [*ofte*]*—from C.*

constreined[e]—constreynede

2096 *his* (1)—hyr

seneca—Senek

2097 *comaundid[e]*—comaundede

2098 *her*—hyr

2099 *whiche*—which
 had[de] ben long—þat hadde ben longe
2100 *courte*—court
 wolde—wolden
2101 [*two*]—from C.
 enforced[e]—enforcede
2102 *ziuen*—yeuen
 his—hyse
2104 *weyzt*—weyhte
2105 *sholden*—sholen
2106 *myzt[e]*—myhte

ORY IS DECEPTIVE.

[QUI SE UALET](#) ⁵ [ESSE POTENTEM.](#)

[The 5th Metur.]

⁵ Read *uolet*

Who so wolde ben myzty he mot daunten hys cruel
 corage. ne put[te] nat his nekke ouercomen
vndir 2116
þe foule reines of lecherie. for al be it so þat þi
lordship[e]
strecche so fer þat þe contre Inde quakip at þi
comaundement. or at þi lawes. *and* þat þe leest isle in
þe see þat hyzt tile be þral to þe ¶ zit yif þou mayst 2120
nat puten away þi foule derk[e] desijres *and* dryuen
oute fro þe wreched compleyntes. Certis it nis no
power þat þou hast.

He who would obtain
sovereign power must
obtain conquest over
himself, and not yield to
his passions.
Though your dominion
extended from India to
Thule, yet if thou art
tormented by care thou
hast no real power.

2115 *wolde ben*—wole be
2116 *put[te]*—putte
2117 *lordship[e]*—lordshype
2119 *comaundement*—comaundement3
 leest isle—last Ile
2120 *hyzt*—hyhte
2121 *puten*—putten
 derk[e]—dyrke
2122 *oute*—owt

NTILITY IS FOREIGN TO RENOWN.

GLORIA UERO QUAM FALLAX.

[The 6th prose.]

B vt glorie how deceivable *and* how foule is it ofte.
for 2124

whiche þing nat vnskilfully a tregedien þat is to
sein a maker of dities þat hyȝten tregedies cried[e] *and*
seide. ¶ O glorie glorie *quod* he. þou nart no þing
ellys to þousandes of folkes. but a gret sweller of eres.

2128

for many[e] han had ful gret renoun by þe fals[e] oppinioun
of poeple. and what þing may ben þouȝt fouler
þen swiche preisyng for þilk[e] folk þat ben preised
falsly. þei moten nedes han shame of hir preisynges.

2132

and yif þat folk han geten hem þank or preysyng by
her desertes. what þing haþ þilk pris echid or encresed
to þe conscience of wise folk þat mesuren hire
good. not by þe rumour of þe poeple. but by þe soþefastnesse 2136

of conscience. *and* yif it seme a fair þing a
man to han encresid *and* sprad his name. þan folweþ
it. þat it is demed to ben a foule þinge yif it ne be
ysprad ne encresed. but as I seide a litel her byforne.

2140

þat syn þer mot nedes ben many folk to whiche folk þe
renoun of a man ne may nat comen. it byfalleþ þat he
þat þou wenest be glorious *and* renommed. semiþ in þe
nexte parties of þe erþe to ben wiþ out glorie. *and* wiþ 2144

out renoun. ¶ *and* certis amonges þise þinges I ne
trowe

nat þat þe pris *and* grace of þe poeple nis neiþer worþi

How deceptive and
deformed a thing is
glory! Well did the
Tragedian exclaim—ὦ
δόξα δόξα μυρίοισι δὴ
βροτῶν, οὐδὲν γεγῶσι
βίοντον ὀγκώσας μέγαν,
for the undeserving have
been crowned with glory
and renown by popular
and erring opinion.

What can be more
infamous than renoun
founded on the
prejudices of the vulgar?
Those that are
undeservedly praised
ought to blush for
shame.
If a wise man gets well-
merited praise it does not
add to his felicity.

If it be a good thing to
spread abroad one's
fame, it must be
dishonourable not to do
so.
But a good name cannot
penetrate everywhere,
and the most illustrious
names must be unknown
to the greatest part of the
world.

The favour of the people
is worth but little as it is
seldom judicious and
never permanent.

*to ben remembrid ne comeþ of wise iugement. ne is
ferm perdurably. ¶ But now of þis name of gentillesse.

2148

what man is it þat ne may wel seen how veyne *and*
how flittyng a þing it is. ¶ For if þe name of gentillesse
be referred to renoun *and* clernesse of linage. þan
is gentil name but a for[e]ine þing. þat is to sein to
hem þat glorifien hem of hir linage. ¶ For it semeþ
þat gentillesse be a maner preysynge þat comeþ of
decert

of auncestres. ¶ And yif preysynge makeþ gentillesse
þan moten þei nedes be gentil þat ben preysed. For
whiche þing it folweþ. þat yif þou ne haue no
gentillesse

of þi self. þat is to sein pris þat comeþ of þi deserte
foreine gentillesse ne makeþ þe nat gentil. ¶ But certis
yif þer be any goode in gentillesse. I trowe it be in al
2160

oonly þis. þat it semeþ as þat a maner necessitee be
imposed

to gentil men. for þat þei ne sholden nat outraien
or forliuen fro þe uertues of hire noble kynrede.

2124 *foule*—fowl

2125 *whiche*—whych

2126 *maker*—makere

cried[e]—cryde

2127 *he*—she

2128 *sweller*—swellere

2129 *many[e]*—manye

had—MS. hadde, C. had

fals[e]—false

2130 *fouler*—fowlere

[* fol. 18 b.]

How empty and
transitory are titles of
nobility!

Gentility is wholly
foreign to renown, and to
those who boast of noble
birth.

Nobility is fame derived
from the merits of one's
ancestors.

If praise can give
nobility they are noble
who are praised.

Then if thou hast no
nobility of thy own, thou
canst not derive any
splendour from the
merits of others.

If there be any good in
nobleness of birth, it
consists alone in this,
that it imposes an
obligation upon its
possessors not to
degenerate from the
virtues of their ancestors.

2131 *þen*—thanne
þilk[e]—thylke
 2133 *or*—of
 2134 *hap*—MS. haþe
þilke—thylke
 2139 *foule þinge*—fowl thing
 2140 *ne*—and
byforne—byforn
 2144 *parties*—partye
erþe—Erthes
out—owte
 2145 *out*—owhte
 2148 *ferm*—ferme
 2149 *veyne*—veyn
 2150 *if*—yif
 2154 *comeþ of*—comth of the
 2157 *whiche*—which
 2158 *pris*—preys
comeþ—comth
 2160 *goode*—good
in (2)—omitted
 2161 *maner*—manere

OMNE HOMINUM GENUS IN TERRIS.

Al þe linage of men þat ben in erþe ben of
 semblable 2164
 burþe. On al one is fadir of þinges. On alone
 minyst[r]eþ alle þinges. ¶ He 3af to þe sonne hys
 bemes. he 3af to þe moone hir hornes. he 3af þe men to
 þe erþe. he 3af þe sterres to þe heuene. ¶ he encloseþ
 2168
 wiþ membres þe soules þat comen fro hys heye sete.
 ¶ þanne comen alle mortal folk of noble seed. whi
 noysen 3e or bosten of 3oure eldris ¶ For yif þou
 look[e] 3oure bygynnyng. and god 3oure auctour *and*
 2172

[The 6th Metre.]

All men have the same origin.

They have one father and one king, who gave the moon her horns, and adorned the sun with his rays.

The same gave the earth to man and adorned the sky with stars.

He breathed into man the breath of life.

All men spring from this illustrious source.

Why then do they boast of pedigree?

He alone is ignoble who submits to vice and forgets his noble origin.

3oure makere. þan is þer no forlyued wyȝt but ȝif he
norisse his corage vnto vices *and* forlete his propre
burþe.

2166 *hys*—hyse

2167 *hir*—hyse

2169 *fro hys*—fram hyse

2170 *seed*—sede

2171 *bosten*—MS. voscen, C. bosten

2172 *look[e]*—loke

USUAL PLEASURES FULL OF ANXIETY.

[QUID AUTEM DE CORPORIBUS.](#) ⁶

But what shal I seie of delices of body. of whic[h]e
2176

delices þe desiringes ben ful of anguisse. *and* þe
fulfillinges of hem ben ful of penaunce. ¶ How grete
sekenesse *and* how grete sorwes vnsuffrable ryȝt as a
manere fruit of wickednesse ben þilke delices wont to
2180

bryngen to þe bo[d]ies of folk þat vsen hem. ¶ Of
whiche delices I not what ioie may ben had of hir
moeuyng. ¶ But þis woot I wel þat who so euere wil
remembren hym of hys luxuries. he shal wel
vndirstonde. 2184

þat þe issues of delices ben sorowful *and* sory.

¶ And yif þilke delices mowen make folk blisful. þan
by þe same cause moten þise bestes ben clepid blisful.
¶ Of whiche bestes al þe entencioun hastep to fulfille
2188

hire bodyly iolyte. and þe gladnesse of wijf [*and*]

[The 7th prose.]

⁶ Read *corporis
voluptatibus*.

But what shall I say with
respect to sensual
pleasures, the desire of
which is full of anxiety,
and the enjoyment of
them full of repentance?
What diseases and
intolerable pains (the
merited fruits of vice)
are these delights wont
to bring upon those who
enjoy them!

I am unable to see what
joy is to be found in the
gratification of them.
The remembrance of
criminal indulgence
brings with it bitter
remorse.

If such things make men
happy, then may brutes
attain to felicity, since by
their instinct they are
urged to satisfy their
bodily delights.

A wife and children do
not always bring

children were [an] honest þing. but it haþ ben seid.
 þat it is ouer myche azeins kynde þat children han ben
 founden tormentours to hir fadres I not how many. 2192
 ¶ Of whiche children how bitynge is euery condicioun.
 It nedep nat to tellen it þe þat hast or þis tyme assaied
 it. *and* art 3it now anguyssous. In þis approue I þe
 sentence of my disciple Euridippus. þat seide þat he
 2196
 þat haþ no children is weleful by infortune.

happiness, for some have
 found tormentors in their
 own offspring.

I approve of this opinion
 of Euripides, that he who
 is childless is happy in
 his misfortune.

2173 *is*—nis
 2176 *delices*—delites
 body—bodye
 2177 *anguisse*—Angwyssh
 2178 *grete*—gret
 2179 *sekenesse*—sykenesse
 grete sorwes—gret soruwes
 2180 *fruit*—frut
 2182 *had*—MS. hadde, C. had
 2183 *wil*—wole
 2184 *hys*—hyse
 2185 *sorrowful*—sorwful
 sory—sorye
 2186 *make*—makyn
 2189 [*and*]*—from C.*
 2190 [*an*]*—from C.*
 haþ—haþe
 seid—MS. seide, C. seyd
 2191 *myche*—mochel
 2192 *many*—manye
 2196 *Euridippus*—Eurydyppys; *read* Euripides
 2197 *haþ*—MS. haþe

HAPPINESS IN EXTERNAL THINGS.

[HABET HOC UOLUPTAS.](#)

[The 7^{de} Metur.]

Euery delit haþ þis. þat it anguisseþ hem wiþ prikkes

þat vsen it. ¶ It resemblip to þise flying flyes þat we clepen been. þat aftre þat þe bee haþ shed hys agreeable 2200

honies he fleep away *and* stynges þe hertes of hem þat ben ysmyte wiþ bytynge ouer longe holdynges.

2198 *Euery*—MS. Ouery, C. Every

2198, 2200 *haþ*—MS. haþe
shed hys—shad hyse

N ARE LED ASTRAY BY IGNORANCE.

NICHIL IGITUR DUBIUM EST.

Now nis it no doute þan þat þise weyes ne ben a maner mysledyng to blisfulnesse. ne þat þei ne 2204

mowe nat leden folke þider as þei byheten to leden hem. ¶ But wiþ how grete harmes þise *forseide weyes ben enlaced. ¶ I shal shewe þe shortly. ¶ For whi yif þou enforcest þe to assemble moneye. þou most by-reuen 2208

hym his moneye þat haþ it. and yif þou wilt shynen wiþ dignites. þou most bysechen *and* supplien hem þat 3iuen þo dignitees. ¶ And yif þou coueitest by honour to gon by-fore oþer folk þou shalt defoule þi 2212

self by humblesse of axing. yif þou desiryst power. þou shalt by awaites of þi subgit3 anoyously be cast vndir many periles. axest þou glorie þou shalt ben so

Pleasure leaves a pain behind it.

The bee gives us agreeable honey, but try to hold it, and it quickly flies, leaving its sting behind.

[The 8th prose.]

It appears then that happiness is not to be found in the above-mentioned external things.

[* fol. 19.]

These false ways are perplexed with many evils, as I shall presently show thee.

Do you want to amass wealth, then you must take it from your neighbours. Would you shine in dignities, then you must beg for them and disgrace yourself by a humiliating supplication.

If power be your ambition, you expose yourself to the snares of inferiors.

destrat by aspre þinges þat þou shalt forgone
sykernesse. 2216

¶ And yif þou wilt leden þi lijf in delices.
euery whiȝt shal dispisen þe *and* forleten þe as þou þat
art þral to þing þat is ryȝt foule *and* brutel. þat is [to]
sein seruaunt to þi body. ¶ Now is it þan wel yseen 2220
how lytel *and* how brutel possessioun þei coueiten þat
putten þe goodes of þe body abouen hire owen resoun.
¶ For mayst þou sourmounten þise olifuñtȝ in
gretnesse

or weyȝt of body. Or mayst þou ben strengier þan þe
2224

bole. Mayst þou ben swifter þan þe tigre. biholde þe
spaces *and* þe stablenesse *and* þe swyfte cours of þe
heuene. *and* stynte somtyme to wondren on foule
þinges. þe whiche heuene certys nis nat raper for þise
2228

þinges to ben wondred vpon. þan for þe resoun by
whiche it is gouerned. but þe shynyng of þi forme þat
is to seien þe beaute of þi body. how swiftly passyng is
it *and* how transitorie. ¶ Certis it is more flittyng 2232
þan þe mutabilite of floures of þe somer sesoun. For so
as aristotil telleþ þat yif þat men hadden eyen of a
beest þat hiȝt lynx. so þat þe lokyng of folk myȝt[e]
percen þoruȝ þe þinges þat wiþstonden it. who so lokid
2236

þan in þe entrailes of þe body of alcibiades þat was
ful fayr in þe superfice wiþ oute. it shulde seme ryȝt
foule. *and* for þi yif þou semest faire. þi nature ne
makip nat þat. but þe desceiuaunce of þe fieblesse of

Do you ask for glory, to
be distracted by
vexations and so lose all
security.

Do you prefer a
voluptuous life? Think
then that all men will
despise him who is a
thrall to his body.

They build upon a weak
foundation that place
bodily delights above
their own reason.

Can you surpass the
elephant in bulk, or the
bull in strength?

Art thou swifter than the
tiger?

Behold the immense
extent of the heavens and
cease to admire vile or
lesser things.

Admire what is still
more admirable, the
consummate wisdom
that governs them.

How fleeting is beauty!

It fades sooner than the
vernal flowers.

For, as Aristotle says, if a
man were lynx-eyed and
could look into the
entrails of Alcibiades (so
fair outwardly) he would
find all foul and
loathsome.

Thy nature does not
make thee seem
beautiful, but the

þe 2240

eyen þat loken. ¶ But preise þe goodes of þi body as
moche as euer þe list. so þat þou know[e] algates þat
what so it be. þat is to seyn of þe goodes of þi body
whiche þat þou wondrest vpon may ben destroyed or

2244

dessolued by þe hete of a feuere of þre dayes. ¶ Of
alle whiche forseide þinges I may reducen þis shortly in
a somme. ¶ þat þise worldly goodes whiche þat ne
mowen nat ȝiuen þat þei byheten. ne ben nat perfit by

2248

þe congregacioun of alle goodes. þat þei ne ben nat
weyes ne papes þat bryngen men to blysfulnesse ne
maken men to ben blysful.

imperfect view of thy
admirers.

Prize bodily perfections
as much as you will, yet
a three days' fever will
destroy them.

Worldly goods do not
give what they promise,
do not comprise every
good, are not the paths to
felicity, nor can of
themselves make any
one happy.

2203 *nis*—is

2204 *mysledyng*—mysledynges

2205 *folke*—folk

2208 *enforcest*—MS. enforced, C. enforcest

2209 *hap*—MS. haþe

wilt—wolt

2211 *ȝiuen*—yeuen

2212 *gon*—MS. gone, C. gon

by-fore—byforn

shalt—shal

2213 *by*—thorw

2214 *by*—be

be—ben

2216 *destrat*—MS. destralle, C. destrat

forgone—forgoon

2217 *wilt*—wolt

2218 *whizt*—wyht

2219 *foule*—fowl

[*to*]—from C.

2220 *yseen*—seen

2221 *brutel*—brotel

2222 *owen*—owne
 2224 *wey3t*—weyhty
 strenger—strengere
 2225 *swifter*—swyftere
 biholde—by-hold
 2227 *stynte*—stynt
 2228 *whiche*—whych
 2230 *whiche*—wych
 2231 *seien*—seyn
 2234 *as*—omitted
 2235 *hi3t*—hyhte
 my3t[e]—myhte
 2237 *alcibiades*—MS. *alcidiades*
 2238 *fayr*—fayre
 þe—omitted
 shulde—sholde
 2239 *foule*—fowl
 faire—fayr
 ne—omitted
 2240 *desceiuauunce of þe fieblesse*—deceyuable or the feblesse
 2242 *moche*—mochel
 know[e]—knowe
 2243 *þe*—omitted
 þi bodyliche—the body whych
 2247 *a*—omitted

N PURSUE FALSE JOYS.

HEU QUE MISEROS TRAMITE.

Allas *whiche folie andliche ignoraunce*
mysledip 2252
 wandryng wrecches fro þe pape of verrey good.
 ¶ Certis 3e ne seken no golde in grene trees. ne 3e ne
 gadren [nat] precious stones in þe vines. ne 3e ne
 hiden nat 3oure gynnes in hey3e mountaignes to
 kachen 2256
 fische of *whiche 3e may maken ryche festes. and yif*

[The 8th Metur.]

Alas! how through folly
 and ignorance do men
 stray from the path of
 true happiness!

Ye do not seek gold upon
 trees nor diamonds from
 the vine.

Ye lay not your nets to
 catch fish upon the lofty
 hills.

The hunter goes not to
 the Tyrrhene waters to

3ow lykeþ to hunte to roos. 3e ne gon nat to þe foordes
of þe water þat hy3t tyrene. *and* ouer þis men knowen
wel þe crikes *and* þe cauernes of þe see yhidd in þe

2260

floodes. *and* knowen eke whiche water is most plentiuous
of white perles. *and* knowen whiche water habundeþ
most of rede purple. þat is to seyen of a maner shelfisshe

with whiche men dien purple. *and* knowen 2264

whiche strondes habunden most of tendre fisshes or
of sharpe fisshes þat hy3ten echynnys. but folk suffren
hem self to ben so blynde þat hem ne recchiþ nat to
knowe where þilk[e] goodes ben yhidd whiche þat þei

2268

coueiten but ploungen hem in erþe *and* seken þere
þilke goode þat sourmunteþ þe heuene þat bereþ þe
sterres. ¶ what *preyere may I make þat be digne to
þe nice þou3tis of men. but I preye þat þei coueiten

2272

rycches *and* honours so þat whan þei han geten þo
false goodes wiþ greet trauayle þat þerby þei mowe
knowen þe verray goodes.

2252 *whiche (both)*—whych

2253 *pape*—paath

good—goode

2254 *golde*—gold

hunt the roe.

Men know where to look
for white pearls, and for
the fish that yields the
purple dye.

They know where the
most delicate of the
finny race abound and
where the fierce sea-
urchin is to be found.
But where the Sovereign
Good abides blinded
mortals never know, but
plunge into the earth
below to look for that
which has its dwelling in
the heavens.

[* fol. 19 b.]

What doom do the silly
race deserve?

May they pursue such
false joys, and having
obtained them, too late
find out the value of the
true.

E INSUFFICIENCY OF WORLDLY BLISS.

HACTENUS MENDACIS FORMAM.

I T suffisiþ þat I haue shewed hider to þe forme of
2276

[The 9^{ne} prose.]

P. I have been describing
the form of counterfeit
happiness, and if you

false wilfulnesse. so þat yif þou look[e] now clerely
þe ordre of myn entencioun requerib from hennes
forþe

to shewen þe verray wilfulnesse. ¶ For *quod* .I. (b) [I.]
se wel now þat suffisaunce may nat comen by richesse.
ne 2280

power by realmes. ne reuerence by dignitees. ne
gentillesse

by glorie. ne ioye by delices. and (p) hast þou wel
knownen *quod* she þe cause whi it is. Certis me semep
quod .I. þat .I. se hem ryzt as þou3 it were þoru3 a litel 2284

clifte. but me were leuer knownen hem more openly of
þe. Certys *quod* she þe resoun is al redy ¶ For
þilk þing þat symply is on þing wiþ outen ony
diuisioun. þe errour *and* folie of mankynde departeþ
2288

and diuidiþ it. *and* mislediþ it *and* transporteþ from
verray *and* perfit goode. to goodes þat ben false *and*
inperfit. ¶ But seye me þis. wenest þou þat he þat hap
nede of power þat hym ne lakkeþ no þing. Nay *quod*
2292

.I. ¶ Certis *quod* she þou seist aryzt. For yif so be
þat þer is a þing þat in any partie be fieble of power.
Certis as in þat it most[e] nedes be nedy of foreine
helpe. ¶ Rizt so it is *quod* .I. Suffisaunce and power
2296

ben þan of on kynde ¶ So semep it *quod* I. ¶ And
demyst þou *quod* she þat a þing þat is of þis manere.
þat is to seine suffisaunt *and* myzty auzt[e] to ben
dispised.

have considered it
attentively I shall
proceed to give you a
perfect view of the true.

B. I now see that there is
no sufficiency in riches,
no power in royalty, no
esteem in dignities, nor
nobility in renown, nor
joy in carnal pleasures.

I have a glimpse of the
cause of all this, but I
should like a more
distinct view.

P. The cause is obvious
—for that which is by
nature one and
indivisible human
ignorance separates and
divides, and reverses the
true order of things.

Does that state which
needs nothing stand in
need of power?

B. I should say no. *P.*
Right! That which wants
power needs external
aid.

B. That is true! *P.*
Sufficiency and power
therefore are of one
nature. *B.* It seems so
indeed.

P. Are power and
sufficiency to be
despised? Are they not
rather worthy of
universal respect?

or ellys þat it be ryzt digne of reuerences abouen 2300
alle þinges. ¶ Certys quod I it nys no doute þat it
nis ryzt worpi to ben reuerenced. ¶ Lat vs quod she þan
adden reuerence to suffisaunce *and* to power ¶ So þat
we demen þat þise þre þinges ben alle o þing. ¶ Certis
2304

quod I lat vs adden it. yif we willen graunten þe soþe.
what demest þou þan quod she is þat a dirke þing *and*
nat noble þat is suffisaunt reuerent *and* myzty. or ellys
þat is ryzt clere *and* ryzt noble of celebrete of renoun.
2308

E UNITY OF TRUE FELICITY.

¶ Considere þan quod she as we han grauntid her
byforne.
þat he þat ne haþ ne[de] of no þing *and* is most
myzty *and* most digne of honour yif hym nedip any
clernesse of renoun whiche clernesse he myzt[e] nat
2312

graunten of hym self. ¶ So þat for lakke of þilke
clerenesse he myzt[e] seme febler on any syde or þe
more outcaste. *Glosa.* þis is to seyne nay. ¶ For who
so þat is suffisaunt myzty *and* reuerent. clernesse of
2316

renoun folweþ of þe forseide þinges. he haþ it alredy of
hys suffisaunce. boice. I may nat quod I denye it.
¶ But I mot graunten as it is. þat þis þing be ryzt
celebrable by clernesse of renoun *and* noblesse. ¶ þan
2320

folweþ it quod she þat we adden clernesse of renoun to

B. They are doubtless highly estimable. *P.* Add respect to sufficiency and power, and consider all three as one and the same thing.

B. I see no objection to that view.

P. But can that be obscure and ignoble which possesses three such attributes? is it not noble and worthy of a shining reputation?

He who is most powerful and worthy of renown—if he lack fame which he cannot give to himself, must (by this defect) seem in some measure more weak and abject.

He that is sufficiently mighty and esteemed will have necessarily an illustrious name.

B. I cannot deny it, for reputation seems inseparable from the advantages you have just mentioned.

P. Therefore Renown differs in no wise from the three above-mentioned attributes.

þe þre forseide þinges. so þat þer ne be amonges hem
no difference. *and* þis is a consequente *quod* .I. þis
þing þan *quod* she þat ne haþ no nede of no foreine

2324

þing. *and* þat may don alle þinges by his strengþes.
and þat is noble *and* honourable. nis nat þat a myrie
þing *and* a ioyful. *boice*. but wenest *quod* I þat any
sorow myȝt[e] comen to þis þing þat is swiche. ¶

Certys 2328

I may nat þinke. *P.* ¶ þanne moten we graunt[e] *quod*
she þat þis þing be ful of gladnesse yif þe þorseide
þinges

be soþe. ¶ And also certys mote we graunten. þat
suffisaunce power noblesse reuerence *and* gladnesse
ben 2332

only dyuerse bynames. but hir substaunce haþ no
diuersite. *Boice*. It mot nedely be so *quod* .I. *P.* þilke
þinge þan *quod* she þat is oon *and* simple in his nature.
þe wikkednesse of men departiþ it *diuidiþ it. *and* 2336
whan þei enforcen hem to gete *partie* of a þing þat ne
haþ no part. þei ne geten hem neiþer þilk[e] *partie* þat
nis none. ne þe þing al hole þat þei ne desire nat. .*b.*

In whiche manere *quod* .I. *p.* þilke man *quod* she þat
2340

sekeþ rychesse to fleen pouerte. he ne trauayleþ hym
nat to for to gete power for he haþ leuer ben dirk *and*
vile. *and* eke wiþdraweþ from hym selfe many naturel
delitȝ for he nolde lesen þe moneye þat he haþ
assembled. 2344

but certis in þis manere he ne getiþ hym nat

And if any one then
stands in need of no
external aid, can have all
he wants, and is
illustrious and respected
—is not his condition
very agreeable and
pleasant?

B. I cannot conceive how
such a one can have grief
or trouble.

P. It must then be a state
of happiness; and we
may also affirm that
sufficiency, power,
nobility, differ only in
name, but not in
substance.

B. It is a necessary
consequence.

P. The depravity of
mankind then divides
that which is essentially
indivisible; and, seeking
for a part of that which
has no parts, they miss
the entire thing which
they so much desire.

[* fol. 20.]

B. How is that?

P. He that seeks riches in
order to avoid poverty, is
not solicitous about
power; he prefers
meanness and obscurity,
and denies himself many
natural pleasures that he
may not lessen his heaps
of pelf.

He who lacks power, is
pricked with trouble, and
rendered an outcast and

suffisaunce þat power forletip. *and* þat moleste prekeþ.
and þat filþe makeþ outcaste. *and* þat derknesse hideþ.
 and certis he þat desireþ only power he wastip *and* 2348
 scatrip rychesse *and* dispiseþ delices *and* eke honour
 þat is wiþ out power. ne he ne preiseþ glorie no þing.

FALSE FELICITY.

¶ Certys þus seest þou wel þat many þingus failen to
 hym. for he haþ somtyme faute of many necessites.

2352

and many anguysses biten hym ¶ *and* whan he may
 nat don þo defautes away. he forleteþ to ben myzty.
and þat is þe þing þat he most desireþ. *and* ryzt þus
 may I make semblable resouns of honours *and* of
 glorie 2356

and of delices. ¶ For so as euery of þise forseide
 þinges is þe same þat þise oþer þinges ben. þat is to
 sein. al oon þing. who so þat euer sekeþ to geten þat
 oon of þise *and* nat þat oþer. he ne geteþ nat þat he 2360
 desireþ. *Boice*. ¶ what seist þou þan yif þat a man
 coueiteþ to geten alle þise þinges to gider. *P*. Certys
quod she .I. wolde seie þat he wolde geten hym
 souereyne

blisfulnes. but þat shal he nat fynde in þo þinges 2364
 þat .I. haue shewed þat ne mowe nat zeuen þat þei by-
 heten.

boice. Certys no *quod* .I. ¶ þan *quod* she ne
 sholden men nat by no weye seken blysfulnesse in
 swiche þinges as men wenen þat þei ne mowe 2368
 zeuen but o þing senglely of alle þat men seken.

obscure by his sordid
 ways, does not possess
 sufficiency.

He who only aims at
 power squanders his
 riches, and despises
 delights and honours
 unaccompanied by
 power.

Such a one must be
 subject to many
 anxieties.

And when he cannot get
 rid of these evils he
 ceases to have what he
 most desired—power.

In the same way honour,
 glory, and pleasure, are
 all inseparable; he that
 seeks one without the
 other will fail to obtain
 his desires.

B. What then if a man
 should desire to gain
 them all at once?

P. He would then indeed
 desire perfect felicity—
 but can he ever expect to
 find it in the acquisitions
 above mentioned, which
 do not perform what they
 promise?

B. No, surely!

P. Then happiness is not
 to be sought in these
 things which are falsely
 supposed capable of
 satisfying our desires?

I graunt[e] wel quod .I. ne no soþer þing ne may nat
ben said. *P.* ¶ Now hast þou þan quod she þe forme
and þe causes of false welefulnesse. ¶ Now turne and
2372

flitte þe eyen of þi þouȝt. for þere shalt þou seen an
oon

pilk verray blysfulnesse þat I haue byhyȝt þee. *b.*
Certys quod .I. it is cler and opyn. þouȝ þat it were to
a blynde man. and þat shewedest þou me [ful wel] a
2376

lytel her byforne. whan þou enforcedest þe to shewe me
þe causes of þe false blysfulnesse ¶ For but yif I be by-
giled.

þan is þilke þe verray perfit blisfulnesse þat perfitly
makip a man suffisaunt. myȝty. honourable noble. 2380
and ful of gladnesse. and for þou shalt wel knowe þat I
haue wel vndirstonden þise þinges wiþ inne myne
herte.

I knowe wel þilke blisfulnesse þat may verrayly ȝeuen
on of þe forseide þinges syn þei ben al oon .I. knowe 2384
douteles þat þilke þing is þe fulle of blysfulnesse.

P. O my nurry quod she by þis oppinioun quod she I
sey[e] þat þou art blisful yif þou putte þis þer to þat I
shal seine. what is þat quod .I. ¶ Trowest þou þat 2388
þer be any þing in þis erþely mortal toublyng þinges
þat may bryngen þis estat. Certys quod I trowe it nat.
and þou hast shewed me wel þat ouer þilke goode þer
is no þing more to ben desired. *P.* þise þinges þan 2392
quod she. þat is to seyne erþely suffisaunce and power.
and swiche þinges eyþer þei semen likenesse of verray

B. I confess it, and
nothing can be more
truly affirmed than this.

Turn your mind's eye
upon the reverse of all
this *false felicity* and you
will perceive *the true*
happiness.

B. It is very clear, and I
had a complete view of it
when you explained to
me the causes of its
counterfeit.

True felicity consists in a
state of sufficiency, of
power, and honour—as
well as of a shining
reputation and every
desirable pleasure: and I
must confess that true
felicity is that which is
bestowed by these
advantages, as they are
in reality all one and the
same.

P. O my nursling, how
happy are you in this
conviction, provided you
add but one limitation.

B. What is that?

P. Thinkest thou that any
thing in this world can
confer this happiness?
(the sovereign good).

B. I think not; for
nothing can be desirable
beyond such a state of
perfection.

P. These imperfect things
above mentioned only

goode. or ellys it semeþ þat þei 3euen to mortal folk a
maner of goodes þat ne ben nat perfit. ¶ But þilke 2396
goode þat is verray *and* perfit. þat may þei nat 3euen.
boice. I. accorde me wel quod .I. þan quod she for as
moche as þou hast knowen whiche is þilke verray
blisfulnesse.

and eke whiche þilke þinges ben þat lien 2400
falsly blisfulnesse. þat is to seyne. þat by desceit
semen verray goodes. ¶ Now byhoueþ þe to knowen
*whennes *and* where þou mowe seek[e] þilke verray
blisfulnesse. ¶ Certys quod I þat desijr I gretly *and* 2404
haue abiden longe tyme to herkene it. ¶ But for as
moche quod she as it likeþ to my disciple plato in his
book of *in thimeo*. þat in ry3t lytel þinges men sholde
bysechen þe helpe of god. ¶ what iugest þou þat be 2408
[now] to done so þat we may deserue to fynde þe sete
of

þilke souereyne goode. *B.* ¶ Certys quod .I. I. deme
þat we shulle clepen to þe fadir of alle goodes. ¶ For
wiþ outen hym nis þer no þing founden ary3t. þou seist
2412

a-ry3t quod she. and bygan on-one to syngen ry3t þus.

2256 *heyze*—the hyye

kachen—kachche

2257 *fisshe*—fyssh

2258 *hunte*—honte

roos—Rooes

2259 *hyzt*—hyhte

2260 *crikes*—brykes

yhidd—MS. yhidde, C. I-hyd

2261, 2262 *whiche*—whyh

2263 *shelfisshe*—shelle fysh

2264, 2265 *whiche*—whyh

confer the shadow of the
supreme good, or at most
only an imperfect
felicity, but they cannot
bestow true and perfect
happiness.

B. I quite agree with you.

P. Then, knowing the
difference between true
and false felicity you
must now learn where to
look for this supreme
felicity.

[* fol. 20 b.]

P. But, as Plato says that
even in the least things
the Divine assistance
ought to be implored,
what ought we do, to
render us worthy of so
important a discovery as
the true source and seat
of the sovereign good?

B. Let us invoke the
Father of all things.

You are right, said
Philosophy, and thus she
sang:—

2264 *dien*—deyen
2265 *of*—with
2266 *echynnys*—MS. ethynnys, C. Echynnys
2268 *yhidd*—MS. yhidde, C. I-hydd
2270 *goode*—good
2271 *make*—maken
2273 *rycches*—Rychesse
2277 *wilfulnesse*—welefulnesse
 look[e]—loke
 clerely—clerly
2279 *wilfulnesse*—welefulnesse
 For—For-sothe
 [I.]—from C.
2280 *richesse*—Rychesses
2281 *realmes*—Reames
2287 *pilk*—thylke
 on—o
2290 *goode*—good
2291 *seye*—sey
 hap—MS. haþe
2294 *fioble*—feblere
2295 *most[e]*—mot
2296 *helpe*—help
2297 *on*—o
2298 *demyst þou*—demesthow
2299 *seine*—seyn
 au3t[e]—owhte
2300 *reuerences*—Reuerence
2302 *nis ry3t*—is ryht
2304 *alle*—al
2305 *willen*—wolen
2306 *dirke*—dyrk
2308 *clere*—cler
 of celebrete—by celebryte
2310 *hap*—MS. haþe
2312 *whiche*—whych
 myzt[e]—myhte
2314 *clerenesse*—clernesse
 myzt[e]—myhte
 febler—the febelere
2315 *seyne*—seyn

2317 *hap*—MS. haþe
2324 *hap*—MS. haþe
2325 *his*—hyse
2326 *myrie*—mery
2327 *wenest*—whennes
2328 *sorow myȝt[e]*—sorwe myhte
2329 *graunt[e]*—graunte
2331 *be*—ben
 also certys—certes also
2333 *hap*—MS. haþe
2334 *nedely*—nedly
2335 *þinge*—thing
2337 *gete*—geten
2338 *hap*—MS. haþe
 þilk[e]—thilke
2339 *none*—non
 hole—hool
2340 *whiche*—whyh
2341 *rychesse*—Rychesses
 fleen—MS. sleen, C. flen
2342 *leuer*—leuer
2343 *vile*—vyl
 selfe—self
2344 *delitȝ*—delices
 lesen—lese
 hap—MS. haþe
2346 *prekeþ*—prykketh
2347 *derknesse*—dyrknesse
2349 *scatriþ*—schatereth
 delices—delycȝ
2350 *wip out*—with owte
2351 *many*—manye
2352 *hap*—MS. haþe
 faute—defaute
2353 *may*—ne may
2354 *don*—MS. done, C. don
2356 *make*—maken
2357 *forseide*—MS. sorseide
2363 *souereyne*—souereyn
2365 *mowe*—mowen

2368 *wenen*—wene
 mowe—mowen
 2370 *graunt[e]*—graunte
 soþer—sothere
 2371 *said*—MS. saide, C. sayd
 2376 [*ful wel*]*—*from C.
 2377 *byforne*—by-forn
 2378 *blysfulnesse*—MS. blyndenesse, C. blysfulnesse
 2385 *of*—omitted
 2386 *nurry*—norye
 2387 *sey[e]*—seye
 2388 *seine*—seyn
 2389 *þis*—thise
 2390 *nat*—nawht
 2393 *seyne*—sey
 2395 *zeuen*—yeue
 2397 *goode*—good
 2399 *whiche*—which
 2401 *seyne*—seyn
 2402 *known*—knowe
 2403 *seek[e]*—seke
 2405 *herkene*—herknen
 2407 *sholde*—sholden
 2408 *bysechen*—by-shechen
 helpe—help
 2409 [*now*]*—*from C.
 2410 *souereyne goode*—verray good
 2411 *shulle*—shollen
 to—omitted
 2413 *on-one*—anon

SEEKING SUPREME FELICITY THE DIVINE AID IS TO BE
 ED.

[O QUI PERPETUA.](#)

[The 9^{ne} Metur.]

O þou fadir creatour of heuene *and* of erþes þat
 gouernest þis worlde by *perdurable* resoun þat
 comaundist

O Father and Maker of
 heaven and earth, by
 whose eternal reason the
 world is governed, and
 by whose supreme

þe tymes for to gon from tyme þat age had[de] 2416
bygynnyng. þou þat dwellest þi self ay stedfast *and*
stable *and* ziuest alle oþer þinges to ben moeued. ne
forein causes necesseden þe neuer to compoune werke
of floterynge mater. but only þe forme of souereyne
2420

goode y-set wiþ inne [þe] wiþ outen envie þat
moeued[e]

þe frely. þou þat art alperfairest beryng þe faire worlde
in þi þouzt. formedest þis worlde to þe likkenesse
semblable of þat faire worlde in þi þouzt. þou drawest
2424

alle þinges of þi souereyne ensampler. *and*
comaundedist

þat þis worlde perfitlyche ymaked haue frely *and*
absolut hyse perfit parties. ¶ þou byndest þe element³
by noumbres proporcionables. þat þe colde þinges 2428
mowen accorde wiþ þe hote þinges. *and* þe drye
þinges

wiþ þe moyst þinges. þat þe fire þat is purest ne fleye
nat ouer heye. ne þat þe heuynesse ne drawe nat adoun
ouer lowe þe erþes þat ben plounged in þe watres. 2432

D IS THE FOUNTAIN OF FELICITY.

¶ þou knytttest to-gidre þe mene soule of treble kynde
moeuyng alle þinges. *and* diuidest it by membres
accordynge.

¶ And whan it is þus diuided it hap assembled
a moeuyng in two roundes. ¶ It goþ to tourne 2436
aȝein to hym owen self. *and* environēþ a fulle deep

command Time flows
from the birth of ages,
Thou, firm and
unchanged thyself,
makest all things else to
move!

Thy sovereign will to
floating matter gave its
various forms, impelled
by no exterior causes,
but by the Idea of the
Best in thy great mind
conceived void of
malice.

Fairest thyself bearing
the world's figure in thy
thought, thou didst create
the world after that
prototype, and dost draw
all things from the image
of the fair Supreme, and
dost command that this
world should have
perfect parts.

By harmonious measures
thou dost bind fast the
elements, so that there is
no discordance between
things cold and hot, or
between the moist and
the dry.

That the fire may not fly
too high, and that weight
may not press the earth
and water lower than
they are now placed,

thou didst join the
Middle Soul (of a
threefold nature) moving
all things, and then by
agreeing numbers didst
resolve it.

When that is done, cut
into two orbs, it moves
about returning to itself,
and then encompassing
the profound mind doth

þouȝt. *and* tourniþ þe heuene by semblable ymage. þou
by euenlyk causes enhaunsest þe soules *and* þe lasse
liues *and* ablynge hem heye by lyȝt[e] cartes. þou 2440
sewest hem in to heuene *and* in to erþe. *and* whan þei
ben conuertid to þe by þi benigne lawe. ¶ þou makest
hem retorne aȝeine to þe by aȝein ledyng fiȝr.

¶ O fadir yif þou to þi þouȝt to stien vp in to þi streite
sete. 2444

and graunte [hym] to enviroune þe welle of good. *and*
þe lyȝte yfounde graunte hym to ficchen þe clere syȝtes
of hys corage in þe. ¶ And scatre þou *and* to-breke
[thow] þe weyȝtes *and* þe cloudes of erþely heuynesse.
2448

and shyne þou by þi bryȝtnes. for þou art clernesse þou
art peisible to debonaire folke. ¶ þou þi self art
bygynnyng.

berere. ledere. paþ *and* terme to loke on þe
[paþ] is oure ende. *Glose.* 2452

by that fair idea turn the
heaven.

Thou by such causes
dost raise all souls and
lesser lives, and adaptest
them to their light
vehicles.

Thou sowest them in
heaven and earth, and
they return to thee by thy
kind law like a recoiling
flame.

O Father, elevate our
souls and let them
behold thy august throne.

Let them behold the
fountain of all good.
Dispel the mists of
sense, remove the
weights of earth-born
cares, and in thy
splendour shine (in our
minds).

For thou art ever clear,
and to the good art peace
and rest. He who looks
on thee beholds
beginning, support,
guide, path and goal,
combined!

2415 *worlde*—world

2416 *from*—*age*—from syn þat age
had[de]—hadde

2417 *stedfast*—stedefast

2418 *oper*—oothre

2419 *forein*—foreyne
werke—werk

2420 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good

2421 *y-set*—MS. y-sette, C. Iset

wiþ inne—with in

[*þe*]—the

wiþ outen—with owte

moeued[e]—moeuede

2422 *alþerfairest*—alderfayrest

2422-24-26 *worlde*—world

2423 *likkenesse*—lyknesse

2426 *and absolut*—C. omits
 2427 *hyse*—hys
 2430 *fire*—fyr
 fleye—fle
 2431 *drawe*—drawen
 2435 *hap*—MS. haþe
 2436 *gop*—MS. goþe
 2437 *owen*—C. omits
 2438 *tournip*—MS. tourniþe
 2439 *euenlyk*—eueene lyke
 2440 *lyzt[e]*—lyhte
 2442 *benigne*—bygynnyng
 2444 *yif*—yiue
 þi streite—the streyte
 2445 [*hym*]—from C.
 2446 *lyzte*—lyht
 2448 [*thow*]—from C.
 2449 *bryztnes*—bryhtnesse
 2451 *pap*—MS. paþe; paath
 2452 [*þat*]—that

D THE SUPREME GOOD.

[QUONIAM IGITUR QUI SCIT.](#) ⁷

F Or as moche þan as þou hast seyn. whiche is þe
 forme of goode þat nys nat perfit. *and* whiche is þe
 forme of goode þat is perfit. now trowe I þat it were
 goode to shewe in what þis perfeccioun of blisfulnesse
 is 2456
 set. *and* in þis þing I trowe þat we sholden first
 enquire
 forto witen yif þat any swiche manere goode as þilke
 goode þat þou hast diffinissed a lytel her byforne. þat
 is to seine souereyne goode may be founden in þe
 nature 2460

[The 10th prose.]

⁷ Read que sit.

Now that thou hast had a faithful representation of future felicity as well as of the true happiness, I shall show thee in what the Perfection of Happiness consists.

Our best plan will be to inquire whether there be in nature such a good as thou hast lately defined, lest we be deceived by the vanity of Imagination and be carried beyond the truth of the matter subjected to our inquiry.

of þinges. For þat veyne ymaginacioun of þouȝt ne
desceiue vs nat. *and* putte vs oute of þe soþefastnesse
of þilke þinge þat is summyttid to vs. þis is to seyne.
but it may nat ben denoyed þat þilke goode ne is. 2464

¶ *and* þat it nis ryȝt as a welle of alle goodes. ¶ For
al þing þat is cleped *inperfit*. is proued *inperfit* by þe
amenusynge of *perfeccioun*. or of þing þat is *perfit*.

and

her of comeþ it. þat in euery þing general. yif þat. þat

2468

men seen any þing þat is *inperfit* *certys in þilke general
þer mot ben somme þing þat is *perfit*. ¶ For yif so
be þat *perfeccioun* is don away. men may nat þinke
nor seye fro whennes þilke þing is þat is cleped *inperfit*. 2472

¶ For þe nature of þinges ne token nat her bygynnyng
of þinges amenused *and inperfit*. but it procediþ of
þingus þat ben al hool. *and absolut. and* descendeþ so
doune in to outerest þinges *and* in to þingus empty *and*

2476

wiþ oute fruyt. but as I haue shewed a litel her byforne.
þat yif þer be a blisfulnesse þat be frele *and vein and*
inperfit. þer may no man doute. þat þer nys som
blisfulnesse

þat is sad stedfast *and perfit*. b. þis is concludid 2480
quod I fermely *and soþefastly*. *P.* But considere
also *quod* she in wham þis blisfulnesse enhabiteþ. þe
commune acordaunce *and* conceite of þe corages of
men

proueþ *and* graunteþ þat god prince of alle þingus is 2484
good. ¶ For so as no þing ne may ben þouȝt better þan

The sovereign good does
exist, and is the source of
all other good.

When we say that a thing
is *imperfect* we assert
that there is something
else of its kind *perfect*.

* fol. 21.

Nature takes not her
origin from things
diminished and
imperfect; but,
proceeding from an
entire and absolute
substance, descends into
the remotest and most
fruitless things.

If there be an imperfect
and fading felicity there
must also be one stable
and perfect.

But now consider
wherein this felicity
resides. That God is the
governor of all things is
proved by the universal
opinion of all men.

For since nothing may be
conceived better than
God, then He who has no

god. it may nat ben doutyd þan þat [he þat] no þing is
bette. þat he nys good. ¶ Certys resoun shewep þat
god is so goode þat it prouep by verray force þat perfit
2488

goode is in hym. ¶ For yif god ne is swiche. he ne
may nat ben prince of alle þinges. for certis som þing
possessyng in hym self perfit goode sholde ben more
þan god. *and* [it] sholde seme þat þilke þing were first
2492

and elder þan god. ¶ For we han shewed apertly þat
alle þinges þat ben perfit. ben first or þinges þat ben
inperfit.

D THE SOURCE OF TRUE FELICITY.

¶ And for þi for as moche as [that] my resoun
or my proces ne go nat away wipoute an ende. we 2496
ou3t[e] to graunten þat þe souereyne god is ry3t ful of
souereyne perfit goode. and we han establissyd þat þe
souereyne goode is verrey blisfulnesse. þan mot it
nedes
ben [þat verray blyfulnesse is] yset in souereyne god.
2500

B. þis take I wel *quod* .I. ne þis ne may nat be wipseyd
in no manere. ¶ But I preie þe *quod* she see now how
þou mayst preuen holily *and* wip-outen corrupcioun
þis
þat I haue seyd. þat þe souereyne god is ry3t ful of 2504
souereyne goode. [In whych manere *quod* I.] wenest
þou ou3t *quod* she þat þis prince of alle þinges haue
ytake þilke souereyne good any where þan of hym self.

equal in goodness must
be good.

Reason clearly
demonstrates (1) that
God is good, and (2) that
the sovereign good exists
in him.

If it were not so He
could not be the Ruler of
all things, for there
would be some other
being excelling him who
possesses the supreme
good and who must have
existed before Him.

And we have already
shown that the perfect
precedes the imperfect;

wherefore, that our
reasonings may not run
on with infinity, we must
confess that the Supreme
God is full of perfect and
consummate good.

And as we have seen that
the perfect good is true
happiness, it follows that
the true felicity resides in
the Supreme Divinity.

But let us see how we
can firmly and
irrefragably prove that
the Supreme God
contains in his own
nature a plenitude of
perfect and consummate
good.

¶ of whiche souereyne goode men proueþ þat he is ful 2508
ryzt as þou myztest þinken. þat god þat haþ blisfulnesse
in hym self. *and* þat ilke blisfulnesse þat is in hym
were diuers in substaunce. ¶ For yif þou wene þat
god haue receyued þilke good oute of hym self. þou
2512

mayst wene þat he þat 3af þilke good to god. be more
goode þan is god. ¶ But I am byknowen *and* confesse
and þat ryzt dignely þat god is ryzt worþi abouen alle
þinges. ¶ And yif so be þat þis good be in hym by 2516
nature. but þat it is diuers from [hym] by wenyng
resoun. syn we speke of god prince of alle þinges
feyne

who so feyne may. who was he þat [hath] conioigned
þise diuers þinges to-gidre. *and* eke at þe last[e] se 2520
wel þat o þing þat is diuers from any þing. þat þilke
þing nis nat þat same þing. fro whiche it is
vndirstonden

to ben diuers. þan folweþ it. þat þilke þing þat
by hys nature is dyuers from souereyne good. þat þat
2524

þing nys nat souereyne good. but certys þat were a
felonous corsednesse to þinken þat of hym. þat no þing
nis more worþe. For alwey of alle þinges. þe nature
of hem ne may nat ben better þan his bygynnyng. 2528

ERE CANNOT BE TWO CHIEF GOODS.

¶ For whiche I may concluden by ryzt uerray resoun.
þat þilke þat is bygynnyng of alle þinges. þilke same

If you think that God has received this good from without, then you must believe that the giver of this good is more excellent than God the receiver.

But we have concluded that there is nothing more excellent than God.

But if this supreme good is in Him by nature, and is nevertheless of a different substance, we cannot conceive, since God is the author of all things, what could have united these two substances differing one from another.

Lastly, a thing which essentially differs from another cannot be the same with that from which it is supposed to differ.

Consequently, what in its nature differs from the chief good cannot be the supreme good.

But it would be impious and profane thus to conceive of God, since nothing can excel Him in goodness and worth.

In fact, nothing can exist whose nature is better than its origin.

We may therefore conclude that the Author of all things is really and

þing is good in his substaunce. *B.* þou hast seid
ry3tfully

quod .I. *P.* But we han graunted *quod* she þat 2532
souereyne good is blysfulnes. þat is soþe *quod* .I. þan
quod she mote we nedes graunten *and* confessen þat
þilke same souereyne goode be god. ¶ Certys **quod*
.I. I ne may nat denye ne wipstonde þe resouns
purposed. 2536

and I see wel þat it folweþ by strengþe of þe
premisses. ¶ Loke nowe *quod* she yif þis be proued
[yit] more fermely þus. ¶ þat þer ne mowen nat ben
two souereyne goodes þat ben diuerse amo[n]ges hem
2540

self. þat on is nat þat þat oþer is. þan [ne] mowen
neiþer of hem ben *perfit*. so as eyþer of hem lakkþ to
oþir. but þat þat nis nat *perfit* men may seen apertly
þat it nis nat souereyne. þe þinges þan þat ben 2544
souereynely goode ne mowen by no wey ben diuerse.

¶ But I haue wel conclude þat blisfulnesse *and* god ben
[the] souereyne goode. For whiche it mot nedes be þat
souereyne blisfulnesse is souerey[ne] dyuynite. ¶ No
2548

þing *quod* I nis more soþefast þan þis ne more ferme
by

resoun. ne a more worþi þing þan god may nat ben
concluded. *P.* vpon þise þinges þan *quod* she. ry3t as
þise geometriens whan þei han shewed her
proposiciouns 2552

ben wont to bryngen in þinges þat þei clepen porismes
or declaraciouns of forseide þinges. ry3t so wil I zeue

substantially the supreme
Good.

B. Most rightly said!

P. But you have owned
that true felicity is the
sovereign good; then you
must also grant that God
is that true felicity.

[* fol. 21 b.]

B. Your conclusions
follow from your
premises.

P. Let us see whether we
cannot prove this more
convincingly by
considering it in this
view, that there cannot
be two sovereign goods
which differ in
themselves.

For it is plain that of the
goods that differ one
cannot be what the other
is; wherefore neither of
them can be perfect
where one wants the
other.

That which is not perfect
cannot be the supreme
good.

Neither can the chief
good be essentially
different.

But it has been shown
that God and happiness
are the chief good,
wherefore the sovereign
felicity and the Supreme
Divinity are one and the
same.

Following then the
examples of
geometricians who
deduce their conse-
quences from their
propositions, I shall
deduce to thee

þe here as a corolarie or a mede of coroune. For whi.
for as moche as by þe getyng of blisfulnesse men ben
2556

maked blysful. *and* blisfulnesse is diuinite. ¶ þan is
it manifest *and* open þat by þe getyng of diuinite men
ben makid blisful. ryzt as by þe getyng of iustice . . .
and by þe getyng of sapience þei ben maked wise. 2560

E HAPPY MAN IS A GOD.

¶ Ryzt so nedes by þe semblable resoun whan þei han
getyn

diuinite þei ben maked goddys. þan is euery blisful
man god. ¶ But certis by nature. þer nys but oon god.
but by þe *participaciouns* of diuinite þere ne letteþ ne
2564

disturbep no þing þat þer ne ben many goddes. ¶ þis
is *quod* .I. a faire þing *and* a precious. ¶ Clepe it as
þou wolt. be it corolarie or porisme or mede of coroune
or declarynges ¶ Certys *quod* she no þing nis fairer. 2568
þan is þe þing þat by resoun sholde ben added to þise
forseide þinges. what þing *quod* .I. ¶ So *quod* she as
it semeþ þat blisfulnesse contenip many þinges. it were
forto witen wheþir [þat] alle þise þinges maken or 2572
conioignen as a maner body of blysfulnesse by
diuersite

of parties or [of] membris. Or ellys yif any of alle
þilke þingus be swyche þat it acomplise by hym self þe
substaunce of blisfulnesse. so þat alle þise oper þinges
2576

ben referred and brouzt to blisfulnesse. þat is to seyne

something like a
corollary as follows:—
Because by the
attainment of felicity
men become happy, and
as felicity is the same as
Divinity itself, therefore
by the attainment of
Divinity men are made
happy.

But as by the
participation of justice or
of wisdom men become
just or wise,

so by partaking of
Divinity they must
necessarily, and by parity
of reason, become gods.

Every happy man then is
a god. But by nature
there is only *One*; but by
participation of Divine
essence there may be
many gods.

But as happiness seems
to be an assemblage of
many things, ought we
not to consider whether
these several things
constitute conjointly the
body of happiness, or
whether there is not
some one of these
particular things that
may complete the
substance or essence of
it, and to which all the
rest have a relation?

as to þe chief of hem. ¶ I wolde quod I þat þou
makedest me clerly to vndirstonde what þou seist. *and*
þat þou recorderst me þe forseide þinges. ¶ Haue I nat
2580

iuged quod she. þat blisfulnesse is goode. 3is forsoþe
quod .I. *and* þat souereyne goode. ¶ Adde þan quod
she þilke goode þat is maked blisfulnes to alle þe
forseide

þinges. ¶ For þilke same blisfulnesse þat is 2584
demed to ben souereyne suffisaunce. þilke self is
souereyne power. souereyne reuerence. souereyne clernesse
or noblesse *and* souereyne delit. what seist þou
þan of alle þise þinges. þat is to seyne. suffisance
power 2588

and þise oþer þinges. ben þei þan as membris of
blisfulnesse.

or ben þei referred *and* brou3t to souereyne good.

¶ Ry3t as alle þinges þat ben brou3t to þe chief of hem.

B. Illustrate this matter
by proper examples.

P. As you grant that
happiness is a good, you
may say the same of all
the other goods; for
perfect sufficiency is
identical with supreme
felicity; so is supreme
power, likewise high
rank, a shining
reputation, and perfect
pleasure.

What say you, then; are
all these things,
sufficiency, power, and
the rest, to be considered
as constituent parts of
felicity? or are they to be
referred to the sovereign
good as their source and
principal?

OD, THE RULE AND SQUARE OF THINGS DESIRABLE.

b. I vndirstonde wel quod .I. what þou purposest to
2592

seke. but I desijr[e] to herkene þat þou shewe it me.

p. Take now þus þe discessioun of þis questioun quod
she. yif al þise þinges quod she weren membris to
felicite. þan weren þei diuerse þat oon fro þat oþer.
2596

¶ And swiche is þe nature of parties or of membris.
þat dyuerse membris compounen a body. ¶ Certis
quod I it haþ wel ben shewed her byforne. þat alle þise

B. I see what you are
aiming at, and I am
desirous to hear your
arguments.

P. If all these things were
members of felicity, they
would differ one from
another, for it is the
property of diverse parts
to compose one body.

But it has been well
shown that all these
things are the same and
do not differ—therefore

þinges ben alle on þing. þan ben þei none membris
quod 2600

she. for ellys it sholde seme þat blisfulnesse were
conioigned *al of one membre alone. but þat is a þing
þat may nat ben doon. þis þing quod .I. nys nat
doutous. but I abide to herkene þe remenaunt of þe 2604
questioun. þis is open *and* clere quod she. þat alle oþer
þinges ben referred *and* brouȝt to goode. ¶ For þerfore
is suffisaunce requered. For it is demed to ben
good. *and* forþi is power requered. for men trowen also
2608

þat it be goode. and þis same þing mowe we þinken *and*
coueiten of reuerence *and* of noblesse *and* of delit. þan
is souereyne good þe soume *and* þe cause of alle þat
auȝt[e] be desired. forwhi þilke þing þat wiþ-holdeþ no
2612

good in it self ne semblaunce of goode it ne may nat
wel in no manere be desired ne requered. *and* þe
contrarie.

For þouȝ þat þinges by hir nature ne ben nat
goode algates yif men wene þat þei ben goode ȝit ben 2616
þei desired as þouȝ [þat] þei were verrayly goode. *and*
þerfore is it þat men auȝten to wene by ryȝt þat bounte
be souereyne fyn *and* þe cause of alle þinges þat ben to
requeren. ¶ But certis þilke þat is cause for whiche 2620
men requeren any þing. ¶ it semeþ þat þilke same
þing be most desired. as þus yif þat a wyȝt wolde ryde
for cause of hele. he ne desireþ nat so mychel þe
moeuyng to ryden as þe effect of his heele. Now þan
2624

they are not parts, for if
they were, happiness
might be made up of one
member—which is
absurd and impossible.

[* fol. 22.]

B. This I doubt not, but I
desire to hear the sequel.

P. All the things above-
mentioned must be tried
by Good, as the rule and
square.
Sufficiency, power, &c.,
are all desired, because
they are esteemed a
good.

Good is the cause why
all things are desired.

For that which contains
no good, either in reality
or appearance, can never
be desired.

On the contrary, things
not essentially good are
desired because they
appear to be real goods.

Hence, Good is esteemed
as the cause and end of
all things that we desire.

That which is the cause
of our desiring any thing
is itself what we chiefly
want.

If a man desire to ride on
account of health—it is
not the ride he wants so
much as its salutary
effects.

syn þat alle þinges ben requered for þe grace of good.
þei ne ben [nat] desired of alle folk more þan þe same
good ¶ But we han graunted þat blysfulnesse is þat
þing for whiche þat alle þise oþer þinges ben desired.

2628

þan is it þus þat certis only blisfulnesse is requered *and*
desired ¶ By whiche þing it shewep clerely þat good
and blisfulnesse is al oone *and* þe same substaunce.

¶ I se nat quod I wher fore þat men myȝt[en] discorden

2632

in þis. *p.* *and* we han shewed þat god *and* verrey
blysfulnesse

is al oon þing ¶ þat is soþe quod .I. þan

mowe we conclude sikerly þat þe substaunce of god is
set in þilke same good *and* in noon oþer place. 2636

Since all things are sought after for the sake of Good, they cannot be more desirable than the good itself.

It has been shown that all the aforesaid things are only pursued for the sake of happiness—hence it is clear that good and happiness are essentially the same.

B. I see no cause to differ from you.

P. It has been proved that God and happiness are identical and inseparable.

B. That is true. Therefore the substance of God is also the same as that of the Supreme Good.

2453 *whiche*—which

2454-55-56-58-59 *goode*—good

2454 *whiche*—whych

2457 *set*—MS. sette, C. set

2460 *seine*—seyn

souereyne goode—souereyn good

be founden—ben fownde

2461 *veyne*—veyn

2463 *þis is to seyne*—C. omits

2464 *denoyed*—MS. deuoyded, C. denoyed
goode—good

2465 *of*—MS. of of

2466 *al þing*—alle thing

2468 *her of comeþ*—ther of comht

2470 *somme*—som

2471 *don*—MS. done, C. don

2473 *token*—took

2475 *hool*—hoole

2476 *doune*—down
 2477 *wip oute fruyt*—with owten frut
 2480 *stedfast*—stydefast
 2481 *fermely*—MS. fennely, C. fermely
 sobefastly—sothfastly
 2486 [*he þat*]*—from C.*
 is bettre—nis bettre
 2488-89-91 *goode*—good
 2489 *swiche*—swych
 2492 [*it*]*—from C.*
 seme—semen
 2493 *elder*—eldere
 2495 [*that*]*—from C.*
 2496 *proces*—processes
 2497 *ouȝt[e]*—owen
 2498 *goode*—good
 2499 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
 2500 [*þat—**is*]*—from C.*
 yset—MS. ysette, C. set
 2501 *be*—ben
 wipseid—MS. wipseide, C. withseid
 2503 *wip-outen*—with-owte
 2504 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyd
 2505 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
 [*In—**I*]*—from C.*
 2506 *ouȝt*—awht
 2507 *þan of*—owt of
 2508 *whiche*—whych
 souereyne goode—souereyn good
 2509 *hap*—MS. haþe
 2510 *þat ilke*—thilke
 2511 *were*—weren
 2514 *goode*—worth
 2517 *from*—fro
 [*hym*]*—from C.*
 2518 *feyne*—faigne
 2519 *feyne*—feigne
 [*hath*]*—from C.*
 2520 *last[e]*—laste
 2521 *o*—a
 2522 *whiche*—whych

2524 *from*—fro
2527 *nis*—is
2528 *better*—bette
2529 *whiche*—whyh
2531 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyð
2533 *soþe*—soth
2534 *mote*—moten
2539 [*yit*]—from C.
2541 *is* (1)—nis
 oþer—othre
 [*ne*]—from C.
2546 *conclude*—concluded
2547 [*the*] from C.
 goode—good
 be—ben
2549 *soþefast*—sothfast
 ferme—MS. forme, C. ferme
2552 *proposiciouns*—MS. proporsiouns, C. proposiciouns
2553 *porismes*—MS. poeismes, C. porysmes
2554 *wil*—wole
2563 *oon*—o
2564 *letteþ*—let
2566 *faire*—fayr
2567 *porisme*—MS. pousme, C. porisme
2572 [*þat*]—from C.
2573 *maner*—manere
 by—be
2574 [*of*]—from C.
2575 *swyche*—swych
2576 *oþer*—oothre
2577 *seyne*—seyn
2578 *chief*—chef
2581 *goode ȝis*—good ys
2582 *souereyne goode*—souereyn good
2583 *goode*—good
2585 *self*—selue
2588 *þise*—C. omits
 seyne—seyn
2589 *oþer*—oothre
2591 *brouȝt*—MS wrouȝt, C. browht
2593 *desijr[e] to herkene*—desire for to herkne

2594 *Take*—tak
 2596 *fro*—from
 2597 *swiche*—swych
 2600 *on þing*—othing
 2602 *one*—on
 2603 *ben doon*—be don
 2604 *herkene*—herknen
 2605 *clere*—cler
 oper—oothre
 2606 *goode*—good
 2609 *goode*—good
 mowe—mowen
 2617 [*þat*]—from C.
 were verrayly—weeren verraylyche
 2618 *þefore*—therfor
 auȝten—owhten
 2619 *alle*—alle the
 2620 *whiche*—whych
 2623 *mychel*—mochel
 2624 *moeuyng*—moeuyng
 2626 [*nat*]—from C.
 2628 *oper*—oothre
 2630 *clerely*—clerly
 good and blisfulnesse—of good *and* of blysfulnesse
 2631 *oone*—oon
 2632 *myȝt[en]*—myhten
 2634 *oon*—oo
 sope—soth
 2635 *mowe*—mowen
 2636 *set*—MS. sette, C. set

D A HAVEN OF REST.

[NUNC OMNES PARITER ETC.](#)

O Comeþ alle to-gidre now ȝe þat ben ycauȝt *and*
 ybounde wiþ wicked[e] cheines by þe deceiuable
 delit of erþely þinges inhabytyng in ȝoure þouȝt. here
 ſhal ben þe reſte of ȝoure laboures. here is þe hauene

[The 10th Metur.]

Come hither, all ye that
 are captives—bound and
 fettered with the chains
 of earthly desires;—
 come to this source of
 goodness, where you

2640

stable in peisible quiete. þis al oone is þe open refut to
wreches. *Glosa.* þis is to seyn. þat 3e þat ben combred
and deceyued wiþ worldly affecciouns comeþ now
to þis souereyne good þat is god. þat is refut to hem þat
wolen come to hym. *Textus.* ¶ Alle þe þinges þat þe
ryuere Tagus 3iueþ 3ow wiþ his golden[e] grauels. or
ellys alle þe þynges þat þe ryuere hermus. 3iueþ wiþ
his

rede brynke. or þat yndus 3iueþ þat is nexte þe hote 2648
partie of þe worlde. þat medeleþ þe grene stones
(smaragde) wiþ þe white (margarits). ne sholde nat
cleren þe lokynge of 3oure þoȝt. but hiden raþer 3oure
blynde corages wiþ inne hire dirkenesse ¶ Alle þat 2652
likeþ 3ow here *and* excitip *and* moeueþ 3oure þouȝtes.
þe erþe haþ noryshed it in hys lowe caues. but þe
shynyng by þe whiche þe heuene is gouerned *and*
whennes þat it haþ hys strengþe þat chaseþ þe derke
2656

ouerþrowyng of þe soule. ¶ And who so euer may
known þilke lyȝt of blisfulnesse. he shal wel seine þat
þe white bemes of þe sonne ne ben nat cleer.

shall find rest and
security.

[Chaucer's gloss upon
the Text.]

2644
Not the gold of Tagus or
of Hermus, nor the gems
of India, can clear the
mental sight from vain
delusions, but rather
darken it.

Such sources of our
delight are found in the
earth's gloomy caverns,
—but the bright light
that rules the heavens
dispels the darkness of
the soul.

He who has seen this
light will confess that the
beams of the sun are
weak and dim.

2638 *wicked[e]*—wyckyde

2639, 2640 *here*—her

2640 *hauene*—MS. heuene, C. hauene

2641 *al oone*—allone

2643 *worldly*—worldely

2645 *come*—comyn

2646 *golden[e] grauels*—goldene grauayles

2647 *þynges*—MS. rynges, C. thinges

hermus—MS. herinus, C. herynus

2648 *nexte*—next

2649 *worlde*—world

2654, 2656 *hap*—MS. *hape*

2654 *hys*—hyse

2656 *chaseþ þe derke*—eschueth the dyrke

2657 *euer*—C. omits

2658 *seine*—seyn

N DO NOT SEEK TRUE FELICITY.

ASSENCIOR INQUAM CUNCTA. Boice.

I assent[e] me *quod* .I. For alle þise þinges ben 2660
strongly bounden wiþ ryȝt ferme resouns. how
mychel wilt þou preisen it *quod* she. yif þat þou
knowe what þilke goode is. I wol preise it *quod* I by
price wiþ outen ende. ¶ yif it shal bytyde me to 2664
knowe also to-gidre god þat is good. ¶ certys *quod* she
þat shal I do þe by verray resoun. yif þat þo þinges þat
I haue conclude[d] a litel her by *forne dwellen oonly
in hir first[e] grauntyng. *Boice*. þei dwellen graunted
2668
to þe *quod* .I. þis is to seyne as who seiþ .I. graunt þi
forseide conclusiouns. ¶ Haue I nat shewed þe *quod*
she þat þe þinges þat ben requered of many folke. ne
ben nat verray goodes ne perfit. for þei ben diuerse þat
2672
oon fro þat oþer. *and* so as eche of hem is lakkyng to
oþer. þei ne han no power to bryngen a good þat is ful
and absolute. ¶ But þan atte arst ben þei verray good
whan þei ben gadred to-gidre al in to a forme *and* in
2676
to oon wirchyng. so þat þilke þing þat is suffisaunce.

[The 11 prose.]

B. I assent, and am convinced by the force of your arguments.

P. But how greatly would you value it, did you fully know what this good is?

B. I should value it infinitely if at the same time I might attain to the knowledge of God, who is the sovereign good.

P. I shall elucidate this matter by incontrovertible reasons if thou wilt grant me those things which I have before laid down as conclusions.

[* fol. 22 b.]

B. I grant them all.

P. Have I not shown that the things which the majority of mankind so eagerly pursue are not true and perfect goods, for they differ from one another; and because where one of them is absent the others cannot confer absolute happiness (or good)? Have I not shown, too, that the true and chief good is made up of an assemblage of all the

þilk same be power *and* reuerence. *and* noblesse *and* mirþe. ¶ And forsoþe but alle þise þinges ben alle o same þing þei ne han nat wher by þat þei mowen ben
2680

put in þe noumbre of þinges. þat auzten ben requered or desired. *b.* ¶ It is shewed quod .I. ne her of may þer no man douten. *p.* þe þinges þan quod she þat ne ben none goodes whan þei ben diuerse. *and* whan þei
2684

bygynnen to ben al o þing. þan ben þei goodes. ne comiþ it hem nat þan by þe getyng of unite þat þei ben

maked goodes. *b.* so it semeþ quod .I. but alle þing þat is good quod she grauntest þou þat it be good by *participacioun* 2688
of good or no. ¶ I graunt[e] it quod .I.

ITY NECESSARY TO EXISTENCE.

¶ þan mayst þou graunt[en] it quod she by sembleable resoun þat oon *and* good ben o same þing. ¶ For of þinges [of] whiche þat þe effect nis nat naturely diuerse 2692

nedys þe substaunce mot ben o same þinge. I ne may nat denye it quod I. ¶ Hast þou nat knowen wel quod she. þat al þing þat is haþ so longe his dwellyng *and* his substaunce. as longe is it oone. ¶ but whan it 2696
forletip to ben oone it mot nedis dien *and* corruppe togidre.

¶ In whiche manere quod .I. ¶ Ryzt as in

goods in such a way, that if sufficiency is an attribute of this good, it must at the same time possess power, reverence, &c.

If they be not one and the same, why should they be classed among desirable things?

While these things differ from one another they are not goods; but as soon as they become one then they are made goods.—Do not they owe their being good to their unity?

B. So it appears.

P. Do you confess that everything that is good becomes such by the participation of the sovereign good or no?

B. It is so.

P. Then you must own that unity and good are the same (for the substance of those things must be the same, whose effects do not naturally differ).

B. I cannot gainsay it.

P. Do you not perceive that everything which exists is permanent so long as it preserves its unity—but as soon as it loses this, it is dissolved and annihilated?

B. How so?

beestes *quod* she. whan þe soule *and* þe body ben
conioigned in oon *and* dwellen to-gidre it is cleped a
2700

beest. *and* whan hire vnite is destroyed by
disseueraunce

þat oon fram þat opir. þan shewep it wel þat it is a
dede þing. *and* þat it is no lenger no beste. *and* þe
body of a wyȝt while it dwelleþ in oon forme by
coniunccioun 2704

of membris it is wel seyn þat it is a figure of
mankynde. and yif þe partyes of þe body ben [so]
diuide[d] *and* disseuered þat oon fro þat opir þat þei
destroien vnite. þe body forletip to ben þat it was byforne. 2708

¶ And who so wolde renne in þe same manere
by alle þinges he sholde seen þat wiþ outen doute euery
þinge is in his substaunce as longe as it is oon. *and*
whan it forletip to ben oon it dieþ *and* perissip. *boice*.
2712

whan I considre *quod* I many þinges I see noon oper.

TURE SUSTAINS VEGETATION.

¶ Is þer any þing þanne *quod* she þat in as moche as
it lyueþ naturely. þat forletip þe appetit or talent of
hys beyng. *and* desireþ to come to deeth *and* to
corrupcioun. 2716

¶ yif I considere *quod* I þe beestes þat han
any manere nature of willynge or of nillynge I ne
fynde no þing. but yif it be constreyned fro wiþ out
forþe. þat forletip or dispiseþ to lyue *and* to duren 2720
or þat wole his þankes hasten hym to dien. ¶ For

P. In the animal creation
as long as the soul and
the body are united and
conjoined in one, this
being is called an animal
or beast, but when the
union is dissolved by the
separation of these, the
animal perishes and is no
longer a beast.

The same may be said of
man and all other things;
they subsist while unity
is preserved, but as soon
as that is destroyed the
things themselves lose
their existence.

B. I believe we should
find this true in every
case.

P. Is there anything
which acts naturally that
forgoes this desire of
existence and wishes for
death and corruption?

B. I do not find any
creature endowed with
volition, which, of itself
and without constraint,
renounces or despises
life and self-preservation
or willingly hastens to
destruction.

euery beest trauayleþ hym to defende *and* kepe þe sauuacioun of lijf. *and* escheweþ deef *and* destruccioun.

b. but certys I doute me of herbes *and* of trees. þat is

2724

to seyn þat I am in a doute of swiche þinges as herbes or trees þat ne han no felyng soule. ne no naturel wirchynges seruyng to appetite as beestes han wheþer þei han appetite to dwellen *and* to duren. ¶ Certis 2728 quod she ne þer of þar þe nat doute. ¶ Now look vpon þise herbes *and* þise trees. þei waxen firste in swiche place as ben couenable to hem. in whiche place þei ne mowen nat sone dien ne dryen as longe as hire

2732

nature may defenden hem. ¶ For some of hem waxen in feldes *and* some in mountaignes. *and* oþir waxen in mareis. [*A leaf lost here, and supplied from C.*]

[*and* oothre cleuyn on Roches / *and* soume waxen plentyuous 2736

in sondes / *and* yif þat any wyht enforce hym to beryn hem in to oother places / they wexen drye // For nature yeueth to euery thing þat / þat is conuenient to hym *and* trauaylith þat they ne dye nat as longe as they

2740

han power to dwellyn *and* to lyuen // what woltow seyn

of this / þat they drawen alle hyr norysshynges by hyr rootes / ryht as they haddyn hyr Mowthes I.-plounged *with* in the erthes / *and* shedyn by hyr maryes (i. medullas) 2744

hyr wode *and* hyr bark / *and* what woltow seyn of this þat thilke thing / þat is ryht softe as the marye

But with regard to herbs and trees, I am doubtful whether I ought to have the same opinion of them, for they have no sensitive soul, nor any natural volition like animals.

P. There is no cause for doubt in respect to these.

Herbs and trees first choose a convenient place to grow in, where, agreeably to their respective natures, they are sure to thrive, and are in no danger of perishing; for some grow on plains, some on mountains, &c.;

and if you try to transplant them, they forthwith wither and die.

To everything that vegetates, nature gives what is needful for its subsistence, and takes care that they should not perish before their time.

Need I tell you that plants are nourished by their roots (which are so many mouths hid in the earth), and diffuse strength throughout the whole plant, as through their marrow?

And further, it is admirably contrived that the pith, the most tender part of plants, is hid in

(i.

sapp) is / þat is alwey hidd in the feete al *with inne and*
þat it is defendid fro *with owte* by the stidefastnesse of

2748

wode // *and* þat the vttereste bark is put ayenis the destempraunce
of the heuene / as a defendowr myhty to suffren

harm / *and* thus certes maystow wel sen / how gret is
the diligence of nature / For alle thinges renouelen *and*

2752

pupplisen hem *with* seed .I.-multiplied / nether nis no
man

þat ne wot wel þat they ne ben ryht as a foundement
and

edyfice for to duren / nat only for a tyme / but ryht as forto

duren *perdurably* by generacyoun // *and* the thinges

ek 2756

þat men wenen ne hauen none sowles / ne desire they
nat ech

of hem by sem[b]lable resoun to kepyn þat that is hirs / þat

is to seyn þat is acordynge to hyr nature in conseruacioun

of hyr beyng *and* enduryng // For wher for elles

berith 2760

lythnesse the flaumbes vp / *and* the weyhte presseth
the

erthe a-doun // but For as moche as thilke places and

thilke moeuynge ben couenable to euerich of hem //

the middle of the trunk,
surrounded with hard
and solid wood, and with
an outer coat of bark to
ward off the storms and
weather.

Admire, too, the
diligence of nature in
propagating plants by a
multiplicity of seeds,
which are as a
foundation for a
building, not to remain
for a time, but as it were
for ever.

Things inanimate incline
to what is most suitable
to their beings, and to
preserve continuance.

For why should the
flame mount upwards by
lightness, and the earth
tend towards its centre
by gravity (weight),
unless these motions
were agreeable to their
respective natures?

E LOVE OF LIFE IS INSTINCTIVE.

and forsothe euery thing kepith thilke þat is acordynge

2764

Whatever is agreeable to
the nature of a thing
preserves it. So what is

and propre to hym // ryht as thinges þat ben contraryes
and enemys corompen hem // *and* yit the harde thinges
as stoones clyuen *and* holden hyr partyes to gydere
ryht faste *and* harde / *and* deffenden hem in
withstondenge 2768

þat they ne departe nat lyhtly a twyne // *and* the
thinges þat ben softe *and* fletynge as is water *and* Eyr
they departyn lyhtly // *and* yeuen place to hem þat
brekyn or deuyden hem // but natheles they retornen 2772
sone ayein in to the same thinges fro whennes they ben
arraced // but fyr [fleeth] *and* refuseth alle deuysyoun /
ne I. ne trete nat heere now of weleful moeuynges of
the
sowle þat is knowynge // but of the naturel entencioun
2776

of thinges // As thus ryht as we swolwe the mete þat
we
resseyuen *and* ne thinke nat on it / *and* as we drawen
owre breth in slepyng þat we wite it nat whil we slepyt //
For certes in the beestys the loue of hyr lyuynges ne of
2780

hyr beeinges ne comth nat of the wilnynges of the
sowle //
but of the bygynnyngis of nature // For certes thorw
constreynynge causes / wil desireth *and* embraceth ful
ofte tyme / the deth þat nature dredith // that is to seyn
2784

as thus that a man may ben constreynyed so by som
cause that his wil desireth and taketh the deth which
þat nature hateth *and* dredeth ful sore // And som tyme

contrary to its nature
destroys it.

Dense bodies, such as
stones, resist an easy
separation of parts;
whereas the particles of
liquid or flowing things,
such as air and water, are
easily separated and
soon reunited.

Fire avoids and utterly
refuses any such
division.
I am not now treating of
the voluntary motion of a
conscious soul, but of
the natural intention and
instinct.

We swallow our meat
without thinking of it,
and we draw our breath
in sleep without
perception.

The love of life in
animals is not derived
from an intellectual will,
but from natural
principles implanted in
them.

For the will, induced by
powerful reasons,
sometimes chooses and
embraces death,
although nature dreads
and abhors it.

And, on the contrary, we
see that concupiscence
(by which alone the

we seeth the contrarye / as thus that the wil of a wight /
2788

human race is
perpetuated) is often
restrained by the will.

destorbeth *and* constreyneth þat þat nature desireth / and
requereth al-vey // that is to sein the werk of generacioun /
by the whiche generacioun only / dwelleth *and* is sustenyd
the longe durablete of mortal thinges // And thus 2792
this charite and this Loue þat euery thing hath to hym
self ne comth nat of the moeuyng of the sowle / but of
the entencioun of nature // For the puruyance of god
hat yeuen to thinges þat ben creat of hym / this þat is
2796

Self-love possessed by
every creature is not the
product of volition, but
proceeds from a natural
impression or intention
of nature.

Providence has
implanted in all created
things an instinct, for the
purpose of self-
preservation, by which
they desire to prolong
existence to its utmost
limits.

a ful gret cause / to lyuen *and* to duren / for which they
desiren naturelly hyr lyf as longe as euer they mowen
//

E WILL IS SUPERIOR TO INSTINCT.

For w[h]ych thou maist nat drede by no manere / that
alle the thinges / that ben anywhere / that they ne
requeren 2800

Doubt not, therefore, that
everything which exists
desires existence and
avoids dissolution.

naturelly / the ferme stablenesse of perdurable
dwellynge / and ek the eschuyng of destruccoun // B
//

B. You have made those
things perfectly plain
and intelligible, which
before were obscure and
doubtful.

now confesse I. wel *quod* I. that I. see wel now
certeynly /

with owte dowtes / the thinges that whylom semeden 2804

vncerteyn to me / P. // but *quod* she thilke thyng þat
desireth to be *and* to dwellyn perdurablely / he desireth
to ben oon // For yif þat that oon weere destroyed //
certes

P. That which desires to
subsist desires also to
retain its unity for if this
be taken away it cannot
continue to exist.

beinge ne shulde ther non dwellyn to no wiht // that

B. That is very true!

2808

is soth *quod* I. // Thanne *quod* she desirin alle thinges
oon // .I. assente *quod* .I. // and I haue shewyd *quod*
she

that thilke same oon is thilke that is good // B // ye
forsothe

quod I. // Alle thinges thanne *quod* she requyren 2812
good // And thilke good thanne [pow] maist descryuen
ryht thus // Good is thilke thing þat euery wyht
desireth //

Ther ne may be thowht *quod* .I. no moore
verray thing / for either alle thinges ben referred *and*
2816

browht to nowht / *and* floteryn with owte gouernour
despoiled of oon / as of hir propre heued / or elles yif
ther be any thinge / to which þat alle thinges tenden
and hyen / that thing moste ben the souereyn good of
2820

alle goodes / P /. thanne seyde she thus // O my norry
quod she I haue gret gladnesse of the // For thow
hast fichched in thin herte the myddel sothtfastnesse //
that is to seyn the prykke // but this thing hath ben 2824
descouered to the / in that thow seydyst þat thow
wystest nat a lytel her by-forn // what was that *quod* I.
//

E END OF ALL THINGS.

That thow ne wystest nat *quod* she whych was
the ende of thinges // and Certes that is the thing þat
2828

P. All things then desire
one thing—unity.

B. They do.

P. Unity then is the same
as good.

B. Yes.

P. Thus all things desire
good—and it is one and
the same good that all
creatures desire.

B. Nothing is more true.
For either all things must
be reduced to nothing (or
have no relation to
anything else), and,
destitute of a head, float
about without control or
order; or if there be
anything to which all
things tend, that must be
the supreme good.

P. I rejoyce greatly, my
dear pupil, that you so
clearly apprehend this
truth, of which but just
now you were ignorant.

B. What was that?

P. The *End of all things*.
And this is what every
one desires; but we have
shown that *good* is the
thing desired by all,

euery wiht desireth // and for as mochel as we han
gaderid / *and* comprehendyd that good is thilke thing
that is desired of alle / thanne moten we nedes confessun /
that good is the fyn of alle thinges. 2832

therefore *Good* is the
End of all things.

2660 *assent*[e]—assente
2662 *mychel*—mochel
2663 *goode*—good
2664 *price*—prys
2669 *is*—omitted
 seyne—seyn
2671 *folke*—folkes
2673 *oper*—oothre
 eche—ech
2675 *absolute*—absolut
 atte arst—at erste
2676 *al*—alle
 a—O
2677 *to*—omitted
 wirchyng—wyrkyng
2678 *pilk*—thilke
2681 *put*—MS. putte, C. put
 auzten—owhten
2684 *none*—no
2685 *al o*—alle oon
2686 *comip*—comth
2689 *graunt*[e]—graunte
2690 *mayst pou graunt*[en]—mosthow graunten
2692 [*of*]—from C.
2695 *al*—alle
 hap—MS. hape
2696, 2697 *oone*—oon
2698 *whiche*—which
2703 *dede*—ded
 lenger—lengere
 beste—beest
2704 *while*—whil
 oon—oo
2706 [*so*] *diuide*[d]—so deuydyd
2709 *so*—omitted

2713 *many*—manye
 2718 *willynge*—wylnyng
 or—*and*
 2719 *þing*—beest
 out forþe—owte forth
 2720 *lyue*—lyuen
 2723 *of lijf*—of hys lyf
 2726 *soule*—sowles
 2727 *appetite*—appetites
 2729 *look*—loke
 2730 *waxen firste*—wexen fyrst
 2733, 2734 *some*—som
 2734 *opir*—oothre
 2753 *pupllisen*—H. publisshen)
 2755 *edyfice*—MS. edyfite
 a tyme—H. oon) tyme
 2758 *that*—H. omits
 hirs—H. his
 2774 [*fleeth*]—from H.
 2775 *weleful*—H. wilfulle
 2779 *slepyt*—H. slepen
 2788 *seeth*—H. seen)
 wil—H. wille
 2792 *And*—H. as
 2796 *hat*—H. haue
 2800 *the*—H. þo
 2806 *perdurably*—H. perdurably
 2807 *destroied*—H. destrued
 2811 *thilke* (1)—H. ilke
 2818 *heued or elles*—H. hede or els
 2820 *hyen*—H. hyen) to
 moste—H. must

UTH INTUITIVE.

[QUISQUIS PROFUNDA MENTE.](#)

[The .11. *Metrum*.]

WHo so that sekith soþ by a deep thoght And
 coueyteth nat to ben deseyuyd by no mys-weyes

He who seeks truth with
 deep research and is
 unwilling to go wrong,
 should collect his

//

lat hym rollen *and* trenden *with* Inne hym self / the

slumbering thoughts, and
turn the inner light upon
the soul itself.

Lyht

of his inward syhte // And lat hym gadere ayein enclynynge 2836

in to a compas the longe moeuynge of hys

thowhtes / And lat hym techen his corage that he hath

The knowledge that he
seeks without he will
find treasured up in the
recesses of the mind.

enclosed *and* hyd / in his tresors / al þat he compaseth

or

sekith fro *with* owte // And thanne thilke thing that the

The light of Truth will
disperse Error's dark
clouds, and shine forth
brighter than the sun.

2840

blake cloude of errour whilom hadde y-couered / shal

lyhten more clerly thanne phebus hym self ne shyneth //

Glosa // who so wole seken the dep[e] grounde / of soth [Chaucer's gloss.]

in his thowht / *and* wol nat be deceyuyd by false *proposiciouns* / 2844

that goon amys fro the trouthe // lat hym wel

examine / *and* rolle *with* inne hym self the nature *and*

the propretes of the thing // and lat hym yit eft sones

examine *and* rollen his thowhtes by good deliberacioun 2848

or that he deme // and lat hym techen his sowle that it

hat by naturel pryncyplis kyndeliche y-hyd *with* in

it self alle the trowthe the whiche he ymagynith to ben

in thinges *with* owte // And thanne alle the dyrknesse of 2852

his mysknowynge shal seen more euydently to [þe]

syhte of his vndyrstondynge thanne the sonne ne semyth

to [þe] syhte *with* owte forth / For certes the body

For when the body
enclosed the soul and
cast oblivion o'er its
powers it did wholly
exterminate the heaven-
born light.

bryngynge the weyhte of foryetynge / ne hath nat

chasyd 2856

owt of yowre thowhte al the clernesse of yowre

knowyng //

For certeynly the seed of sooth haldith *and* clyueth

The germs of truth were
latent within, and were

with in yowre corage / *and* it is a-waked *and* excited
by

the wynde *and* by the blastes of doctryne // For where

2860

for elles demen ye of yowre owne wyl the ryhtes whan
ye ben axed // but yif so were þat the norysynges of
resoun ne lyuede .I.-plowngyd in the depthe of yowre
herte // this [is] to seyn how sholden men demen þe 2864
sooth of any thing þat weere axed / yif ther neere a
Roote of sothfastnesse þat weere yplowngyd *and* hyd in
the nature[1] pryncyplis / the whiche sothfastnesse
lyued *with* in the depnesse of the thowght // *and* yif

2868

so be þat the Muse *and* the doctryne of plato syngyth
sooth // al þat euery whyht lerneth / he ne doth no
thing elles thanne but recordeth as men recordyn thinges
þat ben foryetyn. 2872

fanned into action by the
gentle breath of learning.

Were not truth implanted
in the heart, how could
man distinguish right
from wrong?

So, if what Plato taught
is true, 'to learn is no
other than to remember
what had been before
forgotten.'

2838 *his*—H. þis
 that—H. *and* þat
 2841 *blake*—H. blak
 hadde y-couered—H. had couered
 2842 *lyhten*—H. light
 2843 *dep[e]*—C. dep, H. depe
 2847 *thing*—H. þynges
 2863 *depthe*—H. depe
 2864 [*is*]—from H.
 sholden—H. shulde
 2867 *nature[l]*—H. naturelle

E WORLD GOVERNED BY GOD.

TUM EGO PLATONI INQUAM.

[The .12. prose.]

THanne seide I thus // I acorde me gretly to plato /
 for

thow remenbrist *and* recordist me thise thinges yit]
 *þe seconde tyme. þat is to seyn. first whan I lost[e]
 my

memorie by þe contagioũs coniunccioun of þe body
 wiþ 2876

þe soule. *and* eftsones afterward whan I lost[e] it
 confounded

by þe charge *and* by þe burden of my sorwe.

¶ And þan sayde she þus. ¶ If þou look[e] *quod* she
 firste þe þinges þat þou hast graunted it ne shal nat 2880
 ben ryȝt feer þat þou ne shalt remembren þilke þing þat
 þou seidest þat þou nistest nat. what þing *quod* I.

¶ by whiche gouerment *quod* she þat þis worlde is

B. I am quite of Plato's opinion, for you have now a second time recalled these things to my remembrance which had been forgotten, first by the contagious union of soul and body, and afterwards by the pressure of my afflictions.

[**Addit. MS. 10,340, fol. 23.*]

P. If you will reflect upon the concessions you have already made, you will soon call to mind that truth, of which you lately confessed your ignorance.

B. What is that?

gouerned. Me remembriþ it wel *quod* I. *and* I confesse

2884

wel þat I ne wist[e] it nat ¶ But al be it so þat
I se now from afer what þou *purposest* ¶ Algates I
desire 3it to herkene it of þe more pleyuely. ¶ þou ne
wendest nat *quod* she a litel here byforne þat men 2888
sholden doute þat þis worlde is gouerned by god.

¶ Certys *quod* I ne 3itte doute I it nau3t. ne I nil
neuer wene þat it were to doute. as who seiþ. but I
wot wel þat god gouerneþ þis worlde. ¶ And I shal 2892
shortly answeþe þe by what resouns I am brou3t to þis.

¶ þis worlde *quod* I of so many dyuerse *and*
contrarious

parties ne my3ten neuer han ben assembled in o forme.
but yif þere ne were oon þat conioigned so many[e] 2896
diuerse] þinges. ¶ And þe same diuersite of hire
natures þat so discordeden þat oon fro þat oþer most[e]
departen *and* vnioignen þe þinges þat ben conioigned.
yif þere ne were oon þat contened[e] þat he hap
conioigned 2900

and ybounde. ne þe certein ordre of nature ne
sholde. nat brynge furþe so ordinee moeuynge. by
places. by tymes. by doynge. by spaces. by qualites.
yif þere ne were oon þat were ay stedfast dwellynge.

2904

þat ordeyned[e] *and* disposed[e] þise diuersites of
moeuynge. ¶ and þilke þinge what so euer it be. by
whiche þat alle þinges ben maked *and* ylad. I clepe
hym god þat is a worde þat is vsed to alle folke. þan

2908

P. It was, by what power
the world is governed.

B. With regard to that, I
own I confessed my
ignorance, but though I
now remotely see what
you infer, yet I wish for
further explanation from
you.

P. You acknowledged a
little while ago that this
world was governed by
God?

B. I still cling to this
opinion, and will give
you my reasons for this
belief.

The discordant elements
of this world would
never have assumed their
present form unless there
had been a wise
Intelligence to unite
them; and even after
such a union, the joining
of such opposites would
have disunited and
ruined the fabric made
up of them, had not the
same conjoining hand
kept them together.

The order that reigns
throughout nature could
not proceed so regularly
and uniformly if there
were not a Being,
unchangeable and
stedfast, to order and
dispose so great a
diversity of changes.

This Being, the creator
and ruler of all things, I
call God.

P. As thy sentiments on
these points are so just I
have but little more to do
—for thou mayest be

seide she. syn þou felest þus þise þinges quod she. I
trowe þat I haue lytel more to done. þat þou myȝty of
wilfulnesse hool *and* sounde ne se eftsones þi contre.

D IS ALL-SUFFICIENT.

¶ But lat vs loken þe þinges þat we han *purposed* her-
byform. 2912

¶ Haue I nat noumbred *and* seid quod she
þat suffisaunce is in blisfulnesse. *and* we han accorded
þat god is *and* þilke same blisfulnesse. ¶ yis forsoþe
quod

I. *and* þat to gouerne þis worlde quod she. ne shal he
2916

neuer han nede of none helpe fro wiþoute. for ellys yif
he had[de] nede of any helpe. he ne sholde not haue
[no] ful suffisaunce. ȝis þus it mot nedes be quod I.

¶ þan ordeyneþ he by hym self al oon alle þinges quod
2920

she. þat may nat ben denied quod I. ¶ And I haue
shewed þat god is þe same good. ¶ It remembreþ me
wel quod I. ¶ þan ordeineþ he alle þinges by þilke
goode quod she. Syn he whiche we han accorded to
2924

ben good gouerneþ alle þingus by hym self. *and* he is a
keye *and* a stiere by whiche þat þe edifice of þis
worlde

is ykept stable *and* wiþ oute corumpyng ¶ I accorde
me gretly quod I. *and* I aperceiuede a litel here byform
2928

þat þou woldest seyne þus. Al be it so þat it were by

happy and secure, and
revisit thy own country.

But let us reflect a little
more upon these matters.

Did we not agree that
Sufficiency is of the
nature of true happiness?

And have we not seen
that God is that true
felicity, and that He
needs no external aid nor
instruments?

For if he should, he
would not be self-
sufficient.

And he directs all things
by himself alone?

B. It cannot be gainsaid.

P. I have shown that God
is the chief good; God
must, therefore, direct
and order all things by
good, since he governs
them by himself, whom
we have proved to be the
supreme good, and he is
that helm and rudder, by
which this machine of
the world is steadily and
securely conducted.

B. I entirely agree to this,
and partly anticipated
your remarks.

a þinne suspecion. I trowe it wel *quod* she. ¶ For as
I trowe þou leedest nowe more ententifly þine eyen to
loken þe verray goodes ¶ but napeles þe þinges þat I
2932

shal telle þe 3it ne shewep nat lasse to loken. what is
þat *quod* I. ¶ So as men trowen *quod* she *and* þat
ry3tfully þat god gouerneþ alle þinges by þe keye of
his

goodnesse. ¶ And alle þise same þinges as I [haue] 2936
tauzt þe. hasten hem by naturel *entencion* to comen
to goode þer may no man douten. þat þei ne ben
gouerned uoluntariely. *and* þat þei ne conuerten [hem]
nat of her owen wille to þe wille of hire ordenour. 2940

L THINGS SUBMIT TO GOD.

as þei þat ben accordyng *and* enclinyng to her
gouernour

and her kyng. ¶ It mot nedys be so *quod*. I.

*¶ For þe realme ne sholde not seme blisful 3if þere
were a 3ok

of mysdrawynges in diuerse parties ne þe sauynge of 2944

obedient þinges ne sholde nat be. þan is þere no þing
quod she þat kepip hys nature ; þat enforceþ hym to
gone a3eyne god. ¶ No *quod*. I. ¶ And if þat any þing
enforced[e] hym to wiþstonde god. my3t[e] it auayle at
2948

þe laste a3eyns hym þat we han *graunted* to ben al
my3ty by þe ry3t of blisfulnesse. ¶ Certis *quod* I al
outerly it ne my3t[e] nat auaylen hym. þan is þere no
þing *quod* she þat eyþer wol or may wiþstonde to þis

P. I believe it; for your eyes are now more intent upon these great truths relating to true felicity; but what I am going to say is not less open to your view.

B. What is that?

P. As we believe that God governs all things by his goodness, and that all things have a natural tendency towards the *good*, can it be doubted but that they all voluntarily submit to the will and control of their ruler?

B. It cannot be otherwise. There would be no safety for those who obey, if the discord of a portion were allowed.

[* Fol. 23 b.]

P. Is there anything that follows the dictates of nature that seeks to counteract the will of God?

B. No.

P. If there should be any such, it could not prevail against him, who is supremely happy and consequently omnipotent.

Then there is nothing that either will or can

2952

souereyne good. ¶ I trowe nat *quod*. I ¶ þan is
þilke þe souereyne good *quod* she þat alle þingus
gouerneþ strongly *and* ordeyneþ hem softly. þan seide
I

þus. I delite me *quod* I nat oonly in þe endes or in þe
2956

sommes of [the] resouns þat þou hast concludid *and*
proued. ¶ But þilke wordes þat þou vset deliten me
moche more. ¶ So at þe last[e] fooles þat somtyme
renden greet[e] þinges auȝten ben asshamed of hem 2960
self. ¶ þat is to seyne þat we fooles þat reprehenden
wickedly þe þingus þat touchen goddes gouernaunce we
auȝten ben asshamed of oure self. As I þat seide god
refuseþ oonly þe werkes of men. *and* ne entremetiþ nat 2964

of hem. *p.* þou hast wel herd *quod* she þe fables of þe
poetes. how þe geauntes assailden þe heuene wiþ þe
goddes. but for soþe þe debonaire force of god
disposed[e]

hem so as it was worþi. þat is to seyne distroied[e] þe
2968

geauntes. as it was worþi. ¶ But wilt þou þat we
ioygnen togedre þilke same resouns. for perauenture of
swiche coniunccioun may sterten vp some faire sperkele
of soþe ¶ Do *quod* I as þe list. wenest þou *quod* she

2972

þat god ne is almyȝty. no man is in doute of it. Certys
quod I no wyȝt ne defendiþ it if he be in hys mynde.

withstand this supreme
good?

B. Nothing, certainly.

P. It is then the supreme
good that governs and
orders all things
powerfully and benignly.

B. I am delighted with
your *conclusions*, but
much more with your
language; so that fools
may be ashamed of their
objections to the divine
government.

[Chaucer's gloss.]

P. You have read the
Poets' fables, how the
Giants stormed heaven—
how they were repulsed
and punished according
to their deserts; but may
we not compare our
reasons together, for by
so doing some clear
spark of truth may shine
forth?

B. As you please.

P. Is God omnipotent?

B. No one doubts it.

IL HAS NO EXISTENCE.

but he *quod* she þat is al myȝty þere nis no þing þat he
ne may do. þat is soþe *quod* I. May god done yuel 2976
quod she. ¶ Syn þat he ne may not done yuel þat
may done alle þinges. scornest þou me *quod*. I. or ellys
pleyest þou or deceiuest þou me. þat hast so wouen me
2980

wiþ þi resouns. þe house of didalus so entrelaced. þat it
is vnable to ben vnlaced. þou þat oþer while entrest
þere þou issest *and* oþer while issest þere þou entrest.
ne fooldest þou nat to gidre by replicacioun of wordes
a 2984

maner wondirful cercle or enviroynynge of symplicite
deuyne. ¶ For certys a litel her byforne whan þou
bygunne
atte blisfulnesse þou seidest þat it is souereyne
good. *and* seidest þat it is set in souereyne god. *and* þat
2988

god is þe ful[le] blisfulnesse. for whiche þou ȝaf[e] me
as a couenable ȝifte. þat is to seyne þat no wyȝt nis
blisful. but yif he be good al so þer wiþ *and* seidest
eke þat þe forme of goode is þe substaunce of god. *and*
2992

of blisfulnesse. *and* seidest þat þilke same oone is
þilke
same goode þat is requered *and* desired of al þe kynde
of þinges. *and* þou proeuedest in disputynge þat god
gouerneþ alle [the] þinges of þe worlde by þe
gouernementys 2996
of bountee. *and* seydest þat alle þinges wolen

P. If he is almighty, there
are, then, no limits to his
power?

B. He can doubtless do
all things.

P. May God do evil?

B. No.

P. Is evil nothing, since
God, who is almighty,
cannot do it?

B. Dost thou mock me or
play with me, leading me
with thy arguments into
an inextricable labyrinth,
and enclosing me in a
wonderful circle of
Divine Simplicity?

For thou didst first begin
with happiness, and didst
say that it was the
sovereign good, and that
it resided in God; then,
that God was that *Good*
and the perfection of
happiness; and, hence,
thou didst infer that
nobody could be happy
unless he became
likewise a God.

Again, thou saidst that
the very form of good
was the substance
whereof God and
happiness were
composed, and that it
was the object and desire
of all things in nature.

Thou didst prove that
God rules the world by
his goodness, and that all
things willingly obeyed
him; and that evil has no
existence.

ybeyen to hym. and seidest þat þe nature of yuel nis
no þing. *and* þise þinges ne shewedest þou nat wiþ no
resouns ytake fro wiþoute but by proues in cercles *and*

3000

homelyche knowen. ¶ þe whiche proeues drawn to hem
self hir feiþ *and* hir accorde eueriche [of] hem of oper. þan

seide she þus. I ne scorne þe nat ne pleye ne desseyue
þe. but I haue shewed to þe þinge þat is grettest ouer

3004

alle þinges by þe zifte of god þat we some tyme prayden

These truths you
established by forcible
and natural arguments,
and by no strained and
far-fetched reasons.

P. I have not deluded
you, for by the Divine
aid we have
accomplished our chief
task.

D IS LIKE A SPHERE.

¶ For þis is þe forme of [the] deuyne substaunce. þat
is swiche þat it ne slydeþ nat in to outerest foreine
þinges. ne ne rec[e]yueþ no strange þinges in hym. but

3008

ryzt as parmaynws seide in grek of þilke deuyne
substaunce.

he seide þus þat þilke deuyne substaunce
torneþ þe worlde *and* þilke cercle moeueable of þinges
while þilke dyuyne substaunce kepþ it self wiþ outhen 3012

moeuyng. þat *is to seyne þat it ne moeuiþ neuere mo.
and zitte it moeueþ alle oper þinges. but na-þeles yif I
[haue] stered resouns þat ne ben nat taken fro wiþ outhen
þe compas of þe þinge of whiche we treten. but
resouns 3016

þat ben bystowed wiþ inne þat compas þere nis nat whi
þat þou sholde[st] merueylen. sen þou hast lerned by
þe sentence of plato þat nedes þe wordes moten ben
cosynes to þo þinges of whiche þei speken. 3020

I have proved to you that
it is an essential property
of the Divine nature not
to go out of itself, nor to
receive into itself
anything extraneous.
Parmenides says of the
Deity that *God is like a
well-rounded sphere.*

[* fol. 24.]

He causes the moving
globe to revolve, but is
himself immovable.
If I have chosen my
arguments from the
subjects within range of
our discussion, do not let
that surprise you, for, as
Plato has taught us, there
ought to be an alliance
between the words and
the subject of discourse.

2875, 2877 *lost*[e]—loste
2878 *burden*—burdene
2879 *look*[e]—looke
2880 *firste*—fyrst
2883 *whiche*—which
 gouernment—gouvernement
 worlde—wordyl
2885 *wist*[e]—wiste
2887 *pleynely*—pleynly
2888 *here byforne*—her byforn
2889 *worlde is*—world nis
2890 *3itte doute*—yit ne dowte
 nil—nel
2892 *wot*—MS. wote, C. wot
2892, 2894 *worlde*—world
2893 *answere*—answeren
2894 *many*—manye
2895 *myȝten*—myhte
2896 *pere*—ther
 many[e]—manye
2897 [*diuerse*]—from C.
 hire—hir
2898 *most*[e]—moste
2900 *pere*—ther
 contened[e]—contenede
 hap—MS. hape
2902 *furþe*—forth
 ordinee moeuynge—ordene moeuynge
2904 *pere*—ther
 stedfast—stidefast
2905 *ordeyned*[e]—ordeynede
 disposed[e]—disponede
2907 *whiche*—which
 ben—be
 ylad—MS. yladde, C. I-ladd
2908 *worde*—word
 folke—foolk
2911 *wilfulnesse*—welefulnesse
2912 *han*—ha
2913 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyd
2916 *worlde*—world

2917 *none helpe*—non help
 2918 *had[de]*—hadde
 helpe—help
 2919 [*no*]—from C.
 2920 *al oon*—allone
 2921 *ben denied*—be denoyed
 2924, 2926 *whiche*—which
 2925 *ben*—be
 2926 *worlde*—world
 2928 *gretly*—gretely
 here—her
 2929 *seyne*—seye
 2931 *nowe*—now
 2932 *napeles*—nat[h]les
 2935 *ryȝtfully*—MS. on ryȝtfully
 2936 [*haue*]—from C.
 2938 *goode*—good
 2939 [*hem*]—from C.
 2940 *nat*—omitted
 her—hir
 owen—owne
 wille (both)—wil
 hire—hyr
 2941 *her*—hyr
 2943 *realme*—Reaume
 seme—semen
 2945 *pere*—ther
 2947 *gone aȝeyne*—goon ayein
 2948 *enforced[e]*—enforcede
 myȝt[e]—myhte
 auayle—auaylen
 2949 *aȝeyns*—a-yenis
 2951 *outerly*—owtrely
 myȝt[e]—myhte
 auaylen—MS. aualeyne, C. auaylen
 hym—hem
 pere—ther
 2952 *wol*—wole
 wiȝstonde—with-stondyn
 þis souereyne—his souereyn
 2955 *softly*—softtely

2957 *sommes*—somme
[*the*]—from C.
2959 *last[e]*—laste
2960 *greet[e]*—grete
2960, 2963 *auzten*—owhten
2961 *seyne*—seyn
2965 *of hem*—of it
herd—MS. herde, C. herd
2967 *disposed[e]*—desposede
2968 *seyne distroied[e]*—seyn destroyede
2971 *swiche*—swych
some—som
2972 *soþe*—soth
list—liste
2973 *is* (1)—be
man—omitted
is (2)—nis
2974 *defendip*—dowteth
2975 *pere*—ther
2976 *do*—C. omits
soþe—soth
done—don
2978, 2979 *done*—don
2980 *wouen*—MS. wonnen, C. wouen
2981 *house*—hows
2983 *pere (both)*—ther
2987 *atte*—at
2988 *set*—MS. sette, C. set
2989 *ful[le]*—fulle
whiche—which
ʒaff[e]—yaue
2990 *ʒifte*—yift
seyne—seyn
2992, 2994 *goode*—good
2993 *oone*—oon
2994 *al*—alle
2996 [*the*]—from C.
2998 *ybeyen*—obeyen
2999 *no* (2)—none
3000 *ytake*—I-taken
3001 *homelyche*—hoomlich

3002 *eueriche*—euerich
 [*of*]—from C.
 3004 *þe þinge*—the the thing
 3005 *ʒifte*—yift
 some tyme prayden—whilom preyeden
 3006 [*the*]—from C.
 3007 *swiche*—swich
 3009 *parmaynws*—a parmanides
 3011 *worlde*—world
 3012 *while*—whil
 wiþ outen—with owte
 3013 *seyne*—seyn
 3014 *ʒitte*—yit
 oþer—oothre
 3015 [*haue*]—from C.
 3016 *whiche*—which
 3017 *wiþ inne*—with in
 3020 *cosynes*—MS. conceyued, C. cosynes
 þo—þe
 whiche—which

E POWER OF MUSIC.

FELIX QUI POTERIT. ET CETERA.

[The .12. Metur.]

Blisful is þat man þat may seen þe clere welle of good.

blisful is he þat may vnbynde hym fro þe bonde of heuy erþe. ¶ þe poete of *trace* [orpheus] þat somtyme hadde ryȝt greet sorowe for þe deep of hys wijf. aftir þat 3024

he hadde maked by hys wepely songes þe wodes meueable

to rennen. *and* hadde ymaked þe ryueres to stonden stille. *and* maked þe hertys *and* hyndes to ioignen dredles hir sides to cruel lyouns to herkene his songe. 3028 *and* had[de] maked þat þe hare was nat agast of þe

Happy is he that hath seen the lucid spring of truth! Happy the man that hath freed himself from terrestrial chains! The Thracian poet, consumed with grief for the loss of his wife, sought relief from music. His mournful songs drew the woods along; the rolling rivers ceased to flow; the savage beasts became heedless of their prey; the timid hare was not aghast at the hound.

hounde whiche þat was plesed by hys songe. so þat
 whane þe most[e] ardaunt loue of hys wijf brende þe
 entrailes of his brest. ne þe songes þat hadde ouer 3032
 comen alle þinges ne myȝten nat assuage hir lorde
 orpheus. ¶ He pleynd[e] hym of þe godes þat weren
 cruel to hym. he wente hym to þe houses of helle *and*
 þere he tempred[e] hys blaundissyng songes by
 resounyng 3036
 of hys strenges. ¶ And spak *and* song in
 wepyng alle þat euer he hadde resceyued *and* laued
 oute of þe noble welles of hys modir calliope þe goddesse.
and he song wiþ as mychel as he myȝt[e] of 3040
 wepyng. *and* wiþ as myche as loue þat doubled[e] his
 sorwe myȝt[e] ȝeuen hym *and* teche hym in his seke
 herte. ¶ And he commoeuede þe helle *and* requered[e]
and souȝte by swete preiere þe lordes of soules in helle 3044
 of relesyng. þat is to seyne to ȝelden hym hys wif.
 ¶ Cerberus þe porter of helle wiþ his þre heuedes was
 cauȝt *and* al abaist for þe new[e] songe. *and* þe þre
 goddesses
 furijs *and* vengerisse of felonies þat tourmenten 3048
and agasten þe soules by anoye wexen sorweful *and* sory
and wepen teres for pitee. þan was nat þe heued of
 Ixione ytourmented by þe ouerþrowing whele. ¶ And
 tantalus þat was destroyed by þe woodnesse of longe
 3052
 þrust dispiseþ þe flodes to drynke. þe fowel þat hyȝt
 voltor þat etip þe stomak or þe giser of ticius is so
 fulfilled
 of his songe þat it nil etyn ne tyren no more.

But the songs that did all
 things tame, could not
 allay their master's
 ardent love.

He bewailed the cruelty
 of the gods above, and
 descended to Pluto's
 realm.
 There he struck his
 tuneful strings and sang,
 exhausting all the
 harmonious art imparted
 to him by his mother
 Calliope.

In songs dictated both by
 grief and love, he
 implored the infernal
 powers to give him back
 his Eurydice.

Cerberus, Hell's three-
 headed porter, stood
 amazed;

the Furies, tormentors of
 guilty souls, did weep;

Ixion, tormented by the
 revolving wheel, found
 rest;

Tantalus, suffering from
 a long and raging thirst,
 despised the stream;

and the greedy vulture
 did cease to eat and tear
 the growing liver of
 Tityus.

[NOT THE THOUGHTS ON EARTHLY THINGS.

¶ Atte þe laste þe lorde *and* Iuge of soules was moeued
3056

to misericordes *and* cried[e] we ben ouer comen quod
he. yif[e] we to orpheus his wijf to bere hym
campaigne

he haþ welle I-bouzt hir by his faire songe *and*
his ditee. but we wil putten a lawe in þis. *and*
couenaunt 3060

in þe 3ifte. þat is to seyne. þat til he be out of
helle yif he loke byhynden hym [þat] hys wijf shal
comen azeine to vs ¶ but what is he þat may zeue a
lawe to loueres. loue is a gretter lawe *and* a strengere
to 3064

hym self þan any lawe þat men may zeuen. ¶ Allas
whan Orpheus *and* his wijf were al most at þe termes
of

þe nyzt. þat is to seyne at þe last[e] boundes of helle.
Orpheus loked[e] abakwarde on Erudice his wijf *and* 3068
lost[e] hir *and* was deed. ¶ þis fable apperteineþ to
3ow alle who so euer desireþ or sekib to lede his
þouzte

in to þe souereyne day. þat is to seyne to clerenes[se]
of souereyne goode. ¶ For who so þat euere be so ouer
3072

comen þat he fycche hys eyen in to þe put[te] of helle.
þat is to seyne who so setteþ his þouztes in erþely
þinges. al þat euer he haþ drawen of þe noble good
celestial he lesib it whan he lokeþ þe helles. þat is to 3076
seyne to lowe þinges of þe erþe.

At length Pluto himself
relented, crying out, 'We
are overcome! Let us
give him back his wife,
he hath well won her by
his song.

But we will lay this
injunction upon him. Till
he escape the infernal
bounds, he shall not cast
a backward look.'

But, who shall give a
lover any law? Love is a
greater law than may be
given to any earthly
man.

Alas! having left the
realms of night, Orpheus
cast a look behind and
lost his too-much-loved
Euridice.

This fable belongs to all
you, whose minds would
view the Sovereign
Good.

For he who fixes his
thoughts upon earthly
things and low, must lose
the noble and heaven-
imparted Good.

EXPLICIT LIBER TERCIVS.

- 3022 *vnbynde*—*vnbyndyn*
bonde—*bondes*
- 3023 [*orpheus*]*—*from C.
somtyne—*whilom*
- 3024 *sorowe*—*sorwe*
- 3028 *dredles*—*dredeles*
to herkene—*forto herknenn*
- 3029 *had[de]*—*hadde*
- 3030 *pat* (2)—*omitted*
- 3031 *most[e]*—*moste*
- 3032 *hadde*—*hadden*
- 3033 *assuage*—*asswagen*
lorde—*lord*
- 3034 *pleyned[e]*—*pleynede*
godes—*heuene goodes*
- 3035 *wente*—MS. *wenten*, C. *wente*
- 3036 *tempred[e]* *hys*—*temprede hise*
- 3037 *of hys*—C. *omits*
spak—MS. *spakke*, C. *spak*
song—MS. *songe*, C. *soonge*
- 3038 *alle*—*al*
- 3039 *oute*—*owt*
goddesse—*goddes*
- 3040 *song*—MS. *songe*, C. *soonge*
mychel—*mochel*
- 3041 *myche*—*moche*
doubled[e]—*dowblede*
- 3042 *myzt[e]*—*myhte*
zeuen—*yeue*
teche—*thechen*
in—*herte*—*omitted*
- 3043 *commoeuede*—MS. *comaunded*, C. *commoeuede*
- 3044 *souzte*—*by-sowhte*
- 3045 *zelden*—*yilden*
- 3046 *his*—*hise*
- 3047 *cauzt*—MS. *cauzte*, C. *cawht*
new[e] *songe*—*newe song*
- 3049 *anoye*—*sorweful*—*anoy woxen soruful*

3050 *pan*—tho ne
3051 *whele*—wheel
3053 *prust*—thurst
 hyȝt—hihte
3054 *fulfilled*—fulfyld
3055 *songe*—song
3056 *Atte*—At
 lorde—lord
3057 *cried[e]*—cryde
3058 *yif[e]*—yiue
3059 *hap*—MS. haþe
 welle—wel
 faire—C. omits
 songe—song
3060 *wil putten*—wol putte
3062 *byhynden*—by-hynde
 [pat]—from C.
3063 *to*—vn-to
3064 *gretter*—gret
3066 *were al most*—weren almost
3067 *last[e]*—laste
3068 *loked[e] abakwarde*—lookede abacward
3069 *lost[e]*—loste
3070 *pouȝte*—thowht
3071 *clerenes[se]*—clernesse
3072 *souereyne goode*—souereyn god
3073 *put[te]*—putte
3074 *setteþ*—sette
3075 *hap*—MS. haþe

E EXISTENCE OF EVIL.

*INCIPIT LIBER QUARTUS.

[* fol. 24 b.]

HEC CUM PHILOSOPHIA DIGNITATE UULTUS.

[The 1^{ma} prose.]

Wanne philosophie hadde songen softly *and*
delitably

þe forseide þinges kepyng þe dignitee of hir
choere in þe wey3te of hir wordes. I þan þat ne hadde

3080

nat al outerly for3eten þe wepyng *and* mournyng
þat was set in myne herte for-brek þe entencioun of hir
þat entended[e] 3itte to seyne oþer þinges. ¶ Se *quod*
I. þou þat art gideresse of verray ly3te þe þinges þat
þou 3084

hast seid [me] hider to ben to me so clere *and* so
shewyng

by þe deuyne lokyng of hem *and* by þi resouns þat
þei ne mowe nat ben ouercomen. ¶ And þilke þingus
þat þou toldest me. al be it so þat I hadde som tyme

3088

fo[r]3eten hem for [the] sorwe of þe wronge þat haþ ben
don to me. 3it napeles þei ne were nat alouterly vnknownen
to me. but þis same is namly a gret cause of
my sorwe. þat so as þe gouernoure of þinges is goode.

3092

yif þat yuelys mowen ben by any weyes. or ellys yif
þat yuelys passen wiþ outen punyssheinge. þe whiche
þinge oonly how worþi it is to ben wondred vpon. þou
considerest it weel þi self certeynly. but 3itte to þis 3096
þing þere is an oþer þing y-ioigned more to ben
ywondred

vpon. ¶ For felonie is emperisse *and* flowreþ ful of
rycchesse. and vertues nis nat al oonly wiþ outen
medes.

When P. with grace and dignity had poured forth her songs, I, not quite quit of my load of grief, interrupted her as she was continuing her discourse.

All your discourses, O my conductress to the true light! have been very clear and unanswerable, both by the divine testimony which they carry along with them, and by thy irrefragable arguments.

Through the oppression of grief I had forgotten these truths, but was not wholly ignorant of them.

The principal cause of my trouble is this—that, whilst the absolute Ruler of all things is goodness itself, evil exists and is allowed to pass unpunished.

This, to say the least, is astonishing.

Moreover, while *vice* flourishes *virtue* is not only unrewarded, but trampled under foot by base and profligate men, and suffers the punishment due to impiety.

but it is cast vnder *and* fortroden vnder þe feet of felonous 3100

folk. *and* it abieþ þe tourmentes in sted of

wicked felouns ¶ Of al[le] whiche þing þer nis no wyȝt
þat [may] merueyllen ynouȝ ne compleyne þat swiche
þinges ben don in þe regne of god þat alle þinges woot.

3104

and alle þinges may *and* ne wool nat but only goode
þinges. ¶ þan seide she þus. certys *quod* she þat were
a grete meruayle *and* an enbaissyng wipouten ende.
and wel more horrible þan alle monstres yif it were as

3108

þou wenest. þat is to sein. þat in þe ryȝt ordeyne house
of so mochel a fader *and* an ordenour of meyne. þat þe
vesseles þat ben foule *and* vyle sholde ben honoured
and heried. and þe precious uesseles sholde ben defouled 3112

and vyle. but it nis nat so. For yif þe þinges

þat I haue concluded a litel here byforne ben kept
hoole

and vnaced. þou shalt wel knowe by þe auctorite of
god. of þe whos regne I speke þat certys þe good[e]

3116

folk ben alwey myȝty. *and* shrewes ben alwey yuel *and*
feble. ne þe vices ben neuere mo wip outen peyne ; ne
þe vertues ne ben nat wip outen mede. and þat
blisfulnesses

comen alwey to goode folke. *and* infortune comeþ 3120
alwey to wicked folke. ¶ And þou shalt wel knowe
many[e] þinges of þis kynde þat sholle cessen þi
pleyntes.

Here is cause for wonderment, since such things are possible under the government of an omniscient and omnipotent God, who wills nothing but what is the best.

P. It were indeed, not only marvellous, but also horribly monstrous, if, in the well-regulated family of so great a master, the worthless vessels should be honoured and the precious ones be despised:—but it is not so.

For if the conclusions we have come to, be sound and irrefragable, we must confess that under God's rule the *good* are always powerful and mighty, and the *wicked* weak and contemptible;

that vice never passes unpunished, nor virtue goes unrewarded;

that happiness attends good men, and misfortune falls to the lot of the wicked.

These and many other truths of like nature shall be proved to thee, and shall put an end to thy complaints,

and stedfast þe wiþ stedfast saddenese. ¶ And for þou
hast seyn þe forme of þe verray blisfulnesse by me þat
3124

[haue] somtyme I-shewed it þe. And þou hast knowen
in whom blysfulnesse is set. alle þinges I treted þat I
trowe ben nessessarie to put[te] furþe ¶ I shal shewe
þe. þe weye þat shal brynge þe aʒeyne vnto þi house 3128
and I shal ficche feþeres in þi þouʒt by whiche it may
arysen in heyʒte. so þat al tribulacioun don away þou
by my gidyng & by my pape and by my sledes shalt
mowen retourne hool and sounde in to þi contre. 3132

and strengthen thee with
firmness and solidity.
Having shown you a
picture of true felicity,
and wherein it resides, I
shall now trace out the
way which will lead you
to your home.

I will give your soul
wings to soar aloft, so
that all tribulation being
removed, you may,
under my guiding, by my
road, and with my
vehicle, return whole and
sound into your own
country.

3078 *softly*—softely

3080 *choere in*—cheere and

3082 *set*—MS. sette, C. set

myne—Myn

for-brek—MS. for-breke, C. Forbrak

3083 *entended[e]*—entendede

3084 *lyʒte*—lyht

3085 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seid

[*me*]—from C.

3086 *þi*—the

3087 *mowe*—mowen

3088 *som tyme*—whilom

3089 [*the*]—from C.

wronge—wrong

hap—MS. haþe

3090 *don*—MS. done, C. don

were—weeren

3091 *namly*—namely

3092 *goode*—good

3094 *wiþ outen*—with owte

3095 *þinge*—thing

3097 *þere*—ther

ben ywondred—be wondryd

3098 *flowreþ*—MS. folweþ, C. flowrith

3099 *rycchesse*—Rychesses
 vertues—vertu
 wiþ outen—with owte
3101 *in sted*—in stide
3102 *wicked*—wikkede
 al[le]—alle
 þing—thinges
3103 [*may*]—from C.
3104 *don*—MS. done, C. doon
3105 *wool*—wole
 goode—good
3107 *grete*—gret
 *enbaissyng*e—enbasshinge
3108 *alle*—al
3109 *ordeyne house*—ordenee hows
3111, 3113 *vyle*—vyl
3112 *heried*—he heryed
 sholde—sholden
3113 *þe*—tho
3114 *here byforne*—her byforn
 kept—MS. kepte, C. kept
3116 *good[e]*—goode
3117 *alwey* (2)—*feble*—alwey owt cast *and* feble
3118, 3119 *wiþ outen*—with owte
3119 *vertues*—vertuus
3122 *many[e]*—manye
 sholle cessen—shollen cesen
3123 *stedfast*—*stedfast*—strengthyn the *with* stidfast
3124 *seyn*—MS. seyne, C. seyn
3125 [*haue*]—from C.
 somtyme—whilom
3126 *set*—MS. sette, C. I-set
3127 *put[te] furþe*—putten forth
3128 *weye*—wey
 brynge—bryngen
 þi house—thin hows
3129 *ficche*—fycchen
3130 *arysen*—areysen
 don—MS. done, C. ydoñ
3131 *pape*—paath
 shalt mowen—shal mowe
3132 *sounde*—sownd

¶TUE NEVER GOES UNREWARDED.

SUNT ETENIM PENNE. ET CETERA.

[The fyrste metur.]

I Haue for soþe swifte feþeres þat surmounten þe
heyȝt
of þe heuene whan þe swifte þouȝt haþ cloped it self.
in þo feþeres it dispiseþ þe hat[e]ful erþes. *and*
surmounteþ
þe heyȝenesse of þe greet[e] eyir. *and* it seiþ þe 3136
cloudes by-hynde hir bak *and* passeþ þe heyȝt of þe
regioun of þe fire þat eschaufiþ by þe swifte moeuynge
of
þe firmament. til þat she a-reisiþ hir in til þe houses þat
beren þe sterres. *and* ioyngeþ hir weyes wiþ þe sonne 3140
phebus. *and* felawshiþeþ þe weye of þe olde colde
saturnus. *and* she ymaked a knyȝt of þe clere sterre.
þat is to seyne þat þe soule is maked goddis knyȝt by
þe sekyng of treuþe to comen to þe verray knowlege of 3144
god. *and* þilke soule renne[þ] by þe cercle *of þe
sterres
in alle þe places þere as þe shynyng nyȝt is depeynted.
þat is to seyne þe nyȝt þat is cloudeles. for on nyȝtes
þat
ben cloudeles it semeþ as þe heuene were peynted wiþ
3148
dyuerse ymages of sterres. *and* whan þe soule haþ gon
ynouȝ she shal forleten þe last[e] poynt of þe heuene.

I have nimble wings that
enable the mind to rise
from earth to heaven, to
leave the clouds behind,
to pass the region of
perpetual flame, and to
reach the starry mansion,
journeying either by
Phœbus' radiant path, or
accompanying cold and
aged Saturn, or riding, as
a soldier, with Mars.

[Chaucer's Gloss.]

Through every sphere
she (the mind) runs
where night is most
cloudless and where the
sky is decked with stars,
until she reaches the
heaven's utmost sphere

—
[* fol. 25.]

¶E IS ALWAYS PUNISHED.

and she shal pressen *and* wenden on þe bak of þe
swifte

then pressing on she
shall be prepared to see
the true Source of Light,

firmament. and she shal ben maked *perfit* of þe
dredefulle 3152

clerenesse of god. ¶ þere haldeþ þe lorde of kynges
þe ceptre of his myȝt *and* attempereþ þe gouernementes
of þis worlde. *and* þe shynynge iuge of þinges stable in
hym self gouerneþ þe swifte carte. þat is to seyne þe
3156

circuler moeuynge of [the] sonne. *and* yif þi weye ledeþ
þe aȝeyne so þat þou be brouȝt þider. þan wilt þou seye
now þat þat is þe contre þat þou requeredest of whiche
þou
ne haddest no mynde. but now it remembreþ me wel
3160

here was I born. here wil I fastne my degree. here wil
I dwelle. but yif þe lyke þan to loken on þe derkenesse
of þe erþe þat þou hast for-leten. þan shalt þou seen þat
þise felonous tyrauntes þat þe wrecched[e] poeple
dredeþ 3164

now shule ben exiled from þilke faire contre.

where the great King of
kings bears his mighty
sceptre, and holds the
reins of the universe.

Here the great Judge,
standing in shining
robes, firmly guides his
winged chariot, and rules
the tumultuous affairs of
the world.

If you at length shall
arrive at this abode, you
will say this is my
country—here I was
born—and here will I
abide.

And should you deign to
look on the gloomy
earth, you'll see those
tyrants, the fear of
wretched folk, banished
from those fair realms.

3133 *heyȝt of þe heuene*—heyhte of heuene

3134 *hap*—MS. haþe

3136 *heyȝenesse*—*eyir*—Roundnesse of the grete ayr
seip—seth

3137 *hir*—his

3138 *fire*—Fyr
eschaufiþ—MS. eschaufiþe

3139 *she*—he
hir—hym

3140 *hir*—his

3141 *weye*—wey
þe—*saturnus*—MS. saturnus þe olde colde

3142 *saturnus*—saturnis
she—he

3143 *soule*—thowght

3144 *treupe*—trowthe
 knowlege—knoleche
 3145 *soule*—thoght
 3146 *depeynted*—painted
 3149-50 *and whan*—*she shal*—*and* whanne he hath I-doon there I-nowh he shal
 3149 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 3150 *þe last[e]*—*heuene*—the laste heuene
 3151-2 *she*—he
 3152-3 *of þe*—*of god*—of the worshipful lyht of god
 3153 *þere haldeþ*—ther halt
 3155 *þis worlde*—the world
 3156 *carte*—cart or wayn
 3157 [*the*]—from C.
 3159 *whiche*—which
 3161 *here* (1, 2, 3)—her
 born—MS. *borne*, C. *born*
 wil (1)—wol
 wil (2)—wole
 3162 *lyke*—liketh
 derkenesse—dyrknesses
 3164 *wrecched[e]*—wrecchede
 3165 *shule*—shollen
 from—fro

E GOOD ARE ALWAYS STRONG.

[TUNC EGO PAPE INQUAM. ET CETERA.](#)

[The 2^e prose.]

P Anne seide I þus. [owh] I wondre me þat þou by-
 hetest
 me so grete þinges. ne I ne doute nat þat þou
 ne mayst wel performe þat þou by-hetest. but I preie þe 3168
 oonly þis. þat þou ne tarie nat to telle me þilke þinges
 þat þou hast meoued. first *quod* she þou most nedes
 knowen. þat good[e] folk ben al wey strong[e] *and*
 myȝty. and þe shrewes ben feble *and* desert *and* naked
 3172

B. Ah! thou promisest
 me great things indeed!
 —but without delay,
 satisfy the expectations
 you have raised.

P. You must first be
 convinced that the good
 are always strong and
 powerful and the wicked
 destitute of strength.

of alle strengþes. and of þise þinges certys eueryche of hem is declared *and* shewed by oþer. ¶ For so as good *and* yuel ben two contraries. yif so be þat goode be stedfast. þan sheweþ þe fieblesse of yuel al openly. and
3176

yif þou knowe clerely þe freelnesse of yuel. þe stedfastnesse of goode is knowen. but for as moche as þe fey of my sentence shal be þe more ferme *and* haboundaunt. I wil goon by þat oon wey *and* by þat oþer *and* I wil conferme 3180

þe þinges þat ben purposed now on þis side *and* now on þat syde. ¶ Two þinges þer ben in whiche þe effect of alle þe dedes of man kynde standip. þat is to seyn. wil *and* power. and yif þat oon of þise two fayleþ
3184

þere nis no þing þat may be don. for yif þat wil lakkeþ þere nys no wyȝt þat vndirtakeþ to done þat he wol not don. and yif power fayleþ þe wille nis but in ydel *and* stant for nauȝt. and þer of comeþ it þat yif þou se a 3188 wyȝt þat wolde geten þat he may nat geten. þou mayst nat douten þat power ne fayleþ hym to hauen þat he wolde. ¶ þis is open *and* clere quod I. ne it may nat ben denyed in no manere. and yif þou se a wyȝt quod
3192

she. þat haþ don þat he wolde don þou nilt nat douten þat he ne haþ had power to done it. no quod. I. and in þat. þat euery wyȝt may. in þat þat men may holden hym myȝty. as who seiþ in as moche as a man is myȝty
3196

These assertions do mutually demonstrate each other.

For since good and evil are contrary, if good be powerful evil must be impotent. And if the frailty of evil is known, the strength and stability of good must also be known to you.

But to convince you I shall proceed to prove it from both these principles, establishing these truths, by arguments drawn first from one of these topics and then from the other.

Two things are necessary to every action—the Will and the Power; if either be wanting, nothing can be effected.

A man can do nothing without the concurrence of his will, and if power faileth the will is of no effect.

Hence, if you see a person desirous of getting what he cannot procure, you are sure he lacks power to obtain it.

And if you see another do what he had a mind to do, can you doubt that he had the power to do it?

B. No, surely.

P. A man, then, is esteemed powerful in respect of what he is able to do, and weak in relation to what he is unable to perform.

to done a þing. in so moche men halden hym myȝty.
and in þat þat he ne may. in þat men demen hym to
ben feble. I confesse it wel quod I. Remembriþ þe
quod

she þat I. haue gadred *and* shewed by forseide resouns
3200

þat al þe entencioun of þe wil of mankynde whiche þat
is lad by diuerse studies hastiþ to comen to blisfulnesse.
¶ It remembreþ me wel quod I þat it hath ben shewed.

E IMPOTENCY OF THE WICKED.

and recorderþ þe nat þan quod she. þat blisfulnesse is
3204

þilke same goode þat men requeren. so þat whan þat
blisfulnesse is requered *of alle. þat goode [also] is
requered *and* desired of al. It recorderþ me wel quod I.
for haue it gretly alwey ficche[d] in my memorie. alle
3208

folk þan quod she goode *and* eke badde enforcen hem
wiþ oute difference of entencioun to comen to goode.
þat is a uerray consequence quod I. and certeyne is
quod

she þat by þe getyng of goode ben men ymaked goode. 3212

þis is certeyne quod. I. ¶ þan geten goode men þat þei
desiren. so semeþ it quod I. but wicked[e] folk quod
she yif þei geten þe goode þat þei desiren þei [ne]
mowen nat ben wicked. so is it quod .I. ¶ þan so as 3216
þat oon *and* þat oþer [quod she] desiren good. *and* þe
goode folk geten good *and* nat þe wicked folk ¶ þan
nis it no doute þat þe goode folk ne ben myȝty *and* þe

B. That is true.

P. Do you remember that
I proved that the will of
man, following different
pursuits, seeks happiness
only?

Do you recollect too,
that it has been shown
that happiness is the
supreme good of men—
and all desire this good,
since all seek happiness?
[* fol. 25 b.]

All men, then, good and
bad, seek to acquire
good?

And it is certain that
when men obtain good
they become good?

B. It is most certain.

P. Do good men, then,
get what they desire?

B. It seems so.

P. If evil men obtain the
good, they can be no
longer evil?

B. It is so.

P. Since then both parties
pursue the good, which
only the virtuous obtain,
we must believe that

wicked folk ben feble. ¶ who so þat euer quod I 3220
douteþ of þis. he ne may nat considre þe nature of
þinges. ne þe consequence of resoun. and ouer þis
quod she.

good men are powerful,
and that the wicked are
weak and feeble?
B. None can doubt this,
save such as either
consider not rightly the
nature of things, or are
incapable of
comprehending the force
of any reasoning.

E WICKED DO NOT SEEK ARIGHT THE SUPREME GOOD.

¶ yif þat þer ben two þinges þat han o same
purpos by kynde. and þat one of hem pursueþ and
performeþ 3224

þilke same þinge by naturel office. and þat oþer
ne may nat done þilk naturel office. but folweþ by
oþer manere þan is couenable to nature ¶ Hym þat
acomplisþ hys purpos kyndely. and 3it he ne
acomplisþ 3228

P. If two beings have the
same end in view—and
one of them
accomplishes his
purpose by the use of
natural means, while the
other not using
legitimate means does
not attain his end—
which of these two is the
most powerful?

nat hys owen purpos. wheþer of þise two demest
þou for more my3ty. ¶ yif þat I coniecte quod .I. þat
þou wilt seye algates. 3it I desire to herkene it more
pleynely of þe. þou nilt nat þan denye quod she þat þe
3232

B. Illustrate your
meaning more clearly.

moeuement3 of goynge nis in men by kynde. no for
soþe

P. The motion of walking
is natural to man? And
this motion is the natural
office of the feet? Do
you grant this?

quod I. ne þou ne doutest nat quod she þat þilke naturel
office of goynge ne be þe office of feet. I ne doute
it nat quod .I. þan quod she yif þat a wy3t be my3ty to
3236

B. I do.

moeue and goþ vpon hys feet. and anoþer to whom
þilke naturel office of feet lakkeþ. enforceþ hym to
gone

P. If, then, he who is able
to use his feet walks,
whilst another lacking
this power creeps on his
hands—surely he that is
able to move naturally
upon his feet is more
powerful than he who
cannot.

crepynge vpon hys handes. ¶ whiche of þise two au3te

to ben holden more my3ty by ry3t. knyȝt furþe þe remenaunt 3240

quod I. ¶ For no wyȝt ne douteþ þat he þat
may gone by naturel office of feet. ne be more myȝty
þan he þat ne may nat ¶ but þe souereyne good quod
she þat is euenlyche purposed to þe good folk *and* to
3244

badde. þe good folke seken it by naturel office of
uertues. *and* þe shrewes enforcen hem to geten it by
dyuerse couetise of erþely þinges. whiche þat nis no
naturel office to geten þilke same souereyne goode. 3248
trowest þou þat it be any oþer wyse. nay quod .I. for þe
consequence is open *and* shewyng of þinges þat I
haue

graunted. ¶ þat nedes goode folk moten ben myȝty.
and shrewes feble *and* vnmyȝty. ¶ þou rennest aryȝt
3252

byfore me quod she. *and* þis is þe iugement þat is to
seyn. ¶ I iuge of þe ryȝt as þise leches ben wont forto
hopen of seke folk whan þei aperceyuen þat nature is
redressed *and* wiþstondeþ to þe maladie. ¶ But for I
3256

see þe now al redy to þe vndirstandyng I shal shewe
þe more þilke *and* continuel resouns. ¶ For loke now
how gretly shewiþ þe feblesse *and* infirmite of wicked
folke. þat ne mowen nat come to þat hire naturel 3260
entencioun ledeþ hem. *and* ȝitte almost þilk naturel
entencioun constreineþ hem. ¶ *and* what were to deme
þan of shrewes. yif þilke naturel helpe hadde for-leten
hem. ¶ þe whiche naturel helpe of entencioun goþ
alwey 3264

P. The good and bad seek the supreme good: the good by the natural means of virtue—the wicked by gratifying divers desires of earthly things (which is not the natural way of obtaining it).

Do you think otherwise?

B. The consequence is plain, and that follows from what has been granted—that the good are powerful, while the wicked are feeble.

P. You rightly anticipate me; for it is a good sign, as physicians well know, when Nature exerts herself and resists the malady.

But, as you are so quick of apprehension, I shall continue this mode of reasoning.

The weakness of the wicked is conspicuous—they cannot attain the end to which their natural disposition prompts and almost compels them; what would become of them without this natural prompting, so powerful and irresistible?

byforne hem. *and* is so grete þat vnneþ it may be ouercomen. ¶ Considre þan how gret defaute of power *and* how gret feblesse þere is in grete felonous folk as who seiþ þe gretter þinges þat ben coueited *and* þe desire 3268

nat accomplissed of þe lasse myȝt is he þat coueiteþ it *and* may nat acomplisse. ¶ And forþi philosophie seiþ þus by souereyne good. ¶ Sherewes ne requere nat lyȝt[e] medes ne veyne gaines whiche þei ne may nat 3272

folwen ne holden. but þei faylen of þilke some of þe heyȝte of þinges þat is to seyne souereyne good. ne þise wrecches ne comen nat to þe effect of souereyne good. *þe whiche þei enforcen hem oonly to geten by nyȝtes 3276

and by dayes. ¶ In þe getyn[g] of whiche goode þe strengþe of good folk. is ful wel ysen. For ryȝt so as þou myȝtest demen hym myȝty of goynge þat goþ on his feet til he myȝt[e] come to þilke place fro þe whiche 3280

place þere ne lay no wey forþer to be gon. Ryȝt so most þou nedes demen hym for ryȝt myȝty þat getiþ *and* atteiniþ to þe ende of alle þinges þat ben to desire. by-ȝonde þe whiche ende þat þer nis no þing to desire. 3284

E WICKED HAVE NO REAL EXISTENCE.

¶ Of whiche power of good folk men may conclude þat wicked men semen to ben bareyne *and* naked of alle strengþe. For whi forleten þei vertues *and* folwen

Consider how great is the impotence of the wicked. (The greater the things desired, but unaccomplished, the less is the power of him that desires, and is unable to attain his end.)

The wicked seek after no trivial things—which they fail to obtain; but they aspire in vain to the sovereign good, which they endeavour day and night to obtain.

[* fol. 26.]

The good attain the end of their desires, and therein their power is manifested. For as you deem him a good walker that goes to the end of his journey, so you must esteem him powerful that attains his desires, beyond which there is nothing to desire.

Wicked men, then, are destitute of those powers which the good so amply possess.

vices. nis it nat for þat þei ne knowen nat þe goodes.

3288

¶ But what þing is more feble *and* more caitif þan is þe blyndenesse of ignoraunce. or ellys þei knowen ful wel whiche þinges þat þei auzten to folwen ¶ but lecherye *and* couetise ouerproweþ hem mysturned. ¶ and certis

3292

so doþ distemperaunce to feble men. þat ne mowen nat wrastle azeins þe vices ¶ Ne knowen þei nat þan wel þat þei foreleten þe good wilfully. *and* turnen hem vilfully

to vices. ¶ And in þis wise þei ne forleten nat 3296 oonly to ben myzty. but þei forleten al outerly in any wise forto ben ¶ For þei þat forleten þe comune fyn of alle þinges þat ben. þei for-leten also þerwiþ al forto ben. and peraunture it sholde semen to som folk þat

3300

þis were a merueile to seyne þat shrewes whiche þat contienen þe more *partie* of men ne ben nat. ne han no beynge. ¶ but napeles it is so. *and* þus stant þis þing for þei þat ben shrewes I denye nat þat þei ben shrewes. 3304

but I denye *and* sey[e] symplely and pleynly þat þei [ne] ben nat. ne han no beynge. for ryzt as þou myztest seyn of þe careyne of a man þat it were a ded man.

¶ but þou ne myztest nat symplely callen it a man. 3308

¶ So graunt[e] I wel for soþe þat vicious folk ben wicked. but I ne may nat graunten absolutely *and* symplely þat þei ben. ¶ For þilk þing þat wiþ holdeþ ordre *and* kepiþ nature. þilk þing is *and* hap

Wherefore do they leave virtue, and follow vice? Is it because they are ignorant of good?

What is more weak and base than the blindness of ignorance? Or do they know the way they ought to follow, but are led astray by lust and covetousness?

And so, indeed, weak-minded men are overpowered by intemperance, for they cannot resist vicious temptations.

Do they willingly desert Good and turn to Evil? If they do so, they not only cease to be powerful, but even cease to exist.

For those who neglect the common end of all beings, cease to exist.

You may marvel that I assert that the wicked, the majority of the human race, have no existence—but it is, however, most true.

That the wicked are bad I do not deny—

but I do not admit that they have any real existence.

You may call a corpse a dead man, but you cannot with propriety call it a man. So the vicious are profligate men, but I cannot confess they absolutely exist.

That thing exists that preserves its rank, nature, and constitution,

3312

beynge. but þat þing þat faileþ of þat. þat is to seyne
he þat forletip naturel ordre he for-letip þilk beyng
þat is set in hys nature. but þou wolt sein þat shrewes
mowen. ¶ Certys þat ne denye I nat. ¶ but certys 3316
hir power ne descendep nat of strengþe but of feblesse.
for þei mowen don wickednesses. þe whiche þei ne
myȝten nat don yif þei myȝten dwelle in þe forme *and*
in þe doynge of goode folke. ¶ And þilke power 3320
sheweþ ful euydently þat þei ne mowen ryȝt nauȝt.

WER, AN ATTRIBUTE OF THE CHIEF GOOD.

¶ For so as I haue gadered *and* proued a lytel her
byforn
þat yuel is nauȝt. *and* so as shrewes mowen oonly
but shrewednesse. þis conclusioun is al clere. þat 3324
shrewes ne mowen ryȝt nat to han power. and for as
moche as þou vndirstonde whiche is þe strengþe þat is
power of shrewes. I haue diffinised a lytel here byforn
þat no þing nis so myȝty as souereyne good ¶ þat is
3328

soþe quod .I. [*and* thilke same souereyn good may don
non yuel // Certes no quod I] ¶ Is þer any wyȝt þan
quod she þat wenip þat men mowen don alle þinges.
No man quod .I. but yif he be out of hys witte. ¶ but
3332

certys shrewes mowen doñ yuel quod she. ¶ ȝe wolde
god quod I þat þei ne myȝten don none. þat quod she
so as he þat is myȝty to done oonly but good[e] þinges
may don alle þinges. and þei þat ben myȝty to done

but when it loses these
essentials it ceases to be.

But, you may say that
the wicked have a *power*
to act, nor do I deny it;
but their power is an
effect of weakness.
They can do evil, but this
they could not do, if they
retained the power of
doing good.

This power, then, clearly
shows their impotence.

For as evil is nothing, it
is clear that while the
wicked can only do evil
they can do nothing.

That you may
understand the force of
this power, I have proved
that nothing is more
powerful than the
sovereign good.

B. That is true.

P. And that supreme
good can do no evil?

B. Certainly not.

P. Is there any one who
thinks that man can do
all things?

B. No sane man can
think so.

P. But men may do evil.

B. I would to God they
could not.

P. Since he that can do
good, can do all things,
and he that has power to

3336

yuel[e] þinges ne mowen nat alle þinges. þan is þis
open

þing *and* manifest þat þei þat mowen don yuel ben of
lasse power. and 3itte to proue þis conclusioun þere
helpeþ me þis þat I haue shewed here byforne. þat al
3340

power is to be noumbred amonge þinges þat men
au3ten

requere. *and* haue shewed þat alle þinges þat au3ten ben
desired ben referred to good ry3t as to a manere hey3te
of hyr nature. ¶ But for to mowen don yuel *and* 3344
felonye ne may nat ben referred to good. þan nis nat
yuel of þe noumbre of þinges þat au3ten. *be desired.

but al power au3t[e] ben desired *and* requered. ¶ þan is
it open *and* cler þat þe power ne þe moeuyng of
shrewes 3348

nis no powere. *and* of alle þise þinges it sheweþ wel
þat
þe goode folk ben certeynly my3ty. *and* þe shrewes
ben

douteles vnmy3ty ¶ And it is clere *and* open þat þilke
sentence of plato is uerray *and* soþe. þat seyþ þat
oonly 3352

wisemen may [doon] þat þei desiren. *and* shrewes
mowen haunten þat hem lykeþ. but þat þei desiren þat
is to seyne to comen to souereyne good þei ne han no
power to acomplissen þat. ¶ For shrewes don þat hem
3356

list whan by þo þinges in whiche þei deliten þei wenen

do evil cannot do all
things, therefore the evil-
doers are less powerful.

Let me add too that
power is one of the
things to be desired, and
that all such things are to
be referred to the chief
good (the perfection of
their nature).

But the power of doing
evil has no relation to
that Good, therefore it is
not desirable;

[* fol. 26 b.]

but as all power is
desirable, it is clear that
the ability to do evil is
not power.

It clearly follows from
this reasoning, that the
good only are powerful
while the vicious are
feeble.

And Plato's opinion is
hereby verified that the
wise only have the power
to do what they desire;
the wicked may follow
the dictates of their lusts,
but their great aim and
desire, *i. e.* HAPPINESS,
they can never attain.

The wicked may gratify
their desires, thinking to
attain the chief good (for
which they wish), but
they can never possess it,

to atteyne to þilke good þat þei desiren. but þei ne
geten
ne atteynen nat þer to. ¶ for vices ne comen nat to
blisfulnesse. 3360

for impiety and vice can
never be crowned with
happiness.

3166 [*owh*]*—*from C.
3171 *good*[*e*]*—*goode
 strong[*e*]*—*stronge
3172 *desert**—*dishert
3173 *eueryche**—*euerich
3175 *goode**—*good
3176 *stedfast**—*stidefast
3177 *freelnesse**—*frelenesse
 *stedfastnesse**—*stidefastnesse
3178 *goode**—*good
3180 *oon**—*oo
 wil (2)*—*wole
3185-6 *pere**—*ther
3185 *don**—*MS. done, C. don
3186 *done**—*don
3187 *wille**—*wil
3188 *comeþ**—*comht
3189 *mayst**—*MS. mayste, C. mayst
3191 *clere**—*cler
3192 *denyed**—*denoyed
3193-4 *hap**—*MS. hape
3193 *don* (*both*)*—*MS. done, C. doon
3194 *had**—*MS. hadde, C. had
 *done**—*doon
3196 *as moche**—*so moche
3197 *done**—*doon
 *moche**—*mochel
 *halden**—*halt
3201 *whiche**—*which
3202 *lad**—*MS. ladde, C. lad
3203 *it hath ben**—*MS. I herde þe, C. it hath ben
3205-6 *goode**—*good
3206 [*also*]*—*from C.

3207 *al*—alle
 It—I—it ne recordeth me nat *quod* I
 3210-12(1)-15 *goode*—good
 3214 *wicked*[*e*]—wikkede
 3215 [*ne*]—from C.
 3216 *mowen*—mowe
 3217 [*quod she*]—from C.
 3218 *wicked*—wilke (? wikke)
 3220 *wicked*—wikkede
 3226 *pilk*—thilke
 3229 *owen*—owne
 3231 *wilt*—wolt
 herkene—herkne
 3232 *pleynely*—pleynly
 denye—denoye
 3233 *moeument3*—Moeument
 3237 *gop*—MS. gope
 hys—hise
 3238 *gone*—goon
 3239 *hys*—hise
 whiche—which
 3240 *more*—the Moore
 furpe—forth
 3242 *gone*—gon
 3245 *good*—goode
 3246 *uertues*—vertuus
 3247 *whiche*—which
 3248 *goode*—good
 3253 *byfore*—by-forn
 3254 *forto*—to
 3255 *seke*—sike
 3259 *wicked*—wikkede
 3260 *come*—comyn
 3261 *pilk*—thilke
 3262 *deme*—demen
 3263-4 *helpe*—help
 3264 *whiche*—which
 gop—MS. gope
 3265 *grete*—gret
 vnneþ—vnnethe
 be ouercomen—ben ouercome

3267 *pere*—ther
 grete—wikkede
 3268 *pinges*—thing
 ben—is
 3271 *Sherewes ne requere*—ne shrewes ne requeren
 3272 *lyzt[e]*—lyhte
 veyne—veyn
 nat—omitted
 3276 *whiche*—which
 3277 *getyn[g]*—getinge
 whiche goode—which good
 3278 *ysen*—MS. and C. ysene
 3279 *gop*—MS. gope
 3280 *myzt[e]*—myhte
 3281 *pere*—ther
 lay—laye
 forper—forthere
 be—ben
 3283 *desire*—desired
 3284 *pat*—omitted
 3285 *whiche*—the which
 pat—pat the
 3286 *ben*—be
 3291 *auzten to folwen*—owhten folwe
 3293 *dop*—MS. dope, C. doth
 3394 *wrastle*—wrastlen
 3295 *vilfully*—wilsfully
 3297 *outerly*—owtrely
 3301 *seyne*—seyen
 3304-5 *denye*—denoye
 3305 *sey[e] symplely*—seye sympeli
 3306 [*ne*]—from C.
 3307 *seyn*—seyen
 3309 *graunt[e]*—graunte
 3311-12 *pilk*—thilke
 3312 *hap*—MS. hape
 3313 *pat* (1)—what
 seyne—seyen
 3314 *pilk*—thilke
 3315 *set*—MS. sette, C. set
 3316 *denye*—denoye

3318 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 3319 *myȝten* (1)—myhte
 dwelle—dwellin
 3320 *goode*—good
 3324 *shrewednesse*—shrewednesses
 clere—cleer
 3325 *nat*—*power*—nawht ne han no power
 3326 *whiche*—which
 þat is—of this
 3327 *here*—her
 3328 *nis*—is
 3329 *soþe*—soth
 3329, 3330 [*and thilke*—*quod I*]*—from C.*
 3334 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 none þat—non thanne
 3335 *done*—doon
 good[e]—goode
 3336 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 done—don
 3337 *yuel[e]*—yuele
 þis—it
 3338 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 3339 *ȝitte*—yit
 þere—ther
 3340 *shewed here byforne*—Ishewed her by-forn
 al—alle
 3341 *amonge*—among
 3344 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 3346 *auȝten be*—owhte ben
 3347 *al*—alle
 auȝt[e]—owhte
 3351 *clere*—cler
 3352 *soþe*—soth
 þat seyþ—MS. but siþe, C. þat seyth
 3353 [*doon*]*—from C.*
 3355 *seyne*—seyn
 3357 *whiche*—which

E WICKED ARE UNHAPPY.

[The ij^{de} Metur.]

QUOS UIDES SEDERE CELSOS.

Who so þat þe couertures of her veyn appaiailes
myzt[e] strepen of þise proude kynges þat þou
seest sitten on heyze in her chayeres glyteryng in
shynyng purple envyroneð wip sorweful armures 3364
manasyng wip cruel mouþe. blowyng by woodnesse of
herte. ¶ He sholde se þan þat ilke lordes beren wip
inne hir corages ful streyte cheynes for leccherye
tormentip
hem on þat oon syde wip gredy venyms *and* 3368
troublable Ire þat ariseþ in hem þe floodes of troubynges
tourmentip vpon þat oper side hir þouzt. or sorwe halt
hem wery or ycauht. or slidyng *and* disseyuyng hope
tourmentip hem. And þerfore syn þou seest on heed.
3372
þat is to seyne oon tyraunt bere so many[e] tyrauntis.
þan ne doþ þilk tyraunt nat þat he desirip. syn he
is cast doune wip so many[e] wicked lordes. þat is to
seyn wip so many[e] vices. þat han so wicked lordshipes 3376
ouer hym.

Whosoever might strip
of their purple coverings,
proud kings, who,
surrounded by their
guards, sit on lofty
thrones, and whose stern
looks wear fierce
threatenings, and boiling
breasts breathe fury;
would see those mighty
lords inwardly fettered,
and tormented by lust,
passion, grief, and
delusive hopes.

Since, then, so many
tyrants bear sway over
one head—that lord,
oppressed by so many
masters (i. e. vices), is
weak and feeble, and his
actions are not obedient
to his will.

3361-63 *her*—hir

3362 *myzt[e]*—myhte

3363 *heyze*—heygh

3364 *sorweful*—sorwful

3365 *mouþe*—Mowth

3366 *se*—seen

ilke—thilke

3368 *on*—in

3369 *hem*—hym

3371 *disseyuyng*—deceyuyng

3373 *seyne*—seyn

bere—beeren

3373-75-76 *many[e]*—manye

3373 *tyrauntis*—tyranyes

3374 *dop*—MS. *dope*

pilk—thilke

3375 *doune*—down

wicked—wikkede

3376 *wicked*—wikkedly

EY DO NOT ESCAPE PUNISHMENT.

VIDES NE IGITUR QUANTO.

S Eest þou nat þan in how gret filþe þise shrewes
ben

ywrapped. *and* wiþ whiche cleernesse þise good
folk shynen. In þis sheweþ it wel þat to good folk ne
3380

lakkeþ neuer mo hir medes. ne shrewes ne lakken
neuer mo *tourmentis*. for of alle þinges þat ben ydon
þilke þing for whiche any þing is doon. it semeþ as by
ryȝt þat þilke þing be þe mede of þat. as þus. ¶ yif a
3384

man renneþ in þe stadie or in þe forlonge for þe corone.
þan lieþ þe mede in þe corone for whiche he renneþ.

¶ And I haue shewed þat blisfulnesse is þilke same
good for whiche þat alle þingus ben don. þan is þilke
3388

same good purposed to þe werkes of mankynde ryȝt as
a comune mede. whiche mede ne may ben disseuered
fro good folk. for no wyȝt as by ryȝt fro þennes forþe
þat hym lakkiþ goodnesse ne shal ben cleped good.
3392

For whiche þing folk of good[e] maneres her medes ne
forsaken hem neuer mo. For al be it so þat sherewes

[The iij.^{de} prose.]

See you not in how great
and filthy a mire the
wicked wallow?

This is a proof that good
folks do not go
unrewarded, nor do the
evil-doers escape
punishment.

Every action is done for
a certain end, and that
end is the reward of the
action.

But Happiness is that
good for which all things
are done. Therefore
happiness is the reward
which all the human race
seek as the reward of
their actions.

This good is inseparable
from the virtuous,
therefore virtue can
never want its reward.

Evil men may rage as
they please against the

waxen as wood as hem list aȝeynes good[e] folk. ȝitte
neuer þe les þe corone of wise men ne shal nat fallen

3396

ne faden. ¶ For foreine shrewednesse ne bynymep
nat fro þe corages of good[e] folk hire propre honoure.

good, but the crown of
the wise shall not fall nor
fade.

The wickedness of
another cannot deprive a
virtuous soul of its own
honour.

E REWARD OF THE GOOD.

but yif þat any wyȝt reioiseþ hem of goodnesse þat þei
had[de] taken fro wiþoute. as who seiþ yif [þat] any

3400

wyȝt had[de] hys goodnesse of any oþer man þan of
hym self. certys he þat ȝaf hym þilke goodnesse or
ellys som oþer wyȝt myȝt[e] bynym[e] it hym. but for
as moche as to euery wyȝt hys owen propre bounte 3404
ȝeueþ hym hys mede. þan at arst shal he faylen of
mede whan he forletip to ben good. *and* at þe laste so
as alle medes ben requered for men wenen þat þei ben
good[e]. who is he þat wolde deme þat he þat is ryȝt

3408

myȝty of goode were partles of mede. **and* of what
mede shal he be gerdoned. certys of ryȝt faire mede
and ryȝt greet abouen alle medes. ¶ Remembre þe of
þilk noble corolarie þat I ȝaf þe a lytel here byforne.

3412

and gadre it to gidre in þis manere. so as god hym self
is blisfulnesse. þan is it clere *and* certeyn. þat alle good
folk ben makid blisful for þei ben good[e]. and þilke
folk þat ben blisful it accordip *and* is couenable to ben

3416

godde[s]. þan is þe mede of goode folk swiche. þat no

If a man pride himself on
the possession of an
advantage received from
another, he may be
deprived of it, either by
the giver or by others.

But, as the reward of the
virtuous is derived from
virtue, a man cannot lose
this meed unless he
ceases to be virtuous.
Lastly, since a reward is
desired because it is
supposed to be a good,
can we believe that he
who is capable of good
is deprived of the
recompence?

[* fol. 27.]

What reward shall he
receive?

Certainly the fairest and
richest of all rewards.

Call to mind that
excellent corollary I
have already given thee,
and reason thus:—

Since the supreme good
is happiness, it follows
that all good men are
happy in as much as they
are good; but if they are
happy they must become
as it were gods.

day [ne] shal enpeyren it. ne no wickednesse shal
 endirken
 it. ne power of no wyȝt ne shal nat amenusen it
 þat is to seyn to ben maked goddes. ¶ and syn it is 3420
 þus þat goode men ne faylen neuer mo of hire medes.
 ¶ certys no wise man ne may doute of þe vndepartable
 peyne of shrewes. ¶ þat is to seyn þat þe peyne of
 shrewes ne departiþ nat from hem self neuer mo. 3424

¶TUE EXALTS MANKIND.

¶ For so as goode *and* yuel *and* peyne *and* medes ben
 contrarie it mot nedes ben þat ryȝt as we seen by-tiden
 in gerdoun of goode. þat also mot þe peyne of yuel
 answeere by þe contrarie partye to shrewes. now þan so
 3428
 as bounte *and* prowesse ben þe medes to goode folk.
 also is shrewednesse it self torment to shrewes ¶ þan
 who so þat euer is entecched *and* defouled wiþ yuel.
 yif shrewes wolen þan preisen hem self may it semen
 3432
 to hem þat þei ben wiþ outhen partye of tourment. syn
 þei ben swiche þat þe [vtteriste wikkednesse / þat is to
 seyn wikkede thewes / which þat is the] outereste *and*
 þe w[or]ste kynde of shrewednesse ne defouliþ nat ne
 3436
 entecheiþ nat hem oonly but infectiþ *and* enuenemyþ
 hem gretely ¶ And al so loke on shrewes þat ben þe
 contrarie partye of goode men. how grete peyne
 felawshiþ
and folweþ hem. ¶ For þou hast lerned a litel 3440

The reward (*i. e.*
 divinity) of the righteous
 is such that no time can
 impair it, no power can
 diminish it, nor can any
 wickedness obscure it.

Since, then, happiness
 belongs to good men,
 punishment inseparably
 attends the wicked.

For since *good* and *evil*
 are contraries, so are
rewards and
punishments.

It is evident that rewards
 follow good actions, and
 punishments attend evil
 actions; then as virtue
 itself is the reward of the
 virtuous, so vice is the
 punishment of the
 vicious.

He who is punished with
 pain and uneasiness
 knows that he is afflicted
 with evil.

If, then, the wicked did
 rightly understand
 themselves they would
 perceive that they are not
 exempted from
 punishment.

Since vice, the extreme
 and worst kind of evil,
 not only afflicts them,
 but infects and entirely
 pollutes them.

But contemplate the
 punishment of the
 wicked.

You have been taught
 that *unity* is essential to

here byforn þat al þing þat is *and* haþ beynge is oon.
and þilke same oon is good. þan is þis consequence þat
 it semeþ wel. þat al þat is *and* haþ beynge is good. þis
 is to seyne. as who seiþ þat beynge *and* vnite *and* 3444
 goodnesse is al oon. *and* in þis manere it folweþ þan.
 þat al þing þat faileþ to ben good. it styntiþ forto be.
and forto haue any beynge. wher fore it is þat shrewes
 stynten forto ben þat þei weren. but þilke oþer forme
 3448
 of mankynde. þat is to seyne þe forme of þe body wiþ
 oute. shewiþ 3it þat þise shrewes were somtyme men.

being and is good—and
 all that have this unity
 are good; whatsoever,
 then, fails to be good
 ceases to exist.

So that it appears that
 evil men must cease to
 be what they were.

That they were once
 men, the outward form
 of the body, which still
 remains, clearly testifies.

WHO CEASES TO BE VIRTUOUS CEASES TO BE A MAN.

¶ wher fore whan þei ben *peruerted and* torned in to
 malice. certys þan han þei forlorn þe nature of
 mankynde. 3452
 but so as oonly bounte *and* prowesse may enhawse
 euery man ouer oþer men. þan mot it nedes be
 þat shrewes whiche þat shrewednesse haþ cast out of
 þe
 condicioun of mankynde ben put vndir þe merite *and*
 3456

Wherefore, when they
 degenerate into
 wickedness they lose
 their human nature.

But as virtue alone exalts
 one man above other
 men, it is evident that
 vice, which divests a
 man of his nature, must
 sink him below
 humanity.

þe deserte of men. þan bitidiþ it þat yif þou seest a
 wyzt þat be *transformed* in to vices. þou ne mayst nat
 wene þat he be a man. ¶ For 3if he [be] ardaunt in
 auarice. *and* þat he be a rauynour by violence of 3460
 foreine rychesse. þou shalt seyn þat he is lyke to a
 wolf. *and* yif he be felonous *and* wiþ out reste *and*
 exercise hys tonge to chidynges. þou shalt lykene hym
 to þe hounde. *and* yif he be a preue awaitour yhid *and*

You cannot, therefore,
 esteem him to be a man
 whom you see thus
 transformed by his vices.

The greedy robber, you
 will say, is like a *wolf*.

He who gives no rest to
 his abusive tongue, you
 may liken to a *hound*.

Does he delight in fraud
 and trickery? then is he

3464

reioysep hym to rauysshe by wyles. þou shalt seyne
hym lyke to þe fox whelpes. ¶ And yif he be distempre
and quakip for ire men shal wene þat he bereþ
þe corage of a lyoun. and yif he be dredeful and
fleyng 3468

and dredeþ þinges þat ne auzten nat ben dred. men
shal holde hym lyke to þe herte. and yif he be slowe
and astoned and lache. he lyueþ as an asse. and yif he
be lyzt and vnstedfast of corage and chaungeþ ay his
3472

studies. he is lickened to briddes. ¶ and yif he be
plounged in foule and vnclene luxuries. he is
wipholden
in þe foule delices of þe foule soowe. ¶ þan folweþ it
þat he þat forletip bountee and prowesse. he forletip to
3476

ben a man. syn he ne may nat passe in to þe
condicioun
of god. he is tourned in to a beest.

3379 *whiche*—which

3380 *good*—goode

3381 *ne* (2)—omitted

3383 *whiche*—which

3385 *forlonge*—forlong

3386-88-90 *whiche*—which

3391 *forþe*—forth

3393 *whiche*—which

good[e]—goode

3395 *wood*—woode

good[e]—goode

3396 *les*—leese

ne—omitted

like young *foxes*.

Is he intemperate in his
anger? then men will
compare him to a raging
lion.

If he be a coward, he
will be likened to a *hart*.

If he be slow, dull, and
lazy, then is he like an
ass.

Is he fickle and
inconstant? Then is he
like a *bird*.

Doth he wallow in filthy
lusts? Then doth he roll
himself in the mire like a
nasty *sow*.

It follows, then, that he
who ceases to be
virtuous, ceases to be a
man; and, since he
cannot attain divinity, he
is turned into a beast.

3398 *good[e]*—goode
 3399 *reioiseþ*—reioyse
 hem—hym
 þei had[de]—he hadde
 3400 [*þat*]—from C.
 3401 *had[de]*—hadde
 3402 *self*—MS. selk
 3403 *myȝt[e] bynym[e]*—myhte be-nyme
 3404 *owen*—owne
 3406 *laste*—last
 3408 *good[e]*—goode
 wolde—nolde
 3409 *goode*—good
 of (2)—of the
 3411 *greet*—grete
 3412 *here byforne*—her by-forn
 3413 *god*—good
 3414 *is* (1)—his
 clere—cleer
 3415 *good[e]*—goode
 3417 *godde[s]*—goddes
 swiche—swich
 3418 [*ne*]—from C.
 endirken—derken
 3422 *wise man*—wysman
 þe—omitted
 vndepartable—MS. vndirpartable, C. vndepartable
 3423 *of* (1)—of the
 3428 *answere*—answery
 þe—omitted
 3434 [*vtteriste*—*is the*]—from C.
 3438 *gretely*—gretly
 3439 *grete*—gret
 3441 *al*—alle
 hap—MS. haþe
 3443 *al*—alle
 hap—MS. haþe
 3446 *al*—alle
 3447 *haue*—han
 3448 *stynten*—MS. styntent
 3450 *were somtyme*—weeren whilom

3452 *forlorn*—MS. *forlorne*, C. *forlorn*

3453 *as*—omitted

enhawnse—*enhawsen*

3455 *whiche*—which

hap—MS. *hape*

3459 [*be*]—from C.

3464 *yhid*—MS. *yhidde*, C. *I-hidd*

3465 *seyne*—*seyn*

3468 *dredeful*—*dredful*

3469 *ben*—to *ben*

dred—MS. *dredde*, C. *dredd*

3470 *holde*—*holden*

lyke—*lyk*

herte—*hert*

slowe—*slowh*

3472 *vnstedfast*—*vnstidefast*

his—*hise*

3475 *þan*—MS. *þat*, C. *thanne*

3477 *passe*—*passen*

*[V\[E\]LA NARICII DUCIS.](#)

[The 3^{de} *Metur.*]

[* fol. 27 *b.*]

Evrus þe wynde aryueþ þe sayles of vlixes duc of þe
contre of narice. *and* hys wandryng shippes by þe

3480

see in to þe isle þere as Circe þe fayre goddesse
douȝter

of þe sonne dwelleþ þat medlyþ to hir newe gestes
drynkes þat ben touched *and* maked wiþ
enchauntmentȝ.

and after þat hir hande myȝty of þe herbes 3484

had[de] chaunged hir gestes in to dyuerse maneres. þat
oon of hem is couered his face wiþ forme of a boor. þat
oper is chaunged in to a lyoun of þe contre of marmorike.

and his nayles *and* his teþe wexen. ¶ þat 3488

oper of hem is newliche chaunged in to a wolf. *and*

Ulysses was driven by
the eastern winds upon
the shores of that isle
where Circe dwelt, who,
having entertained her
guests with magic
draughts, transformed
them into divers shapes
—one into a boar,
another into a lion;

some into howling
wolves, and others into
Indian tigers.

howeliþ whan he wolde wepe. þat oþer goþ debonairly
in þe house as a tigre of Inde. but al be it so þat þe
godhed of mercurie þat is cleped þe bride of arcadie
haþ 3492

had mercie of þe duc vlixes byseged wiþ diuerse
yueles

and haþ vnbounden hym fro þe pestilence of hys
oosteresse algates þe rowers *and* þe maryners hadden by
þis ydrawen in to hir moupes *and* dronken þe wicked[e] 3496

drynkes þei þat were woxen swyne hadden by þis
chaunged hire mete of brede forto ete acorns of ookes.

non of hir lymes ne dwelliþ wiþ hem hoole. but
þei han lost þe voys *and* þe body. Oonly hire þouzt 3500
dwelleþ wiþ hem stable þat wepiþ *and* bywailiþ þe
monstruous chaungynge þat þei suffren. ¶ O ouer lyzt
hand. as who seiþ. ¶ O feble *and* lyzt is þe hand of
Circes þe enchaunteresse þat chaungeþ þe bodies of
folk 3504

in to bestes to regarde *and* to comparisoun of mutacioun
þat is makid by vices. ne þe herbes of circes ne ben nat
myzty. for al be it so þat þei may chaungen þe lymes
of þe body. ¶ algates 3it þei may nat chaunge þe 3508
hertes. for wiþ inne is yhid þe strengþe *and* þe vigour
of men in þe secre toure of hire hertys. þat is to seyn
þe strengþe of resoun. but þilke uenymys of vices to-
drawen

a man to hem more myztily þan þe venym of 3512
circes. ¶ For vices ben so cruel þat þei percen *and*
þoru3 passen þe corage wiþ inne. *and* þou3 þei ne
anoye

But Mercury, the
Arcadian god, rescued
Ulysses from the Circean
charms. Yet his mariners,
having drunk of her
infected drinks, were
changed to swine, and
fed on acorns.

All traces of the human
form were lost, and they
were bereft of speech.

Their souls, unchanged,
bewailed their dreadful
fate.

O most weak, are Circe's
powers compared with
the potency of vice, to
transform the human
shape!

Circe's herbs may
change the body, but
cannot touch the mind,
the inward strength of
man.

But vice is more potent
than Circe's poisonous
charms.

Though it leaves the
body whole, it pierces
the inner man, and
inflicts a deadly wound
upon the soul.

nat þe body. 3itte vices wooden to distroien men by
wounde of þouȝt. 3516

- 3479 *aryueþ*—aryuede
 vlixes—MS. vluxies, C. vlixes
3481 *Circe*—Circes
3483 *enchauntmentȝ*—enchauntementȝ
3484 *hande*—hand
 of—ouer
3485 *had[de]*—hadde
 gestes—MS. goostes, C. gestes
3486 *boor*—boere
3488 *his* (1)—hise
 his teþe—hise teth
3489 *newliche*—neweliche
3490 *goþ*—MS. goþe
3491 *house*—hows
3492 *bride*—bryd
 haþ—MS. haþe
3493 *mercie*—MS. mercurie, C. mercy
3494 *haþ*—MS. haþe
3495 *oosteresse*—oostesse
3496 *wicked[e]*—wikkede
3497 *were woxen swyne*—weeren wexen swyn
3498 *chaunged*—Ichaunged
 brede—bred
 forto—MS. *and* forto
 ete acorns—eten akkornes
3499 *hoole*—hool
3501 *wepiþ*—MS. kepiþ, C. weepith
3502 *monstruous*—MS. monstronous, C. Monstruos
3504 *Circes*—MS. Cirtes
 folk—folkys
3509 *yhid*—MS. yhidde, C. I-hydd
3515 *wooden*—MS. wolden, C. wooden

E WICKED ARE TORMENTED BY A THREEFOLD
HEDNESS.

Pan seide I þus I confesse *and* am aknowe *quod* I.
ne

I ne se nat þat men may seyn as by ryȝt. þat
shrewes ne ben nat chaunged in to beestes by þe
qualite of hir soules. ¶ Al be it so þat þei kepen ȝitte

3520

þe forme of þe body of mankynde. but I nolde nat of
shrewes of whiche þe þouȝt cruel woodeþ alwey in to
destruccioun of good[e] men. þat it were leueful to
hem

to done þat. ¶ Certys *quod* she ne it nis nat leueful 3524
to hem as I shal wel shewen þe in couenable place.

¶ But napeles yif so were þat þilke þat men wenen ben
leueful for shrewes were bynomen hem. so þat þei ne
myȝten nat anoyen or don harme to goode men. ¶

Certys 3528

a gret party of þe peyne to shrewes shulde ben
allegged

and releued. ¶ For al be it so þat þis ne seme nat
credible þing perauenture to somme folk ȝit mot it
nedes be þat shrewes ben more wrecches *and* vnsely.

3532

whan þei may don *and* performe þat þei coueiten [than
yif they myhte nat complyssen þat they coueyten]. ¶

For

yif so be þat it be wrecchednesse to wilne to don yuel ;
þan is it more wrecchednesse to mowen don yuel. 3536
wiþ oute whiche moeuyng þe wrecched wille sholde
languisshe wiþ oute effecte. ¶ þan syn þat eueryche of

[The ferthe prose.]

B. I confess that vicious
men are rightly called
beasts.

They retain the outward
form of man, but the
qualities of their souls
prove them to be beasts.

I wish, however, that the
wicked were without the
power to annoy and hurt
good men.

P. They have no power,
as I shall presently show
you.

But were this power,
which men ascribe to
them, taken away from
the wicked, they would
be relieved of the
greatest part of their
punishment.

The wicked are more
unhappy when they have
accomplished their evil
designs than when they
fail to do so.

If it is a miserable thing
to will evil, it is a greater
unhappiness to have the
power to execute it,
without which power the
wicked desires would
languish without effect.

Since, then, each of these
three things (*i. e.* the

þise þinges haþ hys wrecchednesse. þat is to seyne wil
to done yuel. and moeuyng to done yuel. it mot nedes

3540

be. þat þei (shrewes) ben constreyned by þre
vnselynesses

þat wolen *and* mowen *and* performen felonyes
and shrewednesses. ¶ I accorde me *quod* I. but I
desire gretely þat shrewes losten sone þilke
vnselynesses. 3544

þat is to seyne þat shrewes were despoyled of moeuyng
to don yuel. ¶ so shullen þei *quod* she. sonnere
peraenture þen þou woldest *or sonnere þen þei hem
self wenen to lakken mowynge to done yuel. ¶ For 3548
þere nis no þing so late in so short boundes of þis lijf
þat is longe to abide. namelyche to a corage inmortel.
Of whiche shrewes þe grete hope *and* þe heye
compassyngus

of shrewednesse is often destroyed by a 3552
sodeyne ende or þei ben war. *and* þat þing establiþ to
shrewes þe ende of hir shrewednesse. ¶ For yif þat
shrewednesse makeþ wrecches. þan mot he nedes be
most wrecched þat lengest is a shrewe. þe whiche 3556
wicked shrewes wolde ydemen aldirmost vnsely *and*
caytifs yif þat hir shrewednes ne were yfinissed. at þe
leste weye by þe outerest[e] deep. for [yif] I haue
concluded

soþe of þe vnselynesse of shrewednesse. þan sheweþ
3560

it clerely þat þilke shrewednesse is wiþ outen ende þe
whiche is certeyne to ben *perdurable*. ¶ Certys *quod* I

will, the power, and the
accomplishment of evil)
hath its misery, therefore
a threefold wretchedness
afflicts those who both
will, can, and do commit
sin.

B. I grant it—but still I
wish the vicious were
without this misfortune.

P. They shall be
despoiled of it sooner
than you wish perhaps,
or than they themselves
imagine.

[* fol. 28.]

In the narrow limits of
this life, nothing,
however tardy it appears,
can seem to an immortal
soul to have a very long
duration.

The great hopes, and the
subtle machinations of
the wicked, are often
suddenly frustrated, by
which an end is put to
their wickedness.

If vice renders men
wretched, the longer they
are vicious the longer
must they be miserable.
And they would be
infinitely wretched if
death did not put an end
to their crimes.

It is clear, as I have
already shown, that
eternal misery is infinite.

B. This consequence
appears to be just, but
difficult to assent to.

þis [conclusion] is harde *and* wonderful to graunte. ¶ But
I knowe wel þat it accordeþ moche to [the] þinges þat I 3564

haue graunted her byforne. ¶ þou hast *quod* she þe ryȝt
estimacioun of þis. but who so euere wene þat it be an
harde þing to acorde hym to a conclusioun. it is ryȝt
þat he shewe þat somme of þe premisses ben fals. or
3568

ellys he mot shewe þat þe colasioun of preposiciouns
nis nat spedful to a necessarie conclusion. ¶ and yif it
be nat so. but þat þe premisses ben ygranted þer nis
nat whi he sholde blame þe argument. for þis þing þat
3572

I shal telle þe nowe ne shal not seme lasse wondirful.

P. You think rightly; but if you cannot assent to my conclusion you ought to show that the premises are false, or that the consequences are unfairly deduced; for if the premises be granted, you cannot reject the inferences from them.

What I am about to say is not less wonderful, and it follows necessarily from the same premises.

þilke shrewednesse is wiȝt outen ende (l. 3561):
text printed as shown, but may be an error for
“wrecchednesse” as in Skeat; see sidenote (“eternal
misery”).

E WRETCHEDNESS OF THE WICKED IS DIMINISHED BY MENT.

but of þe þinges þat ben taken al so it is necessarie as
who so seiþ it folweþ of þat whiche þat is *purposed*
byforn. what is þat *quod* I. ¶ certys *quod* she þat is 3576
þat þat þise wicked shrewes ben more blysful or ellys
lasse wrecches. þat byen þe tourmentes þat þei han
deserued. þan yif no peyne of Iustice ne chastied[e]
hem. ne þis ne seye I nat now for þat any man myȝt[e]
3580

þenk[e] þat þe maneres of shrewes ben coriged *and*
chastised by veniaunce. *and* þat þei ben brouȝt to þe

B. What is that?

P. That the wicked who have been punished for their crimes, are happier than if justice had allowed them to go unpunished.

I do not appeal to popular arguments, that punishment corrects vice, that the fear of chastisement leads them

ryȝt wey by þe drede of þe tourment. ne for þat þei
ȝeuen to oþer folk ensample to fleyen from vices. ¶ But
3584

I vndirstonde ȝitte [in] an oþer manere þat shrewes
ben more vnsely whan þei ne ben nat punissed al be it
so þat þere ne ben had no resoun or lawe of correccioun.

ne none ensample of lokynge. ¶ And what manere 3588
shal þat ben quod I. ouper þan haþ ben told here
byforn ¶ Haue we nat graunted þan quod she þat
good[e] folk ben blysful. *and* shrewes ben wrecches.
ȝis quod I. [thanne quod she] ȝif þat any good were

3592

added to þe wrecchenesse of any wyȝt. nis he nat more
blisful þan he þat ne haþ no medelyng of goode in hys
solitarie wrecchednesse. so semeþ it quod I. and what
seyst þou þan quod she of þilke wrecche þat lakkeþ
alle 3596

goodes. so þat no goode nis medeled in hys
wrecchednesse.

and ȝitte ouer alle hys wickednesse for whiche
he is a wrecche þat þer be ȝitte an oþer yuel anexid *and*
knyt to hym. shal not men demen hym more vnsely 3600
þan þilke wrecche of whiche þe vnselynesse is re[le]ued
by þe participacioun of som goode. whi sholde he nat
quod I. ¶ þan certys quod she han shrewes whan þei
ben punissed somewhat of good anexid to hir
wrecchednesse. 3604

þat is to seyne þe same peyne þat þei suffren
whiche þat is good by þe resoun of Iustice. And whan
þilke same shrewes ascapen wiþ outen tourment. þan

to take the right path,
and that the sufferings of
evil-doers deter others
from vice, but I believe
that guilty men,
unpunished, become
much more unhappy in
another way.

B. In what way do you
mean?

P. Are not good people
happy, and evil folk
miserable?

B. Yes.

P. If good be added to
the wretchedness of a
man, will not he be
happier than another
whose misery has no
element of good in it?

B. It seems so.

P. And if to the same
wretched being another
misery be annexed, does
not he become more
wretched than he whose
misery is alleviated by
the participation of some
good?

B. He does.

P. When evil men are
punished they have a
degree of good annexed
to their wretchedness, to
wit, the punishment
itself, which as it is the
effect of justice is good.

And when these
wretches escape
punishment something

han þei somewhat more of yuel 3it ouer þe wickednesse
3608

þat þei han don. þat is to seye defaute of peyne.
whiche defaute of peyne þou hast graunted is yuel.

¶ For þe desert of felonye I ne may nat denye it *quod* I.

¶ Moche more þan *quod* she ben shrewes vnsely 3612
whan þei ben wrongfully delyuered fro peyne. þan
whan þei beþ punissed by ry3tful vengeaunce. but þis
is

open þing *and* clere þat it is ry3t þat shrewes ben
punissed. *and* it is wickednesse *and* wrong þat þei 3616
escapin vnpunissed. ¶ who my3t[e] denye *þat *quod* I.
but *quod* she may any man denye. þat al þat is ry3t nis
good. *and* also þe contrarie. þat alle þat is wrong nis
wicked. certys *quod* I þise þinges ben clere ynou3. *and*

3620

þat we han concludid a litel here byforne. but I preye
þe þat þou telle me yif þou accordest to leten no
tourment

to þe soules aftir þat þe body is dedid by þe deþe.

þis [is] to seyn. vndirstondest þou ou3t þat soules han 3624

any tourment after þe deþe of þe body. ¶ Certis *quod*
she 3e *and* þat ry3t grete. of whiche soules *quod* she I
trowe þat somme ben tourmentid by asprenesse of
peyne. *and* somme soules I trowe be excercised by a

3628

purging mekenesse. but my conseil nys nat to
determyne

of þis peyne. but I haue trauayled and told it

hider to. ¶ For þou sholdest knowe þat þe mowynge

more of ill (*i. e.*
exemption from
punishment) is added to
their condition.

B. I cannot deny it.

P. Much more unhappy
are the wicked when
they enjoy an unmerited
impunity than when they
suffer a lawful
chastisement.

It is just to punish evil-
doers, and unjust that
they should escape
punishment.

[* fol. 28 b.]

B. Nobody denies that.

P. Everything, too, which
is just is good; and, on
the contrary, whatsoever
is unjust is evil.

B. These are just
inferences from our
former premises.

But is there any
punishment for the soul
after death of the body?

P. Yes, and great ones
too. Some punishments
are rigorous and eternal.

Others have a corrective
and purifying force, and
are of finite duration.

But this is not to our
purpose.

I want you to see that the
power of the wicked is in
reality nothing, that the

[i. myght] of shrewes whiche mowynge þe semeþ to
3632

ben. vnworþi nis no mowynge. *and* eke of shrewes of
whiche þou pleyndest þat þei ne were nat punissed.
þat þou woldest seen þat þei ne weren neuer mo wiþ
outen þe torment of hire wickednesse. *and* of þe
licence 3636

of mowynge to done yuel. þat þou preidest þat it
myȝt[e] sone ben endid. *and* þat þou woldest fayne
lerne. þat it ne sholde nat longe endure. *and* þat
shrewes ben more vnsely yif þei were of lenger duryng. 3640

and most vnsely yif þei weren *perdurable*. *and* after
þis I haue shewed þe þat more vnsely ben shrewes
whan þei escapen wiþ oute ryȝtful peyne. þan whan þei
ben punissed by ryȝtful uengeaunce. *and* of þis
sentence 3644

folweþ it þat þan ben shrewes constreyned atte laste
wiþ

most greuous tourment. whan men wene þat þei ne ben
nat ypunissed. whan I considre þi resouns *quod* I. I.
ne trowe nat þat men seyn any þing more verrely. *and*
3648

yif I *tourne* aȝeyn to þe studies of men. who is [he] to
whom it sholde seme þat [he] ne sholde nat only leuen
þise þinges. but eke gladly herkene hem. Certys *quod*
she so it is. but men may nat. for þei han hire eyen so
3652

wont to derkenesse of erþely þinges. þat þei may nat
liften hem vp to þe lyȝt of clere soþefastnes. ¶ But
þei ben lyke to briddes of whiche þe nyȝt lyȝtneþ hyre

wicked never go
unpunished; that their
licence to do evil is not
of long duration, and that
the wicked would be
more unhappy if it were
longer, and infinitely
wretched if it were to
continue for ever.

After this I showed that
evil men are more
unhappy, having escaped
punishment, than if
justly chastised.
Wherefore when they are
supposed to get off scot-
free they suffer most
grievously.

B. Your reasoning
appears convincing and
conclusive. But your
arguments are opposed
to current opinions, and
would hardly command
assent, or even a hearing.

P. It is so. For those
accustomed to the
darkness of error cannot
fix their eyes on the light
of perspicuous truth, like
birds of night which are
blinded by the full light
of day.

lookyng. *and* þe day blyndeþ hem. for whan men loken

3656

nat þe ordre of þinges but hire lustes *and* talent3. þei
wene þat oþir þe leue or þe mowyng to done
wickednesse

or ellys þe escaping wiþ oute peyne be weleful.

They consider only the gratification of their lusts, they think there is happiness in the liberty of doing evil and in exemption from punishment.

¶TUE ITS OWN REWARD.

but considere þe iugement of þe perdurable lawe. for if

3660

þou conferme þi corage to þe beste þinges. þou ne hast
no nede to no iuge to 3iuen þe pris or meede. for þou
hast ioigned þi self to þe most excellent þing. and yif
þou haue enclined þi studies to þe wicked þinges. ne

3664

seek no foreyn wrekere out of þi self. for þou þi self
hast þrest þe in to wicked þinges. ry3t as þou my3test
loken by dyuerse tymes þe foule erþe *and* þe heuene.

and þat alle oþer þinges stynten fro wiþ oute. so þat 3668

þou [nere neyther in heuene ne in erthe] ne say[e] no
þing more. þan sholde it semen to þe as by only resoun
of lokyng. þat þou were in þe sterres. *and* now in þe
erþe. but þe poeple ne lokeþ nat on þise þinges. what

3672

þan shal we þan approchen vs to hem þat I haue
shewed þat þei ben lyke to þe bestes. (q. d. non)

Do you attend to the eternal law written in your own heart. Conform your mind to what is good, and you will stand in no need of a judge to confer a reward upon you—for you have it already in the enjoyment of the best of things (*i. e.* virtue).

If you indulge in vice, you need no other chastisement—you have degraded yourself into a lower order of beings.

The multitude doth not consider this. What then? Shall we take them as our models who resemble beasts?

E WICKED NEED PITY.

¶ And what wilt þou seyne of þis ¶ yif þat a man
hadde al forlorn hys sy3t. *and* had[de] for3eten þat he

If a man who had lost his sight, having even forgotten his blindness, should declare that his

3676

euer saw *and* wende þat no þing ne fayled[e] hym of
perfeccioun of mankynde. now we þat myȝten sen þe
same þing wolde we nat wene þat he were blynde (q. d.
sic). ne also ne accordeþ nat þe poeple to þat I shal 3680
seyne. þe whiche þing is susteyned by a stronge
foundement
of resouns. þat is to seyn þat more vnsely ben þei
þat don wrong to oþer folk. þen þei þat þe wrong
suffren. ¶ I wolde heren þilke *same resouns quod I
3684

¶ Deniest þou quod she þat alle shrewes ne ben worþi
to han tourment. nay quod I. but quod she I am
certeyne
by many resouns þat shrewes ben vnsely. it accordeþ
quod I. þan [ne] dowtest þou nat quod she þat 3688
þilke folk þat ben worþi of tourment þat þei ne ben
wrecches. It accordeþ wel quod I. yif þou were þan
quod she yset a Iuge or a knower of þinges. wheþer
trowest þou þat men sholde tourment[e] hym þat haþ
3692
don þe wronge. or hym þat haþ suffred þe wronge.
I ne doute nat quod I. þat I nolde don suffissaunt
satisfaccioun
to hym þat had[de] suffred þe wrong by þe
sorwe of hym þat had[de] don þe wronge. ¶ þan 3696
semeþ it quod she þat þe doar of wrong is more
wrecche
þan he þat haþ suffred þe wrong. þat folweþ wel quod

faculties were all perfect,
shall we weakly believe
that those who retain
their sight are blind?

The vulgar will not
assent to what I am
going to say, though
supported by conclusive
arguments—to wit, that
persons are more
unhappy that do wrong
than those who suffer
wrong.

[* fol. 29.]

B. I would willingly hear
your reasons.

P. Do you deny that
every wicked man
deserves punishment?

B. No, I do not.

P. I am satisfied that
impious men are in many
ways miserable.

B. They are so.

P. Then those that
deserve punishment are
miserable.

B. I admit it.

P. If you were a judge,
upon whom would you
inflict punishment? upon
the wrong-doer, or upon
the injured?

B. I should not hesitate
to punish the offender as
a satisfaction to the
sufferer.

P. Then you would deem
the injuring person more
unhappy than he who
had been wronged?

B. That follows naturally.

[I]. þan quod she by þise causes *and* by oþer causes
þat ben enforced by þe same roate þat filþe or synne by
3700

þe propre nature of it makeþ men wretches. *and* it
sheweþ wel þat þe wrong þat men don nis nat þe
wrecchenesse of hym þat receyueþ þe wrong. but þe
wrecchednesse of hym þat doþ þe wronge ¶ but certys
3704

quod she þise oratours or aduocat3 don al þe contrarie
for þei enforcen hem to commoeue þe iuges to han pite
of hem þat han suffred *and* resceyued þe þinges þat ben
greuous *and* aspre. *and* 3itte men sholden more
ry3tfully 3708

han pitee on hem þat don þe greuaunces *and* þe
wronges. þe whiche shrewes it were a more couenable
þing þat þe accusours or aduocat3 not wroþe but pitous
and debonaire ladden þe shrewes þat han don wrong to
3712

þe Iugement. ry3t as men leden seke folk to þe leche.

E DUTY OF ADVOCATES.

for þat þei sholden seken out þe maladies of synne by
tourment3. *and* by þis couenaunt eyþer þe entent of þe
defendours or aduocat3 sholde fayle *and* cesen in al. or
3716

ellys yif þe office of aduocat3 wolde bettre profiten to
men. it sholde be tourned in to þe habit of accusacioun.
þat is [to] s[e]lyn þei sholden accuse shrewes. *and* nat
excuse hem. *and* eke þe shrewes hem self. 3it it were
3720

P. From this then, and other reasons of like nature, it seems that vice makes men miserable, and an injury done to any man is the misery of the doer, and not of the sufferer.

But our advocates think differently—they try to obtain pity for those that have suffered cruelty and oppression;

but the juster pity is really due to the oppressors, who ought, therefore, to be led to judgment as the sick are to the physician, not by angry but by merciful and kind accusers, so that, by the physic of chastisement, they may be cured of their vices.

I would not have the guilty defrauded by their advocates. Their duty is to accuse, and not to excuse offenders.

Were it permitted the wicked to get a slight view of virtue's beauty, which they have

leueful to hem to seen at any clifte þe vertue þat þei
han forleten. *and* sawen þat þei sholde putten adoun
þe filþes of hire vices by [the] *tourmentz* of peynes. þei
ne auʒten nat ryʒt for þe recompensacioun forto geten

3724

hem bounte *and* prowesse whiche þat þei han lost
demen

ne holden þat þilke peynes weren *tourmentes* to hem.
and eke þei wolden refuse þe attendaunce of hir aduocatʒ
and taken hem self to hire iuges *and* to hir accusours. 3728

for whiche it bytideþ [þat] as to þe wise folk
þer nis no place ylete to hate. þat is to seyn. þat hate
ne haþ no place amonges wise men. ¶ For no wyʒt
wolde haten gode men. but yif he were ouer moche a 3732
fole. ¶ *and* forto haten shrewes it nis no resoun.

¶ For ryʒt so as languissing is maladie of body. ryʒt
so ben vices *and* synne maladies of corage. ¶ *and* so as
we ne deme nat þat þei þat ben seek of hire body ben

3736

worþi to ben hated. but raper worþi of pite. wel more
worþi nat to ben hated. but forto ben had in pite ben
þei of whiche þe þouʒtes ben constreined by felonous
wickednesse. þat is more cruel þan any languissinge of 3740
body.

forsaken, and could they
be persuaded of the
purifying effects of
lawful chastisement,
they surely would not
consider punishment as
an evil, but would
willingly give
themselves up to justice
and refuse the defence of
their advocates.

The wise hate nobody,
only a fool hates good
men; and it is as
irrational to hate the
wicked.

Vice is a sickness of the
soul, and needs our
compassion, and not our
hate, for the distempers
of the soul are more
deplorable than those of
the body, and have more
claims upon our
compassion.

3517 *aknowe*—aknowe it

3518 *seyn*—sayn

3523 *good[e]*—goode

3524 *done*—don

3526 *ben*—be

3527 *for*—to

3528 *myʒten*—myhte

don—MS. done, C. doon

harme—harm
 3529 *gret*—MS. grete, C. gret
 3533-36 *don*—MS. done, C. doon
 3533-34 [*than*—*coueyten*]*—*from C.
 3537 *moeuyng*—mowyng
 wille—wil
 3539 *hap*—MS. haþe
 seyne—seyn
 3540 *done* (1)—doon
 moeuyng to done—Mowyng to don
 mot—MS. mote, C. mot
 3544 *gretely*—gretly
 3545 *seyne*—seyn
 were—weeren
 moeuyng—mowyng
 3548 *wenen*—weene
 to lakken—*yuel*—omitted
 3549 *pere*—ther
 so (2)—the
 3550 *longe*—long
 3552 *shrewednesse*—shrewednesses
 often—ofte
 3558 *shrewednes*—shrewednesse
 yfinissed—fynyshed
 3559 *weye*—wey
 outerest[e]—owtteryte
 [iy]—from C.
 3560 *sope*—soth
 3561 *clerely*—cleerly
 3563 [*conclusion*]*—*from C.
 harde—hard
 3564 [*the*]*—*from C.
 3567 *harde*—hard
 3568 *fals*—false
 3573 *nowe*—now
 3575 *who so seip*—ho seyth
 whiche—which
 3578 *byen*—a-byen
 3579 *chastied*[e]—chastysede
 3580 *myzt*[e]—myhte
 3581 *þenk*[e]—thinke

3584 *zeuen*—MS. *zeuene*, C. *yeuen*
 fleyen—flen
3585 *zitte*—yif
 [*in*]—from C.
3588 *none*—non
3589 *ouper*—oother
 hap—MS. *hape*
 ben—be
 told—MS. *tolde*, C. *told*
3591 *good[e]*—goode
3592 [*thanne*—*she*]—from C.
3594 *blisful*—weleful
 hap—MS. *hape*
3594-97 *goode*—good
3598 *alle*—al
 whiche—which
3600 *knyt*—knytte
3601 *re[le]ued*—releued
3602 *goode*—good
3605 *seyne*—seyn
3606 *whiche*—which
3607 *outen*—owte
3609 *don*—MS. *done*
 seye—seyn
3610 *whiche*—which
3611 *desert*—deserte
3614 *bep*—MS. *bepe*, C. *ben*
3615 *clere*—cler
3617 *myzt[e]*—myhte
3618 *is ryzt nis*—MS. *nis ryzt is*
3619 *alle*—al
 nis wicked—is wykke
3621 *here*—her
3623 *dedid*—endyd
 depe—deth
3624 [*is*]—from C.
 ouzt—awht
3625 *depe*—deth
3626 *grete*—gret
3628 *be*—ben
3629 *determyne*—determenye

3630 *peyne*—peynes
 told—MS. tolde
3632 [.i. *myght*]—from C.
3632-34 *whiche*—which
3633 *eke*—ek
3635 *seen*—seyn
3637 *done*—don
3638 *myȝt[e]*—myhte
 fayne lerne—fayn lernen
3639 *endure*—dure
3645 *atte*—at the
 laste—MS. þast, C. laste
3647 *resouns*—resoun
3649-50 [*he*]—from C.
3651 *eke*—ek
3653 *derkenesse*—derknesse
3654 *clere soþefastnes*—cleer sothfastnesse
3655 *whiche*—which
3658 *opir*—eyther
 done—don
3659 *escaping*—schapyng
3662 *to* (1)—of
3665 *foreyn*—foreyne
3666 *þrest*—thrust
 wicked—wikke
3669 [*nere*—*erthe*]—from C.
 heuene—C. heuenene
 say[e]—C. saye
3672 *on*—in
3674 *lyke*—lyk
 q. d.—MS. quod
3675 *wilt þou seyne*—woltow seyn
3676 *forlorn*—MS. forlorne, C. for-lorn
 syȝt—syhte
 had[de]—hadde
3677 *saw*—MS. sawe, C. sawh
 fayled[e]—faylede
3678 *sen*—MS. sene, C. sen
3679 *þing*—thinges
 q. d.—MS. quod
3681 *whiche*—which

3683 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 oper—oothre
 3688 [*ne*]—from C.
 3691 *yset*—MS. ysette, C. yset
 wheper—omitted
 3692 *tourment*[*e*]—tormenten
 3692-3 *hap*—MS. haþe
 3693 *wronge* (2)—wrong
 3695 *had*[*de*]—hadde
 3696 *had*[*de*]—hadden
 wronge—wrong
 3697 *doar*—doere
 3698 *hap*—MS. haþe
 3699 [*I*]—from C.
 3700 *ben*—ben of
 roate—Roote
 3703-4 *but*—*wronge*—omitted
 3704 *dop*—MS. doþe
 3711 *wroþe*—wroth
 3712 *þe*—tho
 don—MS. done, C. don
 3713 *seke*—syke
 3715 *tourmentz*—torment
 þe (2)—omitted
 3719 [*to*] s[*e*]yn—to seyn
 3722 *sawen*—sawh
 sholde—sholden
 3723 [*the*]—from C.
 3724 *auzten*—owhte
 3725-29 *whiche*—which
 3729 *bytideþ*—MS. byndeþ, C. bytidith
 [*þat*]—from C.
 3730 *ylete*—I-leten
 3731 *hap*—MS. haþe
 3732 *wolde*—nyl
 moche—mochel
 3733 *fole*—fool
 3736 *seek*—syke

What deliteþ it 3ow to exciten so grete moewynges
of

What frenzy causes man
to hasten on his fate, that
is, by war or by strife.

hatredes *and* to hasten *and* bisien [the] fatal disposicioun

of 3oure deep wiþ 3oure propre handes. þat is 3744

to seyn by batailes or [by] kontek. for yif 3e axen þe

If death is desired he
delays not to come.

deep it hastisiþ hym of hys owen wille. ne deep ne

tarieþ nat hys swifte hors. and [the] men þat þe

Why do they who are
exposed to the assaults
of beasts of prey and
venomous reptiles seek
to slay each other with
the sword.

serpent3

and þe lyouns. *and* þe tigre. *and* þe beere *and* þe 3748

boore seken to sleen wiþ her teþe. 3it þilke same men

seken to sleen eueryche of hem oþer wiþ swerde. loo

Lo! their manners and
opinions do not accord,
wherefore they engage in
unjust wars, and fiercely
urge on each other's
destiny.

for

her maners ben *diuerse *and* discordaunt ¶ þei

[* fol. 29 b.]

moeuen vnry3tful oostes *and* cruel batailes. *and* wilne

3752

to perisse by enterchaungynge of dartes. but þe resoun

But this is no just reason
for shedding blood.

of cruelte nis nat ynou3 ry3tful. wilt þou þan 3elden a

couenable gerdoun to þe desertes of men ¶ Loue

Wouldst thou reward
each as he deserves?
Then love the good as
they deserve, and have
pity upon the wicked.

ry3tfully

goode folk ; *and* haue pite on shrewes. 3756

3743 [*the*]*—*from C.

3745 [*by*]*—*from C.

3746 *hastisiþ**—*hasteth
*owen wille**—*owne wyl

3747 [*the*]*—*from C.

3749 *boore**—*boor
*teþe**—*teth

3750 *swerde**—*sword

3751 *her**—*hir

3752 *wilne**—*wylnen

3753 *enterchaungynge**—*entrechaungynges

E OPERATIONS OF CHANCE.

HINC EGO UIDEO INQUAM. ET CETERA.

Pus see I wel *quod* I. eyþer what blisfulnesse or
ellys

what vnselinesse is estab[li]ssed in þe desertys of
goode men *and* of shrewes. ¶ but in þis ilke fortune
of poeple I see somewhat of goode. *and* somewhat of
3760

yuel. for no wise man hap nat leuer ben exiled pore
and nedy *and* nameles. þan forto dwellen in hys Citee
and flouren of rychesses. *and* be redoutable by honoure.
and stronge of power for in þis wise more clerely *and*
3764

more witnesfully is þe office of wise men ytretid whan
þe blisfulnes *and* [the] pouste of *gouernours* is as it
were yshad amonges poeples þat ben neyþboures *and*
subgit3. syn þat namely prisoun lawe *and* þise oþer 3768
tourment3 of lawful peynes ben raper owed to felonous
Cite3eins. for þe whiche felonous Cite3eins þo peynes
ben establissed. þan for goode folk. ¶ þan I merueile
me gretly *quod* I. whi [þat] þe þinges ben so mys 3772
entrechaunged. þat *tourment3* felounes pressen *and*
confounden goode folk. *and* shrewes rauyssen medes
of

vertue *and* ben in honours. *and* in grete estatiss.
and I desire eke to witen of þe. what semeþ þe to ben
þe 3776

resoun of þis so wrongful a confusioun ¶ For I wolde
wondre wel þe lasse yif I trowed[e] þat alle þise þinges
were medeled by fortuouse hap. ¶ But now hepeþ

[The fyfthe prose.]

B. I see plainly the
nature of that felicity
which attends the virtues
of the good, and of the
misery that follows the
vices of the wicked.

But in Fortune I see a
mixture of good and evil.
The wise man prefers
riches, &c., to poverty,
&c.

And wisdom appears
more illustrious, when
wise men are governors
and impart their felicity
to their subjects; and
when imprisonment,
torture, &c., are inflicted
only upon bad citizens.

Why, then, should things
undergo so unnatural a
change?

Why should the worthy
suffer and the vicious
receive the reward of
virtue?

I should like to hear the
reason of so unjust a
distribution.

I should not marvel so
much if *Chance* were the
cause of all this
confusion.

and encreseþ myne astonyenge god gouernour of þinges. 3780

þat so as god ʒeueþ ofte tymes to good[e] men goodes and myrþes. and to shrewes yuel and aspre þinges. and ʒeueþ aʒeynewarde to goode folk hardnesse. and to

shrewes [he] graunteþ hem her wille and þat þei desiren. 3784

what difference þan may þer be bitwixen þat þat god doþ. and þe hap of fortune. yif men ne knowe nat þe cause whi þat [it] is. it nis no merueile quod she þouʒ

þat men wenen þat þer be somewhat folysche and confus 3788

whan þe resoun of þe order is vnknowe. ¶ But alle þouʒ þou ne know nat þe cause of so gret a disposicioun.

napeles for as moche as god þe good[e] gouernour attempreþ

and gouerneþ þe world. ne doute þe nat þat 3792
alle þinges ne ben doon aryʒt.

But I am overwhelmed with astonishment when I reflect, that God the director of all things thus unequally distributes rewards and punishments.

What difference is there, then, unless we know the cause, between God's proceedings and the operations of Chance?

P. It is not at all surprising that you think you see irregularities, when you are ignorant of that order by which God proceeds.

But, forasmuch as God, the good governor, presides over all, rest assured that all things are done rightly and as they ought to be done.

3760 *goode*—good
3761 *hap*—MS. *hape*
 nat—omitted
 leuer—*leuere*
3762 *pan*—MS. *pat*, C. *than*
3763 *redoutable*—MS. *redentable*, C. *redowtable*
3764 *stronge*—strong
 clerely—*clerly*
3766 [*the*]—from C.
3767 *ney3boures*—*nesshebors*
3769 *lawful*—laweful
3771 *goode*—good
3772 [*pat*]—from C.
3775 *grete*—*gret*
3776 *to witen*—*forto weten*
3778 *trowed[e]*—*trowede*
 alle—*al*
3779 *were*—*weeren*
 fortuouse—*fortunous*
3780 *myne*—*myn*
3781 *good[e]*—*goode*
3782 *yuel*—*yuelis*
3783 *hardnesse*—*hardnesses*
3784 [*he*]—from C.
 wille—*wyl*
3785 *difference*—MS. *differenee*
3786 *dop*—MS. *dope*
 hap—*happe*
3787 [*it*]—from C.
 it—*ne it*
3788 *confus*—*confuse*
3789 *alle*—*al*
3791 *good[e]*—*goode*
3793 *ne*—omitted

E HIDDEN CAUSES OF THINGS.

[SI QUIS ARCTURI](#) ⁸ [SYDERA](#).

[The fyfthe Metur.]

⁸ MS. arituri

Who so þat ne knowe nat þe sterres of arctour
ytourned neye to þe souereyne contre or point.
þat is to seyne ytourned neye to þe souereyne pool of
þe 3796
firmament *and* woot nat whi þe sterre boetes passeþ or
gaderiþ his wey[n]es. *and* drenchep his late flaumbes in
þe see. *and* whi þat boetes þe sterre vnfoldiþ his ouer
swifte arisynges. þan shal he wondren of þe lawe of þe 3800
heye eyre. *and* eke if þat he ne knowe nat why þat þe
hornes of þe ful[le] moene waxen pale *and* infect by þe
boundes of þe derke nyzt ¶ *and* how þe moene dirk
and confuse discouereþ þe sterres. þat she had[de] 3804
ycouered by hir clere visage. þe commune error
moeueþ
folk *and* makip wery hir bacines of bras by þikke
strookes. þat is to seyne þat þer is a maner poeple þat
hyzt[e] coribandes þat wenen þat whan þe moone is in 3808
þe eclips þat it be enchauntid. *and* þerfore forto rescowe
þe moone þei betyn hire basines wiþ þikke strokes.
¶ Ne no man ne wondreþ whan þe blastes of þe wynde
chorus betyn þe strondes of þe see by quakyng
floodes. 3812
ne no man ne wondreþ whan þe wey3te of þe snowe
yhardid by þe colde. is resolued by þe brennyng hete
of phebus þe sonne. ¶ For here seen men redyly þe
causes. but þe *causes yhid þat is to seye in heuene 3816
trouble þe brestes of men. ¶ þe moeueable poeple is
a-stoned of alle þinges þat comen selde *and* sodeynely

He who knows not that
the Bear is seen near the
Pole, nor has observed
the path of Boötes, will
marvel at their
appearance.

The vulgar are alarmed
when shadows terrestrial
obscure the moon's
brightness, causing the
stars to be displayed.

Thinking the eclipse the
result of enchantment,
they sought to destroy
the charms by the
tinkling of brazen
vessels or cymbals.

Yet none marvel when
the north-west wind
renders the sea
tempestuous; nor when
vast heaps of congealed
snow are melted by the
warm rays of the sun,
because the causes are
apparent.

[* fol. 30.]

Things whose causes are
unknown disquiet the
human mind.

in

oure age. but yif þe troubyl errour of oure ignorance
departid[e] from vs. so þat we wisten þe causes whi þat
3820
swiche þinges bitiden. certys þei sholden cesse to seme
wondres.

The fickle mob stands
amazed at every rare or
sudden phenomenon.

Fear and wonder,
however, soon cease
when ignorance given
place to certain
knowledge.

3794 *arctour*—MS. aritour

3795 *neye*—neygh

3796 *seyne*—seyn
neye—nygh

3797-99 *boetes*—MS. boeces, C. boetes

3798 *his* (1)—hise
wey[n]es—weynes

3802 *ful[le]*—fulle

3804 *had[de]*—hadde

3806 *bacines*—MS. batines
pikke—MS. pilke, C. thilke

3807 *seyne*—seyn

3808 *hyzt[e]*—hihte

3809 *eclips*—eclipse

3812 *chorus*—MS. thoros, C. chorus

3813 *snowe*—sonwh = snowh

3815 *here*—her
redyly—redely

3816 *yhid*—MS. yhidde, C. I-hid
seye—seyn

3817 *trouble*—trowblen

3820 *departid[e] from*—departede fro

THE GREAT QUESTIONS.

ITA EST INQUAM.

Þ vs is it *quod* I. but so as þou hast zeuen or byhyzt
me to vnwrappen þe hidde causes of þinges ¶ and

3824

[The syxte prose.]

B. So it is. But as thou
hast promised to unfold
the hidden causes of
things, and unveil things
wrapt up in darkness; I
pray thee deliver me

to discoueren me þe resouns couered *with* dirknesses I
preye þe þat þou diuise *and* Iuge me of þis matere. *and*
þat þou do me to vndrestonden it. ¶ For þis miracle
or þis wondre troubleþ me ryȝt gretely. *and* þan she a

3828

litel [what] smylyng seide. ¶ þou clepest me *quod*
she to telle þing. þat is grettest of alle þinges þat mowen
ben axed. ¶ And to þe whiche questioun vnneþ[e]s is
þere auȝt ynow to lauen it. as who seiþ. vnneþes is þer 3832
suffisauntly any þing to answee *perfitly* to þi questioun.

¶ For þe matere of it is swiche þat whan oon doute is
determined *and* kut away þer wexen oþer doutes wiþ-
outen

noumbre. ryȝt as þe heuedes waxen of ydre þe 3836
serpent þat hercules slouȝ. ¶ Ne þere ne were no
manere ne noon ende. but yif þat a wyȝt constreined[e]
þo doutes. by a ryȝt lyuely *and* a quik fire of þouȝt. þat
is to seyn by *vigour and strengþe* of witte. ¶ For in 3840
þis matere men weren wont to maken questiouns of þe
simplicite of þe *purueaunce* of god *and* of þe ordre of
destine. *and* of sodeyne hap. *and* of þe knowyng *and*
predestinacioun deuine *and* of þe lyberte of fre wille.

3844

þe whiche þing þou þi self aperceiust wel of what
weyȝt

þei ben. but for as mochel as þe knowynge of þise
þinges is a manere porcioun to þe medicine to þe. al be it
so þat I haue lytel tyme to don it. ȝit napeles I wole

3848

enforcen me to shewe somewhat of it. ¶ but al þouȝ

from my present
perplexity, and explain
the mystery I mentioned
to you.

P. You ask me to declare
to you the most intricate
of all questions, which I
am afraid can scarce be
answered.

For the subject is of such
a kind, that when one
doubt is removed,
innumerable others, like
the heads of the hydra,
spring up.

Nor would there be any
end of them unless they
were restrained by a
quick and vigorous effort
of the mind.

The question whereof
you want a solution
embraces the five
following points:

1. Simplicity, or unity of
Providence.
2. The order
and course of Destiny.
3. Sudden chance.
4. Prescience of God, and
divine predestination.
5. Free-will.

I will try to treat of these
things:—

þe norissinges of dite of musike deliteþ þe þow most
suffren. *and* forberen a litel of þilk delite while þat I
weue (contexo) to þe resouns yknyt by ordre ¶ As it likeþ 3852

to þe quod I so do. ¶ þo spak she ryzt a[s] by an oþer
bygynnyn[ge] *and* seide þus. ¶ þe engendrynge of alle
þinges quod she *and* alle þe progressiouns of muuable
nature. *and* alle þat moeueþ in any manere takip hys

3856

causes. hys ordre. *and* hys formes. of þe stablenesse of
þe

deuyne þouzt [*and* thilke deuyne thowht] þat is yset
and

put in þe toure. þat is to seyne in þe heyzt of þe
simplicite

of god. stablisip many manere gyses to þinges þat 3860
ben to don.

FATE AND PROVIDENCE.

¶ þe whiche manere whan þat men loken
it in þilke pure clerenesse of þe deuyne intelligence. it
is ycleped *purueaunce* ¶ but whan þilke manere is
referred

by men to þinges þat it moeueþ *and* disponeþ þan 3864
of olde men. it was cleped destine. ¶ þe whiche

þinges yif þat any wyzt lokeþ wel in his þouzt.

þe strengþe of þat oon *and* of þat oþer he shal lyztly
mowen

seen þat þise two þinges ben diuers. ¶ For *purueaunce*
3868

is þilke deuyne resoun þat is establissed in þe

Resuming her discourse
as from a new principle,
Philosophy argued as
follows:—

The generation of all
things, every progression
of things liable to
change, and everything
that moveth, derive their
causes, order, and form
from the immutability of
the divine understanding.

Providence directs all
things by a variety of
means.

These means, referred
only to the divine
intelligence, are called
Providence; but when
contemplated in relation
to the things which
receive motion and order
from them, are called
Destiny.

Reflection on the
efficacy of the one and
the other will soon cause
us to see their
differences.

Providence is the divine
intelligence manifested
in the disposition of
worldly affairs.

souereyne

prince of þinges. þe whiche *purueaunce* disponiþ alle þinges. but destine is þe disposicioun *and* ordenaunce cleuyng to moeuable þinges. by þe whiche disposicioun 3872

þe *purueaunce* knyteþ alle þinges in hire ordres.

¶ For *purueaunce* enbraceþ alle þinges to hepe. al þou3 þat

þei ben dyuerse *and* al þou3 þei ben wiþ outen fyn. but destynie departeþ *and* ordeyneþ alle þinges singlerly

3876

and diuideþ. in moeuynges. in places. in formes. in tymes. departiþ [as] þus. so þat þe vnfoldyng of temporel

ordenaunce assembled *and* ooned in þe lokyng of þe deuyne þou3t ¶ Is *purueaunce* *and* þilke same 3880 assemblynge. *and* oonyng diuided *and* vnfolden by tymes. lat þat ben called destine. *and* al be *it so þat þise þinges ben dyuerse. 3itte nabeles hangeþ þat oon on þat oþer. forwhi þe ordre destinal procediþ of þe

3884

simplicite of *purueaunce*.

for ry3t as a werkman þat

aperceiueþ in hys þou3t þe forme of þe þing þat he wil make moeueþ þe effect of þe werke. *and* lediþ þat he had[de] loked byforne in hys þou3t symply *and* presently 3888

by temporel þou3t. ¶ Certys ry3t so god disponiþ in hys *purueaunce* singlerly *and* stably þe þinges þat ben to done. but he amynistreþ in many maneres

Destiny or Fate is that inherent state or condition of movable things by means whereof Providence retains them in the order in which she has placed them.

Providence embraces all things, although diverse and infinite; but Fate gives motion to every individual thing, and in the place and under the form appropriated to it.

So that the explication of this order of things wrapt up in the divine intelligence is Providence; and being unfolded according to time and other circumstances, may be called Fate.

[* fol. 30 b.]

Though these things appear to differ, yet one of them depends on the other, for the order of Fate proceeds from the unity of Providence. For as a workman, who has formed in his head the plan of a work which he is desirous to finish, executes it afterwards, and produces after a time all the different parts of the model which he has conceived;

so God in the plan of his Providence disposes everything to be brought

and in dyuerse tymes by destyne. þilke same þinges

3892

þat he haþ disponed þan wheþir þat destine be excercised.

about in a certain order
and in a proper time;

PROVIDENCE CONTROLS FATE.

eyþer by somme dyuyne spirites seruaunteȝ to
þe deuyne purueaunce. or ellys by somme soule (*anima*
mundi). or ellys by al nature seruyng to god. or ellys

3896

by þe celestial moeuyng of sterres. or ellys by þe vertue
of aungels. or ellys by þe dyuerse subtilite of deueles.
or ellys by any of hem. or ellys by hem alle þe destynal
ordynaunce is ywouen or accomplissed. certys it is open 3900

þing þat þe purueaunce is an vnmoeueable *and* symple
forme of þinges to done. *and* þe moeueable bonde *and*
þe temporel ordynaunce of þinges whiche þat þe deuyne
simplicite of purueaunce haþ ordeyned to done. þat is 3904

destine. For whiche it is þat alle þinges þat ben put
vndir destine ben certys subgitȝ to purueaunce. to
whiche purueaunce destine it self is subgit *and* vndir.

¶ But somme þinges ben put vndir purueaunce þat 3908
sourmounten þe ordinaunce of destine. *and* þo ben
þilke þat stably ben yficched ney to þe first godhed þei
sourmounten þe ordre of destinal moeuablite. ¶ For
ryȝt as cercles þat tournen aboute a same Centre or 3912
about a poynt. þilke cercle þat is inrest or moost wiþ-
ynne

ioineþ to þe symplesse of þe myddel *and* is as it
were a Centre or a poynt to þat oþer cercles þat
tournen

and afterwards, by the
ministry of Fate, he
accomplishes what he
has planned,
conformably to that
order and that time.

So then, however Fate be
exercised, it is evident
that things subject to
Destiny are under the
control of Providence,
which disposes Destiny.
But some things under
Providence are exempt
from the control of Fate;
being stably fixed near to
the Divinity himself, and
beyond the movement of
Destiny.

For even, as among
several circles revolving
round one common
centre, that which is
innermost approaches
nearest to the simplicity
of the middle points, and
is, as it were, a centre,
round which the outward
ones revolve;

abouten hym. ¶ and þilke þat is outerest compased by
3916

larger envyronnyng is vnfolden by larger spaces in so
mochel as it is forþest fro þe mydel symplicite of þe
poynt. and yif þer be any þing þat knytteþ *and*
felawshippeþ

hym selfe to þilke mydel poynt it is constreyned 3920
in to symplicite. þat is to seyn in to [vn]moeueablete.
and it ceseth to ben shad *and* to fletin dyuersly. ¶ Ryȝt
so by semblable resoun. þilke þinge þat departiþ
firþest

fro þe first þouȝt of god. it is vnfolden *and* summittid
3924

to grettere bondes of destine. and in so moche is þe
þing more free *and* lovs fro destyne as it axeþ *and*
holdeþ hym ner to þilke Centre of þinges. þat is to
seyne god.

STINY RULES NATURE.

¶ and if þe þinge cleueþ to þe stedfastnesse
3928

of þe þouȝt of god. *and* be wiþ oute moeuyng certys it
sourmounteþ þe necessite of destyne. þan ryȝt swiche
comparisoun as [it] is of skilyng to vndirstondyng
and

of þing þat is engendred to þing þat is. *and* of tyme to
3932

eternite. *and* of þe cercle to þe Centre. ryȝt so is þe
ordre of moeueable destine to þe stable symplicite of
purueaunce. ¶ þilke ordinaunce moeueþ þe heuene

whilst the outermost,
revolving in a wider
circumference, the
further it is from the
centre describes a larger
space—but yet, if this
circle or anything else be
joined to the middle
point, it is constrained to
be immovable.

By parity of reason, the
further anything is
removed from the first
intelligence, so much the
more is it under the
control of Destiny;

and the nearer anything
approaches to this
Intelligence, the centre
of all things, the more
stable it becomes, and
the less dependent upon
Destiny.

And if we suppose that
the thing in question is
joined to the stability of
the supreme mind, it
then becomes
immovable, and is
beyond the necessity and
power of destiny.
As reasoning is to the
understanding, as that
which is produced to that
which exists of itself, as
time to eternity, as the
circle to the centre, so is
the movable order of
Fate to the stable
simplicity of Providence.

Destiny rules nature.

and þe sterres *and* attempereþ þe elymenȝ to gider 3936
amonges hem self. *and* transformeþ hem by enterchaungable
mutacioun. ¶ and þilke same ordre neweþ
azein alle þinges growyng *and* fallyng a-doune by sembleables
progressiouns of seedes *and* of sexes. þat is 3940
to sein. male *and* female. and þis ilke ordre
constreyneth

It controls the actions of men by an indissoluble chain of causes, and is, like their origin, immutable.

þe fortunes *and* þe dedes of men by a bonde of causes
nat able to ben vnbounden (indissolubili). þe whiche
destinal causes whanne þei passen oute fro þe bygynnynges 3944
of þe vnmoeueable purueaunce it mot nedes
be þat þei ne be nat mutable. *and* þus ben þe þinges ful
wel ygouerned. yif þat þe symplite dwellynge *in þe
deuyne þouȝt sheweþ furþe þe ordre of causes. vnable
to 3948

Thus, then, are all things well conducted, since that invariable order of cause has its origin in the simplicity of the Divine mind,

[* fol. 31.]

be I-bowed. *and* þis ordre constreyneth by hys propre
stablete þe moeueable þinges. or ellys þei sholde fleten
folily for whiche it is þat alle þinges semen to be
confus

and by its inherent immutability exercises a restraint upon mutable things, and preserves them from irregularity. To those who understand not this order, things appear confused—nevertheless, the proper condition of all things directs and inclines it to their true good.

and trouble to vs men. for we ne mowe nat considere
3952

þilke ordinaunce. ¶ Napeles þe propre manere of
euery þing dressyng hem to goode disponit hem alle.
for þere nis no þinge don for cause of yuel. ne þilke
þing þat is don by wicked[e] folk nis nat don for yuel
3956

For there is nothing done for the sake of evil, not even by the wicked, who, in seeking for felicity, are led astray by crooked error.

þe whiche shrewes as I haue shewed [ful] plentiuously
seken goode. but wicked errour mystourniþ hem.

THING DONE FOR EVIL'S SAKE.

¶ Ne þe ordre comynge fro þe poynt of souereyne
goode ne
declineth nat fro hys bygynnyng. but þou mayst sein

3960

what vnreste may ben a wors confusioun þan þat
goode

men han somme tyme aduersite. *and* somtyme
prosperite.

¶ and shrewes also han now þinges þat þei
desiren. *and* now þinges þat þei haten ¶ wheþer men

3964

lyuen now in swiche hoolnesse of þouȝt. as who seiþ.
ben men now so wise. þat swiche folk as þei demen to
ben goode folk or shrewes þat it mot nedes ben þat
folk

ben swiche as þei wenen. but in þis manere þe domes

3968

of men discorden. þat þilke men þat somme folk
demen

worþi of mede. oþer folk demen hem worþi of *tourment*.

but lat vs graunt[e] I pose þat som man may wel
demen

or knowen þe goode folk *and* þe badde. May he þan

3972

known *and* seen þilke inrest attemperaunce of
corages.

as it haþ ben wont to be said of bodyes. as who saiþ
may a man speken *and* determine of attemperaunce in

corages. as men were wont to demen or speken of complexiouns 3976
and attemperaunces of bodies (q' non).

But the order proceeding
from the centre of
supreme goodness does
not mislead any.

But you may say, what
greater confusion can
there be than that both
prosperous and adverse
things should at times
happen to good men, and
that evil men should at
one time enjoy their
desires and at another be
tormented by hateful
things.

Are men wise enough to
discover, whether those
whom they believe to be
virtuous or wicked, are
so in reality?

Opinions differ as to this
matter. Some who are
deemed worthy of
reward by one person,
are deemed unworthy by
another.

But, suppose it were
possible for one to
distinguish with certainty
between the good and
the bad?

Then he must have as
accurate a knowledge of
the mind as one has of
the body.

ne it [ne] is nat an vnlyke miracle to hem þat ne knowen
it nat. ¶ As who seiþ. but is lyke a merueil or a
miracle to hem þat ne knowen it nat. whi þat swete 3980
þinges [ben] couenable to some bodies þat ben hool
and
to some bodies bittre þinges ben couenable. *and* also
whi þat some seke folk ben holpen *with* lyzt medicines
[*and* some folk ben holpen *with* sharppe medicynes]
but 3984
napeles þe leche þat knoweþ þe manere *and* þe
attemperaunce
of heele *and* of maladie ne merueileþ of it no
þing. but what oþer þing semeþ hele of corages but
bounte *and* prowesse. *and* what oþer þing semeþ
maladie 3988
of corages but vices. who is ellys kepere of good or
dryuere away of yuel but god gouernour *and* leecher of
þouȝtes. þe whiche god whan he haþ by-holden from
þe
heye toure of hys *purueaunce* he knoweþ what is 3992
couenable to euery wyȝt. *and* leneþ hem þat he wot
[þat] is couenable to hem. Loo here of comeþ *and*
here of is don þis noble miracle of þe ordre destinal.

It is miraculous to him who knows it not, why sweet things are agreeable to some bodies, and bitter to others; why some sick persons are relieved by lenitives and others by sharper remedies.

It is no marvel to the leech, who knows the causes of disease, and their cures.

What constitutes the health of the mind, but goodness? And what are its maladies, but vice?

Who is the preserver of good, or the driver away of evil, but God, the physician of souls, who knows what is necessary for men, and bestows it upon them?

From this source springs that great marvel—the *order of destiny*—wrought by the wisdom of God, and marveled at by ignorant men.

D THE SOUL'S PHYSICIAN.

whan god þat alle knoweþ doþ swiche þing. of whiche 3996
þing [þat] vnknowyng folk ben astoned but forto
constreine
as who seiþ ¶ But forto *comprehende* *and* telle

But, now let us notice a few things concerning the depth of the Divine knowledge which human reason may comprehend.

a fewe þinges of þe deuyne depnesse þe whiche þat mans
resoun may vnderstonde. ¶ þilk man þat þou wenest

4000

to ben ryȝt Iuste *and* ryȝt kepyng of equite. þe contrarie
of þat semeþ to þe deuyne purueaunce þat al woot.

¶ And lucan my familier telleþ þat þe victories cause
liked[e] to þe goddes *and* causes ouercomen liked[e] to 4004

catoun. þan what so euer þou mayst seen þat is don in
þis [world] vn hoped or vnwened. certys it is þe ryȝt[e]
ordre of þinges. but as to þi wicked[e] oppinioun it is a
confusioun. but I suppose þat som man be so wel
ypewed. 4008

þat þe deuyne Iugement *and* þe Iugement of mankynde
accorden hem to gidre of hym. but he is so vnstedfast
of corage [þat] yif any aduersite come to hym he
wolde

for-leten perauenture to continue innocence by þe 4012

whiche he ne may nat wiþholden fortune. ¶ þan þe
wise dispensacioun of god spareþ hym þe whiche
manere aduersite *myȝt[e] enpeyren. ¶ For þat god
wil nat suffren hym to trauaile. to whom þat trauayl

4016

nis nat couenable. ¶ An oper man is perfit in alle
uertues. *and* is an holy man *and* neye to god so þat þe
purueaunce of god wolde demen þat it were a felony
þat he were touched wiþ any aduersites. so þat he ne

4020

wil nat suffre þat swiche a man be moeued wiþ any
manere maladie. ¶ But so as seide a philosophre [the
moore excellent by me]. þe aduersites comen nat (he

The man you deem just,
may appear otherwise to
the omniscient eye of
Providence.

When you see apparent
irregularities—
unexpected and
unwished for—deem
them to be rightly done.
Let us suppose a man so
well behaved, as to be
approved of God and
man—but not endowed
with firmness of mind,
so that the reverses of
fortune will cause him to
forgo his probity, since
with it he cannot retain
his prosperity.

A wise Providence,
knowing that adversity
might destroy this man's
integrity, averts from
him that adversity which
he is not able to sustain.

[* fol. 31 b.]

Another man is
thoroughly virtuous, and
approaches to the purity
of the deity—him
Providence deems it an
injustice to oppress by
adversity, and therefore
exempts him even from
bodily disease.

seide in grec ;) þere þat uertues han edified þe bodie 4024

of þe holy man. and ofte tyme it bitideþ þat þe
somme of þinges þat ben to don is taken to good folk
to gouerne. for þat þe malice habundaunt of shrewes
sholde ben abatid. *and* god 3eueþ *and* departiþ to oþer
4028

folk prosp[er]ites *and* aduersites ymedeled to hepe aftir
þe qualite of hire corages *and* remordip som folk by
aduersites. for þei ne sholden nat wexen proude by
longe welefulnesse. *and* oþer folk he suffreþ to ben
4032

trauayled wiþ harde þinges. ¶ For þat þei sholden
conferme
þe vertues of corage by þe vsage *and* exercitacioun
of pacience. and oþer folke dreden more þen þei auzten
þe wiche þei myzt[en] wel beren. *and* pilke folk god
4036

ledip in to experience of hem self by aspre *and*
sorweful

þinges. ¶ And many oþer folk han bouzt honorable
renoune of þis worlde by þe pris of glorious deef.
and som men þat ne mowen nat ben ouer-comen by
4040

tourment han 3euen ensample to oþer folk þat vertue
ne
may nat be ouer-comen by aduersites.

Providence often gives the direction of public affairs to good men, in order to curb and restrain the malice of the wicked. To some is given a mixture of good and evil, according to what is most suitable to the dispositions of their minds.

Upon some are laid moderate afflictions, lest they wax proud by too long a course of prosperity. Others suffer great adversities that their virtues may be exercised, and strengthened by the practice of patience. Some fear to be afflicted with what they are able to endure. Others despise what they are unable to bear; and God punishes them with calamities, to make them sensible of their presumption.

Many have purchased a great name by a glorious death.

Others by their unshaken fortitude, have shown that virtue cannot be overcome by adversity.

The sidenote "Others despise what they are unable to bear" does not correspond to anything in the text. Skeat's edition includes the phrase "and somme dispyse that they mowe nat beren" (Book IV, Prose 6: *Ita Est Inquam*).

W PROVIDENCE DEALS WITH MANKIND.

¶ and of alle

þise þinges þer nis no doute þat þei ne ben don
ry3tfully

and ordeinly to þe profit of hem to whom we 4044

seen þise þinges bitide. ¶ For certys þat aduersite
comeþ some tyme to shrewes. *and* some tyme þat þei
desiren it comeþ of þise forseide causes *and* of
sorweful

þinges þat bytyden to shrewes. Certys no man ne 4048
wondreþ. For alle men wenen þat þei han wel deserued it.

and þei ben of wicked merite of whiche
shrewes þe tourment som tyme agastep oþer to done
folies. *and* som tyme it amendeþ hem þat suffren þe
4052

tourmentis. ¶ And þe prosperite þat is 3euen to
shrewes sheweþ a grete argument to good[e] folk what
þing þei sholde demen of þilk wilfulnesse þe whiche
prosperite men seen ofte serue to shrewes. in þe
whiche 4056

þing I trowe þat god dispensiþ. for peraventure þe
nature

of som man is so ouerþrowyng to yuel *and* so
vncouenable

þat þe nedy pouerte of hys house-hold my3t[e]
raþer egren hym to done felonies. *and* to þe maladie
4060

of hym god puttip remedie to 3iuen hym rychesse. *and*
som oþer man byholdiþ hys conscience defouled wip
synnes *and* makip comparisoun of his fortune *and* of

These things are done
justly, and in order, and
are for the good of those
to whom they happen.

From the same causes it
happens, that sometimes
adversity and sometimes
prosperity falls to the lot
of the wicked.

None are surprised to see
bad men afflicted—they
get what they deserve.

Their punishment, too,
may cause amendment,
or deter others from like
vices.

When the wicked enjoy
felicity—the good
should learn how little
these external
advantages are to be
prized, which may fall to
the lot of the most
worthless.

Another reason for
dispensing worldly bliss
to the wicked is, that
indigence would prompt
naturally violent and
rapacious minds to
commit the greatest
enormities.

Their disease God cures
by the medicine of
money.

Some men will cease to
do wrong for fear, lest
their wealth be lost
through their crimes.

hym self ¶ and dredip peraventure þat hys blisfulnesse 4064

of whiche þe vsage is ioyful to hym þat þe lesynge of
þilke blisfulnesse ne be nat sorweful to hym. *and* þerfore
he wol chaunge hys maneres. and for he dredip
to lese hys fortune. he forletip hys wickednesse. to 4068
oper folk is welefulnesse ygeuen vnworþily þe whiche
ouerþrowep hem in to destruccioun þat þei han
deserued.

and to som oper folk is geuen power to
punissen. for þat it shal be cause of continuacioun *and*
4072

exercisinge to good[e] folk. *and* cause of tourment to
shrewes. ¶ For so as þer nis none alyauce bytwixe
good[e] folke *and* shrewes. ne shrewes ne mowen nat
accorden amonges hem self *and* whi nat. for shrewes
4076

discorden of hem self by her vices þe whiche vices al
to
renden her consciences. *and* don oft[e] tyme þinges þe
whiche þinges whan þei han don hem. þei demen þat
þo þinges ne sholde nat han ben don. for whiche þinge
4080

þilke souereyne purueaunce hap maked oft[e] tyme
[faire] miracle so þat shrewes han maked oftyme
shrewes to ben good[e] men. for whan þat som
shrewes

*seen þat þei suffren wrongfully felonies of oper
shrewes 4084

þei wexen eschaufed in to hat[e] of hem þat aneien

Upon others unmerited happiness is conferred, which at last precipitates them into deserved destruction.

To some there is given the power of chastisement, in order both to exercise the virtues of the good and to punish the wicked.

For as there is no alliance between good and bad, so neither can the vicious agree together.

And how should they? Their vices make them at war with themselves, rending and tearing their consciences, and there is scarce anything they do, but what afterwards they disapprove of.

Hence arises a signal miracle brought about by Providence—that evil men have often made wicked men good.

For these latter having suffered injuries from the former, have become virtuous, in order that they might not resemble those whom they so detested.

[* fol. 32.]

hem. *and* retournen to þe fruit of uertue. when þei studien to ben vnlyke to hem þat þei han hated.

IL IS OVERRULED FOR GOOD.

¶ Certys þis only is þe deuyne myzt to þe whiche myzt
4088

yueles ben þan good. whan it vseþ þo yueles
couenably

and draweþ out þe effect of any good. as who seiþ þat
yuel is good oonly by þe myzt of god. for þe myzt of
god ordeyneþ þilk yuel to good. For oon ordre enbrasip 4092

alle þinges. so þat what wyzt [þat] departip fro
þe resoun of þe ordre whiche þat is assigned to hym.
algates 3it he slideþ in to an oþer ordre. so þat noþing
nis leueful to folye in þe realme of þe deuyne
purueaunce. 4096

as who seiþ no þing nis wiþouten ordinaunce in
þe realme of þe deuyne purueaunce. ¶ Syn þat þe ryzt
strong[e] god gouernip alle þinges in þis worlde for it
nis nat leueful to no man to *comprehenden* by witte ne
4100

vnfolden by worde alle þe subtil ordinaunces *and*
disposiciouns

of þe deuyne entent. for oonly it auzt[e]
suffice to han loket þat god hym self makere of alle
natures ordeynip and dressip alle þinges to good. while
4104

þat he hastip to wiþhalden þe þinges þat he haþ maked
in to hys semblaunce. þat is to seyn forto wiþholden
þinges in to good. for he hym self is good he chaseþ

It is only the Divine power that can turn evil to good, overruling it for his own purposes.

Nothing occurs by the caprice of chance in the realms of Divine Providence.

Since God is the governor of all things, it is not lawful to man to attempt to comprehend the whole of the Divine economy, or to explain it in words.

Let it suffice to know that God orders all things for the best.

And while he retains things created after his own likeness conformably to his goodness, he banishes evil by the cause of destiny out of his empire.

oute al yuel of þe boundes of hys communalite by þe 4108

ordre of necessite destynable. For whiche it folweþ þat

yif þou loke þe purueaunce ordeynynge þe þinges þat

men wenen ben haboundaunt in erþes. þou ne shalt not

seen in no place no þing of yuel. ¶ but I se now þat 4112

þou art charged wiþ þe wey3te of þe questiou[n] *and*

wery wiþ lengþe of my resoun. *and* þat þou abidest

som

swetnesse of songe. tak þan þis drau3t *and* whan þou

art wel refresshed *and* refet þou shalt ben more stedfast

4116

to styte in to heyere questiouns.

So that those evils which
you seem to see are only
imaginary.

But you are exhausted
and weary with the
prolixity of my
reasoning, and look for
relief from the harmony
of my verse.

Take, then, this draught,
with which when
refreshed, you may more
strongly proceed to
higher matters.

3823 *byhy3t*—by-hyhte

3824 *hidde*—hyd

3826 *preye*—preey

diuise—deuyse

3827 *do*—don

3828 *gretely*—gretly

3829 [*what*]—from C.

3832 *þere au3t*—ther awht

3834 *swiche*—swych

oon—o

3835 *wiþouten noumbre*—with-owte nowmbyr

3836 *waxen*—wexen

3837 *þere*—ther

3838 *constreined*[e]—constreynede

3839 *lyuely*—lyfly

3840 *witte*—wit

3843 *hap*—happe

3845 *wey3t*—wyht

3848 *wole*—wol

3850 *þow*—MS. now, C. þou

most suffren—MS. moste to souereyne; C. most suffren

3851 *pilk*—thilke

3853 *þo*—so

spak—MS. spake, C. spak

a[s]—as
 3856 *alle*—al
 3858 [*and*—*thowht*]—from C.
 yset—MS. *ysette*, C. *yset*
 3859 *toure*—towr
 seyne—seyn
 heyzt—heyhte
 3861 *don*—done
 3862 *clerenesse*—klennesse
 3872 *cleuyng*—clyuyng
 3875 *wip ouden fyn*—Infynyte
 3876 *singlerly*—syngulerly
 3877 *in* (3)—MS. *and*, C. *in*
 3878 *departip*—omitted
 [*as*]—from C.
 so pat—lat
 3884 *on*—of
 3886 *wil*—wol
 3888 *had[de]*—hadde
 symply—symplely
 3889 *pouzt*—ordinaunce
 3890 *singlerly*—syngulerly
 stably—stablely
 3893 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 3894 *eyþer*—owther
 seruaunteȝ—MS. *seruaunceȝ*
 3895 *somme*—som
 3896 *al*—alle
 3897 *moeuyng*—moeuynges
 3900 *ywouen*—MS. *ywonnen*, C. *ywouen*
 or—*and*
 3902 *bonde*—bond
 3904 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 3905 *whiche*—which
 3912 *as*—as of
 3913 *about*—a-bowte
 inrest—innerest
 3917 *larger* (1)—a large
 3918 *mochel*—moche
 forþest—ferthere
 3920 *selfe*—self

3921 [vn]moeueablete—vnmoeuablete
 3922 *ceseth*—MS. fleþe, C. cesith
 3923 *þinge*—thing
 3924 *of*—MS. to, C. of
 3926 *lovs*—laus
 3927 *ner*—nere
 3928 *seyne*—seyn
 þinge cleueþ—thing clyueth
 stedfastnesse—stydefastnesse
 3930 *swiche*—swych
 3931 [it]—from C.
 3932 *to* (2)—MS. of, C. to
 3937 *enterchaungable*—MS. enterchaungyngable, C. entrechaungeable
 3939 *a-doune*—a-down
 sembleables—semblable
 3942 *bonde*—bond
 3943 *ben vnbounden*—be vnbownde
 3944 *oute*—owt
 3948 *furþe*—forth
 3949 *I-bowed*—MS. vnbounden, C. I-bowed
 3950 *sholde*—sholden
 3951 *whiche*—which
 3952 *mowe*—mowen
 3956 *wicked[e]*—wykkede
 3957 [ful]—from C.
 3958-9 *goode*—good
 3960 *declineþ*—MS. enclineþ, C. declynyth
 3961 *wors*—worse
 3962 *somme tyme*—somytyme
 3965 *swiche*—swych
 3967 *goode*—good
 mot—moste
 3971 *graunt[e]*—graunte
 3973 *inrest*—Inneryste
 3974 *hap*—MS. haþe
 said—MS. saide, C. seyd
 3975 *determine*—determinen
 3978 [ne]—from C.
 vnlyke—vn-lyk
 3979 *lyke*—lik

3981 [*ben*]*—*from C.
 *hool**—*hoole
3984 [*and**—medicynes*]*—*from C.
3991 *hap**—*MS. haþe
3993 *wot**—*MS. wote, C. wot
3994 [*pat*]*—*from C.
3995 *don**—*MS. done, C. don
 *miracle**—*MS. mirache, C. myracle
 *ordre**—*MS. ordre of
3996 *alle**—*al
 *dop**—*MS. doþe
 *whiche**—*which
3997 [*pat*]*—*from C.
3999 *mans**—*mannes
4000 *pilk**—*thilke
4004 *liked*[*e*] (*both*)*—*lykede
4005 *is don**—*MS. is to don
4006 *...[world]**—*from C.
 ryzt[*e*]*—*ryhte
4007 *wicked*[*e*]*—*wykkede
4010 *vnstedfast**—*vnstydefast
4011 [*pat*]*—*from C.
 *wolde**—*wol
4015 *manere**—*man
 myzt[*e*]*—*myhte
4016 *wil**—*wol
4018 *neye**—*negh
4021 *wil**—*wol
 *swiche**—*swych
4022 *manere**—*bodyly
4022-3 [*the**—me*]*—*from C.
4023 *þe aduersites**—nat**—*omitted
4024 *þere**—*omitted
4026 *don**—*done
 to (2)*—*MS. so
 *to good**—gouerne**—*to gouerne to goode folk
4028 *oper**—*oothre
4030 *som**—*some
4031 *sholden**—*sholde
4033 *conferme**—*confermen
4034 *corage**—*corages

4036 *myȝt[en]*—myhten
 4037 *hem*—hym
 sorweful—sorwful
 4038 *oper*—oothre
 4039 *worlde*—world
 of (2)—of the
 4041 *oper*—othre
 4046 *comeþ*—comth
 some (both)—som
 þat þei—MS. *þei þat*, C. *þat that they*
 4047 *comeþ*—comth
 sorweful—sorwful
 4050 *wicked*—wykkede
 merite—MS. *uerite*, C. *meryte*
 4051 *oper*—oothre
 done—don
 4052 *folies*—felonies
 4054 *grete*—gret
 good[e]—goode
 4055 *sholde*—sholden
 pilk—thilke
 4056 *serue*—seruen
 whiche—which
 4057 *dispensiþ*—MS. *dispisiþ*, C. *dispensith*
 4059 *myȝt[e]*—myhte
 4060 *done*—don
 4061 *rychesse*—Rychesses
 4065 *whiche*—which
 4068 MS. wrongly inserts *welefulnesse* after *wickednesse*
 4069-71 *oper*—oothre
 4073 *good[e]*—goode
 4074 *none*—non
 4075 *good[e]*—goode
 4076 *accorden*—acordy
 4078 *don*—MS. *done*, C. *don*
 oft[e]—ofte
 4079 *don*—MS. *done*, C. *don*
 4080 *sholde*—sholden
 whiche þinge—which thing
 4081 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
 oft[e]—ofte

4082 [*faire*]*—*from C.
*oftyme—*omitted
 4083 *good[e]—*goode
 4085 *hat[e]—*hate
*anoien—*anoyeden
 4087 *studien—*omitted
*vnlyke—*vnlyk
 4089-90 *good—*goode
 4092 *pilk—*thilke
 4093 [*pat*]*—*from C.
 4094 *þe* (2)*—*thilke
*whiche—*which
 4096 *realme—*Reame
 4099 *strong[e]—*stronge
*worlde—*world
 4100 *no—*omitted
*witte—*wit
 4101 *worde alle—*word al
 4102 *auzt[e]—*owhte
 4104 *good while—*goode wyl
 4105 *hap—*MS. haþe
 4108 *of* (1)*—*fro
 4109 *whiche—*which
 4111 *ben haboundaunt—*ben outraious / or habowndant
 4115 *tak—*MS. take, C. tak
 4116 *refet—*refect
*shalt ben—*shal be
*stedfast—*stydefast

VE TEMPER ALL THINGS.

[SI UIS CELSI IURA.](#)

[The syxte Metur.]

Y if þou wolt demen in þi pure þouȝt þe ryȝtes or þe
 lawes of þe heye þund[ere]re. þat is to seyne of
 god.

loke þou *and* bihold þe heyȝtes of souereyne heuene.

4120

¶ þere kepen þe sterres by ryȝtful alliaunce of þinges

If thou wouldst explore
 the laws of the high
 Thunderer, behold the
 lofty heavens, where,
 bound by fixed laws, the
 stars keep their ancient
 peace.

hir olde pees. þe sonne ymoewed by hys rody fire. ne
destourbiþ nat þe colde cercle of þe moone. ¶ Ne þe
sterre yclepid þe bere. þat encliniþ hys rauyssynge 4124
courses abouten þe souereyne heyzt of þe worlde. ne
þe

same sterre vrsa nis neuer mo wasshen in þe depe
westernne see. ne coueitþ nat to dyzen hys flaumbes in
þe see of [the] occian. al þouȝ he see oþer sterres yplounded 4128

in to þe see. ¶ And hesperus þe sterre
bodip *and* tellip alwey þe late nyȝtes. And lucifer þe
sterre bryngeþ aȝeyne þe clere day. ¶ And þus makip
loue enterchaungeable þe *perdurable* courses. *and* þus
4132

is discordable bataile yput oute of þe contre of þe
sterres.

þis accordaunce attempreþ by euene-lyke manere[s] þe
elementes. þat þe moyste þinges striuen nat wiþ þe
drye þinges. but ȝiuen place by stoundes. and þat þe
4136

colde þinges ioynen hem by feiþ to þe hote þinges. *and*
þat þe lyȝt[e] fyre arist in to heyȝte. *and* þe heuy erþes
aualen by her weyȝtes. ¶ by þise same cause þe floury
yere ȝeldeþ swote smellys in þe fyrste somer sesoun
4140

warmynge. *and* þe hote somer dryeþ þe cornes. *and*
autumpne comeþ aȝeyne heuy of apples. and þe fletyng
reyne bydeweþ þe wynter. þis attemperaunce noryssiþ
and bryngeþ furþe al þinge þat bredip lyfe in þis 4144
worlde. ¶ and þilk same attemperaunce rauyssyng
hideþ

There the rosy Sun does
not invade the moon's
colder sphere. Nor doth
the Bear stray from his
appointed bounds, to
quench his light in the
western main.

Vesper always makes its
wonted appearance at
eve. Lucifer ushers in the
morn.

So mutual love moves all
things, and from the
starry region banishes all
strife.

This concord in equal
measures tempers the
elements, so that the
moist atoms war no more
with the dry, nor heat
with cold contends; but
the aspiring flame soars
aloft, while down the
heavy earth descends.

By these same causes the
flowing year yields
sweet smells in the warm
spring-tide; the hot
summer ripens the corn.
Autumn comes crowned
with plenty, and winter
wets the earth with
showers.

These changes give life
and growth to all that
breathe; and at last by

and bynymeþ *and* drencheþ vndir þe last[e] deþe alle
*þinges yborn. ¶ Amonges þise þinges sitteþ þe heye
makere kyng *and* lorde. welle *and* bygynnyng. lawe

4148

and wise Iuge. to don equite *and* gouerniþ *and* encliniþ
þe bridles of þinges. *and* þo þinges þat he stireþ to don
by moeuyng he wiþdraweþ *and* arestiþ *and* affermiþ
þe

moeueable or wandryng þinges. ¶ For 3if þat he ne 4152
clepiþ nat a3ein þe ry3t goynge of þinges. *and* 3if þat
he

ne constreyned[e] hem nat eftesones in to roundenesse
enclined þe þinges þat ben now continued by stable
ordinaunce. þei sholde deperten from hir welle. þat is 4156
to sein from hir bygynnyng *and* failen. þat is to sein
tournen in to nau3t. ¶ þis is þe commune loue of alle
þinges. *and* alle þinges axen to be holden by þe fyn of
good. For ellys ne my3ten þei nat lasten yif þei ne 4160
come nat eftesones a3eine by loue retourned to þe
cause

þat haþ 3euen hem beyng. þat is to seyn to god.

4118 þou wolt—þou wys wilt

4119 þund[ere]re—thonderere
seyne—seyn

4120 bihold—MS. biholde, C. byhold

4122 rody—MS. redy, C. rody
fire—Fyr

4123 cercle—clerke

4125 courses—cours
hey3t—heyhte

4127 westerne—westrene
dy3en—deeyn

death efface whatever
has had birth.

[* fol. 32 b.]

Meanwhile the world's
Creator, the Source of
all, the Lawgiver, the
wise Judge, sits above
equitably directing all
things.

Those things which have
been set in motion by
him are also checked and
forced to move in an
endless round, lest they
go from their source, and
become chaotic.

This love is common to
all things, and all things
tend to good; so, urged
by this, they all revert to
that First Cause that gave
them being.

4128 [*the*]*—*from C.
*he see**—*MS. it sewe, C. he see
*oper**—*oothre
 4131 *azeyne**—*ayein
 4133 *oute**—*owt
 4134 *euene-lyke manere*[s]*—*euenelyk maneres
 4135 *striuen**—*stryuynge
*nat**—*omitted
 4136 *but**—*omitted
 4138 *lyȝt*[e] *fyre arist**—*lyhte fyr arysith
 4140 *yere**—*ȝer
 4142 *comeþ azeyne**—*comth ayein
 4143 *reyne**—*reyn
 4144 *furþe al þinge**—*forth alle thing
*bredip lyfe**—*berith lyf
 4145 *worlde**—*world
*þilk**—*thilke
 4146 *last*[e] *deþe**—*laste deth
 4147 *yborn**—*MS. yborne, C. I-born
 4148 *lorde**—*lord
 4149 *wise**—*wys
 4150 *stireþ**—*sterith
*don**—*gon
 4151 *þe**—*omitted
 4153 *clepip**—*klepede
 4154 *constreyned*[e]*—*constreynede
*roundenesse**—*Rowndnesses
 4156 *sholde**—*sholden
 4158 *tournen**—*torne
*of**—*to
 4159 *be**—*ben
 4161 *eftesones aȝeine**—*eft sones ayein
 4162 *haþ**—*MS. haþe

L FORTUNE IS BENEFICIAL.

[IAM NE IGITUR UIDES.](#)

[The seuende prose.]

S_I est þou nat þan what þing folweþ alle þe þinges þat

P. Do you see what follows from our arguments?

haue seid. what þing quod I. ¶ Certys quod she 4164
outerly þat al fortune is good. and how may þat be
quod .I. ¶ Now vndirstand quod she so as [alle
fortune wheyther so it be Ioyeful fortune / or aspre]
fortune is 3iuen eiper by cause of gerdonyng or ellys
of 4168

exercisyng of goode folk or ellys by cause to
punissen.

or ellys to chastysen shrewes. ¶ þan is alle fortune
good. þe whiche fortune is certeyne þat it be eiper ry3tful
or profitable. ¶ For soþe þis is a ful verray resoun 4172
quod I. and yif I considere þe purueaunce and þe
destine þat þou tau3test me a litel here byforne þis
sentence

is susteyned by stedfast resouns. but yif it like
vnto þe lat vs noumbre hem amonges þilk[e] þinges of 4176
whiche þou seidest a litel here byforne þat þei ne were
nat able to ben ywened to þe poeple. ¶ whi so quod
she.

for þat þe comune worde of men mysusip quod I.
þis manere speche of fortune. and sein ofte tymes [þat]
4180

þe fortune of som wy3t is wicked.

NISHMENT IS BENEFICIAL.

wilt þou þan quod
she þat I proche a litel to þe wordes of þe poeple so it
seme nat to hem þat I be ouer moche departid as fro þe
vsage of man kynde. as þou wolt quod I. ¶ Demest 4184
þou nat quod she þat al þing þat profitip is good. 3is

B. What is it?

P. That all fortune is
good.

B. How can that be?

P. Since all fortune,
whether prosperous or
adverse, is for the reward
of the good or the
punishment of the bad,
all fortune is good which
is either just or useful.

But let us put this
opinion among those
positions which thou
saidst were not
commonly believed by
the people.

P. Why so?

B. Because it is a
common expression that
the fortune of such a one
is bad.

P. Do you wish me to
conform for awhile to
the language of the
people, lest we should
seem to depart too much
from the popular mode
of expression?

B. As you please.

quod I. certis þilk þing þat exercisiþ or corrigiþ profitiþ.
I confesse it wel quod I. þan is it good quod she.

whi nat quod I. but þis is þe fortune [quod she] of 4188
hem þat eiþer ben put in vertue *and* batailen azeins
aspre þinges. or ellys of hem þat eschewen *and*
declinen

fro vices *and* taken þe weye of vertue. ¶ þis ne may
nat I denye quod I ¶ But what seist þou of þe myrye
4192

fortune þat is zeuen to good folk in gerdoun deuiniþ
ou3t þe poeples þat it is wicked. nay forsoþe quod I.
but

þei demen as it soþe is þat it is ry3t good. ¶ And what
seist þou of þat oþer fortune quod she. þat al þou3 it
4196

be aspre *and* restreiniþ þe shrewes by ry3tful tourment.
weniþ ou3t þe poeple þat it be good. nay quod I. ¶ But
þe poeple demiþ þat it be most wrecched of alle þinges
þat may ben þou3t. war now *and* loke wel quod she
4200

lest þat we in folwyng þe opynioun of poeple haue
confessed

and concluded þing þat is vnable to be wened to
þe poeple. what is þat quod I ¶ Certys quod she it
folweþ or comeþ of þinges þat ben graunted þat alle
4204

fortune what so euer it be. of hem þat eyþer ben in
possessioun of vertue. [or in the encres of vertu] or
ellys

in þe purchasyng of vertue. þat þilke fortune is good.

P. Is everything
profitable that is good?

B. Yes, certainly.

P. That which exercises
or corrects is profitable?

B. It is.

P. Therefore it is good?

B. Yes.

P. This is the fortune of
the virtuous who combat
with adversity, or of
those who, relinquishing
vice, pursue the path of
virtue?

B. It is.

P. The vulgar regard that
prosperity which is
bestowed as a reward on
the good to be beneficial,
and they believe those
calamities by which the
wicked are punished as
the most miserable
things that can be
imagined.

But in following the
popular opinion, let us
beware of being
involved in some new
and incredible conse-
quence.

B. What is that?

P. We have decided that
the fortune of the
virtuous or of those
growing up in virtue
must needs be good—
but that the fortune of
the wicked must be most
wretched.

¶ And þat alle fortune is ryȝt wicked to hem þat 4208
dwellen in shrewednesse. as who seiþ. *and* þus wenep
nat þe poeple.

E FORTUNE OF THE VIRTUOUS IS GOOD.

¶ þat is soþe quod I. ¶ Al be it so
þat noman dar confessen it ne byknowen it. ¶ whi so
quod she. For ryȝt as no strong man ne semeþ nat to
4212
abassen or disdaignen as *ofte tyme as he hereþ þe
noise
of þe bataile. ne also it ne semeþ nat to þe wyse man to
beren it greuously as oft[e] as he is lad in to þe strif of
fortune. for boþe to þat on man *and* eke to þat oþer
4216
þilke difficulte is þe matere to þat oon man of encrese
of his glorious renoun. *and* to þat oþer man to
conferme
hys sapience. þat is to seine þe asprenesse of hys estat.
¶ For þerfore is it called uertue. for þat it susteniþ *and*
4220
enforceþ by hys strengþes þat it nis nat ouer-comen by
aduersites. ¶ Ne certys þou þat art put in þe encrese
or in þe heyȝt of uertue ne hast nat comen to fleten wiþ
delices *and* forto welken in bodyly lust. ¶ þou sowest
4224
or plauntest a ful egre bataile in þi corage azeins euery
fortune. for þat þe sorweful fortune ne confounde þe
nat.
ne þat þe myrre fortune ne corruppe þe nat. ¶ Occupy

B. That's true, though
none dare acknowledge
it.

P. Why so? The wise
man ought not to be cast
down, when he has to
wage war with Fortune,
no more than the valiant
man ought to be
dismayed on hearing the
noise of the battle.

[* fol. 33.]

The dangers of war
enable the one to acquire
more glory, and the
difficulties of the other
aid him to confirm and
improve his wisdom.

Thus virtue, in its literal
acceptation, is a power
that, relying on its own
strength, overcomes all
obstacles.

You, who have made so
much progress in virtue,
are not to be carried
away by delights and
bodily lusts.

You must engage in a
fierce conflict with every
fortune—with adversity,
lest it dismay you—with
prosperity, lest it corrupt
you.

Seize the *golden mean*
with all your strength.

þe mene by stedfast strengþes. for al þat euer is vndir

4228

þe mene. or ellys al þat ouer-passeþ þe mene despiseþ
welefulnesses. ¶ As who seiþ. it is vicious *and* ne haþ
no mede of hys trauaile. ¶ For it is set in 3oure hand.
as who seiþ it lieþ in 3oure power what fortune 3ow is

4232

leuest. þat is to seyne good or yuel. ¶ For alle fortune
þat semeþ sharpe or aspre yif it ne exercise nat þe
good

folk. ne chastisiþ þe wicked folk. it punisseþ.

All below or above this
line is a contemptible
and a thankless felicity.

The choice of fortune
lies in your own hands,
but remember that even
adverse fortune, unless it
exercises the virtues of
the good or chastises the
wicked, is a punishment.

4163 *þing*—thinge

4165 *outerly*—al owtrely

al—alle

4166-7 [*alle*—*aspre*]—from C.

4169 *goode*—good

4174 *here byforne*—her by-forn

4175 *stedfast*—stydefast

4176 *noumbre*—nowmbren

þilk[e]—thilke

4177 *here byforne*—her by-forn

4178 *ywened*—weened

4179 *worde*—word

4180 [*þat*]—from C.

4181 *wicked*—wykkede

4182 *proche*—aproche

4185 *al*—alle

4186 *þilk*—thilke

4188 [*quod she*]—from C.

4191 *weye*—wey

4193 *deuinip*—demyth

4194 *ou3t*—awht

4195 *soþe*—soth

4198 *ou3t*—awht

4199 *be*—is

4204 *comeþ*—comth
 4206 [*or*—*vertu*] from C.
 4208 *wicked*—wykkede
 4210 *soþe*—soth
 4211 *confessen*—confesse
 4212 *no strong*—the stronge
 4213 *abassen*—abayssen
 4215 *oft[e]*—ofte
 4219 *seine*—seyn
 4223 *heyzt*—heyhte
 4224 *welken*—wellen
 4226 *confounde*—MS. confounded, C. confownde
 4227 *Occupy*—Ocupye
 4228 *stedfast*—stydefast
 4230 *hap*—MS. haþe
 4231 *set*—MS. sette, C. set
 4232 *lieþ*—lith
 4233 *seyne*—seyn
 4234 *sharpe*—sharp

CHOOSE OUR OWN FORTUNE.

[BELLA BIS QUENIS. ET CETERA.](#)

[The seuende Metur.]

PE wrekere attrides ¶ þat is to seyne agamenon þat
 4236

Atrides carried on a ten years' war to punish the licentious Paris.

wrouzt[e] *and* continued[e] þe batailes by ten 3ere
 recouered[e] *and* purged[e] in wrekyng by þe destruccioun
 of troie þe loste chambres of mariage of hys broþer
 þis is to seyn þat [he] agamenon wan a3ein Eleine þat 4240
 was Menelaus wif his broþer. In þe mene while þat
 þilke agamenon desired[e] to 3euen sailes to þe
 grekysshe

With blood he purchased propitious gales for the Grecian fleet, by casting off all fatherly pity, and sacrificing his daughter Iphigenia to the vengeance of Diana.

nauye *and* bouzt[e] a3ein þe wyndes by blode. he
 vncloped[e] hym of pite as fader. *and* þe sory prest

4244

3iueþ in sacrificyng þe wreched kuytting of þrote of þe
 dou3ter. ¶ þat is to sein þat agamenon lete kuytten þe
 þrote of hys dou3ter by þe prest. to maken alliaunce wiþ
 hys goddes. *and* for to haue wynde wiþ whiche he 4248
 my3t[e] wende to troie. ¶ Itakus þat is to sein vlixies
 bywept[e] hys felawes ylorn þe whiche felawes þe
 fiers[e] pholifemus ligginge in his grete Caue had[de]
 freten *and* dreint in hys empty wombe. but napeles 4252
 polifemus wood for his blinde visage 3eld to vlixies ioie
 by hys sorrowful teres. þis is to seyn þat vlixes smot
 oute þe eye of poliphemus þat stod in hys forhede.

Ulysses bewailed his lost
 mates, devoured by
 Polyphemus, but, having
 deprived the Cyclop of
 his sight, he rejoiced to
 hear the monster's roar.

E LABOURS OF HERCULES.

for whiche vlixes hadde ioie whan he saw poliphemus 4256
 wepyng *and* blynde. ¶ Hercules is celebrable for hys
 hard[e] trauaile he dawntede þe proude Centauris half
 hors half man. *and* he rafte þe despoilyng fro þe
 cruel lyoun þat is to seyne he slou3 þe lyoun *and* 4260
 rafte hym hys skyn. he smot þe brids þat hy3ten
 arpijs [in þe palude of lyrne] wiþ certeyne arwes.
 he rauyssed[e] applis fro þe wakyng dragoun. *and*
 hys hand was þe more heuy for þe golde[ne] 4264
 metal. He drou3 Cerberus þe hound of helle by
 hys treble cheyne. he ouer-comer as it is seid hap
 put an vnmeke lorde fodre to hys cruel hors ¶ þis is
 to sein. þat hercules slou3 diomedes *and* made his hors
 4268
 to etyn hym. *and* he hercules slou3 Idra þe serpent *and*
 brend[e] þe venym. *and* achelaus þe flode defouled[e]
 in

Hercules is renowned for
 his many labours, so
 successfully overcome.

He overthrew the proud
 Centaurs;
 he slew the Nemean lion
 and wore his skin as a
 trophy of his victory;
 he smote the Harpies
 with his arrows;
 he caried off the golden
 apples of the Hesperides,
 and killed the watchful
 dragon;

he bound Cerberus with
 a threefold chain;
 he gave the body of
 proud Diomede as food
 for the tyrant's horses;

he slew the serpent
 Hydra;

he caused Achelous to
 hide his blushing head
 within his banks;

his forhede dreint[e] his shamefast visage in his
 strondes. þis is to sein þat achelaus couþe transfigure 4272
 hym self in to dyuerse lykenesse. *and* as he fauþt wiþ
 orcules at þe laste he turnid[e] hym in to a bole and
 hercules brak of oon of hys hornes. *and* achelaus for
 shame hidde hym in hys ryuer. ¶ And [he] hercules 4276
 *cast[e] adoun Antheus þe geaunt in þe strondes of
 libye. *and* kacus apaised[e] þe wrappes of euander. þis
 is to sein þat hercules slouþ þe Monstre kacus *and*
 apaised[e] wiþ þat deef þe wrappe of euander. ¶ And
 4280
 þe bristled[e] boor marked[e] wiþ scoms þe sholdres
 of
 hercules. þe whiche sholdres þe heye cercle of heuene
 sholde þreste. *and* þe laste of his labours was þat he
 sustened[e] þe heuene vpon his nekke vnbowed. *and*
 he 4284
 deserued[e] eftsones þe heuene to ben þe pris of his
 laste trauayle ¶ Gop now þan 3e stronge men þere as
 þe heye weye of þe grete ensample ledeþ 3ou. ¶ O nice
 men whi nake 3e 3oure bakkes. as who seiþ. ¶ O 3e 4288
 slowe *and* delicat men whi fley 3e aduersites. *and* ne
 fyþten nat aþeins hem by vertue to wynnyn þe mede of
 þe heuene. for þe erþe ouer-comen 3eueþ þe sterres.
 ¶ þis is to seyne þat whan þat erþely lust is ouer-
 comen. 4292
 a man is maked worþi to þe heuene.

he left Antæus dead upon
 the Lybian shore;
 [* fol. 33 b.]

he appeased Evander's
 wrath by killing Cacus;

he slew the Erymanthean
 boar;

and bore the weight of
 Atlas upon his shoulders.

These labours justly
 raised him to the rank of
 a god.

Go then, ye noble souls,
 and follow the path of
 this great example.

O ye slothful ones,
 wherefore do ye basely
 fly!

He who conquers earth
 doth gain the heavens.

EXPLICIT LIBER QUARTUS.

4237 *wrouzt[e]*—wrowhte
 continued[e]—continuede
 3ere—3er
 4238 *purged[e]*—purgede
 4240 [*he*]*—*from C.
 wan—MS. wanne, C. wan
 4242 *desired[e]*—desiredede
 4243 *bouzt[e]*—bowhte
 blode—blod
 4244 *vncloped[e]*—vnclothede
 as—of
 4245 *kuytting*—MS. knyttyng, C. kuttynge
 4246 *lete*—let
 kuytten—MS. knydden, C. kuttyn
 4248 *haue*—han
 4249 *myzt[e]* *wende*—myhte wenden
 4250 *bywept[e]*—by-wepte
 ylorn—MS. ylorne, C. y-lorn
 4251 *fiers[e]*—feerse
 had[de]—hadde
 4253 *3eld*—yald
 4254 *sorrowful*—sorwful
 smot—MS. smote, C. smot
 4255 *oute*—owt
 stod—MS. stode, C. stood
 forhede—forehed
 4256 *saw*—say
 4258 *hard[e]* *trauaile*—harde trauayles
 dawntede—MS. dawnded, C. dawntede
 4259 *half*—MS. hals
 rafte—byrafte
 fro—from
 4260 *seyne*—seyn
 4261 *smot*—MS. smote, C. smot
 4262 [*in*—*lyrne*]*—*from C.
 4263 *rauysse[d]**[e]*—rauysshede
 4266 *seid*—MS. seide, C. sayd
 hap—MS. hape
 4267 *lorde*—lord
 4269 *etyn*—freten
 4270 *brend[e]*—brende
 flode defouled[e]—flood defowlede

4271 *forhede dreint[e]*—forhed dreynte

4273 *lykenesse*—lyknesses

4274 *turnid[e]*—tornede

4275 *brak*—MS. brake, C. brak
hys—hise

4276 [*he*]—from C.

4278-80 *apaised[e]*—apaysede

4281 *bristled[e]*—brysteled
marked[e]—marked

4282 *cercle*—clerke

4283 *preste*—thriste

4285 *deserued[e]*—deseruede

4286 *Gop*—MS. Gope
pere—ther

4287 *weye*—way

4288 *nake*—MS. make, C. nake

4289 *slowe*—MS. slou3, C. slowe
fley—flee

4292 *seyne*—seyn

E EXISTENCE OF CHANCE.

INCIPIT LIBER QUINTUS.

DIXERAT ORACIONISQUE CURSUM.

She hadde seid *and* tourned[e] þe cours of hir
resoun to
somme oþer þinges to ben tretid *and* to ben ysped.
þan seide I. Certys ryȝtful is þin amonestyng *and* ful
4296
digne by auctorite. but þat þou seidest som tyme þat
þe questioun of þe deuyne purueaunce is enlaced wiþ
many oþer questiouns. I vndir-stonde wel *and* proue it

[The fyrste prose.]

When Philosophy had
thus spoken, and was
about to discuss other
matters I interrupted her.

B. Thy exhortation is just
and worthy of thy
authority, but thou saidst
that the question of the
Divine Superintendence
or Providence is
involved with many
others—and this I
believe.

by þe same þinge. but I axe yif þat þou wenest þat hap
4300

be any þing in any weys. *and* if þou wenest þat hap be
any [thing] what is it. þan *quod* she. I haste me to
zelden *and* assoilen þe to þe dette of my byheste *and*
to shewen *and* opnen þe wey by whiche wey þou maist
4304

come azein to þi contre. ¶ but al be it so þat þe þinges
whiche þat þou axest ben ryzt profitable to knowe.
zitte ben þei diuers somewhat fro þe pape of my purpos.
And it is to douten þat þou ne be makid weery by 4308
mysweys so þat þou ne mayst nat suffise to mesuren þe
ryzt weye. ¶ Ne doute þe þer-of no þing *quod* I. for
forto knowen þilke þinges to-gidre in þe whiche þinges
I delite me gretly. þat shal ben to me in stede of reste.
4312

Syn it nis nat to douten of þe þinges folwyng whan
euery side of þi disputisoun shal be stedfast to me by
vndoutous feiþ. þan seide she. þat manere wol I don
þe. *and* bygan to speken ryzt þus ¶ Certys *quod* she
4316

yif any wyzt diffynisse hap in þis manere. þat is to seyn.

FINITION OF CHANCE.

þat hap is bytydunge y-brouzt forþe by foelyshe
moeuyng. *and* by no knyttyng of causes. ¶ I conferme
þat hap nis ryzt nauzt in no wise. *and* I deme al 4320
outerly þat hap nis ne dwelliþ but a voys. ¶ As who
seiþ. but an ydel worde wiþ outen any significacioun
of

I am desirous, however,
of knowing whether
there be such a thing as
Chance, and what thou
thinkest it is.

P. I hasten to fulfil my
promise and to show the
road to your own
country.

But although these
things you question me
about are profitable to
know, yet they lead us a
little out of our way.
And by straying from the
path you may be too
fatigued to return to the
right road.

B. Don't be afraid of
that, for it will refresh
me as much as rest to
know these things in
which I am delightfully
interested.

P. I will then comply
with thy requests.

If we define Chance to
be an event produced by
an unintelligent motion,
and not by a chain or
connection of causes, I
should then affirm that
Chance is nothing and an
empty sound.

þing summittid to þat vois. for what place myȝt[e] ben
left or dwellynge to folie *and* to disordinaunce. syn þat
4324

god lediþ *and* streyniþ alle þinges by ordre. ¶ For þis
sentence is verray *and* soþe þat no þinge ne haþ his
beynge of nouȝt. to [the] whiche sentence none of þise
olde folk ne wiþseide neuere al be it so þat þei ne 4328
vndirstoden ne moeueden it nauȝt by god prince *and*
gynner of wirkyng. but þei casten as a manere foundement
of subgit material. þat is to seyn of [the] nature
of alle resoun. *and* ȝif þat ony þinge is woxen or
comen 4332

of no causes. þan shal it seme þat þilke þinge is comen
or woxen of nouȝt. but yif þis ne may nat ben don.
þan is it nat possible þat þere haþ ben any swiche þing
as I haue diffinissid a litel here byforne. ¶ How shal
4336

it þan ben *quod* I. nis þer þan no þing þat by ryȝt may
be cleped eyþer *happe* or ellis auenture of fortune. or is
þer ouȝt al *be it so þat it is hidd fro þe poeple to
whiche þise wordes ben couenable.

Myn aristotul *quod* 4340

she. in þe book of his phisik diffinisseþ þis þing by
short resoun and neyȝe to þe soþe. ¶ In whiche manere
quod I. ¶ As ofte *quod* she as men don any þing for
grace of any oþer þing. *and* an oþer þinge þan þilke
4344

þing þat men ententen to doon bytideþ by som[e]
causes

it is ycleped *happe*. ¶ Ryȝt as a man dalf þe erþe by

What room is there for
folly and disorder where
all things are restrained
by order, through the
ordinance of God?

For it is a great truth that
nothing can spring out of
nothing.

Now, if anything arises
without the operation of
a cause, it proceeds from
nothing.

But if this is impossible,
then there can be no such
a thing as Chance, as we
have defined it.

B. Is there nothing, then,
that may be called
Chance or Fortune?

Is there nothing (hid
from the vulgar) to
which these words may
be applied?

[* fol. 34.]

P. Aristotle defines this
matter with much
precision and
probability.

B. How?

P. So often as a man does
anything for the sake of
any other thing, and
another thing than what
he intended to do is
produced by other
causes, that thing so
produced is called
Chance.

cause of tylienge of þe felde. *and* fond þere a gobet of golde by-doluen. þan wenen folk þat it is fallen by fortunous 4348

bytydyng. but for soþe it nis nat for nauȝt for it haþ hys propre causes of whiche causes þe cours vnforseyn and vnwar semip to han maked *happe*. ¶ For yif þe tilier in þe erþe ne delue nat in þe felde. and yif 4352

þe hider of þe golde ne hadde hidd þe golde in þilke place. þe golde ne had[de] nat ben founde. þise ben þan þe causes of þe abreggyng of fortune hap. þe whiche abreggyng of fortune hap comeþ of causes encountrynge 4356

and flowyng to-gidre to hem selfe. *and* nat by þe entencioun of þe doer. ¶ For neiþer þe hider of þe gold.

ne þe deluer of þe felde ne vndirstanden nat þat þe golde sholde han be founde. but as I seide. it bytidde 4360

and ran to-gidre þat he dalf þere as þat oþer hadde hidd þe golde. Now may I þus diffinissen *happe*. ¶ *Happe* is an vnwar bytydyng of causes assembled in þinges þat ben don for som oþer þinge. but þilke ordre procedyng 4364

by an vneschewable byndyng to-gidre. whiche þat descendep fro þe wel of purueaunce þat ordeineþ alle þinges in hire places *and* in hire tymes makeþ þat þe causes rennen *and* assemblen to-gidre. 4368

As if a man trench the ground for tillage and find gold, then this is believed to happen by chance, although it is not so.

For if the tiller had not ploughed the field, and if the hider of the gold had not concealed it in that spot, the gold had not been found.

These, then, are the causes of a fortuitous acquisition which proceeds from a conflux of encountering causes, and not from the intention of the doer.

For neither the hider of the gold nor the husbandman intended or understood that the gold should be found. But it happened by the concurrence of these two causes that the one did dig where the other had hidden the money. Chance, then, is an unexpected event, by a concurrence of causes, following an action designed for a particular purpose.

This concurrence of causes proceeds from that order which flows from the fountain of Providence and disposes all things as to place and time.

4294 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyd
 þe—by
 4297 *som tyme*—whilom
 4298 *þe* (2)—thy
 4300 *þinge*—thing
 4302 [*thing*]*—from C.*
 4303 *zelden*—yilden
 assoilen—MS. assailen, C. assoylen
 byheste—byhest
 4304-6 *whiche*—which
 4306 *ben*—MS. bene
 4307 *pape*—paath
 4312 *stede*—styde
 4314 *disputisoun*—disputacioun
 be—han ben
 stedfast—stydefast
 4317 *seyn*—seyng
 4318 *forþe*—forth
 4322 *worde*—word
 4323 *myȝt[e]*—myhte
 4324 *left*—lefte
 4325 *streynip*—constreynyth
 4326 *soþe*—soth
 no þinge—nothing
 hap—MS. haþe
 4327 [*the*]*—from C.*
 4330 *gynner*—bygynnere
 4331 [*the*]*—from C.*
 4332 *ȝif*—MS. ȝit, C. yif
 þinge—thing
 4335 *þat*—*ben*—þat hap be
 hap—MS. haþe
 swiche—swych
 4338 *happe*—hap
 4339 *hidd*—MS. hidde, C. hidd
 4340 *whiche*—which
 4342 *neyȝe*—nehg
 whiche—which
 4343 *don*—MS. done, C. don
 4344 *þinge*—thing

4345 *som[e]*—some
 4346 *happe*—hap
 4347 *of* (1)—to
 fond—MS. *fonde*, C. *fownde*
 4348 *golde*—gold
 fallen—byfalle
 4349 *for* (2)—of
 4350 *hap*—MS. *hape*
 hys—hise
 4351 *happe*—hap
 4352 *tilier*—tylyere
 delue—dolue
 4353 *hider*—hydere
 golde—gold
 hidd—MS. *hidde*
 4353-4 *golde*—gold
 4354 *had[de]*—hadde
 4355 *fortune*—fortuit
 whiche—which
 4356 *fortune*—fortuit
 comeþ—comth
 4357 *flowyng*—MS. *folwyng*, C. *flowynge*
 selfe—self
 4358 *doer*—doere
 hider—hidere
 4359 *deluer*—deluere
 felde—feeld
 vndirstanden—vndirstoden
 4360 *golde*—gold
 4361 *hidd*—MS. *hidde*, C. *hyd*
 4362 *happe (both)*—hap
 4365 *whiche*—which
 4366 *descendeþ*—MS. *defendeþ*, C. *descendith*
 wel—welle

RUPIS ACHEMENIE.

[The fyrste Metur.]

T Igris [*and*] eufrates resoluen *and* spryngen of a
 welle in
 þe kragges of þe roche of þe contre of achemenye þere

Where the flying
 Parthian doth pierce his
 pursuers with his shafts,
 there from the
 Achemenian heights
 flow the Tigris and

as þe fleenge [batayle] ficchiþ hire dartes retournid in
þe brestes of hem þat folwen hem. ¶ And sone aftre

4372

þe same ryueres tigris *and* eufrates vnioygnen *and* departen
hire watres. and yif þei comen to-gidre *and* ben
assembled *and* clepid to-gidre in to o cours. þan moten
þilke þinges fletyn to-gidre whiche þat þe water of þe

4376

entrechaungyng flode bryngeþ þe shippes *and* þe
stokkes

araced wiþ þe flood moten assemble. *and* þe watres
ymedlyd wrappiþ or implieþ many fortunel happes or
maneres. þe whiche wandryng happes nabeles þilke
enclinyng 4380

lowenes of þe erþe. *and* þe flowynge ordre of
þe slidyng water gouerniþ. ¶ Ryȝt so fortune þat
semeþ as [þat] it fletiþ wiþ slaked or vngouerned[e]
bridles. It suffriþ bridles þat is to seyn to ben gouerned

4384

and passeþ by þilke lawe. þat is to sein by þe deuyne
ordinaunce.

4369 [*and*]*—*from C.

a—oo

4371 [*batayle*]*—*from C.

4373 *þe—*tho

4374 *to-gidre—*to-gyderes

4376 *whiche—*which

4377 *flode—*flod

4378 *assemble—*assemblyn

4380 *enclinyng—*declynyngge

4381 *lowenes—*lownesse

4383 [*þat*]*—*from C.

*vngouerned[e]—*vngouernede

Euphrates, but soon their
streams divide and flow
into separate channels.

But should they unite
again, in the impetuous
stream, boats, ships, and
trees would be all
intermingled, whirled
about; and blind Chance
seems to direct the
current's course.

But the sloping earth, the
laws of fluids, govern
these things.

So though Chance seems
to wander unrestrained,
it is nevertheless curbed
and restrained by Divine
Providence.

FREE WILL.

[ANIMADUERTO INQUAM.](#)

Þis vndirstonde I wel *quod* I. *and* accorde wel þat it
is ryzt as þou seist. but I axe yif þer be any liberte

4388

or fre wil in þis ordre of causes þat cliuen þus to-gidre
in hem self. ¶ or ellys I wolde witen yif þat þe
destinal cheine constreiniþ þe moeueyng of þe
corages

of men. yis *quod* she þer is liberte of fre wille. ne þer

4392

ne was neuer no nature of resoun þat it ne hadde liberte
of fre wille. ¶ For euery þing þat may naturely vsen
resoun. it haþ doom by whiche it discerniþ *and* demiþ
euery þing. ¶ þan knoweþ it by it self þinges þat ben

4396

to fleen. *and* þinges þat ben to desiren. *and* þilk þing
þat any wyzt demeþ to ben desired þat axeþ or desireþ
he *and* fleþ [thilke] þing þat he troueþ ben to fleen.

ÐVIDENCE SEES ALL THINGS.

¶ wher-fore in alle þinges þat resoun is. *in* hem also is

4400

libertee of willyng *and* of nillynge. ¶ But I ne ordeyne
nat. as who seiþ. I ne graunte nat þat þis libertee be
euene like in alle þinges. forwhi in þe souereyns
deuynes

substaunces. þat is to *seyne in spiritz ¶ Iugement is

[The .2^{de}. prose.]

B. Is there any *free-will*
in this chain of cohering
causes?

Or doth the *chain of*
destiny constrain the
motions of the human
mind?

P. There is a freedom of
the will possessed by
every rational being.

A rational being has
judgment to judge of and
discern everything.

Of himself he knows
what he is to avoid or to
desire. He seeks what he
judges desirable, and he
shuns what he deems
should be avoided.

A rational being
possesses, then, the
liberty of choosing and
rejecting.

This liberty is not equal
in all beings.

In heavenly substances,
as spirits, &c., judgment
is clear, and the will is

4404

more clere *and* wil nat be corumped. *and* hap myȝt
redy to speden þinges þat ben desired. ¶ But þe soules
of men moten nedes ben more free whan þei loken
hem

in þe speculacioun or lokynge of þe deuyne þouȝt. *and*
4408

lasse free whan þei sliden in to þe bodies. *and* ȝit lasse
free whan þei ben gadred to-gidre *and* comprehendid
in

erpely membris. but þe last[e] seruage is whan þat þei
ben ȝeuen to vices. *and* han yfalle fro þe possessioun
of 4412

hire propre resoun ¶ For after þat þei han cast awaye
hir eyen fro þe lyȝt of þe souereyn soþefastnesse to
lowe

þinges *and* dirke ¶ Anon þei dirken by þe cloude of
ignoraunce *and* ben troubled by felonous talentȝ. to þe
4416

whiche talentȝ whan þei approchen *and* assenten. þei
hepen *and* encresen þe seruage whiche þei han ioigned
to hem self. and in þis manere þei ben caitifs fro hire
propre libertee. þe whiche þinges napeles þe lokynge
of 4420

þe deuyne purueaunce seep þat alle þinges byholdep
and seep fro eterne. and ordeyneþ hem eueryche in her
merites. as þei ben prodestinat. *and* it is seid in grek.
þat alle þinges he seep *and* alle þinges he hereþ. 4424

4389 *or*—of

incorruptible, and has a
ready and efficacious
power of doing things
which are desired.

[* fol. 34 b.]

The souls of men must
needs be more free when
employed in the
contemplation of the
Divine Mind, and less so
when they enter into a
body, and still less free
when enclosed and
confined in earthly
members; but the most
extreme servitude is
when they are given over
to vice and wholly fallen
from their proper reason.

For at once they are
enveloped by the cloud
of ignorance and are
troubled by pernicious
desires, by yielding to
which they aid and
increase that slavery
which they brought upon
themselves, and thus
even under the liberty
proper to them, they
remain captives.

Yet the eye of
Providence, beholding
all things from eternity,
sees all this and disposes
according to their merit
all things as they are
predestinated.

He, as Homer says of the
sun, *sees and hears all
things*.

4390 *hem*—hym
 4392 *yis*—MS. yif, C. yis
 4392-94 *wille*—wil
 4395 *whiche*—which
 4397 *pilk*—thilke
 4399 [*thilke*]—from C.
 4405 *hap*—MS. haþe
 4411 *last[e]*—laste
 4412 *fro*—from
 4415 *cloude*—clowdes
 4418 *whiche*—which
 4423 *seid*—MS. seide, C. seyd

D'S FOREKNOWLEDGE AND MAN'S FREE WILL.

[PURO CLARUM LUMINE.](#)

[The .2^{de}. Metur.]

HOmer wiþ þe hony mouþe. þat is to seyn. homer
 wiþ þe swete dities syngeþ þat þe sonne is cleer by
 pure lyzt. naþeles 3it ne may it nat by þe inferme lyzt
 of hys bemes breken or *percen* þe inwarde entrailes of
 4428

The sweet-tongued
 Homer sings of the sun's
 pure light. Yet the sun's
 beams cannot pierce into
 the inner bowels of the
 earth, nor into the depths
 of the sea.

þe erþe. or ellys of þe see. ¶ so ne seeþ nat god makere
 of þe grete worlde to hym þat lokeþ alle þinges from
 on
 heye ne wiþstandiþ nat no þinges by heuynesses of erþe.
 ne þe nyzt ne wiþstondeþ nat to hym by þe blake 4432
 cloudes. ¶ þilke god seeþ *in* o strook of þouzt alle
 þinges þat ben or weren or schullen come. ¶ and þilke
 god for he lokeþ *and* seeþ alle þinges al oon. þou maist
 seyn þat he is þe verray sonne. 4436

But God, the world's
 maker, beholding from
 on high, has his vision
 impeded neither by earth
 nor cloud.

At a glance he sees all
 events, present, past, and
 future.

God, then, that alone
 sees all things, may
 indeed be called the true
 Sun.

4425 *mouþe*—Mowth
 4428 *percen*—MS. perten, C. percen
inwarde—inward

4430 *worlde*—world

on heye—an hegh

4431 *nat*—omitted

4434 *schullen come*—shollen comyn

4435 *al oon*—alone

TAMEN EGO EN INQUAM.

PAn seide I now am I confounded by a more harde
doute þan I was. what doute is þat *quod* she.

¶ For certys I coniecte now by whiche þinges þou art
troubled. It semeþ *quod* I to repugnen *and* to
contrarien 4440

gretly þat god knoweþ byforn alle þinges. *and*
þat þer is any fredom of liberte. for yif so be þat god
lokeþ alle þinges byforn. ne god ne may nat ben
desseiuid in no manere. þan mot it nedes ben þat alle
4444

þinges bytyden þe whiche þat þe purueaunce of god haþ
sein byforn to comen. ¶ For whiche yif þat god
knoweþ by-forn nat oonly þe werkes of men. but also
hir conseils *and* hir willes. þan ne shal þer be no 4448
liberte of arbitre. ne certys þer ne may ben noon oþer
dede ne no wille but þilke whiche þe deuyne
purueaunce

þat ne may nat ben desseiued haþ feled byforn ¶ For
yif þat þei myȝten wryþen away in oþer manere þan
þei 4452

ben purueyed. þan ne sholde þer ben no stedfast
prescience

of þinge to comen but raþer an vncerteyn
oppinioun. þe whiche þinge to trowen on god I deme it

[The .3^{de}. prose.]

B. I am distracted by a
more difficult doubt than
ever.

God's foreknowledge
seems to me inconsistent
with man's free-will.

For if God foresees all
things, and cannot be
deceived, then that
which Providence hath
foreseen must needs
happen.

If God from eternity doth
foreknow not only the
works, but the designs
and wills of men, there
can be no liberty of will
—nor can there be any
other action or will than
that which a Divine and
infallible Providence
hath foreseen.

For if things fall out
contrary to such
foreseeing, and are
wrested another way, the
prescience of God in
regard to futurity would
not be sure and unerring
—it would be nothing
but an uncertain opinion
of them: but I take it to
be impious and unlawful
to believe this of God.

felonie *and* vnleueful. ¶ Ne I ne proeue nat þilk 4456
 same resoun. as who seiþ I ne allowe nat. or I ne preise
 nat þilke same resoun by whiche þat som men wenen
 þat þei mowen assoilen *and* vnknyttē þe knot of þis
 questioun. ¶ For certys þei seyn þat þing nis nat to 4460
 come for þat þe purueaunce of god haþ seyn it byforne.
 þat is to comen but raþer þe contrarie. ¶ And þat
 is þis þat for þat þe þing is to comen þat þerfore
 ne may it nat ben hyd fro þe purueaunce of god. 4464
 **and* in þis manere þis necessite slydiþ aȝein in to þe
 contrarie partie. ne it ne byhoueþ [nat] nedes þat
 þinges
 bytiden þat ben ypurueid. [but it by-houeth nedes /
 þat thinges þat ben to comyn ben yporueyid] but as it
 4468
 were ytrauailed. as who seiþ. þat þilke answe
 procediþ
 ryȝt as þouȝ men trauailden or weren bysy to
 enqueren þe whiche þing is cause of whiche þinges. as
 wheþer þe *prescience* is cause of þe necessite of þinges
 to 4472
 comen. or ellys þat þe necessite of þinges to comen is
 cause of þe purueaunce. ¶ But I ne enforce me nat now
 to shewen it þat þe bytydyng of þinges y-wist byforn is
 necessarie. how so or in what manere þat þe ordre of
 4476
 causes haþ it self. al þouȝ þat it ne seme nat þat þe
prescience brynge in necessite of bytydyng of þinges
 to comen. ¶ For certys yif þat any wyȝt sitteþ it
 byhoueþ

Nor do I approve of the reasoning made use of by some. For they say that a thing is not necessarily to happen because God hath foreseen it, but rather because it is to happen it cannot be hid from the divine Providence.

[* fol. 35.]

Now by this reason necessity appears to change sides. For it is not necessary that the things which are foreseen should happen, but it is necessary that the things which are to befall should be foreseen.

As if the question was, which was the cause of the other—*prescience* the cause of the necessity of future events, or the *necessity* the cause of the *prescience* of future events?

But I will prove that, however the order of causes may stand, the event of things foreseen is necessary, although *prescience* doth not seem to impose a necessity upon future things to fall out.

For if a man sit—the belief in the sitting is true; and, on the other hand, if the opinion is

by necessite þat þe oppinioun be soþe of hym 4480
þat coniectiþ þat he sitteþ. and aȝeinward. al so is it of
þe contrarie. yif þe oppinioun be soþe of any wyȝt for
þat he sitteþ it byhoueþ by necessite þat he sitte ¶ þan
is here necessite in þat oon *and* in þat oþer. for in þat
4484

oon is necessite of sittynge. *and* certys in þat oþer is
necessite of soþe but þerfore ne sitteþ nat a wyȝt for
þat
þe oppinioun of sittynge is soþe. but þe oppinioun is
raþer soþe for þat a wyȝt sitteþ by-forn. and þus al 4488
þouȝ þat þe cause of soþe comeþ of [þe] sytting. and
nat of þe trewe oppinioun. Algates ȝitte is þer comune
necessite in þat oon *and* in þat oþer. ¶ þus sheweþ it
þat I may make semblable skills of þe purueaunce of
god 4492

and of þinges to come. ¶ For al þouȝ for þat þat þinges
ben to comen. þerfore ben þei purueid. nat certys for
þei ben purueid. þerfore ne bytide þei nat. ȝit napeles
byhoueþ it by necessite þat eiþer þe þinges to comen
4496

ben ypurueied of god. or ellys þat þe þinges þat ben
purueied of god bitiden [.s.] by necessite. ¶ And þis
þing oonly suffiseþ I-nouȝ to distroien þe fredome of
oure arbitre. þat is to seyn of oure fre wille ¶ But now
4500

[certes] sheweþ it wel how fer fro þe soþe *and* how vp
so doun is þis þing þat we seyn þat þe bytydinge of
temporel þinges is þe cause of þe eterne prescience.
¶ But forto wenen þat god purueiþ [the] þinges to

true of his sitting, he
must needs sit.

In both cases there is a
necessity—in the latter
that the person sits—in
the former, that the
opinion concerning the
other is true.

But the man does not sit
because the opinion of
his sitting is true, but the
opinion is true because
the action of his being
seated was antecedent in
time.

So that although the
cause of truth arises from
the sitting, there is a
common necessity in
both.

Thus may we reason
concerning Providence
and future events.

For allowing things are
foreseen because they
are to happen, and that
they do not befall
because they are
foreseen, it is necessary
that future events should
be foreseen of God, or if
foreseen that they should
happen; and this alone is
sufficient to destroy all
idea of *free-will*.

But it is preposterous to
make the happening of
temporal things the
cause of eternal
prescience, which we do
in imagining that God
foresees future events
because they are to
happen.

comen. 4504

for þei ben to comen. what oper þing is it but forto
wene þat þilke þinges þat bitiden som tyme ben causes
of þilke souereyne purueaunce þat is in god. ¶ And
her-to I adde 3itte þis þing þat ryzt as whan þat I woot
4508

þat o þing is it byhoueþ by necessite þat þilke self þing
be. *and* eke þat whan I haue knowe þat any þinge shal
bitiden so byhoueþ it by necessite þat þilk[e] same
þing bytide. so folweþ it þan þat þe bytydyng of þe
4512

þinge I wist by-forn ne may nat ben eschewed. ¶ And
at þe last[e] yif þat any wyzt wene a þing to ben oper
weyes þan it is. it nys nat oonly vnsience. but it is
deceiuable
oppinioun ful diuerse *and* fer fro þe soþe of 4516
science. ¶ wher-fore yif any þing be so to comen so þat
þe bytydyng of it ne be nat certeyne ne necessarie.
¶ who may weten [byforn] þat þilke þing is to come.

EDOM OF THE HUMAN WILL.

¶ For ryzt as science ne may nat be medelyd wip
falsnesse. 4520

as who seiþ þat yif I woot a þing. it ne may nat
be fals þat I ne woot it. ¶ Ryzt so þilk þing þat
is conceyued by science ne may [nat] ben noon
oper weyes þan [as] it is conceiued. For þat is þe cause
4524

whi þat science wantiþ lesyng. as who seiþ. whi þat
wityng ne receyueþ nat lesyng of þat it woot. ¶ For

And, moreover, when I know that anything exists, it is necessary for my belief that it should be.

So also when I know that an event shall come to pass, it must needs happen.

The event, therefore, of a thing foreseen must befall.

Lastly, if a person judge a thing to be different to what it is—this is not knowledge, but a false opinion of it, and far from the true knowledge.

If, therefore, a thing be so to happen that the event of it is neither necessary nor certain, how can any one foresee what is to happen?

For as pure knowledge has no element in it of falsehood, so what is comprehended by true knowledge cannot be otherwise than as comprehended.

Hence it is that true knowledge cannot err, because everything must precisely be what true knowledge perceives it to be.

it byhoueþ by necessite þat euery þinge [be] ryzt as science

comprehendiþ it to be. what shal I þan sein. ¶ In 4528

whiche manere knoweþ god byforn þe þinges to comen.

¶ yif þei ne be nat certeyne. ¶ For yif þat he deme þat þei ben to comen vneschewably. *and* so may be þat it is possible þat þei ne shullen *nat comen. god is 4532 desseiued. but nat only to trowen þat god is desseiued. but for to speke it wiþ mouþe it is a felonous synne.

¶ But yif þat god woot þat ryzt so as þinges ben to comen. so shulle þei comen. so þat he wit[e] egaly. as 4536

who seiþ indifferently þat þinges mowen ben don or ellys nat don. what is þilke prescience þat ne comprehendip

no certeyne þinge ne stable. or ellys what difference is þer bytwixe þe prescience. *and* þilke iape-worþi 4540 dyuynynge of Tiresie þe diuinour þat seide. ¶ Al þat I seie *quod* he eyþer it shal be. or ellys it ne shal nat be. Or ellis how moche is worþe þe diuynne prescience more þan þe oppinioun of mankynde yif so be þat it 4544 demeþ þe þinges vncerteyne as men don. of þe whiche domes of men þe bytydyngne nis nat certeyne. ¶ But yif so be þat noon vncerteyne þinge may ben in hym þat is ryzt certeyne welle of alle þinges. þan is þe 4548 bytydyngne certeyne of þilke þinges whiche he haþ wist byforn fermely to comen. For whiche it folweþ þat þe fredom of þe conseils *and* of þe werkes of mankynde nis

non syn þat þe pouzt of god seep alle þinges *with* outen

What follows, then?
How does God foreknow these uncertain contingencies?

For if he thinks that a thing will inevitably happen, which possibly may not, he is deceived—but this is sheer blasphemy.
[* fol. 35 b.]

But if God discerns that just as things are to come they shall come; if he knows that they may or may not come, what sort of prescience is this, which comprehends nothing certain, nothing invariable?

Or how does divine prescience differ from human opinion, if He hath an uncertain judgment of things, whereof the events are uncertain and unfixed?

But if there can be no uncertainty in his knowledge, who is the source of all certainty; the event of all things which he foreknows must be fixed and inevitable.

Whence it follows that men have no freedom in their designs and actions; because the Divine Mind, endowed with an infallible foresight,

errour of falsnesse byndeþ *and* constreiniþ hem to a
bitidyng by necessite. and yif [this] þing be on-is
grauntid *and* receyued. þat is to seyn. þat þer nis no
fre wille. þan sheweþ it wel how gret distruccioun *and* 4556
how grete damages þer folwen of þinges of mankynde.

THE UNDER THE CONTROL OF PROVIDENCE.

¶ For in ydel ben þer þan purposed and byhyzt medes
of goode folk. *and* peynes to badde folk. syn þat no
moeuyng of free corage uoluntarie ne haþ nat deserued 4560
hem. þat is to seyn neiþer mede nor payne. ¶ And it
sholde seme þan þat þilke þinge is alþer worste whiche
þat is nowe demed. for alþer moste iuste *and* moste
ryztful. þat is to seyn þat shrewes ben punyssed. or 4564
ellys þat good[e] folk ben ygerdoned. þe whiche folk
syn þat þe propre wille [ne] sent hem nat to þat oon ne
to þat oþer. þat is to seyn. neiþer to good[e] ne to
harme. but constreineþ hem certeyne necessite of
þinges 4568

Rewards and
punishments now
deemed just and
equitable, will be
considered most unjust,
when, it is allowed, that
mankind are not
prompted by any will of
their own, to either
virtue or vice, but in all
their actions are impelled
by a fatal necessity.

to comen. ¶ þanne ne shollen þer neuer ben ne neuer
weren vice ne vertue. but it sholde raþer ben
confusioun
of alle desertes medlid wiþoute discesioun. ¶ And
zitte þer folweþ an oþer inconuenient of þe whiche þer 4572
ne may ben þouzt ne more felonous ne more wikke.
and
þat is þis þat so as þe ordre of þinges is yledd *and*
comeþ of þe purueaunce of god. ne þat no þing nis
leueful to þe conseils of mankynde. as who seiþ þat

Nor would there be such
things as virtue or vice,
but such a medley of the
one and the other as
would be productive of
the greatest confusion.

And from this it will
follow—that since all
order comes of Divine
Providence, and that
there is no freedom of
the human will, that also
our vices must be
referred to the author of

4576

men han no power to done no þing. ne wilne no þing.
þan folweþ it þat oure vices ben refferred to þe mak[er]e
of alle good. as who seiþ þan folweþ it. þat god au3t[e]
han þe blame of oure vices. syn he constreiniþ by 4580
necessite to don vices. þan nis þer no resoun to han
hopen in god. ne forto preien to god. ¶ For what
sholde any wy3t hopen to god. or whi sholde he preien
to god. syn þat þe ordenaunce of destine whiche þat ne
4584

may nat ben enclined. knytteþ *and* streiniþ alle þinges
þat men may desiren. ¶ þan sholde þere be don away
þilke oonly alliaunce bytwixen god *and* men. þat is to
seien to hopen *and* to preien. but by þe preis of
ry3tfulnesse 4588

and of veray mekenesse we deserue þe gerdoun
of þe deuyne grace whiche þat is inestimable. þat is to
sein þat it is so grete þat it ne may nat ben ful ypreised.
and þis is oonly þe manere. þat is to seyen hope *and*
4592

prayeres. for whiche it semeþ þat [men] mowen speken
wiþ god. *and* by resoun of supplicacioun ben conioigned
to þilk clernesse þat nis nat approched no raper or
þat men byseken it *and* emprenten it. And yif men 4596
ne wene [nat] þat [hope] ne preiers ne han no
strengþes.

by þe necessite of þinges to comen y-resceiued. what
þing is þer þan by whiche we mowen be conioygned
and clyuen to þilke souereyne prince of þinges. ¶ For
4600

all good—which is a
most impious opinion.

Then is it useless to hope
for anything from God,
or to pray to him.

For why should men do
either, when all they can
desire is irreversibly
predestined?

Hope and prayer being
thus ineffectual, all
intercourse is cut off
between God and man.

By reverent and humble
supplication we earn
divine grace, a most
inestimable favour, and
are able to associate with
the Deity, and to unite
ourselves to the
inaccessible light.

If men believe that hope
and prayer have no
power because of the
necessity of future
events, by what other
way can we be united,
and hold fast to the
sovereign Lord of all
things?

Wherefore mankind
must be dissevered and
disunited from the

whiche it byhoueþ by necessite þat þe lynage of
mankynde

source of its existence,
and shrink from its
beginning.

as *þou songe a litel here byforne ben departed
and vnioyned from hys welle *and* faylen of hys bygynnyng.
þat is to seien god. 4604

[* fol. 36.]

4437 *harde*—hard

4445 *hap*—MS. haþe

4446 *whiche*—which

4450 *wille*—wil

whiche—which þat

4451 *hap*—MS. haþe

4453 *stedfast*—stydefast

4454-55 *þinge*—thing

4455 *on*—of

4456 *pilk*—thilke

4458 *whiche*—which

4459 *knot*—knotte

4461 *come*—comyn

hap—MS. haþe

4464 *hyd*—MS. hydde, C. hidde

4466 [*nat*]—from C.

4467-8 [*but*—*yporueyid*]—from C.

4471 *þinges*—thing

4477 *hap*—MS. haþe

4480-82 *soþe*—soth

4486 *soþe*—sooth

4487 *soþe*—soth

4488 *soþe*—sooth

4489 *soþe comeþ*—sooth comth

[*þe*]—from C.

4490 *comune*—MS. comme, C. comune

4493 *come*—comyn

4494 *to*—omitted

4494-95 *purueid*—MS. purueide, C. purueyid

4498 [*.s.*]—from C.

4499 *fredome*—freedom

4500 *wille*—wil

4501 [*certes*]*—*from C.
 4504 *purueip**—*MS. *purueipe*
 [*the*]*—*from C.
 4506 *bitiden**—*bytydden
 *som tyme**—*whilom
 4509 *o**—*a
 *self**—*selue
 4510 *pinge**—*thing
 4511 *pilk[e]**—*thilke
 4513 *pinge**—*thing
 4514 *last[e]**—*laste
 4515 *nys**—*is
 4518 *it**—*hit
 4519 [*byforn*]*—*from C.
 4522 *fals**—*false
 4523 [*nat*]*—*from C.
 *ben**—*MS. by, C. ben
 4524 *þan* [*as*] *it is**—*MS. *þan it is be*
 4527 [*be*]*—*from C.
 4529 *whiche**—*which
 4534 *mouþe**—*Mowth
 4536 *shulle**—*shullyn
 *wit[e]**—*wite
 4538 *don**—*MS. done, C. y-doon
 4543 *moche**—*mochel
 *worþe**—*worth
 4549 *hap**—*MS. haþe
 4550 *whiche**—*which
 4551 *mankynde**—*man-kynd
 4554 [*this*]*—*from C.
 4555 *grauntid**—*ygraunted
 4558 *medes of**—*Meedes to
 4560 *hap**—*MS. haþe
 4562 *alþer worsteliche**—*alderworst which
 4563 *nowe**—*MS. newe, C. now
 *alþer moste iuste**—*alder moost Iust
 *moste**—*most
 4565-67 *good[e]**—*goode
 4566 *wille**—*wil
 [*ne*]*—*from C.
 4571 *wipoute**—*with-owten

4573 *pouȝt*—thoght
 4574 *yledd*—MS. yledde, C. yled
 4575 *comeþ*—comth
 4577 *done*—doon
 4578 *mak[er]e*—makere
 4579 *auȝt[e]*—owhte
 4584 *whiche*—which
 4588 *preis*—prys
 ryȝtfulnesse—Rihtwessenesse
 4589 *deserue*—desseruyn
 4590 *deuyne*—MS. deuynes, C. dyuyne
 4590-93 *whiche*—which
 4591 *grete*—gret
 4593 *[men]*—from C.
 speken—speke
 4595 *pilk*—thilke
 4596 *emprenten*—impetrent
 4597 *[nat]*—from C.
 [hope]—from C.
 4601 *whiche*—which
 4602 *byforne*—by-forn

E UNKNOWN CANNOT BE DESIRED.

QUE NAM DISCORS

[The .3^{de}. *Metur*.]

What discordable cause haþ to-rent *and* vnioigned
 þe

Say what discordant
 cause looses the bonds of
 things?

byndyng or þe alliaunce of þinges. þat is to seyne
 þe coniunccioun of god *and* of man. ¶ whiche god
 haþ establissed so grete bataile bitwixen þise two
 soþefast 4608

What power doth make
 these two great truths
 (*i. e.* Providence and
 Free-will) contend,
 which when separate are
 plain and clear, but
 united appear dark and
 perplexed?

or verray þinges. þat is to sein bytwixen þe *purueaunce*
 of god *and* fre wille. þat þei ben synguler *and*
 diuided. ne þat þei ne wolen nat ben medeled ne
 coupled to-gidre. but þer nis no discorde to [tho] verray 4612

þinges. but þei cleuen certeyne al wey to hem self. but
þe þouzt of man confounded *and* ouerþrowen by þe
dirke

The mind of man
encumbered by the
earthly body, can never,
with her cloudy sight,
discover the subtle and
close bonds of things.

membris of þe body ne may nat by fir of his dirk[ed]
lokyng. þat is to seyn by þe vigour of hys insyzt while 4616

þe soule is in þe body knowen þe þinne subtil knyttynges

of þinges. ¶ But wherfore eschaufiþ it so by so
grete loue to fynden þilke note[s] of soþe y-couered.

But why does man burn
with ardour to learn the
hidden notes of truth?

(*glosa*)

þat is to sein wherfore eschaufiþ þe þouzt of man by so 4620

grete desir to knowen þilke notificaciouns þat ben yhidd

vndir þe couertours of soþe. woot it ouzt þilke þinges

þat it anguissous desireþ to knowe. as who seiþ nay.

¶ For no man ne trauaileþ forto witen þinges þat he

Why gropes he for he
knows not what? None
seek to know what is
known.

woot. 4624

and þerfore þe texte seiþ þus. ¶ [*Glosa*] Si enim anima
ignorat istas subtiles connexiones. responde. vnde est
quod desiderat scire cum nil ignotum possit desiderare.

¶ But who traua[i]leþ to wyten þinges y-knowe. and
yif 4628

If he knows them not,
what does he so blindly
seek?

þat he ne knoweþ hem nat. what sekiþ þilke blynde
þouzt. what is he þat desireþ any þinge of whiche he
woot ryzt nat. as who seiþ who so desiriþ any þing
nedis som what he knoweþ of it. or ellys he ne coupe 4632

Who wishes for things
he hath never known?

nat desire it. or who may folwen þinges þat ne ben nat
ywist ¶ and þou3 [þat] he seke þo þinges where shal
he fynden hem. what wyzt þat is al vnknowynge *and*
ignoraunt may knowe þe forme þat is yfounded. ¶ But
4636

Or if he seek, where
shall he find them? Or if
he find, how shall he be
sure that he has found
what he sought for?
The pure soul that sees
the divine thought,
knows all the secret
chains of things.

whan þe soule byholdeþ *and* seeþ þe heye þouzt. þat is

to seyn god. þan knoweþ it to-gidre þe somme *and* þe
singularites. þat is to seyn þe principles *and* eueryche
by hym self. ¶ But now while þe soule is hidd in þe

4640

cloude *and* in þe derknesse of þe membris of þe body.
it ne haþ nat al forȝeten it selfe. but it wiþholdeþ þe
somme of þinges *and* lesiþ þe singularites. þan who so
þat sekeþ soþenesse. he nis in neiþer nouþir habit. for

4644

he not nat alle ne he ne haþ nat alle for-ȝeten. ¶ But
ȝitte hym remembriþ þe somme of þinges þat he
wiþholdeþ
and axeþ counseil *and* tretip depelyche þinges
ysein byforne. [*Glosa*] þat is to sein þe grete somme in

4648

hys mynde. [*textus*] so þat he mowe adden þe parties
þat he haþ forȝeten. to þilke þat he haþ wiþholden.

4605 *haþ*—MS. haþe

4606 *seyne*—seyn

4607 *whiche*—which

4608 *haþ*—MS. haþe

grete—gret

soþefast—soothfast

4610 *wille*—wil

4612 *discorde*—discord

[*tho*]—from C.

4613 *cleuen*—clyuen

4615 *dirked*—derkyd

4616 *while*—whil

4617 *knownen*—knowe

4619-21 *grete*—gret

note[s]—notes

4619 *soþe*—soth

4621 *yhidd*—MS. yhidde, C. Ihyd

Yet, though now hidden in its fleshly members, it hath some remembrance of its pure state—it retains the sums of things, but has lost their particulars.

He who seeks truth is not in either circumstance (*i. e.* seeking for what he knows or knows not), he knoweth not all things, nor hath he wholly forgotten all. But he ponders on what he knows, that he may add those things that he hath forgotten to those that he retains.

4622 *soþe*—sooth
þinges—thing
 4625 [*Glosa*]*—*from C.
 4630 *þinge*—thing
whiche—which
 4631 *woot*—not
nat—nawht
 4632 *couþe*—kowde
 4634 [*þat*]*—*from C.
where—wher
 4635 *what*—MS. *þat*, C. what
vnknowynge—vnkunnynge
 4639 *eueryche*—euerych
 4640 *while*—whil
þe—MS. *þe þe*
hidd—MS. *hidde*, C. *hidde*
 4641 *derknesse*—derkenesse
 4642 *hap*—MS. *haþe*
selfe—self
 4644 *nouþir habit*—nother habite
 4645 *alle (both)*—al
hap—MS. *haþe*
 4648 [*Glosa*]*—*from C.
 4649 [*textus*]*—*from C.
 4650 *hap (both)*—MS. *haþe*

SWERS TO OBJECTIONS AGAINST PROVIDENCE.

TAMEN ILLA UETUS INQUIT HEC EST.

[The 4th prose.]

Panne seide she. þis is *quod* she þe olde questioun
 of
 þe purueaunce of god. *and* marcus tulius whan he 4652
 deuided[e] þe deuinaciouns. þat is to sein in hys booke
 þat he wroot of deuinaciouns. he moeued[e] gretly þis
 questioun. *and* þou þi self hast souzt it mochel *and*
 outerly *and* long[e]. but 3it ne hap it nat ben
 determined 4656

P. This is the old
 objection against
 Providence, so ably
 handled by Cicero in his
Book of Divination; and
 you yourself have
 anxiously discussed it.

But neither of you have
 offered a satisfactory
 solution of the difficulty.

ne yspedd fermely *and* diligently of any of yow.

¶ And þe cause of þis derkenesse *and* [of this] difficulte

is for þat þe moeuyng of þe resoun of mankynde ne may nat moeuen to. þat is to sein applien or ioynen to
4660

þe simplicitie of þe deuyne prescience. ¶ þe whiche symplite of þe deuyne prescience 3if þat men [myhten thinken it in any manere / þat is to seyn / þat yif men] my3te þinken *and* comprehenden þe þinges as god seep hem. 4664

þan ne sholde þer dwellen outerly no doute. þe whiche resoun *and* cause of difficulte I shal assaie at þe laste to shewen *and* to speden. ¶ whan I haue *firste

[yspendyd / *and*] ansewered to þo resouns by whiche þou 4668

art ymoewed. ¶ For I axe whi þou wenest þat þilk[e] resouns of hem þat assoilen þis questioun ne ben nat spedeful ynou3 ne sufficient þe whiche solucioun or þe whiche resoun for þat it demip þat þe prescience nis
nat 4672

cause of necessite to þinges to comen. þan ne wenep it nat þat fredom of wille be distourbed or ylett by prescience.

CESSITY AND PRESCIENCE.

for ne drawest þou nat argumentes from ellys where of þe necessite of þinges to comen. As who seip
4676

any oþer wey þan þus. but þat þilke þinge[s] þat þe prescience

woot byforn [ne] mowen nat vnbitide. þat is to seyn þat þei moten bitide. ¶ But þan yif þat prescience

The cause of this mystery is that the human understanding cannot conceive the simplicity of the divine prescience, for if it were possible to comprehend this, every difficulty would at once disappear.

I shall, therefore, try to explain and solve this difficult question.

[* fol. 36 b.]

I ask, then, why you do not approve the reasoning of such as think—that Prescience does not obstruct the liberty of the will, because it is not the necessitating cause of future events?

Do you draw an argument of the necessity of future events, from any other topic than this,—that those things which are foreknown must of necessity happen?

If divine prescience imposes no necessity upon future things, must

ne putteþ no necessite to þinges to comen. as þou þi
self 4680

not the issue of things be
voluntary, and man's will
free and unconstrained?

hast confessed it *and* byknowen a litel herbyforne. ¶ what
cause [or what] is it. as who seiþ þere may no cause be.
by whiche þat þe endes (exitus) uoluntarie of þinges
myȝten be constreyned to certeyne bitydyng. ¶ For 4684
by grace of possessioun. so þat þou mowe þe better
vndirstonde

For argument sake let us
suppose there is no
prescience, would, then,
the events which proceed
from free-will alone be
under the power of
necessity?

þis þat folweþ. ¶ I pose (impossible) þat
þer ne be no prescience. þan axe I quod she in as
moche as appertenþ to þat. sholde þan þinges þat 4688
comen of frewille ben constreined to bytiden by
necessite. *Boicius*. nay quod I. þan aȝeinward quod
she. I suppose þat þere be prescience but þat ne putteþ
no necessite to þinges. þan trowe I þat þilk self freedom
4692

B. No.

P. Let us, then, admit
Prescience, but that it
imposes no necessity on
what is to happen; the
freedom of the will
would still remain entire
and absolute.

of wille shal dwellen al hool *and* absolut *and*
vnbounden.

but þou wolt sein þat al be it so þat prescience
nis nat cause of þe necessite of bitidyng to þinges to
comen. ¶ Al gates ȝitte it is a signe þat þe þinges ben
4696

But although Prescience,
you may say, is not the
necessary cause of future
events, yet it is a sign
that they shall
necessarily happen, and
hence it follows that,
although there were no
prescience, future events
would still be an
inevitable necessity.

to bytiden by necessite. by þis manere þan al þouȝ þe
prescience ne hadde neuer yben. ȝit algate or at þe
lest[e] wey. it is certeyne þing þat þe endys *and* þe
bitydynges of þinges to comen sholde ben necessarie. 4700

¶ For euery sygne sheweþ *and* signifieþ oonly what þe
þing is ¶ but it ne makþ nat þe þing þat it signifieþ.

For the sign of a thing is
not really the thing itself,
but only points out what
the individual is.
Wherefore, it must be
first proved that
everything happens by
necessity before we can

¶ For whiche it byhoueþ firste to shewen þat no þing
ne bitidiþ [þat it ne bytydith] by necessite. so þat it 4704

may apere þat þe prescience is signe of þis necessite
¶ or ellys yif þere nere no necessite. certys þilke
prescience
ne myȝt[e] nat ben signe of þinge þat nis nat.

conclude that prescience
is a sign of that
necessity.

For if there be no
necessity, prescience
cannot be the sign of that
which has no existence.

T ALL THINGS CONTROLLED BY NECESSITY.

¶ But certys it is nowe certeyne þat þe preue of þis 4708
sustenip by stedfast resoun ne shal nat ben ladd ne
proued by signes ne by argumentys ytaken fro wiþ
oute.

The assertion that
nothing happens but by
necessity, must be
proved by arguments
drawn from causes
connected and agreeing
with this necessity, and
not from signs or foreign
causes.

but by causes couenable *and* necessarie ¶ But þou
mayst sein how may it be þat þe þinges ne bitiden nat
4712

þat ben ypurueyed to comen. but certys ryȝt as we
trowen þat þo þinges whiche þat þe purueaunce woot byforn
to comen. ne ben nat to bitiden. but [þat] ne sholde
we nat demen. but raþer al þouȝ [þat] þei schal bitiden. 4716
ȝit ne haue þei no necessite of hire kynde to bitiden.
and þis maist þou lyȝtly aperceyuen by þis þat I shal
seyn. but we seen many þinges whan þei ben don
byforn

We see many things
when they are done
before our eyes; such as
a charioteer driving his
chariot, and other things
of like nature.

oure eyen ryȝt as men seen þe karter worken in þe 4720
tourneyng *and* in attempryng or in adressyng of hys
kartes or chariottes. ¶ *and* by þis manere as who seiþ
mayst þou vnderstonde of alle manere opir werkemen.
¶ Is þere þanne any necessite as who seiþ in oure
lokyng 4724

Now, is there any
necessity which compels
these things to be done?

[þat] constreineþ or compelliþ any of þilke þinges
to ben don so. b. nay *quod* I ¶ For in ydel *and* in
veyne were alle þe effect of crafte yif þat alle þinges

B. No. For if all things
were moved by
compulsion—the efforts

weren moeued by constreynynge. þat is to seyn by
constreynynge 4728

of oure eyen or of oure syzt. *P.* þise þingus
þan quod she þat whan men don hem ne han non
necessite þat men don hem. eke þo same þinges first or
þei be don. þei ben to comen wiþ out necessite. for whi
4732

þer ben somme þinges to bytide of whiche þe endys
and þe bitidynges of hem ben absolut **and* quit of alle
necessite. for certys I ne trowe nat þat any man wolde
seyn

þis. þat þo þinges þat men don now þat þei ne weren
4736

to bitiden. first or þei were ydon ¶ and þilk same
þinges al þou3 þat men hadden ywyst hem by-forn.
3itte þei han fre bitidynges. for ryzt as science of
þinges present ne bryngeþ in no necessite to þinges
4740

[þat men doon // Ryht so the prescience of thinges to
comen ne bryngeth in no necessite to thinges] to bytiden
but þou mayst seyn þat of þilke same it is ydouted. as
wheþer þat of þilke þinges þat ne han non endes *and*
4744

bytidynges necessaryes yif þer-of may ben any
prescience

E NATURE OF TRUE KNOWLEDGE.

¶ For certys þei seme to discorde. for þou
wenest þat yif þat þinges ben yseyn byforn þat
necessite

of art would be vain and
fruitless.

P. The things, then,
which are done are under
no necessity that they
should be done; then first
before they were done,
they were under no
necessity of coming to
pass; wherefore some
things happen, the event
of which is
unconstrained by
necessity.

[* fol. 37.]

These things therefore,
although foreknown,
have free events: for as
the knowledge of present
things imposes no
necessity upon things
which are now done, so
neither does the
foreknowledge of
futurities necessitate the
things which are to
come.

But you may doubt
whether there can be any
certain prescience of
things, of which the
event is not necessitated:
for here there seems to
be an evident
contradiction.

If things are foreknown,
you may contend they
must necessarily happen;
and if their event is not
necessary, they cannot be
foreseen, because true

folweþ hem. and yif (*et putas*) necessite faileþ hem þei
ne 4748

myȝten nat ben wist byforn. *and* þat no þinge ne may
ben comprehendid by science but certeyne. *and* yif þo
þinges þat ne han no certeyne bytidynges ben
ypurueied

as certeyn. it sholde ben dirkenesse of oppinioun nat

4752

soþefastnesse of science [*and* þou weenyst þat it be
diuerse

fro the hoolnesse of science / þat any man sholde deme
a thing to ben oother weys thanne it is it self]. and þe
cause of þis errour is. þat of alle þe þinges þat euery

4756

wyȝt haþ yknowe. þei wenen þat þo þinges ben y-
knowe

al oonly by þe strengþe *and* by þe nature of þe þinges
þat ben ywyst or yknowe. *and* it is al þe contrarie. for
alle þat euere is yknowe. it is raper comprehendid *and*

4760

yknowen nat after his strengþe *and* hys nature. but
after

þe faculte þat is to seyn þe power *and* [the] nature of
hem þat knowen. *and* for þat þis shal mowe shewen by
a short ensample þe same roundenes of a body .O. oþer

4764

weyes þe syȝt of þe eye knoweþ it. *and* oþer weyes þe
touching. þe lokynge by castynge of his bemes waiteþ
and seeþ fro afer alle þe body to-gider wiþ oute
mouynge

knowledge can
comprehend nothing but
what is absolutely
certain.

And if things uncertain
in their events are
foreseen as certain, this
knowledge is nothing
more than a false
opinion.

For it is very remote
from true knowledge to
judge of things otherwise
than they really are.

The cause of this error is
that men imagine that
their knowledge is
wholly derived from the
nature of the things
known, whereas it is
quite the reverse.

Things are not known
from their inherent
properties, but by the
faculties of the observer.

The roundness of a body
affects the sight in one
way, and the touch in
another.

The eye, from afar, darts
its rays upon the object,
and by beholding it
comprehends its form.

of it self. but þe touchinge cliuiþ *and* conioigneþ to þe

4768

rounde body (orbi) *and* moueþ abouten þe

environynge.

and comprehendþ by parties þe roundenesse.

But the object is not distinguished by the touch unless the hand comes in contact with it and feels it all round.

USE, REASON, AND INTELLIGENCE.

¶ and þe man hym self oþer weies wyt byholdþ hym.

and

oþerweyes ymaginacioun *and* oþer weyes resoun. *and*

4772

oþer weyes intelligence. ¶ For þe wit comprehendþ

fro wiþ outen furþe þe figure of þe body of þe man. þat

is establissed in þe matere subiect. But þe

ymaginacioun

[comprehendith only the figure *with* owte the matere / 4776

Resoun surmounteth ymaginacioun] *and*

comprehendeþ

by an vniuersel lokynge þe *commune* spece (*speciem*)

þat is in þe singuler peces. ¶ But þe eye of intelligence

is heyzer for it *sourmounteth* þe *envirounynge* of þe

4780

vniuersite *and* lookeþ ouer þat by pure subtilite of

þouȝt.

þilk same symple forme of man þat is *perdurably* in þe

deuyne þouȝt. in whiche þis auȝt[e] gretely to ben

considered

þat þe heyest strengþe to comprehendē þinges 4784

enbraceþ *and* conteyneþ þe lower[e] strengþe [but the

lowere strengthe ne arysith nat in no manere to heyere

Man himself is surveyed in divers ways—by the senses, by the imagination, by reason, and by the intelligence (of the Deity).

The senses take note of his material figure—the imagination considers the form alone, exclusive of the matter.

Reason transcends the imaginations, and examining existences in general discovers the particular species, but the eye of Intelligence soars still higher; for, going beyond the bounds of what is general, it surveys the *simple forms* themselves, by its own pure and subtle thought:

in which this is chiefly to be considered, that the higher power of perception embraces the lower; but the inferior cannot attain to the energy of the superior:

strengthe]. for wit ne may no þinge comprehende oute of

matere. ne þe ymagynacioun ne lokeþ nat þe vniuerseles 4788

speces. ne resoun ne takeþ nat þe symple forme. so as intelligence takeþ it. but þe intelligence þat lokeþ al abouen whan it haþ comprehendid þe forme it knoweþ *and* demeþ alle þe þinges þat ben vndir þat forme. but 4792

she knoweþ hem vndir þilke manere in þe whiche it comprehendip þilke same symple forme þat ne may neuer be knownen to non of þat oper. þat is to seyn to non of þo þre forseide strengþes of þe soule. for it 4796 knoweþ þe vniuersite of resoun *and* þe figure of þe ymaginacioun.

and þe sensible material conseiued. *and* þou wenest þat it be diuerse fro þe hoolnesse of science. þat

any man sholde deme a þing to ben operweyes þan it is 4800 it self *and* þe cause of þis errour etc'. vt supra. by wit. ne it ne vseþ nat nor of resoun ne of ymaginacioun ne of wit wiþ oute forþe but it byholdeþ alle þinges so as I shal seye. by a strok of þouzt formely wiþ oute discours 4804

or collacioun ¶ Certys resoun whan it lokeþ any þing vniuersel it ne vseþ nat of ymaginacioun nor of wit *and* algates 3it [it] comprendip þe þinges ymaginable *and* sensible. for resoun is she þat *diffinisseþ þe vniuersel 4808

of hir conseite ryzt þus. ¶ Man is a resonable t[w]o-

for the senses cannot go beyond the perception of matter; the imagination cannot comprehend existences in general, nor can the reason conceive the simple form.

But the Intelligence looking down (as from above) and having conceived the form, discerns all things that are below it, and comprehends what does not fall within the reach of the other faculties of the mind.

Without the aid of those faculties Intelligence comprehends things *formally* (i. e. by beholding their simple forms) by one effort of mind.

Reason, without the aid of Imagination and Sense, in considering things in general, comprehends all imaginable and sensible things.

For instance, reason defines her general conceptions thus:—

[* fol. 37 b.]

footid

beest. and how so þat þis knowynge [is] vniuersel.
3it nys þer no wyȝt þat ne woot wel. þat a man is [a
thing]

ymaginable *and* sensible ¶ and þis same considereþ
wel 4812

resoun. but þat nis nat by ymaginacioun. nor by witte.
but it lokip it by [a] resonable concepcioun.

¶ Also ymaginacioun

al be it so. þat it takeþ of wit þe bygynyngus
to seen *and* to formen þe figures. algates al þouȝ þat
wit 4816

ne ware not *present*. 3it it envirounip *and*
comprehendip

alle þinges sensible. nat by resoun sensible of
demynge.

but by resoun ymaginatif. ¶ sest þou nat þan þat alle
þe þinges in knowynge vsen more of hir faculte or of
hir 4820

power. þan þei don of [the] faculte or of power of
þinges

þat ben yknowen. ne þat nis no wronge. for so as euery
iugement is þe dede or þe doynge of hym þat demeþ. It
byhoueþ þat euery wyȝt performe þe werke *and* hys
entencioun 4824

nat of forein power ; but of hys propre power.

Man is a rational two-footed animal, which, though it be a general idea, yet every one knows that man thus defined is perceived both by the imagination and the senses, notwithstanding that in this instance reason does not make use of imagination or the senses, but of her own rational conception. The imagination also, although it derives its power of seeing and forming figures from the senses, yet in the absence and without the use of the senses it considers and comprehends all sensible things by its own imaginative power.

Do not you see that men attain to the knowledge of things more by their own faculties, than by the inherent property of things?

Nor is it unreasonable that it should be so—for since every judgment is the act of the person judging; every one must needs do his own work by the help of his own faculties, and not by the aid of foreign power.

4653 *deuided*[e]—deuynede
 booke—book
 4654 *moeued*[e]—moeuede
 4655 *souȝt*—I-sowht
 4656 *long*[e]—longe
 hap—MS. haȝe
 4657 *yspedd*—MS. yspedde, C. Isped
 firmely—MS. feruently, C. fermely
 4658 *derkenesse*—dirknesse
 [*of this*]—from C.
 4662-3 [*myhten*—*men*]—from C.
 4663 *myȝte*—myhten
 4667 *firste*—fyrst
 4668 [*yspendyd and*]—from C.
 þo—the
 whiche—which
 4669 *art*—MS. arte
 þilk[e]—thilke
 4671 *spedeful*—spedful
 4672 *whiche*—which
 4674 *wille*—wyl
 4677 *þinge*[s]—thinges
 4683 *whiche*—which
 4685 *better*—betere
 4688 *moche*—mochel
 4689 *frewille*—free wyl
 4691 *þat ne*—þat is ne
 4692 *þat*—MS. þan
 þilk self—thilke selue
 4693 *wille*—wil
 4699 *lest*[e]—leeste
 4700 *sholde*—sholden
 4703 *whiche*—which
 firste—fyrst
 4704 [*þat*—*bytydith*]—from C.

4707 *myȝt[e]*—myhte
þinge—thing
 4708 *nowe*—now
 4709 *sustenip*—ysustenyd
stedfast—stydefast
ladd—MS. ladde, C. lad
 4714 *whiche*—which
 4715 [*þat*]—from C.
sholde—sholden
 4716 *demen*—MS. denyen
 [*þat*]—from C.
 4717 *necessite*—MS. necessites
 4721 *hys*—hise
 4725 [*þat*]—from C.
 4727 *veyne*—veyn
alle—al
craft—craft
 4729 *þise*—MS. þise þise, C. the
 4732 *wip out*—with-owte
 4733 *bytide*—bytyden
whiche—which
 4737 *were*—weeren
ydon—MS. ydone, C. I-doon
þilk—thilke
 4741-2 [*þat*—*thinges*]—from C.
 4744 *endes*—issues
 4746 *seme*—semyn
discorde—discorden
 4749 *þat*—yif
 4753-5 [*and*—*self*]—from C.
 4757 *hap*—MS. haþe
 4760 *alle*—al
 4763 *mowe*—mowen
 4764 *roundenes*—Rowndnesse
 4765 *syȝt*—sihte
 4767 *alle*—al
 4769 *abouten*—abowte
 4770 *roundenesse*—Rowndnesse
 4774 *fro wip outhen furþe*—with owte forth
 4776-7 [*comprehendith*—*ymaginacioun*]—from C.
 4777 *comprehendþ*—MS. comprehendynge

4778 *an*—omitted
 4780 *heyzer*—heyere
 4783 *whiche*—which
 au3t[e]—owhte
 4784 *heyest*—heyiste
 4785 *lower[e]*—lowere
 4785-7 [*but*—*strengthe*]*—*from C.
 4787 *wit*—witte
 oute—owt
 4791 *hap*—MS. haþe
 4793 *whiche*—which
 4795-6 *non*—none
 4796 *strengþes*—thinges
 4798-4801 *and þou*—*vt supra*—omitted
 4805 *collacioun*—MS. callacioun, C. collacioun
 4806 *wit*—witte
 4810 [*is*]*—*from C.
 4813 *witte*—wit
 4821 *don*—MS. done, C. doon
 [*the*]*—*from C.
 4822 *yknowen*—Iknowe]
 no wronge—nat wrong
 4824 *werke*—werk
 4825 *forein*—foreyne

W OUR KNOWLEDGE OF OUTWARD THINGS IS GAINED.

QUONDAM PORTICUS ATTULIT.

[The 4th Metur.]

ÞE porche þat is to sein a gate of þe toune of athenis
 þer as philosophres hadde hir congregacioun to
 dispoyten.

Fallacious and obscure
 was the lore of the
 Stoics,

and þilke porche brou3t[e] somtyme olde men ful 4828
 derke in hire sentences. þat is to sein philosophers þat
 hy3ten stoiciens. þat wenden þat ymages [*and*]
 sensibilibites

who taught that images
 of things obvious to the
 senses were imprinted on
 the mind by external
 objects, and that the soul
 is at first like a mirror or

þat is to sein sensible ymaginaciouns. or ellys

ymaginacioun

a clean parchment, free
from figures and letters.

of sensible þinges weren *inprentid* in to soules 4832
fro bodies wiþ oute forþe. ¶ As who seiþ þat þilke
stoiciens wenden þat þe soule hadde ben naked of it
self. as a mirour or a clene *parchemyn*. so þat alle
fygures mosten [fyrst] comen fro þinges fro wiþ oute in to 4836
soules. *and* ben *inprentid* in to soules. *Textus*. Ryȝt
as we ben wont some tyme by a swift poyntel to ficchen
lettres *emprentid* in þe smopenesse or in þe plainesse of
þe table of wex. or in *parchemyn* þat ne haþ no figure 4840
[ne] note in it. *Glosa*. But now arguiþ boece aȝeins þat
oppinioun *and* seiþ þus. but yif þe þriuȝng soule ne
vnplitiþ no þing. þat is to sein ne doþ no þing by hys
propre moeuȝnges. but suffriþ *and* lieþ subgit to þe
4844

But if the mind is
passive in receiving the
impressions of outward
objects, whence
proceeds the knowledge
by which the mind
comprehends all things?

figures *and* to þe notes of bodyes wiþ oute forþe. *and*
ȝeldeþ ymages ydel *and* veyne in þe manere of a
mirour. whennes þriuēþ þan or whennes comeþ þan
þilke knowȝng in oure soule. þat discerniþ *and* byholdeþ 4848
alle þinges. *and* whennes is þilke strengþe þat
byholdeþ þe syngulere þinges. or whennes is þe
strengþe
þat dyuydeþ þinges yknowe. *and* þilke strengþe þat
gadereþ to-gidre þe þinges deuided. *and* þe strengþe
þat 4852

Whence its force to
conceive individual
existences, to separate
those things when
known, to unite divided
things, and to choose and
change its path, soaring
to the highest and
descending to the lowest
things—and returning to
itself, to confute false
things by the true?

cheseþ hys entrechaunged wey for som tyme it heueþ
vp þe heued. þat is to sein þat it heueþ vp þe
entencioun

to ryȝt heye þinges. *and* som tyme it discendiþ in
to ryȝt lowe þinges. *and* whan it retourniþ in to hym 4856

self. it repreuip *and* destroieþ þe false þinges by þe
trewe þinges. ¶ Certys þis strengþe is cause more
efficient *and* mochel more myȝty to seen *and* to knowe
þinges. þan þilke cause þat suffriþ and resceyueþ þe
4860

notes *and* þe figures inpressed in manere of matere
algates

þe passioun þat is to seyn þe suffraunce or þe wit
in þe quik[e] body goþ byforne excitynge *and*
moeuyng

þe strengþes of þe þouȝte. ryȝt so as whan þat 4864
clerenesse smyteþ þe eyen *and* moeuip hem to seen. or
ryȝt so as voys or sounne hurtliþ to þe eres *and* commoeuip
hem to herkne. þan is þe strengþe of þe þouȝt
ymoeuid *and* excitid *and* clepeþ furþe þe semblable
4868

moeuynges þe speces þat it halt wiþ inne it self. *and*
addiþ þo speces to þe notes *and* to þe þinges wiþ out
forþe. *and* medeleþ þe ymages of þinges wiþ out forþe
to þe forme[s] yhid wiþ inne hym self. 4872

This cause is more
efficacious and powerful
to see and to know
things, than that cause
which receives the
characters impressed like
servile matter.

Yet the sense in the
living body excites and
moves the mental
powers; as when the
light striking the eyes
causes them to see, or as
the voice rushing into the
ear excites hearing.

Then is the force of
thought excited; it calls
forth the images within
itself, and adds to them
the outward forms,
blending external images
with the counterparts
concealed within.

4827 *hadde*—hadden

dispoiten—desputen

4828 *brouȝt[e]*—browhte

4830 [*and*]—from C.

4837 *inprentid*—aprentyd

4838 *some tyme*—somytyme

swift—swyfte

4840 *hap*—MS. haþe

4843 *vnplitiþ*—vnpleyteth

dop—MS. doþe

4845 *þe*—tho

4863 *quik[e]*—qwyke

gop—MS. goþe

4864 *pouzte*—thought
4865 *clerenesse*—cleernesne
4866 *soune*—sown
4868 *furpe*—forth
4870 *out*—owte
4871 *out forpe*—owte forth
4872 *forme[s]*—formes
yhid—I-hidde

WISDOM A DIVINE ATTRIBUTE.

QUOD SI IN CORPORIBUS SENCIENTIS.

*QUESTIO.

[The .5.th prose.]

[* fol. 38.]

But what [yif] þat in bodies to ben feelid þat is
to sein in þe takynge of knowelechinge of bodyly
þinges. and al be it so þat þe qualites of bodies þat ben
object fro wiþ oute forþe moeuen *and* entalenten þe
instrumentes 4876
of þe wittes. and al be it so þat þe passioun
of þe body þat is to seyn þe witte [or the] suffraunce
[goth to-forn the strengthe of the workynge corage /
the
which passioun or suffraunce] clepiþ furþe þe dede of
4880
þe pouzt in hym self. *and* moeueþ *and* exiteþ in þis
mene while þe formes þat resten wiþ in forþe. and yif
þat in sensible bodies as I haue seid oure corage nis nat
ytauzt or enprentid by passioun to knowe þise þinges. 4884
but demip *and* knowep of hys owen strengþe þe passioun
or suffraunce subiect to þe body. Moche more þan þoo
þinges þat ben absolut *and* quit fram alle talentz or
affecciouns of bodies. as god or hys aungels ne folwen

Although there are in
objects certain qualities
which strike externally
upon the senses, and put
their instruments in
motion; although the
passive impression upon
the body precedes the
action of the mind,

and although the former
rouses the latter to
action, yet if in the
perception of bodily
things, the soul is not by
the impression of
external things made to
know these things, but
by its own power judgeth
of these bodily
impressions,

how much more shall
those pure spiritual
beings (as God or
angels) discern things by
an act of their

4888

nat in discernynge þinges object from wiþ oute forþe.
but þei accomplissen *and* speden þe dede of hir þouȝt
by þis resoun.

¶ þan þere comen many manere knowynges
to dyuerse *and* differyng substaunces. for þe wit 4892
of þe body þe whiche witte is naked *and* despoyled of
alle oþer knowynges. þilke witte comeþ to bestes þat
ne

mowen nat moeuen hem self here ne þere. as oystres
and muscles *and* oþer swiche shelle fyssh of þe see. 4896
þat cliuen *and* ben norissed to roches. but þe
ymaginacioun

comeþ to remuable bestes þat semen to han talent
to fleen or to desiren any þinge. but resoun is al only to
þe lynage of mankynde ryȝt as intelligence is oonly þe
4900

deuyne nature. of whiche it folweþ þat þilke knowyng
is more worþe þan [th]is[e] oþer. syn it knoweþ by hys
propre nature nat only hys subiect. as who seiþ it ne
knoweþ nat al oonly þat apperteiniþ proprely to hys
4904

knowynge. but it knoweþ þe subgitȝ of alle oþer knowynges.

E POWERS OF SENSE AND IMAGINATION.

but how shal it þan be yif þat wit *and* ymaginacioun
stryuen aȝeins resonyng *and* sein þat of þilke
vniuersel þinges. þat resoun wenep to seen þat it nis
4908

ryȝt nauȝt. for wit *and* ymaginacioun seyn þat þat. þat

understanding alone,
without the aid of
impressions from
external objects?

For this reason, then,
there are several sorts of
knowing distributed
among various beings.

For sense (or sensation)
destitute of all other
knowledge is allotted to
those creatures that have
no motion, as shell-fish.

But imagination is given
to such brutes capable of
motion, and having in
some degree the power
of desiring or refusing.
Reason, however, is the
attribute of man alone, as
Intelligence is that of
God.

Hence His (i. e. God's)
knowledge exceeds all
other, comprehending
both what belongs to His
own nature, and what is
comprehended by all
inferior creatures.

But how shall it be then,
if sense and imagination
oppose reason, affirming
that the general idea of
things, which reason
thinks it so perfectly
sees, is nothing?

is sensible or ymaginable it ne may nat ben vniuersel.
þan is eiþer þe iugement of resoun [soth]. ne þat
þer nis no þinge sensible. or ellys for þat resoun woot

4912

wel þat many þinges ben subiect to wit *and* to ymaginacioun.

þan is þe consepçioun of resoun veyn *and* fals
whiche þat lookeþ *and* comprehendþ. þat þat is
sensible *and* synguler as uniuersele. and 3if þat resoun

4916

wolde answeren azein to þise two þat is to sein to wit
and to ymaginacioun. *and* sein þat sobely she hir self.
þat is to seyn þat resoun lokeþ *and* comprehendþ by
resoun of vniuersalite. boþe þat þat is sensible *and* þat

4920

þat is ymaginable. *and* þat þilke two þat is to seyn wit
and ymaginacioun ne mowen nat stretchen ne
enhaunsen

hem self to knowynge of vniuersalite for þat
þe knowyng of hem ne may exceden nor sourmounten

4924

þe bodyly figure[s] ¶ Certys of þe knowyng of þinges
men au3ten raþer 3eue credence to þe more stedfast *and*
to þe more perfit iugement. In þis manere stryuyng
þan we þat han strengþe of resonyng *and* of
ymaginyng 4928

and of wit þat is to seyn by resoun *and* by
ymaginacioun

and by wit. [*and*] we sholde raþer preise þe cause
of resoun. as who seiþ þan þe cause of wit or ymaginacioun.

For what falls under the
cognisance of the senses
and imagination cannot
be general.

But if reason should
answer to this—that in
her idea of what is
general she comprehends
whatever is sensible and
imaginable; but as to the
senses and imagination,
they cannot attain to the
knowledge of what is
general, since their
knowledge is confined to
material figures; and
therefore in all real
knowledge of things we
must give the greatest
credit to that faculty
which has a more
steadfast and perfect
judgment of things.

In a controversy of this
kind ought not we, who
possess faculties of
reason, &c., to side with
reason and espouse her
cause?

ASON SHOULD SUBMIT TO INTELLIGENCE.

semblable þinge is it þat þe resoun of mankynde 4932
ne weneþ nat þat þe deuyne intelligence byholdeþ or
knoweþ þinges to comen. but ryzt as þe resoun of
mankynde
knoweþ hem. for þou arguist *and* seist þus.

þat yif it ne seme nat to men þat somme þinges han
certeyne 4936
and necessarie bytydnynges. þei ne mowen nat ben wist
byforn certeynely to bytiden. þan nis [ther] no
prescience

of þilke þinges. *and* yif we trowen þat prescience
ben in þise þinges. þan is þer no þinge þat it ne 4940
bitidyþ by necessite. but certys yif we myzten han þe
iugement of þe deuyne þouzt as we *ben parsoners of
resoun. ryzt so as we han demed. it byhoueþ þat
ymaginacioun

and wit ben byneþe resoun. ryzt so wolde 4944
we demen þat it were ryztful þing þat mans resoun
auzt[e] to summitten it self *and* to ben byneþe þe deuyne
þouzt. for whiche þat yif we mowen. as who seip.
þat yif þat we mowen I conseil[e] þat we enhanse vs in
4948

to þe heyzt of þilke souereyne intelligence. for þere
shal
resoun wel seen þat þat it ne may nat by-holden in it
self. and certys þat is þis in what manere þe prescience
of god seep alle þinges certeins *and* difinissed al þou3
þei 4952
ne han no certein issues or by-tydnynges. ne þis is non

The case is entirely similar when human reason thinks the Divine Intelligence cannot behold future events in any other way than she herself is capable of perceiving them.

For thus you argue:—
What things are not necessitated cannot be foreknown; therefore there is no prescience of these things, for, if there were, everything would be fixed by an absolute necessity.

If it were possible to enjoy the intelligence of the Deity, we should then deem it right that sense and imagination should yield to reason, and also judge it proper that human reason should submit to the Divine Intelligence.

[* fol. 38 b.]

Let us, therefore, strive to elevate ourselves to the height of the supreme intelligence—there shall reason see what she cannot discover in herself; and that is in what manner the prescience of God sees and defines all things; although they have no certain event; and she will see that this is no mere conjecture, but rather simple, supreme, and unlimited knowledge.

oppinioun but it is rap̃er þe simplicit̃e of þe souereyn
science þat nis nat enclosed nor yshet wiþinne no boundes.

4873 [yif]—from C.

4878 [or the]—from C.

suffraunce—MS. *suffisaunce*, C. *suffraunce*

4879-80 [goth—*suffraunce*]—from C.

4883 *seid*—MS. *seide*, C. *seyd*

4887 *quit*—quite

4888 *hys*—hise

4889 *discernynge*—MS. *discryuyng*, C. *discernynge*
from—fro

4893-94 *witte*—wit

4895 *mowen*—mowe

here ne þere—her *and* ther

4901 *whiche*—which

4902 [th]is[e] *oþer*—thise oothre

4907 *aþeins*—ayein

4908 *vniuersel*—vniuersels

4911 [soth]—from C.

4914 *falsliche*—false which

4917 *wit*—witte

4918 *sopely*—soothly

4923 *knowynge*—knowy

4926 *þeue*—yeuen

stedfast—stidefast

4930 [and]—from C.

4931 *or*—*and* of

4938 [ther]—from C.

4939 *trowen*—trowe

4942 *parsoners*—parsoneres

4945 *mans*—mannes

4946 *auzt[e]*—owte

4947 *whiche*—which

4948 *þat yif*—yif þat

4949 *heyzt*—heihte

þere—ther

4952 *þouȝ*—MS. *þouȝt*

4955 *no*—none

QUAM UARIIS FIGURIS.

[The 5th Metur.]

PE bestes passen by þe erþes by ful dyuerse figures
4956

Various are the shapes of
created beings. Some
creep along the ground
and trace the dust in
furrows as they go;

for *somme* of hem han hir bodies strauȝt *and*
crepen in þe dust *and* drawen after hem a *trais* or a
forghe contynued. þat is to sein as addres or snakes.
and oþer bestes by [the] wandryng lyȝtnesse of hir 4960
wenges beten þe wyndes *and* ouer-swymmen þe
spaces

others with nimble wings
float through the air;

of þe longe eyer by moist flee[y]nge. and oþer bestes
gladen hem to diggen her traas or her stappes in þe
erþe wiþ hir goynge or wiþ her feet. or to gone eyþe[r]
4964

some with their feet
impress the ground, or
tread lightly o'er the
meads, or seek the shady
grove.

by þe grene feldes or [elles] to walken vnder þe wodes.
and al be it so þat þou seest þat þei alle discorden by
dyuerse formes. algate hire [faces] enclini[n]g heuieþ
hire
dulle wittes. Onlyche þe lynage of man heueþ heyest
hys 4968

Though we see an
endless variety of forms,
yet all are prone; to the
earth they bend their
looks, increasing the
heaviness of their dull
sense.

heyȝe heued *and* stondeþ lyȝt wiþ hys vpryȝt body *and*
byholdeþ þe erþe vndir hym. [and] but-ȝif þou erþely
man

Man alone doth raise
aloft his noble head;
light and erect he spurns
the earth.

wexest yuel oute of þi witte. þis figure amonesteþ þe
þat
axest þe heuene wiþ þi ryȝt[e] visage. *and* hast areised
4972

Thou art admonished by
this figure then, unless
by sense deceived, that
whilst taught by thy lofty
mien to look above, thou
shouldst elevate thy
mind lest it sink below
its proper level.

þi forhede to beren vp on heye þi corage so þat þi þouȝt
ne be nat yheuied ne put lowe vndir foot. sen þat þi
body is so heye areised.

4959 *forghē contynued*—forwh Ikonntynued
addres—nadris
 4960 [*the*]—from C.
 4963 *hem*—hem self
stappes—steppis
 4964 *or to gone*—*and to gon*
eyþe[r]—eyther
 4965 [*elles*]—from C.
 4967 [*faces*]—from C.
algate—algates
enclini[n]g—enclynynd
 4968 *Onlyche*—Oonly
heyste—heyste
 4970 *erþe*—erthes
 4971 *oute*—owt
witte—wit
 4972 *ryȝt[e]*—ryhte
hast—MS. haþe, C. hast
 4973 *forhede*—foreheuyd
on heye—a heygh
 4974 *foot sen*—foote syn

FINITION OF ETERNITY.

PROSA VLTIMA.

[QUONIAM IGITUR UTI PAULO ANTE.](#)

PEr-fore þan as I haue shewed a litel her byforne þat
 4976
 al þinge þat is ywist nis nat knowen by hys nature
propre. but by þe nature of hem þat *comprehenden* it.
 ¶ Lat vs loke now in as moche as it is leueful to vs. as
 who seiþ lat vs loken now as we mowen whiche þat þe
 4980
 estat is of þe deuyne substaunce so þat we mowen [ek]
 knowen what his science is. þe comune iugement of
 alle

[The 6^{te} prose *and* the
 laste.]

Since everything which
 is known is not, as I have
 shown, perceived by its
 own inherent properties,
 but by the faculties of
 those comprehending
 them, let us now
 examine the disposition
 of the Divine nature.

All rational creatures
 agree in affirming that
 God is eternal.

creatures resonables þan is þis þat god is eterne. lat vs
considere þan what is eternite. For certys þat shal 4984
shewen vs to-gidre þe deuyne nature *and* þe deuyne
science ¶ Eternite þan is perfit possessioun *and* al
togidre of lijf interminable *and* þat sheweþ more
clerely

by þe comparisoun or collacioun of temporel þinges.
for 4988

al þing þat lyueþ in tyme it is present *and* procediþ fro
preterit3 in to futures. þat is to sein. fro tyme passed
in to tyme comynge. ne þer nis no þing establissed in
tyme þat may enbracen to-gidre al þe space of hys lijf.
4992

E WORLD IS NOT ETERNAL.

for certys 3it ne haþ it nat taken þe tyme of þe morwe.
and it haþ lost þat of 3ister-day. and certys in þe lijf
of þis day 3e ne lyuen no more but ry3t as in þis
moeueable

and transitorie moment. þan þilke þinge þat suffriþ
4996

temporel condicioun. a[l]þoughe þat [it] bygan neuer
to be. ne þoughe it neuere cese forto be. as aristotle
demde of þe worlde. and al þou3 þat þe lif of it be
strecchid wiþ infinite of tyme. 3it al*gates nis it no 5000
swiche þing þat men my3ten trowen by ry3t þat it is
eterne. for al þou3 þat it comprehende *and* embrace þe
space of life infinite. 3it algates ne [em]braceþ it nat þe
space of þe lif alto-gidre. for it ne haþ nat þe futures

5004

And eternity is a full,
total, and perfect
possession of a life
which shall never end.
This will appear more
clearly from a
comparison with
temporal things.
Temporal existence
proceeds from the past to
the present, and thence
to the future.

And there is nothing
under the law of time,
which can at once
comprehend the whole
space of its existence.

Having lost *yesterday* it
does not as yet enjoy *to-
morrow*; and as for *to-
day* it consists only in
the present transitory
moment.

Whatever, therefore, is
subjected to a temporal
condition, as Aristotle
thought of the world,
may be without
beginning and without
end; and although its
duration may extend to
an infinity of time, yet it
cannot rightly be called
eternal: for it doth not
comprehend at once the
whole extent of its
infinite duration, having
no knowledge of things
future which are not yet
arrived.

[* fol. 39.]

þat ne ben nat 3it. ne it ne haþ no lenger þe preterit3
þat ben ydon or ypassed. but þilke þing þan þat haþ
and comprehendþ to-gidre alle þe plente of þe lif
interminable.

to whom þere ne failiþ nat of þe future. 5008

and to whom þer nis nat of þe preterit escapid nor
ypassed. þilk[e] same is ywitnessed or yproued by ry3t
to ben eterne. and it byhoueþ by necessite þat þilke
þinge be alwey present to hym self *and* compotent. as 5012

who seiþ alwey present to hym self *and* so my3ty þat al
by ry3t at hys plesaunce. *and* þat he haue al present
þe infinit of þe moeuable tyme. wherfore som men
trowen wrongefully þat whan þei heren þat it semid[e]
5016

to plato þat þis worlde ne had[de] neuer bygynnyng
of tyme. ne þat it neuere shal haue faylyng. þei wenen
in þis manere þat þis worlde ben maked coeterne wiþ
his makere. as who seiþ. þei wenen þat þis worlde *and* 5020
god ben maked to-gidre eterne. and it is a wrongful
wenyng. for oþer þing is it to ben yladd by lif
interminable

as plato graunted[e] to þe worlde. *and* oþer
þing is it to embracen to-gidre alle þe presence to þe lif
5024

interminable. þe whiche þing it is clere *and* manifest
þat it is propre to þe deuine þou3t. ne it ne sholde nat
semen to vs þat god is elder þan þinges þat ben
ymaked

by quantite of tyme. but raþer by þe proprete of hys
5028

For what is eternal must
be always present to
itself and master of
itself, and have always
with it the infinite
succession of time.

Therefore some
philosophers, who had
heard that Plato believed
that this world had
neither beginning nor
end, falsely concluded,
that the created universe
was coeternal with its
Creator.

But it is one thing to be
conducted through a life
of infinite duration,
which was Plato's
opinion of the world, and
another thing to
comprehend at once the
whole extent of this
duration as present
which, it is manifest, can
only belong to the
Divine mind.
Nor ought it to seem to
us that God is prior to
and more ancient than
his creatures by the
space of time, but rather
by the simple and
undivided properties of
his nature.

symple nature. for þis ilke infinit[e] moeuyng of
temporel
þinges folwiþ þis presentarie estat of þe lijf
inmoeueable.

D IS ETERNAL.

and so as it ne may nat contrefeten it ne feynen
it ne ben euene lyke to it. for þe inmoeueablete. þat is
5032

to seyn þat is in þe eternite of god. ¶ it faileþ *and*
falleþ in to moeuyng fro þe simplicitie of [the]
presence

of god. *and* disencresib to þe infinite quantite of
future *and* of preterit. *and* so as it ne may nat han
togidre 5036

al þe plente of þe lif. algates ȝitte for as moche as
it ne cesiþ neuere forto ben in som manere it semeþ
somde[l] to vs þat it folwiþ *and* resemblib þilke þing
þat it ne may nat attayne to. ne fulfille. *and* byndeþ it
5040

self to som manere presence of þis litel *and* swifte
moment. þe whiche presence of þis lytele *and* swifte
moment. for þat it bereþ a manere ymage or lykenesse
of þe ay dwellynge presence of god. it graunteþ to 5044
swiche manere þinges as it bitidiþ to þat it semeþ hem
þat þise þinges han ben *and* ben *and* for [þat] þe
presence

of swiche litel moment ne may nat dwelle þer-for
[it] rauyssid[e] *and* took þe infinit[e] wey of tyme. þat
5048

The infinite progression
of temporal things
imitates the ever-present
condition of an
immovable life:

and since it cannot copy
nor equal it from an
immovable and simply
present state, it passes
into motion and into an
infinite measure of past
and future time.

But since it cannot
possess at once the
whole extent of its
duration, yet, as it never
ceases wholly to be, it
faintly emulates *that*
whose perfection it can
neither attain nor
express, by attaching
itself to the present
fleeting moment, which,
because it resembles the
durable present time,
imparts to those things
that partake of it an
appearance of existence.

But as it cannot stop or
abide it pursues its
course through infinite
time, and by gliding
along it continues its
duration, the plenitude of
which it could not
comprehend, by abiding
in a permanent state.

is to seyn by successioun. *and* by þis manere it is ydon.
for þat it sholde continue þe lif in goynge of þe whiche
lif it ne myȝt[e] nat embrace þe plente in dwellynge.
and for þi yif we willen putte worþi name[s] to þinges

5052

and folwen plato. lat vs seyn þan sopely þat god is
eterne. *and* þat þe worlde is perpetual. þan syn þat
euery iugement knoweþ *and* comprehendþ by hys
owen

nature þinges þat ben subiect vnto hym. þere is sopely

5056

al-wey to god an eterne *and* presentarie estat. *and* þe
science of hym þat ouer-passeþ alle temporel
moe[ue]ment

dwelleþ in þe symplite of hys presence *and* embraceþ
and considereþ alle þe infinit spaces of tymes 5060

preteritȝ *and* futures *and* lokeþ in þis symple knowynge
alle þinges of preterit ryȝt as þei weren ydoon presently
ryȝt now ¶ yif þou wolt þan þenke *and* avisen þe
prescience by whiche it knoweþ al[le] þinges *þou ne

5064

shalt nat demen it as prescience of þinges to comen.

FINITION OF PRESCIENCE.

but þou shalt demen [it] more ryȝtfully þat it is science
of presence or of instaunce þat neuer ne fayleþ. for
whiche it nis nat ycleped prouidence but it sholde raper

5068

be cleped purueaunce þat is establissed ful fer fro ryȝt
lowe þinges. *and* byholdeþ from a-fer alle þinges ryȝt as

If we would follow Plato in giving things their right names, let us say that God is *eternal* and the world *perpetual*.

His knowledge, surpassing the progression of time, is ever present, containing the infinite space of past and future times, and embraces in his clear insight all things, as if they were now transacting.

Prescience is, then, a foreknowledge, not of what is to come, but of the present and *never-failing now* (in which God sees all things as if immovably present).

[* fol. 39 b.]

Therefore *foreknowledge* is not so applicable a term as *providence*—for God looks down upon all things from the summit of the universe.

it were fro þe heye heyzte of þinges. whi axest þou þan
or why disputest þou þan þat þilke þinges ben don by
5072

necessite whiche þat ben yseyen *and* yknowen by þe
deuyne syzt. syn þat for soþe men ne maken nat þilke
þinges necessarie. whiche þat þe[i] seen be ydoon in
hire syzt. for addiþ þi byholdynge any necessite to
þilke 5076

þinges þat þou byholdest present. ¶ Nay quod I. *p.*
Certys þan yif men myzte maken any digne
comparisoun
or collacioun of þe presence diuine. *and* of þe presence
of mankynde. ryzt so as 3e seen somme þinges in þis
5080

temporel presente. ryzt so seeþ god alle þinges by hys
eterne present. ¶ wherfore þis dyuyne prescience ne
chaungeþ nat þe nature ne þe proprete of þinges but
byholdeþ swyche þinges present to hym ward. as þei
5084

shollen bytiden to 3ow ward in tyme to come. ne it ne
confoundeþ nat þe Iugement3 of þinges but by of syzt
of hys þouzt he knoweþ þe þinges to comen as wel
necessarie as nat necessarie. ryzt so as whan 3e seen
togidre 5088

a man walke on þe erþe *and* þe sonne aysen in
[the] heuene. al be it so þat 3e seen *and* byholden þat
oon *and* þat oþer to-gidre. 3it nabeles 3e demen *and*
discerne þat þat oon is uoluntarie *and* þat oþer is necessarie. 5092

Do you think that God imposes a necessity on things by beholding them? It is not so in human affairs.

Does your view of an action lay any necessity upon it?

B. No.

P. By parity of reason it is clear that whilst you see only some things in a limited instant, God sees all things in his ever-present time.

His Divine prescience therefore does not change the nature of things—but only beholds those things as present to him which shall in time be produced.

Nor does he judge confusedly of them, but knows at one view what will necessarily and what will not necessarily happen.

¶ Ryȝt so þan [the] deuyne lokynge byholdynge
alle þinges vndir hym ne troubleþ nat þe qualite of
þinges þat ben certeynely present to hym ward. but as
to þe condicioun of tyme for soþe þei ben future. for

5096

whiche it folwiþ þat þis nis non oppinioun. but raþer a
stedfast knowyng ystrenged by soþenes. þat whan
þat god knoweþ any þinge to be he ne vnwoot nat þat
þilke þinge wanteþ necessite to be. þis is to seyn þat

5100

whan þat god knoweþ any þinge to bitide. he woot wel
þat it ne haþ no necessite to bitide. *and* yif þou seist
here þat þilke þinge þat god seeþ to bytide it ne may
nat vnbytide. as who seiþ it mot bitide. ¶ *and* þilke 5104
þinge þat þat ne may nat vnbytide it mot bitide by
necessite. and þat þou streine me to þis name of
necessite.

certys I wol wel confessen *and* byknowe a þinge of
ful sadde troupe. but vnnep shal þere any wyȝt [mowe]

5108

seen it or comen þer-to. but yif þat he be byholder of þe
deuyne þouȝte. ¶ for I wol answer þe þus. þat þilke
þinge þat is future whan it is referred to þe deuyne
knowyng þan is it necessarie. but certys whan it is
vndirstonden 5112

in hys owen kynde men sen it [is] vtterly fre
and absolut from alle necessite. for certys þer ben two
maneres of necessites. þat oon necessite is symple as
þus. þat it byhoueþ by necessite þat alle men be mortal

5116

The eye of God, seeing
all things, doth not alter
the properties of things,
for everything is present
to him, though its
temporal event is future.

When God knows that
anything is to be, he
knows at the same time
that it is not under the
necessity of being—but
this is not conjecture, but
certain knowledge
founded upon truth.

If you insist that *what
God foresees shall and
must happen; and that
which cannot do
otherwise than happen,
must needs happen*, and
so bind me to admit a
necessity, I must confess
that things are under
such a restraint; but it is
a truth that we scarce can
comprehend, unless we
be acquainted with the
Divine counsels.

For I will answer you
thus. That the thing
which is to happen in
relation to the Divine
knowledge is necessary;
but, considered in its
own nature, seems free
and absolute.

There are two kinds of
necessity—one simple;
as men must necessarily
die—the other is
conditional, as if you
know a man walks he
must necessarily walk—
for that which is known

or dedely. an oþer necessite is condicionel as þus. yif þou wost þat a man walkiþ. it byhoueþ by necessite þat he walke. þilke þinge þan þat any wyȝt haþ yknowe to be. it ne may ben non oþer weyes þan he knoweþ it to be. 5120

cannot be otherwise than what it is apprehended to be.

SCIENCE AND NECESSITY.

¶ but þis condicioun ne draweþ nat wiþ hir þilke necessite symple. For certys þis necessite condicionel. þe propre nature of it ne makeþ it nauȝt. but þe adieccioun of þe condicioun makith it. for no necessite ne constreyneþ 5124

But this condition does not infer the absolute necessity, for the nature of the thing itself does not here constitute the necessity, but the necessity arises from the conjunction of the condition.

a man to [gon / þat] gooþ by his propre wille. al be it so þat whan he gooþ þat it is necessarie þat he gooþ.

No necessity compels a man to walk who does so willingly, but it must be necessary that he walk when he does step forward.

¶ Ryȝt on þis same manere þan. yif þat þe purueaunce of god seeþ any þing present. þan mot þilke *þinge be 5128

So everything that is present to the eye of Providence must assuredly be, although there is nothing in its own nature to constitute that necessity.

[* fol. 40.]

by necessite. al þouȝ þat it ne haue no necessite of hys owen nature. but certys þe futures þat bytyden by fredom

Since God beholds all future events proceeding from free-will as actually present—these events in relation to Divine sight are necessary—yet in relation to themselves they are absolutely free.

of arbitre god seeþ hem alle to-gidre presentȝ. þise þinges þan [yif] þei ben referred to þe deuyne syȝt. 5132 þan ben þei maked necessarie to þe condicioun of þe deuyne knowynge. but certys yif þilke þinges ben considred

by hem self þei ben absolut of necessite. *and* ne forleten nat ne cesen nat of þe liberte of hire owen 5136 nature. þan certys wiþ outhen doute alle þe þingus shollen be doon whiche þat god woot by-forn þat þei

All things which God foresees shall surely come to pass; but some of these things proceed from free-will, which

ben to comen. but somme of hem comen *and* bitiden of
[free] arbitre or of fre wille. þat al be it so þat þei
bytiden. 5140

although they happen,
yet do not thereby
change their nature,

DIVIDENCE AND HUMAN INTENTIONS.

3it algates ne lese þei nat hire *propre* nature ne
beynge. by þe whiche first or þat þei were doon þei
hadden power nat to han bitidd. *Boece*. what is þis
to seyn þan *quod* I. þat þinges ne ben nat necessarie by
5144

as before they happened
they had it in their power
not to happen.

But it is a thing of no
moment then, whether
things are necessary in
their own nature or not,
since by the condition of
the Divine knowledge
they fell out as if they
were necessitated.

hire *propre* nature. so as þei comen in alle maneres in
þe lykenesse of necessite by þe condicioun of þe
deuyne

science. *Philosophie*. þis is þe difference *quod* she. þat
þo þinges þat I purposed[e] þe a litel here byforn. þat
5148

P. The difference is
explained in the
instances lately given
you, of the man walking,
&c.

is to seyn þe sonne arysynge *and* þe man walkynge þat
þerwhiles þat þilke þinges ben ydon. þei ne my3ten nat
ben vndon. napeles þat oon of hem or it was ydon it
byhoued[e] by necessite þat it was ydon. but nat þat
5152

The event of the former
was necessary before it
befell, whereas that of
the latter was altogether
free.

oper. ry3t so it is here þat þe þinges þat god haþ present.
wiþ outen doute þei shulle ben. but somme of hem descendip
of þe nature of þinges as þe sonne arysynge.
and somme descendip of þe power of þe doers as þe man 5156

walkynge. ¶ þan seide I. no wronge þat yif þat þise
þinges ben referred to þe deuyne knowynge þan ben
þei
necessarie. *and* yif þei ben considered by hem selfe
þan

B. Then I did not go
from the truth when I
said that some things
referred to the Divine
knowledge are
necessary, while
considered in themselves
they are not under the
bond of necessity.

ben þei absolut from þe bonde of necessite. ryȝt so [as]

5160

alle þinges þat appiereþ or sheweþ to þe wittes yif þou
referre it to resoun it is vniuersel. *and* yif þou referre
it or look[e] it to it self. þan is it synguler. but now
yif þou seist þus þat yif it be in my power to chaunge

5164

my *purpose*. þan shal I voide þe *purueaunce* of god.
whan þat perauenture I shal han chaunged þo þinges
þat he knoweþ byforn. þan shal I answeere þe þus

In the same way everything that is an object of sense is *general* when considered in relation to reason—but particular when considered by itself.

But you may say—If I am able to change my purpose I can deceive providence by changing that which she hath foreseen I would do.

D'S KNOWLEDGE FIXED AND UNCHANGED.

¶ Certys þou maist wel chaungen þi *purpos* but for as

5168

mochel as þe *present* soþenesse of þe *deuyne*
purueaunce

byholdeþ þat þou mayst chaungen þi *purpose*. *and*
wheþir þou wolt chaunge it or no. *and* whider-ward
þat þou tourne it. þou maist nat eschewen þe *deuyne*

5172

prescience ryȝt as þou ne mayst nat fleen þe syȝt of þe
present eye. al þouȝ þat þou tourne þi self by þi fre
wille in to *dyuerse* accioun. ¶ But þou mayst seyn
aȝeyne how shal it þan be. shal nat þe *dyuyne science*

5176

ben chaunged by my *disposicioun* whan þat I wol o
þing now *and* now an oþer. *and* þilke *prescience* ne
semeþ it nat to enterchaunge stoundes of knowynges.
as who seiþ. ne shal it nat seme to vs þat þe *deuyne* 5180
prescience enterchaungeþ hys *dyuers* stoundes of knowynges.

P. You may perhaps alter your purpose—but as providence takes note of your intentions, you cannot deceive her; for you cannot escape the divine prescience though you have the power, through a free-will, to vary and diversify your actions.

But you may say—Shall the divine knowledge be changed according to the mutability of my disposition, and the apprehensions of the Deity fluctuated with my changing purposes?

so þat it knowe somme tyme o þing *and* somme tyme
þe contrarie. ¶ No for soþe. [*quod* I] for þe deuyne syzt
renneþ to-forne *and* seep alle futures *and* clepeþ hem
a3ein 5184

and retourniþ hem to þe presence of hys propre
knowynge.

ne he ne entrechaungeþ nat [so] as þou wenest þe
stoundes of forknowyng [as] now þis now þat. but he
ay dwellynge comiþ byforn *and* embraceþ at o strook
5188

alle þi mutaciouns. and þis presence to *comprehenden*
and to sen alle þinges. god ne haþ nat taken it of þe
bitydyng of þinges forto come. but of hys propre
symplicite.

ANSWER TO FORMER OBJECTIONS.

¶ and her by is assoiled þilke þing þat þou 5192
puttest a litel her byforne. þat is to seyne þat it is
vnworþi

þinge to seyn þat oure futures 3euen cause of þe
science of god ¶ For certys *þis strengþe of þe deuyne
science whiche þat embraceþ alle þinge by his
presentarie 5196

knowynge establissep manere to alle þingus *and* it
ne awiþ nat to lattere þinges. *and* syn þat þise þinges
ben þus. þat is to seyn syn þat necessite nis nat in
þinges by þe deuyne prescience. þan is þer fredom of
5200

arbitre. þat dwelleþ hool *and* vnwemmed to mortal
men.

No, indeed! The view of the Deity foreruns every future event, and brings it back into the presence of his own knowledge, which does not vary, as you imagine, to conform to your caprices, but remaining fixed, at once foresees and comprehends all your changes.

This faculty of comprehending and seeing all things as present, God does not receive from the issue of futurities, but from the simplicity of his own nature.

Here, then, is an answer to your former objection—that it is folly to think that our future actions and events are the causes of the prescience of God.

For the Divine mind, embracing and comprehending all things by a present knowledge, plans and directs all things and is not dependent upon futurity.

[* fol. 41 b.]

Since no necessity is imposed upon things by the Divine prescience, there remains to men an inviolable freedom of will.

ne þe lawes ne purpose nat wikkedly meedes *and*
peynes
to þe willynges of men þat ben vnbounde *and* quit of
alle necessite.

¶ And god byholder *and* forwiter of 5204
alle þinges dwelliþ aboue *and* þe present eternite of
hys
syȝt renneþ alwey wiþ þe dyuerse qualite of oure dedes
dispensyng *and* ordeynynge medes to good[e] men.
and

tourmentȝ to wicked men. ne in ydel ne in veyn ne ben
5208

þer nat put in god hope *and* prayeres. þat ne mowen
nat ben vnspedful ne wiþ oute effect whan þei ben
ryȝtful

¶ wiþstond þan *and* eschewe þou vices. worshippe
and loue þou vertus. arise þi corage to ryȝtful hoopes.
5212

ȝelde þou humble preiers an heyȝe. grete necessite of
prowesse *and* vertue is encharged *and* comaunded to
ȝow yif ȝe nil nat dissimulen. ¶ Syn þat ȝe worchen
and doon. þat is to seyn ȝoure dedes *and* ȝoure workes
5216

by-fore þe eyen of þe Iuge þat seep *and* demep alle
þinges. [To whom be goye *and* worshiþe bi Infynyt
tymes / AMEN.]

EXPLICIT LIBER QUINTUS. ET VLTIMUS.

And those laws are just
which assign rewards
and punishments to men
possessing free-will.

Moreover, God, who sits
on high, foreknows all
things, and the eternal
presence of his
knowledge concurs with
the future quality of our
actions, dispensing
rewards to good and
punishments to evil men.

Nor are our hopes and
prayers reposed in, and
addressed to God in
vain, which when they
are sincere cannot be
inefficacious nor
unsuccessful.

Resist and turn from vice
—honour and love
virtue, exalt your mind
to God (the truest hope),
offer up your prayers
with humility.

If you are sincere you
will feel that you are
under an obligation to
lead a good and virtuous
life, inasmuch as all your
actions and works are
done in the presence of
an all-discerning Judge.

4977 *al þinge*—alle thinges

4979 *moche*—mochel

4980 *loken*—loke
 whiche—which
4981 [*ek*]—from C.
4987 *clerely*—cleerly
4989 *al*—alle
4993-4 *hap*—MS. haþe
4993 *þe* (2)—to
4994 *þat*—the tyme
4997 *a[l]þoughe*—al-thogh
 [*it*]—from C.
4999 *worlde*—world
5001 *swiche*—swych
5002 *eterne*—from C., MS. eternite
5003 *life*—lyf
5004-5-6 *hap*—MS. haþe
5006 *ydon*—MS. ydone, C. I-doon
5007 *alle*—al
5008-9 *nat*—nawht
5010 *pilk[e]*—thilke
 or—*and*
5014 *by*—be
5016 *semid[e]*—smede
5017 *worlde*—world
 had[de]—hadde
5018 *haue*—han
5019-20 *worlde*—world
5022 *yladd*—MS. yladde, C. I-lad
5023 *worlde*—world
5024 *embracen*—enbrace
 alle—al
 presence to—present of
5025 *clere*—cleer
5032 *lyke*—lyk
5034 [*the*]—from C.
5039 *somde[l]*—somdel
5040 *fulfille*—fullfyllen
5041 *litel*—from C., MS. lykly
5042 *whiche*—which
 lytele—from C., MS. lykly
5046 *ben* (1)—yben
 [*þat*]—from C.

5047 *swiche*—swych
5048 [it]—from C.
5051 *myȝt[e]*—myhte
5052 *willen putte*—wollen putten
 name[s]—names
5053 *sopely*—sothly
5054 *worlde*—world
5055 *owen*—owne
5056 *sopely*—sothly
5057 *al-vey*—al-weys
5058 *alle*—al
 moe[ue]ment—moeuement
5063 *þenke*—thinken
 avisen—auyse
5064 *whiche*—which
 al[le]—alle
5066 *shalt*—shal
 [it]—from C.
5068 *whiche*—which
5074-76 *syȝt*—syhte
5075 *whiche*—which
 þe[i]—they
5085 *come*—comyn
5086 *of syȝt*—O syhte
5087 *he knoweþ*—MS. repeats
5090 [the]—from C.
5092 *discerne*—discernen
5093 [the]—from C.
5097 *whiche*—which
5098 *stedfast*—stidefast
 sopenes—sothnesse
5102 *hap*—MS. haþe
5104 *bitide*—bide
5108 *sadde*—sad
 vnnep—vnnethe
 [mowe]—from C.
5109 *comen*—come
5110 *pouȝte*—thoght
 answere—answeren
5113 *sen*—MS. sene, C. sen
 [is]—from C.

5117 *dedely*—dedly
 5119 *hap*—MS. haþe
 5121 *condicioun*—from C., MS. *necessite*
 5123 *nauȝt*—nat
 5125 [*gon þat*]—from C.
 wille—wil
 5128 *mot*—MS. mote, C. mot
 5131 *presentȝ*—present
 5132 [*yif*]—from C.
 syȝt—syhte
 5137 *wiþ outen*—with-owte
 5138 *whiche*—which
 5139 *somme*—som
 5140 [*free*]—from C.
 5141 *ne* (2)—C. in
 5142 *whiche*—which
 were doon—weeryn Idoon
 5143 *bitidd*—MS. bitidde, C. bityd
 5148 *purposed[e]*—purposede
 5150 *ydon*—MS. ydone, C. I-doon
 myȝten—myhte
 5151 *vndon*—MS. vndone, C. vndoon
 5151-2 *ydon*—MS. ydone, C. I-doon
 5152 *byhoued[e]*—houyd
 5153 *hap*—MS. haþe
 5154 *wiþ outen*—with-owte
 shulle—shollen
 5156 *doers*—doeres
 5157 *wronge*—wrong
 5159 *selfe*—self
 5160 *from*—fro
 bonde—bond
 [*as*]—from C.
 5163 *look[e]*—loke
 5166 *þo*—the
 5169 *sopenesse*—sothnesse
 5170 *chaungen*—chaunge
 5173 *syȝt*—syhte
 5175 *wille*—wyl
 5177 *wol*—wole
 5179 *enterchaunge*—MS. enterchaungyng, C. entrechaunge

5181 *hys*—hise
 5182 *somme* (1)—sum
 somme (2)—som
 5183 *syȝt*—syhte
 5184 *to-forne*—to-forn
 5186 [*so*]*—*from C.
 5187 [*as*]*—*from C.
 5188 *comiþ*—comth
 5190 *hap*—MS. haþe
 5193 *seyne*—seyn
 5196 *whiche*—which
 5198 *awip*—oweth
 5199 *þat is to*—*prescience*—omitted
 5203 *vnbounde*—vnbownden
 quit—quite
 5206 *syȝt*—sihte
 5207 *good[e]*—goode
 5211 *wipstond*—MS. wiþstonde, C. withstond
 5213 *an heyȝe*—a heygh
 grete—Gret
 5215 *worchen*—workyn
 5216 *and* (2)—or
 5217 *by-fore*—by-forn
 5218 [*To whom*—*Amen*]*—*from C.; MS. reads *et cetera* after ‘þinges.’ C. ends with the following rubric:
 Explicit expliceat ludere scriptor eat
 Finito libro sit laus *et gloria Christo*
 Corpore scribentis sit *gratia cunctipotentis*

APPENDIX.

[*Camb. Univ. MS. Ii. 3. 21, fol. 52 b.*]

Chawcer vp-on this fyfte metur of the second book

A Blysfyl lyf a paysyble *and* a swete
Ledden the poeples in the former age
They helde hem paied of the fructes þat þey ete
Whiche þat the feldes yaue hem by vsage 4
They ne weere nat forpampred *with* owtrage
Onknowyn was þ^e quyerne *and* ek the melle
They eten mast hawes *and* swych pownage
And dronken water of the colde welle 8

¶ Yit nas the grownd nat wownded *with* þ^e plowh
But corn vp-sprong vnsowe of mannes hond
þe which they gnodded *and* eete nat half .I.-nowh
No man yit knewe the forwes of his lond 12
No man the fyr owt of the flynt yit fonde
Vn-koruen and vn-grobbed lay the vyne
No man yit in the mortar spices grond
To clarre ne to sawse of galentyne 16

¶ No Madyr welde or wod no litestere
Ne knewh / the fles was of is former hewe
No flessch ne wyste offence of egge or spere
No coyn ne knewh man which is fals or trewe 20
No ship yit karf the wawes grene *and* blewe

No Marchaunt yit ne fette owt-landissh ware
No batails trompes for the werres folk ne knewe
Ne towres heye *and* walles rownde or square 24

¶ What sholde it han avayled to werreye
Ther lay no profyt ther was no rychesse
But corsed was the tyme .I. dar^h wel seye [fol. 53.]
þat men fyrst dede hir swety bysynesse 28
To grobbe vp metal lurkyng in dirkenesse
And in þe Ryueris fyrst gemmys sowhte
Allas than sprong⁺ vp al the cursydnesse
Of coueytyse þat fyrst ovr sorwe browhte 32

¶ Thyse tyraunt3 put hem gladly nat in pres
No places wyldnesse ne no bussches for to wyne
Ther pouerte is as seith diogenes
Ther as vitayle ek is so skars *and* thinne 36
þat nat but mast or apples is ther inne
But þer as bagges ben *and* fat vitaille
Ther wol they gon *and* spare for no synne
With al hir ost the Cyte forto a-sayle 40

¶ Yit was no paleis chaumbres ne non halles
In kaues *and* wodes softe *and* swete
Sleptin this blyssed folk⁺ *with-owte* walles
On gras or leues in parfyt Ioye reste *and* quiete 44
No down of fetheres ne no bleched shete
Was kyd to hem but in surte they slepte
Hir hertes weere al on *with-owte* galles
Euerych of hem his feith to oother kepte 48

¶ Vnforged was the hawberke *and* the plate
þe lambyssh poeple voyded of alle vyse
Hadden no fantesye to debate
But eche of hem wolde oother wel cheryce 52
No pride non enuye non Auaryce

No lord no taylage by no tyranye
Vmblesse *and* pes good feith the emperice

. 56

¶ Yit was nat Iuppiter the lykerous
Bat fyrst was fadyr of delicacie
Come in this world ne nembroth desyrous
To regne had nat maad his towres hye 60
Allas allas now may [men] wepe And crye
For in owre dayes nis but couetyse
Dowblenesse *and* tresoun *and* enuye
Poyson *and* manslawhtre *and* mordre in sondry wyse 64

39, 40 MS. transposes the lines

44 *On*—MS. Or

56 A line omitted, but no gap left for one.

LADES DE VILAGE SANZ PEINTURE.

[CAUSER](#) / BALADES DE VILAGE SANZ PEINTURE

¶ This wrecched worlde-is *transmutacioun*
As wele / or wo / now poeere *and* now honour
With-owten ordyr or wis descresyoun
Gouerned is by fortunes errorr 4
But natheles the lakke of hyr fauowr¹
Ne may nat don me syngen thowh I. deye
Iay tout *perdu moun temps et moun labour*
For fynaly fortune .I. the deffye 8

[fol. 53 b.]

¶ Yit is me left the lyht of my resoun

To knowen frend fro foo in thi merowr)
So mochel hath yit thy whirlynge vp *and* down
I-tawht me for to knowe in an howr 12
But trewely no fors of thi reddowr)
To hym þat ouer hym self hath the maystrye
My suffysaunce shal be my socour)
For fynaly fortune I. thee deffye 16

¶ O socrates þou stidfast chaumpyoun
She neuer myht[e] be thi tormentowr
Thow neuer dreddest hyr oppressyoun
Ne in hyr chere fownde thow no sauour) 20
Thow knewe wel the deseyte of hyr colour)
And þat hir most[e] worshipe is to lye
I knew hir ek a fals dissimulour)
For fynaly fortune .I. the deffye 24

LE RESPOUNCE DE FORTUNE A PLEINTIF.

¶ No man ys wrechchyd but hym self yt wene
And he þat hath hym self hat suffisaunce
Whi seysthow thanne y am [to] the so kene
þat hast thy self owt of my gouernaunce 28
Sey thus graunt mercy of thyn haboundaunce
That thow hast lent or this why wolt þou stryue
What woost thow yit how y the wol auaunce
And ek thow hast thy beste frende a-lyue 32

¶ I haue the tawht deuisyoun by-twene
Frend of effect⁺ *and* frende of cowntenaunce
The nedeth nat the galle of no hyene
þat cureth eyen derkyd for penaunce 36
Now se[st] thow cleer þat weere in ignoraunce
Yit halt thin ancre *and* yit thow mayst aryue
Ther bownte berth the keye of my substaunce
And ek þou hast thy beste frende alyue 40

¶ How manye haue .I. refused to sustigne
Syn .I. the fostred haue in thy plesaunce
Wolthow thanne make a statute on þy quyene
þat .I. shal ben ay at thy ordynaunce 44
Thow born art in my regne of varyaunce
Abowte the wheel *with* oother most thow dryue
My loore is bet than wikke is thi greuaunce
And ek þou hast thy beste frende a-lyue 48

37 *se[st]*—partly erased and *ist* written on it in a later hand.

41 *igne* of *sustigne* is in a later hand.

LE RESPONCE DU PLEINTIF COUNTRE FORTUNE.

¶ Thy loore y dempne / it is aduersyte [fol. 54.]
My frend maysthow nat reuen blynde goddesse
þat .I. thy frendes knowe .I. thanke to the
Tak hem agayn / lat hem go lye on presse 52
The negardye in kepyng hyr rychesse
Prenostik is thow wolt hir^ʒ towr^ʒ asayle
Wikke appetyt comth ay before sykenesse
In general this rewle may nat fayle 56

LE RESPONCE DE FORTUNE COUNTRE LE PLEINTIF

¶ Thow pynchest at my mutabylyte
For .I. the lente a drope of my rychesse
And now me lykyth to *with*-drawe me
Whi sholdysthow my realte apresse 60
The see may ebbe *and* flowen moore or lesse
The welkne hath myht to shyne reyne or hayle
Ryht so mot .I. kythen my brutelnesse
In general this rewle may nat fayle 64

LE PLEINTIF

¶ Lo excussyoun of the maieste

Þat al purueyeth of his ryhtwysnesse
That same thinge fortune clepyn ye
Ye blynde beestys ful of lewednesse 68
The heuene hath proprete of sykynesse
This world hath euer resteles trauayle
Thy laste day is ende of myn inter[er]sse
In general this rewele may nat fayle 72

LENUOY DE FORTUNE

¶ Prynses .I. prey yow of yowre gentileesses
Lat nat this man on me thus crye *and* pleyne
And .I. shal quyte yow yowre bysynesse
At my requeste as thre of yow or tweyne 76
Þat but yow lest releue hym of hys peyne
Preyeth hys best frend of his noblesse
That to som betere estat he may attayne

The following section contains the text alone of Chaucer's translation of *De Consolatione Philosophiae*, without the editor's annotations. It is followed by the [Glossarial Index](#).

LIBER PRIMUS.

INCIPIT LIBER BOICII DE CONSOLACIONE PHILOSOPHIE.

Carmina qui quondam studio florente peregi. [The fyrste Metur.]

Allas I wepyng am constreined to bygynne vers of sorouful matere. ¶ Þat whilom in florysching studie made delitable ditees. For loo rendyng muses of poetes enditen to me þinges to be writen. and drery vers of wrecchednes weten my face wiþ verray teers. ¶ At þe leest no drede ne myzt[e] ouer-come þo muses. þat þei ne weren felawes *and* folweden my wey. þat is to seyne when I was exiled. þei þat weren glorie of my youȝth whilom weleful *and* grene conforten now þe sorouful werdes of me olde man. for elde is comen vnwarly vpon me hasted by þe harmes þat I haue. *and* sorou haþ comaunded his age to be in me. ¶ Heeres hore ben schad ouertymelyche vpon myne heued. and þe slak[e] skyn trembleþ vpon myn emty body. þilk[e] deef of men is welful þat ne comeþ not in ȝeres þat ben swete (.i. mirie.) but comeþ to wrecches often yclepid.

¶ Allas allas wiþ how deef an eere deef cruel tourneþ away fro wrecches *and* naieþ to closen wepyng eyen. ¶ While fortune vnfeipful fauored[e] me wiþ lyȝte goodes (.s. temporels.) þe sorouful houre þat is to seyne þe deef had[de] almost dreynt myne heued. ¶ But now for fortune clowdy haþ chaunged hir disceyuable chere to me warde. myn vnpitouse lijf draweþ a long vnagreable dwellynges in me. ¶ O ȝe my frendes what or wherto auaunted[e] ȝe me to be weleful: for he þat haþ fallen stood not *in* stedfast degree.

HIC DUM MECUM TACITUS.

[The firste prose.]

IN þe mene while þat I stille recorded[e] þise þinges wiþ my self. *and* markede my wepli compleynte wiþ office of poyntel. I saw stondyng aboute þe heyzt of my heued a woman of ful greet reuerence by semblaunt hir eyen brennyng *and* clere seing ouer þe comune myzt of men. wiþ a lijfly colour *and* wiþ swiche vigoure *and* strenkeþ þat it ne myzt[e] not be emptid. ¶ Al were it so þat sche was ful of so greet age. þat men ne wolde not trowe in no manere þat sche were of oure elde. þe stature of hir was of a doutous iugement. for sumtyme sche constreyned[e] *and* schronk hir seluen lyche to þe comune mesure of men. *and* sumtyme it semed[e] þat sche touched[e] þe heuene wiþ þe heyzte of hir heued. and when sche hef hir heued heyer sche perced[e] þe selue heuene. so þat þe syzt of men lokyng was in ydel. ¶ Hir cloþes weren maked of ryzt delye þredes *and* subtil crafte of perdurable matere. þe wyche cloþes sche hadde wouen wiþ hir owen hondes: as I knew wel aftir by hir selfe. declaryng *and* schewyng to me þe beaute. þe wiche cloþes a derkenes of a forleten and dispised elde had[de] duskid *and* dirkid as it is wont to dirken by-smoked ymages. ¶ In þe neþerest[e] hem or bordure of þese cloþes men redder ywouen in swiche a gregkysche .P. þat signifieþ þe lijf actif. And abouen þat lettre in þe heyzest[e] bordure a grekysche T. þat signifieþ þe lijf contemplatif. ¶ And by-twene þese two lettres þere weren seien degrees nobly wrouzt in manere of laddres. By wyche degrees men myzt[en] clymbe fro þe neþemast[e] lettre to þe ouermast[e]. ¶ Napeles hondes of sum men hadde korue þat cloþe by vyolence *and* by strenkeþ. ¶ And eueryche man of hem hadde born away syche peces as he myzte geet[e]. ¶ And forsoþe þis forsaide woman ber bookes in hir ryzt honde. *and* in hir lefte honde sche ber a ceptre. ¶ And when sche sauþ þese poetical muses aprochen aboute my bedde. *and* endytyng wordes to my wepynges. sche was a lytel ameued and glowed[e] wiþ cruel eyen. ¶ Who quod sche haþ suffred aprochen to þis seek[e] man þise comune strumpetis of siche a place þat men clepen þe theatre. ¶ Þe wyche only ne asswage not his sorowes. wiþ no remedies. but þei wolde fede *and* norysche hem wiþ swete venym. ¶ Forsoþe þise ben þo þat wiþ þornes *and* prykkynge of talentz or affeccions wiche þat ben no þing fruteþyng nor profitable destroyen þe cornes plenteuouse of frutes of reson. ¶ For þei holden þe hertes of men in usage. but þei ne delyuere not folk fro maladye. but if ze muses hadde wiþdrawen fro me wiþ zoure flateries. any vnkonnyng *and* vnprofitable man as men ben wont to fynde comunely

amonges þe peple. I wolde wene suffre þe lasse greuously. ¶ For-why in syche an vnprofitable man myne ententes weren no þing endamaged. ¶ But 3e wiþdrawen me þis man þat haþ ben norysched in studies or scoles of Eleaticis *and* of achademicis in grece. ¶ But goþ now raper away 3e meremaydenes wyche ben swete til it be at þe laste. *and* suffreþ þis man to be cured *and* heled by myne muses. þat is to say by notful sciences. ¶ And þus þis compaygnie of muses I-blamed casten wroþely þe chere adounward to þe erþe *and* schewyng by redenesse hir schame þei passeden sorowfully þe þreschefolde. ¶ And I of whom þe syzt plunged in teres was derked so þat I ne myzt[e] not knowe what þat woman was of so imperial auctorite. ¶ I wex al a-besid *and* astoned. *and* caste my syzt adoune in to þe erþe. *and* bygan stille forto abide what sche wolde don afterwarde. ¶ Þo come sche nere *and* sette hir doun vpon þe vterrest[e] corner of my bedde. *and* sche byholdyng my chere þat was cast to þe erþe heuy *and* greuous of wepyng. compleinede wiþ þise wordes þat I schal sey þe perturbacioun of my þouzt.

HEU QUAM PRECIPITI MERSA PROFUNDO. [The 2de Metur.]

Allas how þe þouzt of man dreint in ouer þrowyng depnesse dulleþ *and* forletip hys propre clerenesse. myntyng to gone in to foreyne derknesses as ofte as hys anoious bisines wexip wiþ-outen mesure. þat is dryuen to *and* fro wiþ worldly wyndes. ¶ Þis man þat sumtyme was fre to whom þe heuene was open *and* knowen *and* was wont to gone in heuenelyche papes. *and* sau3 þe lyztnesse of þe rede sunne. *and* sau3 þe sterres of þe colde moone. *and* wyche sterre in heuene vseþ wandryng risorses yflit by dyuerse speres. ¶ Þis man ouer comere hadde *comprehendid* al þis by noumbre. of accountyng in astronomye. ¶ And ouer þis he was wont to seche þe causes whennes þe sounyng wyndes moeuen *and* bisien þe smoþe water of þe see. *and* what spirit turneþ þe stable heuene. *and* whi þe sterre ryseþ oute of þe reede eest. to falle in þe westren wawes. *and* what attempriþ þe lusty houres of þe fyrste somer sesoun þat hizteþ *and* apparaileþ þe erþe wiþ rosene floures. ¶ And who makeþ þat plenteuouse autumpne in fulle 3eres fletip wiþ heuy grapes. ¶ And eke þis man was wont to telle þe dyuerses causes of nature þat weren yhid. ¶ Allas now lieþ he emptid of lyzt of hys þouzt. *and* hys nekke is pressid wiþ heuy cheynes *and*

bereþ his chere enclined adoune for þe greet[e] weyzt. and is constreyned to loke on foule erþe.

SET MEDICINE INQUIT TEMPUS.

[The ij^{de} prose.]

B vt tyme is now *quod* sche of medicine more þen of compleynte. ¶ Forsope þen sche entyndyng to me warde wiþ al þe lokyng of hir eyen saide. ¶ Art not þou he *quod* sche þat sumtyme I-norschid wiþ my mylke *and* fostre[d] wiþ my meetes were ascaped *and* comen to corage of a perfit man. ¶ Certys I 3af þe syche armures þat 3if þou þi self ne haddest first caste hem away. þei schulden haue defendid þe in sykernesse þat may not be ouer-comen. ¶ Knowest þou me not. Why art þou stille. is it for schame or for astonyng. It were me leuer þat it were for schame. but it semeþ me þat astonyng haþ oppressed þe. ¶ And whan sche say me not oonly stille. but wiþ-uten office of tonge *and* al doumbe. sche leide hir honde softely vpon my brest *and* seide. ¶ Here nis no peril *quod* sche. ¶ He is fallen in to a litargie. whiche þat is a comune sekenes to hertes þat ben desceiued. ¶ He haþ a litel for3eten hym self. but certis he schal lyztly remembren hym self. ¶ 3if so be þat he haþ knowen me or now. *and* þat he may so done I wil wipe a litel hys eyen. þat ben derked by þe cloude of mortel þinges ¶ Þise wordes seide sche. and wiþ þe lappe of hir garment yplitid in a frounce sche dried[e] myn eyen þat were ful of þe wawes of my wepynges.

TUNC ME DISCUSSA.

[The 3^{de} Metur.]

Þ us when þat nyzt was discussed *and* chased away. derknesses forleften me. *and* to myn eyen repeyre a3eyne her firste strenkeþ. and ryzt by ensample as þe sonne is hid when þe sterres ben clustred. þat is to sey when sterres ben couered wiþ cloudes by a swifte wynde þat hyzt chorus. *and* þat þe firmament stont derked by wete ploungy cloudes. and þat þe sterres not apperen vpon heuene. ¶ So þat þe nyzt semeþ sprad vpon erþe. ¶ Yif þan þe wynde þat hyzt borias sent out of þe kaues of þe contre of Trace betiþ þis nyzt. þat is to seyn chasiþ it away *and* descouereþ þe closed day. ¶ Þan schineþ phebus yshaken wiþ sodeyne lyzt *and* smyteþ wiþ hys bemes in meruelyng eyen.

Ryzt so *and* none oþer wyse þe cloudes of sorowe dissolued *and* don away. ¶ I took heuene. *and* receyuede mynde to knowe þe face of my fyciscien. ¶ So þat I sette myne eyen on hir *and* festned[e] my lokyng. I byholde my norice philosophie. in whos houses I hadde conuersed *and* haunted fro my zouþe. *and* I seide þus. ¶ O þou maistresse of alle uertues descendid fro þe souereyne sete. Whi art þou comen in to þis solitarie place of myn exil. ¶ Art þou comen for þou art mad coupable wiþ me of fals[e] blames. ¶ O *quod* sche my norry scholde I forsake þe now. *and* scholde I not parte wiþ þe by comune trauaille þe charge þat þou hast suffred for envie of my name. ¶ Certis it nar[e] not leueful ne sitting to philosophie to leten wiþ-uten compaignie þe wey of hym þat is innocent. ¶ Scholde I þan redoute my blame *and* agrisen as þou3 þer were byfallen a newe þing. q. d. non. ¶ For trowest þou þat philosophi be now alþerfirst assailed in perils by folk of wicked[e] maneres. ¶ Haue I not stryuen wiþ ful greet strife in olde tyme byfore þe age of my plato azeins þe foolhardines of foly *and* eke þe same plato lyuyng. hys maistre socrates deserued[e] victorie of vnryztful deep in my presence. ¶ Þe heritage of wyche socrates. þe heritage is to seyne þe doctrine of þe whiche socrates in hys oppinioun of felicite þat I clepe welfulnesse ¶ Whan þat þe people of epicuriens *and* stoyciens *and* many oþer enforceden hem to go rauische eueryche man for his part þat is to seyne. þat to eueryche of hem wolde drawen to þe defence of his oppinioun þe wordes of socrates. ¶ Þei as in *partie* of hir preye todrowen me cryinge *and* debatyng þer azeins. *and* tornen *and* torenten my cloþes þat I hadde wouen wiþ myn handes. *and* wiþ þe cloutes þat þei hadden arased oute of my cloþes. þei wenten away wenyng þat I hadde gon wiþ hem euery dele. In whiche epicuryens *and* stoyciens. for as myche as þer semed[e] *somme* traces *and* steppes of myne habit. þe folye of men wenyng þo epicuryens *and* stoyciens my familers *peruertede* (.s. *persequendo*) *somme* þoru3 þe errour of þe wikked[e] or vnkunnyng[e] multitude of hem. ¶ Þis is to seyne for þei semeden philosophres: þei weren *pursued* to þe deep *and* slayn. ¶ So yif þou hast not knowen þe exilynge of anaxogore. ne þe empoysenyng of socrates. ne þe *tourment3* of zeno for þei [weren] straungers. ¶ 3it my3test þou haue knowen þe senectiens *and* þe Canyos *and* þe sorancis of wyche folk þe renoun is neyþer ouer oolde ne

vnsolompne. ¶ Þe whiche men no þing ellys ne brouzt[e] hem to þe deep but oonly for þei weren enfourmed of my maneres. *and* semeden moste vnlyke to þe studies of wicked folk. ¶ And forþi þou au3test not to wondre þou3 þat I in þe bitter see of þis lijf be fordryuen wiþ tempestes blowyng aboute. in þe whiche tempeste þis is my most purpos þat is to seyn to displese to wikked[e] men. ¶ Of whiche schrews al be þe oost neuer so grete it is to dispyse. for it nis gouerned wiþ no leder of resoune. but it is rauysched only by flityng errorr folylly *and* lyztly. ¶ And if þei somtyme makyng an ost a3eynest vs assaile vs as strengere. oure leder draweþ to gedir hys rycchesse in to hys toure. *and* þei ben ententif aboute sarpulers or sachels vnprofitable forto taken. but we þat ben hey3 abouen syker fro al tumulte *and* wode noise. ben stored *and* enclosed in syche a palays. whider as þat chateryng or anoying folye ne may not attayne. ¶ We scorne swiche rauiners *and* honters of foulest[e] þinges.

QUISQUIS COMPOSITO.

[The ferthe Metur.]

Who so it be þat is clere of vertue sad *and* wel ordinat of lyuyng. þat haþ put vnderfote þe prowed[e] wierdes *and* lokip vpryzt vpon eyþer fortune. he may holde hys chiere vndiscomfited. ¶ Þe rage ne þe manace of þe commoeuyng or chasyng vpwarde hete fro þe botme. ne schal not moeue þat man. ne þe vnstable mountaigne þat hyzt veseuus. þat wircheþ oute þoru3 hys broken[e] chemineys smokyng fires. ¶ Ne þe wey of þonder lyzt þat is wont to smyte hey3e toures ne schal not mouene þat man. ¶ Wherto þen wrecches drede 3e tyrauntes þat ben wode *and* felownes wiþ-uten ony strenkeþ. ¶ Hope after no þing ne drede nat. *and* so schalt þou desarmen þe ire of þilke vnmyzty tyraunt. ¶ But who so þat quakyng dredeþ or desireþ þing þat nis not stable of his ryzt. þat man þat so doþ haþ cast away hys schelde *and* is remoeued fro hys place. *and* enlaceþ hym in þe cheyne wiþ whiche he may be drawen.

SENTIS NE INQUIT.

[The verthe prose.]

F Elest þou *quod* sche þise þinges *and* entren þei ouzt in þi corage. ¶ Art þou like an asse to þe harpe. Whi wepest þou whi spillest þou teres. ¶ Yif þou abidest after helpe of þi leche. þe byhoueþ discouere þi wounde.

¶ Þo .I. þat hadde gadered strenkeþ in my corage answered[e] *and* seide. *and* nedep it 3itte *quod* .I. of rehersyng or of amonicioun. *and* scheweþ it not ynou3 by hym self þe scharpnes of fortune þat wexeþ woode a3eynes me. ¶ Ne moeueþ it nat þe to seen þe face or þe manere of þis place (.i. prisoun.). ¶ Is þis þe librarie wyche þat þou haddest chosen for a ryzt certeyne sege to þe in myne house. ¶ Pere as þou desputest of[te] wiþ me of þe sciences of þinges touching diuinitee *and* touchyng mankynde. ¶ Was þan myn habit swiche as it is now.

quasi diceret non.

was þan my face or my chere swiche as now. ¶ Whan I souzt[e] wiþ þe secretys of nature. whan þou enfourmedest my maners *and* þe resoun of al my lijf. to þe ensauple of þe ordre of heuene.

ironice

¶ Is nat þis þe gerdoun þat I refere to þe to whom I haue be obeisaunt. ¶ Certis þou enfourmedist by þe mouþe of plato þis sentence. þat is to seyne þat *commune* þinges or comunabletes weren blysfyl yif þei þat haden studied al fully to wisdom gouerneden þilke þinges. or ellys yif it so byfelle þat þe gouernours of *communalites* studieden in grete wisdomes. ¶ Þou saidest eke by þe mouþe of þe same plato þat it was a necessarie cause wyse men to taken *and* desire þe gouernaunce of comune þinges. for þat þe gouernementes of comune citees y-left in þe hondes of felonous *tourmentours* Citizenis ne scholde not brynge inne pestilence *and* destruccioun to goode folk. ¶ And þerfore I folowyng þilk auctoritee (.s. platonis). desiryng to put[te] furþe in excusioun *and* in acte of comune *administracioun* þo þinges þat .I. hadde lerned of þe among my secre restyng whiles. ¶ Þou *and* god þat put[te] þee in þe þouztis of wise folk ben knowen wiþ me þat no þing brouzt[e] me to maistrie or dignite: but þe comune studie of al goodenes. ¶ And þer-of comeþ it þat by-twixen wikked folk *and* me han ben greuouse discordes. þat ne my3ten not be relested by *prayeres*. ¶ For þis libertee haþ fredom of conscience þat þe wrapþe of more my3ty folk haþ alwey ben despised of me for saluacioun of ryzt. ¶ How ofte haue .I. resisted *and* wiþstonde þilk man þat hyzt[e] conigaste þat made alwey assautes a3eins þe *propre* fortunes of poure feble folke. ¶ How ofte haue .I. 3itte put of. or cast out hym trigwille prouost of þe kynges hous boþe of þe wronges þat he hadde bygon[ne] to done *and* eke fully performed. ¶ How ofte haue I couered *and* defended by þe auctorite of

me put azeins perils. þat is to seine put myne auctorite in peril for þe wreched pore folke. þat þe couetise of straungeres vnpunysched tourmentid alwey wiþ myseses *and* greuaunces oute of noumbre. ¶ Neuer man drow me zitte fro ryzt to wrong. When I say þe fortunes *and* þe rychesse of þe people of þe prouinces ben harmed eyþer by priue rauynes or by comune tributis or cariages. as sory was I as þei þat suffred[e] þe harme. *Glosa.* ¶ Whan þat theodoric þe kyng of gothes in a dere zere hadde hys gerneris ful of corne *and* comaundede þat no man ne schold[e] bie no corne til his corne were solde *and* þat at a dere greuous pris. ¶ But I withstod þat ordinaunce *and* ouer-com it knowyng al þis þe kyng hym self. ¶ Coempcioun þat is to seyn comune achat or bying to-gidere þat were establised vpon poeple by swiche a manere imposicioun as who so bouzt[e] a busshel corn he most[e] zeue þe kyng þe fifte part. *Textus.* ¶ Whan it was in þe soure hungry tyme þere was establised or cried greuous *and* inplitable coempcioun þat men seyn wel it schulde greetly tourmentyn *and* endamagen al þe prouince of compaigne I took strif azeins þe prouost of þe pretorie for comune profit. ¶ And þe kyng knowyng of it I ouercom it so þat þe coempcioun ne was not axed ne took effect. ¶ Paulyn a counseiller of Rome þe rychesse of þe whyche paulyn þe houndys of þe palays. þat is to seyn þe officeres wolde han deuoured by hope *and* couetise ¶ Zit drow I hym out of þe lowes .s. faucibus of hem þat gapeden. ¶ And for as myche as þe peyne of þe accusacioun aiuged byforn ne scholde not sodeynly henten ne punischen wrongfully Albyn a counseiller of Rome. I put[te] me azenis þe hates *and* indignaciouns of þe accusour Ciprian. ¶ Is it not þan ynought yseyn þat I haue purchased greet[e] discordes azeins my self. but I aughte be more asseured azenis alle oþer folk þat for þe loue of ryztwisnesse .I. ne reserued[e] neuer no þing to my self to hem ward of þe kynges halle .s. officers. by þe whiche I were þe more syker. ¶ But þoruþ þe same accusours accusyng I am condempned. ¶ Of þe noumbre of whiche accusours one basilius þat somtyme was chased out of þe kynges seruice. is now compelled in accusyng of my name for nede of foreine moneye. ¶ Also opilion *and* Gaudencius han accused me. al be it so þat þe Iustice regal hadde sumtyme demed hem boþe to go in to exil. for her treccheries *and* fraudes wiþ-outen noumbre. ¶ To whiche iugement þei wolde not obeye. but defended[e] hem by sykernesse of holy houses. þat is to seyne fledden in to seyntuaries. *and* whan þis was aperceiued to þe kyng. he comaunded[e] but

þat þei voided[e] þe citee of Rauenne by certeyne day assigned þat men
scholde merken hem on þe forheued wiþ an hoke of iren *and* chasen hem
out of toune. ¶ Now what þing semeþ þe myzt[e] be lykned to þis cruelte.
For certys þilk same day was receyued þe accusyng of my name by þilk[e]
same accusours. ¶ What may be seid herto. haþ my studie *and* my konnyng
deserued þus. or ellys þe forseide dampnacioun of me. made þat hem ryztful
accusours or no (q.d. non). ¶ Was not fortune asshamed of þis. [Certes alle
hadde nat fortune ben asshamyd] þat innocence was accused. 3it auzt[e]
sche haue had schame of þe filþe of myn accusours. ¶ But axest þou in
somme of what gilt .I. am accused. men seyne þat I wolde sauen þe
compaignie of þe senatours. ¶ And desirest þou to here in what manere .I.
am accused þat I scholde han distourbed þe accusour to beren *lettres*. by
whiche he scholde han maked þe senatours guilty azeins þe kynges Real
maieste. ¶ O meistresse what demest þou of þis. schal .I. forsake þis blame
þat I ne be no schame to þe (q. d. non). ¶ Certis .I. haue wold it. þat is to
seyne þe sauuacioun of þe senat. ne I schal neuer leten to wilne it. *and* þat I
confesse *and* am a-knowe. but þe entent of þe accusour to be destourbed
schal cese. ¶ For schal I clepe it a felonie þan or a synne þat I haue desired
þe sauuacioun of þe ordre of þe senat. and certys 3it hadde þilk same senat
don by me þoru3 her decret3 *and* hire iugementys as þou3 it were a synne or
a felonie þat is to seyne to wilne þe sauuacioun of hem (.s. senatus). ¶ But
folye þat lieth alwey to hym self may not chaunge þe merit of þinges. ¶ Ne
.I. trowe not by þe iugement of socrates þat it were leueful to me to hide þe
soþe. ne assent[e] to lesynges. ¶ But certys how so euer it be of þis I put[te]
it to gessen or *preisen* to þe iugement of þe *and* of wise folk. ¶ Of whiche
þing al þe ordinaunce *and* þe soþe for as moche as folk þat ben to comen
aftir oure dayes schollen knowen it. ¶ I haue put it in scripture *and*
remembraunce. for touching þe *lettres* falsly maked. by whiche *lettres* I am
accused to han hooped þe fredom of Rome. What apperteneþ me to speken
þer-of. Of whiche *lettres* þe fraude hadde ben schewed apertly if I hadde
had libertee forto han vsed *and* ben at þe confessioun of myn accusours.
¶ Þe whiche þing in alle nedys haþ grete strenkeþ. ¶ For what oþer fredom
may men hopen. Certys I wolde þat some oþer fredom myzt[e] be hoped.
¶ I wolde þan haue answered by þe wordes of a man þat hyzt[e] Canius. for
whan he was accused by Gayus Cesar Germeins son þat he (canius) was
knowyng *and* consentyng of a coniuracioun maked azeins hym (.s. Gaius).

¶ Dis Canius answered[e] þus. ¶ Yif I had[de] wist it þou haddest not wist it. In whiche þing sorwe haþ not so dulled my witte þat I pleyne oonly þat schrewed[e] folk apparailen folies azeins vertues. ¶ But I wondre gretly how þat þei may performe þinges þat þei had[de] hoped forto done. For why. to wylne schrewednesse þat comeþ paraenture of oure defaute. ¶ But it is lyke to a monstre *and* a meruaille. ¶ How þat in þe present syzt of god may ben acheued *and* performed swiche þinges. as euery felonous man haþ conceyued in hys þouzt azeins innocent. ¶ For whiche þing oon of þi familers not vnskillfully axed þus. ¶ 3if god is. whennes comen wikked[e] þinges. *and* yif god ne is whennes comen goode þinges. but al hadde it ben leueful þat felonous folk þat now desiren þe bloode *and* þe deep of alle goode men. *and* eke of al þe senat han wilned to gone destroien me. whom þei han seyn alwey batailen *and* defenden goode men *and* eke al þe senat. 3it hadde I not desserued of þe fadres. þat is to seyne of þe senatours þat þei scholde wilne my destruccioun. ¶ Þou remembrest wele as I gesse þat whan I wolde don or seyn any þing. þou þi self alwey present reweledest me. ¶ At þe citee of verone whan þat þe kyng gredy of comune slauzter. caste hym to transporten vpon al þe ordre of þe senat. þe gilt of his real maieste of þe whiche gilt þat albyn was accused. wiþ how grete sykernesse of peril to me defended[e] I al þe senat. ¶ Þou wost wel þat I seide soþe. ne I auaunted[e] me neuer in preysyng of my self. ¶ For alwey when any wyzt resceiueþ precieuse renoun in auauntynge hym self of hys werkes: he amenusiþ þe secre of hys conscience. ¶ But now þou mayst wel seen to what ende I am comen for myne innocence. I receiue peyne of fals felonie in gerdoun of verray vertue. ¶ And what open confessioun of felonie had[de] euer iugis so accordaunt in cruelte. þat is to seyne as myne accusyng haþ. ¶ Þat oþer errour of mans witte or ellys condicioun of fortune þat is vncerteyne to al mortal folk ne submytted[e] summe of hem. þat is to seyne þat it ne cheyned[e] summe iuge to han pitee or compassioun. ¶ For al þou3 I had[de] ben accused þat I wolde brenne holy houses. *and* strangle prestys wiþ wicked swerde. ¶ or þat .I. had[de] grayped deep to alle goode men algatis þe sentence scholde han punysched me present confessed or conuict. ¶ But now I am remewed fro þe Citee of rome almost fyue-hundreþ þousand pas. I am wiþ outhen defence dampned to *proscripcioun* *and* to þe deep. for þe studie *and* bountees þat I haue done to þe senat. ¶ But o wel ben þei worþi of mercye (as who seiþ nay.) þer myzt[e] neuer 3it non of

hem ben conuicte. Of swiche a blame as myn is of swiche trespas myn accusours seyen ful wel þe dignitee. þe wiche dignite for þei wolde derken it wiþ medelyng of some felonye. þei beren me on honde *and* lieden. þat I hadde polute *and* defouled my conscience wiþ sacrelege. for couetise of dignite. ¶ And certys þou þi self þat art plaunted in me chacedest oute þe sege of my corage al couetise of mortal þinges. ne sacrilege ne had[de] no leue to han a place in me byforne þine eyen. ¶ For þou drouppedest euery day in myn eeres *and* in my þouzt þilk comaundement of pictogoras. þat is to seyne men schal seruen to god. *and* not to goddes. ¶ Ne it was no couenaunt ne no nede to taken helpe of þe foulest spirites. ¶ I þat þou hast ordeyned or set in syche excellence þat [þou] makedest me lyke to god. and ouer þis þe ryzt clene secre chaumbre of myn house. þat is to seye my wijf *and* þe compaignie of myn honeste frendis. *and* my wyues fadir as wel holy as worþi to ben reuerenced þoruȝ hys owen dedis. defenden me of al suspeccioun of syche blame. ¶ But o malice. ¶ For þei þat accusen me taken of þe philosophie feiþe of so grete blame. ¶ For þei trowen þat .I. haue had affinite to malyfice or enchauntementȝ by cause þat I am replenished *and* fulfilled wiþ þi techynges. *and* enformed of þi maners. ¶ And þus it sufficeþ not only þat þi reuerence ne auayle me not. but ȝif þat þou of þi fre wille raper be blemissid wiþ myne offensioun. ¶ But certys to þe harmes þat I haue þere bytydeþ ȝit þis encrece of harme. þat þe gessinge *and* þe iugement of myche folk ne loken no þing to þe[de]sertys of þinges but only to þe auenture of fortune. ¶ And iugen þat only swiche þinges ben purueied of god. whiche þat temporel welefulnesse commendip. *Glosa.* ¶ As þus þat yif a wyzt haue prosperite. he is a good man *and* worþi to haue þat prosperite. and who so haþ aduersite he is a wikked man. *and* god haþ forsake hym. *and* he is worþi to haue þat aduersite. ¶ Þis is þe opinioun of somme folke. *and* þer of comeþ þat good gessyng. ¶ Fyrste of al þing forsakeþ wrecches certys it greueþ me to þink[e] ryzt now þe dyuerse sentences þat þe poeple seiþ of me. ¶ And þus moche I seye þat þe laste charge of contrarious fortune is þis. þat whan þat ony blame is laid vpon a caytif. men wenen þat he haþ deserued þat he suffreþ. ¶ And I þat am put away from goode men *and* despoiled from dignitees *and* defoulid of my name by gessyng haue suffred torment for my goode dedis. ¶ Certys me semeþ þat I se þe felonus couines of wikked men abunden in ioie *and* in gladnes. ¶ And I se þat euery lorel shapiþ hym to fynde oute newe fraudes

forto accusen goode folke. and I se þat goode men ben ouerbrowen for drede of my peril. ¶ and euery luxurious *tourmentour* dar don alle felonie vnpunissed *and* ben excited þerto by ziftes. and innocent3 ne ben not oonly despoiled of sykernesse but of defence *and* þefore me list to crien to god in þis manere.

O STELLIFERI CONDITOR ORBIS.

[The fifthe metur.]

O þou maker of þe whele þat bereþ þe sterres. whiche þat art fastned to þi perdurable chayere. *and* turnest þe heuene wiþ a rauyssyng sweighe *and* constreimest þe sterres to suffren þi lawe. ¶ So þat þe mone somtyme schynyng wiþ hir ful hornes metyng wiþ alle þe bemes of þe sonne. ¶ Hir broþer hideþ þe sterres þat ben lasse. *and* somtyme whan þe mone pale wiþ hir derke hornes approcheþ þe sonne. leesith hir lyztes. ¶ And þat þe euesterre esperus whiche þat in þe first[e] tyme of þe nyzt bryngeþ furþe hir colde arysynges comeþ eft azeynes hir vsed cours. *and* is pale by þe morwe at þe rysyng of þe sonne. and is þan cleped lucifer. ¶ Þou restrainest þe day by schorter dwellyng in þe tyme of colde wynter þat makeþ þe leues to falle. ¶ Þou diuident þe swifte tides of þe nyzt when þe hote somer is comen. ¶ Þi myzt attempre[þ] þo variaunt3 sesons of þe 3ere. so þat 3epherus þe deboneire wynde bringeþ a3ein in þe first[e] somer sesoun þe leues þat þe wynde þat hyzt[e] boreas haþ reft away in autumpne. þat is to seyne in þe laste eende of somer. and þe sedes þat þe sterre þat hyzt arcturus saw ben waxen hey[e] cornes whan þe sterre sirius eschaufeþ hym. ¶ Þere nis no þing vnbounde from hys olde lawe ne forleteþ hym of hys propre estat. ¶ O þou *gouvernour* gouernyng alle þinges by certeyne ende. why refusest þou oonly to gouerne þe werkes of men by dewe manere. ¶ Whi suffrest þou þat slidyng fortune turneþ to grete vtter chaungynges of þinges. so þat anioius peyne þat scholde duelly punisshe felouns punissit3 innocent3. ¶ And folk of wikked[e] maneres sitten in hei3e chaiers. *and* anoienge folk treden *and* þat vnryztfully in þe nekkes of holy men. ¶ And vertue clere *and* schynyng naturely is hid in dirke dirkenesses. *and* þe ryztful man berip þe blame *and* þe peyne of þe felowne. ¶ Ne þe forsweryng ne þe fraude couered *and* kembd wiþ a fals colour ne a-noyeþ not to schrewes. ¶ Þe whiche schrewes whan hem lyst to vsen her strengþe þei reioisen hem to putten vndir hem þe souerayne kynges. whiche þat poeple

wiþ[outen] noumbre dreden. ¶ O þou what so euer þou be þat knyttes[t] alle bondes of þinges loke on þise wrecched[e] erþes. we men þat ben nat a foule party but a faire party of so grete a werke we ben turmentid in þe see of fortune. ¶ Þou gouvernour wiþdraw *and* restreyne þe rauyssinge flodes *and* fastne *and* forme þise erþes stable wiþ þilke [bonde] wiþ whiche þou gouernest þe heuene þat is so large.

HIC UBI CONTINUATO DOLORE.

[The fyfthe prose.]

Whan I hadde wiþ a continuel sorwe sobbed or broken out þise þinges sche wiþ hir chere peisible *and* no þing amoeued. wiþ my compleyntes seide þus. whan I say þe *quod* sche sorweful *and* wepyng I wist[e] on-one þat þou were a wrecche *and* exiled. but I wist[e] neuer how fer þine exile was: 3if þi tale ne hadde schewed it to me. but certys al be þou fer fro þi contre. þou nart nat put out of it. but þou hast fayled of þi weye *and* gon amys. ¶ *and* yif þou hast leuer forto wene þan þou be put out of þi contre. þan hast þou put oute þi self raþer þen ony oþer wyzt haþ. ¶ For no wyzt but þi self ne myzt[e] neuer haue don þat to þe. ¶ For 3if þou remembre of what contre þou art born. it nis not gouerned by emperoures. ne by gouernement of multitude. as weren þe contres of hem of athenes. ¶ But o lorde *and* o kyng *and* þat is god þat is lorde of þi contree. whiche þat reioiseþ hym of þe dwellyng of hys Citezenis. *and* not forto putte hem in exile. Of þe whiche lorde it is a souerayne fredom to be gouerned by þe bridel of hym *and* obeie to his iustice. ¶ Hast þou for3eten þilke ryzt olde lawe of þi Citee. in þe whiche Citee it is ordeyned *and* establissed þat what wyzt þat haþ leuer founden þer inne hys sete or hys house. þen ellys where: he may not be exiled by no ryzt fro þat place. ¶ For who so þat is contened in-wiþ þe paleis [*and* the clos] of þilke Citee. þer nis no drede þat he may deserue to ben exiled. ¶ But who þat letteþ þe wille forto enhabit[e] þere. he forleteþ also to deserue to ben Citezein of þilke Citee. ¶ So þat I seye þat þe face of þis place ne amoeueþ me nat so myche as þine owen face. Ne .I. ne axe not raþer þe walles of þi librarie apparailled *and* wrouzt wiþ yvory *and* wiþ glas þan after þe sete of þi þouzt. In whiche I putte nat somtyme bookes. but .I. putte þat þat makeþ bookes worþi of *pris* or *precious* þat is to sein þe sentence of my books. ¶ *And* certainly of þi decertes by-stowed in *commune* good. þou hast seid soþe but after þe multitude of þi goode dedys.

þou hast seid fewe. *and* of þe vnhonestee or falsnesse of þinges þat ben opposed azeins þe. þou hast remembred þinges þat ben knowe to alle folk. and of þe felonies *and* fraudes of þine accusours. it semeþ þe haue I-touched it forsoþe ryztfully *and* schortly. ¶ Al myzten þo same þinges bettere *and* more plentiuously be couth in þe mouþe of þe poeple þat knoweþ al þis. ¶ Þou hast eke blamed gretly *and* compleyned of þe wrongful dede of þe senat. ¶ And þou hast sorwed for my blame. *and* þou hast wepen for þe damage of þi renoune þat is appaired. *and* þi laste sorwe eschaufed azeins fortune *and* compleinest þat gerdouns ne ben not euenliche zolde to þe desertes of folk. *and* in þe lattre ende of þi woode muse þou priedest þat þilke pees þat gouerneþ þe heuene scholde gouerne þe erþe ¶ But for þat many tribulaciouns of affecciouns han assailed þe. *and* sorwe *and* Ire *and* wepyng todrawen þee dyuersely ¶ As þou art now feble of þouzt. myztyer remedies ne schullen not zit touchen þe for whiche we wil[e] vsen somedel lyzter medicines. So þat þilk[e] passiouns þat ben woxen harde in swellyng by perturbacioun folowyng in to þi þouzt mowen woxe esy *and* softe to receyuen þe strenkeþ of a more myzty *and* more egre medicine by an esier touchyng.

CUM PHEBI RADIIS GRAUE CANCRI SIDUS [The sixte metur.]
ENESTUAT.

Whan þat þe heuy sterre of þe cancre eschaufed by þe beme of phebus. þat is to seyne whan þat phebus þe sonne is in þe signe of þe Cancre. Who so zeueþ þan largely hys sedes to þe feldes þat refuse to receiuen hem. lete hym gon bygyled of trust þat he hadde to hys corn. to acorns or okes. yif þou wilt gadre violett3. ne go þou not to þe purper wode whan þe felde chirkyng agriseþ of colde by þe felnesse of þe wynde þat hyzt aquilon ¶ Yif þou desirest or wolt vsen grapes ne seke þou nat wiþ a glotonus hande to streine *and* presse þe stalkes of þe vine in þe first somer sesoun. for bachus þe god of wyne haþ raper zeuen his ziftes to autumpne þe latter ende of somer. ¶ God tokeniþ *and* assigneþ þe tymes. ablyng hem to her propre offices. ¶ Ne he ne suffreþ not stoundes whiche þat hym self haþ deuided *and* constreined to be medeled to gidre ¶ And forþi he þat forleteþ certeyne

ordinaunce of doyng by ouerþrowyng wey. he ne haþ no glade issue or ende of hys werkes.

PRIMUM IGITUR PATERIS ROGACIONIBUS. [The syxte prose.]

First wolt þou suffre me to touche *and* assaie þe stat of þi þouzt by a fewe demaundes. so þat I may vnderstonde what be þe manere of þi curacioun. ¶ Axe me *quod* .I. atte þi wille what þou wilt. *and* I schal answer. ¶ Þo saide sche þus. wheþer wenest þou *quod* sche þat þis worlde be gouerned by foolisshe happes *and* fortunes. or elles wenest þou þat þer be in it any gouernement of resoun. Certes *quod* .I. ne trowe not in no manere þat so certeyne þinges scholde be moeued by fortunouse fortune. but I wot wel þat god maker *and* mayster is gouernour of þis werk. Ne neuer nas zit day þat myzt[e] putte me oute of þe soþenesse of þat sentence. ¶ So is it *quod* sche. for þe same þing songe þou a lytel here byforne *and* byweyledest *and* byweptest. þat only men weren put oute of þe cure of god. ¶ For of alle oþer þinges þou ne doutest nat þat þei nere gouerned by reson. but how (.i. pape.). I wondre gretly certes whi þat þou art seek. siþen þou art put in to so holesom a sentence. but lat vs seken depper. I coniecte þat þere lakkeþ I not what. but sey me þis. siþen þat þou ne doutest nat þat þis worlde be gouerned by god ¶ wiþ swycche gouernailes takest þou hede þat it is gouerned. ¶ vnneþ *quod* .I. knowe .I. þe sentence of þi questioun. so þat I ne may nat zit answeren to þi demaundes. ¶ I nas nat deceiued *quod* sche þat þere ne faileþ sumwhat. by whiche þe maladie of perturbacioun is crept in to þi þouzt. so as þe strengþe of þe paleys schynyng is open. ¶ But seye me þis remembrest þou ouzt what is þe ende of þi þinges. whider þat þe entencioun of al kynde tendeth. ¶ I haue herd told it somtyme *quod* .I. but drerynesse haþ dulled my memorie. ¶ Certys *quod* sche þou wost wel whennes þat alle þinges ben comen *and* proceded. I wot wel *quod* .I. *and* answered[e] þat god is þe bygynnyng of al. ¶ And how may þis be *quod* sche þat siþen þou knowest þe bygynnyng of þinges. þat þou ne knowest not what is þe endyng of þinges. but swiche ben þe customes of perturbaciouns. *and* þis power þei han. þat þei may moeue a man fro hys place. þat is to seyne from þe stablenes *and* perfeccioun of hys knowyng. but certys þei may not al arace hym ne alyene hym in al. ¶ But I wolde þat þou woldest answeren to þis. ¶ Remembrest þou þat þou art a man ¶ Boice.

¶ Whi scholde I nat remembre þat *quod* .I. *Philosophie*. ¶ Maiste þou not telle me þan *quod* sche what þing is a man. ¶ Axest not me *quod* I. wheþir þat be a resonable best mortel. I wot wel *and* I confesse wel þat I am it. ¶ Wistest þou neuer 3it þat þou were ony oþer þing *quod* she. No *quod* .I. now wot I *quod* she oþer cause of þi maladie *and* þat ry3t grete ¶ Þou hast left forto knowe þi self what þou art. þoru3 whiche I haue pleynellyche knowen þe cause of þi maladie. or ellis þe entre of recoueryng of þin hele. ¶ Forwhy for þou art confounded wiþ for3etyng of þi self. forþi sorwest þou þat þou art exiled of þi propre goodes. ¶ And for þou ne wost what is þe ende of þinges. for[þi] demest [þou] þat felonous *and* wikked men ben my3ty *and* weleful for þou hast for3eten by whiche gouvernement3 þe worlde is gouerned. ¶ Forþi wenest þou þat þise mutaciouns of fortune fleten wiþ outen gouernour. þise ben grete causes not oonly to maladie. but certes grete causes to deep ¶ But I þanke þe auctour *and* þe makere of heele þat nature haþ not al forleten þe. *and* I haue g[r]ete norissinges of þi hele. *and* þat is þe soþe sentence of gouernaunce of þe worlde. þat þou byleuest þat þe gouernynge of it nis nat subgit ne vnderput to þe folie of þise happes auenterouses. but to þe resoun of god ¶ And þer fore doute þe noþing. For of þis litel spark þine heet of lijf schal shine. ¶ But for as muche as it is not tyme 3itte of fastere remedies ¶ And þe nature of þou3tes disseiued is þis þat as ofte as þei casten awaye soþe opyniouns: þei cloþen hem in fals[e] opyniouns. [of whiche false opyniouns] þe derknesse of perturbacioun wexep vp. þat comfoundeþ þe verray insy3t. *and* þat derkenes schal .I. say somewhat to maken þinne *and* wayk by ly3t *and* meenelyche remedies. so þat after þat þe derknes of desseyuynge desyrynges is don away. þou mow[e] knowe þe schynyng of verray ly3t.

NUBIBUS ATRIS CONDITA.

[The seuende Metyr.]

ÞE sterres couered wiþ blak[e] cloudes ne mowen geten a doun no ly3t. 3if þe trouble wynde þat hy3t auster stormynge *and* walwyng þe see medleþ þe heete þat is to seyne þe boylyng vp from þe botme ¶ Þe wawes þat somtyme weren clere as glas *and* lyke to þe fair[e] bry3t[e] dayes wiþstant anon þe sy3tes of men. by þe filþe *and* ordure þat is resolved. *and* þe fletyng streme þat royleþ doun dyuersely fro heyze mountaignes is arestid *and* resisted ofte tyme by þe encountrynge of a stoon þat is departid

and fallen from some roche. ¶ And forþi yif þou wilt loken *and* demen soþe wiþ clere lyzt. *and* holde þe weye wiþ a ryzt pape. ¶ Weyue þou ioie. drif fro þe drede. fleme þou hope. ne lat no sorwe aproche. þat is to sein lat noon of þise four passiouns ouer come þe. or blynde þe. for cloudy *and* dirke is þilk þouzt *and* bounde with bridles. where as þise þinges regnen.

EXPLICIT LIBER PRIMUS.

INCIPIT LIBER SECUNDUS.

POSTEA [PAU]LISPER CONTICUIT.

[The fyrst prose.]

After þis she stynte a litel. and after þat she hadde gadred by atempre stillenesse myn attencioun she seide þus. ¶ As who so myzt[e] seye þus. After þise þinges she stynt[e] a lytel. *and* whanne she aperceiued[e] by atempre stillenesse þat I was ententif to herkene hire. she bygan to speke in þis wyse. ¶ Yif I *quod* she haue vnderstonden *and* knowe vtterly þe causes *and* þe habit of þi maladie. þou languissed *and* art deffeted for talent *and* desijr of þi raþer fortune. ¶ She þat ilke fortune only þat is chaunged as þou feinst to þe ward. haþ peruerted þe clerenesse *and* þe astat of þi corage. ¶ I vnderstonde þe felefolde colour *and* deceites of þilke merueillous monstre fortune. and how she vseþ ful flatryng familiarite wiþ hem þat she enforceþ to bygyle. so longe til þat she confounde wiþ vnsuffreable sorwe hem þat she haþ left in despeir vnpurueyed. ¶ and if þou remembrest wel þe kynde þe maners *and* þe desert of þilke fortune. þow shalt wel knowe as in hir þou neuer ne haddest ne hast ylost any fair þing. But as I trowe I shal not gretly trauaile to don þe remembren of þise þinges. ¶ For þou were wont to hurtlen [*and* despysen] hir wiþ manly wordes whan she was blaundissinge *and* presente *and* pursewedest hir wiþ sentences þat were drawn oute of myne entre. þat is to seyne out of myn informacioun ¶ But no sudeyne mutacioun ne bytideþ nat wiþ outhen a maner chaungyng of curages. and so is it byfallen þat þou art departed a litel fro þe pees of þi þouzt. but now is tyme þat þou drynke *and* atast[e] some softe *and* delitable þinges. so þat whan þei ben entred wiþ inne þe. it mow make weye to strengre drynkes of

medycynes. ¶ Com nowe furþe þerfore þe suasioun of swetnesse Rethoryen.
whiche þat goþ oonly þe ryȝt wey whil she forsakeþ not myne estatutȝ.
¶ And wiþ Rethorice com forþe musice a damoisel of oure house þat syngeþ
now lyȝter moedes or prolaciouns now heuyer. what ayleþ þe man. what is
it þat haþ cast þe in to murnyng *and* in to wepyng. I trow[e] þat þou hast
sen some newe þing *and* uncouþe. ¶ Þou wenest þat fortune be chaunged
aȝeins þe ¶ But þou wenest wrong. yif þou [þat] wene. Alwey þo ben hire
maners. she haþ raper [kept] as to þe ward hire propre stablenes in þe
chaungyng of hyre self. ¶ Ryȝt swyche was she whan she flatered[e] þe. *and*
desseiued[e] þe wiþ vnleueful lykynges of false welefulnesse. þou hast now
known *and* ataynt þe doutous or double visage of þilke blynde goddesse
fortune. ¶ She þat ȝit couereþ hir *and* wympleþ hir to oþer folk. haþ shewed
hir euerydel to þe. ¶ Ȝif þou approuest hir *and* þenkest þat she is good. vse
hir maners *and* pleyne þe nat. ¶ And if þou agrisest hir fals[e] trecherie.
dispiȝe *and* cast aweye hir þat pleyeþ so harmefully. for she þat is now
cause of so myche sorwe to þe. sholde be to þe cause of pees *and* [of] ioie.
¶ she haþ forsaken þe forsoþe. þe whiche þat neuer man may be syker þat
she ne shal forsake hym. *Glose.* ¶ But napeles some bookes han þe text þus.
For soþe she haþ forsaken þe ne þer nis no man syker þat she ne haþ not
forsaken. ¶ Holdest þou þan þilke welefulnesse precieuse to þe þat shal
passen. *and* is present fortune derworþi to þe. whiche þat nis not feiþful
forto dwelle. *and* whan she goþ aweye þat she bryngeþ a wyȝt in sorwe
¶ For syn she may nat be wiþholden at a mans wille. she makeþ hym a
wrecche when she departeþ fro hym. ¶ What oþer þing is flitting fortune
but a manere shewyng of wrycchednesse þat is to comen. ne it ne suffriþ nat
oo[n]ly to loken of þing þat is present byforne þe eyen of man. but wisdom
lokeþ *and* mesureþ þe ende of þinges. *and* þe same chaungyng from one to
an oþer. þat is to seyne fro aduersite to prosperite makeþ þat þe manaces of
fortune ne ben not forto dreden. ne þe flatrynges of hir to ben desired. ¶ Þus
atte þe last it byhoueþ þe to suffren wiþ euene wille in pacience al þat is don
inwiþ þe floor of fortune. þat is to seyne in þis worlde. ¶ Syþen þou hast
oonen put þi nekke vnder þe ȝokke of hir. for if þou wilt write a lawe of
wendyng *and* of dwellyng to fortune whiche þat þou hast chosen frely to be
þi lady ¶ Art þou nat wrongful in þat *and* makest fortune wroþe *and* aspere
by þin inpacience. *and* ȝit þou mayst not chaungen hir. ¶ Yif þou committest
[*and*] bitakest þi sayles to þe wynde. þou shalt be shouen not þider þat þou

woldest(:) but whider þat þe wynde shoueþ þe ¶ Yif þou castest þi seedes in þe feldes þou sholdest haue in mynde þat þe 3eres ben oþer while plenteuous *and* oþer while bareyne. ¶ Þou hast bytaken þiself to þe gouernaunce of fortune. *and* forþi it byhoueþ þe to ben obeisaunt to þe manere of þi lady. and enforcest þou þe to aresten or wiþstonden þe swyftnesse *and* þe sweyes of hir tournyng whele. ¶ O þou fool of alle mortel fooles if fortune bygan to dwelle stable. she cesed[e] þan to ben fortune.

HEC CUM SUPERBA.

[The fyrst metur.]

Whan fortune wiþ a proude ryzt hande haþ turnid hir chaungyng stoundes she fareþ lyke þe maners of þe boillyng eurippe. *Glose.* Eurippe is an arme of þe see þat ebbith *and* flowiþ. *and* somtyme þe streme is on one syde *and* somtyme on þat oþer. *Texte* ¶ She cruel fortune kastep adoune kynges þat somtyme weren ydred. *and* she deceiuable enhaunseth vp þe humble chere of hym þat is discomfited. *and* she neyþer hereþ ne reccheþ of wrecched[e] wepynges. *and* she is so harde þat she lau3eþ *and* scorneþ þe wepyng of hem þe whiche she haþ maked wepe wiþ hir free wille. ¶ Þus she pleyeþ *and* þus she preueþ hir strengþe *and* sheweþ a grete wondre to alle hir seruau3t3. ¶ Yif þat a wyzt is seyn weleful *and* ouerþrowe in an houre.

VELLEM AUTEM PAUCA.

[The secunde prose.]

CErtis I wolde plete wiþ þee a fewe þinges vsynge þe wordes of fortune tak heede now þi self. yif þat she axeþ ryzt. ¶ O þou man wher fore makest þou me gilty by þine euerydayes pleynynge. what wronges haue I don þe. what goodes haue I byreft þe þat weren þine. stryf or plete wiþ me by fore what iuge þat þou wilt of þe possessioun of rycchesse or of dignites ¶ And yif þou maist shewe me þat euer any mortal man haþ receyued any of þese þinges to ben his in propre. þan wol I graunt[e] frely þat [alle] þilke þinges weren þine whiche þat þou axest. ¶ Whan þat nature brou3t[e] þe forþe out of þi moder wombe. I receyued[e] þe naked *and* nedy of al þing. *and* I norysshed[e] þe wiþ my rychesse. *and* was redy *and* ententif þoru3 my fauour to sustene þe. ¶ And þat makeþ þe now inpacient azeins me. *and*

I enviournde þe wiþ al þe habundaunce *and* shynyng of al goodes þat ben in my ryzt. ¶ Now it lykeþ me to wiþ drawe myne hande. þou hast had grace as he þat haþ vsed of foreyne goodes. þou hast no ryzt to pleyne þe. as þou3 þou haddest vtterly lorn alle þi þinges. whi pleyneþ þou þan. I haue don þe no wrong. Ricches honoures *and* swyche oþer þinges ben of my ryzt. ¶ My seruauntes knowen me for hir lady. þei comen wiþ me *and* departen whan I wende. I dar wel affermen hardyly. þat yif þo þinges of whiche þou pleyneþ þat þou hast forlorn hadde ben þine. þou ne haddest not lorn hem. ¶ shal I þan only be defended to vse my ryzt. ¶ Certis it is leueful to þe heuene to make clere dayes. *and* after þat to keuere þe same dayes wiþ derke nyztes. ¶ Þe erþe haþ eke leue to appaile þe visage of þe erþe now *with* floures *and* now wiþ fruyt. *and* to confounde hem somtyme wiþ raynes *and* wiþ coldes. ¶ Þe see haþ eke hys ryzt to be somtyme calme *and* blaundyshing wiþ smoþe water. *and* somtyme to be horrible wiþ wawes *and* wiþ tempestes. ¶ But þe couetyse of men þat may not be staunched shal it bynde me to be stedfast. syn þat stedfastnesse is vnkouþ to my maneres. ¶ Swyche is my strengþe. *and* þis pley. I pley[e] continuely. I tourne þe whirlyng whele wiþ þe tournyng cercle ¶ I am glade to chaunge þe lowest to þe heyeste. *and* þe heyest to þe loweste. worþe vþ yif þou wilt. so it be by þis lawe. þat þou ne holde not þat I do þe wronge þou3 þou descende doun whanne resoun of my pleye axeþ it. Wost þou not how Cresus kyng of lyndens of whiche kyng Cirus was ful sore agast a litel byforne þat þis rewlyche Cresus was cau3t of Cirus *and* lad to þe fijr to be brent. but þat a reyne descended[e] doun from heuene þat rescowed[e] hym ¶ And is it out of þi mynde how þat Paulus consul of Rome whan he hadde take þe kyng of perciens weep pitou[s]ly for þe captiuitee of þe self[e] kyng. What oþer þinges bywaylen þe criinges of Tragedies. but only þe dedes of fortune. þat wiþ an vnwar stroke ouerturneþ þe realmes of grete nobley ¶ *Glose.* Tragedie is to seyne a dite of a prosperite for a tyme þat endiþ in wrechednesse. Leredest nat þou in grek whan þou were 3onge þat in þe entre or in þe seler of Iuppiter þer ben couched two tunnes. þat on is ful of good þat oþer is ful of harme. ¶ What ryzt hast þou to pleyne. yif þou hast taken more plenteuously of þe goode syde þat is to seyne of my rycchesse *and* prosperites. *and* what eke. yif I be nat departed fro þe. What eke. yif my mutabilitee 3iueþ þe ryztful cause of hope to han 3it better þinges.

¶ Napeles desmaie þe nat in þi þouȝt. and þou þat art put in comune realme of alle: ne desir[e] nat to lyue by þine oonly propre ryȝt.

SI QUANTAS RAPIDIS.

[the secunde metur.]

Þouȝ plentee þat is goddesse of rycches hielde adoun wiþ ful horn. *and* wiþdraweþ nat hir hand. ¶ As many recches as þe see turneþ vpwardes sandes whan it is moeued wiþ rauysshing blastes. or ellys as many rycches as þer shynen bryȝt[e] sterres on heuene on þe sterry nyȝt. Ȝit for al þat mankynde nolde not cesce to wope wrecched[e] pleyntes. ¶ And al be it so þat god receyueþ gladly her *prayers* *and* ȝeueþ hem as ful large muche golde *and* apparaileþ coueytous folk wiþ noble or clere honours. ȝit semeþ hem haue I-gete noþing. but alwey her cruel ravyne deuourynge al þat þei han geten shewiþ oþer gapinges. þat is to seye gapen *and* desiren ȝit after moo rycchesse. ¶ What brideles myȝten wiþholde to any certeyne ende þe desordene coueitise of men ¶ Whan euere þe raþer þat it fletiþ in large ȝiftis: þe more ay brenneþ in hem þe þrest of hauyng. ¶ Certis he þat quakyng *and* dredeful weneþ hym seluen nedy. he ne lyueþ neuere mo ryche.

HIIS IGITUR SI PRO SE.

[The thrydde prose.]

Þerfore yif þat fortune spake wiþ þe for hir self in þis manere. For soþe þou ne haddest [nat] what þou myȝtest answee. and if þou hast any þing wherwiþ. þou mayist ryȝtfully tellen þi compleynt. ¶ It byhoueþ þe to shewen it. *and* .I. wol ȝeue þe space to tellen it. ¶ Certeynely *quod* I þan þise ben faire þinges *and* enoyntid wiþ hony swetnesse of rethorike *and* musike. *and* only while þei ben herd þei ben deliciouse. ¶ But to wrecches is a deppere felyng of harme. þis is to seyn þat wrecches felen þe harmes þat þei suffren more greuously þan þe remedies or þe delites of þise wordes mowe gladen or comforten hem. so þat whan þise þinges stynten forto soun[e] in eres. þe sorwe þat is inset greueþ þe þouȝt. Ryȝt so is it *quod* she. ¶ For þise ne ben ȝit none remedies of þi maladie. but þei ben a manere norissinges of þi sorwe ȝit rebel aȝeyne þi curacioun. ¶ For whan þat tyme is. I shal moue swiche þinges þat percen hem self depe. ¶ But napeles þat þou shalt not wilne to leten þi self a wrecche. ¶ Hast þou forȝeten þe

noumbre *and* þe manere of þi welefulnesse. I holde me stille how þat þe souerayn men of þe Citee token þe in cure *and* kepyng when þou were orphelyn of fadir *and* modir. *and* were chosen in affinite of princes of þe Citee. ¶ And þou bygunne raper to ben leef *and* deere þan0 forto ben a ney3bour. þe whiche þing is þe most preciouſe kynde of any propinquitee or aliaunce þat may ben. ¶ Who is it þat ne seide þou nere ry3t weleful wiþ so grete a nobley of þi fadres in lawe. ¶ *And* wiþ þe chastite of þi wijf. *and* wiþ þe oportunitie *and* noblesse of þi masculyn children. þat is to seyne þi sones *and* ouer al þis me lyst to passe of comune þinges. ¶ How þou haddest in þi þou3t dignitees þat weren warned to olde men. but it deliteþ me to comen now to þe singuler vphepyng of þi welefulnesse. ¶ Yif any fruyt of mortal þinges may han any wey3te or price of welefulnesse. ¶ My3test þou euere for3eten for any charge of harme þat my3t[e] byfallen. þe remembraunce of þilke day þat þou sey[e] þi two sones maked conseillers. *and* ylad to gidre from þin house vnder so gret assemble of senatours. *and* vnder þe blybenesse of poeple. *and* when þou say[e] hem sette in þe court in her chaires of dignites. ¶ Pou rethorien or pronouncere of kynges preysinges. deseruedest glorie of wit *and* of eloquence. when þou sitting bytwix þi two sones conseillers in þe place þat hy3t Circo. *and* fulfildest þe abydyng of multitude of poeple þat was sprad about þe wiþ large praysynge *and* laude as men synge in victories. þo 3aue þou wordes of fortune as I trowe. þat is to seyne. þo feffedest þou fortune wiþ glosynge wordes *and* desseiuedest hir. when she accoied[e] þe *and* norsshed[e] þe as hir owen delices. ¶ Pou hast had of fortune a 3ifte þat is to seyn swiche gerdoun þat she neu[er]e 3af to preue man ¶ Wilt þou þefore leye a rekenyng wiþ fortune. she haþ now twynkeled first vpon þe wiþ a wykkeð eye. ¶ Yif þou considere þe noumbre *and* þe manere of þi blysses. *and* of þi sorwes. þou maist nat forsake þat þou nart 3it blysfyl. For if þou þefore wenest þi self nat weleful for þinges þat þo semeden ioyful ben passed. ¶ Þer nis nat whi þou sholdest wene þi self a wrecche. for þinges þat now semen soory passen also. ¶ Art þou now comen firste a sodeyne gest in to þe shadowe or tabernacle of þis lijf. or trowest þou þat any stedfastnesse be in mannish þinges. ¶ Whan ofte a swifte houre dissolueþ þe same man. þat is to seyne when þe soule departiþ fro þe body. For al þou3 þat yelde is þer any feiþ þat fortunous þinges willen dwelle. 3it napeles þe last[e] day of a mannish lijf is a manere deef to fortune. *and* also to þilke þat haþ dwelt. *and*

þerfore what wenist þou þar recche yif þou forlete hir in deyng or ellys þat she fortune forlete þe in fleenge away.

CUM PRIMO POLO.

[The .iiij. Metur.]

Whan phebus þe sonne bygynneþ to spreden his clerenesse *with* rosene chariettes. þan þe sterre ydimmyd paleþ hir white cheres. by þe flamus of þe sonne þat ouer comeþ þe sterre lyzt. ¶ Dis is to seyn whan þe sonne is risen þe day sterre wexiþ pale *and* lesiþ hir lyzt for þe grete bryztnesse of þe sonne. ¶ Whan þe wode wexeþ redy of rosene floures in þe first somer sesoun þoruþ þe breþe of þe wynde Zephirus þat wexeþ warme. ¶ Yif þe cloudy wynde auster blowe felliche. þan goþ away þe fayrnesse of þornes. Ofte þe see is clere *and* calme wiþoute moeuyng floodes. And ofte þe horrible wynde aquilon moeueþ boylyng tempestes *and* ouer whelweþ þe see. ¶ Yif þe forme of þis worlde is so [zeelde] stable. *and* yif it tourniþ by so many entrechaungynges. wilt þou þan trusten in þe trublyng fortune of men. wilt þou trowen in flittyng goodes. It is certeyne *and* establissed by lawe perdurable þat no þing þat is engendred nys stedfast no stable.

TUNC EGO UERA INQUAM.

[The ferthe prose.]

PAnne seide I þus. O norice of alle uertues þou seist ful soþe. ¶ Ne I may nat forsake þe ryzt[e] swifte cours of my prosperitee. þat is to seine. þat prosperitee ne be comen to me wondir swiftly *and* soone. but þis is a þing þat gretly smertiþ me whan it remembreþ me. ¶ For in alle aduersitees of fortune þe most vnsely kynde of contrariouse fortune is to han ben weleful. ¶ But þat þou *quod* she abaist þus þe tourment of þi fals[e] opinioun þat maist þou not ryztfully blamen ne aretten to þinges. as who seiþ for þou hast zitte many habundaunces of þinges. ¶ *Textus*. For al be it so þat þe ydel name of auenterouse welefulnesse moeueþ þe now. it is leueful þat þou rekene *with* me of how many[e] þinges þou hast zit plentee. ¶ And þerfore yif þat þilke þing þat þou haddest for most precious in alle þi rycchesse of fortune be kept to þe by þe grace of god vnwemmed *and* vndefouled. Mayst þou þan pleyne ryztfully vpon þe myschief of fortune. syn þou hast zit þi best[e] þinges. ¶ Certys zit lyueþ in goode poynt þilke precious honour of mankynde. ¶ Symacus þi wyues fadir whiche þat is a man maked al of

sapience *and* of vertue. þe whiche man þou woldest b[i]en redely wiþ þe pris of þin owen lijf. he byweyleþ þe wronges þat men don to þee. *and* not for hym self. for he liueþ in sykernesse of any sentence put azeins him.

¶ And 3it lyueþ þi wif þat is attempre of witte *and* passyng oþer women in clennes of chastitee. and for I wol closen shortly her bountes she is lyke to hir fadir. I telle þe welle þat she lyueþ loop of hir life. *and* kepib to þee oonly hir goost. *and* is al maat *and* ouer-comen by wepyng *and* sorwe for desire of þe ¶ In þe whiche þing only I mot graunten þat þi welefulnesse is amenused. ¶ What shal I seyn eke of þi two sones conseilours of whiche as of children of hir age þer shineþ þe lyknesse of þe witte of hir fadir *and* of hir eldefadir. and siþen þe souereyn cure of alle mortel folke is to sauen hir owen lyues. ¶ O how weleful art þou þou3 þou knowe þi goodes. ¶ But 3itte ben þer þinges dwellyng to þe wardes þat no man douteþ þat þei ne ben more derworþe to þe þen þine owen lijf. ¶ And forþi drie þi teres for 3itte nys nat eueriche fortune al hateful to þe warde. ne ouer greet tempest haþ nat 3it fallen vpon þe. whan þat þin ances cliue fast[e] þat neiþer wole suffre þe comfort of þis tyme present. ne þe hope of tyme comynge to passen ne to fallen. ¶ And I preie *quod* I þat fast[e] mot[en] þei holden. ¶ For whiles þat þei halden. how so euere þat þinges ben. I shal wel fleten furþe and eschafen. ¶ But þou mayst wel seen how greet[e] apparailes *and* aray þat me lakkeþ þat ben passed away fro me. ¶ I haue somewhat auanced *and* forþered þe *quod* she. if þat þou anoie nat or forþenke nat of al þi fortune. As who seiþ. ¶ I haue somewhat comforted þe so þat þou tempest nat þe þus wiþ al þi fortune. syn þou hast 3it þi best[e] þinges. ¶ But I may nat suffre þin delices. þat pleinst so wepyng. *and* anguissous for þat oþer lakkeþ somewhat to þi welefulnesse. ¶ For what man is so sad or of so perfit welefulnesse. þat he ne stryueþ or pleyneþ on some half azeine þe qualitee of his estat. ¶ For whi ful anguissous þing is þe condicioun of mans goodes. ¶ For eyþer it comeþ al to gidre to a wy3t. or ellys it lasteþ not perpetuely. ¶ For som man haþ grete rycchesse. but he is asshamed of hys vngentil lynage. *and* som man is renommed of noblesse of kynrede. but he is enclosed in so grete angre for nede of þinges. þat hym were leuer þat he were vnknowe. and som man habundeþ boþe in rychesse *and* noblesse. but 3it he bywaileþ hys chast[e] lijf. for he haþ no wijf. ¶ and som man is wel *and* selily married but he haþ no children. *and* norissheþ his ricchesse to þe heires of straunge folk. ¶ And som man is gladded wiþ children. but he

wepiþ ful sory for þe trespas of his son or of his douȝtir. ¶ and for þis þer accordeþ no wyȝt lyȝtly to þe condicioun of his fortune. for alwey to euery man þere is in mest somewhat þat vnassaieþ he ne wot not or ellys he dredieþ þat he haþ assaied. ¶ And adde þis also þat euery weleful man haþ a wel delicat felyng. ¶ So þat but yif alle þinges fallen at hys owen wille for he impacient or is nat vsed to han none aduersitee. an-oone he is þrowe adoũne for euery lytel þing. ¶ And ful lytel þinges ben þo þat wiþdrawen þe somme or þe perfeccioun of blisfulnesse fro hem þat ben most fortunat. ¶ How many men trowest þou wolde demen hem self to ben almost in heuene yif þei myȝten atteyne to þe leest[e] partie of þe remenaunt of þi fortune. ¶ Þis same place þat þou clepist exil is contre to hem þat enhabiten here. *and* forþi. Noþing wrecched. but whan þou wenest it ¶ As who seip. þouȝ þi self ne no wyȝt ellys nys no wrecche but whan he wenep hym self a wrecche by reputacioun of his corage.

CONTRAQUE.

And aȝeinewarde al fortune is blisful to a man by þe agreablete or by þe egalite of hym þat suffreþ it. ¶ What man is þat. þat is so weleful þat nolde chaungen his estat whan he haþ lorn pacience. þe swetnesse of mannes welefulnesse is yspranid wiþ many[e] bitternesses. þe whiche welefulnesse al þouȝ it seme swete *and* ioieful to hym þat vseþ it. ȝit may it not be wiþ-holden þat it ne goþ away whan it wol. ¶ Þan is it wel sen how wrecched is þe blisfulnesse of mortel þinges. þat neiþer it dwelliþ perpetuel wiþ hem þat euery fortune receyuen agreablely or egaly. ¶ Ne it ne deliteþ not in al. to hem þat ben anguissous. ¶ O ye mortel folkes what seke ȝe þan blisfulnesse oute of ȝoure self. whiche þat is put in ȝoure self. *Error and folie confoundeþ ȝow* ¶ I shal shewe þe shortly. þe poynt of souereyne blisfulnesse. Is þer any þing to þe more precieuse þan þi self ¶ Þou wilt answer nay. ¶ Þan if it so be þat þou art myȝty ouer þi self þat is to seyn by tranquillitee of þi soule. þan hast þou þing in þi power þat þou noldest neuer lesen. ne fortune may nat by-nyme it þe. *and* þat þou mayst knowe þat blisfulnesse [ne] may nat standen in þinges þat ben fortunous *and* temperel. ¶ Now vndirstonde *and* gadir it to gidir þus yif blisfulnesse be þe souereyne goode of nature þat liueþ by resoun ¶ Ne þilke þing nis nat souereyne goode þat may be taken away in any wyse. for more worþi þing *and* more digne is

þilke þing þat may nat be taken away. ¶ Þan shewiþ it wele þat þe
 vnstablenesse of fortune may nat attayne to receyue verray blisfulnes.
 ¶ And ȝit more ouer. ¶ What man þat þis toublyng welefulnesse leediþ.
 eiþer he woot þat [it] is chaungeable. or ellis he woot it nat. ¶ And yif he
 woot it not. what blisful fortune may þer be in þe blyndenesse of
 ignoraunce. and yif he woot þat it is chaungeable. he mot alwey ben adrad
 þat he ne lese þat þing. þat he ne douteþ nat but þat he may leesen it. ¶ As
 whoo seiþ he mot ben alwey agast lest he leese þat he wot wel he may
 leese. ¶ For whiche þe continuel drede þat he haþ ne suffriþ hym nat to ben
 weleful. ¶ Or ellys yif he leese it he wene to be dispised *and* forleten hit.
 ¶ Certis eke þat is a ful lytel goode þat is born wiþ euene hert[e] whan it is
 loost. ¶ Þat is to seyne þat men don no more force. of þe lost þan of þe
 hauynge. ¶ And for as myche as þou þi self art he to whom it haþ ben
 shewid *and* proued by ful many[e] demonstraciouns. as I woot wel þat þe
 soules of men ne mowen nat dien in no wise. and eke syn it is clere. *and*
 certeyne þat fortunous welefulnesse endiþ by þe deep of þe body. ¶ It may
 nat ben doutid þat yif þat deep may take away blysfulnesse þat al þe kynde
 of mortal þingus ne descendiþ in to wrecchednesse by þe ende of þe deep.
 ¶ And syn we knowen wel þat many a man haþ souȝt þe fruit of blisfulnesse
 nat only wiþ suffryng of deep. but eke wiþ suffryng of peynes *and*
tourmentes. how myȝt[e] þan þis present lijf make men blisful. syn þat
 whanne þilke self[e] lijf is endid. it ne makeþ folk no wrecches.

QUISQUIS UOLET PERHENNEM CAUTUS. [The ferthe metur.]

What maner man stable *and* war þat wil founden hym a *perdurable* sete
and ne wil not be cast doune wiþ þe loude blastes of þe wynde Euris.
and wil dispise þe see manassyng wiþ floodes ¶ Lat hym eschewe to bilde
 on þe cop of þe mountayngne. or in þe moyste sandes. ¶ For þe fel[le]
 wynde auster *tourment* þe cop of þe mountayngne wiþ alle his strengþes.
 ¶ *and* þe lowe see sandes refuse to beren þe heuy weyȝte. *and* forþi yif þou
 wolt flee þe *perilous* auenture þat is to seine of þe worlde ¶ Haue mynde
 certeynly to ficchyn þi house of a myrie site in a lowe stoone. ¶ For al þouȝ
 þe wynde troubyng þe see þondre wiþ ouereþrowynges ¶ Þou þat art put in
 quiete *and* welful by strengþe of þi palys shalt leden a cleer age. scornynge
 þe wodenesses *and* þe Ires of þe eir.

But for as moche as þe noryssinges of my resouns descenden now in to þe. I trowe it were tyme to vsen a litel strengre medicynes. ¶ Now vndirstonde here al were it so þat þe ziftis of fortune nar[e] nat brutel ne transitorie. what is þer in hem þat may be þine in any tyme. or ellis þat it nys foule if þat it be considered *and* lokid *perfitely*. ¶ Richesse ben þei precieuse by þe nature of hem self. or ellys by þe nature of þe. What is most worþi of rycchesse. is it nat golde or myzt of moneye assembled. ¶ Certis þilke golde *and* þilke moneye shineþ *and* zeueþ better renoun to hem þat dispenden it. þen to þilke folke þat mokeren it. For auarice makeþ alwey mokeres to be hated. *and* largesse makeþ folke clere of renoun ¶ For syn þat swiche þing as is *transferred* from o man to an oþer ne may nat dwellen wiþ no man. Certis þan is þilke moneye *precious*. whan it is translated in to oþer folk. *and* stynted to ben had by vsage of large zeuyng of hym þat haþ zeuen it. *and* also yif al þe moneye þat is ouer-al in þe world were gadered towar[d] o man. it sholde maken al oþer men to ben nedy as of þat. ¶ And certys a voys al hool þat is to seyn wiþ-oute amenusynge fulfilled to gyder þe heryng of myche folke. but Certys zoure rycchesse ne mowen nat passen vnto myche folk wiþ-oute amenussyng ¶ And whan þei ben apassed. nedys þei maken hem pore þat forgon þe rycchesses. ¶ O streite *and* nedy clepe I þise rycchesses. syn þat many folke [ne] may nat han it al. ne al may it nat comen to on man wiþ-oute pouerte of al oþer folke. ¶ And þe shynynge of gemmes þat I clepe *precieuse* stones. draweþ it nat þe eyen of folk in to hem warde. þat is to seyne for þe beaute. ¶ For certys yif þer were beaute or bounte in shynynge of stones. þilke clerenesse is of þe stones hem self. *and* nat of men. ¶ For whiche I wondre gretly þat men merueilen on swiche þinges. ¶ For whi what þing is it þat yif it wanteþ moeuyng *and* ioynture of soule *and* body þat by ryzt myzt[e] semen a faire creature to hym þat haþ a soule of resoun. ¶ For al be it so þat gemmes drawn to hem self a litel of þe laste beaute of þe worlde. þoruþ þe entent of hir creatour *and* þoruþ þe distinccioun of hem self. zit for as myche as þei ben put vndir zoure excellence. þei han not desserued by no weye þat ze shullen merueylen on hem. ¶ And þe beaute of feeldes deliteþ it nat mychel vnto zow. *Boyce*. ¶ Whi sholde it nat deliten vs. syn þat it is a ryzt fayr porcioun of þe ryzt fair werk. þat is to seyn of þis worlde. ¶ And ryzt so ben we gladed

somtyme of þe face of þe see whan it is clere. And also merueylen we on þe heuene *and* on þe sterres. *and* on þe sonne. *and* on þe mone. *Philosophie.*

¶ Apperteineþ quod she any of þilke þinges to þe. whi darst þou glorifie þe in þe shynynge of any swiche þinges. Art þou distingwed *and* embelised by þe spryngyng floures of þe first somer sesoun. or swellip þi plente in fruytes of somer. whi art þou rauyshed wiþ ydel ioies. why embracest þou straunge goodes as þei weren þine. Fortune shal neuer maken þat swiche þinges ben þine þat nature of þinges maked foreyne fro þe. ¶ Syche is þat wiþ-uten doute þe fruytes of þe erþe owen to ben on þe norssinge of bestes. ¶ And if þou wilt fulfille þi nede after þat it suffiseþ to nature þan is it no nede þat þou seke after þe superfluite of fortune. ¶ For wiþ ful fewe þinges *and* with ful lytel þing nature halt hire appaied. *and* yif þou wilt achoken þe fulfillyng of nature wiþ superfluites ¶ Certys þilke þinges þat þou wilt presten or pouren in to nature shullen ben vnioyeful to þe or ellis anoies.

¶ Wenest þou eke þat it be a fair þinge to shine wiþ dyuerse cloþing. of whiche cloþing yif þe beaute be agreable to loken vpon. I wol merueylen on þe nature of þe matere of þilke cloþes. or ellys on þe werkeman þat wrouzt[e] hem. but al so a longe route of meyne. makip þat a blisful man. þe whiche seruauntes yif þei ben vicioũs of condiciouns it is a greet charge *and* a destruccioun to þe house. *and* a greet enmye to þe lorde hym self

¶ *And* yif þei ben goode men how shal straung[e] or foreyne goodenes ben put in þe noubre of þi rycchesse. so þat by alle þise forseide þinges. it is clerly shewed þat neuer none of þilke þinges þat þou accoumptedest for þin goodes nas nat þi goode. ¶ In þe whiche þinges yif þer be no beaute to ben desired. whi sholdest þou be sory yif þou leese hem. or whi sholdest þou reioysen þe to holden hem. ¶ For if þei ben fair of hire owen kynde. what apperteneþ þat to þe. for as wel sholde þei han ben faire by hem self. þou3 þei weren departid from alle þin rycchesse. ¶ For-why faire ne precioũs ne weren þei nat. for þat þei comen amonges þi rycchesse. but for þei semeden fair *and* precious. þerfore þou haddest leuer rekene hem amonges þi rycchesse. but what desirest þou of fortune wiþ so greet a noyse *and* wiþ so greet a fare ¶ I trowe þou seke to dryue away nede wiþ habundaunce of þinges. ¶ But certys it turneþ to 3ow al in þe contrarie. for whi certys it nedip of ful many[e] helpynges to kepen þe dyuersite of precieuse ostelment3. and soþe it is þat of many[e] þinges han þei nede þat many[e] þinges han. *and* a3eyneward of litel nedip hem þat mesuren hir fille after þe

nede of kynde *and* nat after þe outrage of couetyse ¶ Is it þan so þat ye men ne han no propre goode. I-set in 3ow. For whiche 3e moten seken outwardes 3oure goodes in foreine *and* subgit þinges. ¶ So is þan þe condicioun of þinges turned vpso doun. þat a man þat is a devyne beest by merit of hys resoun. þinkeþ þat hym self nys neyþer fair ne noble. but if it be þoru3 possessioun of ostelmentes. þat ne han no soules. ¶ And certys al oþer þinges ben appaied of hire owen beauties. but 3e men þat ben semblable to god by 3oure resonable þou3t desiren to apparaille 3oure excellent kynde of þe lowest[e] þinges. ne 3e ne vndirstonde nat how gret a wrong 3e don to 3oure creatour. for he wolde þat man kynde were moost worþi *and* noble of any oþer erþely þinges. and 3e þresten adoun 3oure dignitees by-neþen þe lowest[e] þinges. ¶ For if þat al þe good of euery þing be more precious þan is þilk þing whos þat þe good is. syn 3e demen þat þe foulest[e] þinges ben 3oure goodes. þanne summytten 3e *and* putten 3oure self vndir þo foulest[e] þinges by 3oure estimacioun. ¶ And certis þis bitidiþ nat wiþ out 3oure desert. For certys swiche is þe condicioun of al man kynde þat oonly whan it haþ knowyng of it self. þan passeþ it in noblesse alle oþer þinges. and whan it forletiþ þe knowyng of it self. þan it is brou3t by-neþen alle beestes. ¶ For-why alle oþer [leuyng] beestes han of kynde to knowe not hem self. but whan þat men leten þe knowyng of hem self. it comeþ hem of vice. but how brode sheweþ þe errour *and* þe folie of 3ow men þat wenen þat ony þing may ben apparailled wiþ straunge apparaillement3 ¶ but for-soþe þat may nat be don. for yif a wy3t shyneþ wiþ þinges þat ben put to hym. as þus. yif þilke þinges shynen wiþ whiche a man is apparailled. ¶ Certis þilke þinges ben commendid *and* preised wiþ whiche he is apparailled. ¶ But napeles þe þing þat is couered *and* wrapped vndir þat dwelleþ in his filþe. and I denye þat þilke þing be good þat anoyeþ hym þat haþ it. ¶ Gabbe I of þis. þou wolt seye nay. ¶ Certys rycchesse han anoyed ful ofte hem þat han þe rycchesse. ¶ Syn þat euery wicked shrew *and* for hys wickednesse þe more gredy aftir oþer folkes rycchesse wher so euer it be in any place. be it golde or precious stones. *and* wenip hym only most worþi þat haþ hem ¶ þou þan þat so besy dredest now þe swerde *and* þe spere. yif þou haddest entred in þe pape of þis lijf a voide wayfaryng man. þan woldest þou syng[e] by-fore þe þeeff. ¶ As who seiþ a poure man þat bereþ no rycchesse on hym by þe weye. may boldly syng[e] byforne þeues. for he haþ nat wher-of to ben robbed. ¶ O precious *and* ry3t clere is þe

blysfulnesse of mortal rycchesse. þat whan þou hast geten it. þan hast þou lorn þi syke[r]nesse.

FELIX IN MIRUM PRIOR ETAS.

[The fyfthe metur.]

Blysful was þe first age of men. þei helden hem apaied wiþ þe metes þat þe trewe erþes brouzten furþe. ¶ þei ne destroyed[e] ne desceyued[e] not hem self wiþ outerage. ¶ þei weren wont lyztly to slaken her hunger at euene wiþ acornes of okes ¶ þei ne couþe nat medle þe zift of bacus to þe clere hony. þat is to seyn. þei couþe make no piment of clarre. ne þei couþe nat medle þe brizt[e] flies of þe contre of siriens wiþ þe venym of tirie. þis is to seyne. þei couþe nat dien white flies of sirien contre wiþ þe blode of a manar shelfysshe. þat men fynden in tyrie. wiþ whiche blode men deien purper. ¶ þei slepen holesom slepes vpon þe gras. and dronken of þe rynnyng watres. *and* laien vndir þe shadowe of þe heyze pyne trees. ¶ Ne no gest ne no straunger [ne] karf zit þe heye see wiþ oores or wiþ shippes. ne þei ne hadden seyne zitte none newe strondes to leden merchaundyse in to dyuerse contres. ¶ þo weren þe cruel clariouns ful whist *and* ful stille. ne blode yshed by egre hate ne hadde nat deied zit armurers. for wherto or whiche woodenesse of enmys wolde first moeuen armes. whan þei seien cruel woundes ne none medes ben of blood yshad ¶ I wolde þat oure tymes sholde turne azeine to þe oolde maneres. ¶ But þe anguissous loue of hauyng brenneþ in folke moore cruely þan þe fijr of þe Mountaigne of Ethna þat euer brenneþ. ¶ Allas what was he þat first dalf vp þe gobets or þe weyztys of gold couered vndir erþe. *and* þe precious stones þat wolden han ben hid. he dalf vp precious perils. þat is to seyne þat he þat hem first vp dalf. he dalf vp a precious peril. for-whi. for þe preciousnesse of swyche haþ many man ben in peril.

QUID AUTEM DE DIGNITATIBUS ET

[The sixte prose.]

CETERA.

But what shal I seyne of dignitees *and* of powers. þe whiche [ye] men þat neiþer knowen verray dignitee ne verray power areysen hem as heye as þe heuene. þe whiche dignitees *and* powers yif þei come to any

wicked man þei don [as] greet[e] damages *and* destruccioun as doþ þe flamme of þe Mountaigne Ethna whan þe flamme wit walwiþ vp ne no deluge ne doþ so cruel harmes. ¶ Certys ye remembriþ wel as I trowe þat þilke dignitee þat men clepiþ þe emperie of *consulers* þe whiche þat somtyme was bygynnyng of fredom. ¶ 3oure eldres coueiteden to han don a-wey þat dignitee for þe pride of þe conseilors. ¶ And ryzt for þe same pride 3oure eldres byforne þat tyme hadden don away out of þe Citee of rome þe kynges name. þat is to seien. þei nolden haue no lenger no kyng ¶ But now yif so be þat dignitees *and* powers ben 3euen to goode men. þe whiche þing is ful 3elde. what agreable þinges is þer in þo dignitees. or powers. but only þe goodenes of folk þat vsen hem. ¶ And þerfore it is þus þat honour ne comeþ nat to vertue for cause of dignite. but a3einward. honour comeþ to dignite by cause of vertue. but whiche is 3oure derworþe power þat is so clere *and* so requerable ¶ O 3e erþelyche bestes considere 3e nat ouer whiche þing þat it semeþ þat 3e han power. ¶ Now yif þou say[e] a mouse amongus oþer myse þat chalenged[e] to hymself ward ryzt *and* power ouer alle oþer myse. how gret scorne woldest þou han of hit. ¶ *Glosa.* ¶ So fareþ it by men. þe body haþ power ouer þe body. For yif þow loke wel vpon þe body of a wyzt what þing shalt þou fynde moore frele þan is mannes kynde. þe whiche ben ful ofte slayn wiþ bytyng of smale flies. or ellys wiþ þe entryng of crepyng wormes in to þe priuetees of mennes bodies. ¶ But wher shal men fynden any man þat may exercen or haunten any ryzt vpon an oþer man but oonly vpon hys body. or ellys vpon þinges þat ben lower þen þe body. whiche I clepe fortunous possessiouns ¶ Mayst þou euer haue any comaundement ouer a fre corage ¶ Mayst þou remuen fro þe estat of hys propre reste. a þouzt þat is cleuyng to gider in hym self by stedfast resoun. ¶ As somtyme a tiraunt wende to confounde a freeman of corage ¶ *And* wende to constreyne hym by tourment to maken hym dyscoueren *and* acusen folk þat wisten of a coniuracioun. whiche I clepe a confederacie þat was cast a3eins þis tyraunt ¶ But þis free man boot of hys owen tunge. *and* cast it in þe visage of þilke woode tyraunte. ¶ So þat þe tourment3 þat þis tyraunt wende to han maked matere of cruelte. þis wyse man maked[e it] matere of vertues. ¶ But what þing is it þat a man may don to an oþer man. þat he ne may receyue þe same þing of oþer folke in hym self. or þus. ¶ What may a man don to folk. þat folk ne may don hym þe same. ¶ I haue herd told of busirides þat was wont to sleen hys gestes þat

herburghden in hys hous. and he was slayn hym self of ercules þat was hys gest ¶ Regulus had[de] taken in bataile many men of affrike. and cast hem in to fetteres. but sone after he most[e] ȝiue hys handes to ben bounden with þe cheynes of hem þat he had[de] somtyme ouercomen. ¶ Wenest þou þan þat he be myȝty. þat may nat don a þing. þat oþer ne may don hym. þat he doþ to oþer. *and* ȝit more ouer yif it so were þat þise dignites or poweres hadden any propre or naturel goodnesse in hem self neuer nolden þei comen to shrewes. ¶ For contrarious þinges ne ben not wont to ben yfelawshipped togidres. ¶ Nature refuseþ þat contra[r]ious þinges ben yioigned. ¶ And so as I am in certeyne þat ryȝt wikked folk han dignitees ofte tymes. þan sheweþ it wel þat dignitees *and* powers ne ben not goode of hir owen kynde. syn þat þei suffren hem self to cleuen or ioynen hem to shrewes. ¶ And certys þe same þing may most digneliche Iugen *and* seyen of alle þe ȝiftis of fortune þat most plenteuously comen to shrewes. ¶ Of þe whiche ȝiftys I trowe þat it auȝt[e] ben considered þat no man doutiþ þat he nis strong. in whom he seeþ strengþe. *and* in whom þat swiftnesse is ¶ Soþe it is þat he is swyfte. Also musyk makeþ musiciens. *and* fysik makeþ phisiciens. *and* rethorik rethoriens. ¶ For whi þe nature of euery þing makip his propretee. ne it is nat entermedled wiþ þe effectis of contrarious þinges. ¶ And as of wil it chaseþ oute þinges þat to it ben contrarie ¶ But certys rycchesse may nat restreyne auarice vnstaunched ¶ Ne power [ne] makeþ nat a man myȝty ouer hym self. whiche þat vicious lustis holden destreined wiþ cheins þat ne mowen nat ben vnbounden. *and* dignitees þat ben ȝeuen to shrewed[e] folk nat oonly ne makip hem nat digne. but it sheweþ raper al openly þat þei ben vnworþi *and* vndigne. ¶ And whi is it þus. ¶ Certis for ȝe han ioie to clepen þinges wiþ fals[e] names. þat beren hem al in þe contrarie. þe whiche names ben ful ofte reproued by þe effect of þe same þinges. so þat þise ilke rycchesse ne auȝten nat by ryȝt to ben cleped rycchesse. ne whiche power ne auȝt[e] not ben cleped power. ne whiche dignitee ne auȝt[e] nat ben cleped dignitee. ¶ And at þe laste I may conclude þe same þinge of al þe ȝiftes of fortune in whiche þer nis no þing to ben desired. ne þat haþ in hym self naturel bounte. ¶ as it is ful wel sene. for neyþer þei ne ioynen hem nat alwey to goode men. ne maken hem alwey goode to whom þei ben y-ioigned.

NOUIMUS QUANTOS DEDERAT.

[The sixte Metur.]

WE han wel knowen how many greet[e] harmes *and* destrucciouns weren doñ by þe Emperoure Nero. ¶ He letee brenne þe citee of Rome *and* made slen þe senatours. and he cruel somtyme slou3 hys broþer. *and* he was maked moyst wiþ þe blood of hys modir. þat is to seyn he let sleen *and* slitten þe body of his modir to seen where he was conceiued. *and* he loked[e] on euery half vpon hir colde dede body. ne no tere ne wette his face. but he was so hard herted þat he myzt[e] ben domesman or Iuge of hire dede beaute. ¶ And 3itte neuerþeles gouerned[e] þis Nero by Ceptre al þe peoples þat phebus þe sonne may seen comyng from his outerest arysyng til he hidde his bemes vnder þe wawes. ¶ þat is to seyne. he gouerned[e] alle þe peoples by Ceptre imperial þat þe sonne goþ aboute from est to west ¶ And eke þis Nero goueyrende by Ceptre. alle þe peoples þat ben vnder þe colde sterres þat hy3ten þe seuene triones. þis is to seyn he gouerned[e] alle þe poeples þat ben vnder þe parties of þe norþe. ¶ And eke Nero gouerned[e] alle þe poeples þat þe violent wynde Nothus scorchiþ *and* bakþ þe brennyng sandes by his drie hete. þat is to seyne. alle þe poeples in þe souþe. [but yit ne myhte nat al his heye power torne the woodnesse of this wykkyd nero / Allas it is greuouse fortune it is]. as ofte as wicked swerde is ioyned to cruel venym. þat is to sein. venomous cruelte to lordshipe.

TUM EGO SCIS INQUAM.

[The seuende prose.]

PAnne seide I þus. þou wost wel þiself þat þe couetise of mortal þinges ne hadden neuer lordshipe of me. but I haue wel desired matere of þinges to done. as who seiþ. I desired[e] to han matere of gouernaunce ouer comunalites. ¶ For vertue stille ne sholde not elden. þat is to seyn. þat list þat or he wex olde ¶ His uertue þat lay now ful stille. ne sholde nat perisshe vnexercised in gouernaunce of comune. ¶ For whiche men my3ten speke or writen of his goode gouernement. ¶ *Philosophie*. ¶ For soþe quod she. *and* þat is a þing þat may drawen to gouernaunce swiche hertes as ben worþi *and* noble of hir nature. but napeles it may nat drawen or tollen swiche hertes as ben y-brou3t to þe ful[le] perfeccioun of vertue. þat is to seyn couetyse of glorie *and* renoun to han wel administred þe comune

þinges. or doon goode decertes to profit of þe comune. for se now *and* considere how litel *and* how voide of al prise is þilke glorie. ¶ Certeine þing is as þou hast lerned by demonstracioun of astronomye þat al þe envyronyng of þe erþe aboute ne halt but þe resoun of a prykke at regard of þe gretnesse of heuene. þat is to seye. þat yif þat þer were maked comparisoun of þe erþe to þe gretnesse of heuene. men wolde Iugen in alle þat erþe [ne] helde no space ¶ Of þe whiche litel regioun of þis worlde þe ferþe partie is enhabitid wiþ lyuyng beestes þat we knowen. as þou hast þi self lerned by tholome þat prouith it. ¶ yif þou haddest wiþ drawn *and* abated in þi þouzte fro þilke ferþe partie as myche space as þe see *and* [the] mareys contenen *and* ouergon *and* as myche space as þe regioun of droughte ouerstreccheþ. þat is to seye sandes *and* desertes wel vnnep sholde þer dwellen a ryzt streite place to þe habitacioun of men. *and* 3e þan þat ben environed *and* closed wiþ inne þe leest[e] prikke of þilk prikke þenke 3e to manifesten 3oure renoun *and* don 3oure name to ben born forþe. but 3oure glorie þat is so narwe *and* so streyt yprongen in to so litel boundes. how myche conteinþe it in largesse *and* in greet doynge. And also sette þis þer to þat many a nacioun dyuerse of tonge *and* of maneres. *and* eke of resoun of hir lyuyng ben enhabitid in þe cloos of þilke litel habitacle. ¶ To þe whiche naciouns what for difficulte of weyes. *and* what for diuersite of langages. *and* what for defaute of vnusage entercomunynge of marchaundise. nat only þe names of singler men ne may [nat] strecchen. but eke þe fame of Citees ne may nat strecchen. ¶ At þe last[e] Certis in þe tyme of Marcus tulyus as hym self writeþ in his book þat þe renoun of þe comune of Rome ne hadde nat 3itte passed ne cloumben ouer þe mountaigne þat hyzt Caucasus. *and* 3itte was þilk tyme rome wel wexen *and* gretly redouted of þe parthes. and eke of oþer folk enhabityng aboute. ¶ Sest þou nat þan how streit *and* how compressed is þilke glorie þat 3e trauailen aboute to shew *and* to multiplie. May þan þe glorie of a singlere Romeyne strecchen þider as þe fame of þe name of Rome may nat clymben ne passen. ¶ And eke sest þou nat þat þe maners of diuerse folk *and* eke hir lawes ben discordaunt amonge hem self. so þat þilke þing þat sommen iugen worþi of preysynge. oþer folk iugen þat it is worþi of torment. ¶ and þer of comeþ þat þou3 a man delite hym in preysyng of his renoun. he ne may nat in no wise bryngen furþe ne spreden his name to many manere peoples. ¶ And þerfore euery maner man auzte to ben paied of hys glorie þat is puplissed among hys owen ney3bores. ¶ And

þilke noble renoun shal be restreyned wiþ-inne þe boundes of o maner folk but how many a man þat was ful noble in his tyme. haþ þe nedy *and* wrecched forȝetyng of writers put oute of mynde *and* don away. ¶ Al be it so þat certys þilke writynges profiten litel. þe whiche writynges longe *and* derke elde doþ awaye boþe hem *and* eke her autours. but ȝe men semen to geten ȝow a *perdurablete* whan ȝe þenke þat in tyme comyng ȝoure fame shal lasten. ¶ But napeles yif þou wilt maken *comparisoun* to þe endeles space of eternite what þing hast þou by whiche þou maist reioysen þe of long lastyng of þi name. ¶ For if þer were maked *comparysoun* of þe abidyng of a moment to ten þousand wynter. for as myche as boþe þo spaces ben endid. ¶ For ȝit haþ þe moment some porcioun of hit al þouȝ it a litel be. ¶ But napeles þilke self noumbre of ȝeres. and eke as many ȝeres as þer to may be multiplied. ne may nat certys be *comparisoun* to þe *perdurablete* þat is een[de]les. ¶ For of þinges þat han ende may be mad *comparisoun* [but of thinges that ben *with-owtyn* ende to thinges þat han ende may be maked no *comparysoun*]. ¶ And for þi is it al þouȝ renoun of as longe tyme as euer þe lyst to þinken were þouȝt by þe regard of eternite. þat is vnstauncheable *and* infinit. it ne sholde nat oonly semen litel. but pleinliche ryȝt nouȝt. ¶ But ȝe men certys ne konne don no þing aryȝt. but ȝif it be for þe audience of poeple. *and* for ydel rumours. *and* ȝe forsaken þe grete worþinesse of conscience *and* of vertue. *and* ȝe seken ȝoure gerdouns of þe smale wordes of strange folke. ¶ Haue now here *and* vndirstonde in þe lyȝtnesse of whiche pride *and* veyne glorie. how a man scorned[e] festiually *and* myrily swiche vanite. somtyme þere was a man þat had[de] assaied wiþ striuyng wordes an oþer man. ¶ þe whiche nat for vsage of verrey vertue. but for proude veyne glorie had[de] taken vpon hym falsly þe name of a philosopher. ¶ þis raper man þat I speke of þouȝt[e] he wolde assay[e] where he þilke were a philosopher or no. þat is to seyne yif he wolde han suffred lyȝtly in pacience þe wronges þat weren don vnto hym. ¶ þis feined[e] philosophre took pacience a litel while. *and* whan he hadde receiued wordes of outeage he as in stryuyng aȝeine *and* reioysyng of hym self seide at þe last[e] ryȝt þus. ¶ vndirstondest þou nat þat I am a philosophre. þat oþer man answered[e] aȝein ful bityngly *and* seide. ¶ I had[de] wel vndirstonden [yt]. yif þou haddest holden þi tonge stille. ¶ But what is it to þise noble worþi men. For certys of swyche folk speke .I. þat seken glorie wiþ vertue. what is it *quod* she. what atteiniþ fame to swiche

folk whan þe body is resolued by þe deef. atte þe last[e]. ¶ For yif so be þat men dien in al. þat is to seyne body *and* soule. þe whiche þing oure resoun defendiþ vs to byleuen þanne is þere no glorie in no wyse. For what sholde þilke glorie ben. for he of whom þis glorie is seid to be nis ryzt nouzt in no wise. and 3if þe soule whiche þat haþ in it self science of goode werkes vnbounden fro þe prisoun of þe erþe wendeþ frely to þe heuene. dispiseþ it nouzt þan alle erþely occupaciouns. *and* beyng in heuene reioiseþ þat it is exempt from alle erþely þinges [as wo seith / thanne rekketh the sowle of no glorye of renoun of this world].

QUICUMQUE SOLAM MENTE.

[The 7th Metre.]

Who so þat wiþ ouerþrowyng þouzt only sekeþ glorie of fame. *and* wenip þat it be souereyne good ¶ Lete hym loke vpon þe brode shewyng contreys of þe heuen. *and* vpon þe streite sete of þis erþe. *and* he shal be ashamed of þe encres of his name. þat may nat fulfille þe litel compas of þe erþe. ¶ O what coueiten proude folke to liften vpon hire nekkes in ydel *and* dedely 3ok of þis worlde. ¶ For al þou3 [þat] renoune y-spradde passyng to ferne poeples goþ by dyuerse tonges. and al þou3 grete houses *and* kynredes shyne wiþ clere titles of honours. 3it napeles deef dispiseþ al heye glorie of fame. *and* deef wrappeþ to gidre þe heye heuedes *and* þe lowe *and* makeþ egal *and* euene þe heyest[e] to þe lowest[e]. ¶ where wonen now þe bones of trewe fabricius. what is now brutus or stiern Caton þe þinne fame 3it lastyng of hir ydel names is markid wiþ a fewe lettres. but al þou3 we han knowen þe faire wordes of þe fames of hem. it is nat 3euen to knowe hem þat ben dede *and* consumpt. Liggip þanne stille al vtterly vnknowable ne fame ne makeþ 3ow nat knowe. and yif 3e wene to lyuen þe lenger for wynde of 3oure mortal name. whan o cruel day shal rauyshe 3ow. þan is þe secunde deef dwellyng in 3ow. *Glosa.* þe first deef he clepiþ here þe departyng of þe body *and* þe soule. ¶ *and* þe secunde deef he clepeþ as here. þe styntyng of þe renoune of fame.

[SET NE ME INEXORABILE CONTRA.

[The viij prose.]

BVt for-as-mochel as thow shalt nat wenen *quod* she þat I bere vntretable batayle ayenis fortune // yit som-tyme it by-falleth þat she

desseyuable desserueth to han ryht good thank of men // *And þat* is whan she hire self opneth / *and* whan she descouereth hir frownt / *and* sheweth hir maneres *par-aventure* yit vndirstondesthow nat þat .I. shal seye // it is a wondyr þat .I. desyre to telle / *and* forthi vnnethe may I. vnpleyten my sentence *with* wordes for I. deme þat contraryos fortune profiteth more to men than fortune debonayre // For al-vey whan fortune semeth debonayre than she lyeth falsly in by-hetyng the hope of welefulnesse // but forsothe contraryos fortune is alwey sothfast / whan she sheweth hir self vnstable thorw hyr chaungynge // the amyable fortune desseyueth folk / the contrarye fortune techeth // the amyable fortune byndeth *with* the beaute of false goodys the hertes of folk þat vsen hem / the contrarye fortune vnbyndeth hem by þ^e knowynge of freele welefulnesse // the amyable fortune maysthow sen alwey wyndynge *and* flowynge / *and* euere mysknowynge of hir self // the contrarye fortune is a-tempre *and* restreynynd *and* wys thorw excersyse of hir aduersyte // at the laste amyable fortune *with* hir flaterynges draweth mys wandrynge men fro the souereyne good // the contraryos fortune ledith ofte folk ayein to sothfast goodes / *and* haleth hem ayein as *with* an hooke / weenesthow thanne þat thou owhtest to leten this a lytel thing / þat this aspre *and* horrible fortune hath discoueryd to the / the thowhtes of thy trewe frendes // For-why this ilke fortune hath departyd *and* vncoueryd to the bothe the certeyn vysages *and* ek the dows visages of thy felawes // whan she departyd away fro the / she took away hyr frendes *and* lafte the thyne frendes // now whan thou were ryche *and* weleful as the semede / *with* how mochel woldesthow han bowht the fulle knowynge of this // þat is to seyn the knowynge of thy verray frendes // now pleyne the nat thanne of Rychesse .I.-lorn syn thou hast fowndyn the moste presyos kynde of Rychesses þat is to seyn thy verray frendes.

QUOD MUNDUS STABILI FIDE.

[The viij Metur.]

T Hat þ^e world *with* stable feith / varieth acordable chaungynge // þat the contraryos qualite of elementz holden amonge hem self aliaunce perdurable / þat phebus the sonne *with* his goldene chariet / bryngeth forth the rosene day / þat the mone hath *commaundement* ouer the nyhtes // whiche nyhtes hesperus the eue sterre hat browt // þat þ^e se gredy to flowen

constreyneth *with* a certeyn ende hise floodes / so þat it is nat l[e]ueful to
 strechche hise brode termes or bowndes vp-on the erthes // þat is to seyn to
 couere alle the erthe // Al this a-cordaunce of thinges is bownden *with* looue
 / þat gouerneth erthe *and* see / *and* hath also *commaundement* to the
 heuenes / *and* yif this looue slakede the brydelis / alle thinges þat now
 louen hem to gederes / wolden maken a batayle contynuely *and* stryuen to
 fordoon the fasoun of this worlde / the which they now leden in acordable
 feith by fayre moeuynge // this looue halt to gideres poeples Ioygned *with*
 an hooly bond / *and* knytteth sacrament of maryages of chaste looues // And
 loue enditeth lawes to trewe felawes // O weleful weere mankynde / yif
 thilke loue þat gouerneth heuene gouerned[e] yowre corages /

EXPLICIT LIBER 2^{us}.

INCIPIT LIBER 3^{us}.

IAM CANTUM ILLA FINIERAT.

[The fyrste prose.]

By this she hadde endid hire songe / whan the swetnesse of hire ditee
 hadde thorw perced me þat was desirous of herkninge / *and* .I. astoned
 hadde yit streyhte myn Eres / þat is to seyn to herkne the bet / what she
 wolde seye // so þat a litel here after .I. seyde thus // O thow þat art
 souereyn comfort of Angwissos corages // So thow hast remounted *and*
 norysshed me *with* the weyhte of thy sentences *and* *with* delit of thy
 syngynge // so þat .I. trowe nat now þat .I. be vnpanygal to the strokes of
 fortune / as who seyth. I. dar wel now suffren al the assautes of fortune *and*
 wel deffende me fro hyr // *and* tho remedies whyche þat thow seydest hire
 byforn weren ryht sharpe Nat oonly þat .I. am nat agrysen of hem now //
 but .I. desiros of herynge axe gretely to heeren tho remedyes // than seyde
 she thus // þat feeledde .I. ful wel *quod* she // whan þat thow ententyf *and*
 style rauysshedest my wordes // *and* .I. abood til þat thow haddest swych
 habyte of thy thought as thow hast now // or elles tyl þat .I. my self had[de]
 makid to the the same habyt / which þat is a moore verray thinge // And
 certes the remenaunt of thinges þat ben yit to seye / ben swyche // þat fyrst

whan men tasten hem they ben bytynge / but whan they ben resseyuyd
with-inne a whyht than ben they swete // but for thow seyst þat thow art so
 desirous to herkne hem // wit[h] how gret brennyng woldesthow glown /
 yif thow wystest whyder .I. wol leden the // whydyre is þat *quod* .I. // to
 thilke verray welefulnesse *quod* she // of whyche thyng herte dremeth //
 but for as moche as thy syhte is ocupied *and* distorbed / by Imagynasyon of
 herthely thynges / thow mayst nat yit sen thilke selue welefulnesse // do
quod .I. *and* shewe me / what is thilke verray welefulnesse / .I. preye the
with-howte tarynge // þat wole .I. gladly don *quod* she / for the cause of the
 // but .I. wol fyrst marken the by wordes / *and* I wol enforcen me to
 enformen the // thilke false cause of blysfulnesse þat thow more knowest /
 so þat whan thow hast fully by-holden thilke false goodes *and* torned thyne
 eyen to þat oother syde / thow mowe knowe the clernesse of verray
 blysfulnesse //

QUI SERERE INGENIUM.

[The fyrst metur.]

¶ Who so wil sowe a felde plentiuous. lat hym first delyuer it of þornes *and*
 kerue asondre wiþ his hooke þe bushes *and* þe ferne so þat þe corne may
 comen heuy of eres *and* of greins. hony is þe more swete yif mouþes han
 firste tastid sauoures þat ben wikke. ¶ þe sterres shynen more agreably
 whan þe wynde Nothus letiþ his ploungy blastes. *and* aftir þat lucifer þe day
 sterre haþ chased away þe derke nyzt. þe day þe feirer lediþ þe rosene horse
 of þe sonne. ¶ Ryzt so þou byholdyng first þe fals[e] goodes. bygynne to
 wiþdrawe þi nek[ke] fro þe 3ok of erpely affeccions. *and* afterwarde þe
 verrey goodes shollen entre in to þi corage.

TUNC DEFIXO PAULULUM.

[The 2^{de} prose.]

Þ O fastned[e] she a lytel þe syzt of hir eyen *and* wiþdrow hir ryzt as it
 were in to þe streite sete of hir þouzt. *and* bygan to speke ryzt þus. Alle
 þe cures *quod* she of mortal folk whiche þat trauaylen hem in many manere
 studies gon certys by diuerse weies. ¶ But napeles þei enforced hem to
 comen oonly to on ende of blisfulnesse [And blysfulnesse] is swiche a
 goode þat who so haþ geten it he ne may ouer þat no þing more desiire. and
 þis þing for soþe is þe souereyne good þat conteiniþ in hym self al manere

goodes. to þe whiche goode yif þere failed[e] any þing. it myȝt[e] nat ben souereyne goode. ¶ For þan were þere som goode out of þis ilke souereyne goode þat myȝt[e] ben desired. Now is it clere *and* certeyne þan þat blisfulnesse is a *perfit* estat by þe congregacioun of alle goodes. ¶ þe whiche blisfulnesse as I haue seid alle mortal folke enforcen hem to geten by dyuerse weyes. ¶ For-whi þe couetise of verray goode is naturely y-plaunted in þe hertys of men. ¶ But þe myswandryng *errour* mysledip hem in to fals[e] goodes. ¶ of þe whiche men some of hem wenen þat souereygne goode is to lyue wiþ outen nede of any þing. *and* *traueilen* hem to ben habundaunt of rycchesse. and some oþer men demen. þat souerein goode be forto be ryȝt digne of reuerences. *and* enforcen hem to ben reuerenced among hir neyȝbours. by þe honours þat þei han ygeten ¶ *and* some folk þer ben þat halden þat ryȝt heyȝe power to be souereyn goode. *and* enforcen hem forto regnen or ellys to ioignen hem to hem þat regnen. ¶ And it semep to some oþer folk þat noblesse of renoun be þe souerein goode. *and* hasten hem to geten glorious name by þe artes of werre or of pees. and many folke mesuren *and* gessen þat souerein goode be ioye *and* gladnesse *and* wenen þat it be ryȝt blisful [thyng] to ploungen hem in uoluptuous delit. ¶ And þer ben folk þat enterchaungen þe causes *and* þe endes of þise forseide goodes as þei þat desiren rycchesse to han power *and* delices. Or ellis þei desiren power forto han moneye or for cause of renoun. ¶ In þise þinges *and* in swyche oþer þinges is tourned al þe entencioun of desirynges *and* [of] werkes of men. ¶ As þus. ¶ Noblesse *and* fauour of poeple whiche þat ȝiueþ as it semep a manere clernesse of renoun. ¶ *and* wijf *and* children þat men desiren for cause of delit *and* mirinesse. ¶ But forsoþe frendes ne shollen nat ben rekkened among þe goodes of fortune but of vertue. for it is a ful holy manere þing. alle þise oþer þinges forsoþe ben taken for cause of power. or ellis for cause of delit. ¶ Certis now am I redy to referen þe goodes of þe body to þise forseide þinges abouen. ¶ For it semep þat strengþe *and* gretnesse of body ȝeuen power *and* worþinesse. ¶ *and* þat beaute *and* swiftenesse ȝeuen noblesse *and* glorie of renoun. *and* hele of body semep ȝiuen delit. ¶ In alle þise þingus it semep oonly þat blisfulnesse is desired. ¶ For-whi þilke þing þat euery man desireþ moost ouer alle þinges. he demip þat be þe souereyne goode. ¶ But I haue diffined þat blisfulnesse is þe souereyne goode. for whiche euery wyȝt demip þat þilke estat þat he desireþ ouer alle þinges þat it be þe blisfulnesse. ¶ Now

hast þou þan byforne [thy eyen] almost al þe purposed forme of þe
 welfulnesse of mankynde. þat is to seyne rycchesse. honours. power. glorie.
and delit3. þe whiche delit oonly considered Epicurus Iuged *and*
 establissed. þat delit is þe souereyne goode. for as myche as alle oþer þinges
 as hym þou3t[e] by-refte away ioie *and* myrþe from þe herte. ¶ But I
 retourne a3eyne to þe studies of meen. of whiche men þe corage alwey
 rehersiþ *and* seekeþ þe souereyne goode of alle be it so þat it be wiþ a derke
 memorie [but he not by whiche paath]. ¶ Ry3t as a dronke man not nat by
 whiche pape he may retourne home to hys house. ¶ Semeþ it þanne þat folk
 folyen *and* erren þat enforcen hem to haue nede of no þing ¶ Certys þer nys
 non oþer þing þat may so weel perfourny blisfulnesse as an estat plenteuous
 of alle goodes þat ne haþ nede of none oþer þing. but þat it is suffisant of
 hym self. vnto hym self. and foleyen swyche folk þanne. þat wenen þat þilk
 þing þat is ry3t goode. þat it be eke ry3t worþi of honour *and* of reuerence.
 ¶ Certis nay. for þat þing nys neyþer foule ne worþi to ben dispised þat al þe
 entencioun of mortel folke trauaille forto geten it. ¶ And power au3t[e] nat
 þat eke to be rekened amonges goodes what ellis. for it nys nat to wene þat
 þilke þing þat is most worþi of alle þinges be feble *and* wiþ out strengþe
and clernesse of renoun au3te þat to ben dispised. ¶ Certys þer may no man
 forsake þat al þing þat is ry3t excellent *and* noble. þat it ne semeþ to be ry3t
 clere *and* renommed. ¶ For certis it nedip nat to seie. þat blisfulnesse be
 anguissous ne dreri ne subgit to greuances ne to sorwes. syn þat in ry3t litel
 þingus folk seken to haue *and* to vsen þat may deliten hem. ¶ Certys þise
 ben þe þinges þat men wolen *and* desyren to geten. and for þis cause
 desiren þei rycches. dignites. regnes. glorie *and* delices ¶ For þerby wenen
 þei to han suffisaunce honour power. renoun *and* gladnesse. ¶ þanne is it
 goode. þat men seken þus by so many dyuerse studies. In whiche desijr it
 may lyztly be shewed. how grete is þe strengþe of nature. ¶ For how so þat
 men han dyuerse sentences *and* discordyng algates men accordyn alle in
 lyuyng þe ende of goode.

QUANTAS RERUM FLECTAT.

[The 2^{de} Metur.]

IT likeþ me to shew[e] by subtil songe wiþ slakke *and* delitable soun of
 strenges how þat nature my3ty enclineþ *and* flitteþ gouvernement3 of
 þinges ¶ *and* by whiche lawes she purueiable kepip þe grete worlde. *and*

how she bindynge restreineþ alle þingus by a bonde þat may nat be
 vnbounden. ¶ Al be it so þat þe liouns of þe contree of pene beren þe [i]
 fair[e] cheines. *and* taken metes of þe handes of folk þat zeuen it hem.
and dreden her sturdy maystres of whiche þei ben wont to suffren
 [betinges]. yif þat hir horrible moupes ben bi-bled. þat is to sein of bestes
 devoured. ¶ Hir corage of tyme passeþ þat haþ ben ydel *and* rested. repaireþ
 azein þat þei roren greuously. *and* remembren on hir nature. *and* slaken hir
 nekkes from hir cheins vnbounden. and hir maistre first to-teren wiþ blody
 toþe assaieþ þe woode wrappes of hem. ¶ þis is to sein þei freten hir
 maister. ¶ And þe Iangland brid þat syngiþ on þe heye braunches. þis [ii]
 is to sein in þe wode *and* after is inclosed in a streit cage. ¶ al þou3
 [þat] þe pleiyng besines of men zeueþ hem honied[e] drinkes *and* large
 metes. wiþ swete studie. ¶ 3it nabeles yif þilke brid skippynge oute of hir
 streite cage seeþ þe agreable shadewes of þe wodes. she defouleþ wiþ hir
 fete hir metes yshad *and* sekeþ mournyng oonly þe wode *and* twitriþ
 desiryng þe wode wiþ hir swete voys. ¶ þe 3erde of a tree þat is [iii]
 haled adoun by my3ty strengþe bowiþ redely þe croppe adoun. but yif
 þat þe hande of hym þat it bente lat it gon azein. ¶ An oon þe crop lokeþ vp
 ry3t to heuene. ¶ þe sonne phebus þat failleþ at euene in þe westrene [iiij]
 wawes retorniþ azein eftsones his cart by a priue pape þere as it is
 wont aryse. ¶ Alle þinges seken azein in to hir propre cours. and alle þinges
 reioisen hem of hir retournyng azein to hir nature ne noon ordinaunce nis
 bytaken to þinges but þat. þat haþ ioignyng þe endynge to þe bygynnyng.
and haþ makid þe cours of it self stable þat it chaungeþ nat from hys propre
 kynde.

VOSQUE TERRENA ANIMALIA.

[The 3^{de} prose.]

C Ertis also 3e men þat ben erpeliche bestes dremen alwey [yowre
 bygynnyng] al þou3 it be wiþ a þinne ymaginacioun. *and* by a maner
 pou3t al be it nat clerly ne perfitly 3e looken from a fer til þilk verray fyn of
 blisfulnesse. and þerfore þe naturel entencioun ledeþ 3ow to þilk verray
 good ¶ But many manere errours mistourniþ 3ow þer fro. ¶ Considere now
 yif þat be þilke þinges by whiche a man weniþ to gete hym blysfulnesse. yif
 þat he may comen to þilke ende þat he wenep to come by nature ¶ For yif
 þat moneye or honours or þise oþer forseide þinges bryngen to men swiche

a þing þat no goode ne faille hem. ne semeþ faille. ¶ Certys þan wil I graunt[e] þat þei ben maked blisful. by þilke þinges þat þei han geten. ¶ but yif so be þat þilke þinges ne mowe nat *perfourmen* þat þei by-heten *and* þat þer be defaute of many goodes. ¶ Sheweþ it nat þan clerely þat fals beaute of blisfulnesse is knowe *and* a-teint in þilke þinges. ¶ First *and* forward þou þi self þat haddest haboundaunces of rycchesses nat long agon. ¶ I axe 3if þat in þe haboundaunce of alle þilk[e] rycchesses þou were neuer anguissous or sory in þi corage of any wrong or greuaunce þat by-tidde þe on any syde. ¶ Certys *quod* I it remembreþ me nat þat euere I was so free of my þou3t. þat I ne was al-wey in anguyshe of somewhat. þat was þat þou lakkedest þat þou noldest han lakked. or ellys þou haddest þat þou noldest han had. ry3t so is it *quod* I þan. desiredest þou þe presence of þat oon *and* þe absence of þat oþer. I graunt[e] wel *quod* .I. for soþe *quod* she þan nedip þer somewhat þat euery man desireþ. 3e þer nedip *quod* I. ¶ Certis *quod* she *and* he þat haþ lakke or nede of a wy3t nis nat in euery way suffisaunt to hym self. no *quod* .I. *and* þou *quod* she in alle þe plente of þi rycchesse haddest þilke lak of suffisaunce. ¶ what ellis *quod* .I. ¶ þanne may nat rycchesse maken þat a man nis nedy. ne þat he be suffisaunt to hym self. *and* þat was it þat þei byhy3ten as it semeþ. ¶ and eke certys I trowe þat þis be gretly to consydere þat moneye ne haþ nat in hys owen kynde þat it ne may ben by-nomen of hem þat han it maugre hem. ¶ I by-knowe it wel *quod* I ¶ whi sholdest þou nat by-knownen it *quod* she. whan euery day þe strenger folke by-nymen it fram þe febler maugre hem. ¶ Fro whennes comen ellys alle þise foreine compleintes or quereles of pletyngus. ¶ But for þat men axen azeine her moneye þat haþ be by-nomen hem by force or by gyle. *and* alwey maugre hem. ¶ Ry3t so it is *quod* I. þan *quod* she haþ a man nede to seken hym foreyne helpe by whiche he may defende hys moneye. who may say nay *quod* .I. ¶ Certis *quod* she *and* hym nedip no helpe yif he ne hadde no moneye þat he my3t[e] leese. ¶ þat is doutles *quod* .I. þanne is þis þing turned in to þe contrarie *quod* she ¶ For rycchesse þat men wenen sholde make suffisaunce. þei maken a man raþer han nede of foreine helpe. ¶ whiche is þe manere or þe gise *quod* she þat rycches may dryuen away nede. ¶ Riche folk may þei neiþer han hungre ne þrest. þise ryche men may þei feele no colde on hir lymes in wynter. ¶ But þou wilt answeere þat ryche men han y-nou3 wher wip þei may staunchen her hunger. *and* slaken her þrest *and* don away colde. ¶ In þis wise may nede be confortyd by

rycchesses. but certys nede ne may nat al outerly be don away. for þou3 þis nede þat is alwey gapyng *and* gredy be fulfilled wip rycchesses. *and* axe any þing 3it dwelleþ þanne a nede þat my3t[e] ben fulfilled. ¶ I holde me stille *and* telle nat how þat litel þing suffiseþ to nature. but certys to auarice ynou3 ne suffiseþ no þinge. ¶ For syn þat rychesse ne may nat al don away nede. but rychesse maken nede. what may it þanne be þat 3e wenen þat rycchesses mowen 3euen 3ow suffisaunce.

QUAMUIS FLUENTER DIUES.

[The 3^{de} Metur.]

A l were it so þat a ryche couetous man hadde riuer fletyng alle of golde 3itte sholde it neuer staunche hys couetise. ¶ And þou3 he hadde his nekke I-charged wip *precious* stones of þe rede see. *and* þou3 he do eryl his felde plentiuus wip an hundreþ oxen neuere ne shal his bytyng bysynesse forleten hym while he lyueþ. ne þe ly3t[e] rycchesses ne shal nat beren hym compaignie whanne he is dede.

SET DIGNITATIBUS.

[The 4th prose.]

B vt dignitees to whom þei ben comen make þei hym honorable *and* reuerent. han þei nat so grete strengþe þat þei may putte vertues in þe hertis of folk. þat vsen þe lordshipes of hem. or ellys may þei don away þe vices. Certys þei [ne] ben nat wont to don away wikkednesses. but þei ben wont rapen to shew[en] wikkednesses. *and* þer of comeþ it þat I haue ry3t grete desdayne. þat dignites ben 3euen ofte to wicked men. ¶ For whiche þing catullus clepid a consul of Rome þat hy3t nonius postum. or boch. as who seiþ he clepiþ hym a congregacioun of uices in his brest as a postum is ful of corrupcioun. al were þis nonius set in a chayere of dignitee. Sest þou nat þan how gret vylenye dignitees don to wikked men. ¶ Certys vnworþines of wikked men sholde ben þe lasse ysen yif þei nere renommed of none honours. ¶ Certys þou þi self ne my3test nat ben brou3t wip as many perils as þou my3test suffren þat þou woldest bere þi magistrat wip decorat. þat is to seyn. þat for no peril þat my3t[e] bifallen þe by þe offence of þe kyng theodorik þou noldest nat ben felawe in gouernaunce with decorat. whanne þou say[e] þat he had[de] wikkid corage of a likerous shrewe *and* of an acusor. ¶ Ne I ne may nat for swiche honours Iugen hem

worþi of reuerence þat I deme *and* holde vnworþi to han þilke same honours. ¶ Now yif þou saie a man þat were fulfilled of wisdom. certys þou ne myȝtest nat demen þat he were vnworþi to þe honour. or ellys to þe wisdom of whiche he is fulfilled. No *quod* .I. ¶ Certys dignitees *quod* she appertienen properly to vertue. *and* uertue transporteþ dignite anon to þilke man to whiche she hir self is conioigned. ¶ And for as moche as honours of poeple ne may nat maken folk digne of honour. it is wel seyn clerly þat þei ne han no propre beaute of dignite. ¶ And ȝit men auȝten take more hede in þis. ¶ For if it so be þat he is most out cast þat most folk dispisen. or as dignite ne may nat maken shrewes worþi of no reuerences. þan makeþ dignites shrewes more dispised þan preised. þe whiche shrewes dignit[e] scheweþ to moche folk ¶ *and* for soþe nat vnpunished. þat is forto sein. þat shrewes reuengen hem aȝeinward vpon dignites. for þei ȝelden aȝein to dignites as gret gerdoun whan þei byspotten *and* defoulen dignites wiþ hire vylenie. ¶ And for as moche as þou mow[e] knowe þat þilke verray reuerence ne may nat comen by þe shadewy transitorie dignitees. vndirstonde now þis. yif þat a man hadde vsed *and* hadde many manere dignites of consules *and* were comen perauenture amonges straunge naciouns. sholde þilke honour maken hym worshipful *and* redouted of straunge folk ¶ Certys yif þat honour of poeple were a naturel ȝifte to dignites. it ne myȝte neuer cesen nowher amonges no maner folke to done hys office. ¶ Ryȝt as fire in euery contre ne stinteþ nat to enchaufen *and* to ben hote. but for as myche as forto be holden honorable or reuerent ne comeþ nat to folk of hir propre strengþe of nature. but only of þe fals[e] opinioun of folk. þat is to sein. þat wenen þat dignites maken folk digne of honour. An on þefore whan þat þei comen þer as folk ne knowen nat þilke dignites. her honours vanissen away *and* þat on oon. but þat is a-mong straung folk. maist þou sein. but amongus hem þat þei weren born duren þilk[e] dignites alwey. ¶ Certys þe dignite of þe prouostrie of Rome was somtyme a grete power. now is it no þing but an ydel name. *and* þe rente of þe senatorie a gret charge. *and* yif a whiȝt somtyme hadde þe office to taken he[de] to þe vitailles of þe poeple as of corne *and* what oþer þinges he was holden amonges grete. but what þing is more nowe out cast þanne þilke prouostrie ¶ And as I haue seid a litel here byforne. þat þilke þing þat haþ no propre beaute of hym self resceyueþ somtyme pris *and* shynynge *and* somtyme lesiþ it by þe opinioun of vsaunces. ¶ Now yif þat dignites þanne

ne mowen nat maken folk digne of reuerence. *and* yif þat dignites wexen foule of hir wille by þe filþe of shrewes. ¶ *and* yif þat dignites lesen hir shynynge by chaungyng of tymes. *and* yif þei wexen foule by estimacioun of poeple. what is it þat þei han in hem self of beaute þat auzte ben desired. as who seiþ none. þanne ne mowen þei ziuen no beaute of dignite to none oþer.

QUAMUIS SE TIRIO.

[The 4th Metur.]

Al be it so þat þe proude nero wiþ al his woode luxurie kembed hym *and* apparaild hym wiþ faire purpers of Tirie *and* wiþ white perles. Algates zitte throf he hateful to alle folk ¶ þis is to seyn þat al was he by-hated of alle folk. ¶ zitte þis wicked Nero hadde gret lordship *and* 3af somtyme to þe dredeful senatours þe vnworshipful setes of dignites. ¶ vnworshipful setes he clepiþ here fore þat Nero þat was so wikked 3af þo dignites. who wolde þanne resonably wenen þat blysfulnesse were in swiche honours as ben 3euen by vicious shrewes.

AN UERO REGNA.

[The 5th prose.]

Bvt regnes *and* familiarites of kynges may þei maken a man to ben myzty. how ellys. ¶ whanne hir blysfulnesse dureþ perpetuely but certys þe olde age of tyme passeþ. *and* eke of present tyme now is ful of ensaumples how þat kynges þat han chaunged in to wrechednesse out of hir welefulnesse. ¶ O a noble þing *and* a cler þing is power þat is nat founden myzty to kepe it self. ¶ *And* yif þat power of realmes be auctour *and* maker of blisfulnesse. yif þilke power lakkeþ on any side. amenusiþ it nat þilke blisfulnesse *and* bryngeþ in wrechednesse. but yif al be it so þat realmes of mankynde stretchen broode. 3it mot þer nede ben myche folk ouer whiche þat euery kyng ne haþ no lordshipe no comaundement ¶ *and* certys vpon þilke syde þat power failleþ whiche þat makip folk blisful. ryzt on þat same side nounpower entriþ vndirneþ þat makeþ hem wreches. ¶ In þis manere þanne moten kynges han more porcioun of wrechednesse þan of welefulnesse. ¶ A tyraunt þat was kyng of sisile þat had[de] assaied þe peril of his estat shewid[e] by similitude þe dredes of realmes by gastnesse of a swerde þat heng ouer þe heued of his familier. what þing is þan þis power

þat may nat don away þe bytynges of besines ne eschewe þe prikkes of drede. and certys 3it wolden þei lyuen in syknesse. but þei may nat. and 3it þei glorifien hem in her power ¶ Holdest þou þan þat þilk[e] man be my3ty þat þou seest þat he wolde don þat he may nat don. ¶ And holdest þou þan hym a my3ty man þat haþ environed hise sydes wiþ men of armes or seruauntes *and* dredeþ more [hem] þat he makeþ agast. þen þei dreden hym. *and* þat is put in þe handes of hise seruaunt3. for he sholde seme my3ty but of familiers [or] seruaunt3 of kynges. ¶ what sholde I telle þe any þing. syn þat I my self haue shewed þe þat realmes hem self ben ful of gret feblenesse. þe whiche familiers certis þe real power of kynges in hool estat *and* in estat abated ful [ofte] þroweþ adoun. ¶ Nero constrained[e] his familier *and* his maistre seneca to chesen on what deep he wolde deien. ¶ Antonius comaundid[e] þat kny3tis slowen wiþ her swerdis Papinian his familier whiche Papinian had[de] ben long tyme ful my3ty a-monges hem of þe courte. and 3it certis þei wolde boþe han renounced her power. of whiche [two] senek enforced[e] hym to 3iuen to Nero his rychesses. *and* also to han gon in to solitarie exil. ¶ But whan þe grete wey3t. þat is to sein of lordes power or of fortune draweþ hem þat sholden falle. neyþer of hem ne my3t[e] do þat he wolde. what þing is þanne þilke power þat þou3 men han it þat þei ben agast. ¶ *and* whan þou woldest han it þou nart nat siker. ¶ And yif þou woldest forleten it þou mayst nat eschewen it. ¶ But wheþir swiche men ben frendes at nede as ben conseiled by fortune *and* nat by vertue. Certys swiche folk as weleful fortune makeþ frendes. contrarious fortune makeþ hem enmyse. ¶ And what pestilence is more my3ty forto anoye a wi3t þan a familier enemy.

QUI SE UALET ESSE POTENTEM.

[The 5th Metur.]

Who so wolde ben my3ty he mot daunten hys cruel corage. ne put[te] nat his nekke ouercomen vnder þe foule reines of lecherie. for al be it so þat þi lordship[e] strecche so fer þat þe contre Inde quakiþ at þi comaundement. or at þi lawes. *and* þat þe leest isle in þe see þat hy3t tile be þral to þe ¶ 3it yif þou mayst nat puten away þi foule derk[e] desijres *and* dryuen oute fro þe wreched compleyntes. Certis it nis no power þat þou hast.

GLORIA UERO QUAM FALLAX.

[The 6th prose.]

B vt glorie how deceiuable *and* how foule is it ofte. for whiche þing nat vnskilfully a tregedien þat is to sein a maker of dities þat hyzten tregedies cried[e] *and* seide. ¶ O glorie glorie *quod* he. þou nart no þing ellys to þousandes of folkes. but a gret sweller of eres. for many[e] han had ful gret renoun by þe fals[e] oppinioun of poeple. and what þing may ben þouzt fouler þen swiche *preisyng* for þilk[e] folk þat ben *preised* falsly. þei moten nedes han shame of hir *preisynges*. *and* yif þat folk han gotten hem þank or *preysyng* by her desertes. what þing haþ þilk pris echid or encresed to þe conscience of wise folk þat mesuren hire good. not by þe rumour of þe poeple. but by þe soþefastnesse of conscience. *and* yif it seme a fair þing a man to han encresid *and* sprad his name. þan folweþ it. þat it is demed to ben a foule þinge yif it ne be ysprad ne encresed. but as I seide a litel her byforne. þat syn þer mot nedes ben many folk to whiche folk þe renoun of a man ne may nat comen. it byfalleþ þat he þat þou wenest be glorious *and* renommed. semip in þe nexte parties of þe erþe to ben wiþ out glorie. *and* wiþ out renoun. ¶ *and* certis amonges þise þinges I ne trowe nat þat þe pris *and* grace of þe poeple nis neiþer worþi to ben remembrid ne comeþ of wise iugement. ne is ferm perdurably. ¶ But now of þis name of gentilesse. what man is it þat ne may wel seen how veyne *and* how flittyng a þing it is. ¶ For if þe name of gentilesse be referred to renoun *and* clernesse of linage. þan is gentil name but a for[e]line þing. þat is to sein to hem þat glorifien hem of hir linage. ¶ For it semeþ þat gentilesse be a maner *preisyng* þat comeþ of decert of auncestres. ¶ *And* yif *preisyng* makeþ gentilesse þan moten þei nedes be gentil þat ben *preysed*. For whiche þing it folweþ. þat yif þou ne haue no gentilesse of þi self. þat is to sein pris þat comeþ of þi deserte foreine gentilesse ne makeþ þe nat gentil. ¶ But certis yif þer be any goode in gentilesse. I trowe it be in al oonly þis. þat it semeþ as þat a maner necessitee be imposed to gentil men. for þat þei ne sholden nat outraien or forliuen fro þe uertues of hire noble kynrede.

OMNE HOMINUM GENUS IN TERRIS.

[The 6th Metre.]

A l þe linage of men þat ben in erþe ben of semblable burþe. On al one is fadir of þinges. On alone minyst[r]eþ alle þinges. ¶ He ʒaf to þe sonne

hys bemes. he ȝaf to þe moone hir hornes. he ȝaf þe men to þe erþe. he ȝaf þe sterres to þe heuene. ¶ he encloseþ wiþ membres þe soules þat comen fro hys heye sete. ¶ þanne comen alle mortal folk of noble seed. whi noysen ȝe or bosten of ȝoure eldris ¶ For yif þou look[e] ȝoure bygynnyng. and god ȝoure auctour *and* ȝoure makere. þan is þer no forlyued wyȝt but ȝif he norisse his corage vnto vices *and* forlete his propre burþe.

QUID AUTEM DE CORPORIBUS.

[The 7th prose.]

But what shal I seie of delices of body. of whic[h]e delices þe desiringes ben ful of anguisse. *and* þe fulfillinges of hem ben ful of penaunce. ¶ How grete sekenesse *and* how grete sorwes vnsuffrable ryȝt as a manere fruit of wickednesse ben þilke delices wont to bryngen to þe bo[d]ies of folk þat vsen hem. ¶ Of whiche delices I not what ioie may ben had of hir moeuyng. ¶ But þis woot I wel þat who so euere wil remembren hym of hys luxuries. he shal wel vndirstonde. þat þe issues of delices ben sorowful *and* sory. ¶ And yif þilke delices mowen make folk blisful. þan by þe same cause moten þise bestes ben clepid blisful. ¶ Of whiche bestes al þe entencioun hasten to fulfille hire bodyly iolyte. and þe gladnesse of wijf [*and*] children were [an] honest þing. but it haþ ben seid. þat it is ouer myche aȝeins kynde þat children han ben founden tormentours to hir fadres I not how many. ¶ Of whiche children how bitynge is euery condicioun. It nedeth nat to tellen it þe þat hast or þis tyme assaied it. *and* art ȝit now anguyssous. In þis approue I þe sentence of my disciple Euridippus. þat seide þat he þat haþ no children is weleful by infortune.

HABET HOC UOLUPTAS.

[The 7^{de} Metur.]

Euery delit haþ þis. þat it anguisseþ hem wiþ prikkes þat vsen it. ¶ It resemblith to þise flying flyes þat we clepen been. þat afre þat þe bee haþ shed hys agreeable honies he fleeth away *and* styngeth þe hertes of hem þat ben ysmyte wiþ bytynge ouer longe holdynge.

NICHIL IGITUR DUBIUM EST.

[The 8th prose.]

N ow nis it no doute þan þat þise weyes ne ben a maner mysledyng to blisfulnesse. ne þat þei ne mowe nat leden folke þider as þei byheten to leden hem. ¶ But wiþ how grete harmes þise forseide weyes ben enlaced. ¶ I shal shewe þe shortly. ¶ For whi yif þou enforcest þe to assemble moneye. þou most by-reuen hym his moneye þat haþ it. and yif þou wilt shynen wiþ dignites. þou most bysechen *and* supplien hem þat ȝiuen þo dignitees. ¶ And yif þou coueitest by honour to gon by-fore oþer folk þou shalt defoule þi self by humblesse of axing. yif þou desiryst power. þou shalt by awaites of þi subgitȝ anoyously be cast vnder many periles. axest þou glorie þou shalt ben so destrat by aspre þinges þat þou shalt forgone sykernesse. ¶ And yif þou wilt leden þi lijf in delices. euery whiȝt shal dispisen þe *and* forleten þe as þou þat art þral to þing þat is ryȝt foule *and* brutel. þat is [to] sein seruauant to þi body. ¶ Now is it þan wel yseen how lytel *and* how brutel possessioun þei coueiten þat putten þe goodes of þe body abouen hire owen resoun. ¶ For mayst þou sourmounten þise olifuȝtȝ in gretnesse or weyȝt of body. Or mayst þou ben strenger þan þe bole. Mayst þou ben swifter þan þe tigre. biholde þe spaces *and* þe stablenesse *and* þe swyfte cours of þe heuene. *and* stynte somtyme to wondren on foule þinges. þe whiche heuene certys nis nat raþer for þise þinges to ben wondred vpon. þan for þe resoun by whiche it is gouerned. but þe shynyng of þi forme þat is to seien þe beaute of þi body. how swiftly passyng is it *and* how transitorie. ¶ Certis it is more flittyng þan þe mutabilite of floures of þe somer sesoun. For so as aristotil telleþ þat yif þat men hadden eyen of a beest þat hiȝt lynx. so þat þe lokyng of folk myȝt[e] percen þoruȝ þe þinges þat wiþstonden it. who so lokid þan in þe entrailes of þe body of alcibiades þat was ful fayr in þe superfice wiþ oute. it shulde seme ryȝt foule. *and* for þi yif þou semest faire. þi nature ne makip nat þat. but þe desceiuaunce of þe fieblesse of þe eyen þat loken. ¶ But preise þe goodes of þi body as moche as euer þe list. so þat þou know[e] algates þat what so it be. þat is to seyn of þe goodes of þi body whiche þat þou wondrest vpon may ben destroied or dessolued by þe hete of a feuere of þre dayes. ¶ Of alle whiche forseide þinges I may reducen þis shortly in a somme. ¶ þat þise worldly goodes whiche þat ne mowen nat ȝiuen þat þei byheten. ne ben nat perfit by þe congregacioun of alle goodes. þat þei ne ben nat weyes ne papes þat bryngen men to blysfulnesse ne maken men to ben blysful.

HEU QUE MISEROS TRAMITE.

[The 8th Metur.]

Allas whiche folie *and* whiche ignoraunce mysledip wandryng wrecches fro þe pape of verrey good. ¶ Certis 3e ne seken no golde in grene trees. ne 3e ne gadren [nat] *precious* stones in þe vines. ne 3e ne hiden nat 3oure gynnes in hey3e mountaignes to kachen fisshe of whiche 3e may maken ryche festes. and yif 3ow lykeþ to hunte to roos. 3e ne gon nat to þe foordes of þe water þat hyzt tyrene. *and* ouer þis men knowen wel þe crikes *and* þe cauernes of þe see yhidd in þe floodes. *and* knowen eke whiche water is most plentiuous of white perles. *and* knowen whiche water habundeþ most of rede purpre. þat is to seyen of a maner shelffisshe *with* whiche men dien purpre. *and* knowen whiche strondes habounden most of tendre fisshes or of sharpe fisshes þat hyzten echynnys. but folk suffren hem self to ben so blynde þat hem ne recchiþ nat to knowe where þilk[e] goodes ben yhidd whiche þat þei coueiten but ploungen hem in erþe *and* seken þere þilke goode þat sourmounteþ þe heuene þat bereþ þe sterres. ¶ what preyere may I make þat be digne to þe nice þouztis of men. but I preye þat þei coueiten rycches *and* honours so þat whan þei han geten þo false goodes wiþ greet trauayle þat þerby þei mowe knowen þe verray goodes.

HACTENUS MENDACIS FORMAM.

[The 9th prose.]

IT suffisiþ þat I haue shewed hider to þe forme of false wilfulnesse. so þat yif þou look[e] now clerely þe ordre of myn entencioun requeriþ from hennes forþe to shewen þe verray wilfulnesse. ¶ For *quod* .I. (b) [I.] se wel now þat suffisaunce may nat comen by richesse. ne power by realmes. ne reuerence by dignitees. ne gentillesse by glorie. ne ioye by delices. and (p) hast þou wel knowen *quod* she þe cause whi it is. Certis me semeþ *quod* .I. þat .I. se hem ryzt as þou3 it were þoru3 a litel clifte. but me were leuer knowen hem more openly of þe. Certys *quod* she þe resoun is al redy ¶ For þilk þing þat symply is on þing wiþ outen ony diuisioun. þe error *and* folie of mankynde departeþ *and* diuidiþ it. *and* mislediþ it *and* transporteþ from verray *and* perfit goode. to goodes þat ben false *and* inperfit. ¶ But seye me þis. wenest þou þat he þat haþ nede of power þat hym ne lakkeþ no þing. Nay *quod* .I. ¶ Certis *quod* she þou seist aryzt. For yif so be þat þer is a þing þat in any partie be fieble of power. Certis as in þat it most[e] nedes be

nedy of foreine helpe. ¶ Riȝt so it is *quod* .I. Suffisaunce and power ben þan
 of on kynde ¶ So semeþ it *quod* I. ¶ And demyst þou *quod* she þat a þing
 þat is of þis manere. þat is to seine suffisaunt *and* myȝty auȝt[e] to ben
 dispised. or ellys þat it be ryȝt digne of reuerences abouen alle þinges.
 ¶ Certys *quod* I it nys no doute þat it nis ryȝt worþi to ben reuerenced. ¶ Lat
 vs *quod* she þan adden reuerence to suffisaunce *and* to power ¶ So þat we
 demen þat þise þre þinges ben alle o þing. ¶ Certis *quod* I lat vs adden it. yif
 we willen graunten þe soþe. what demest þou þan *quod* she is þat a dirke
 þing *and* nat noble þat is suffisaunt reuerent *and* myȝty. or ellys þat is ryȝt
 clere *and* ryȝt noble of celebrete of renoun. ¶ Considere þan *quod* she as we
 han grauntid her byforne. þat he þat ne haþ ne[de] of no þing *and* is most
 myȝty *and* most digne of honour yif hym nedip any clernesse of renoun
 whiche clernesse he myȝt[e] nat graunten of hym self. ¶ So þat for lakke of
 þilke clerenesse he myȝt[e] seme febler on any syde or þe more outcaste.
Glosa. þis is to seyne nay. ¶ For who so þat is suffisaunt myȝty *and*
 reuerent. clernesse of renoun folweþ of þe forseide þinges. he haþ it alreȝd
 of hys suffisaunce. boice. I may nat *quod* I denye it. ¶ But I mot graunten as
 it is. þat þis þing be ryȝt celebrable by clernesse of renoun *and* noblesse.
 ¶ þan folweþ it *quod* she þat we adden clernesse of renoun to þe þre
 forseide þinges. so þat þer ne be amonges hem no difference. *and* þis is a
 consequente *quod* .I. þis þing þan *quod* she þat ne haþ no nede of no foreine
 þing. *and* þat may don alle þinges by his strengþes. *and* þat is noble *and*
 honourable. nis nat þat a myrie þing *and* a ioyful. boice. but wenest *quod* I
 þat any sorow myȝt[e] comen to þis þing þat is swiche. ¶ Certys I may nat
 þinke. *P.* ¶ þanne moten we graunt[e] *quod* she þat þis þing be ful of
 gladnesse yif þe þorseide þinges be soþe. ¶ And also certys mote we
 graunten. þat suffisaunce power noblesse reuerence *and* gladnesse ben only
 dyuerse bynames. but hir substaunce haþ no diuersite. Boice. It mot nedely
 be so *quod* .I. *P.* þilke þinge þan *quod* she þat is oon *and* simple in his
 nature. þe wikkednesse of men departip it diuidip it. *and* whan þei enforcen
 hem to gete partie of a þing þat ne haþ no part. þei ne geten hem neiþer
 þilk[e] partie þat nis none. ne þe þing al hole þat þei ne desire nat. .*b.* In
 whiche manere *quod* .I. *p.* þilke man *quod* she þat sekeþ rychesse to fleen
 pouerte. he ne trauayleþ hym nat to for to gete power for he haþ leuer ben
 dirk *and* vile. *and* eke wiþdraweþ from hym selfe many naturel delitȝ for he
 nolde lesen þe moneye þat he haþ assembled. but certis in þis manere he ne

getiþ hym nat suffisaunce þat power forletiþ. *and* þat moleste prekeþ. *and*
 þat filþe makeþ outcaste. *and* þat derknesse hideþ. and certis he þat desireþ
 only power he wastiþ *and* scatriþ rychesse *and* dispiseþ delices *and* eke
 honour þat is wiþ out power. ne he ne preiseþ glorie no þing. ¶ Certys þus
 seest þou wel þat many þingus failen to hym. for he haþ somtyme faute of
 many necessites. *and* many anguysses biten hym ¶ *and* whan he may nat
 don þo defautes away. he forleteþ to ben myȝty. *and* þat is þe þing þat he
 most desireþ. *and* ryȝt þus may I make semblable resouns of honours *and* of
 glorie *and* of delices. ¶ For so as euery of þise forseide þinges is þe same
 þat þise oþer þinges ben. þat is to sein. al oon þing. who so þat euer sekeþ
 to geten þat oon of þise *and* nat þat oþer. he ne geteþ nat þat he desireþ.
Boice. ¶ what seist þou þan yif þat a man coueiteþ to geten alle þise þinges
 to gider. *P.* Certys quod she .I. wolde seie þat he wolde geten hym
 souereyne blisfulnes. but þat shal he nat fynde in þo þinges þat .I. haue
 shewed þat ne mowe nat ȝeuen þat þei by-heten. *boice.* Certys no quod .I.
 ¶ þan quod she ne sholden men nat by no weye seken blysfulnesse in
 swiche þinges as men wenen þat þei ne mowe ȝeuen but o þing senglely of
 alle þat men seken. I graunt[e] wel quod .I. ne no soþer þing ne may nat ben
 said. *P.* ¶ Now hast þou þan quod she þe forme *and* þe causes of false
 welefulnesse. ¶ Now turne *and* flitte þe eyen of þi þouȝt. for þere shalt þou
 seen an oon þilk verray blysfulnesse þat I haue byhyȝt þee. *b.* Certys quod
 .I. it is cler *and* opyn. þouȝ þat it were to a blynde man. *and* þat shewedest
 þou me [ful wel] a lytel her byforne. whan þou enforcedest þe to shewe me
 þe causes of þe false blysfulnesse ¶ For but yif I be by-giled. þan is þilke þe
 verray perfit blisfulnesse þat perfitly makith a man suffisaunt. myȝty.
 honourable noble. *and* ful of gladnesse. *and* for þou shalt wel knowe þat I
 haue wel vndirstonden þise þinges wiþ inne myne herte. I knowe wel þilke
 blisfulnesse þat may verrayly ȝeuen on of þe forseide þinges syn þei ben al
 oon .I. knowe douteles þat þilke þing is þe fulle of blysfulnesse. *P.* O my
 nurry quod she by þis oppinioun quod she I sey[e] þat þou art blisful yif þou
 putte þis þer to þat I shal seine. what is þat quod .I. ¶ Trowest þou þat þer be
 any þing in þis erþely mortal toublyng þinges þat may bryngen þis estat.
 Certys quod I trowe it nat. *and* þou hast shewed me wel þat ouer þilke
 goode þer is no þing more to ben desired. *P.* þise þinges þan quod she. þat is
 to seyne erþely suffisaunce *and* power. *and* swiche þinges eyþer þei semen
 likenesse of verray goode. or ellys it semeþ þat þei ȝeuen to mortal folk a

maner of goodes þat ne ben nat perfit. ¶ But þilke goode þat is verray *and* perfit. þat may þei nat zeuen. *boice*. I. accorde me wel quod .I. þan quod she for as moche as þou hast knowen whiche is þilke verray blisfulnesse. *and* eke whiche þilke þinges ben þat lien falsly blisfulnesse. þat is to seyne. þat by desceit semen verray goodes. ¶ Now byhoueþ þe to knowen whennes *and* where þou mowe seek[e] þilke verray blisfulnesse. ¶ Certys quod I þat desijr I gretly *and* haue abiden longe tyme to herkene it. ¶ But for as moche quod she as it likeþ to my disciple plato in his book of *in thimeo*. þat in ryȝt lytel þinges men sholde bysechen þe helpe of god. ¶ what iugest þou þat be [now] to done so þat we may deserue to fynde þe sete of þilke souereyne goode. *B.* ¶ Certys quod .I. I. deme þat we shulle clepen to þe fadir of alle goodes. ¶ For wiþ outen hym nis þer no þing founden aryȝt. þou seist a-ryȝt quod she. *and* bygan on-one to syngen ryȝt þus.

O QUI PERPETUA.

[The 9^{ne} Metur.]

O þou fadir creatour of heuene *and* of erþes þat gouernest þis worlde by perdurable resoun þat comaundist þe tymes for to gon from tyme þat age had[de] bygynnyng. þou þat dwellest þi self ay stedfast *and* stable *and* ȝiuest alle oþer þinges to ben moeued. ne forein causes necesseden þe neuer to compoune werke of floterynge mater. but only þe forme of souereyne goode y-set wiþ inne [þe] wiþ outen envie þat moeued[e] þe frely. þou þat art alperfairest beryng þe faire worlde in þi þouȝt. formedest þis worlde to þe likkenesse semblable of þat faire worlde in þi þouȝt. þou drawest alle þinges of þi souereyne ensampler. *and* comaundedist þat þis worlde perfitlyche ymaked haue frely *and* absolut hyse perfit parties. ¶ þou byndest þe elementȝ by noumbres *proporcionables*. þat þe colde þinges mowen accorde wiþ þe hote þinges. *and* þe drye þinges wiþ þe moyst þinges. þat þe fire þat is purest ne fleye nat ouer heye. ne þat þe heuynesse ne drawe nat adoun ouer lowe þe erþes þat ben plounged in þe watres. ¶ þou knytttest togidre þe mene soule of treble kynde moeuyng alle þinges. *and* diuidest it by membres accordyng. ¶ And whan it is þus diuided it haþ assembled a moeuyng in two roundes. ¶ It goþ to tourne aȝein to hym owen self. *and* enviroñeþ a fulle deep þouȝt. *and* tourniþ þe heuene by semblable ymage. þou by euenlyk causes enhaunsest þe soules *and* þe lasse liues *and* ablynge hem heye by lyȝt[e] cartes. þou sewest hem in to heuene *and* in to erþe. *and*

whan þei ben conuertid to þe by þi benigne lawe. ¶ þou makest hem retorne
 azeine to þe by azein ledyng fjr. ¶ O fadir yif þou to þi þouzt to stien vp in
 to þi streite sete. *and* graunte [hym] to enviroune þe welle of good. *and* þe
 lyzte yfounde graunte hym to ficchen þe clere syztes of hys corage in þe.
 ¶ And scatre þou *and* to-breke [thow] þe weyztas *and* þe cloudes of erþely
 heuynesse. *and* shyne þou by þi bryztnes. for þou art clernesse þou art
 peisible to debonaire folke. ¶ þou þi self art bygynnyng. berere. ledere. pap
and terme to loke on þe [þat] is oure ende. *Glose.*

QUONIAM IGITUR QUI SCIT.

[The 10th prose.]

F Or as moche þan as þou hast seyn. whiche is þe forme of goode þat nys
 nat perfit. *and* whiche is þe forme of goode þat is perfit. now trowe I
 þat it were goode to shewe in what þis perfeccioun of blisfulnesse is set.
and in þis þing I trowe þat we sholden first enquire forto witen yif þat any
 swiche manere goode as þilke goode þat þou hast diffinissed a lytel her
 byforne. þat is to seine souereyne goode may be founden in þe nature of
 þinges. For þat veyne ymaginacioun of þouzt ne desceiue vs nat. *and* putte
 vs oute of þe soþefastnesse of þilke þinge þat is summyttid to vs. þis is to
 seyne. but it may nat ben denoyed þat þilke goode ne is. ¶ *and* þat it nis ryzt
 as a welle of alle goodes. ¶ For al þing þat is cleped *inperfit*. is proued
inperfit by þe amenusyng of *perfeccioun*. or of þing þat is *perfit*. *and* her
 of comeþ it. þat in euery þing general. yif þat. þat men seen any þing þat is
inperfit certys in þilke general þer mot ben somme þing þat is *perfit*. ¶ For
 yif so be þat *perfeccioun* is don away. men may nat þinke nor seye fro
 whennes þilke þing is þat is cleped *inperfit*. ¶ For þe nature of þinges ne
 token nat her bygynnyng of þinges amenused *and* *inperfit*. but it procediþ
 of þingus þat ben al hool. *and* absolut. *and* descendeþ so doune in to
 outerest þinges *and* in to þingus empty *and* wiþ oute fruyt. but as I haue
 shewed a litel her byforne. þat yif þer be a blisfulnesse þat be frele *and* vein
and *inperfit*. þer may no man doute. þat þer nys som blisfulnesse þat is sad
 stedfast *and* *perfit*. b. þis is concludid *quod* I fermely *and* soþefastly. *P.* But
 considere also *quod* she in wham þis blisfulnesse enhabiteþ. þe *commune*
acordaunce and conceite of þe corages of men proueþ *and* graunteþ þat god
 prince of alle þingus is good. ¶ For so as no þing ne may ben þouzt better
 þan god. it may nat ben douted þan þat [he þat] no þing is better. þat he nys

good. ¶ Certys resoun shewep þat god is so goode þat it prouep by verray force þat perfit goode is in hym. ¶ For yif god ne is swiche. he ne may nat ben prince of alle þinges. for certis som þing possessyng in hym self perfit goode sholde ben more þan god. *and* [it] sholde seme þat þilke þing were first *and* elder þan god. ¶ For we han shewed apertly þat alle þinges þat ben perfit. ben first or þinges þat ben inperfit. ¶ And for þi for as moche as [that] my resoun or my proces ne go nat away wiþoute an ende. we ouzt[e] to graunten þat þe souereyne god is ryzt ful of souereyne perfit goode. and we han establissed þat þe souereyne goode is verrey blisfulnesse. þan mot it nedes ben [þat verray blysfulnesse is] yset in souereyne god. *B.* þis take I wel quod .I. ne þis ne may nat be wiþseid in no manere. ¶ But I preie þe quod she see now how þou mayst preuen holily *and* wiþ-outen corrupcioun þis þat I haue seid. þat þe souereyne god is ryzt ful of souereyne goode. [In whych manere quod I.] wenest þou ouzt quod she þat þis prince of alle þinges haue ytake þilke souereyne good any where þan of hym self. ¶ of whiche souereyne goode men prouep þat he is ful ryzt as þou myzttest þinken. þat god þat haþ blisfulnesse in hym self. *and* þat ilke blisfulnesse þat is in hym were diuers in substaunce. ¶ For yif þou wene þat god haue receyued þilke good oute of hym self. þou mayst wene þat he þat 3af þilke good to god. be more goode þan is god. ¶ But I am byknowen *and* confesse *and* þat ryzt dignely þat god is ryzt worþi abouen alle þinges. ¶ And yif so be þat þis good be in hym by nature. but þat it is diuers from [hym] by wenyng resoun. syn we speke of god prince of alle þinges feyne who so feyne may. who was he þat [hath] conioined þise diuers þinges to-gidre. *and* eke at þe last[e] se wel þat o þing þat is diuers from any þing. þat þilke þing nis nat þat same þing. fro whiche it is vndirstonden to ben diuers. þan folweþ it. þat þilke þing þat by hys nature is dyuers from souereyne good. þat þat þing nys nat souereyne good. but certys þat were a felonous corsednesse to þinken þat of hym. þat no þing nis more worþe. For alwey of alle þinges. þe nature of hem ne may nat ben better þan his bygynnyng. ¶ For whiche I may concluden by ryzt uerray resoun. þat þilke þat is bygynnyng of alle þinges. þilke same þing is good in his substaunce. *B.* þou hast seid ryztfully quod .I. *P.* But we han graunted quod she þat souereyne good is blysfulnes. þat is soþe quod .I. þan quod she mote we nedes graunten *and* confessen þat þilke same souereyne goode be god. ¶ Certys quod .I. I ne may nat denye ne wiþstonde þe resouns purposed. and I see

wel þat it folweþ by strengþe of þe premisses. ¶ Loke nowe quod she yif þis be proued [yit] more fermely þus. ¶ þat þer ne mowen nat ben two souereyne goodes þat ben diuerse amo[n]ges hem self. þat on is nat þat þat oþer is. þan [ne] mowen neiþer of hem ben perfit. so as eyþer of hem lakkiþ to oþir. but þat þat nis nat perfit men may seen apertly þat it nis nat souereyne. þe þinges þan þat ben souereynely goode ne mowen by no wey ben diuerse. ¶ But I haue wel conclude þat blisfulnesse *and* god ben [the] souereyne goode. For whiche it mot nedes be þat souereyne blisfulnesse is souerey[n]e dyuynite. ¶ No þing quod I nis more soþefast þan þis ne more ferme by resoun. ne a more worþi þing þan god may nat ben concluded. *P.* vpon þise þinges þan quod she. ryzt as þise geometriens whan þei han shewed her *proposiciouns* ben wont to bryngen in þinges þat þei clepen *porismes* or *declaraciouns* of forseide þinges. ryzt so wil I zeue þe here as a corolarie or a mede of coroune. For whi. for as moche as by þe getyng of blisfulnesse men ben makid blysfyl. *and* blisfulnesse is diuinite. ¶ þan is it manifest *and* open þat by þe getyng of diuinite men ben makid blisful. ryzt as by þe getyng of iustice . . . *and* by þe getyng of sapience þei ben makid wise. ¶ Ryzt so nedes by þe semblable resoun whan þei han getyn diuinite þei ben makid goddys. þan is euery blisful man god. ¶ But certis by nature. þer nys but oon god. but by þe *participaciouns* of diuinite þere ne letteþ ne disturbeþ no þing þat þer ne ben many goddes. ¶ þis is quod .I. a faire þing *and* a precious. ¶ Clepe it as þou wolt. be it corolarie or *porisme* or mede of coroune or declarynges ¶ Certys quod she no þing nis fairer. þan is þe þing þat by resoun sholde ben added to þise forseide þinges. what þing quod .I. ¶ So quod she as it semeþ þat blisfulnesse contenip many þinges. it were forto witen wheþir [þat] alle þise þinges maken or conioignen as a maner body of blysfulnesse by diuersite of parties or [of] *membris*. Or ellys yif any of alle þilke þingus be swyche þat it acomplise by hym self þe substaunce of blisfulnesse. so þat alle þise oþer þinges ben referred and brouzt to blisfulnesse. þat is to seyne as to þe chief of hem. ¶ I wolde quod I þat þou makedest me clerly to vndirstonde what þou seist. *and* þat þou recordest me þe forseide þinges. ¶ Haue I nat iuged quod she. þat blisfulnesse is goode. 3is forsoþe quod .I. *and* þat souereyne goode. ¶ Adde þan quod she þilke goode þat is makid blisfulnes to alle þe forseide þinges. ¶ For þilke same blisfulnesse þat is demed to ben souereyne suffisaunce. þilke self is souereyne power. souereyne reuerence. souereyne clernesse or noblesse *and*

souereyne delit. what seist þou þan of alle þise þinges. þat is to seyne.
suffisance power *and* þise oþer þinges. ben þei þan as membris of
blisfulnesse. or ben þei referred *and* brouȝt to souereyne good. ¶ Ryȝt as alle
þinges þat ben brouȝt to þe chief of hem. b. I vndirstonde wel quod .I. what
þou purposest to seke. but I desir[e] to herkene þat þou shewe it me. p.
Take now þus þe discressioun of þis questioun quod she. yif al þise þinges
quod she weren membris to felicite. þan weren þei diuerse þat oon fro þat
oþer. ¶ And swiche is þe nature of parties or of membris. þat dyuerse
membris compounen a body. ¶ Certis quod I it haȝ wel ben shewed her
byforne. þat alle þise þinges ben alle on þing. þan ben þei none membris
quod she. for ellys it sholde seme þat blisfulnesse were conioined al of one
membre alone. but þat is a þing þat may nat ben doon. þis þing quod .I. nys
nat doutous. but I abide to herkene þe remenaunt of þe questioun. þis is
open *and* clere quod she. þat alle oþer þinges ben referred *and* brouȝt to
goode. ¶ For þerfore is suffisaunce requered. For it is demed to ben good.
and forþi is power requered. for men trowen also þat it be goode. and þis
same þing mowe we þinken *and* coueiten of reuerence *and* of noblesse *and*
of delit. þan is souereyne good þe soume *and* þe cause of alle þat auȝt[e] be
desired. forwhi þilke þing þat wiȝ-holdeȝ no good in it self ne semblaunce
of goode it ne may nat wel in no manere be desired ne requered. *and* þe
contrarie. For þouȝ þat þinges by hir nature ne ben nat goode algates yif
men wene þat þei ben goode ȝit ben þei desired as þouȝ [þat] þei were
verrayly goode. *and* þerfore is it þat men auȝten to wene by ryȝt þat bounte
be souereyne fyn *and* þe cause of alle þinges þat ben to requeren. ¶ But
certis þilke þat is cause for whiche men requeren any þing. ¶ it semeȝ þat
þilke same þing be most desired. as þus yif þat a wyȝt wolde ryde for cause
of hele. he ne desireȝ nat so mychel þe moeuyng to ryden as þe effect of his
heele. Now þan syn þat alle þinges ben requered for þe grace of good. þei
ne ben [nat] desired of alle folk more þan þe same good ¶ But we han
graunted þat blysfulnesse is þat þing for whiche þat alle þise oþer þinges
ben desired. þan is it þus þat certis only blisfulnesse is requered *and* desired
¶ By whiche þing it sheweȝ clerely þat good *and* blisfulnesse is al oone *and*
þe same substaunce. ¶ I se nat quod I wher fore þat men myȝt[en] discorden
in þis. p. *and* we han shewed þat god *and* verrey blysfulnesse is al oon þing
¶ þat is soþe quod .I. þan mowe we conclude sikerly þat þe substaunce of
god is set in þilke same good *and* in noon oþer place.

O Comeþ alle to-gidre now 3e þat ben ycau3t *and* ybounde wiþ wicked[e] cheines by þe deceiuable delit of erþely þinges inhabytynge in 3oure þou3t. here shal ben þe reste of 3oure laboures. here is þe hauene stable in peisible quiete. þis al oone is þe open refut to wrechis. *Glosa.* þis is to seyn. þat 3e þat ben combred *and* deceyued wiþ worldly affeccions comeþ now to þis souereyne good þat is god. þat is refut to hem þat wolen come to hym. *Textus.* ¶ Alle þe þinges þat þe ryuere Tagus 3iueþ 3ow wiþ his golden[e] grauels. or ellys alle þe þynges þat þe ryuere hermus. 3iueþ wiþ his rede brynke. or þat yndus 3iueþ þat is nexte þe hote *partie* of þe worlde. þat medeleþ þe grene stones (smaragde) wiþ þe white (margarits). ne sholde nat cleren þe lokyng of 3oure þo3t. but hiden raþer 3oure blynde corages wiþ inne hire dirkenesse ¶ Alle þat likeþ 3ow here *and* excitiþ *and* moeueþ 3oure þou3tes. þe erþe haþ noryshed it in hys lowe caues. but þe shynyng by þe whiche þe heuene is gouerned *and* whennes þat it haþ hys strengþe þat chaseþ þe derke ouerþrowyng of þe soule. ¶ And who so euer may knowen þilke ly3t of blisfulnesse. he shal wel seine þat þe white bemes of þe sonne ne ben nat cleer.

I assent[e] me *quod* .I. For alle þise þinges ben strongly bounden wiþ ry3t ferme resouns. how mychel wilt þou preisen it *quod* she. yif þat þou knowe what þilke goode is. I wol preise it *quod* I by price wiþ outen ende. ¶ yif it shal bytyde me to knowe also to-gidre god þat is good. ¶ certys *quod* she þat shal I do þe by verray resoun. yif þat þo þinges þat I haue conclude[d] a litel her by forne dwellen oonly in hir first[e] grauntyng. *Boice.* þei dwellen graunted to þe *quod* .I. þis is to seyne as who seiþ .I. graunt þi forseide conclusiouns. ¶ Haue I nat shewed þe *quod* she þat þe þinges þat ben requered of many folke. ne ben nat verray goodes ne *perfit*. for þei ben diuerse þat oon fro þat oþer. *and* so as eche of hem is lakkyng to oþer. þei ne han no power to bryngen a good þat is ful *and* absolute. ¶ But þan atte arst ben þei verray good whan þei ben gadred to-gidre al in to a forme *and* in to oon wirchyng. so þat þilke þing þat is suffisaunce. þilk same be power *and* reuerence. *and* noblesse *and* mirþe. ¶ And forsoþe but

alle þise þinges ben alle o same þing þei ne han nat wher by þat þei mowen
 ben put in þe noumbre of þinges. þat auȝten ben required or desired. *b.* ¶ It
 is shewed quod .I. ne her of may þer no man douten. *p.* þe þinges þan quod
 she þat ne ben none goodes whan þei ben diuerse. *and* whan þei bygynnen
 to ben al o þing. þan ben þei goodes. ne comiþ it hem nat þan by þe getyng
 of unite þat þei ben makid goodes. *b.* so it semet quod .I. but alle þing þat
 is good quod she graunteþ þou þat it be good by participacioun of good or
 no. ¶ I graunt[e] it quod .I. ¶ þan mayst þou graunt[en] it quod she by
 sembleable resoun þat oon *and* good ben o same þing. ¶ For of þinges [of]
 whiche þat þe effect nis nat naturely diuerse nedys þe substaunce mot ben o
 same þinge. I ne may nat denye it quod I. ¶ Hast þou nat knowen wel quod
 she. þat al þing þat is haþ so longe his dwellyng *and* his substaunce. as
 longe is it oone. ¶ but whan it forletip to ben oone it mot nedis dien *and*
 corruppe togidre. ¶ In whiche manere quod .I. ¶ Ryȝt as in beestes quod
 she. whan þe soule *and* þe body ben conioined in oon *and* dwellen to-gidre
 it is cleped a beest. *and* whan hire vnite is destroyed by disseueraunce þat
 oon fram þat opir. þan shewet it wel þat it is a dede þing. *and* þat it is no
 lenger no beste. *and* þe body of a wyȝt while it dwelleþ in oon forme by
 coniunccioun of membris it is wel seyn þat it is a figure of mankynde. *and*
 yif þe parties of þe body ben [so] diuide[d] *and* disseuered þat oon fro þat
 opir þat þei destroyen vnite. þe body forletip to ben þat it was byforne.
 ¶ And who so wolde renne in þe same manere by alle þinges he sholde seen
 þat wiþ outen doute euery þinge is in his substaunce as longe as it is oon.
and whan it forletip to ben oon it dieþ *and* perissip. *boice.* whan I considre
 quod I many þinges I see noon oper. ¶ Is þer any þing þanne quod she þat in
 as moche as it lyueþ naturely. þat forletip þe appetit or talent of hys beyng.
and desireþ to come to deeth *and* to corrupcioun. ¶ yif I considere quod I þe
 beestes þat han any manere nature of willynge or of nillynge I ne fynde no
 þing. but yif it be constreyned fro wiþ out forþe. þat forletip or dispiseþ to
 lyue *and* to duren or þat wole his þankes hasten hym to dien. ¶ For euery
 beest trauayleþ hym to defende *and* kepe þe sauuacioun of lijf. *and*
 escheweþ deeth *and* destruccioun. *b.* but certys I doute me of herbes *and* of
 trees. þat is to seyn þat I am in a doute of swiche þinges as herbes or trees
 þat ne han no felyng soule. ne no naturel wirchynges seruyng to appetite as
 beestes han wheþer þei han appetite to dwellen *and* to duren. ¶ Certis quod
 she ne þer of þar þe nat doute. ¶ Now look vpon þise herbes *and* þise trees.

þei waxen firste in swiche place as ben couenable to hem. in whiche place
þei ne mowen nat sone dien ne dryen as longe as hire nature may defenden
hem. ¶ For some of hem waxen in feldes *and* some in mountaignes. *and*
opir waxen in mareis. [*A leaf lost here, and supplied from C.*] [*and* oothre
cleuyn on Roches / *and* soume waxen plentyuous in sondes / *and* yif þat any
wyht enforce hym to beryn hem in to oother places / they wexen drye // For
nature yeueth to euery thing þat / þat is conuenient to hym *and* trauaylith
þat they ne dye nat as longe as they han power to dwellyn *and* to lyuen //
what woltow seyn of this / þat they drawen alle hyr norysshynge by hyr
rootes / ryht as they haddyn hyr Mowthes I.-plounged *with* in the erthes /
and shedyn by hyr maryes (i. medullas) hyr wode *and* hyr bark / *and* what
woltow seyn of this þat thilke thing / þat is ryht softe as the marye (i. sapp)
is / þat is alwey hidd in the feete al *with* inne *and* þat it is defendid fro *with*
owte by the stidefastnesse of wode // *and* þat the vttereste bark is put ayenis
the destemprance of the heuene / as a defendowr myhty to suffren harm /
and thus certes maystow wel sen / how gret is the diligence of nature / For
alle thinges renouelen *and* pupplisen hem *with* seed .I.-multiplied / nether
nis no man þat ne wot wel þat they ne ben ryht as a foundement *and*
edyfice for to duren / nat only for a tyme / but ryht as forto duren
perdurably by generacyoun // *and* the thinges ek þat men wenen ne hauen
none sowles / ne desire they nat ech of hem by sem[b]lable resoun to kepyn
þat that is hirs / þat is to seyn þat is acordynge to hyr nature in
conseruacioun of hyr beyng *and* enduryng // For wher for elles berith
lythnesse the flaumbes vp / *and* the weyhte presseth the erthe a-doun // but
For as moche as thilke places and thilke moeuynge ben couenable to
euerich of hem // *and* forsothe euery thing kepith thilke þat is acordynge
and propre to hym // ryht as thinges þat ben contraries *and* enemys
corompen hem // *and* yit the harde thinges as stoones clyuen *and* holden hyr
partyes to gydere ryht faste *and* harde / *and* deffenden hem in
withstondenge þat they ne departe nat lyhtly a twyne // *and* the thinges þat
ben softe *and* fletynge as is water *and* Eyr they departyn lyhtly // *and* yeuen
place to hem þat brekyn or deuyden hem // but natheles they retornen sone
ayein in to the same thinges fro whennes they ben arraced // but fyr [fleeth]
and refuseth alle deuysyoun / ne I. ne trete nat heere now of weleful
moeuynge of the sowle þat is knowynge // but of the naturel entencioun of
thinges // As thus ryht as we swolwe the mete þat we resseyuen *and* ne

thinke nat on it / *and* as we drawen owre breth in slepyng þat we wite it
nat whil we slepyt // For certes in the beestys the loue of hyr lyuynge ne of
hyr beeinges ne comth nat of the wilnynges of the sowle // but of the
bygynnyngis of nature // For certes thorw constreynynge causes / wil
desireth *and* embraceth ful ofte tyme / the deth þat nature dredith // that is
to seyn as thus that a man may ben constreynyd so by som cause that his
wil desireth and taketh the deth which þat nature hateth *and* dredeth ful sore
// And som tyme we seeth the contrarye / as thus that the wil of a wight /
destorbeth *and* constreyneth þat þat nature desireth / and requereth al-wey //
that is to seyn the werk of generacioun / by the whiche generacioun only /
dwelleth *and* is sustenyd the longe durablete of mortal thinges // And thus
this charite and this Loue þat euery thing hath to hym self ne comth nat of
the moeuynge of the sowle / but of the entencioun of nature // For the
puruyance of god hat yeuen to thinges þat ben creat of hym / this þat is a ful
gret cause / to lyuen *and* to duren / for which they desiren naturelly hyr lyf
as longe as euer they mowen // For w[h]ych thou maist nat drede by no
manere / that alle the thinges / that ben anywhere / that they ne requeren
naturelly / the ferme stablenesse of perdurable dwellynge / and ek the
eschuyng of destruccyon // B // now confesse I. wel *quod* I. that I. see wel
now certeynly / with owte dowtes / the thinges that whylom semeden
vncerteyn to me / P. // but *quod* she thilke thyng þat desireth to be *and* to
dwellyn perdurablely / he desireth to ben oon // For yif þat that oon weere
destroied // certes beinge ne shulde ther non dwellyn to no wiht // that is
soth *quod* I. // Thanne *quod* she desirin alle thinges oon // .I. assente *quod* .I.
// *and* I haue shewyd *quod* she that thilke same oon is thilke that is good //
B // ye forsothe *quod* I. // Alle thinges thanne *quod* she requyren good //
And thilke good thanne [pow] maist descryuen ryht thus // Good is thilke
thing þat euery wyht desireth // Ther ne may be thowht *quod* .I. no moore
verray thing / for either alle thinges ben referred *and* browht to nowht / *and*
floteryn with owte gouernour despoiled of oon / as of hir propre heued / or
elles yif ther be any thinge / to which þat alle thinges tenden *and* hyen / that
thing moste ben the souereyn good of alle goodes / P /. thanne seyde she
thus // O my norry *quod* she I haue gret gladnesse of the // For thou hast
fichched in thin herte the myddel sothtfastnesse // that is to seyn the prykke
// but this thing hath ben descouered to the / in that thou seydyst þat thou
wystest nat a lytel her by-forn // what was that *quod* I. // That thou ne

wystest nat *quod* she whych was the ende of thinges // and Certes that is the thing þat euery wiht desireth // and for as mochel as we han gaderid / *and* comprehendyd that good is thilke thing that is desired of alle / thanne moten we nedes confessun / that good is the fyn of alle thinges.

QUISQUIS PROFUNDA MENTE.

[The .11. Metrum.]

W Ho so that sekith soth by a deep thocht And coueyteth nat to ben deseyuyd by no mys-weyes // lat hym rollen *and* trenden *with* Inne hym self / the Lyht of his inward syhte // And lat hym gadere ayein enclynyng in to a compas the longe moeuynge of hys thowhtes / And lat hym techen his corage that he hath enclosed *and* hyd / in his tresors / al þat he compaseth or sekith fro *with* owte // And thanne thilke thing that the blake cloude of errour whilom hadde y-couered / shal lyhten more clerly thanne phebus hym self ne shyneth // Glosa // who so wole seken the dep[e] grounde / of soth in his thowht / *and* wol nat be deceyuyd by false proposiciouns / that goon amys fro the trouthe // lat hym wel examine / *and* rolle *with* inne hym self the nature *and* the propretes of the thing // and lat hym yit eft sones examine *and* rollen his thowhtes by good deliberacioun or that he deme // and lat hym techen his sowle that it hat by naturel pryncyplis kyndeliche y-hyd *with* in it self alle the trowthe the whiche he ymagynith to ben in thinges *with* owte // And thanne alle the dyrknesse of his mysknowynge shal seen more euydently to [þe] syhte of his vndyrstondynge thanne the sonne ne semyth to [þe] syhte *with* owte forth / For certes the body bryngynge the weyhte of foryetyng / ne hath nat chasyd owt of yowre thowhte al the clernesse of yowre knowyng // For certeynly the seed of sooth haldith *and* clyueth *with* in yowre corage / *and* it is a-waked *and* excited by the wynde *and* by the blastes of doctryne // For where for elles demen ye of yowre owne wyl the ryhtes whan ye ben axed // but yif so were þat the norysynges of resoun ne lyuede .I.-plowngyd in the depthe of yowre herte // this [is] to seyn how sholden men demen þe sooth of any thing þat weere axed / yif ther neere a Roote of sothfastnesse þat weere yplowngyd *and* hyd in the nature[l] pryncyplis / the whiche sothfastnesse lyued *with* in the depnesse of the thowght // *and* yif so be þat the Muse *and* the doctryne of plato syngyth sooth // al þat euery whyht

lerneth / he ne doth no thing elles thanne but recordeth as men recordyn
thinges þat ben foryetyn.

TUM EGO PLATONI INQUAM.

[The .12. prose.]

THanne seide I thus // I acorde me gretly to plato / for thow remenbrist
and recordist me thise thinges yit] þe seconde tyme. þat is to seyn. first
whan I lost[e] my memorie by þe contagioũs coniunccioun of þe body wiþ
þe soule. *and* eftsones afterward whan I lost[e] it confounded by þe charge
and by þe burden of my sorwe. ¶ And þan sayde she þus. ¶ If þou look[e]
quod she firste þe þinges þat þou hast graunted it ne shal nat ben ryzt feer
þat þou ne shalt remembren þilke þing þat þou seidest þat þou nistest nat.
what þing *quod* I. ¶ by whiche gouernment *quod* she þat þis worlde is
gouerned. Me remembriþ it wel *quod* I. *and* I confesse wel þat I ne wist[e]
it nat ¶ But al be it so þat I se now from afer what þou purposest ¶ Al gates I
desire ȝit to herkene it of þe more pleynely. ¶ þou ne wendest nat *quod* she a
litel here byforne þat men sholden doute þat þis worlde is gouerned by god.
¶ Certys *quod* I ne ȝitte doute I it nauȝt. ne I nil neuer wene þat it were to
doute. as who seiþ. but I wot wel þat god gouerneþ þis worlde. ¶ And I shal
shortly answer þe by what resouns I am brouȝt to þis. ¶ þis worlde *quod* I
of so many dyuerse *and* contrarious parties ne myȝten neuer han ben
assembled in o forme. but yif þere ne were oon þat conioigned so many[e
diuerse] þinges. ¶ And þe same diuersite of hire natures þat so discordeden
þat oon fro þat oþer most[e] departen *and* vnioignen þe þinges þat ben
conioigned. yif þere ne were oon þat contened[e] þat he haþ conioigned *and*
ybounde. ne þe certein ordre of nature ne sholde. nat brynge furþe so
ordinee moeuynge. by places. by tymes. by doynges. by spaces. by qualites.
yif þere ne were oon þat were ay stedfast dwellynge. þat ordeyned[e] *and*
disposed[e] þise diuersites of moeuynge. ¶ and þilke þinge what so euer it
be. by whiche þat alle þinges ben maked *and* ylad. I clepe hym god þat is a
worde þat is vsed to alle folke. þan seide she. syn þou felest þus þise þinges
quod she. I trowe þat I haue lytel more to done. þat þou myȝty of
wilfulnesse hool *and* sounde ne se eftsones þi contre. ¶ But lat vs loken þe
þinges þat we han purposed her-byforne. ¶ Haue I nat noumbred *and* seid
quod she þat suffisaunce is in blisfulnesse. *and* we han accorded þat god is
and þilke same blisfulnesse. ¶ yis forsoþe *quod* I. *and* þat to gouerne þis

worlde *quod* she. ne shal he neuer han nede of none helpe fro wipoute. for ellys yif he had[de] nede of any helpe. he ne sholde not haue [no] ful suffisaunce. ȝis þus it mot nedes be *quod* I. ¶ þan ordeyneþ he by hym self al oon alle þinges *quod* she. þat may nat ben denied *quod* I. ¶ And I haue shewed þat god is þe same good. ¶ It remembreþ me wel *quod* I. ¶ þan ordeineþ he alle þinges by þilke goode *quod* she. Syn he whiche we han accorded to ben good gouerneþ alle þingus by hym self. *and* he is a keye *and* a stiere by whiche þat þe edifice of þis worlde is ykept stable *and* wipoute corrupynge ¶ I accorde me gretly *quod* I. *and* I aperceiuede a litel here byforn þat þou woldest seyne þus. Al be it so þat it were by a þinne suspecion. I trowe it wel *quod* she. ¶ For as I trowe þou leedest now more ententifly þine eyen to loken þe verray goodes ¶ but nabeles þe þinges þat I shal telle þe ȝit ne sheweþ nat lasse to loken. what is þat *quod* I. ¶ So as men trowen *quod* she *and* þat ryȝtfully þat god gouerneþ alle þinges by þe keye of his goodnesse. ¶ And alle þise same þinges as I [haue] tauȝt þe. hasten hem by naturel entencion to comen to goode þer may no man douten. þat þei ne ben gouerned uoluntariely. *and* þat þei ne conuerten [hem] nat of her owen wille to þe wille of hire ordenour. as þei þat ben accordyng *and* enclinyng to her gouernour *and* her kyng. ¶ It mot nedys be so *quod*. I. ¶ For þe realme ne sholde not seme blisful ȝif þere were a ȝok of mysdrawynges in diuerse parties ne þe sauynge of obedient þinges ne sholde nat be. þan is þere no þing *quod* she þat kepiþ hys nature ; þat enforceþ hym to gone aȝeyne god. ¶ No *quod*. I. ¶ And if þat any þing enforced[e] hym to wipstonde god. myȝt[e] it auayle at þe laste aȝeyns hym þat we han graunted to ben al myȝty by þe ryȝt of blisfulnesse. ¶ Certis *quod* I al outerly it ne myȝt[e] nat auaylen hym. þan is þere no þing *quod* she þat eyþer wol or may wipstonde to þis souereyne good. ¶ I trowe nat *quod*. I ¶ þan is þilke þe souereyne good *quod* she þat alle þingus gouerneþ strongly *and* ordeyneþ hem softly. þan seide I þus. I delite me *quod* I nat oonly in þe endes or in þe sommes of [the] resouns þat þou hast concludid *and* proued. ¶ But þilke wordes þat þou vsest deliten me moche more. ¶ So at þe last[e] fooles þat somtyme renden greet[e] þinges auȝten ben asshamed of hem self. ¶ þat is to seyne þat we fooles þat reprehenden wickedly þe þingus þat touchen goddes gouernaunce we auȝten ben asshamed of oure self. As I þat seide god refuseþ oonly þe werkes of men. *and* ne entremetiþ

nat of hem. *p.* þou hast wel herd quod she þe fables of þe poetes. how þe geauntes assailden þe heuene wiþ þe goddes. but for soþe þe debonaire force of god disposed[e] hem so as it was worþi. þat is to seyne distroied[e] þe geauntes. as it was worþi. ¶ But wilt þou þat we ioygnen togedre þilke same resouns. for perauenture of swiche coniunccioun may sterten vp some faire sperkele of soþe ¶ Do quod I as þe list. wenest þou quod she þat god ne is almyȝty. no man is in doute of it. Certys quod I no wyȝt ne defendiþ it if he be in hys mynde. but he quod she þat is al myȝty þere nis no þing þat he ne may do. þat is soþe quod I. May god done yuel quod she. nay for soþe quod. I. ¶ þan is yuel no þing quod she. ¶ Syn þat he ne may not done yuel þat may done alle þinges. scornest þou me quod. I. or ellys pleyest þou or deceiuest þou me. þat hast so wouen me wiþ þi resouns. þe house of didalus so entrelaced. þat it is vnable to ben unlaced. þou þat oper while entrest þere þou issest *and* oper while issest þere þou entrest. ne fooldest þou nat to gidre by replicacioun of wordes a maner wondirful cercle or enviroynynge of symplite deuyne. ¶ For certys a litel her byforne whan þou bygunne atte blisfulnesse þou seidest þat it is souereyne good. *and* seidest þat it is set in souereyne god. *and* þat god is þe ful[le] blisfulnesse. for whiche þou ȝaf[e] me as a couenable ȝifte. þat is to seyne þat no wyȝt nis blisful. but yif he be good al so þer wiþ *and* seidest eke þat þe forme of goode is þe substaunce of god. *and* of blisfulnesse. *and* seidest þat þilke same oone is þilke same goode þat is requered *and* desired of al þe kynde of þinges. *and* þou proeuedest in disputynge þat god gouerneþ alle [the] þinges of þe worlde by þe gouvernementys of bountee. *and* seydest þat alle þinges wolen ybeyen to hym. *and* seidest þat þe nature of yuel nis no þing. *and* þise þinges ne shewedest þou nat wiþ no resouns ytake fro wiþoute but by proues in cercles *and* homelyche knowen. ¶ þe whiche proeues drawn to hem self hir feiþ *and* hir accorde eueriche [of] hem of oper. þan seide she þus. I ne scorne þe nat ne pleye ne desseyue þe. but I haue shewed to þe þinge þat is grettest ouer alle þinges by þe ȝifte of god þat we some tyme prayden ¶ For þis is þe forme of [the] deuyne substaunce. þat is swiche þat it ne slydeþ nat in to outerest foreine þinges. ne ne rec[e]lyueþ no strange þinges in hym. but ryȝt as *parmaynws* seide in grek of þilke deuyne substaunce. he seide þus þat þilke deuyne substaunce torneþ þe worlde *and* þilke cercle moeueable of þinges while þilke dyuyne substaunce kepiþ it self wiþ outen moeuyng. þat is to seyne þat it ne moeuiþ neuere mo. *and*

zitte it moeueþ alle oþer þinges. but na-þeles yif I [haue] stered resouns þat ne ben nat taken fro wiþ oute þe compas of þe þinge of whiche we treten. but resouns þat ben bystowed wiþ inne þat compas þere nis nat whi þat þou sholde[st] merueylen. sen þou hast lerned by þe sentence of plato þat nedes þe wordes moten ben cosynes to þo þinges of whiche þei speken.

FELIX QUI POTERIT. *ET CETERA.*

[The .12. Metur.]

Blisful is þat man þat may seen þe clere welle of good. blisful is he þat may vnbynde hym fro þe bonde of heuy erþe. ¶ þe poete of trace [orpheus] þat somtyme hadde ryzt greet sorowe for þe deef of hys wijf. aftir þat he hadde maked by hys wepely songes þe wodes meueable to rennen. *and* hadde ymaked þe ryueres to stonden stille. *and* maked þe hertys *and* hyndes to ioignen dredles hir sides to cruel lyouns to herkene his songe. *and* had[de] maked þat þe hare was nat agast of þe hounde whiche þat was plesed by hys songe. so þat whane þe most[e] ardaunt loue of hys wijf brende þe entrailes of his brest. ne þe songes þat hadde ouer comen alle þinges ne myzten nat assuage hir lorde orpheus. ¶ He pleyned[e] hym of þe godes þat weren cruel to hym. he wente hym to þe houses of helle *and* þere he tempred[e] hys blaundissyng songes by resounyng of hys strenges. ¶ And spak *and* song in wepyng alle þat euer he hadde resceyued *and* laued oute of þe noble welles of hys modir calliope þe goddesse. *and* he song wiþ as mychel as he myzt[e] of wepyng. *and* wiþ as myche as loue þat doubled[e] his sorwe myzt[e] zeuen hym *and* teche hym in his seke herte. ¶ And he commoeuede þe helle *and* requered[e] *and* souzte by swete preiere þe lordes of soules in helle of relesyng. þat is to seyne to zelden hym hys wif. ¶ Cerberus þe porter of helle wiþ his þre heuedes was cauzt *and* al abaist for þe new[e] songe. *and* þe þre goddesses furijs *and* vengerisse of felonies þat tourmenten *and* agasten þe soules by anoye wexen sorweful *and* sory *and* wepen teres for pitee. þan was nat þe heued of Ixione ytourmented by þe ouerþrowing whele. ¶ And tantalus þat was destroyed by þe woodnesse of longe þrust dispiseþ þe flodes to drynke. þe fowel þat hyzt voltor þat etip þe stomak or þe giser of ticius is so fulfilled of his songe þat it nil etyn ne tyren no more. ¶ Atte þe laste þe lorde *and* Iuge of soules was moeued to misericordes *and* cried[e] we ben ouer comen *quod* he. yif[e] we to orpheus his wijf to bere hym compaignye he hap welle

I-bouȝt hir by his faire songe *and* his ditee. but we wil putten a lawe in þis. *and* couenaunt in þe ȝifte. þat is to seyne. þat til he be out of helle yif he loke byhynden hym [þat] hys wijf shal comen aȝeine to vs ¶ but what is he þat may ȝeue a lawe to loueres. loue is a gretter lawe *and* a strengere to hym self þan any lawe þat men may ȝeuen. ¶ Allas whan Orpheus *and* his wijf were al most at þe termes of þe nyȝt. þat is to seyne at þe last[e] boundes of helle. Orpheus loked[e] abakwarde on Erudice his wijf *and* lost[e] hir *and* was deed. ¶ þis fable apperteineþ to ȝow alle who so euer desirēþ or sekēþ to lede his þouȝte in to þe souereyne day. þat is to seyne to clerenes[se] of souereyne goode. ¶ For who so þat euere be so ouer comen þat he fycche hys eyen in to þe put[te] of helle. þat is to seyne who so setteþ his þouȝtes in erþely þinges. al þat euer he haþ drawen of þe noble good celestial he lesiþ it whan he lokeþ þe helles. þat is to seyne to lowe þinges of þe erþe.

EXPLICIT LIBER TERCIUS.

INCIPIT LIBER QUARTUS.

HEC CUM PHILOSOPHIA DIGNITATE

[The 1^{ma} prose.]

UULTUS.

Whanne philosophie hadde songen softly *and* delitably þe forseide þinges kepyng þe dignitee of hir choere in þe weyȝte of hir wordes. I þan þat ne hadde nat al outerly forȝeten þe wepyng *and* mournyng þat was set in myne herte for-brek þe entencioun of hir þat entended[e] ȝitte to seyne oþer þinges. ¶ Se quod I. þou þat art gideresse of verray lyȝte þe þinges þat þou hast seid [me] hider to ben to me so clere *and* so shewyng by þe deuyne lokyng of hem *and* by þi resouns þat þei ne mowe nat ben ouercomen. ¶ And þilke þingus þat þou toldest me. al be it so þat I hadde som tyme fo[r]ȝeten hem for [the] sorwe of þe wronge þat haþ ben don to me. ȝit napeles þei ne were nat alouterly vnknownen to me. but þis same is namly a gret cause of my sorwe. þat so as þe gouernoure of þinges is goode. yif þat yuelys mowen ben by any weyes. or ellys yif þat yuelys passen wiþ outen punyssheinge. þe whiche þinge oonly how worþi it is to ben wondred

vpon. þou considerest it weel þi self certeynly. but 3itte to þis þing þere is an oþer þing y-ioigned more to ben ywondred vpon. ¶ For felonie is emperisse *and* flowreþ ful of rycchesse. and vertues nis nat al oonly wiþ outen medes. but it is cast vndir *and* fortroden vndir þe feet of felonous folk. *and* it abieþ þe tourmentes in sted of wicked felouns ¶ Of al[le] whiche þing þer nis no wyȝt þat [may] merueyllen ynouȝ ne compleyne þat swiche þinges ben don in þe regne of god þat alle þinges woot. and alle þinges may *and* ne wool nat but only goode þinges. ¶ þan seide she þus. certys quod she þat were a grete meruayle *and* an enbaissyng wiþouten ende. *and* wel more horrible þan alle monstres yif it were as þou wenest. þat is to sein. þat in þe ryȝt ordeyne house of so mochel a fader *and* an ordenour of meyne. þat þe vesseles þat ben foule *and* vyle sholde ben honoured *and* heried. and þe precious uesteles sholde ben defouled *and* vyle. but it nis nat so. For yif þe þinges þat I haue concluded a litel here byforne ben kept hoole *and* vnaced. þou shalt wel knowe by þe auctorite of god. of þe whos regne I speke þat certys þe good[e] folk ben alwey myȝty. *and* shrewes ben alwey yuel *and* feble. ne þe vices ben neuere mo wiþ outen peyne ; ne þe vertues ne ben nat wiþ outen mede. and þat blisfulnesses comen alwey to goode folke. *and* infortune comeþ alwey to wicked folke. ¶ And þou shalt wel knowe many[e] þinges of þis kynde þat sholle cessen þi pleyntes. *and* stedfast þe wiþ stedfast saddenesse. ¶ And for þou hast seyn þe forme of þe verray blisfulnesse by me þat [haue] somtyme I-shewed it þe. And þou hast knowen in whom blysfulnesse is set. alle þinges I treted þat I trowe ben nessessarie to put[te] furþe ¶ I shal shewe þe. þe weye þat shal brynge þe aȝeyne vnto þi house *and* I shal ficche feperes in þi þouȝt by whiche it may aysen in heyȝte. so þat al tribulacioun don away þou by my gidyng & by my pape *and* by my sledes shalt mowen retourne hool *and* sounde in to þi contre.

SUNT ETENIM PENNE. *ET CETERA.*

[The fyrste metur.]

I Haue for soþe swifte feperes þat surmounten þe heyȝt of þe heuene whan þe swifte þouȝt haþ cloped it self. in þo feperes it dispiseþ þe hat[e]ful erþes. *and* surmounteþ þe heyȝenesse of þe greet[e] eyir. *and* it seiþ þe cloudes by-hynde hir bak *and* passeþ þe heyȝt of þe regioun of þe fire þat

eschaufiþ by þe swifte moeuyng of þe firmament. til þat she a-reisiþ hir in til þe houses þat beren þe sterres. *and* ioygneþ hir weyes wiþ þe sonne phebus. *and* felawshiþ þe weye of þe olde colde saturnus. and she ymaked a knyzt of þe clere sterre. þat is to seyne þat þe soule is maked goddys knyzt by þe sekyng of treuþe to comen to þe verray knowlege of god. and þilke soule renne[þ] by þe cercle of þe sterres in alle þe places þere as þe shynyng nyzt is depeynted. þat is to seyne þe nyzt þat is cloudeles. for on nyztes þat ben cloudeles it semeþ as þe heuene were peynted wiþ dyuerse ymages of sterres. *and* whan þe soule haþ gon ynouȝ she shal forleten þe last[e] poynt of þe heuene. *and* she shal pressen *and* wenden on þe bak of þe swifte firmament. and she shal ben maked perfit of þe dredefulle clerenesse of god. ¶ þere haldeþ þe lorde of kynges þe ceptre of his myzt *and* attempereþ þe gouernementes of þis worlde. *and* þe shynyng iuge of þinges stable in hym self gouerneþ þe swifte carte. þat is to seyne þe circuler moeuyng of [the] sonne. *and* yif þi weye ledeþ þe aȝeyne so þat þou be brouȝt þider. þan wilt þou seye now þat þat is þe contre þat þou requeredest of whiche þou ne haddest no mynde. but now it remembreþ me wel here was I born. here wil I fastne my degree. here wil I dwelle. but yif þe lyke þan to loken on þe derkenesse of þe erþe þat þou hast for-leten. þan shalt þou seen þat þise felonous tyrauntes þat þe wrecched[e] poeple dredeþ now shule ben exiled from þilke faire contre.

TUNC EGO PAPE INQUAM. *ET CETERA.*

[The 2^e prose.]

P Anne seide I þus. [owh] I wondre me þat þou by-hetest me so grete þinges. ne I ne doute nat þat þou ne mayst wel performe þat þou by-hetest. but I preie þe oonly þis. þat þou ne tarie nat to telle me þilke þinges þat þou hast meoued. first quod she þou most nedes knowen. þat good[e] folk ben al wey strong[e] *and* myȝty. and þe shrewes ben feble *and* desert *and* naked of alle strengþes. and of þise þinges certys eueryche of hem is declared *and* shewed by oþer. ¶ For so as good *and* yuel ben two contraries. yif so be þat goode be stedfast. þan sheweþ þe fieblesse of yuel al openly. and yif þou knowe clerely þe freelnesse of yuel. þe stedfastnesse of goode is knowen. but for as moche as þe fey of my sentence shal be þe more ferme *and* haboundaunt. I wil goon by þat oon wey *and* by þat oþer *and* I wil conferme þe þinges þat ben purposed now on þis side *and* now on þat syde.

¶ Two þinges þer ben in whiche þe effect of alle þe dedes of man kynde standiþ. þat is to seyn. wil *and* power. and yif þat oon of þise two fayleþ þere nis no þing þat may be don. for yif þat wil lakkeþ þere nys no wyzt þat vndirtakeþ to done þat he wol not don. and yif power fayleþ þe wille nis but in ydel *and* stant for nauzt. and þer of comeþ it þat yif þou se a wyzt þat wolde geten þat he may nat geten. þou mayst nat douten þat power ne fayleþ hym to hauen þat he wolde. ¶ þis is open *and* clere quod I. ne it may nat ben denyed in no manere. and yif þou se a wyzt quod she. þat haþ don þat he wolde don þou nilt nat douten þat he ne haþ had power to done it. no quod. I. and in þat. þat euery wyzt may. in þat þat men may holden hym myzty. as who seiþ in as moche as a man is myzty to done a þing. in so moche men halden hym myzty. and in þat þat he ne may. in þat men demen hym to ben feble. I confesse it wel quod I. Remembriþ þe quod she þat I. haue gadred *and* shewed by forseide resouns þat al þe entencioun of þe wil of mankynde whiche þat is lad by diuerse studies hastiþ to comen to blisfulnesse. ¶ It remembreþ me wel quod I þat it hath ben shewed. *and* recorderþ þe nat þan quod she. þat blisfulnesse is þilke same goode þat men requeren. so þat whan þat blisfulnesse is requered of alle. þat goode [also] is requered *and* desired of al. It recorderþ me wel quod I. for haue it gretly alwey ficche[d] in my memorie. alle folk þan quod she goode *and* eke badde enforcen hem wiþ oute difference of entencioun to comen to goode. þat is a uerray consequence quod I. and certeyne is quod she þat by þe getyng of goode ben men ymaked goode. þis is certeyne quod. I. ¶ þan geten goode men þat þei desiren. so semeþ it quod I. but wicked[e] folk quod she yif þei geten þe goode þat þei desiren þei [ne] mowen nat ben wicked. so is it quod .I. ¶ þan so as þat oon *and* þat oþer [quod she] desiren good. *and* þe goode folk geten good *and* nat þe wicked folk ¶ þan nis it no doute þat þe goode folk ne ben myzty *and* þe wicked folk ben feble. ¶ who so þat euer quod I douteþ of þis. he ne may nat conside þe nature of þinges. ne þe consequence of resoun. and ouer þis quod she. ¶ yif þat þer ben two þinges þat han o same purpos by kynde. *and* þat one of hem pursueþ *and* performeþ þilke same þinge by naturel office. *and* þat oþer ne may nat done þilk naturel office. but folweþ by oþer manere þan is couenable to nature ¶ Hym þat acomplisþ hys purpos kyndely. *and* zit he ne acomplisþ nat hys owen purpos. wheþer of þise two demest þou for more myzty. ¶ yif þat I coniecte quod .I. þat þou wilt seye algates. zit I desire to herkene it more

pleynely of þe. þou nilt nat þan denye quod she þat þe moeuementz of goynge nis in men by kynde. no for soþe quod I. ne þou ne doutest nat quod she þat þilke naturel office of goynge ne be þe office of feet. I ne doute it nat quod .I. þan quod she yif þat a wyzt be myzty to moeue *and* goþ vpon hys feet. and anoper to whom þilke naturel office of feet lakkeþ. enforceþ hym to gone crepyng vpon hys handes. ¶ whiche of þise two auzte to ben holden more myzty by ryzt. knyht furþe þe remenaunt quod I. ¶ For no wyzt ne douteþ þat he þat may gone by naturel office of feet. ne be more myzty þan he þat ne may nat ¶ but þe souereyne good quod she þat is euenlyche purposed to þe good folk *and* to badde. þe good folke seken it by naturel office of uertues. *and* þe shrewes enforcen hem to geten it by dyuerse couetise of erþely þinges. whiche þat nis no naturel office to geten þilke same souereyne goode. trowest þou þat it be any oþer wyse. nay quod .I. for þe consequence is open *and* shewynge of þinges þat I haue graunted. ¶ þat nedes goode folk moten ben myzty. *and* shrewes feble *and* vnmyzty. ¶ þou rennest aryzt byfore me quod she. *and* þis is þe iugement þat is to seyn. ¶ I iuge of þe ryzt as þise leches ben wont forto hopen of seke folk whan þei aperceyuen þat nature is redressed *and* wiþstondeþ to þe maladie. ¶ But for I see þe now al redy to þe vndirstandyng I shal shewe þe more þilke *and* continuel resouns. ¶ For loke now how gretly shewiþ þe feblesse *and* infirmite of wicked folke. þat ne mowen nat come to þat hire naturel entencioun ledeþ hem. *and* zitte almost þilk naturel entencioun constreineþ hem. ¶ *and* what were to deme þan of shrewes. yif þilke naturel helpe hadde for-leten hem. ¶ þe whiche naturel helpe of entencioun goþ alwey byforne hem. *and* is so grete þat vnneþ it may be ouercomen. ¶ Considre þan how gret defeaute of power *and* how gret feblesse þere is in grete felonous folk as who seiþ þe gretter þinges þat ben coueited *and* þe desire nat accomplisshed of þe lasse myzt is he þat coueiteþ it *and* may nat acomplisse. ¶ And forþi philosophie seiþ þus by souereyne good. ¶ Shrewes ne requere nat lyzt[e] medes ne veyne gaines whiche þei ne may nat folwen ne holden. but þei faylen of þilke some of þe heyzte of þinges þat is to seyne souereyne good. ne þise wrecches ne comen nat to þe effect of souereyne good. þe whiche þei enforcen hem oonly to geten by nyztes *and* by dayes. ¶ In þe getyn[g] of whiche goode þe strengþe of good folk. is ful wel ysen. For ryzt so as þou myztest demen hym myzty of goynge þat goþ on hys feet til he myzt[e] come to þilke place fro þe whiche place þere ne lay no wey forþer to be

gon. Ryȝt so most þou nedes demen hym for ryȝt myȝty þat getiþ *and* atteiniþ to þe ende of alle þinges þat ben to desire. by-ȝonde þe whiche ende þat þer nis no þing to desire. ¶ Of whiche power of good folk men may conclude þat wicked men semen to ben bareyne *and* naked of alle strengþe. For whi forleten þei *vertues and* folwen vices. nis it nat for þat þei ne knowen nat þe goodes. ¶ But what þing is more feble *and* more caitif þan is þe blyndenesse of ignoraunce. or ellys þei knowen ful wel whiche þinges þat þei auȝten to folwen ¶ but lecherye *and* couetise ouerproweþ hem mysturned. ¶ and certis so doþ distemperaunce to feble men. þat ne mowen nat wrastle aȝeins þe vices ¶ Ne knowen þei nat þan wel þat þei foreleten þe good wilfully. *and* turnen hem vilfully to vices. ¶ And in þis wise þei ne forleten nat oonly to ben myȝty. but þei forleten al outerly in any wise forto ben ¶ For þei þat forleten þe comune fyn of alle þinges þat ben. þei for-leten also þerwiþ al forto ben. and perauenture it sholde semen to som folk þat þis were a merueile to seyne þat shrewes whiche þat contienen þe more *partie* of men ne ben nat. ne han no beyng. ¶ but napeles it is so. *and* þus stant þis þing for þei þat ben shrewes I denye nat þat þei ben shrewes. but I denye *and* sey[e] symplely and pleynly þat þei [ne] ben nat. ne han no beyng. for ryȝt as þou myȝtest seyn of þe careyne of a man þat it were a ded man. ¶ but þou ne myȝtest nat symplely callen it a man. ¶ So graunt[e] I wel for soþe þat vicious folk ben wicked. but I ne may nat graunten absolutely *and* symplely þat þei ben. ¶ For þilk þing þat wiþ holdeþ ordre *and* kepiþ nature. þilk þing is *and* haþ beyng. but þat þing þat faileþ of þat. þat is to seyne he þat forletiþ naturel ordre he for-letiþ þilk beyng þat is set in hys nature. but þou wolt sein þat shrewes mowen. ¶ Certys þat ne denye I nat. ¶ but certys hir power ne descendep nat of strengþe but of feblesse. for þei mowen don wickednesses. þe whiche þei ne myȝten nat don yif þei myȝten dwelle in þe forme *and* in þe doynge of goode folke. ¶ And þilke power sheweþ ful euydently þat þei ne mowen ryȝt nauȝt. ¶ For so as I haue gadered *and* proued a lytel her byforn þat yuel is nauȝt. *and* so as shrewes mowen oonly but shrewednesse. þis conclusioun is al clere. þat shrewes ne mowen ryȝt nat to han power. and for as moche as þou vndirstonde whiche is þe strengþe þat is power of shrewes. I haue diffinised a lytel here byforn þat no þing nis so myȝty as souereyne good ¶ þat is soþe *quod* .I. [*and* thilke same souereyn good may don non yuel // Certes no *quod* I] ¶ Is þer any wyȝt þan *quod* she þat wenip þat men mowen don alle þinges. No man *quod*

.I. but yif he be out of hys witte. ¶ but certys shrewes mowen doñ yuel quod she. ¶ 3e wolde god quod I þat þei ne myȝten don none. þat quod she so as he þat is myȝty to done oonly but good[e] þinges may don alle þinges. and þei þat ben myȝty to done yuel[e] þinges ne mowen nat alle þinges. þan is þis open þing *and* manifest þat þei þat mowen don yuel ben of lasse power. and ȝitte to proue þis conclusioun þere helpeþ me þis þat I haue shewed here byforne. þat al power is to be noumbred amonge þinges þat men auȝten requere. *and* haue shewed þat alle þinges þat auȝten ben desired ben referred to good ryȝt as to a manere heyȝte of hyr nature. ¶ But for to mowen don yuel *and* felonye ne may nat ben referred to good. þan nis nat yuel of þe noumbre of þinges þat auȝten. be desired. but al power auȝt[e] ben desired *and* required. ¶ þan is it open *and* cler þat þe power ne þe moeuynge of shrewes nis no powere. *and* of alle þise þinges it sheweþ wel þat þe goode folk ben certeynly myȝty. *and* þe shrewes ben douteles vnmyȝty ¶ And it is clere *and* open þat þilke sentence of plato is uerray *and* soþe. þat seȝþ þat oonly wisemen may [doon] þat þei desiren. *and* shrewes mowen haunten þat hem lykeþ. but þat þei desiren þat is to seyne to comen to souereyne good þei ne han no power to acomplissen þat. ¶ For shrewes don þat hem list whan by þo þinges in whiche þei deliten þei wenen to atteyne to þilke good þat þei desiren. but þei ne geten ne atteynen nat þer to. ¶ for vices ne comen nat to blisfulnesse.

QUOS UIDES SEDERE CELSOS.

[The ij^{de} Metur.]

Who so þat þe couertures of her veyn apparailes myȝt[e] strepen of þise proude kynges þat þou seest sitten on heyȝe in her chayeres glyteryng in shynyng purpre envyrned wiþ sorweful armures manasyng wiþ cruel mouþe. blowyng by woodnesse of herte. ¶ He sholde se þan þat ilke lordes beren wiþ inne hir corages ful streyte cheynes for leccherye tormentiþ hem on þat oon syde wiþ gredy venyms *and* troublable Ire þat araiseþ in hem þe floodes of troublinges tourmentiþ vpon þat oþer side hir þouȝt. or sorwe halt hem wery or ycauȝt. or slidyng *and* disseyuyng hope tourmentiþ hem. And þerfore syn þou seest on heed. þat is to seyne oon tyraunt bere so many[e] tyrauntis. þan ne doþ þilk tyraunt nat þat he desiriþ. syn he is cast doune wiþ so many[e] wicked lordes. þat is to seyn wiþ so many[e] vices. þat han so wicked lordshipes ouer hym.

S Eest þou nat þan in how gret filþe þise shrewes ben ywrapped. *and* wiþ
 whiche cleernesse þise good folk shynen. In þis sheweþ it wel þat to
 good folk ne lakkeþ neuer mo hir medes. ne shrewes ne lakken neuer mo
tourmentis. for of alle þinges þat ben ydon þilke þing for whiche any þing is
 doon. it semeþ as by ryzt þat þilke þing be þe mede of þat. as þus. ¶ yif a
 man renneþ in þe stadie or in þe forlonge for þe corone. þan lieþ þe mede in
 þe corone for whiche he renneþ. ¶ And I haue shewed þat blisfulnesse is
 þilke same good for whiche þat alle þingus ben don. þan is þilke same good
purposed to þe werkes of mankynde ryzt as a comune mede. whiche mede
 ne may ben disseuered fro good folk. for no wyzt as by ryzt fro þennes
 forþe þat hym lakkiþ goodnesse ne shal ben cleped good. For whiche þing
 folk of good[e] maneres her medes ne forsaken hem neuer mo. For al be it
 so þat shrewes waxen as wood as hem list azeynes good[e] folk. zitte neuer
 þe les þe corone of wise men ne shal nat fallen ne faden. ¶ For foreine
 shrewednesse ne bynymeþ nat fro þe corages of good[e] folk hire *propre*
honoure. but yif þat any wyzt reioiseþ hem of goodnesse þat þei had[de]
 taken fro wiþoute. as who seiþ yif [þat] any wyzt had[de] hys goodnesse of
 any oþer man þan of hym self. certys he þat 3af hym þilke goodnesse or
 ellys som oþer wyzt myzt[e] bynym[e] it hym. but for as moche as to euery
 wyzt hys owen *propre* bounte 3eueþ hym hys mede. þan at arst shal he
 faylen of mede whan he forletip to ben good. *and* at þe laste so as alle
 medes ben requered for men wenen þat þei ben good[e]. who is he þat
 wolde deme þat he þat is ryzt myzty of goode were *partles* of mede. *and* of
 what mede shal he be gerdoned. certys of ryzt faire mede *and* ryzt greet
 abouen alle medes. ¶ Remembre þe of þilk noble corolarie þat I 3af þe a
 lytel here byforne. *and* gadre it to gidre in þis manere. so as god hym self is
 blisfulnesse. þan is it clere *and* certeyn. þat alle good folk ben makid blisful
 for þei ben good[e]. and þilke folk þat ben blisful it accordip *and* is
 couenable to ben godde[s]. þan is þe mede of goode folk swiche. þat no day
 [ne] shal enpeyren it. ne no wickednesse shal endirken it. ne power of no
 wyzt ne shal nat amenusen it þat is to seyn to ben maked goddes. ¶ and syn
 it is þus þat goode men ne faylen neuer mo of hire medes. ¶ certys no wise
 man ne may doute of þe vndepartable peyne of shrewes. ¶ þat is to seyn þat
 þe peyne of shrewes ne departip nat from hem self neuer mo. ¶ For so as

goode *and* yuel *and* peyne *and* medes ben contrarie it mot nedes ben þat ryzt as we seen by-tiden in gerdoun of goode. þat also mot þe peyne of yuel answer by þe contrarie partye to shrewes. now þan so as bounte *and* prowesse ben þe medes to goode folk. also is shrewednesse it self torment to shrewes ¶ þan who so þat euer is entecched *and* defouled wiþ yuel. yif shrewes wolen þan preisen hem self may it semen to hem þat þei ben wiþ outen partye of tourment. syn þei ben swiche þat þe [vtteriste wikkednesse / þat is to seyn wikkede thewes / which þat is the] outereste *and* þe w[or]ste kynde of shrewednesse ne defouliþ nat ne entecehiþ nat hem oonly but infectiþ *and* enuenemyþ hem gretely ¶ And al so loke on shrewes þat ben þe contrarie partye of goode men. how grete peyne felawshiþ *and* folweþ hem. ¶ For þou hast lerned a litel here byforn þat al þing þat is *and* haþ beyng is oon. *and* þilke same oon is good. þan is þis consequence þat it semeþ wel. þat al þat is *and* haþ beyng is good. þis is to seyne. as who seiþ þat beyng *and* vnite *and* goodnesse is al oon. *and* in þis manere it folweþ þan. þat al þing þat faileþ to ben good. it styntiþ forto be. *and* forto haue any beyng. wher fore it is þat shrewes stynten forto ben þat þei weren. but þilke oþer forme of mankynde. þat is to seyne þe forme of þe body wiþ oute. shewiþ ȝit þat þise shrewes were somtyme men. ¶ wher fore whan þei ben peruerted *and* torned in to malice. certys þan han þei forlorn þe nature of mankynde. but so as oonly bounte *and* prowesse may enhawnse euery man ouer oþer men. þan mot it nedes be þat shrewes whiche þat shrewednesse haþ cast out of þe condicioun of mankynde ben put vnder þe merite *and* þe deserte of men. þan bitidiþ it þat yif þou seest a wyzt þat be transformed in to vices. þou ne mayst nat wene þat he be a man. ¶ For ȝif he [be] ardaunt in auarice. *and* þat he be a rauynour by violence of foreine rychesse. þou shalt seyn þat he is lyke to a wolf. *and* yif he be felonous *and* wiþ out reste *and* exercise hys tonge to chidynges. þou shalt lykene hym to þe hounde. *and* yif he be a preue awaitour yhid *and* reioyseþ hym to rauysshe by wyles. þou shalt seyne hym lyke to þe fox whelpes. ¶ And yif he be distempre *and* quakiþ for ire men shal wene þat he bereþ þe corage of a lyoun. *and* yif he be dredeful *and* fleyng and dredeþ þinges þat ne auȝten nat ben dred. men shal holde hym lyke to þe herte. *and* yif he be slowe *and* astoned *and* lache. he lyueþ as an asse. *and* yif he be lyzt *and* vnstedfast of corage *and* chaungeþ ay his studies. he is lickened to briddes. ¶ *and* yif he be plounged in foule *and* vnclene luxuries. he is wiþholden in þe foule

delices of þe foule soowe. ¶ þan folweþ it þat he þat forletip bountee *and* prowesse. he forletip to ben a man. syn he ne may nat passe in to þe condicioun of god. he is tourned in to a beest.

V[E]LA NARICII DUCIS.

[The 3^{de} Metur.]

Evrus þe wynde aryueþ þe sayles of vlixes duc of þe contre of narice. *and* hys wandryng shippes by þe see in to þe isle þere as Circe þe fayre goddesse douȝter of þe sonne dwelleþ þat medlyþ to hir newe gestes drynkes þat ben touched *and* maked wiþ enchauntmentȝ. *and* after þat hir hande myȝty of þe herbes had[de] chaunged hir gestes in to dyuerse maneres. þat oon of hem is couered his face wiþ forme of a boor. þat oþer is chaunged in to a lyoun of þe contre of marmorike. *and* his nayles *and* his teþe wexen. ¶ þat oþer of hem is newliche chaunged in to a wolf. *and* howeliþ whan he wolde wepe. þat oþer goþ debonairly in þe house as a tigre of Inde. but al be it so þat þe godhed of mercurie þat is cleped þe bride of arcadie haþ had mercie of þe duc vlixes byseged wiþ diuerse yueles *and* haþ vnbounden hym fro þe pestilence of hys oosteresse algates þe rowers *and* þe maryners hadden by þis ydrawen in to hir mouþes *and* dronken þe wicked[e] drynkes þei þat were woxen swyne hadden by þis chaunged hire mete of brede forto ete acorns of ookes. non of hir lymes ne dwelliþ wiþ hem hoole. but þei han lost þe voys *and* þe body. Oonly hire þouȝt dwelleþ wiþ hem stable þat wepiþ *and* bywailiþ þe monstrous chaungynge þat þei suffren. ¶ O ouer lyȝt hand. as who seiþ. ¶ O feble *and* lyȝt is þe hand of Circes þe enchaunteresse þat chaungeþ þe bodies of folk in to bestes to regarde *and* to comparisoun of mutacioun þat is makid by vices. ne þe herbes of circes ne ben nat myȝty. for al be it so þat þei may chaungen þe lymes of þe body. ¶ algates ȝit þei may nat chaunge þe hertes. for wiþ inne is yhid þe strengþe *and* þe vigour of men in þe secre toure of hire hertys. þat is to seyn þe strengþe of resoun. but þilke uenymys of vices to-drawen a man to hem more myȝtily þan þe venym of circes. ¶ For vices ben so cruel þat þei percen *and* þoruȝ passen þe corage wiþ inne. *and* þouȝ þei ne anoye nat þe body. ȝitte vices wooden to distroien men by wounde of þouȝt.

TUNC EGO FATEOR INQUAM.

[The ferthe prose.]

Pan seide I þus I confesse *and* am aknowe quod I. ne I ne se nat þat men may seyn as by ryzt. þat shrewes ne ben nat chaunged in to beestes by þe qualite of hir soules. ¶ Al be it so þat þei kepen zitte þe forme of þe body of mankynde. but I nolde nat of shrewes of whiche þe þouzt cruel woodeþ alwey in to destruccioun of good[e] men. þat it were leueful to hem to done þat. ¶ Certys quod she ne it nis nat leueful to hem as I shal wel shewen þe in couenable place. ¶ But napeles yif so were þat þilke þat men wenen ben leueful for shrewes were bynomen hem. so þat þei ne myzten nat anoyen or don harme to goode men. ¶ Certys a gret party of þe peyne to shrewes shulde ben allegged *and* releued. ¶ For al be it so þat þis ne seme nat credible þing peraventure to somme folk zit mot it nedes be þat shrewes ben more wrecches *and* vnsely. whan þei may don *and* performe þat þei coueiten [than yif they myhte nat compllyssen þat they coueyten]. ¶ For yif so be þat it be wrecchednesse to wilne to don yuel ; þan is it more wrecchednesse to mowen don yuel. wiþ oute whiche moeuyng þe wrecched wille sholde languisshe wiþ oute effecte. ¶ þan syn þat eueryche of þise þinges haþ hys wrecchednesse. þat is to seyne wil to done yuel. and moeuyng to done yuel. it mot nedes be. þat þei (shrewes) ben constreyned by þre vnselynesses þat wolen *and* mowen *and* performen felonyes *and* shrewednesses. ¶ I accorde me quod I. but I desire gretely þat shrewes losten sone þilke vnselynesses. þat is to seyne þat shrewes were despoyled of moeuyng to don yuel. ¶ so shullen þei quod she. sonnere peraventure þen þou woldest or sonnere þen þei hem self wenen to lakken mowynge to done yuel. ¶ For þere nis no þing so late in so short boundes of þis lijf þat is longe to abide. namelyche to a corage inmortal. Of whiche shrewes þe grete hope *and* þe heye compassyngus of shrewednesse is often destroyed by a sodeyne ende or þei ben war. *and* þat þing establiþ to shrewes þe ende of hir shrewednesse. ¶ For yif þat shrewednesse make wrecches. þan mot he nedes be most wrecched þat lengest is a shrewe. þe whiche wicked shrewes wolde ydemen aldirmost vnsely *and* caytifs yif þat hir shrewednes ne were yfinissed. at þe leste weye by þe outerest[e] deep. for [yif] I haue concluded soþe of þe vnselynesse of shrewednesse. þan sheweþ it clerely þat þilke shrewednesse is wiþ outen ende þe whiche is certeyne to ben perdurable. ¶ Certys quod I þis [conclusion] is harde *and* wonderful to graunte. ¶ But I knowe wel þat it accordeþ moche to [the] þinges þat I haue graunted her

byforne. ¶ þou hast quod she þe ryȝt estimacioun of þis. but who so euere wene þat it be an harde þing to acorde hym to a conclusioun. it is ryȝt þat he shewe þat somme of þe premisses ben fals. or ellys he mot shewe þat þe colasioun of preposiciouns nis nat spedful to a necessarie conclusion. ¶ and yif it be nat so. but þat þe premisses ben ygranted þer nis nat whi he sholde blame þe argument. for þis þing þat I shal telle þe nowe ne shal not seme lasse wondirful. but of þe þinges þat ben taken al so it is necessarie as who so seiþ it folweþ of þat whiche þat is purposed byforn. what is þat quod I. ¶ certys quod she þat is þat þat þise wicked shrewes ben more blysful or ellys lasse wrecches. þat byen þe tourmentes þat þei han deserued. þan yif no peyne of Iustice ne chastied[e] hem. ne þis ne seye I nat now for þat any man myȝt[e] þenk[e] þat þe maneres of shrewes ben coriged *and* chastised by veniaunce. *and* þat þei ben brouȝt to þe ryȝt wey by þe drede of þe tourment. ne for þat þei ȝeuen to oþer folk ensample to fleyen from vices. ¶ But I vndirstonde ȝitte [in] an oþer manere þat shrewes ben more vnsely whan þei ne ben nat punissed al be it so þat þere ne ben had no resoun or lawe of correccioun. ne none ensample of lokynge. ¶ And what manere shal þat ben quod I. ouþer þan haþ ben told here byforn ¶ Haue we nat graunted þan quod she þat good[e] folk ben blysful. *and* shrewes ben wrecches. ȝis quod I. [thanne quod she] ȝif þat any good were added to þe wrecchenesse of any wyȝt. nis he nat more blisful þan he þat ne haþ no medelyng of goode in hys solitarie wrecchednesse. so semeþ it quod I. and what seyst þou þan quod she of þilke wrecche þat lakkeþ alle goodes. so þat no goode nis medeled in hys wrecchednesse. *and* ȝitte ouer alle hys wickednesse for whiche he is a wrecche þat þer be ȝitte anoþer yuel anexid *and* knyȝt to hym. shal not men demen hym more vnsely þan þilke wrecche of whiche þe vnselynesse is re[le]ued by þe participacioun of som goode. whi sholde he nat quod I. ¶ þan certys quod she han shrewes whan þei ben punissed somewhat of good anexid to hir wrecchednesse. þat is to seyne þe same peyne þat þei suffren whiche þat is good by þe resoun of Iustice. And whan þilke same shrewes ascapen wiþ outen tourment. þan han þei somewhat more of yuel ȝit ouer þe wickednesse þat þei han don. þat is to seye defaute of peyne. whiche defaute of peyne þou hast graunted is yuel. ¶ For þe desert of felonye I ne may nat denye it quod I. ¶ Moche more þan quod she ben shrewes vnsely whan þei ben wrongfully delyuered fro peyne. þan whan þei beþ punissed by ryȝtful vengeance. but þis is open þing *and* clere þat it is

ryȝt þat shrewes ben punissed. *and* it is wickednesse *and* wrong þat þei escapin vnpunissed. ¶ who myȝt[e] denye þat quod I. but quod she may any man denye. þat al þat is ryȝt nis good. *and* also þe contrarie. þat alle þat is wrong nis wicked. certys quod I þise þinges ben clere ynouȝ. *and* þat we han concludid a litel here byforne. but I preye þe þat þou telle me yif þou accordest to leten no tourment to þe soules aftir þat þe body is dedid by þe deþe. þis [is] to seyn. vndirstondest þou ouȝt þat soules han any tourment after þe deþe of þe body. ¶ Certis quod she ȝe *and* þat ryȝt grete. of whiche soules quod she I trowe þat somme ben tourmentid by asprenesse of peyne. *and* somme soules I trowe be excercised by a purging mekenesse. but my conseil nys nat to determyne of þis peyne. but I haue trauayled and told it hider to. ¶ For þou sholdest knowe þat þe mowynge [.i. myght] of shrewes whiche mowynge þe semeþ to ben. vnworþi nis no mowynge. *and* eke of shrewes of whiche þou pleyndest þat þei ne were nat punissed. þat þou woldest seen þat þei ne weren neuer mo wiþ outen þe torment of hire wickednesse. *and* of þe licence of mowynge to done yuel. þat þou preidest þat it myȝt[e] sone ben endid. *and* þat þou woldest fayne lerne. þat it ne sholde nat longe endure. *and* þat shrewes ben more vnsely yif þei were of lenger duryng. *and* most vnsely yif þei weren perdurable. *and* after þis I haue shewed þe þat more vnsely ben shrewes whan þei escapen wiþ oute ryȝtful peyne. þan whan þei ben punissed by ryȝtful uengeaunce. and of þis sentence folweþ it þat þan ben shrewes constreyned atte laste wiþ most greuous tourment. whan men wene þat þei ne ben nat ypunissed. whan I considre þi resouns quod I. I. ne trowe nat þat men seyn any þing more verrelly. *and* yif I tourne aȝeyn to þe studies of men. who is [he] to whom it sholde seme þat [he] ne sholde nat only leuen þise þinges. but eke gladly herkene hem. Certys quod she so it is. but men may nat. for þei han hire eyen so wont to derkenesse of erpely þinges. þat þei may nat liften hem vp to þe lyȝt of clere soþefastnes. ¶ But þei ben lyke to briddes of whiche þe nyȝt lyȝtneþ hyre lookyng. *and* þe day blyndeþ hem. for whan men loken nat þe ordre of þinges but hire lustes *and* talentȝ. þei wene þat opir þe leue or þe mowynge to done wickednesse or ellys þe escaping wiþ oute peyne be weleful. but considere þe iugement of þe perdurable lawe. for if þou conferme þi corage to þe beste þinges. þou ne hast no nede to no iuge to ȝiuen þe pris or meede. for þou hast ioigned þi self to þe most excellent þing. *and* yif þou haue enclined þi studies to þe wicked þinges. ne seek no

foreyn wrekere out of þi self. for þou þi self hast þrest þe in to wicked þinges. ryȝt as þou myȝtest loken by dyuerse tymes þe foule erþe *and* þe heuene. *and* þat alle oþer þinges stynten fro wiþ oute. so þat þou [nere neyther in heuene ne in erthe] ne say[e] no þing more. þan sholde it semen to þe as by only resoun of lokynge. þat þou were in þe sterres. *and* now in þe erþe. but þe poeple ne lokeþ nat on þise þinges. what þan shal we þan approchen vs to hem þat I haue shewed þat þei ben lyke to þe bestes. (q. d. non) ¶ And what wilt þou seyne of þis ¶ yif þat a man hadde al forlorn hys syȝt. *and* had[de] forȝeten þat he euer saw *and* wende þat no þing ne fayled[e] hym of perfeccioun of mankynde. now we þat myȝten sen þe same þing wolde we nat wene þat he were blynde (q. d. sic). ne also ne accordeþ nat þe poeple to þat I shal seyne. þe whiche þing is susteyned by a stronge foundement of resouns. þat is to seyn þat more vnsely ben þei þat don wrong to oþer folk. þen þei þat þe wrong suffren. ¶ I wolde heren þilke same resouns quod I ¶ Deniest þou quod she þat alle shrewes ne ben worpi to han tourment. nay quod I. but quod she I am certeyne by many resouns þat shrewes ben vnsely. it accordeþ quod I. þan [ne] dowtest þou nat quod she þat þilke folk þat ben worpi of tourment þat þei ne ben wrecches. It accordeþ wel quod I. yif þou were þan quod she yset a Iuge or a knower of þinges. wheþer trowest þou þat men sholde tourment[e] hym þat haþ don þe wronge. or hym þat haþ suffred þe wronge. I ne doute nat quod I. þat I nolde don suffissaunt satisfaccioun to hym þat had[de] suffred þe wrong by þe sorwe of hym þat had[de] don þe wronge. ¶ þan semeþ it quod she þat þe doar of wrong is more wrecche þan he þat haþ suffred þe wrong. þat folweþ wel quod [I]. þan quod she by þise causes *and* by oþer causes þat ben enforced by þe same roate þat filþe or synne by þe propre nature of it makeþ men wretches. *and* it sheweþ wel þat þe wrong þat men don nis nat þe wrecchenesse of hym þat receyueþ þe wrong. but þe wrecchednesse of hym þat doþ þe wronge ¶ but certys quod she þise oratours or aduocatȝ don al þe contrarie for þei enforcen hem to commoeue þe iuges to han pite of hem þat han suffred *and* resceyued þe þinges þat ben greuous *and* aspre. *and* ȝitte men sholden more ryȝtfully han pitee on hem þat don þe greuaunces *and* þe wronges. þe whiche shrewes it were a more couenable þing þat þe accusours or aduocatȝ not wroþe but pitous *and* debonaire ladden þe shrewes þat han don wrong to þe Iugement. ryȝt as men leden seke folk to þe leche. for þat þei sholden seken out þe maladies of synne by

tourment3. and by þis couenaunt eyþer þe entent of þe defendours or
 aduocat3 sholde fayle *and* cesen in al. or ellys yif þe office of aduocat3
 wolde bettere profiten to men. it sholde be tourned in to þe habit of
 accusacioun. þat is [to] s[e]yn þei sholden accuse shrewes. *and* nat excuse
 hem. *and* eke þe shrewes hem self. 3it it were leueful to hem to seen at any
 clifte þe vertue þat þei han forleten. *and* sawen þat þei sholde putten adoun
 þe filþes of hire vices by [the] tourment3 of peynes. þei ne au3ten nat ry3t
 for þe recompensacioun forto geten hem bounte *and* prowesse whiche þat
 þei han lost demen ne holden þat þilke peynes weren tourmentes to hem.
and eke þei wolden refuse þe attendaunce of hir aduocat3 *and* taken hem
 self to hire iuges *and* to hir accusours. for whiche it bytideþ [þat] as to þe
 wise folk þer nis no place ylete to hate. þat is to seyn. þat hate ne haþ no
 place amonges wise men. ¶ For no wy3t wolde haten gode men. but yif he
 were ouer moche a fole. ¶ *and* forto haten shrewes it nis no resoun. ¶ For
 ry3t so as languissing is maladie of body. ry3t so ben vices *and* synne
 maladies of corage. ¶ *and* so as we ne deme nat þat þei þat ben seek of hire
 body ben worþi to ben hated. but raþer worþi of pite. wel more worþi nat to
 ben hated. but forto ben had in pite ben þei of whiche þe þou3tes ben
 constrained by felonous wickednesse. þat is more cruel þan any
 languissinge of body.

QUID TANTOS IUUAT.

[The ferthe Metur.]

What deliteþ it 3ow to exciten so grete moewynges of hatredes *and* to hasten *and* bisien [the] fatal disposicioun of 3oure deef wip 3oure propre handes. þat is to seyn by batailes or [by] kontek. for yif 3e axen þe deef it hastisiþ hym of hys owen wille. ne deef ne tariēþ nat hys swifte hors. and [the] men þat þe serpent3 *and* þe lyouns. *and* þe tigre. *and* þe beere *and* þe boore seken to sleen wip her teþe. 3it þilke same men seken to sleen eueryche of hem oþer wip swerde. loo for her maners ben diuerse *and* discordaunt ¶ þei moeuen vnry3tful oostes *and* cruel batailes. *and* wilne to perisse by enterchaungynge of dartes. but þe resoun of cruelte nis nat ynou3 ry3tful. wilt þou þan 3elden a couenable gerdoun to þe desertes of men ¶ Loue ry3tfully goode folk ; *and* haue pite on shrewes.

HINC EGO UIDEO INQUAM. *ET CETERA.* [The fyfthe prose.]

Pus see I wel quod I. eyþer what blisfulnesse or ellys what vnselinesse is estab[l]ished in þe desertys of goode men *and* of shrewes. ¶ but in þis ilke fortune of poeple I see somewhat of goode. *and* somewhat of yuel. for no wise man hap nat leuer ben exiled pore *and* nedy *and* nameles. þan forto dwellen in hys Citee *and* flouren of rychesses. *and* be redoutable by honoure. *and* stronge of power for in þis wise more clerely *and* more witnesfully is þe office of wise men ytretid whan þe blisfulnes *and* [the] pouste of gouernours is as it were yshad amonges poeples þat ben ney3boures *and* subgit3. syn þat namely prisoun lawe *and* þise oþer tourment3 of lawful peynes ben raper owed to felonous Cite3eins. for þe whiche felonous Cite3eins þo peynes ben establised. þan for goode folk. ¶ þan I merueile me gretly quod I. whi [þat] þe þinges ben so mys entrechaunged. þat tourment3 felounes pressen *and* confounden goode folk. *and* shrewes rauyssen medes of vertue *and* ben in honours. *and* in grete estatis. and I desire eke to witen of þe. what semeþ þe to ben þe resoun of þis so wrongful a confusioun ¶ For I wolde wondre wel þe lasse yif I trowed[e] þat alle þise þinges were medeled by fortuouse hap. ¶ But now hepeþ *and* encreseþ myne astonyenge god gouernour of þinges. þat so as god 3eueþ ofte tymes to good[e] men goodes *and* myrþes. *and* to shrewes yuel and aspre þinges. *and* 3eueþ a3eynewarde to goode folk hardnesse. *and* to shrewes [he] graunteþ hem her wille *and* þat þei desiren. what difference

þan may þer be bitwixen þat þat god doþ. *and* þe hap of fortune. yif men ne knowe nat þe cause whi þat [it] is. it nis no merueile *quod* she þou3 þat men wenen þat þer be somewhat folysche and confus whan þe resoun of þe order is vnknowe. ¶ But alle þou3 þou ne know nat þe cause of so gret a disposicioun. naþeles for as moche as god þe good[e] gouernour attempreþ *and* gouerneþ þe world. ne doute þe nat þat alle þinges ne ben doon ary3t.

SI QUIS ARCTURI SYDERA.

[The fyfthe Metur.]

Who so þat ne knowe nat þe sterres of arctour ytourned neye to þe souereyne contre or point. þat is to seyne ytourned neye to þe souereyne pool of þe firmament *and* woot nat whi þe sterre boetes passeþ or gaderiþ his wey[n]es. *and* drenchep his late flaumbes in þe see. *and* whi þat boetes þe sterre vnfoldiþ his ouer swifte arisynges. þan shal he wondren of þe lawe of þe heye eyre. *and* eke if þat he ne knowe nat why þat þe hornes of þe ful[le] moene waxen pale *and* infect by þe boundes of þe derke ny3t ¶ *and* how þe moene dirk *and* confuse discouereþ þe sterres. þat she had[de] ycouered by hir clere visage. þe commune errour moeueþ folk *and* makip wery hir bacines of bras by þikke strookes. þat is to seyne þat þer is a maner poeple þat hy3t[e] coribandes þat wenen þat whan þe moone is in þe eclips þat it be enchauntid. and þerfore forto rescowe þe moone þei betyn hire basines wiþ þikke strokes. ¶ Ne no man ne wondreþ whan þe blastes of þe wynde chorus betyn þe strondes of þe see by quakyngge floodes. ne no man ne wondreþ whan þe wey3te of þe snowe yhardid by þe colde. is resolved by þe brennyng hete of phebus þe sonne. ¶ For here seen men redyly þe causes. but þe causes yhid þat is to seye in heuene trouble þe brestes of men. ¶ þe moeueable poeple is a-stoned of alle þinges þat comen selde *and* sodeynely in oure age. but yif þe troublly errour of oure ignorance departid[e] from vs. so þat we wisten þe causes whi þat swiche þinges bitiden. certys þei sholden cesse to seme wondres.

ITA EST INQUAM.

[The syxte prose.]

Pvs is it *quod* I. but so as þou hast 3euen or byhy3t me to vnwrappen þe hidde causes of þinges ¶ *and* to discoueren me þe resouns couered with dirknesses I preye þe þat þou diuise *and* Iuge me of þis matere. *and* þat þou

do me to vndrestonden it. ¶ For þis miracle or þis wondre troubleþ me ryzt gretely. *and* þan she a litel [what] smylyng seide. ¶ þou clepest me quod she to telle þing. þat is grettest of alle þinges þat mowen ben axed. ¶ And to þe whiche questioun vnneþ[e]s is þere auzt ynow to lauen it. as who seiþ. vnneþes is þer suffisauntly any þing to answeare perfitly to þi questioun. ¶ For þe matere of it is swiche þat whan oon doute is determined *and* kut away þer wexen oþer doutes wiþ-outen noumbre. ryzt as þe heuedes waxen of ydre þe serpent þat hercules slouȝ. ¶ Ne þere ne were no manere ne noon ende. but yif þat a wyzt constreined[e] þo doutes. by a ryzt lyuely *and* a quik fire of þouȝt. þat is to seyn by vigour *and* strengþe of witte. ¶ For in þis matere men weren wont to maken questiouns of þe simplicitie of þe purueaunce of god *and* of þe ordre of destine. *and* of sodeyne hap. *and* of þe knowyng *and* predestinacioun deuine *and* of þe lyberte of fre wille. þe whiche þing þou þi self aperceiust wel of what weyȝt þei ben. but for as mochel as þe knowynge of þise þinges is a manere porcioun to þe medicine to þe. al be it so þat I haue lytel tyme to don it. ȝit nabeles I wole enforcen me to shewe somewhat of it. ¶ but al þouȝ þe norissinges of dite of musike deliteþ þe þow most suffren. *and* forberen a litel of þilk delite while þat I weue (contexo) to þe resouns yknyt by ordre ¶ As it likeþ to þe quod I so do. ¶ þo spak she ryzt a[s] by an oþer bygynnyn[ge] *and* seide þus. ¶ þe engendrynge of alle þinges quod she *and* alle þe progressiouns of muuable nature. *and* alle þat moeueþ in any manere takiþ hys causes. hys ordre. *and* hys formes. of þe stablenesse of þe deuyne þouȝt [*and* thilke deuyne thowht] þat is yset *and* put in þe toure. þat is to seyne in þe heyȝt of þe simplicitie of god. stablisþ many manere gyses to þinges þat ben to don. ¶ þe whiche manere whan þat men loken it in þilke pure clerenesse of þe deuyne intelligence. it is ycleped purueaunce ¶ but whan þilke manere is referred by men to þinges þat it moeueþ *and* disponeþ þan of olde men. it was cleped destine. ¶ þe whiche þinges yif þat any wyzt lokeþ wel in his þouȝt. þe strengþe of þat oon *and* of þat oþer he shal lyȝtly mowen seen þat þise two þinges ben diuers. ¶ For purueaunce is þilke deuyne resoun þat is establissed in þe souereyne prince of þinges. þe whiche purueaunce disponiþ alle þinges. but destine is þe disposicioun *and* ordenaunce cleuyng to moeuable þinges. by þe whiche disposicioun þe purueaunce knyteþ alle þinges in hire ordres. ¶ For purueaunce embraceþ alle þinges to hepe. al þouȝ þat þei ben dyuerse *and* al þouȝ þei ben wiþ outen fyn. but

destynie departeþ *and* ordeyneþ alle þinges singlerly *and* diuideþ. in moeuynge. in places. in formes. in tymes. departiþ [as] þus. so þat þe vnfolding of temporel ordenaunce assembled *and* ooned in þe lokyng of þe deuyne þouzt ¶ Is purueaunce *and* þilke same assemblynge. *and* oonyng diuided *and* vnfolden by tymes. lat þat ben called destine. *and* al be it so þat þise þinges ben dyuerse. 3itte nabeles hangeþ þat oon on þat oþer. forwhi þe ordre destinal procediþ of þe simplicitie of purueaunce. for ryzt as a werkman þat aperceiueþ in hys þouzt þe forme of þe þing þat he wil make moeueþ þe effect of þe werke. *and* lediþ þat he had[de] lokyd byforne in hys þouzt symple *and* presently by temporel þouzt. ¶ Certys ryzt so god disponiþ in hys purueaunce singlerly *and* stably þe þinges þat ben to done. but he amynistreþ in many maneres *and* in dyuerse tymes by destyne. þilke same þinges þat he haþ disponed þan wheþir þat destine be excercised. eyþer by somme dyuyne spirites seruaunte3 to þe deuyne purueaunce. or ellys by somme soule (*anima mundi*). or ellys by al nature seruynge to god. or ellys by þe celestial moeuynge of sterres. or ellys by þe vertue of aungels. or ellys by þe dyuerse subtilite of deueles. or ellys by any of hem. or ellys by hem alle þe destynal ordynaunce is ywouen or accomplished. certys it is open þing þat þe purueaunce is an vnmoeueable *and* symple forme of þinges to done. *and* þe moeueable bonde *and* þe temporel ordynaunce of þinges whiche þat þe deuyne simplicitie of purueaunce haþ ordeyned to done. þat is destine. For whiche it is þat alle þinges þat ben put vnder destine ben certys subgit3 to purueaunce. to whiche purueaunce destine it self is subgit *and* vnder. ¶ But somme þinges ben put vnder purueaunce þat sourmounten þe ordynaunce of destine. *and* þo ben þilke þat stably ben yficched ney to þe first godhed þei sourmounten þe ordre of destinal moeuablite. ¶ For ryzt as cercles þat tournen aboute a same Centre or about a poynt. þilke cercle þat is inrest or moost wiþ-ynne ioineþ to þe symplesse of þe myddel *and* is as it were a Centre or a poynt to þat oþer cercles þat tournen abouten hym. ¶ *and* þilke þat is outerest compased by larger envyrannyng is vnfolden by larger spaces in so mochel as it is forþest fro þe mydel symplite of þe poynt. *and* yif þer be any þing þat knytteþ *and* felawshippeþ hym selfe to þilke mydel poynt it is constreyned in to symplite. þat is to seyn in to [vn]moeueablete. *and* it ceseth to ben shad *and* to fletin dyuersly. ¶ Ryzt so by semblable resoun. þilke þinge þat departiþ firþest fro þe first þouzt of god. it is vnfolden *and* summittid to

grettere bondes of destine. and in so moche is þe þing more free *and* lovs fro destyne as it axep *and* holdeþ hym ner to þilke Centre of þinges. þat is to seyne god. ¶ and if þe þinge cleueþ to þe stedfastnesse of þe þouzt of god. *and* be wiþ oute moeuyng certys it sourmountep þe necessite of destyne. þan ryzt swiche comparisoun as [it] is of skilynge to vndirstondyng *and* of þing þat is engendred to þing þat is. *and* of tyme to eternite. *and* of þe cercle to þe Centre. ryzt so is þe ordre of moeueable destine to þe stable symplite of *purueaunce*. ¶ þilke ordinaunce moeueþ þe heuene *and* þe sterres *and* attempreþ þe elymentz to gider amonges hem self. *and* transformep hem by enterchaungable mutacioun. ¶ and þilke same ordre newep azein alle þinges growyng *and* fallyng a-doune by sembleables *progressiouns* of seedes *and* of sexes. þat is to sein. male *and* female. and þis ilke ordre constreyneþ þe fortunes *and* þe dedes of men by a bonde of causes nat able to ben vnbounden (indissolubili). þe whiche destinal causes whanne þei passen oute fro þe bygynnynges of þe vnmoeueable *purueaunce* it mot nedes be þat þei ne be nat mutable. *and* þus ben þe þinges ful wel ygouerned. yif þat þe symplite dwellynge in þe deuyne þouzt shewep furþe þe ordre of causes. vnable to be I-bowed. *and* þis ordre constreyneþ by hys propre stablete þe moeueable þinges. or ellys þei sholde fleten folily for whiche it is þat alle þinges semen to be confus *and* trouble to vs men. for we ne mowe nat considere þilke ordinaunce. ¶ Napeles þe propre manere of euery þing dressyng hem to goode disponit hem alle. for þere nis no þinge don for cause of yuel. ne þilke þing þat is don by wicked[e] folk nis nat don for yuel þe whiche shrewes as I haue shewed [ful] plentiuously seken goode. but wicked errorr mystourniþ hem. ¶ Ne þe ordre comyng fro þe poynt of souereyne goode ne declineþ nat fro hys bygynnyng. but þou mayst sein what vnreste may ben a wors confusioun þan þat goode men han somme tyme aduersite. *and* somtyme prosperite. ¶ and shrewes also han now þinges þat þei desiren. *and* now þinges þat þei haten ¶ wheþer men lyuen now in swiche hoolnesse of þouzt. as who seiþ. ben men now so wise. þat swiche folk as þei demen to ben goode folk or shrewes þat it mot nedes ben þat folk ben swiche as þei wenen. but in þis manere þe domes of men discorden. þat þilke men þat somme folk demen worþi of mede. oþer folk demen hem worþi of *tourment*. but lat vs graunt[e] I pose þat som man may wel demen or knowen þe goode folk *and* þe badde. May he þan knowen *and* seen þilke inrest attemperaunce of corages. as it

hap ben wont to be said of bodyes. as who saip may a man speken *and* determine of attemperaunce in corages. as men were wont to demen or speken of complexiouns *and* attemperaunces of bodies (q' non). ne it [ne] is nat an vnlyke miracle to hem þat ne knowen it nat. ¶ As who seiþ. but is lyke a merueil or a miracle to hem þat ne knowen it nat. whi þat swete þinges [ben] couenable to some bodies þat ben hool *and* to some bodies bittre þinges ben couenable. *and* also whi þat some seke folk ben holpen *with* lyzt medicines [*and* some folk ben holpen *with* sharppe medicynes] but napeles þe leche þat knoweþ þe manere *and* þe attemperaunce of heele *and* of maladie ne merueileþ of it no þing. but what oþer þing semeþ hele of corages but bounte *and* prowesse. *and* what oþer þing semeþ maladie of corages but vices. who is ellys kepere of good or dryuere away of yuel but god gouernour *and* leecher of þouztes. þe whiche god whan he hap byholden from þe heye toure of hys purueaunce he knoweþ what is couenable to euery wyzt. *and* leneþ hem þat he wot [þat] is couenable to hem. Loo here of comeþ *and* here of is don þis noble miracle of þe ordre destinal. whan god þat alle knoweþ doþ swiche þing. of whiche þing [þat] vnknowyng folk ben astoned but forto constreine as who seiþ ¶ But forto comprehende *and* telle a fewe þinges of þe deuyne depnesse þe whiche þat mans resoun may vnderstonde. ¶ þilk man þat þou wenest to ben ryzt iuste *and* ryzt kepyng of equite. þe contrarie of þat semeþ to þe deuyne purueaunce þat al woot. ¶ And lucan my familier telleþ þat þe victories cause liked[e] to þe goddes *and* causes ouercomen liked[e] to catoun. þan what so euer þou mayst seen þat is don in þis [world] vnhoped or vnwened. certys it is þe ryzt[e] ordre of þinges. but as to þi wicked[e] oppinioun it is a confusioun. but I suppose þat som man be so wel ypewed. þat þe deuyne Iugement *and* þe Iugement of mankynde accorden hem to gidre of hym. but he is so vnstedfast of corage [þat] yif any aduersite come to hym he wolde for-leten perauenture to continue innocence by þe whiche he ne may nat wiþholden fortune. ¶ þan þe wise dispensacioun of god spareþ hym þe whiche manere aduersite myzt[e] enpeyren. ¶ For þat god wil nat suffren hym to trauaile. to whom þat trauayl nis nat couenable. ¶ An oþer man is perfit in alle uertues. *and* is an holy man *and* neye to god so þat þe purueaunce of god wolde demen þat it were a felony þat he were touched wiþ any aduersites. so þat he ne wil nat suffre þat swiche a man be moeued wiþ any manere maladie. ¶ But so as seide a philosophre [the moore

excellent by me]. þe aduersites comen nat (he seide in grec ;) þere þat uertues han edified þe bodie of þe holy man. and ofte tyme it bitideþ þat þe somme of þinges þat ben to don is taken to good folk to gouerne. for þat þe malice habundaunt of shrewes sholde ben abatid. *and* god zeueþ *and* departiþ to oþer folk prosp[er]ites *and* aduersites ymedeled to hepe aftir þe qualite of hire corages *and* remordip som folk by aduersites. for þei ne sholden nat wexen proude by longe welefulnesse. *and* oþer folk he suffreþ to ben trauayled wiþ harde þinges. ¶ For þat þei sholden conferme þe vertues of corage by þe vsage *and* exercitacioun of pacience. and oþer folke dreden more þen þei auzten þe wiche þei myzt[en] wel beren. *and* þilke folk god ledip in to experience of hem self by aspre *and* sorweful þinges. ¶ And many oþer folk han bouzt honorable renoune of þis worlde by þe pris of glorious deef. and som men þat ne mowen nat ben ouer-comen by tourment han zeuen ensample to oþer folk þat vertue ne may nat be ouer-comen by aduersites. ¶ and of alle þise þinges þer nis no doute þat þei ne ben don ryztfully *and* ordeinly to þe profit of hem to whom we seen þise þinges bitide. ¶ For certys þat aduersite comeþ some tyme to shrewes. *and* some tyme þat þei desiren it comeþ of þise forseide causes *and* of sorweful þinges þat bytyden to shrewes. Certys no man ne wondreþ. For alle men wenen þat þei han wel deserued it. *and* þei ben of wicked merite of whiche shrewes þe tourment som tyme agastep oþer to done folies. *and* som tyme it amendeþ hem þat suffren þe tourmentis. ¶ And þe prosperite þat is zeuen to shrewes sheweþ a grete argument to good[e] folk what þing þei sholde demen of þilk wilfulnesse þe whiche prosperite men seen ofte serue to shrewes. in þe whiche þing I trowe þat god dispensiþ. for perauenture þe nature of som man is so ouerþrowyng to yuel *and* so vncouenable þat þe nedy pouerte of hys house-hold myzt[e] rapen egren hym to done felonies. and to þe maladie of hym god puttip remedie to ziuen hym rychesse. *and* som oþer man byholdip hys conscience defouled wiþ synnes *and* makip comparisoun of his fortune *and* of hym self ¶ and dredip perauenture þat hys blisfulnesse of whiche þe vsage is ioyful to hym þat þe lesynge of þilke blisfulnesse ne be nat sorweful to hym. *and* þerfore he wol chaunge hys maneres. and for he dredip to lese hys fortune. he forletip hys wickednesse. to oþer folk is welefulnesse yzeuen vnworþily þe whiche ouerþrowep hem in to destruccioun þat þei han deserued. and to som oþer folk is zeuen power to

punissen. for þat it shal be cause of continuacioun *and* exercisinge to good[e] folk. *and* cause of tourment to shrewes. ¶ For so as þer nis none alyaunce bytwixe good[e] folke *and* shrewes. ne shrewes ne mowen nat accorden amonges hem self *and* whi nat. for shrewes discorden of hem self by her vices þe whiche vices al to renden her consciences. *and* don oft[e] tyme þinges þe whiche þinges whan þei han don hem. þei demen þat þo þinges ne sholde nat han ben don. for whiche þinge þilke souereyne purueaunce haþ makend oft[e] tyme [faire] miracle so þat shrewes han makend oftyme shrewes to ben good[e] men. for whan þat som shrewes seen þat þei suffren wrongfully felonies of oþer shrewes þei wexen eschaufed in to hat[e] of hem þat anoien hem. *and* retournen to þe fruit of uertue. when þei studien to ben vnlyke to hem þat þei han hated. ¶ Certys þis only is þe deuyne myzt to þe whiche myzt yueles ben þan good. whan it vseþ þo yueles couenably *and* draweþ out þe effect of any good. as who seiþ þat yuel is good oonly by þe myzt of god. for þe myzt of god ordeyneþ þilk yuel to good. For oon ordre enbrasþ alle þinges. so þat what wyzt [þat] departþ fro þe resoun of þe ordre whiche þat is assigned to hym. algates ȝit he slideþ in to an oþer ordre. so þat noþing nis leueful to folye in þe realme of þe deuyne purueaunce. as who seiþ no þing nis wiþouten ordinaunce in þe realme of þe deuyne purueaunce. ¶ Syn þat þe ryzt strong[e] god gouerniþ alle þinges in þis worlde for it nis nat leueful to no man to comprehend by witte ne vnfolden by worde alle þe subtil ordinaunces *and* disposiciouns of þe deuyne entent. for oonly it auȝt[e] suffice to han lokend þat god hym self makere of alle natures ordeyniþ *and* dressiþ alle þinges to good. while þat he hastiþ to wiþhalden þe þinges þat he haþ makend in to hys semblaunce. þat is to seyn forto wiþholden þinges in to good. for he hym self is good he chaseþ oute al yuel of þe boundes of hys communalite by þe ordre of necessite destinable. For whiche it folweþ þat yif þou loke þe purueaunce ordeynynge þe þinges þat men wenen ben haboundaunt in erþes. þou ne shalt not seen in no place no þing of yuel. ¶ but I se now þat þou art charged wiþ þe weyȝte of þe questioun *and* wery wiþ lengþe of my resoun. *and* þat þou abidest som swetnesse of songe. tak þan þis drauȝt *and* whan þou art wel refreshed *and* refet þou shalt ben more stedfast to styte in to heyere questiouns.

Yif þou wolt demen in þi pure þouȝt þe ryȝtes or þe lawes of þe heye
 þund[ere]re. þat is to seyne of god. loke þou *and* bihold þe heyȝtes of
 souereyne heuene. ¶ þere kepen þe sterres by ryȝtful alliaunce of þinges hir
 olde pees. þe sonne ymoeued by hys rody fire. ne destourbiþ nat þe colde
 cercle of þe moone. ¶ Ne þe sterre yclepid þe bere. þat encliniþ hys
 rauyssyng courses abouten þe souereyne heyȝt of þe worlde. ne þe same
 sterre vrsa nis neuer mo wasshen in þe depe westernne see. ne coueitþ nat to
 dyȝen hys flaumbes in þe see of [the] occian. al þouȝ he see oþer sterres
 yplounged in to þe see. ¶ And hesperus þe sterre bodiþ *and* telliþ alwey þe
 late nyȝtes. And lucifer þe sterre brynggeþ aȝeyne þe clere day. ¶ And þus
 makþ loue enterchaungeable þe perdurable courses. *and* þus is discordable
 bataile yput oute of þe contre of þe sterres. þis accordaunce attempreþ by
 euene-lyke manere[s] þe elementes. þat þe moyste þinges striuen nat wiþ þe
 drye þinges. but ȝiuen place by stoundes. and þat þe colde þinges ioynen
 hem by feiþ to þe hote þinges. *and* þat þe lyȝt[e] fyre arist in to heyȝte. *and*
 þe heuy erþes aualen by her weyȝtes. ¶ by þise same cause þe floury yere
 ȝeldeþ swote smellys in þe fyrste somer sesoun warmyng. *and* þe hote
 somer dryeþ þe cornes. *and* autumpne comeþ aȝeyne heuy of apples. and þe
 fletyng reyne bydeweþ þe wynter. þis attemperaunce noriȝsiþ *and*
 brynggeþ furþe al þinge þat brediþ lyfe in þis worlde. ¶ and þilk same
 attemperaunce rauyssyng hideþ *and* bynymeþ *and* drenceþ vndir þe last[e]
 depe alle þinges yborn. ¶ Amonges þise þinges sitteþ þe heye makere kyng
and lorde. welle *and* bygynnyng. lawe *and* wise Iuge. to don equite *and*
 gouerniþ *and* encliniþ þe bridles of þinges. *and* þo þinges þat he stireþ to
 don by moeuyng he wiþdraweþ *and* arestiþ *and* affermiþ þe moeueable or
 wandryng þinges. ¶ For ȝif þat he ne clepiþ nat aȝein þe ryȝt goyng of
 þinges. *and* ȝif þat he ne constreyned[e] hem nat eftesones in to
 roundenesse enclined þe þinges þat ben now continued by stable
 ordinaunce. þei sholde deperten from hir welle. þat is to sein from hir
 bygynnyng *and* failen. þat is to sein tournen in to nauȝt. ¶ þis is þe
 commune loue of alle þinges. *and* alle þinges axen to be holden by þe fyn of
 good. For ellys ne myȝten þei nat lasten yif þei ne come nat eftesones aȝeine
 by loue retourned to þe cause þat haþ ȝeuen hem beyng. þat is to seyn to
 god.

Sest þou nat þan what þing folweþ alle þe þinges þat I haue seid. what þing quod I. ¶ Certys quod she outerly þat al fortune is good. and how may þat be quod .I. ¶ Now vndirstand quod she so as [alle fortune wheyther so it be Ioyeful fortune / or aspre] fortune is 3iuen eiþer by cause of gerdonyng or ellys of exercisyng of goode folk or ellys by cause to punissen. or ellys to chastysen shrewes. ¶ þan is alle fortune good. þe whiche fortune is certeyne þat it be eiþer ryztful or profitable. ¶ For soþe þis is a ful verray resoun quod I. and yif I considere þe purueaunce and þe destine þat þou tauztest me a litel here byforne þis sentence is susteyned by stedfast resouns. but yif it like vnto þe lat vs noumbre hem amonges þilk[e] þinges of whiche þou seidest a litel here byforne þat þei ne were nat able to ben ywened to þe poeple. ¶ whi so quod she. for þat þe comune worde of men mysusiþ quod I. þis manere speche of fortune. and sein ofte tymes [þat] þe fortune of som wyzt is wicked. wilt þou þan quod she þat I proche a litel to þe wordes of þe poeple so it seme nat to hem þat I be ouer moche departid as fro þe vsage of man kynde. as þou wolt quod I. ¶ Demest þou nat quod she þat al þing þat profitiþ is good. 3is quod I. certis þilk þing þat exercisiþ or corigiþ profitiþ. I confesse it wel quod I. þan is it good quod she. whi nat quod I. but þis is þe fortune [quod she] of hem þat eiþer ben put in vertue and batailen azeins aspre þinges. or ellys of hem þat eschewen and declinen fro vices and taken þe weye of vertue. ¶ þis ne may nat I denye quod I ¶ But what seist þou of þe myrre fortune þat is 3euen to good folk in gerdoun deuiniþ ouzt þe poeples þat it is wicked. nay forsoþe quod I. but þei demen as it soþe is þat it is ryzt good. ¶ And what seist þou of þat oper fortune quod she. þat al þou3 it be aspre and restreiniþ þe shrewes by ryztful tourment. wenip ouzt þe poeple þat it be good. nay quod I. ¶ But þe poeple demip þat it be most wrecched of alle þinges þat may ben þouzt. war now and loke wel quod she lest þat we in folwyng þe opynioun of poeple haue confessed and concluded þing þat is vnable to be wened to þe poeple. what is þat quod I ¶ Certys quod she it folweþ or comeþ of þinges þat ben graunted þat alle fortune what so euer it be. of hem þat eyþer ben in possessioun of vertue. [or in the encres of vertu] or ellys in þe purchasyng of vertue. þat þilke fortune is good. ¶ And þat alle fortune is ryzt wicked to hem þat dwellen in shrewednesse. as who seiþ. and þus wenep nat þe

poeple. ¶ þat is soþe quod I. ¶ Al be it so þat noman dar confessen it ne
 byknowen it. ¶ whi so quod she. For ryzt as no strong man ne semeþ nat to
 abassen or disdaignen as ofte tyme as he hereþ þe noise of þe bataile. ne
 also it ne semeþ nat to þe wyse man to beren it greuously as oft[e] as he is
 lad in to þe strif of fortune. for boþe to þat on man *and* eke to þat oþer þilke
 difficulte is þe matere to þat oon man of encrese of his glorious renoun. *and*
 to þat oþer man to conferme hys sapience. þat is to seine þe asprenesse of
 hys estat. ¶ For þerfore is it called uertue. for þat it sustenip *and* enforceþ by
 hys strengþes þat it nis nat ouer-comen by aduersites. ¶ Ne certys þou þat
 art put in þe encrese or in þe heyzt of uertue ne hast nat comen to fleten wiþ
 delices *and* forto welken in bodyly lust. ¶ þou sowest or plauntest a ful egre
 bataile in þi corage azeins euery fortune. for þat þe sorweful fortune ne
 confounde þe nat. ne þat þe myrre fortune ne corruppe þe nat. ¶ Occupy þe
 mene by stedfast strengþes. for al þat euer is vnder þe mene. or ellys al þat
 ouer-passeþ þe mene despiseþ welefulnesses. ¶ As who seiþ. it is vicious
and ne haþ no mede of hys trauaile. ¶ For it is set in þoure hand. as who seiþ
 it lieþ in þoure power what fortune þow is leuest. þat is to seyne good or
 yuel. ¶ For alle fortune þat semeþ sharpe or aspre yif it ne exercise nat þe
 good folk. ne chastisip þe wicked folk. it punisseþ.

BELLA BIS QUENIS. *ET CETERA.*

[The seuende Metur.]

ÞE wrekere attrides ¶ þat is to seyne agamenon þat wrouzt[e] *and*
 continued[e] þe batailes by ten þere recouered[e] *and* purged[e] in
 wrekyng by þe destruccioun of troie þe loste chambres of mariage of hys
 broþer þis is to seyn þat [he] agamenon wan azein Eleine þat was Menelaus
 wif his broþer. In þe mene while þat þilke agamenon desired[e] to zeuen
 sailes to þe grekysshe nauye *and* bouzt[e] azein þe wyndes by blode. he
 vncloped[e] hym of pite as fader. *and* þe sory prest ȝiueþ in sacrificyng þe
 wreched kuytting of þrote of þe douȝter. ¶ þat is to sein þat agamenon lete
 kuytten þe þrote of hys douȝter by þe prest. to maken alliaunce wiþ hys
 goddes. *and* for to haue wynde wiþ whiche he myzt[e] wende to troie.
 ¶ Itakus þat is to sein vlixies bywept[e] hys felawes ylorn þe whiche
 felawes þe fiers[e] pholifemus ligginge in his grete Caue had[de] freten *and*
 dreint in hys empty wombe. but napeles polifemus wood for his blinde
 visage ȝeld to vlixies ioie by hys sorowful teres. þis is to seyn þat vlixes

smot oute þe eye of poliphemus þat stod in hys forhede. for whiche vlixes
 hadde ioie whan he saw poliphemus wepyng *and* blynde. ¶ Hercules is
 celebrable for hys hard[e] trauaile he dawntede þe proude Centauris half
 hors half man. *and* he rafte þe despoilynge fro þe cruel lyoun þat is to
 seyne he slou3 þe lyoun *and* rafte hym hys skyn. he smot þe brids þat hy3ten
 arpijs [in þe palude of lyrne] wiþ certeyne arwes. he rauyssed[e] applis fro
 þe wakyng dragoun. *and* hys hand was þe more heuy for þe golde[ne]
 metal. He drou3 Cerberus þe hound of helle by hys treble cheyne. he ouer-
 comer as it is seid haþ put an vnmeke lorde fodre to hys cruel hors ¶ þis is
 to sein. þat hercules slou3 diomedes *and* made his hors to etyn hym. *and* he
 hercules slou3 Idra þe serpent *and* brend[e] þe venym. *and* achelaus þe flode
 defouled[e] in his forhede dreint[e] his shamefast visage in his strondes. þis
 is to sein þat achelaus couþe transfigure hym self in to dyuerse lykenesse.
and as he fau3t wiþ orcules at þe laste he turnid[e] hym in to a bole *and*
 hercules brak of oon of hys hornes. *and* achelaus for shame hidde hym in
 hys ryuer. ¶ And [he] hercules cast[e] adoun Antheus þe geaunt in þe
 strondes of libye. *and* kacus apaised[e] þe wrapþes of euander. þis is to sein
 þat hercules slou3 þe Monstre kacus *and* apaised[e] wiþ þat deep þe wrapþe
 of euander. ¶ And þe bristled[e] boor marked[e] wiþ scomes þe sholdres of
 hercules. þe whiche sholdres þe heye cercle of heuene sholde þreste. *and* þe
 laste of his labours was þat he sustened[e] þe heuene vpon his nekke
 vnbowed. *and* he deserued[e] eftsones þe heuene to ben þe pris of his laste
 trauayle ¶ Gop now þan 3e stronge men þere as þe heye weye of þe grete
 ensample ledeþ 3ou. ¶ O nice men whi nake 3e 3oure bakkes. as who seiþ.
 ¶ O 3e slowe *and* delicat men whi fley 3e aduersites. *and* ne fy3ten nat
 a3eins hem by vertue to wynnyn þe mede of þe heuene. for þe erþe ouer-
 comen 3eueþ þe sterres. ¶ þis is to seyne þat whan þat erþely lust is ouer-
 comen. a man is maked worþi to þe heuene.

EXPLICIT LIBER QUARTUS.

INCIPIT LIBER QUINTUS.

She hadde seid *and* tourned[e] þe cours of hir resoun to somme oþer þinges to ben tretid *and* to ben ysped. þan seide I. Certys ryȝtful is þin amonestyng *and* ful digne by auctorite. but þat þou seidest som tyme þat þe questioun of þe deuyne purueaunce is enlaced wiþ many oþer questiouns. I vndir-sonde wel *and* proue it by þe same þinge. but I axe yif þat þou wenest þat hap be any þing in any weys. *and* if þou wenest þat hap be any [thing] what is it. þan quod she. I haste me to ȝelden *and* assoilen þe to þe dette of my byheste *and* to shewen *and* openen þe wey by whiche wey þou maist come aȝein to þi contre. ¶ but al be it so þat þe þinges whiche þat þou axest ben ryȝt profitable to knowe. ȝitte ben þei diuers somewhat fro þe pape of my purpos. And it is to douten þat þou ne be makid weery by mysweys so þat þou ne mayst nat suffise to mesuren þe ryȝt weye. ¶ Ne doute þe þer of no þing quod I. for forto knowen þilke þinges to-gidre in þe whiche þinges I delite me gretly. þat shal ben to me in stede of reste. Syn it nis nat to douten of þe þinges folwyng whan euery side of þi disputisoun shal be stedfast to me by vndoutous feiþ. þan seide she. þat manere wol I don þe. *and* bygan to speken ryȝt þus ¶ Certys quod she yif any wyȝt diffinisid hap in þis manere. þat is to seyn. þat hap is bytydyng y-brouȝt forþe by foelyshe moeuyng. *and* by no knyttyng of causes. ¶ I conferme þat hap nis ryȝt nauȝt in no wise. and I deme al outerly þat hap nis ne dwelliþ but a voys. ¶ As who seiþ. but an ydel worde wiþ outen any significacioun of þing summittid to þat voys. for what place myȝt[e] ben left or dwellyng to folie *and* to disordinaunce. syn þat god lediþ *and* streyniþ alle þinges by ordre. ¶ For þis sentence is verray *and* soþe þat no þinge ne hap his beyng of nouȝt. to [the] whiche sentence none of þise olde folk ne wiþseide neuere al be it so þat þei ne vndirstoden ne moeueden it nauȝt by god prince *and* gynner of wirkyng. but þei casten as a manere foundement of subgit material. þat is to seyn of [the] nature of alle resoun. *and* ȝif þat ony þinge is woxen or comen of no causes. þan shal it seme þat þilke þinge is comen or woxen of nouȝt. but yif þis ne may nat ben don. þan is it nat possible þat þere hap ben any swiche þing as I haue diffinissid a litel here byforne. ¶ How shal it þan ben quod I. nis þer þan no þing þat by ryȝt may be cleped eyþer happe or ellis auenture of fortune. or is þer ouȝt al be it so þat it is hidd fro þe poeple to whiche þise wordes ben couenable. Myn aristotul

quod she. in þe book of his phisik diffinissep þis þing by short resoun and ney3e to þe soþe. ¶ In whiche manere quod I. ¶ As ofte quod she as men don any þing for grace of any oþer þing. *and* an oþer þinge þan þilke þing þat men ententen to doon bytideþ by som[e] causes it is ycleped *happe*. ¶ Ry3t as a man dalf þe erþe by cause of tylienge of þe felde. *and* fond þere a gobet of golde by-doluen. þan wenen folk þat it is fallen by fortunous bytydyng. but for soþe it nis nat for nau3t for it haþ hys propre causes of whiche causes þe cours vnforseyen and vnwar semip to han maked *happe*. ¶ For yif þe tilier in þe erþe ne delue nat in þe felde. and yif þe hider of þe golde ne hadde hidd þe golde in þilke place. þe golde ne had[de] nat ben founde. þise ben þan þe causes of þe abreggyng of fortune hap. þe whiche abreggyng of fortune hap comeþ of causes encountrynge *and* flowyng to-gidre to hem selfe. *and* nat by þe entencioun of þe doer. ¶ For neiþer þe hider of þe gold. ne þe deluer of þe felde ne vndirstanden nat þat þe golde sholde han be founde. but as I seide. it bytidde *and* ran to-gidre þat he dalf þere as þat oþer hadde hidd þe golde. Now may I þus diffinissen *happe*. ¶ *Happe* is an vnwar bytydyng of causes assembled in þinges þat ben don for som oþer þinge. but þilke ordre procedyng by an vneschewable byndyng to-gidre. whiche þat descendep fro þe wel of purueaunce þat ordeineþ alle þinges in hire places *and* in hire tymes makeþ þat þe causes rennen *and* assemblen to-gidre.

RUPIS ACHEMENIE.

[The fyrste Metur.]

T Igris [*and*] eufrates resoluen *and* spryngen of a welle in þe kragges of þe roche of þe contre of achemenye þere as þe fleenge [batayle] ficchiþ hire dartes retournid in þe brestes of hem þat folwen hem. ¶ And sone aftre þe same ryueres tigris *and* eufrates vnioygnen *and* departen hire watres. and yif þei comen to-gidre *and* ben assembled *and* clepid to-gidre in to o cours. þan moten þilke þinges fletyn to-gidre whiche þat þe water of þe entrechaungyng flode bryngeþ þe shippes *and* þe stokkes araced wiþ þe flood moten assemble. *and* þe watres ymedlyd wrappiþ or implieþ many fortunel happes or maneres. þe whiche wandryng happes napeles þilke enclinyng lowenes of þe erþe. *and* þe flowyng ordre of þe slidyng water gouerniþ. ¶ Ry3t so fortune þat semeþ as [þat] it fletiþ wiþ slaked or

vngouerned[e] bridles. It suffriþ bridles þat is to seyn to ben gouerned *and* passeþ by þilke lawe. þat is to sein by þe deuyne ordinaunce.

ANIMADUERTO INQUAM.

[The .2^{de}. prose.]

Þis vndirstonde I wel quod I. *and* accorde wel þat it is ryzt as þou seist. but I axe yif þer be any liberte or fre wil in þis ordre of causes þat cliuen þus to-gidre in hem self. ¶ or ellys I wolde witen yif þat þe destinal cheine constreiniþ þe moeueyng of þe corages of men. yis quod she þer is liberte of fre wille. ne þer ne was neuer no nature of resoun þat it ne hadde liberte of fre wille. ¶ For euery þing þat may naturely vsen resoun. it haþ doom by whiche it discerniþ *and* demiþ euery þing. ¶ þan knoweþ it by it self þinges þat ben to fleen. *and* þinges þat ben to desiren. *and* þilk þing þat any wyzt demeþ to ben desired þat axeþ or desireþ he *and* fleep [thilke] þing þat he troueþ ben to fleen. ¶ wher-fore in alle þinges þat resoun is. in hem also is libertee of willyng *and* of nillynge. ¶ But I ne ordeyne nat. as who seiþ. I ne graunte nat þat þis libertee be euene like in alle þinges. forwhi in þe souereyns deuynes substaunces. þat is to seyn in spirit3 ¶ Iugement is more clere *and* wil nat be corumped. *and* haþ myzt redy to speden þinges þat ben desired. ¶ But þe soules of men moten nedes ben more free whan þei loken hem in þe speculacioun or lokyng of þe deuyne pouzt. *and* lasse free whan þei sliden in to þe bodies. *and* 3it lasse free whan þei ben gadred to-gidre *and* comprehendid in erþely membris. but þe last[e] seruage is whan þat þei ben zeuen to vices. *and* han yfalle fro þe possessioun of hire propre resoun ¶ For after þat þei han cast awaye hir eyen fro þe lyzt of þe souereyn soþefastnesse to lowe þinges *and* dirke ¶ Anon þei dirken by þe cloude of ignoraunce *and* ben troubled by felonous talent3. to þe whiche talent3 whan þei approchen *and* assenten. þei hepen *and* encresen þe seruage whiche þei han ioigned to hem self. *and* in þis manere þei ben caitifs fro hire propre libertee. þe whiche þinges nabeles þe lokyng of þe deuyne purueaunce seeþ þat alle þinges byholdeþ *and* seeþ fro eterne. *and* ordeyneþ hem eueryche in her merites. as þei ben prodestinat. *and* it is seid in grek. þat alle þinges he seeþ *and* alle þinges he hereþ.

PURO CLARUM LUMINE.

[The .2^{de}. Metur.]

H Omer wiþ þe hony mouþe. þat is to seyn. homer wiþ þe swete dities synged þat þe sonne is cleer by pure lyzt. nabeles 3it ne may it nat by þe inferme lyzt of hys bemes breken or *percen* þe inwarde entrailes of þe erþe. or ellys of þe see. ¶ so ne seep nat god makere of þe grete worlde to hym þat lokeþ alle þinges from on heye ne wiþstandiþ nat no þinges by heuynesses of erþe. ne þe nyzt ne wiþstondeþ nat to hym by þe blake cloudes. ¶ þilke god seep in o strook of þouzt alle þinges þat ben or weren or schullen come. ¶ and þilke god for he lokeþ *and* seep alle þinges al oon. þou maist seyn þat he is þe verray sonne.

TAMEN EGO EN INQUAM.

[The .3^{de}. prose.]

D An seide I now am I *confounded* by a more harde doute þan I was. what doute is þat *quod* she. ¶ For certys I coniecte now by whiche þinges þou art troubled. It semed *quod* I to repugnen *and* to contrarien gretly þat god knoweþ byforn alle þinges. *and* þat þer is any fredom of liberte. for yif so be þat god lokeþ alle þinges byforn. ne god ne may nat ben desseiuid in no manere. þan mot it nedes ben þat alle þinges bytyden þe whiche þat þe purueaunce of god haþ sein byforn to comen. ¶ For whiche yif þat god knoweþ by-forn nat oonly þe werkes of men. but also hir conseyls *and* hir willes. þan ne shal þer be no liberte of arbitre. ne certys þer ne may ben noon oper dede ne no wille but þilke whiche þe deuyne purueaunce þat ne may nat ben desseiued haþ feled byforn ¶ For yif þat þei myzten wrypen away in oper manere þan þei ben purueyed. þan ne sholde þer ben no stedfast *prescience* of þinge to comen but raþer an vncerteyn oppinioun. þe whiche þinge to trowen on god I deme it felonie *and* vnleueful. ¶ Ne I ne proeue nat þilk same resoun. as who seiþ I ne allowe nat. or I ne preise nat þilke same resoun by whiche þat som men wenen þat þei mowen assoilen *and* vnknyttyn þe knot of þis questioun. ¶ For certys þei seyn þat þing nis nat to come for þat þe purueaunce of god haþ seyn it byforne. þat is to comen but raþer þe *contrarie*. ¶ And þat is þis þat for þat þe þing is to comen þat þefore ne may it nat ben hyd fro þe purueaunce of god. *and* in þis manere þis necessite slydiþ azein in to þe *contrarie* partie. ne it ne byhoued [nat] nedes þat þinges bytiden þat ben ypurueid. [but it by-houeth

nedes / þat thinges þat ben to comyn ben yporueyid] but as it were ytrauailed. as who seiþ. þat þilke answeþ procediþ ryȝt as þouȝ men trauailden or weren bysy to enqueren þe whiche þing is cause of whiche þinges. as wheþer þe prescience is cause of þe necessite of þinges to comen. or ellys þat þe necessite of þinges to comen is cause of þe purueaunce.

¶ But I ne enforce me nat now to shewen it þat þe bytydyng of þinges y-wist byforn is necessarie. how so or in what manere þat þe ordre of causes haþ it self. al þouȝ þat it ne seme nat þat þe prescience brynge in necessite of bytydyng of þinges to comen. ¶ For certys yif þat any wyȝt sitteþ it byhoueþ by necessite þat þe oppinioun be soþe of hym þat coniectiþ þat he sitteþ. and aȝeinward. al so is it of þe contrarie. yif þe oppinioun be soþe of any wyȝt for þat he sitteþ it byhoueþ by necessite þat he sitte ¶ þan is here necessite in þat oon *and* in þat oþer. for in þat oon is necessite of sittynge. *and* certys in þat oþer is necessite of soþe but þerfore ne sitteþ nat a wyȝt for þat þe oppinioun of sittynge is soþe. but þe oppinioun is raþer soþe for þat a wyȝt sitteþ by-forn. and þus al þouȝ þat þe cause of soþe comeþ of [þe] syttyng. and nat of þe trewe oppinioun. Algates ȝitte is þer comune necessite in þat oon *and* in þat oþer. ¶ þus sheweþ it þat I may make semblable skills of þe purueaunce of god *and* of þinges to come. ¶ For al þouȝ for þat þat þinges ben to comen. þer-fore ben þei purueid. nat certys for þei ben purueid. þer-fore ne bytide þei nat. ȝit naþeles byhoueþ it by necessite þat eiþer þe þinges to comen ben ypurueied of god. or ellys þat þe þinges þat ben purueied of god bitiden [.s.] by necessite. ¶ And þis þing oonly suffiseþ I-nouȝ to distroien þe fredome of oure arbitre. þat is to seyn of oure fre wille ¶ But now [certes] sheweþ it wel how fer fro þe soþe *and* how vp so down is þis þing þat we seyn þat þe bytydinge of temporel þinges is þe cause of þe eterne prescience. ¶ But forto wenen þat god purueiþ [the] þinges to comen. for þei ben to comen. what oþer þing is it but forto wene þat þilke þinges þat bitiden som tyme ben causes of þilke souereyne purueaunce þat is in god. ¶ And her-to I adde ȝitte þis þing þat ryȝt as whan þat I woot þat o þing is it byhoueþ by necessite þat þilke self þing be. *and* eke þat whan I haue knowe þat any þinge shal bitiden so byhoueþ it by necessite þat þilk[e] same þing bytide. so folweþ it þan þat þe bytydyng of þe þinge Iwist by-forn ne may nat ben eschewed. ¶ And at þe last[e] yif þat any wyȝt wene a þing to ben oþer weyes þan it is. it nys nat oonly vnscience. but it is deceiuable oppinioun ful diuerse *and* fer fro þe soþe of

science. ¶ wherfore yif any þing be so to comen so þat þe bytydyng of it ne be nat certeyne ne necessarie. ¶ who may weten [byforn] þat þilke þing is to come. ¶ For ryzt as science ne may nat be medelyd wip falsnesse. as who seiþ þat yif I woot a þing. it ne may nat be fals þat I ne woot it. ¶ Ryzt so þilk þing þat is conceyued by science ne may [nat] ben noon oþer weyes þan [as] it is conceiued. For þat is þe cause whi þat science wantiþ lesynge. as who seiþ. whi þat witynge ne receyueþ nat lesynge of þat it woot. ¶ For it byhoueþ by necessite þat euery þinge [be] ryzt as science comprehendþ it to be. what shal I þan sein. ¶ In whiche manere knoweþ god byforn þe þinges to comen. ¶ yif þei ne be nat certeyne. ¶ For yif þat he deme þat þei ben to comen vneschewably. *and* so may be þat it is possible þat þei ne shullen nat comen. god is desseiued. but nat only to trowen þat god is desseiued. but for to speke it wip mouþe it is a felonous synne. ¶ But yif þat god woot þat ryzt so as þinges ben to comen. so shulle þei comen. so þat he wit[e] egaly. as who seiþ indifferently þat þinges mowen ben don or ellys nat don. what is þilke prescience þat ne comprehendþ no certeyne þinge ne stable. or ellys what difference is þer bytwixe þe prescience. *and* þilke iape-worþi dyuynynge of Tiresie þe diuinour þat seide. ¶ Al þat I sie *quod* he eyþer it shal be. or ellys it ne shal nat be. Or ellis how moche is worþe þe diuyn prescience more þan þe oppinioun of mankynde yif so be þat it demeþ þe þinges vncerteyne as men don. of þe whiche domes of men þe bytydyng nis nat certeyne. ¶ But yif so be þat noon vncerteyne þinge may ben in hym þat is ryzt certeyne welle of alle þinges. þan is þe bytydyng certeyne of þilke þinges whiche he haþ wist byforn fermely to comen. For whiche it folweþ þat þe fredom of þe conseyls *and* of þe werkes of mankynde nis non syn þat þe þouzt of god seep alle þinges *with* outen errour of falsnesse byndeþ *and* constreiniþ hem to a bitidynge by necessite. *and* yif [this] þing be on-is grauntid *and* receyued. þat is to seyn. þat þer nis no fre wille. þan sheweþ it wel how gret distruccioun *and* how grete damages þer folwen of þinges of mankynde. ¶ For in ydel ben þer þan purposed *and* byhyzt medes of goode folk. *and* peynes to badde folk. syn þat no moeuyng of free corage uoluntarie ne haþ nat deserued hem. þat is to seyn neiþer mede nor peyne. ¶ And it sholde seme þan þat þilke þinge is alþer worste whiche þat is nowe demed. for alþer moste iuste *and* moste ryztful. þat is to seyn þat shrewes ben punyssed. or ellys þat good[e] folk ben ygerdoned. þe whiche folk syn þat þe propre wille [ne] sent hem nat to

þat oon ne to þat oþer. þat is to seyn. neþer to good[e] ne to harme. but constreineþ hem certeyne necessite of þinges to comen. ¶ þanne ne shollen þer neuer ben ne neuer weren vice ne vertue. but it sholde raþer ben *confusioun* of alle desertes medlid wiþoute *discrecioun*. ¶ And zitte þer folweþ an oþer *inconuenient* of þe whiche þer ne may ben þouzt ne more felonous ne more wikke. *and* þat is þis þat so as þe ordre of þinges is yledd *and* comeþ of þe purueaunce of god. ne þat no þing nis leueful to þe conseils of mankynde. as who seiþ þat men han no power to done no þing. ne wilne no þing. þan folweþ it þat oure vices ben refferred to þe mak[er]e of alle good. as who seiþ þan folweþ it. þat god auzt[e] han þe blame of oure vices. syn he constreiniþ by necessite to don vices. þan nis þer no resoun to han hopen in god. ne forto preien to god. ¶ For what sholde any wyzt hopen to god. or whi sholde he preien to god. syn þat þe ordenaunce of destine whiche þat ne may nat ben enclined. knytteþ *and* streiniþ alle þinges þat men may desiren. ¶ þan sholde þere be don away þilke oonly alliaunce bytwixen god *and* men. þat is to seien to hopen *and* to preien. but by þe preis of ryztfulnesse *and* of veray mekenesse we deserue þe gerdoun of þe deuyne grace whiche þat is inestimable. þat is to sein þat it is so grete þat it ne may nat ben ful ypreised. *and* þis is oonly þe manere. þat is to seyen hope *and* prayeres. for whiche it semeþ þat [men] mowen speken wiþ god. *and* by resoun of supplicacioun ben conioigned to þilk clernesse þat nis nat approched no raþer or þat men byseken it *and* emprenten it. And yif men ne wene [nat] þat [hope] ne preiers ne han no strengþes. by þe necessite of þinges to comen y-resceiued. what þing is þer þan by whiche we mowen be conioygned *and* clyuen to þilke souereyne prince of þinges. ¶ For whiche it byhoueþ by necessite þat þe lynage of mankynde as þou songe a litel here byforne ben departed *and* vnioyned from hys welle *and* faylen of hys bygynnyng. þat is to seien god.

QUE NAM DISCORS

[The .3^{de}. Metur.]

What discordable cause hap to-rent *and* vnioigned þe byndyng or þe alliaunce of þinges. þat is to seyne þe coniunccioun of god *and* of man. ¶ whiche god hap establissed so grete bataile bitwixen þise two soþefast or verray þinges. þat is to sein bytwixen þe purueaunce of god *and* fre wille. þat þei ben synguler *and* diuided. ne þat þei ne wolen nat ben

medeled ne coupled to-gidre. but þer nis no discorde to [tho] verray þinges. but þei cleuen certeyne al wey to hem self. but þe þouzt of man confounded *and* ouerþrowen by þe dirke membris of þe body ne may nat by fir of his dirk[ed] lokynge. þat is to seyn by þe vigour of hys insyzt while þe soule is in þe body knowen þe þinne subtil knyttynges of þinges. ¶ But wherfore eschaufiþ it so by so grete loue to fynden þilke note[s] of soþe y-couered. (*glosa*) þat is to sein wherfore eschaufiþ þe þouzt of man by so grete desir to knowen þilke notificaciouns þat ben yhidd vnder þe couertours of soþe. woot it ouzt þilke þinges þat it anguissous desirþ to knowe. as who seiþ nay. ¶ For no man ne trauaileþ forto witen þinges þat he woot. *and* þerfore þe texte seiþ þus. ¶ [*Glosa*] Si enim anima ignorat istas subtiles connexiones. responde. vnde est quod desiderat scire cum nil ignotum possit desiderare. ¶ But who traua[i]leþ to wyten þinges y-knowe. and yif þat he ne knoweþ hem nat. what sekþ þilke blynde þouzt. what is he þat desirþ any þinge of whiche he woot ryzt nat. as who seiþ who so desirþ any þing nedis som what he knoweþ of it. or ellys he ne coue nat desire it. or who may folwen þinges þat ne ben nat ywist ¶ *and* þou3 [þat] he seke þo þinges where shal he fynden hem. what wyzt þat is al vnknowynge *and* ignoraunt may knowe þe forme þat is yfounde. ¶ But whan þe soule byholdeþ *and* seeþ þe heye þouzt. þat is to seyn god. þan knoweþ it to-gidre þe somme *and* þe singularites. þat is to seyn þe principles *and* eueryche by hym self. ¶ But now while þe soule is hidd in þe cloude *and* in þe derknesse of þe membris of þe body. it ne haþ nat al forzeten it selfe. but it wiþholdeþ þe somme of þinges *and* lesiþ þe singularites. þan who so þat sekeþ soþenesse. he nis in neiþer nouþir habit. for he not nat alle ne he ne haþ nat alle forzeten. ¶ But 3itte hym remembriþ þe somme of þinges þat he wiþholdeþ *and* axeþ counseil *and* tretþ depelyche þinges ysein byforne. [*Glosa*] þat is to sein þe grete somme in hys mynde. [*textus*] so þat he mowe adden þe parties þat he haþ forzeten. to þilke þat he haþ wiþholden.

TAMEN ILLA UETUS INQUIT HEC EST. [The 4th prose.]

Panne seide she. þis is quod she þe olde questioun of þe purueaunce of god. *and* marcus tulius whan he deuided[e] þe deuinaciouns. þat is to sein in hys booke þat he wroot of deuinaciouns. he moeued[e] gretly þis questioun. *and* þou þi self hast souzt it mochel *and* outerly *and* long[e]. but

3it ne haþ it nat ben determined ne yspedd fermely *and* diligently of any of
 yow. ¶ And þe cause of þis derkenesse *and* [of this] difficulte is for þat þe
 moeuyng of þe resoun of mankynde ne may nat moeuen to. þat is to sein
 applien or ioynen to þe simplicitie of þe deuyne prescience. ¶ þe whiche
 symplicitie of þe deuyne prescience 3if þat men [myhten thinken it in any
 manere / þat is to seyn / þat yif men] myzte þinken *and* comprehenden þe
 þinges as god seep hem. þan ne sholde þer dwellen outerly no doute. þe
 whiche resoun *and* cause of difficulte I shal assaie at þe laste to shewen *and*
 to speden. ¶ whan I haue firste [yspendyd / *and*] ansewered to þo resouns by
 whiche þou art ymoewed. ¶ For I axe whi þou wenest þat þilk[e] resouns of
 hem þat assoilen þis questioun ne ben nat spedeful ynou3 ne sufficient þe
 whiche solucioun or þe whiche resoun for þat it demip þat þe prescience nis
 nat cause of necessite to þinges to comen. þan ne wenep it nat þat fredom of
 wille be distourbed or ylett by prescience. for ne drawest þou nat
 argumentes from ellys where of þe necessite of þinges to comen. As who
 seip any oþer wey þan þus. but þat þilke þinge[s] þat þe prescience woot
 byforn [ne] mowen nat vnbitide. þat is to seyn þat þei moten bitide. ¶ But
 þan yif þat prescience ne putteþ no necessite to þinges to comen. as þou þi
 self hast confessed it *and* byknowen a litel herbyforne. ¶ what cause [or
 what] is it. as who seip þere may no cause be. by whiche þat þe endes
 (exitus) uoluntarie of þinges my3ten be constreyned to certeyne bitydyng.
 ¶ For by grace of possessioun. so þat þou mowe þe better vndirstonde þis
 þat folweþ. ¶ I pose (impossibile) þat þer ne be no prescience. þan axe I
 quod she in as moche as appertenip to þat. sholde þan þinges þat comen of
 frewille ben constreined to bytiden by necessite. *Boicius.* nay quod I. þan
 a3einward quod she. I suppose þat þere be prescience but þat ne putteþ no
 necessite to þinges. þan trowe I þat þilk self fredom of wille shal dwellen al
 hool *and* absolut *and* vnbounden. but þou wolt sein þat al be it so þat
 prescience nis nat cause of þe necessite of bitidyng to þinges to comen.
 ¶ Algates 3itte it is a signe þat þe þinges ben to bytiden by necessite. by þis
 manere þan al þou3 þe prescience ne hadde neuer yben. 3it algate or at þe
 lest[e] wey. it is certeyne þing þat þe endys *and* þe bitydynges of þinges to
 comen sholde ben necessarie. ¶ For euery sygne sheweþ *and* signifiep oonly
 what þe þing is ¶ but it ne makip nat þe þing þat it signifiep. ¶ For whiche it
 byhoueþ firste to shewen þat no þing ne bitidip [þat it ne bytydith] by
 necessite. so þat it may apere þat þe prescience is signe of þis necessite ¶ or

ellys yif þere nere no necessite. certys þilke prescience ne myzt[e] nat ben signe of þinge þat nis nat. ¶ But certys it is nowe certeyne þat þe preue of þis sustenib by stedfast resoun ne shal nat ben ladd ne proued by signes ne by argumentys ytaken fro wiþ oute. but by causes couenable *and* necessarie ¶ But þou mayst sein how may it be þat þe þinges ne bitiden nat þat ben ypurueyed to comen. but certys ryzt as we trowen þat þo þinges whiche þat þe purueaunce woot byforn to comen. ne ben nat to bitiden. but [þat] ne sholde we nat demen. but raþer al þou3 [þat] þei schal bitiden. 3it ne haue þei no necessite of hire kynde to bitiden. *and* þis maist þou lyztly aperceyuen by þis þat I shal seyn. but we seen many þinges whan þei ben don byforn oure eyen ryzt as men seen þe karter worken in þe tournynge *and* in attemprynge or in adressyng of hys kartes or chariottes. ¶ *and* by þis manere as who seiþ mayst þou vnderstonde of alle manere opir werkemen. ¶ Is þere þanne any necessite as who seiþ in oure lokynge [þat] constreineþ or compelliþ any of þilke þinges to ben don so. b. nay quod I ¶ For in ydel *and* in veyne were alle þe effect of crafte yif þat alle þinges weren moeued by constreynynge. þat is to seyn by constreynynge of oure eyen or of oure syzt. *P.* þise þingus þan quod she þat whan men don hem ne han non necessite þat men don hem. eke þo same þinges first or þei be don. þei ben to comen wiþ out necessite. for whi þer ben somme þinges to bytide of whiche þe endys *and* þe bitidynges of hem ben absolut *and* quit of alle necessite. for certys I ne trowe nat þat any man wolde seyn þis. þat þo þinges þat men don now þat þei ne weren to bitiden. first or þei were ydon ¶ *and* þilk same þinges al þou3 þat men hadden ywyst hem by-forn. 3itte þei han fre bitidynges. for ryzt as science of þinges present ne bryngeþ in no necessite to þinges [þat men doon // Ryht so the prescience of thinges to comen ne bryngeth in no necessite to thinges] to bytiden but þou mayst seyn þat of þilke same it is ydouted. as wheþer þat of þilke þinges þat ne han non endes *and* bytidynges necessaryes yif þer-of may ben any prescience ¶ For certys þei seme to discorde. for þou wenest þat yif þat þinges ben yseyn byforn þat necessite folweþ hem. *and* yif (*et putas*) necessite faileþ hem þei ne myzten nat ben wist byforn. *and* þat no þinge ne may ben comprehendid by science but certeyne. *and* yif þo þinges þat ne han no certeyne bytidynges ben ypurueied as certeyn. it sholde ben dirkenesse of oppinioun nat soþefastnesse of science [*and* þou weenyst þat it be diuerse fro the hoolnesse of science / þat any man sholde deme a thing

to ben oother weys thanne it is it self]. and þe cause of þis errour is. þat of alle þe þinges þat euery wyȝt haþ yknowe. þei wenen þat þo þinges ben yknowe al oonly by þe strengþe *and* by þe nature of þe þinges þat ben ywyst or yknowe. *and* it is al þe contrarie. for alle þat euere is yknowe. it is raþer comprehendid *and* yknowen nat after his strengþe *and* hys nature. but after þe faculte þat is to seyn þe power *and* [the] nature of hem þat knowen. *and* for þat þis shal mowe shewen by a short ensample þe same roundenes of a body .O. oþer weyes þe syȝt of þe eye knoweþ it. *and* oþer weyes þe touching. þe lokynge by castynge of his bemes waiteþ *and* seeþ fro afer alle þe body to-gider wiþ oute mouynge of it self. but þe touchinge cliuiþ *and* conioigneþ to þe rounde body (orbi) *and* moueþ abouten þe environynge. *and* comprehendþ by parties þe roundenesse. ¶ *and* þe man hym self oþer weies wyt byholdþ hym. *and* oþerweyes ymaginacioun *and* oþer weyes resoun. *and* oþer weyes intelligence. ¶ For þe wit comprehendþ fro wiþ outen furþe þe figure of þe body of þe man. þat is establissed in þe matere subiect. But þe ymaginacioun [comprehendith only the figure with owte the matere / Resoun surmounteth ymaginacioun] *and* comprehendþ by an vniuersel lokynge þe *commune* spece (*speciem*) þat is in þe singuler peces. ¶ But þe eye of intelligence is heyȝer for it sourmounteþ þe enviroynynge of þe vniuersite *and* lookeþ ouer þat by pure subtilite of þouȝt. þilk same symple forme of man þat is perdurably in þe deuyne þouȝt. in whiche þis auȝt[e] gretely to ben considered þat þe heyest strengþe to comprehenden þinges enbraceþ *and* conteyneþ þe lower[e] strengþe [but the lowere strengthe ne arysith nat in no manere to heyere strengthe]. for wit ne may no þinge comprehende oute of matere. ne þe ymagynacioun ne lokeþ nat þe vniuerseles spes. ne resoun ne takeþ nat þe symple forme. so as intelligence takeþ it. but þe intelligence þat lokeþ al abouen whan it haþ comprehendid þe forme it knoweþ *and* demeþ alle þe þinges þat ben vndir þat forme. but she knoweþ hem vndir þilke manere in þe whiche it comprehendþ þilke same symple forme þat ne may neuer be knowen to non of þat oþer. þat is to seyn to non of þo þre forseide strengþes of þe soule. for it knoweþ þe vniuersite of resoun *and* þe figure of þe ymaginacioun. *and* þe sensible material conseiued. *and* þou wenest þat it be diuerse fro þe hoolnesse of science. þat any man sholde deme a þing to ben oþerweyes þan it is it self *and* þe cause of þis errour etc'. vt *supra*. by wit. ne it ne vseþ nat nor of resoun ne of ymaginacioun ne of wit wiþ oute forþe

but it byholdeþ alle þinges so as I shal seye. by a strok of þouzt formely wiþ oute discours or collacioun ¶ Certys resoun whan it lokeþ any þing vniuersel it ne vseþ nat of ymaginacioun nor of wit *and* algates 3it [it] comprehendþ þe þinges ymaginable *and* sensible. for resoun is she þat diffiniseseþ þe vniuersel of hir conseite ryzt þus. ¶ Man is a resonable t[w]o-footid beest. and how so þat þis knowynge [is] vniuersel. 3it nys þer no wyzt þat ne woot wel. þat a man is [a thing] ymaginable *and* sensible ¶ *and* þis same considereþ wel resoun. but þat nis nat by ymaginacioun. nor by witte. but it lokeþ it by [a] resonable concepcioun. ¶ Also ymaginacioun al be it so. þat it takeþ of wit þe bygynyngus to seen *and* to formen þe figures. algates al þou3 þat wit ne ware not present. 3it it envirouniþ *and* comprehendþ alle þinges sensible. nat by resoun sensible of demynge. but by resoun ymaginatif. ¶ sest þou nat þan þat alle þe þinges in knowynge vsen more of hir faculte or of hir power. þan þei don of [the] faculte or of power of þinges þat ben yknowen. ne þat nis no wronge. for so as euery iugement is þe dede or þe doynge of hym þat demeþ. It byhoueþ þat euery wyzt performe þe werke *and* hys entencioun nat of forein power ; but of hys propre power.

QUONDAM PORTICUS ATTULIT.

[The 4th Metur.]

PE porche þat is to sein a gate of þe toune of athenis þer as philosophres hadde hir congregacioun to dispoyten. *and* þilke porche brouzt[e] somtyme olde men ful derke in hire sentences. þat is to sein philosophers þat hyzten stoiciens. þat wenden þat ymages [*and*] sensibilites þat is to sein sensible ymaginaciouns. or ellys ymaginacioun of sensible þinges weren inprentid in to soules fro bodies wiþ oute forþe. ¶ As who seiþ þat þilke stoiciens wenden þat þe soule hadde ben naked of it self. as a mirour or a clene parchemyn. so þat alle fygyres mosten [fyrst] comen fro þinges fro wiþ oute in to soules. *and* ben inprentid in to soules. *Textus.* Ryzt as we ben wont some tyme by a swift poyntel to ficchen lettres emprentid in þe smopenesse or in þe plainesse of þe table of wex. or in parchemyn þat ne haþ no figure [ne] note in it. *Glosa.* But now arguiþ boece azeins þat oppinioun *and* seiþ þus. but yif þe þriuyng soule ne vnplitiþ no þing. þat is to sein ne doþ no þing by hys propre moeuynges. but suffriþ *and* lieþ subgit

to þe figures *and* to þe notes of bodyes wiþ oute forþe. *and* ȝeldeþ ymages ydel *and* veyne in þe manere of a mirour. whennes þriueþ þan or whennes comeþ þan þilke knowyng in oure soule. þat discerniþ *and* byholdeþ alle þinges. *and* whennes is þilke strengþe þat byholdeþ þe syngulere þinges. or whennes is þe strengþe þat dyuydeþ þinges yknowe. *and* þilke strengþe þat gadereþ to-gidre þe þinges deuided. *and* þe strengþe þat cheseþ hys entrechaunged wey for som tyme it heueþ vp þe heued. þat is to sein þat it heueþ vp þe entencioun to ryȝt heye þinges. *and* som tyme it discendiþ in to ryȝt lowe þinges. *and* whan it retourniþ in to hym self. it repreuiþ *and* destroieþ þe false þinges by þe trewe þinges. ¶ Certys þis strengþe is cause more efficient *and* mochel more myȝty to seen *and* to knowe þinges. þan þilke cause þat suffriþ *and* resceyueþ þe notes *and* þe figures inpressed in manere of matere algates þe passioun þat is to seyn þe suffraunce or þe wit in þe quik[e] body goþ byforne excitynge *and* moeuyng þe strengþes of þe þouȝte. ryȝt so as whan þat clerenesse smyteþ þe eyen *and* moeuiþ hem to seen. or ryȝt so as voys or sounne hurtliþ to þe eres *and* commoeuiþ hem to herkne. þan is þe strengþe of þe þouȝt ymoeuid *and* excitid *and* clepeþ furþe þe semblable moeuynges þe speces þat it halt wiþ inne it self. *and* addiþ þo speces to þe notes *and* to þe þinges wiþ out forþe. *and* medeleþ þe ymages of þinges wiþ out forþe to þe forme[s] yhid wiþ inne hym self.

QUOD SI IN CORPORIBUS SENCIENTIS. [The .5.th prose.]

QUESTIO.

But what [yif] þat in bodies to ben feelid þat is to sein in þe takyng of knowelechinge of bodyly þinges. *and* al be it so þat þe qualites of bodies þat ben obiet fro wiþ oute forþe moeuen *and* entalenten þe instrumentes of þe wittes. *and* al be it so þat þe passioun of þe body þat is to seyn þe witte [or the] suffraunce [goth to-forn the strengthe of the workyng corage / the which passioun or suffraunce] clepiþ furþe þe dede of þe þouȝt in hym self. *and* moeueþ *and* exiteþ in þis mene while þe formes þat resten wiþ in forþe. *and* yif þat in sensible bodies as I haue seid oure corage nis nat ytauȝt or enprentid by passioun to knowe þise þinges. but demþ *and* knoweþ of hys owen strengþe þe passioun or suffraunce subiect to þe body. Moche more þan þoo þinges þat ben absolut *and* quit fram alle talentȝ or

affecciouns of bodies. as god or hys aungels ne folwen nat in discernynge þinges obiect from wiþ oute forþe. but þei accomplissen *and* speden þe dede of hir þouȝt by þis resoun. ¶ þan þere comen many manere knowynges to dyuerse *and* differyng substaunces. for þe wit of þe body þe whiche witte is naked *and* despoyled of alle oþer knowynges. þilke witte cometh to bestes þat ne mowen nat moeuen hem self here ne þere. as oystres *and* muscles *and* oþer swiche shelle fysshe of þe see. þat cliuen *and* ben norissed to roches. but þe ymaginacioun cometh to remuable bestes þat semen to han talent to fleen or to desiren any þinge. but resoun is al only to þe lynage of mankynde ryȝt as intelligence is oonly þe deuyne nature. of whiche it folweþ þat þilke knowyng is more worþe þan [th]is[e] oþer. syn it knoweþ by hys propre nature nat only hys subiect. as who seiþ it ne knoweþ nat al oonly þat apperteiniþ proprely to hys knowynge. but it knoweþ þe subgitȝ of alle oþer knowynges. but how shal it þan be yif þat wit *and* ymaginacioun stryuen aȝeins resonyng *and* sein þat of þilke vniuersel þinges. þat resoun weneþ to seen þat it nis ryȝt nauȝt. for wit *and* ymaginacioun seyn þat þat. þat is sensible or ymaginable it ne may nat ben vniuersel. þan is eiper þe iugement of resoun [soth]. ne þat þer nis no þinge sensible. or ellys for þat resoun woot wel þat many þinges ben subiect to wit *and* to ymaginacioun. þan is þe consepçioun of resoun veyn *and* fals whiche þat lookeþ *and* comprehendith. þat þat is sensible *and* synguler as uniuersele. and ȝif þat resoun wolde answeren aȝein to þise two þat is to sein to wit *and* to ymaginacioun. *and* sein þat soþely she hir self. þat is to seyn þat resoun lokeþ *and* comprehendith by resoun of vniuersalite. boþe þat þat is sensible *and* þat þat is ymaginable. *and* þat þilke two þat is to seyn wit *and* ymaginacioun ne mowen nat strecchen ne enhaunsen hem self to knowynge of vniuersalite for þat þe knowyng of hem ne may exceden nor sourmounten þe bodyly figure[s] ¶ Certys of þe knowyng of þinges men auȝten raþer ȝeue credence to þe more stedfast *and* to þe more perfit iugement. In þis manere stryuyng þan we þat han strengþe of resonyng *and* of ymaginyng *and* of wit þat is to seyn by resoun *and* by ymaginacioun *and* by wit. [and] we sholde raþer preise þe cause of resoun. as who seiþ þan þe cause of wit or ymaginacioun. semblable þinge is it þat þe resoun of mankynde ne weneþ nat þat þe deuyne intelligence byholdeþ or knoweþ þinges to comen. but ryȝt as þe resoun of mankynde knoweþ hem. for þou arguist *and* seist þus. þat yif it ne seme nat to men þat somme

þinges han certeyne *and* necessarie bytydynges. þei ne mowen nat ben wist byforn certeynely to bytiden. þan nis [ther] no prescience of þilke þinges. *and* yif we trowen þat prescience ben in þise þinges. þan is þer no þinge þat it ne bitidiþ by necessite. but certys yif we myzten han þe iugement of þe deuyne þouzt as we ben parsoners of resoun. ryzt so as we han demed. it byhoueþ þat ymaginacioun *and* wit ben byneþe resoun. ryzt so wolde we demen þat it were ryztful þing þat mans resoun auzt[e] to summitten it self *and* to ben byneþe þe deuyne þouzt. for whiche þat yif we mowen. as who seip. þat yif þat we mowen I conseil[e] þat we enhanse vs in to þe heyzt of þilke souereyne intelligence. for þere shal resoun wel seen þat þat it ne may nat by-holden in it self. and certys þat is þis in what manere þe prescience of god seep alle þinges *certeins and* difinissed al þou3 þei ne han no certein issues or by-tydynges. ne þis is non oppinioun but it is rap̃er þe simplicit̃e of þe souereyn science þat nis nat enclosed nor yshet wiþinne no boundes.

QUAM UARIIS FIGURIS.

[The 5th Metur.]

ÞE bestes passen by þe erþes by ful dyuerse figures for somme of hem han hir bodies strauzt *and* crepen in þe dust *and* drawn after hem a trais or a forghe contynued. þat is to sein as addres or snakes. and oþer bestes by [the] wandryng lyztnesse of hir wenges beten þe wyndes *and* ouer-swymmen þe spaces of þe longe eyer by moist flee[y]nge. and oþer bestes gladen hem to diggen her traas or her stappes in þe erþe wiþ hir goynge or wiþ her feet. or to gone eyþe[r] by þe grene feldes or [elles] to walken vnder þe wodes. *and* al be it so þat þou seest þat þei alle discorden by dyuerse formes. algate hire [faces] enclini[n]g heuieþ hire dulle wittes. Onlyche þe lynage of man heueþ heyest hys heyze heued *and* stondeþ lyzt wiþ hys vpryzt body *and* byholdeþ þe erþe vndir hym. [and] but-3if þou erþely man wexest yuel oute of þi witte. þis figure amonesteþ þe þat axest þe heuene wiþ þi ryzt[e] visage. *and* hast areised þi forhede to beren vp on heye þi corage so þat þi þouzt ne be nat yheuied ne put lowe vndir foot. sen þat þi body is so heye areised.

PROSA VLTIMA.

ANTE.

PEr-fore þan as I haue shewed a litel her byforne þat al þinge þat is ywist
 nis nat knowen by hys nature *propre*. but by þe nature of hem þat
 comprehendē it. ¶ Lat vs loke now in as moche as it is leueful to vs. as
 who seiþ lat vs loken now as we mowen whiche þat þe estat is of þe deuyne
 substaunce so þat we mowen [ek] knowen what his science is. þe comune
 iugement of alle creatures resonables þan is þis þat god is eterne. lat vs
 considere þan what is eternite. For certys þat shal shewen vs to-gidre þe
 deuyne nature *and* þe deuyne science ¶ Eternite þan is *perfit* possessioun
and al togidre of lijf interminable *and* þat sheweþ more clerely by þe
 comparisoun or collacioun of temporel þinges. for al þing þat lyueþ in tyme
 it is *present and procediþ* fro preterit3 in to futures. þat is to sein. fro tyme
 passed in to tyme comynge. ne þer nis no þing establissed in tyme þat may
 enbracen to-gidre al þe space of hys lijf. for certys 3it ne haþ it nat taken þe
 tyme of þe morwe. *and* it haþ lost þat of 3ister-day. and certys in þe lijf of
 þis day 3e ne lyuen no more but ry3t as in þis moeueable *and* transitorie
 moment. þan þilke þinge þat suffriþ temporel condicioun. a[l]þoughe þat
 [it] bygan neuer to be. ne þoughe it neuere cese forto be. as aristotle demde
 of þe worlde. and al þou3 þat þe lif of it be strecchid wiþ infinite of tyme. 3it
 algates nis it no swiche þing þat men my3ten trowen by ry3t þat it is eterne.
 for al þou3 þat it comprehende *and* embrace þe space of life infinite. 3it
 algates ne [em]braceþ it nat þe space of þe lif alto-gidre. for it ne haþ nat þe
 futures þat ne ben nat 3it. ne it ne haþ no lenger þe preterit3 þat ben ydon or
 ypassed. but þilke þing þan þat haþ *and* comprehendiþ to-gidre alle þe
 plente of þe lif interminable. to whom þere ne failiþ nat of þe future. *and* to
 whom þer nis nat of þe preterit escapid nor ypassed. þilk[e] same is
 ywitnessed or yproued by ry3t to ben eterne. and it byhoueþ by necessite þat
 þilke þinge be alwey present to hym self *and* compotent. as who seiþ alwey
 present to hym self *and* so my3ty þat al by ry3t at hys plesaunce. *and* þat he
 haue al present þe infinit of þe moeuable tyme. wherfore som men trowen
 wrongefully þat whan þei heren þat it semid[e] to plato þat þis worlde ne
 had[de] neuer bygynnyng of tyme. ne þat it neuere shal haue faylyng. þei
 wenen in þis manere þat þis worlde ben maked coeterne wiþ his makere. as

who seip. þei wenen þat þis worlde *and* god ben maked to-gidre eterne. and it is a wrongful wenyng. for oþer þing is it to ben yladd by lif interminable as plato graunted[e] to þe worlde. *and* oþer þing is it to embracen to-gidre alle þe presence to þe lif interminable. þe whiche þing it is clere *and* manifest þat it is propre to þe deuine þouzt. ne it ne sholde nat semen to vs þat god is elder þan þinges þat ben ymaked by quantite of tyme. but raþer by þe proprete of hys symple nature. for þis ilke infinit[e] moeuyng of temporel þinges folwiþ þis presentarie estat of þe lijf inmoeueable. *and* so as it ne may nat contrefeten it ne feynen it ne ben euene lyke to it. for þe inmoeueablete. þat is to seyn þat is in þe eternite of god. ¶ it faileþ *and* falleþ in to moeuyng fro þe simplicitie of [the] presence of god. *and* disencresip to þe infinite quantite of future *and* of preterit. *and* so as it ne may nat han togidre al þe plente of þe lif. algates ȝitte for as moche as it ne cesip neuere forto ben in som manere it semeþ somde[l] to vs þat it folwiþ *and* resemblip þilke þing þat it ne may nat attayne to. ne fulfille. *and* byndeþ it self to som manere presence of þis litel *and* swifte moment. þe whiche presence of þis lytele *and* swifte moment. for þat it bereþ a manere ymage or lykenesse of þe ay dwellynge presence of god. it graunteþ to swiche manere þinges as it bitidip to þat it semeþ hem þat þise þinges han ben *and* ben *and* for [þat] þe presence of swiche litel moment ne may nat dwelle þer-for [it] rauyssid[e] *and* took þe infinit[e] wey of tyme. þat is to seyn by successioun. *and* by þis manere it is ydon. for þat it sholde continue þe lif in goynge of þe whiche lif it ne myzt[e] nat embrace þe plente in dwellynge. *and* for þi yif we willen putte worþi name[s] to þinges *and* folwen plato. lat vs seyn þan sobely þat god is eterne. *and* þat þe worlde is perpetuel. þan syn þat euery iugement knoweþ *and* comprehendip by hys owen nature þinges þat ben subiect vnto hym. þere is sobely al-wey to god an eterne *and* presentarie estat. *and* þe science of hym þat ouer-passeþ alle temporel moe[ue]ment dwellip in þe symplite of hys presence *and* embraceþ *and* considereþ alle þe infinit spaces of tymes preterit3 *and* futures *and* lokeþ in þis symple knowynge alle þinges of preterit ryzt as þei weren ydoon presently ryzt now ¶ yif þou wolt þan þenke *and* avisen þe prescience by whiche it knoweþ al[le] þinges þou ne shalt nat demen it as prescience of þinges to comen. but þou shalt demen [it] more ryztfully þat it is science of presence or of instaunce þat neuer ne fayleþ. for whiche it nis nat ycleped prouidence but it sholde raþer be cleped purueaunce þat is

establisshed ful fer fro ryȝt lowe þinges. *and* byholdeþ from a-fer alle þinges ryȝt as it were fro þe heye heyȝte of þinges. whi axest þou þan or why disputest þou þan þat þilke þinges ben don by necessite whiche þat ben yseyen *and* yknowen by þe deuyne syȝt. syn þat for soþe men ne maken nat þilke þinges necessarie. whiche þat þe[i] seen be ydoon in hire syȝt. for addiþ þi byholdynge any necessite to þilke þinges þat þou byholdest present. ¶ Nay quod I. *p.* Certys þan yif men myȝte maken any digne comparisoun or collacioun of þe presence diuine. *and* of þe presence of mankynde. ryȝt so as ȝe seen somme þinges in þis temporel presente. ryȝt so seep god alle þinges by hys eterne present. ¶ wherfore þis dyuyne prescience ne chaungeþ nat þe nature ne þe proprete of þinges but byholdeþ swyche þinges present to hym ward. as þei shollen bytiden to ȝow ward in tyme to come. ne it ne confoundeþ nat þe Iugementȝ of þinges but by of syȝt of hys þouȝt he knoweþ þe þinges to comen as wel necessarie as nat necessarie. ryȝt so as whan ȝe seen togidre a man walke on þe erþe *and* þe sonne aysen in [the] heuene. al be it so þat ȝe seen *and* byholden þat oon *and* þat oþer to-gidre. ȝit napeles ȝe demen *and* discernen þat þat oon is uoluntarie *and* þat oþer is necessarie. ¶ Ryȝt so þan [the] deuyne lokynge byholdynge alle þinges vndir hym ne troubleþ nat þe qualite of þinges þat ben certeynely present to hym ward. but as to þe condicioun of tyme for soþe þei ben future. for whiche it folwiþ þat þis nis non oppinioun. but raper a stedfast knowyng ystrenged by sopenes. þat whan þat god knoweþ any þinge to be he ne vnwoot nat þat þilke þinge wanteþ necessite to be. þis is to seyn þat whan þat god knoweþ any þinge to bitide. he woot wel þat it ne haþ no necessite to bitide. *and* yif þou seist here þat þilke þinge þat god seep to bytide it ne may nat vnbytide. as who seiþ it mot bitide. ¶ *and* þilke þinge þat þat ne may nat vnbytide it mot bitide by necessite. *and* þat þou streine me to þis name of necessite. certys I wol wel confessen *and* byknowe a þinge of ful sadde troupe. but vnneþ shal þere any wyȝt [mowe] seen it or comen þer-to. but yif þat he be byholder of þe deuyne þouȝte. ¶ for I wol answeren þe þus. þat þilke þinge þat is future whan it is referred to þe deuyne knowyng þan is it necessarie. but certys whan it is vndirstonden in hys owen kynde men sen it [is] vtterly fre *and* absolut from alle necessite. for certys þer ben two maneres of necessites. þat oon necessite is symple as þus. þat it byhoueþ by necessite þat alle men be mortal or dedely. an oþer necessite is condicionel as þus. yif þou wost

þat a man walkiþ. it byhoueþ by necessite þat he walke. þilke þinge þan þat
 any wyȝt haþ yknowe to be. it ne may ben non oþer weyes þan he knoweþ it
 to be. ¶ but þis condicioun ne draweþ nat wiþ hir þilke necessite symple.
 For certys þis necessite condicionel. þe propre nature of it ne makeþ it
 nauȝt. but þe adieccioun of þe condicioun makeþ it. for no necessite ne
 constreyneth a man to [gon / þat] gooþ by his propre wille. al be it so þat
 whan he gooþ þat it is necessarie þat he gooþ. þan mot þilke þinge be by
 necessite. al þouȝ þat it ne haue no necessite of hys owen nature. ¶ Ryȝt on
 þis same manere þan. yif þat þe purueaunce of god seeþ any þing present.
 but certys þe futures þat bytyden by fredom of arbitre god seeþ hem alle to-
 gidre presentȝ. þise þinges þan [yif] þei ben referred to þe deuyne syȝt. þan
 ben þei maked necessarie to þe condicioun of þe deuyne knowynge. but
 certys yif þilke þinges ben considred by hem self þei ben absolut of
 necessite. *and* ne forleten nat ne cesen nat of þe liberte of hire owen nature.
 þan certys wiþ outhen doute alle þe þingus shollen be doon whiche þat god
 woot by-forn þat þei ben to comen. but somme of hem comen *and* bitiden of
 [free] arbitre or of fre wille. þat al be it so þat þei bytiden. ȝit algates ne lese
 þei nat hire propre nature ne beyng. by þe whiche first or þat þei were
 doon þei hadden power nat to han bitidd. *Boece*. what is þis to seyn þan
quod I. þat þinges ne ben nat necessarie by hire propre nature. so as þei
 comen in alle maneres in þe lykenesse of necessite by þe condicioun of þe
 deuyne science. *Philosophie*. þis is þe difference *quod* she. þat þo þinges
 þat I purposed[e] þe a litel here byforn. þat is to seyn þe sonne arysynge
and þe man walkynge þat þerwhiles þat þilke þinges ben ydon. þei ne
 myȝten nat ben vndon. napeles þat oon of hem or it was ydon it byhoued[e]
 by necessite þat it was ydon. but nat þat oþer. ryȝt so it is here þat þe þinges
 þat god haþ present. wiþ outhen doute þei shulle ben. but somme of hem
 descendip of þe nature of þinges as þe sonne arysynge. *and* somme
 descendip of þe power of þe doers as þe man walkynge. ¶ þan seide I. no
 wronge þat yif þat þise þinges ben referred to þe deuyne knowynge þan ben
 þei necessarie. *and* yif þei ben considered by hem selfe þan ben þei absolut
 from þe bonde of necessite. ryȝt so [as] alle þinges þat appiereþ or sheweþ
 to þe wittes yif þou referre it to resoun it is vniuersel. *and* yif þou referre it
 or look[e] it to it self. þan is it synguler. but now yif þou seist þus þat yif it
 be in my power to chaunge my purpose. þan shal I voide þe purueaunce of
 god. whan þat perauenture I shal han chaunged þo þinges þat he knoweþ

byforn. þan shal I answere þe þus ¶ Certys þou maist wel chaungen þi purpos but for as mochel as þe present soþenesse of þe deuyne purueaunce byholdeþ þat þou mayst chaungen þi purpose. *and* wheþir þou wolt chaunge it or no. *and* whider-ward þat þou tourne it. þou maist nat eschewen þe deuyne prescience ryzt as þou ne mayst nat fleen þe syzt of þe present eye. al þou3 þat þou tourne þi self by þi fre wille in to dyuerse accioun. ¶ But þou mayst seyn azeyne how shal it þan be. shal nat þe dyuyne science ben chaunged by my disposicioun whan þat I wol o þing now *and* now an oþer. *and* þilke prescience ne semeþ it nat to enterchaunge stoundes of knowynges. as who seiþ. ne shal it nat seme to vs þat þe deuyne prescience enterchaungeþ hys dyuers stoundes of knowynge. so þat it knowe somme tyme o þing *and* somme tyme þe contrarie. ¶ No for soþe. [*quod* I] for þe deuyne syzt renneþ to-forne *and* seeþ alle futures *and* clepeþ hem azein *and* retourniþ hem to þe presence of hys propre knowynge. ne he ne entrechaungeþ nat [so] as þou wenest þe stoundes of forknowyng [as] now þis now þat. but he ay dwellynge comiþ byforn *and* embraceþ at o strook alle þi mutaciouns. and þis presence to comprehend *and* to sen alle þinges. god ne haþ nat taken it of þe bitydyng of þinges forto come. but of hys propre symplite. ¶ *and* her by is assoiled þilke þing þat þou puttest a litel her byforne. þat is to seyne þat it is vnworþi þinge to seyn þat oure futures zeuen cause of þe science of god ¶ For certys þis strengþe of þe deuyne science whiche þat embraceþ alle þinge by his presentarie knowynge establissep manere to alle þingus *and* it ne awiþ nat to lattere þinges. *and* syn þat þise þinges ben þus. þat is to seyn syn þat necessite nis nat in þinges by þe deuyne prescience. þan is þer fredom of arbitre. þat dwelleþ hool *and* vnwemmed to mortal men. ne þe lawes ne purpose nat wikkedly meedes *and* peynes to þe willynges of men þat ben vnbounde *and* quit of alle necessite. ¶ And god byholder *and* forwiter of alle þinges dwelliþ aboue *and* þe present eternite of hys syzt renneþ alwey wiþ þe dyuerse qualite of oure dedes dispensyng *and* ordeynynge medes to good[e] men. *and* tourment3 to wicked men. ne in ydel ne in veyn ne ben þer nat put in god hope *and* prayeres. þat ne mowen nat ben vnspedful ne wiþ oute effect whan þei ben ryztful ¶ wiþstond þan *and* eschewe þou vices. worshippe *and* loue þou vertus. arise þi corage to ryztful hoopes. zelde þou humble preiers an heyze. grete necessite of prowesse *and* vertue is encharged *and* comaunded to 3ow yif 3e nil nat dissimulen. ¶ Syn þat 3e worchen *and*

doon. þat is to seyn 3oure dedes *and* 3oure workes by-fore þe eyen of þe
luge þat seep *and* demep alle þinges. [To whom be goye *and* worshipe bi
Infynyt tymes / AMEN.]

EXPLICIT LIBER QUINTUS. *ET VLTIMUS.*

GLOSSARIAL INDEX.

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N O P Q R S T U V W Y 3

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[ABAIST](#) = ABYEST, sufferest, endurest, [39/1014](#)

ABAIST, abashed, [107/3047](#)

ABASSEN, to be abashed, dismayed, [146/4213](#)

ABESID (= ABAYSSHED), abashed, [7/92](#)

ABIDE, to await, [7/93](#).

‘ABIDE after’ = look after, expect, [13/250](#);

p.p. ABIDEN, waited, [86/2405](#)

Abieþ, suffers, [109/3101](#)

ABLYNGE, enabling, fitting (*aptans*), [26/624](#), [88/2440](#)

Abood, abode, [63/1716](#)

Aboven, above, [6/52](#)

Abreggyng, curtailng; hence *gain* obtained by curtailment (*compendium*), [151/4355](#)

Accoie, to soothe, quiet (*demulcere*), [38/967](#)

Accordaunce, agreement, [143/4134](#)

Accordaunt, agreeing, unanimous, [19/431](#)

Accorde, to agree, [42/1080](#)

Accoumpte, account, [47/1251](#)

Accountyng, calculation, [8/110](#)

Achat, purchase, [15/310](#)

Acheve, to achieve, accomplish, [18/404](#)

Achoken, to choke, [47/1235](#)

Acomplise, Acomplisse, to accomplish, [92/2575](#), [118/3356](#)

Acordable, agreeing, [62/1694](#)

Acusor, informer, [72/1990](#)

Addre (Nadre), adder, [170/4959](#)

Adoune, down, downward, [7/92](#)

Adounward, downwards, [7/87](#)
Adrad, in fear, afraid, [43/1132](#)
Adresse, to direct, control, [163/4721](#)
Afer, afar, [164/4767](#)
Agast, aghast, frightened, [76/2107](#)
Agaste, to terrify, frighten, [141/4051](#)
Agon, ago, [70/1907](#)
Agreableté, goodwill, [42/1099](#)
Agrisen, to be afraid, dread, [10/178](#), [31/777](#)
Ajuge, to adjudge, [15/325](#)
Aknowe, acknowledged, [17/367](#)
Aldirmost, most of all, [124/3557](#)
Algates, Algate, yet, nevertheless, [19/439](#), [68/1849](#), [81/2242](#), [162/4696](#), [4698](#)
Allegge, to alleviate, [124/3529](#)
Alouterly, utterly, entirely, [109/3090](#)
Alperfairest, fairest of all, [87/2422](#)
Alperfirst, first of all, [10/180](#)
Albermoste, most of all, [158/4563](#)
Alperworste, worst of all, [157/4562](#)
Alyene, to alienate, [27/671](#)
Amenuse, to lessen, diminish, [19/426](#), [40/1039](#)
Amenusynge, diminution, [46/1192](#)
Ameve, Amoeve, Amove, to move, [6/64](#), [23/551](#)
Amoneste, to admonish, [171/4971](#)
Amonestyng, admonition, exhortation, [149/4296](#)
Amongus, amongst, [52/1380](#)
Amonicioun, admonition, [13/253](#)
Amynistre, to administer, [135/3891](#)
Ancre, anchor, [41/1050](#)
Angre, grief, misery, [41/1072](#)
Anguisse, Angysse, anguish, [79/2177](#);
to torment, [80/2198](#)
Anguissous, anxious, sorrowful, [41/1062](#), [1066](#)
Anoie, to be grieved, be sorry, [41/1058](#)
Anoienge, [22/532](#)
Anoies, hurtful, [47/1238](#)
Anoious, annoying, hurtful, [7/102](#)
An-oone, anon, [42/1086](#)
Anoyously, dangerously, hurtfully, [80/2214](#)

Apaise, to appease, [148/4278](#)
Apasse, to pass away, go, [46/1195](#)
Aperceive, to perceive, [16/344](#), [134/3845](#)
Apertly, plainly, [17/386](#), [91/2543](#)
Appaie, to please, satisfy, [47/1235](#)
Appaire, to impair, [25/597](#)
Apparaile, to clothe, adorn, [8/116](#)
Apparaillement, clothing, ornament, [49/1300](#)
Appertiene, to appertain, [73/1996](#)
Applien, bend to, join, [161/4660](#)
Apresse, to oppress, [184/60](#)
Aprochen, to approach, [6/63](#), [66](#)
Arace, Arase, Arrace, to tear, tear from, separate, [11/196](#), [27/671](#), [98/2774](#), [152/4278](#)
Araise, Areise, Areyse, to raise, [51/1357](#), [118/3369](#), [178/5212](#)
Arbitre, will, free will, [156/4500](#)
Ardaunt, ardent, [106/3031](#)
Aresten, to stop, arrest, [32/815](#)
Aretten, to ascribe to, impute to, [40/1016](#)
Arist, arises, [143/4138](#)
Armurers, armours, arms, [51/1342](#)
Armures, armour, [9/131](#)
Arst, first, [95/2675](#)
Arwe, arrow, [148/4262](#)
Arysynge, rising, [22/512](#)
Aryve, to bring to shore, [122/3479](#)
Asayle, to assail, [181/40](#)
Ascape, to escape, [8/129](#)
Asondre, asunder, [64/1740](#)
Aspre, sharp, rough, [32/806](#), [80/2216](#)
Asprenesse, sharpness, [127/3627](#)
Assaie, to essay, [42/1083](#)
Assemble, to gather together, amass (money), [80/2208](#)
Asseure, to assure, [16/330](#)
Assoilen, to absolve, pay, unloose, dissolve, [149/4303](#), [154/4459](#)
Astat, estate, state, [30/738](#)
Astoned, astonished, [7/92](#), [63/1702](#);
 stupidus, [122/3471](#)
Astonynge, Astonyenge, astonishment, [9/134](#), [132/3780](#)
Ataste, to taste, [30/756](#)

Ataynt, Ateint, attained, knowing, experienced, [31/772](#), [69/1905](#)
Attayne, to reach, [12/227](#)
Atte, at the, [95/2675](#)
Attemperaunce, tempering, temperament, [138/3973](#), [144/4145](#)
Attempre, to temper, moderate, [8/115](#), [111/3154](#);
control, [163/4721](#);
(*adj.*) modest, [29/728](#), [40/1033](#)
Atteyne, to attain, [118/3358](#)
Atwyne, in two, [98/2769](#)
Avalen, to fall down, [143/4139](#)
Avaunce, to advance, further, [41/1057](#)
Avaunte, to boast, [5/26](#), [19/426](#)
Auctorité, authority, [7/91](#)
Aventerouse, fortuitous, [28/697](#), [40/1018](#)
Aventure, event, [21/476](#)
Autour, author, [58/1556](#)
Auzte, ought, [11/213](#)
Avisen, to consider, [174/5063](#)
Awaite, snare, [80/2214](#)
Awaitour, one who lies in wait, [121/3463](#)
Awip̃ = aweþ, oweth (*debet*), [178/5198](#)
Ay, ever, [184/55](#)
Ay-dwellynge, ever-dwelling, [173/5044](#)
Ayenis, against, [97/2749](#)
Axe, to ask, [17/357](#), [24/579](#)
Azeins, Azeynes, Azeynest, against, [10/183](#), [11/194](#), [12/221](#), [13/255](#)
Azeinewarde, on the contrary, on the other hand, [42/1098](#)

[Bacine](#), basin, [133/3806](#)

Batailen, to war on, do battle against, [18/412](#)

Been, bees, [80/2200](#)

Ber, did bear, [6/61](#)

Bere, Bear, [143/4124](#)

Beren on hond, to accuse falsely, [20/449](#)

Bet, better, [63/1703](#)

Bibled, covered over with blood, [48/1860](#)

Bisien, to trouble, [8/112](#)

Bitake. *See* Bytake.

Bitidd, happened, [176/5143](#)

Bitwixen. *See* Bytwixen.

Blaundissinge, flattering, [30/749](#)

Blaundyshing, flattery, blandishment, [34/866](#)

Bleched, bleached, [181/45](#)

Blemisse, to blemish, abuse (*lacero*), [20/472](#)

Blyssed, blessed, [181/43](#)

Blyþenese, joyfulness, [37/957](#)

Boch, botch, blain, sore, [72/1977](#)

Bode, to foretell, [143/4130](#)

Bole, bull, [148/4274](#)

Boot, did bite, [53/1400](#)

Bordure, border, hem, [6/50](#)

Bosten, to boast, [79/2171](#)

Botme, bottom, [12/234](#)

Bounté, Bownté, goodness, kindness, [19/444](#), [46/1202](#), [183/39](#)

Brenne (*pret.* Brende), to burn, [19/437](#), [106/3031](#)

Brid, bird, [68/1867](#)

Bristlede, bristly, [148/4281](#)

Brode, broadly, plainly, [49/1298](#)

Brutel, brittle, fragile, [45/1174](#)

Brutelnesse, brittleness, frailty, [184/63](#)

Burpe, birth, [78/2165](#)

Busshel (corn), [15/312](#)

Bydolven (*p.p.*), buried, [151/4348](#)

Byen (for *abyen*), suffer, [125/3578](#)

Byforen, BYFORN, BYFORNE, before, [20/454](#)

Bygunne, didst begin, [37/941](#)

Bygyle, to beguile, [25/615](#)

Byhate, to hate, [75/2051](#)

Byheste, promise, [149/4303](#)

Byhete, to promise, [61/1651](#), [69/1903](#)

Byhynde, Byhynden, behind, [108/3062](#), [110/3137](#)

Byhyzt, promised, [70/1925](#), [85/2374](#), [157/4558](#)

Byknowen, Byknowe, to acknowledge, [146/4211](#), [175/5107](#);
p.p. Byknowen, [90/2514](#)

Byleve, believe, [28/695](#)

Byname, an additional name, [84/2333](#)

Byneþen, beneath, [49/1295](#)

Bynomen (*p.p.*), taken from, [124/3527](#)

Bynyme, to deprive of, take away, [43/1117](#), [70/1930](#)
Byreft, bereft, [33/837](#)
Byseche, to beseech, [86/2408](#)
Bysmoked, besmoked, [5/49](#)
Byspotte, to defile, [73/2009](#)
Bystowe, to bestow, [24/585](#)
Bysynesse, toil, [184/75](#)
Bytake, to entrust, [32/808](#)
Bytide (*pret.* BYTIDDE, *p.p.* BYTID), to befall, happen, [20/474](#), [151/4360](#), [155/4467](#)
Bytwene, between, [6/54](#)
Bytwixen, betwixt, [132/3785](#)
Bytynge, biting, sharp, [63/1721](#)
Bywepe, to weep for, [26/644](#)
Byweyle, to bewail, [26/643](#)

[Caitif](#), Caytif, wretched, [21/489](#), [116/3289](#)
Careyne, carcase, corpse, [116/3307](#)
Cariages, taxes (*vectigalia*), [15/303](#)
Celebrable, commendable, noted, [84/2320](#), [147/4257](#)
Certein, certain, [170/4952](#)
Cese, to cease, [36/904](#), [130/3716](#)
Cesse, to cease, [133/3821](#)
Challenge, to claim, [52/1380](#)
Chastie, Chastysen, to chastise, [125/3579](#), [145/4170](#)
Chayere, chair, seat, [21/503](#)
Cheminey, furnace (*caminus*), [12/236](#)
Cheryce, to cherish, [181/52](#)
Chesen, to choose, [76/2096](#)
Cheyn, chain, [8/122](#)
Chiere, CHERE, CHOERE, face, countenance, [8/123](#), [12/232](#), [108/3080](#)
Chirkyng, groaning (*stridens*), [25/618](#)
Clarré, a kind of wine, [50/1329](#)
Cleer, serene, [45/1168](#)
Clepe, to call, [4/17](#), [11/188](#), [17/369](#)
Clifte, fissure, cleft, [130/3721](#)
Cliven, CLIVE, to stick, cling, adhere to, [41/1050](#), [101/2858](#), [159/4600](#)
Cloumben = CLOMBEN, climbed, ascended, [57/1533](#)
Coempcioun, coemption, [15/309](#)
Coeterne, coeternal, [172/5019](#)

Colasioun, collation, [125/3569](#)
Collacioun, comparison, [165/4805](#)
Combred, troubled, [94/2642](#)
Commoeve, to move, [107/3043](#)
Commoevyng, moving (*excitans*), [12/233](#)
Communalité, commonwealth, [14/271](#), [142/4108](#)
Comparisoune, to compare, [58/1567](#)
Complyssen, to accomplish, [124/3534](#)
Compotent, having the mastery (*compos*), [172/5012](#)
Compoune, to compose, form, [87/2419](#), [93/2598](#)
Comprende, comprehend, [165/4807](#)
Comunableté, commonwealth, [13/268](#)
Comune, common, [9/140](#), [15/310](#)
Confederacie, conspiracy, [53/1399](#)
Confus, confused, [132/3788](#)
Conjecte, to conjecture, [27/649](#), [114/3230](#)
Conjoignen, to join, [92/2573](#)
Conjuracioun, conspiracy, [18/394](#), [53/1399](#)
Consequeute, consequence, [84/2323](#)
Constreyne, to constrain, contract, [5/38](#)
Consuler (CONSEILER), consul, [51/1364](#), [1366](#)
Consumpt (*consumptus*), consumed, [60/1632](#)
Contek, contest, strife, [130/3745](#)
Contene, Contienen, to contain, comprehend, [24/573](#), [116/3302](#)
Contrarien, to be opposed to, adverse to, [154/4440](#)
Contrarious, adverse, opposite, [21/488](#), [53/1420](#)
Contrefeten, to counterfeit, [173/5031](#)
Convenably, fitly, conveniently, [142/4089](#)
Convict, convicted, [19/440](#)
Cop, top, summit, [44/1159](#)
Corage, mind, spirit, [118/3367](#), [119/3398](#)
Corige, to correct, [125/3581](#)
Corompe, Corrumpe, to become corrupt, [98/2766](#), [96/2697](#)
Corone, Coroune, a crown, [119/3385](#), [91/2555](#)
Corsed, cursed, [181/27](#)
Corsednesse, cursedness, [90/2526](#)
Corumpynge, corruption, [103/2927](#)
Cosyne, cousin, [106/3020](#)
Couche, to lay, set, [35/890](#)

Coupable, guilty, [10/172](#)
Couth, known, [25/592](#)
Coveite, to covet, [51/1365](#)
Covenable, fit, convenient, [97/2731](#)
Covertour, Coverture, covering, [118/3361](#), [159/4622](#)
Covetise, Coveytyse, covetousness, [20/451](#), [181/32](#)
Covine, deceit, collusion, [21/493](#)
Coyn, money, [180/20](#)
Creat, created, [99/2796](#)
Crike, creek, [82/2260](#)
Croppe, top, [69/1877](#)
Curacioun, cure (*curatio*), [26/632](#)
Curage, [30/753](#). See Corage.
Cure, care, [64/1753](#)

[Dalf](#) (*pret. of delven*), dug, delved, [51/1349](#)
Damoisel, damsel, [30/762](#)
Dampnacioun, condemnation, [16/352](#)
Daunten, Dawnte, to subdue, daunt, [77/2115](#), [147/4258](#)
Debonairly, mildly, [122/3490](#)
Deboneire, gentle (*mitis*), [22/519](#);
 good, [88/2450](#)
Deceivable, deceptive, [77/2124](#)
Dede, did, [181/28](#)
Dedid, made dead, [127/3623](#)
Deef, deaf, [4/18](#)
Deere, dear, [37/941](#)
Deep, death, [4/15](#)
Defaute, fault, defect, [18/402](#)
Defende, to forbid, [34/859](#)
Deffeted, enfeebled, weakened, [30/735](#)
Defoule, to defile, [21/491](#), [68/1873](#)
Degrees, steps, [6/54](#)
Delices, delight, delights (*deliciæ*), [38/968](#), [41/1062](#), [66/1787](#)
Delitable, delectable, [30/756](#)
Delitably, delightfully, [108/3078](#)
Delve, should dig, [151/4352](#)
Delver, a digger, [151/4359](#)
Delyé, thin, fine, [5/43](#). Fr. *délié*.

Dempne, to condemn, [183/49](#)
Denoye, to deny, [88/2464](#)
Departé, to separate, [29/719](#)
Depelyche, deeply, [160/4647](#)
Depeynte, to depict, [111/3146](#)
Depper, deeper, [27/649](#)
Derke, Derken, to darken, [7/90](#), [20/448](#)
Derworpe, Derworpi, precious, [31/787](#), [41/1046](#)
Desarmen, disarm, [13/241](#)
Desceivaunce, deception, [81/2240](#)
Desceive, Deseive, to deceive, [9/141](#), [38/967](#)
Descryven, to describe, [99/2813](#)
Desmaie, to dismay, [35/896](#)
Desordene, inordinate, [36/912](#)
Despoylynge, spoil, prey, [147/4259](#)
Destempraunce, severity, [97/2749](#)
Destinal, fatal, [135/3884](#)
Destourbe, disturb, [143/4123](#)
Destrat, distracted, [80/2216](#)
Destreine, to constrain, bind, [54/1441](#)
Diffinisse, to define, [88/2459](#), [165/4808](#)
Digne, worthy, just, [43/1124](#), [149/4297](#)
Digneliche, worthily, [53/1427](#)
Dirke, dark, [83/2306](#)
Dirke, Dirken, to make dark, darken, [5/48](#), [49](#)
Dirkenesse, darkness, [23/535](#)
Disceyvable, deceptive, [4/23](#)
Discordable, discordant, [143/4133](#)
Discorde, to disagree, [94/2632](#), [102/2898](#)
Discordyng, disagreeing, discordant, [68/1849](#)
Discours, judgment, reason, [165/4804](#)
Discressioun, discretion, [93/2594](#)
Discussed, dispersed, scattered, [9/149](#)
Disdaignen, to disdain (*indignari*), [146/4213](#)
Disencrese, to decrease, [173/5035](#)
Disordinaunce, disorder, [150/4324](#)
Dispenden, to spend, expend, [45/1181](#)
Dispone, to dispose, [135/3864](#)
Disputisoun, disputation, [149/4314](#)

Disseveraunce, separation, [96/2701](#)
Dissimulen, to dissemble, [178/5215](#)
Distempre, intemperate, [121/3466](#)
Distingwed, distinguished, [47/1223](#)
Dité, ditty, [134/3850](#)
Divinour, diviner, [157/4541](#)
Domesman, judge, [55/1467](#)
Doom, judgment, [152/4395](#)
Doumbe, dumb, [9/138](#)
Doutous, Dowtos, doubtful, [5/37](#)
Dowbleness, duplicity, [182/63](#)
Drede, dread, [21/497](#)
Dredeful, timid, [121/3468](#)
Dredles, fearless, [106/3028](#)
Dreint, Dreynt, drowned, drenched, [4/22](#), [7/99](#), [148/4271](#)
Dresse, to direct, order, [137/3954](#), [142/4104](#)
Drouppe, to drop, [20/455](#)
Drow, drew, [15/300](#)
Duelly, duly, [22/530](#)
Dulle, to become dull, [7/100](#)
Dure, Duren, to last, [98/2755](#)
Duske, to make dusk or dim, [5/48](#)
Dyverses (*pl.*), divers, [8/120](#)
Dyvynyng, divination, [157/4541](#)

[Echid](#), increased, [77/2134](#)
Echynnys, sea-urchins, [82/2266](#)
Egalité, equality, evenness (of mind), [42/1099](#)
Egaly, equally, evenly, [43/1108](#), [157/4536](#)
Egge, edge, [180/19](#)
Egre, sharp, [25/610](#)
Egren, to urge, excite, [141/4060](#)
Eir, air, [45/1169](#)
Ek, Eke, also, [40/1040](#), [181/36](#)
Elde, old age, [5/48](#)
Eldefadir, grandfather, [40/1042](#)
Elder, older, [89/2493](#)
Embelise, to embellish, [47/1223](#)
Emperie, government, [51/1363](#)

Emperisse, empress, [109/3098](#)
Empoysenyng, poisoning, [11/206](#) (*venenum*)
Emprente, to imprint, [166/4839](#)
Emprenten, obtain (translates the Latin, *impetrent*), [159/4596](#).
Perhaps a mistake for *empetren*.
Emptid, exhausted, [5/34](#)
Enbaissyng, a debasing, [109/3107](#)
Enbrase, embrace, [142/4092](#)
Enchaufen, to make hot, *chafe*, [73/2020](#)
Encharge, to impose, [178/5214](#)
Enchaunteresse, enchantress, [123/3504](#)
Endamagen, to damage, [15/316](#)
Endirken, to obscure, [120/3418](#)
Enditen, to indite, [4/4](#)
Enfourme, to inform, instruct, [11/212](#), [13/263](#)
Enhaunse, Enhawnse, to raise, exalt (*enhance*), [33/825](#)
Enlace, to bind, entangle, entertwine, perplex, [13/245](#), [80/2207](#), [149/4298](#)
Enoynte, to anoint, [36/923](#)
Enpeyren, to impair, [120/3418](#), [139/4015](#)
Ensample, example, [9/151](#)
Entalenten, to excite, [168/4876](#)
Entecche, defile, pollute, [120/3431](#)
Entendyng, intent, looking stedfastly on, [8/126](#)
Entente, to intend, [150/4345](#)
Ententes, endeavours, labours, [7/79](#)
Ententif, attentive, intent, [12/223](#), [29/731](#)
Ententifly, attentively, [103/2931](#)
Enterchaunge, to interchange, [65/1785](#), [131/3753](#)
Entercomunynge, commerce, communication, [57/1528](#)
Entermedle, to intermix, [54/1436](#)
Entré (*adytum*), [30/751](#)
Entreachunge, to interchange, [39/1003](#)
Entrelaced, intermingled, entangled, [105/2981](#)
Entremete, intermeddle, [104/2964](#)
Enveneme, to poison, infect, [120/3437](#)
Enviroune, to surround, [34/848](#), [88/2437](#)
Environynge, circumference, [164/4769](#)
Erpeliche, Erpelyche, earthly, [52/1378](#), [69/1888](#)
Erye, to plough, ear, [71/1964](#)

Eschafen, to escape, [41/1054](#)
Eschaufe, to become hot, to burn, [22/524](#)
Eschewen, to avoid, escape, [177/5172](#)
Eschuyng, eschewing, [99/2802](#)
Establishe, to establish, [15/311](#)
Eterne, eternal;
 fro eterne = from eternity, [153/4422](#)
Eternité, eternity, [171/4986](#)
Evenliche, evenly, [25/599](#)
Everyche, every, [11/190](#);
 each, [181/48](#)
Evesterre, evening star, [22/510](#)
Excussyoun, execution, [184/65](#)
Exercen, to exercise, practise, [52/1389](#)
Exercitacioun, exercise, [140/4034](#)
Exilyng, banishment, [11/205](#)
Exite, to excite, [168/4881](#)
Eyen, eyes, [183/36](#)
Eyer, air, [170/4962](#)

[Fader](#), father, [18/414](#)
Familiarité, familiarity, [30/740](#)
Familers, familiars, [18/407](#)
Fantesye, fancy, inclination, [181/51](#)
Fasoun, fashion, [62/1693](#)
Feffe, (?) [38/966](#)
Fel, felle, fierce [44/1160](#)
Felawschipe, to accompany, [111/3141](#)
Felefold, manifold, [30/738](#)
Felliche, fiercely, [39/997](#)
Felnesse, fierceness, [25/618](#)
Felonous, wicked, depraved, [18/405](#)
Felonye, crime, [124/3542](#)
Fer, far, [23/554](#)
Ferm, firm, [78/2148](#)
Fermely, firmly, [157/4550](#)
Ferne, fern, [64/1741](#)
Ferne, distant, [60/1621](#)
Ferþe, fourth, [56/1509](#)

Festivaly, gaily, [59/1581](#)
Festne, to fasten, fix, [10/166](#)
Fette, fetched, [180/22](#)
Fey, faith, truth, [112/3178](#)
Ficchen, to fix, fasten, [45/1164](#), [88/2446](#)
Fieblesse, feebleness, [81/2240](#), [112/3176](#)
Fille, abundance, [48/1269](#)
Flaumbe, flame, [98/2761](#)
Fleme, to banish, [29/723](#)
Fles, fleece, [180/18](#)
Flete, Fleten, to float, flow, pass away, abound, [8/118](#), [28/690](#), [146/4223](#), [152/4376](#)
Fletyng, flowing, [71/1961](#)
Fley, flee, [149/4289](#)
Fleyen, to flee, [125/3584](#)
Flies, fleece, [50/1330](#)
Flitte, to remove, [68/1853](#)
Flittyng, changing, fickle, [78/2150](#)
Flityng, flitting, [12/220](#)
Flotere, to float, [99/2817](#)
Floterynge, floating, [87/2420](#)
Flouren, to flourish, [131/3763](#)
Fodre, fodder, [148/4267](#)
Foleyn, Folyen, to act foolishly, [67/1821](#), [1826](#)
Folyly, foolishly, [12/220](#)
Fooldest, foldest, [105/2984](#)
Forbrek, broke, interrupted, [108/3082](#)
Fordoon, to undo, destroy, [62/1693](#)
Fordryven, driven about, [12/215](#)
Foreyne, foreign, [34/851](#)
Forghe, furrow, [170/4959](#)
Forheved, forehead, [16/346](#)
Forknowyng, foreknowledge, [178/5187](#)
Forleften, left (*pret. of forleve, linquo*), [9/150](#)
Forlete, to cease, [96/2697](#);
 leave, forsake, [22/525](#)
Forleten (*p.p.*), neglected, forsaken, [5/47](#)
Forliven, degenerate from (*degenero*), [78/2163](#)
Forlorn, lost, [34/858](#), [121/3452](#)
Forme, an error for *ferme*, to make firm, [23/547](#)

Forpampred, overpampered, [180/5](#)
Fors, force;
 ‘no fors,’ no matter, [182/13](#)
Forsweryng, perjury, [23/536](#)
Forþenke, to be sorry, grieved, [41/1058](#)
Forþere, to further, promote, [41/1057](#)
Forþest, farthest, [136/3918](#)
Forþi, therefore, [28/689](#)
Fortroden, trodden upon, trampled, [109/3100](#)
Fortunel, fortuitous, [152/4379](#)
Fortunouse, Fortuouse, fortuitous, [26/639](#), [38/983](#), [132/3779](#)
Forwes, furrows, [180/12](#)
Forwiter, foreknower, [178/5204](#)
Foryetyn, forgotten, [101/2872](#)
Foundement, foundation, [98/2754](#)
Fowel, bird, [107/3053](#)
Fram, from, [70/1931](#)
Freele, frail, [61/1658](#)
Frete, to eat, devour, [147/4252](#)
Frounce, flounce, [9/147](#)
Fructe, fruit, [180/3](#)
Frutefiying, fructifying, fruitful, [6/72](#)
Fulfilling, satisfying, [79/2178](#)
Fycche, fix, [108/3073](#). See Ficchen.
Fyn, end, [69/1892](#)

[Gabbe](#), ‘gabbe I?’ am I deceived? [49/1308](#)

Galentyne, a dish in ancient cookery made of sopped bread and spices (*Halliwell*), [180/16](#)

Galles, galls, [181/47](#)

Gapen, to desire, be greedy for, [15/324](#), [36/910](#)

Gapinge, desire, [36/910](#)

Gastnesse, terror, fear, [75/2079](#)

Geaunt, giant, [104/2966](#)

Gentilesse, nobility, [78/2154](#)

Geometrien, geometrician, [91/2552](#)

Gerdoned, rewarded, [120/3410](#)

Gerdoun, reward, [13/265](#)

Gerner, garner, [15/305](#)

Gesse, Gessen, to deem, suppose, estimate, [17/378](#), [19/416](#), [65/1782](#)

Gessinge, opinion, [21/475](#)
Gest, guest, [38/979](#)
Gideresse, a female guide, [108/3084](#)
Gise, guise, mode, [71/1943](#)
Giser, gizzard, [107/3054](#)
Glotonus, greedy, [26/620](#)
Gnodded, pounded, [180/11](#)
Gobet, a bit (of gold), [51/1349](#)
Godhed, divinity, [122/3492](#)
Goost, spirit, ghost, [40/1036](#)
Gouvernaile, government (*gubernaculum*), [27/651](#)
Governaunce, control, [32/813](#)
Goye, joy, [179/5218](#)
Graype, to devise, prepare, [19/438](#)
Grobbe up, to grub up, [181/29](#)
Grond, did grind, [180/15](#)
Gynne, snare, trap, [82/2256](#)
Gynner, beginner, [150/4330](#)
Gyse, guise, mode, [134/3860](#)

[Habitacle](#), habitation, [57/1525](#)
Habunde, to abound, [41/1073](#)
Halden, to hold, [41/1053](#)
Hale, to draw, drag, [61/1665](#)
Halt, holds, [56/1504](#)
Hardnesse, hardship, [132/3783](#)
Hardyly, boldly, [34/857](#)
Hastise, to hasten, [131/3746](#)
Haunten, to frequent, [10/168](#);
to practise, exercise, [52/1389](#)
Heeres, hairs, [4/12](#)
Heet, heat, [28/699](#)
Hef, raised, heaved, [5/41](#)
Hele, health, [93/2623](#)
Henten, to seize, [15/326](#)
Hepen, to heap up, increase, [153/4418](#)
Herburghden, harboured, lodged, [53/1409](#)
Herie, to praise, [109/3112](#)
Hert, hart, [106/3027](#)

Herted, hearted, [55/1466](#)
Heve, to raise, heave, [171/4968](#)
Heved, head, [4/13](#)
Hevenelyche, heavenly, [8/105](#)
Hevie, to make heavy, [171/4967](#)
Hey, high, [22/523](#)
Heyere, higher, [143/4117](#)
Hey3e, high, [171/4969](#)
Hielde, pour, [35/899](#)
Hizte, to adorn, [8/116](#)
Hoke, hook, [16/347](#)
Holily, wholly, entirely, [90/2503](#)
Homelyche, homely, [105/3001](#)
Hond, hand, [20/449](#)
Honter, a hunter, [12/228](#)
Hool, whole, [46/1191](#)
Hoolnesse, wholeness, [164/4754](#)
Hoope, to hope, [17/384](#)
Hore, hoary, [4/13](#)
Humblesse, humility, [80/2213](#)
Hungry tyme, time of famine, [15/314](#)
Hurtlen, to rush against, to oppose, [30/748](#), [167/4866](#)
Hyene, hyæna, [185/35](#)
Hy3t, is called, [9/154](#), [25/619](#)
Hy3ten, are called, [77/2126](#)

[Ibou3t](#), bought, [157/4540](#)
Ibowed, bent, turned, [137/3949](#)
Icharged, loaded, [71/1962](#)
Igete, gotten, [36/908](#)
Ilorn, lost, [62/1677](#)
Imperial, august (*imperiosus*), [7/91](#)
Implie, to fold, enclose, [152/4379](#)
Infortune, misfortune, [79/2197](#)
Inmoeveable, immovable, [173/5030](#)
Inmoeveableté, immobility, [173/5032](#)
Inorschid, nourished, nurtured, [8/128](#)
I-nowh, enough, [180/11](#)
Inperfit, imperfect, [83/2291](#)

Inplitable (*inexplicabilis*), [15/315](#)
Inprente, to imprint, [166/4832](#)
Inpressed, impressed, [167/4861](#)
Inrest, innermost, [136/3913](#)
Instaunce (*instantia*), presence, [174/5067](#)
Intil, into, [110/3139](#)
Inwiþ, within, [32/801](#)
Issest, issuest, [105/2983](#)
Iwist, known, [156/4513](#)

[Jangland](#), chattering, [68/1867](#)
Jape-worthi, ridiculous, [157/4540](#)
Jolyté, pleasure, [79/2189](#)
Jowes, jaws, [15/323](#)
Joygnen, to join, [54/1455](#)
Joynture, juncture, joining, [46/1207](#)
Juge, a judge, [19/431](#);
 to judge, [53/1427](#)
Jugement, judgment, [114/3253](#)

[Karf](#) (*pret.* of Kerven), cut, [50/1337](#)
Kembd, KEMBED, combed, [23/537](#)
Kerve, to cut, [64/1740](#)
Kevere, cover, obscure, [34/861](#)
Keye, helm (*clavus*), [103/2926](#)
Knowelechinge, knowledge, [168/4874](#)
Knyzt, soldier, [111/3142](#)
Konnyng, knowledge, [16/351](#)
Korue (*p.p.*), cut, rent, [6/58](#)
Kuytten, to cut, [147/4246](#)
Kyd, known, [181/46](#)
Kyndeliche, Kyndely, naturally, [101/2850](#), [114/3228](#)
Kythen, to make known, show, [184/63](#)

[Lache](#), slow, lazy, [122/3471](#)
Lad (*p.p.*), led, [35/879](#)
Laddre, ladder, [6/55](#)

Lambyssh, lamb-like, [181/50](#)
Languisse, to languish, [30/734](#), [130/3740](#)
Lappe, flap, [9/146](#)
Largesse, liberality, [45/1183](#)
Lasse, less, [22/508](#)
Leche, Leecher, physician, [13/250](#), [114/3254](#), [139/3990](#)
Leef, dear, [37/941](#)
Leesen, Leese, to lose, [22/509](#), [43/1133](#)
Lene, to give, [139/3993](#)
Lenger, longer, [52/1370](#)
Lesynge, loss, [141/4066](#)
Lesynge, leasing, lie, [156/4525](#)
Leten, to leave, [10/176](#);
 to esteem, [61/1666](#)
Leve, permission, leave, [128/3658](#)
Leveful, allowable, lawful, [10/176](#)
Ligge, to lie, [60/1632](#), [147/4251](#)
Liifly, lively, lifelike, [5/33](#)
Likerous, lecherous, [72/1989](#)
Litargie, lethargy, [9/140](#)
Litestere, a dyer, [180/17](#)
Lokyng, sight, [10/167](#)
Loos, praise
Loop, loath, [40/1036](#)
Lorel, a wretch, [21/495](#)
Lorn, lost, [34/859](#)
Lous, loose, free, [136/3926](#)
Lykyng, pleasure, [31/771](#)
Lymes, limbs, [71/1946](#)
Lynage, lineage, [41/1070](#)
Lythnesse, lightness, [98/2761](#)
Lyzte goodes, temporal goods, [4/21](#)
Lyztly, easily, [12/220](#)
Lyztne, to enlighten, [128/3655](#)
Lyztnesse, light, brightness, [8/106](#)

[Maat](#), weary, dejected, [40/1037](#)

Magistrat, magistracy, [72/1985](#)

Maistresse, mistress, [10/169](#)

Malice, *nefas*, wickedness, [20/466](#)
Malyfice, *maleficium*, [20/468](#)
Manace, menace, [12/232](#)
Manase, to menace, [118/3365](#)
Manassyng, threatening, [44/1158](#)
Mareis, Mareys, marsh, [56/1513](#), [97/2735](#)
Margarits, pearls, [94/2650](#)
Marye, pith, marrow, [97/2744](#)
Maugré, in spite of, [70/1928](#)
Mede, meed, reward, [91/2555](#)
Medle, to mix, *Medelyng*, mixing, mixture, [20/449](#), [122/3482](#), [126/3594](#)
Meenelyche, moderate, [28/706](#)
Meistresse, mistress, [17/363](#)
Melle, mill, [180/6](#)
Mene, the mean or middle path, [146/4228](#)
Meremaydenes, mermaids, [7/83](#)
Merken, to mark, [16/346](#)
Mervaille, Merveile, marvel, [18/403](#), [132/3787](#)
Merveilen, to marvel, [46/1205](#)
Mervelyng, wondering, [10/161](#)
Mest, most, [42/1081](#)
Mesuren, to measure, [65/1782](#)
Meyné, servants, domestics, [47/1243](#)
Mirie, pleasant, sweet, [4/16](#)
Mirinesse, pleasure, [66/1793](#)
Misericorde, mercy, pity, [107/3057](#)
Mistourne, to misturn, mislead, [69/1894](#)
Mochel, great, [62/1674](#), [109/3110](#)
Moeveable, mobile, fickle, [133/3817](#)
Moeven, to move, [8/112](#), [150/4329](#)
Moewyng, moving, motion, [130/3742](#)
Mokere, to hoard up, [45/1182](#)
Mokere, miser, [45/1182](#). A mistake for *mokerere*.
Molesté, trouble, grief, [85/2346](#)
Monstre, prodigy, [18/403](#)
More, greater, [129/3697](#)
Morwe, morning, [22/513](#)
Mosten (*pl.*), must, [166/4836](#)
Mot, must, [40/1038](#)

Mowen, be able, [25/608](#)
Mowynges, ability, power, [124/3548](#)
Myche, much, [21/475](#)
Mychel, much, [46/1215](#)
Myntynges, purposing, endeavouring, [7/101](#)
Myrie, pleasant, [45/1165](#)
Myrily, pleasantly, [59/1582](#)
Myrpes, pleasures, [132/3782](#)
Mys, badly, wrongly, [131/3772](#)
Mysese, grievance, trouble, [15/299](#)
Mysknowynges, ignorant, [61/1659](#)
Mysweys, wrong paths, [149/4309](#)

[Naie](#), to refuse, [4/19](#)
Nake, to make naked, [148/4288](#)
Nameles, unrenowned, [131/3762](#)
Namelyche, Namly, especially, [124/3550](#)
Nare, were not, [10/176](#)
Nart, art not, [23/556](#)
Narwe, narrow, [57/1520](#)
Nas, was not, [180/9](#)
Napeles, nevertheless, [6/57](#)
Nat, not, [23/556](#)
Necesseden, necessitated, [87/2419](#)
Nedely, of necessity, [84/2334](#)
Negardye, (sb.) misers, [183/53](#)
Nere, were not, [26/646](#)
Nepemaste, lowest, nethermost, [6/56](#)
Nepereste, lowest, [6/50](#)
Newe, to renew, [137/3938](#)
Newliche, recently, [122/3489](#)
Nice, foolish, [148/4287](#)
Nil, will not, [107/3055](#)
Nillynges, being unwilling, [97/2718](#)
Nilt, wilt not, [112/3193](#)
Nis, is not, [12/218](#)
Niste, knew not, [102/2882](#)
Noblesse, nobleness, [37/947](#)
Nobley, nobility, nobleness, [37/945](#)

Nolden, would not, [52/1369](#)
Norice, nurse, [10/167](#)
Norisse, to nourish, [79/2174](#)
Norry, nursling, pupil, [10/173](#)
Norssinge, nourishment, support, [47/1231](#);
 nutriment, [37/932](#)
Not, know not (*1st pers.*), [27/649](#)
Notful, useful, [7/85](#)
Nounpower, impotence, [75/2074](#)
Noupir, neither, [160/4644](#)
Noyse, to make a noise (about a thing), to brag, [79/2171](#)
Nurry (*see* Norry), [86/2386](#)
Nys, is not, [45/1175](#)

[O](#), one, [24/564](#)
Obeisaunt, obedient, [13/266](#), [32/814](#)
Object, presented, [168/4889](#)
Occupy, to seize, [146/4227](#)
Offence, hurt, damage, [180/19](#)
Offensioun, offence, [20/473](#)
Olifunt3, elephants, [80/2223](#)
Onknowyn, unknown, [180/6](#)
Onlyche, only, [171/4968](#)
Onone, Onoon, at once, anon, [23/553](#), [74/2027](#)
Ony, any, [21/488](#)
Ooned, united, [135/3879](#)
Oor, oar, [50/1338](#)
Oosteresse, hostess, [122/3495](#)
Or, ere, before, [9/143](#)
Ordeinly, orderly, [140/4044](#)
Ordenour, ordainer, [109/3110](#)
Ordeyne, orderly, [109/3109](#)
Ordinat, ordered, settled, [12/229](#)
Ordinee, orderly, [102/2902](#)
Ordure, filth, [29/716](#)
Ostelment3, furniture, goods, [48/1266](#)
Oþerweyes, otherwise (*aliter*), [164/4772](#)
Outerage, excess, [50/1326](#)
Outerest, extremest, remotest, [55/1469](#), [89/2476](#)

Outerly, utterly, [108/3081](#)
Outraien, do harm (?), [78/2162](#)
Over-comere, conqueror, [8/109](#)
Overmaste, highest, uppermost, [6/57](#)
Overmyche, overmuch, very much, [79/2191](#)
Overoolde, very old, [11/209](#)
Overprowen, prostrate, [21/497](#)
Overprowyng, forward, headstrong, [7/99](#), [141/4058](#)
Overtymelyche, untimely, [4/13](#)
Owh, an exclamation (*papæ*), [112/3166](#)
Owtrage, excess, [180/5](#)

[Paied](#), satisfied, [58/1549](#)
Paleis, pale, [24/574](#)
Palude, marsh, [148/4262](#)
Paraventure, peradventure, [18/402](#)
Parchemyn, parchment, [166/4835](#)
Parsoners, sharers, partakers, [170/4942](#)
Partles, without a share, [120/3409](#)
Pas, paces, [19/442](#)
Paysyble, peaceable, peaceful, [180/1](#)
Peisible, quiet, placid, [23/550](#), [88/2450](#)
Percen, to pierce, [81/2236](#)
Perdurable, lasting, perpetual, [5/44](#), [21/503](#)
Perdurableté, immortality, [58/1557](#)
Perfitlyche, *Perfitly*, perfectly, [87/2426](#), [133/3833](#)
Perfourny, to afford, furnish, [67/1823](#)
Perisse, to perish, [96/2712](#)
Perturbacioun, perturbation, [7/98](#)
Perverte, to destroy, [11/201](#)
Peyne, punishment, [121/3439](#)
Piment, a kind of drink, [50/1329](#)
Plenté, fulness, [173/5037](#)
Plentevous, affluent, [67/1824](#)
Plentivous, yielding abundantly, fertile, [64/1739](#)
Plentivously, abundantly, [25/592](#)
Plete, argue, plead, [33/833](#)
Pletyngus, pleadings, debates (at law), [70/1933](#)
Pleyne, to complain, [31/777](#)

Pleynelyche, plainly, [28/681](#)
Pleynt, complaint, [110/3122](#)
Plonge, Ploungen, to plunge, [7/89](#), [65/1784](#)
Ploungy, wet, rainy (*imbrifer*), [64/1745](#)
Polute, polluted, [20/450](#)
Pose, to put a case, cf. put a *poser*, [162/4686](#)
Pousté, power, [131/3766](#)
Pownage, pasturage, [180/7](#)
Poyntel, style, [166/4838](#)
Preiere, prayer, [107/3044](#)
Preisen, to estimate, judge, [7/379](#)
Preisyng, praising, [77/2131](#)
Preke, to prick, [85/2346](#)
Prenostik, prognostic, [183/54](#)
Presentarie, present, [178/5196](#)
Preterit, preterite, past, [171/4990](#)
Pretorie, the imperial body-guard, [15/317](#)
Prevé, secret, [121/3464](#)
Preven, to prove, [90/2503](#)
Prie, to pray, [25/600](#)
Pris, value;
 ‘worþi of *pris*,’ precious, [24/583](#)
Proche, to approach, [145/4182](#)
Proeve, to approve, [154/4456](#)
Punisse, to punish, [22/531](#)
Puplissee, to publish, spread, propagate, [58/1549](#), [98/2753](#)
Purper, purple, [25/617](#)
Purpose, to propose, [176/5148](#)
Purveaunce, providence, [134/3863](#)
Purveiable, provident, foreseeing, [68/1854](#)
Purveie, to ordain, order, [21/478](#)
Purvyance, providence, [99/2795](#)

[Quereles](#), complaints, [70/1932](#)
Quik, living, [134/3839](#)
Quyene, queen, [183/43](#)
Quyerne, a mill, [180/6](#)

[Rafte](#), bereft, [147/4259](#)
Raper, earlier, former, [30/735](#)
Raviner, a plunderer, [12/228](#)
Ravische, to snatch, [11/190](#)
Ravyne, plunder, rapine, [15/302](#), [36/909](#)
Ravynour, plunderer, [121/3460](#)
Ravysse, to carry off, [131/3774](#)
Real, royal, [19/420](#)
Recche, to care, reck, [33/827](#), [38/987](#)
Recompensacioun, recompense, [130/3724](#)
Recorde, to recount, recall, [92/2580](#), [101/2871](#)
Reddowr, severity, rigour, [182/13](#)
Redenesse, redness, flushing, [7/88](#)
Redoutable, venerable, [131/3763](#)
Redoute, to fear, [10/178](#), [57/1535](#)
Redy = rody, red, ruddy, [39/995](#)
Refet, refreshed, [143/4116](#)
Reft (away), carried off, [22/521](#)
Refut, refuge, [94/2644](#)
Regne, kingdom, [67/1843](#)
Regnen, to reign, rule, [29/726](#)
Remewe, to remove, [19/441](#)
Remorde, to vex, trouble, [140/4030](#)
Remuable, able to remove from one place to another, [168/4898](#)
Remuen, to remove, [52/1394](#)
Renomed, renowned, [41/1070](#), [78/2143](#)
Renovele, to renew, [98/2752](#)
Replenissee, to replenish, [20/469](#)
Reprere, to reprove, [167/4857](#)
Repugnen, to be repugnant to, [154/4440](#)
Requerable, desirable, [52/1377](#)
Requere, to require, [99/2790](#)
Rescowe, to recover, [133/3809](#)
Rescowe, to rescue, [35/881](#)
Resolve, to loosen, melt, [133/3814](#)
Resoune, to resound, [107/3036](#)
Rethoryen, rhetorical, [30/759](#)
Rewlyche, pitiable, sorrowful, [35/878](#)
Risorse = recourse (*recursus*), course, [8/108](#)

Rody, ruddy, [143/4122](#)

Roos, roes, [82/2258](#)

Rosene, roseat, [8/117](#)

Route, company, [47/1243](#)

Royle, to run, roll, [29/717](#)

Rynnyng, running, [50/1335](#)

Ryztwysnesse, righteousness, equity, [16/331](#)

[Sachel](#), satchel, sack, [12/223](#)
Sad, stable, [41/1064](#)
Saddenesse, stability, [110/3123](#)
Sarpuler, a sack made of coarse cloth (*Sarcinula*), [12/223](#)
Sauuacioun, safety, salvation, [97/2723](#)
Sau3, Say, saw, [8/106](#), [9/137](#)
Saye, sawest, [37/958](#)
Schad, shed, [4/13](#)
Schrew, a wicked person, a wretch, [12/217](#)
Schrewed, wicked, [18/398](#)
Schrewednesse, wickedness, [18/401](#), [117/3324](#)
Schronk, shrunk, [5/38](#)
Schulden (*pl.*), should, [9/132](#)
Schullen (*pl.*), shall, [25/605](#)
Scom, foam, froth, [148/4281](#)
Scripture, writing, [17/382](#)
Sege, seat, [13/258](#)
Seien (*pl.*), saw, [51/1344](#)
Seien (*p.p.*), seen, [6/54](#)
Selde, seldom, [133/3818](#)
Seler, cellar, [35/890](#)
Selily, happily, blissfully, [42/1076](#)
Selve, very, [5/42](#)
Semblable, like, [48/1279](#)
Semblaunce, likeness, [142/4106](#)
Semblaunt, appearance, countenance, [5/31](#)
Senglely, singly, [85/2369](#)
Sensibilites, sensations, [166/4830](#)
Servage, servitude, [153/4411](#)
Sewe, to follow, [88/2441](#)
Seye, sawest, [37/955](#)
Seyntuaries, sanctuaries, [16/343](#)
Shad, divided, spread, [136/3922](#)
Sholdres, shoulders, [148/4281](#)
Sich, such, [6/67](#)
Sikerly, certainly, [94/2635](#)
Singler, individual, single, [57/1529](#)
Singerly, singly, [135/3890](#)

Sittyng, fitting, becoming, [10/176](#)
Skilynge, reason, [137/3931](#)
Slaken, to slake (hunger), [50/1326](#)
Slede, sledge, [110/3131](#)
Sleen, Slen, to slay, [53/1409](#), [55/1460](#)
Slouȝ, slew, [55/1461](#)
Smaragde, emerald, [94/2650](#)
Smerte, to smart, pain, [39/1011](#)
Smot, smote, [147/4254](#)
Smoȝe, smooth, [8/112](#)
Sodeyn, sudden, [10/161](#)
Somedel, somewhat, [25/606](#)
Somer, summer, [22/517](#)
Songen (*p.p.*), sung, [108/3078](#)
Soory, sorry, grievous, [38/978](#)
Soȝe, true, [17/377](#), [118/3352](#)
Soȝefastly, truly, [89/2481](#)
Soȝely, truly, [169/4918](#)
Soȝenesse, truth, [26/641](#)
Sothfast, true, [61/1652](#)
Soun, sound, [68/1852](#)
Soune, to sound, [37/929](#)
Sounyng, sounding, roaring, [8/111](#)
Sovereyne, supreme, [90/2508](#)
Sovereynely, supremely, [91/2545](#)
Sourmounte, to surpass, [80/2223](#)
Spece, species, [165/4789](#)
Speculacioun, looking, contemplation, [153/4408](#)
Spedeful, Spedful, efficacious, conducive, [125/3570](#), [161/4671](#)
Speden, to make clear, explain, [161/4667](#)
Spere, sphere, [8/108](#)
Sperkele, spark, [104/2971](#)
Sprad, spread (*p.p.*), [9/156](#)
Stableté, stability, [137/3950](#)
Stablise, to establish, [134/3860](#)
Stably, firmly, [135/3890](#)
Stappe, step, [170/4963](#)
Staunche, to satisfy, [71/1948](#), [1961](#)
Stere, to move (*agitare*), [106/3015](#)

Sterre, star, [36/903](#)
Sterry, starry, [36/904](#)
Sterten, to start, [104/2971](#)
Stidefastnesse, stability, strength, [97/2748](#)
Stidfast, steadfast, [182/17](#)
Stien, to ascend, [88/2444](#)
Stiere, *steer*, rudder (*gubernaculum*), [103/2926](#)
Stiern, stern, [60/1628](#)
Stoon, stone, [45/1165](#)
Stormynge, making stormy, [29/712](#)
Stont, stands, [9/154](#)
Stoundes, times, [178/5187](#)
Strauȝt, stretched, extended, [170/4957](#)
Strengere, stronger, [12/221](#)
Strenkeȝ, strength, [12/240](#)
Streyhte, stretched, [63/1702](#)
Streyne, to restrain, [150/4325](#)
Strond, strand, [51/1339](#)
Strook, stroke, [153/4433](#)
Strumpet, [6/66](#)
Stye, to ascend, [143/4117](#)
Stynte, to stop, [37/929](#)
Styntynghe, stopping, ceasing, [61/1638](#)
Suasioun, persuasion (*suadela*), [30/759](#)
Subgit, subject, [48/1273](#)
Submytte, to compel, force (*summitto*), [19/434](#)
Sudeyn, sudden, [30/752](#)
Suffisaunce, sufficiency, [70/1922](#)
Suffisaunt, sufficient, [70/1924](#)
Suffisauntly, sufficiently, [133/3833](#)
Summitte, Summytte, to submit, [49/1288](#), [136/3924](#)
Superfice, surface, [81/2238](#)
Supplien, to supplicate, [80/2210](#)
Surté, security, [181/46](#)
Sustigne, to sustain, [183/41](#)
Sweighe, whirl, circular motion (*turbo*), [22/504](#)
Swerd, sword, [19/438](#)
Swety, sweaty, [181/28](#)
Sweyes, whirlings, [32/816](#)

Swich, such, [20/446](#)
Swolwe, to swallow, [98/2777](#)
Syker, secure, safe, [12/224](#), [16/333](#)
Sykernessee, security, safety, [9/132](#)
Symplesse, simplicity, [136/3914](#)
Syn, since, [31/789](#)
Syþen, since, [32/802](#)

[Talent](#), affection, desire, will, [6/71](#), [168/4887](#)
Taylage, tollage, [181/54](#)
Ȓar, need, [38/987](#)
Ȓerwhiles, whilst, [176/5150](#)
Ȓilke, the same, that, [99/2814](#)
Ȓo, Ȓoo (*pl.*), the, [11/200](#), [168/4886](#)
Ȓondre, thunder, [45/1166](#)
ȒoruȒ, through, [11/202](#)
Ȓreschefolde, threshold, [7/89](#)
Ȓrest, thirst, [36/914](#), [71/1945](#)
Ȓreste, Ȓresten, thrust, [47/1237](#), [148/4283](#)
Ȓhrof, throve, flourished, [74/2050](#)
Ȓrust, thirst, [107/3053](#)
Ȓil, to, [69/1891](#)
Ȓilier, a tiller, [151/4352](#)
To-breke, break in pieces, [88/2447](#)
Ȓodrowen (*pl.*), drew asunder, [11/193](#)
Ȓoforne, before, [177/5184](#)
Ȓogidres, together, [53/1421](#)
Ȓo hepe, together, [140/4029](#)
Ȓokene, to token, [26/624](#)
Ȓollen, to draw, [56/1496](#)
Ȓorenten (*pl.*), rent asunder, [11/194](#)
Ȓo-teren, tear in pieces, [68/1865](#)
Ȓraas, Ȓrais, trace, track, [170/4958](#), [4963](#)
Ȓransporten, throw on (*transfere*), [19/419](#)
Ȓravaille, labour, toil, [10/174](#)
Ȓravayle, to toil, labour, [64/1754](#)
Ȓravayle, labour, [148/4286](#)
Ȓregedie, tragedy, [77/2126](#)
Ȓregedien, tragedian, [77/2125](#)

Trenden, to roll, turn, [100/2835](#)
Troublable, troublesome, [118/3369](#)
Trouble, turbid, stormy, [29/711](#)
Troubly, troubled, cloudy (*nubilus*), [133/3819](#)
Trowen, to trow, believe, [20/468](#), [152/4399](#)
Twitre, to twitter, [68/1875](#)
Twynkel, to wink, [38/971](#)
Tylienge, tilling, [151/4347](#)
Tyren, to tear, [107/3055](#)

[Umblesse](#), humility, [181/55](#)
Unagreeable, unpleasant, disagreeable, [4/25](#)
Unassaieþ, untried, [42/1082](#)
Unbitide, not to happen, [161/4678](#)
Unbowed, unbent, [148/4284](#)
Uncovenable, unmeet, importunate (*importunus*), [141/4058](#)
Undefouled, undefiled, [40/1023](#)
Undepartable, inseparable, [120/3422](#)
Underput, put under, subject, [28/696](#)
Understonde, to understand, [30/733](#), [43/1120](#)
Undigne, unworthy, [54/1444](#)
Undirneþ, underneath, [75/2074](#)
Undiscomfited, not discomfited (*invictus*), [12/232](#)
Undoutous, indubitable, [149/4315](#)
Uneschewably, unavoidably, [157/4531](#)
Ungentil, ignoble, [41/1070](#)
Ungrobbed, ungrubbed, [180/14](#)
Unhonestee, disreputableness, [24/587](#)
Unhoped, unexpected, [139/4006](#)
Université, whole, [165/4797](#)
Unjoynen, Unjoygnen, to separate, [151/4373](#)
Unknowyng, ignorant, [139/3997](#)
Unknyttten, to unloose (*dissolvere*), [154/4459](#)
Unkonnyng, Unkunnyng, unknowing, ignorant, [7/76](#), [11/202](#)
Unkorven, uncut, [180/14](#)
Unkouþ, unknown, foreign, [34/870](#)
Unlace, to disentangle, [105/2982](#)
Unleueful, illicit, unlawful, [154/4456](#)
Unmeke, fierce, cruel, [148/4267](#)

Unmoeveable, immovable, [136/3901](#)
Unmoeveableté, immobility, [136/3921](#)
Unmyȝty, weak, impotent, [13/241](#)
Unneþ, scarcely, [27/652](#)
Unparygal, unequal, [63/1708](#)
Unpitouse, cruel, [4/24](#)
Unpleyten, to explain, [61/1647](#)
Unplite, explain, unfold, [167/4843](#)
Unpunissed, unpunished, [21/498](#)
Unpurveyed, unforeseen, [30/743](#)
Unraced, unbroken, whole, [110/3115](#)
Unryȝtful, unjust, [10/185](#)
Unryȝtfully, unrightfully, unjustly, [23/533](#)
Unscience, unreal knowledge, no knowledge, [156/4515](#)
Unsely, wretched, [39/1013](#)
Unselynesse, wretchedness, [124/3544](#)
Unskilfuly, unwisely, improperly, [18/407](#)
Unsolempne, not famous, not celebrated, [11/210](#)
Unsowe, unsown, [180/10](#)
Unspedful, unsuccessful, [178/5210](#)
Unstauncheable, unlimited, infinite, [58/1573](#)
Unstaunched, uncurbed, unrestrained, [54/1439](#)
Unsuffrable, intolerable, [79/2179](#)
Unusage, unfrequency, [57/1528](#)
Untretable, inexorable, implacable, [61/1641](#)
Unwar, unexpected, [35/886](#)
Unwarly, unaware, unexpectedly, [4/10](#)
Unwemmed, inviolate, [40/1023](#), [178/5201](#)
Unwened, unexpected, [139/4006](#)
Unwoot, knows not, [175/5099](#)
Unworshipful, dishonoured, [75/2054](#)
Uphepyng, heaping up, [37/951](#)
Upsodoun, upside down, [48/1274](#), [156/4501](#)
Upsprong, upsprung, [180/10](#)
Used, accustomed, wonted, [22/512](#)
Uterreste, extremest, outermost, [7/95](#)

[Vanisse](#), to vanish, [74/2027](#)

Variaunt, varying, [22/518](#)

Vengerisse, a she-avenger, [107/3048](#)
Verray, Verrey, true, [19/429](#)
Vilfully (Wilsfully), wilfully, [116/3295](#)
Voide, having an empty purse (*vacuus*), [50/1316](#)
Voyded (of), emptied of, free from, [181/50](#)

[Wakyng](#), watchful, [148/4263](#)

Walwe, to toss, [51/1361](#)

Walwyng, tossing, [29/712](#)

Wan, did win, [147/4240](#)

War, be aware, take care, [145/4200](#)

Warne, to refuse, deny, [37/950](#)

Wawe, a wave, [8/115](#)

Wayk, weak, [28/706](#)

Weep (*pret.*), wept, [35/883](#)

Welde, wild, [180/17](#). It may mean *boiled*, since another copy reads *wellyd*.

Weleful, Welful, prosperous, joyful, [4/15](#)

Welefulnesse, Welfulnesse, prosperity, felicity, [11/188](#), [21/478](#)

Welken, to wither, fade, [146/4224](#)

Welkne, welkin, [184/62](#)

Welle, well, source, [157/4548](#)

Wende, weened, thought, [53/1397](#)

Wenge, wing, [170/4961](#)

Wenyng, opinion, [172/5022](#)

Wepen (*p.p.*), wept, [25/596](#)

Wepli, tearful, [5/29](#)

Werdes, fates, destinies, [4/10](#)

Werreye, to make war, [181/25](#)

Weten, to know, [156/4519](#)

Wex, wax, [167/4840](#)

Weyve, to waive, forsake, [29/722](#)

Wham, whom, [89/2482](#)

Whelwe, to toss, roll, [39/1001](#)

Whiderward, whither, [177/5171](#)

Whist, hushed, [51/1341](#)

Wierdes, fates, destinies, [12/231](#)

Wikke, wicked, bad, [64/1743](#)

Willynge, desire, [178/5203](#)

Wilne, to desire, [17/367](#)

Wilnyng, desire, [98/2781](#)
Wirche, to work, [12/235](#)
Wirchyng, working, operation, [95/2677](#)
Wist, known, [170/4937](#)
Witen, to know, learn, [88/2458](#), [132/3776](#), [160/4624](#)
Wiþdrow, withdrew, [64/1751](#)
Wiþhalden, to withhold, [142/4105](#)
Wiþoute forþe, outwardly, [165/4803](#)
Wiþseid, denied, [90/2501](#)
Wiþstant, withstand, [29/715](#)
Wiþstonde (*p.p.*), withstood, [14/290](#)
Witnesfully, attestedly, publicly, [131/3765](#)
Witynge, knowledge, [156/4526](#)
Wod, woad, [180/17](#)
Wod, Wode, mad, raging, [12/225](#)
Wode, wood, [39/995](#)
Wodenesse, rage, madness, [45/1169](#), [107/3052](#)
Wolen (*pl.*), will, [94/2645](#)
Woltow, wilt thou, [97/2741](#)
Wone, to dwell, [60/1627](#)
Woode, Wode, furious, mad, [25/600](#)
Woode, to rage, [123/3515](#)
Woodnesse, rage, madness, [107/3052](#)
Woot, knows, [43/1128](#)
Wope, to weep, [36/905](#)
Worchen, to work, [178/5215](#)
Wost, knowest, [19/423](#)
Woxe, to increase, wax, grow, [25/608](#)
Woxen (*p.p.*), grown, [25/607](#)
Wrekere, avenger, [128/3665](#)
Wrekyng, vengeance, [147/4238](#)
Wroþely, grieved, sad, [7/87](#)
Wryþen, twist, turn, wrest, [154/4452](#)
Wymple, to cover with a veil or wimple, [31/774](#)
Wyt, sense, [164/4771](#)
Wyȝt, wight, person, [19/425](#)

[Yave](#) (*pl.*), gave, [180/4](#)

Yben, been, [162/4698](#)

Ybeyen, to obey, [105/2998](#)
Ycauȝt, caught, captured, [118/3371](#)
Ycleped, called, [150/4346](#)
Ydel, ‘*in ydel*,’ in vain, [5/43](#)
Ydred, feared, [33/825](#)
Yfelawshipped, associated, united, [53/1421](#)
Yficched, fixed, [136/3910](#)
Yfinissed, finished, [125/3558](#)
Yflit, flitted, removed, [8/108](#)
Ygeten, gotten, [65/1776](#)
Yhardid, hardened, [133/3814](#)
Yheuied, made heavy, [171/4974](#)
Ylad, led, [37/956](#), [172/5022](#)
Ylete, permitted, [130/3730](#)
Ylett, hindered, [161/4674](#)
Ylorn, lost, [147/4250](#)
Ymaginable, possessing imagination, [166/4812](#)
Ymaked, made, [87/2426](#)
Ymedeled, mixed, [140/4029](#)
Ynouȝ, enough, [71/1947](#)
Yplitid, pleated, folded, [9/147](#)
YPORVEYID, YPURVEID, foreseen, [155/4467](#), [4468](#)
Ysen, seen, [72/1982](#)
Yshad, shed, scattered, [68/1874](#)
Yshet, shut, [170/4955](#)
Ysmyte, smitten, [80/2202](#)
Yspedd, made clear, determined, [161/4657](#);
despatched, [149/4295](#)
Yspendyd, examined (*expediero*), [161/4668](#)
Ysprad, spread, [78/2140](#)
Yspranid, sprinkled, mixed, [42/1102](#).
Read yspraind.
Ystrengēped, strengthened, [175/5098](#)
Ypewed, behaved, [139/4008](#)
Yprongen, pressed, squeezed, [57/1521](#)
Ytravailed, laboured, [155/4469](#)
Ytretid, handled, performed, [131/3765](#)
Yvel, evil, [105/2976](#)
Ywened, believed, [145/4178](#)

Ywist, known, [155/4475](#)

Ywoven, woven, [6/51](#)

Ywyst, known, [164/4759](#)

Yȝeven, given, [141/4069](#)

[Ȝaf](#), gave, [8/130](#)

Ȝeelde, Ȝelde, seldom, [39/1002](#), [52/1372](#)

Ȝeld, yielded, [147/4253](#)

Ȝelden, to yield, [149/4303](#)

Ȝeve, to give, [149/4291](#)

Ȝevyng, giving, [45/1188](#)

Ȝif, if, [9/131](#)

Ȝis, yes, [103/2919](#)

Ȝisterday, yesterday, [171/4994](#)

Ȝitte, yet, [156/4508](#)

Ȝok, Ȝokke, yoke, [32/802](#), [60/1620](#)

Ȝolde (*p.p.*), yielded, [25/599](#)

Ȝonge, young, [35/889](#)

Ȝouȝe, youth, [10/168](#)

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